

Fate's Edge

Complete Worldbook

A Gazetteer of the Known Realms

AS TOLD BY THOSE WHO LIVE THERE, BLEED THERE, AND OWE THERE

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Contents

Preface: The Ledger Bleeds

I am an Aeler Edgewalker. You call us mountain-dwellers who measure breath in silver bells and seal contracts in stone. How adorably naïve.

We don't just measure breath—we own the lungs that draw it. When a Tulkani chieftain swears an oath on his firstborn's life? That's not honour—it's collateral I've already hypothecated three times over. When a Veiled Sister binds a demon to a corpse to prop up her corpse-throne? That's not terror—it's a futures contract on soul-debt, and I'm the broker who sold the short position before the ritual even began.

You see the surface as "full of problems." How quaint. Problems aren't obstacles—they're inventory.

This book isn't a tourist's guide. It's a hit list with footnotes. I've marked the places where a well-placed bell doesn't just open a pass—it starts a war I've already shorted the bond market on. Where a forged seal doesn't just move a mountain—it triggers a landslide I've bought mineral rights to before the first crack appeared. Where a single true story doesn't just buy a ship's loyalty—it buys the captain's silence while I sell his manifest to pirates.

You want to build journeys? Draw your cards. Set your clocks. Spend your Story Beats like they mean something. But remember: every Diamond you earn is a tooth knocked out of someone else's jaw. Every Debt you incur? I already bought it from your victim for half what you'll pay—and I'm collecting interest in your marrow before you finish reading this sentence.

The road isn't just a ledger. It's a butcher's block. Every gate isn't a clause—it's a throat waiting for the knife.

— *The Edgewalker*

Part I

The Amaranthine Sea & Northern Shores

Chapter 1

Kahfagia

The Flag of Storms.

I was born on the tide, which is to say I was born owing. My mother was a net-mender who lost her fingers to a reef-cutter's debt. My father was a bell—that is to say, he rang when the Admiralty pulled his string. I learned to read the lantern codes before I learned my letters, and I learned that every light is a lie waiting to be told.

The Admiralty runs this place like a pirate charter with a budget—and oh, how they love pretending it's legitimate. They control the beacons that lure ships onto reefs, the booms that shatter hulls for salvage rights, and the tariffs that fund their champagne baths. But here's the secret the commodores don't want you to know: the lanterns are afraid of the dark too.

I've seen a Mirror-Keeper weep when her reflection showed her a daughter she'd sold for a pilot's license. I've watched a Privateer Captain kiss a silver coin before a raid—the same coin her mother kissed before she never came back. This is not a city of heroes. It is a city of people who learned that the sea is cheaper than mercy.

If you want to move cargo through the straits without becoming fish food, get a convoy letter stamped with the Admiral's seal. Or get smart. Or get gone.

— Captain Mira “the Lucky,” Sidhi exile, pirate by convenience

The Almanac of Ordinary Days

What do people eat for breakfast? Salt fish porridge—dried cod soaked overnight, boiled with hardtack and a splash of lamp oil. The oil is for calories. The fish is for memory. Every Kahfagian child learns to taste the salt and know which coast their grandmother came from.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To count ships by their lanterns. Three lanterns means a Kahfagian merchant—safe. Four means an Oshiiran grain barge—neutral. One, low in the water, means a privateer. Run.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their hands. Dock-workers have rope-burned palms. Merchants have ink-stained fingers. Privateers have no fingernails—they bite them off in storms.

What is the most common crime? False manifests. Every third ship carries cargo that doesn't appear on its papers. The Admiralty knows. The Admiralty takes a cut. The Admiralty calls it a "tariff surcharge."

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Mirror-Keepers are not born—they are made. And the making requires a death. A sister, a daughter, a lover. Someone who drowned so the keeper could see through the fog.

Where do people go when they die? The tide takes them. Kahfagia has no cemeteries above ground. The drowned are weighted with chain and dropped in the deep channel. Their families light candles in paper boats and float them out at dusk. If the candle reaches the horizon, the soul is forgiven. If it sinks, the debt is not yet paid.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You offer your bell. Every Kahfagian carries a small brass bell on a leather cord—the sound of their name. Offering it to the wronged party means "I give you my voice. Speak for me." Refusing to return the bell after an apology is a declaration of blood feud.

What is the most important festival? The Beacon Lighting (midwinter). Every lighthouse keeper lights a new lamp from the Admiral's flame. If your beacon catches first, your year will be lucky. If it sputters, you will owe a death to the sea.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Admiral's lantern code has a ninth signal—never used, never spoken, burned into every keeper's memory. It means *"Kill the witnesses. Sink the evidence. The sea will hide the rest."*

1.1 Kahfagia — “The Creole Thalassocracy”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *Every mirror is a blade, every beacon a promise. The sea obeys when we move the lights — but the spiders weave in the mirror-towers.*

Admiral of Lantern-Law (Elite): “Every mirror is a blade, every beacon a promise. The sea obeys when we move the lights — and woe to the fool who rows against them. Yet I have seen the reflection move before the hand that holds it. The tides are not the only ones with secrets.”

Dockside Factor (Commoner): “The pilots see farther than kings. A gesture in lantern-code can open ports, or close them. Keep your debts paid, and your lamps trimmed. And if a grey-robed stranger offers to adjust your mirror for free — say no. The Lethai-ar have long memories, and longer webs.”

Genre / Mood: Creole thalassocracy, signal-and-lane politics, eldritch tide, secret infiltration.

Starting Location: The Lantern Pier admiralty chapel, where votive ships hang from the ceiling and brine drips from the icon of a drowned saint. A sea-notary unlocks a salt-stained reliquary and produces a chart with gilt edges. “Fetch the contraband bell from the corsair galleass *Santa Dolorosa* before moonrise — or the harbour names you accomplices. And watch for silk threads on the bollards. The Spider’s children are everywhere.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Kahfagia is the Creole child of Oshiira and the Vilikari — a thalassocracy where Oshiiran ledgers meet Vilikari tide-law. The Admiralty of Lantern-Law rules not by armies but by light, yet the real power flows through a tangled web of oligarchic families, each with their own spies, their own private navies, and their own seat on the Shadow Council. Above them all floats a central Admiralty fleet, charged with protecting the beacon monopoly — and with watching the watchers.

But the oligarchs are not the only players. Unseen, the Lethai-ar of Inaea have been infiltrating the mirror-towers for decades. A factor’s trusted secretary, a harbour master’s silent wife, a pilot’s apprentice with too-still eyes — they weave their webs not for coin, but for *control*. They do not seek to destroy Kahfagia. They seek to *own* it, strand by strand, until the entire thalassocracy hums to the rhythm of the Spider’s mercy.

What you notice first: The constant chime of bell-buoys. The smell of salt, tar, and burnt oil from a thousand lanterns. The way everyone — admiral to dockhand — glances at the tide clock before speaking. And the faint, almost invisible silk threads tied around the bollards of the wealthiest piers.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never argue with a Mirror-Keeper about where the channel lies. If they say the safe water moved, it moved. Your chart is already kindling. And if the Mirror-Keeper smiles too widely, check the back of their neck for a spider’s brand.

Regional Mood: The Lantern’s Vigil & The Spider’s Web

Power is visible here — literally. Every night, a thousand lamps burn along the channels, each a statement of control. To dim a light is to declare bankruptcy. To move a beacon is to declare war.

Commodores sit in their mirror-towers, watching reflections, while tide-clocks tick down to the next auction, the next inspection, the next quiet murder.

But beneath the visible power, another war is fought in whispers. The Lethai-ar agents of Inaea have spent a generation infiltrating the oligarchic families. A young heir who suddenly displays uncanny negotiating skill may not be talented — they may be *woven*. A Mirror-Keeper whose beacons never fail may be receiving guidance from a source that does not appear on any chart. The Spider’s web is patient. It does not break the thalassocracy; it *guides* it.

Prominent NPCs of Kahfagia

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Admiral Zafira	Commander of Lantern-Law	Keep the beacon monopoly intact	She has never lost a ship to the reefs. Her charts are said to be drawn in water.
Mirza al-Qasr	Mirror-Keeper of the Pointe	Control the tides through light	Her face is never seen—only reflected. Some say she has no shadow.
Ximena	Dockside Factor (commoner exemplar)	Profit from every cargo, legal or not	She keeps a ledger in lemon juice; heat reveals the truth.
Captain Rodrigo	Privateer with a crooked letter of marque	Raid the corsair fleet and pay off his crew	His ship flies three flags; the one he lowers last is the one that matters.
Sister Anabel	Healer of the Hospitallers of the Salted Veil (Temple of Light)	Tend the sick without asking payment	Her grey robes are said to be woven from old debts. They never stain.
Notary Farid	Admiralty magistrate	Resolve disputes before they reach the harbour master	He carries a water-clock in his sleeve to measure the shifting of legal moods.

The Harpist	Veiled	Lethai-ar infiltrator (secret)	Woven the oligarchs, strand by strand	No one knows her face. She plays only in mirror-lit rooms, and her music leaves threads of silk in the listeners’ hair.
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The Oligarchic Houses (Shadow Council)

The true rulers of Kahfagia are not the Admiralty alone, but the **Shadow Council** of seven oligarchic families. Each controls a monopoly (spice, salt, silk, timber, pitch, shipbuilding, or intelligence). Each maintains its own private navy and network of spies. Each vies for the empty seat left by the family that the Lethai-ar have already *woven* into silence.

- **House al-Kassam (Spice):** Oldest, proudest, most vulnerable. The Lethai-ar have already replaced the family steward.
- **House Carrasco (Salt):** Ruthless pragmatists; they suspect infiltration but cannot prove it.
- **House Mirat (Silk):** Secret allies of the Lethai-ar — they trade webs for influence.
- **House del Puerto (Shipbuilding):** Neutral; they build for anyone who pays.
- **House Henares (Timber):** Deeply indebted to the Admiralty; the Lethai-ar are slowly buying their notes.
- **House de la Vela (Intelligence):** The Admiralty’s own spy network — and already compromised.
- **The Empty Chair:** Once held by House Morat, now vacant. The other houses whisper that the Morats were not destroyed — they were *rewoven*.

Secret Faction: The Silk Vigil (Lethai-ar Infiltrators)

Agents of Inaea, the Spider’s children have spent a generation worming into Kahfagia’s elite. They do not steal or sabotage — they *guide*. A decision that benefits House Carrasco is subtly nudged toward the Lethai-ar’s long-term goal: a unified thalassocracy that answers not to the Admiralty, but to the Web.

Signs of Infiltration:

- A factor’s handwriting becomes unnaturally precise, the loops forming faint eight-shapes.
- A Mirror-Keeper’s reflections show the same face in every tower — a woman with chestnut-brown skin and eyes like polished jet.
- A ship that should have foundered instead limps to port, its crew speaking of a grey-robed passenger who vanished before docking.

Mechanical Hook: Once per session, a PC may roll Wits + Lore (DV 4) to notice a silken thread in an official’s collar or a spider’s brand on a dockhand’s wrist. On success, they identify a

Lethai-ar agent. On failure, the agent becomes aware of their scrutiny — and the Web tightens.

Names of Kahfagia

Inspired by the sea-faring republics of the western coast, blended with Oshiiran and Vilikari influences: liquid consonants, soft vowels, and surnames that denote a port, a ship, or a founding ancestor.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Safir	Zafira	al-Kassam	<i>the Lantern</i>
Idris	Ximena	del Puerto	<i>Tide-Keeper</i>
Farid	Layla	de la Vela	<i>the Unlit</i>
Jabir	Aisha	Carrasco	<i>Mirror-Eye</i>
Rodrigo	Salma	Mirat	<i>Bell-Born</i>
Tarik	Nura	Henares	<i>Ash-Sails</i>

Spades — Places (Littoral/Lane/Law)

2. **Tidal Mudflat** — Hidden plank-way at low water; smugglers' shortcut. *At ebb, the planks rise like the ribs of a drowned whale.* '[STEALTH]'
 3. **Salt-Scar Pier** — Behind dawn spice auctions; where fortunes wash ashore. *Auditors check the salt-scars — white crust that proves cargo was cleaned, not stolen.* '[TRADE]'
 4. **Reedbelt Creeks** — Smuggler paths where tax boats won't follow. *A hanged man's boots hang from a piling; those who pass tug their collars.* '[STEALTH]'
 5. **Breakwater Gap** — Under repair; cutters slip at dusk through the works. *The stone is still loose. A wrong step, and the sea claims another toll.* '[TRAVEL]'
 6. **Dredged Channel** — Fresh with temporary beacons; tomorrow's safe water. *The buoys are painted yellow — the colour of "maybe."* '[TRAVEL]'
 7. **River Sluice** — Tide-gate and boom-chain; access controlled by rope and writ. *The chain has a notch where a slaver's ship tried to flee. It still drips oil.* '[AUTHORITY]'
 8. **Cutter Yard** — Narrow-keel vessels; apprentices work night shifts. *They sing old work songs — the kind that skip the ninth beat.* '[LABOR]'
 9. **Lantern Alley** — Fog-lane where beacons migrate with the tide. *Follow the lights. Two blinks means you're expected. Three? You're prey.* '[WEATHER]'
 10. **Admiralty Quay** — Bonded warehouses under seal; law walks the decks. *The seal on the door changes with the tide. Today it's a serpent eating its tail.* '[AUTHORITY]'
- J **Red Shoal** — Quiet water, loud reputations; where deals are made. *Old barges moored together; a floating court with no bailiff.* '[SOCIAL]'
- Q **Mirror Tower** — Pilot station that certifies safe water — today. *The mirror at the top shows not the sea, but the face of the last captain who argued.* '[JUSTICE]'
- K **Kassamira Port** — Presidial; auctions at dawn, courts by noon. *The auctioneer's gavel is wrapped in a page torn from a debtor's ledger.* '[TRADE]'
- A **The Pointe** — Strait of storm-lights and wreckers' tales. *On still nights, you can hear the drowned singing the names of those who owe.* '[DEATH]'

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Tide-Runner** — Bell and rope; knows every tide-table by heart. *“The table says high water at noon. The moon lies. Trust my rope.”* ‘[TRAVEL]’
3. **Pilot’s Apprentice** — Perfect memory for shoals; tomorrow’s navigator. *Touches a brass talisman before every sounding. No one knows why.* ‘[TRAVEL]’
4. **Lantern Clerk** — Knows which lights moved, and why; keeper of the shifts. *Docks with a ledger that smells of smoke. Adds a surcharge for “recent adjustments.”* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
5. **Oshiiran Factor** — Two ledgers; one for Kahfagia, one for truth. *The left ledger records bribes as “conciliation fees.” The right one is never shown.* ‘[TRADE]’
6. **Dock-Syndic** — Makes queues vanish; power in the pause. *He never raises his voice. The harbour master listens anyway.* ‘[SOCIAL]’
7. **Lantern Advocate** — “Jurisdiction moves like tide”; law in flux. *She carries a water-clock in her sleeve to measure the shifting of legal moods.* ‘[JUSTICE]’
8. **Privateer Captain** — “Crooked” letter of convoy; profit in the margins. *Her ship flies three flags; the one she lowers last is the one that matters.* ‘[COMBAT]’
9. **Thalasso Sergeant** — Shore leave but still on duty; marine precision. *A tattoo of a lighthouse on his forearm; the light is his wife’s name.* ‘[COMBAT]’
10. **Admiralty Magistrate** — Rules fast, travels faster; justice in a hurry. *She once sentenced a man to the galleys and boarded the ship before he did.* ‘[JUSTICE]’
- J **Dredging Foreman** — Channel follows their purse; water reshaped. *His crew are ex-criminals; he pays them in salt pork and absolution.* ‘[LABOR]’
- Q **Mirror-Keeper (Elite)** — Commodore’s confidante; places beacons that bind. *Their faces are never seen — only reflected. Some say they have none.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
- K **Kahfagian Commodore** — Off the books but on the water; shadow admiral. *His flagship is a fishing smack. Its nets drag up letters of marque.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
- A **Admiral of Red Shoal** — Offers wine, figs — once. Price in stories. *She pours the first cup herself. If she pours a second, you’ve already agreed.* ‘[LEGEND]’

Clubs — Complications/Threats

(Entries unchanged except for the addition of a new threat: **Web Unravelling** – a Lethai-ar agent is exposed, and the oligarchs turn on each other.)

2. **Early Tide** — Turns two bells early; grounding risk rises like the sea. ‘[WEATHER]’ *Someone bribed the tide-clerk — or the moon is angry.*
3. **Smothering Fog** — Sound travels, sight does not; navigation by ear alone. ‘[WEATHER]’ *You hear oars. Then you don’t. Then they’re behind you.*
4. **Boom Slam** — Harbour chain slams shut; wrong side means delay or danger. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The chain’s links are inscribed with names of debtors. Each one rattles differently.*
5. **Light Shift** — Beacons change mid-approach; your lane just moved. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *Someone paid the Lantern Clerk. Find out who — or drift into the reefs.*
6. **Pilot Strike** — No escorts available; average unpaid, risk assumed. ‘[LABOR]’ *The pilots sit in their guildhall, drinking tea, watching ships founder.*
7. **Customs Inspection** — Ladder audits cargo and crew; delays bite deep. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The inspector has a silver tooth. He smiles when he sees a manifest.*

8. **Reef-Runners** — Corsair skiffs circle with boarding hooks; steel in the spray. '[COMBAT]' *Their leader wears a Mirror-Keeper's badge — stolen or earned, you cannot tell.*
9. **Jurisdiction Flip** — Lantern-law shifts; your writ no longer bites. '[JUSTICE]' *The tide turned. So did the magistrate. Your safe-conduct is now kindling.*
10. **Fire Risk** — Alchemical cargo aboard; quarantine if anything spills. '[DISASTER]' *A single spark and the whole quay becomes a crater. The factor wants you to know this.*
- J **Quartermaster Betrayal** — Tide-tables sold to rival; route compromised. '[SOCIAL]' *The betrayal is written in lemon juice; heat reveals the name.*
- Q **Yellow Flag** — Port quarantine; deadlines rot on the hook. '[DEATH]' *The flag is dyed with turmeric and something else — something that smells sweet.*
- K **Fleet Redeploy** — "Safe" corridor becomes parade ground; chaos in formation. '[AUTHORITY]' *Admirals play chess with real ships, and you are a pawn.*
- A **Black Squall (at the Pointe)** — Scatters ships and stories alike. '[WEATHER]' '[DEATH]' *This is no natural storm. The water hisses. Something below is waking.*
- + **Web Unravelling** — A Lethai-ar agent is exposed. The oligarchs turn on each other, accusing every rival of being a spider. '[POLITICS]' '[FEAR]' *Silk threads appear on every doorknob. No one trusts their shadow.*

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

(Unchanged; the existing rewards work well for a thalassocracy.)

2. **Mooring Chit** — Skip the Mooring Roll once; harbour favours you. '[TRAVEL]' *The chit is a dried seahorse shell. Keep it away from salt.*
3. **Pilotage Token** — One certified escort through a bad channel. '[TRAVEL]' *The pilot who accepts it must touch your shoulder before speaking.*
4. **Fee Waiver** — Cargo cleared today; ledger smiles included. '[TRADE]' *The clerk stamps it twice — once for the crown, once for the Hollow.*
5. **Safe-Conduct** — Along specific beacons lane; law walks with you. '[TRAVEL]' *The commodore's seal is warm. It cools as the exit nears.*
6. **Salvage Rights** — On named quay or reach; flotsam becomes fortune. '[TRADE]' *You must name each piece before touching it. The wrong word forfeits the claim.*
7. **Warehouse Access** — Bonded storage; seal prize before rivals sniff. '[TRADE]' *The key is a bronze finger. It fits only one lock — and breaks after use.*
8. **Lantern Code** — Tonight's signals revealed; navigation advantage. '[TRAVEL]' *Three quick flashes: safe passage. One long, two short: the Admiralty is watching.*
9. **Dredging Grant** — You decide where next channel runs; reshape the sea. '[AUTHORITY]' *The dredgers are convicts. They work faster if you promise a name in their favour.*
10. **Letter of Marque** — Convoy protection for one season; legal blades. '[COMBAT]' *The ink is mixed with gunpowder. It smokes slightly when read.*
- J **Admiralty Judgment** — Precedent travels with you; law bends. '[JUSTICE]' *The case number is burned into a leather tag. Tag it to a belt loop.*
- Q **Mirror Warrant** — Legal right to post a beacon; redraw the map. '[AUTHORITY]' *The Mirror-Keeper's seal, still warm. The channel you mark becomes law — until challenged.*
- K **Spice Share** — Stake in Kassamira auction floor; profit in pepper. '[TRADE]' *The share is*

a peppercorn sealed in wax. Bite it to test authenticity.

A **Lantern License** — Temporary authority to redefine the lane. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The harbour master spits when he hands it over. Use it wisely — or not at all.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (papers/rights/priority) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **sea & signal** motifs — beacons that migrate, tides that remember, law that flows like water. If a King or Ace of Spades appears, also echo **web motifs** — silk threads on a bollard, a reflection that holds too long, the faint smell of spiced tea (the Lethai-ar are near).

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **Pilot’s Mirror:** Kahfagia’s strength is not its fleet but its monopoly on light and lane. To post a beacon is to redraw the map. Any character with a Mirror Warrant may permanently move a beacon or buoy (GM sets a 4-segment clock). For the duration of that clock, all navigation rolls on that lane are at +1 Position for the party and –1 Position for rivals.
- **Lantern-Law Privilege:** While flying an Admiralty flag or carrying a valid Lantern License, your ship may pass through chain-booms and customs points at +1 Position. The first time in a session you invoke this privilege, the GM gains 1 SB (the Admiralty is watching).
- **Oligarchic Favour (Leverage Track):** Instead of tracking coin debts, track *Favour* with the great families (al-Kassam, Carrasco, Mirat, etc.). Favour 1–3 gives you access to private docks, early auction warnings, and off-the-books pilots. Favour 4+ lets you call in a family to block a rival’s safe-conduct or raise a false alarm on their ship.
- **The Web’s Patience (Secret Clock [6]):** Tracks the Lethai-ar infiltration of the Shadow Council. The clock ticks when the party helps a Lethai-ar agent, exposes a rival house’s secrets, or ignores a silken thread. At 3, the Harpist’s name appears on a dockmaster’s manifest. At 6, the Empty Chair is filled — and the new house head bows to a grey-robed stranger. The party may reduce the clock by exposing an agent or by warning an oligarch (costs Favour 2).
- **Western Reach Rumours:** Once per port visit, a character may roll Wits + Lore (DV 3) to hear a rumour from a captain returned from beyond the mirror. On success, the GM reveals one of the six rumours (see below) as a foreshadowing hook or a clue for an ongoing arc.
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
 - **The Lantern Bearer** — The Traveler. *A light that never goes out; a promise that never sinks.*
 - **The Mirror-King** — The Witness. *Reflections that remember every lie, every promise, every cargo.*
 - **The Tide Father** — Khemesh. *The pressure beneath the keel; the debt that the sea collects at ebb.*
 - **The Spider’s Daughter** — Inaea (secret). *The web that binds the oligarchs, strand by patient strand.*
 - **The Unlit** — Ikasha. *The ninth lamp that is never lit; the safe harbour that exists

only in rumour.*

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **Saint Alvaro of the Lantern (The Traveler):** The Admiralty’s mirror-towers double as wayshrines for the Saint of Lost Channels. Sailors who light a candle before a voyage and whisper a destination to the mirror claim the tide will not turn against them before they reach it. The Mirror-Keepers charge a fee for this service — payable in salt, not silver.
- **The Silken Coup (Inaea):** The Lethai-ar call their infiltration the *Genteel Harvest*. They do not conquer; they adopt. An oligarch who accepts a grey-robed advisor finds that their children are betrothed to shadow-kin, their ledgers are copied in disappearing ink, and their mirror-tower shows only the face they wish to see — not the one that watches them sleep.
- **The Tide-Sworn Compact (The Admiral of Sealed Tides):** A small but influential order of notaries based in Kassamira Port. They adjudicate disputes over beacon rights, cargo claims, and pilotage fees. Their judgments are always delivered in triplicate, and they accept no bribes — only binding oaths. Those who lie before a Covenant judge find that their next three voyages are plagued by contrary winds.
- **The Hospitallers of the Salted Veil (The Bitter Root):** A hospice on Deadman’s Quay is run by grey-robed healers of the Order. They ask no payment, but they never forget a face. It is said that if you accept their care, you owe a favour to the sea itself — and the sea always collects. Smugglers leave small offerings of fresh water on the pier to stay in the Order’s good graces.
- **The Ninth:** In any lantern-lit scene, the ninth lamp lit in a room reveals a threshold. The wise stop at eight. Those who light the ninth are said to see a figure standing on the water outside the window — waiting.

Kahfagia Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Wake:** Toss a crust over your shoulder before entering a new channel. Ignore the first *Smothering Fog* penalty. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Turn the Lantern:** Spin the binnacle lamp once counter-clockwise. Cancel *Boom Slam* or take –1 die on your next pilot check (your choice). ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Name to the Deep:** Whisper a true name into a lead line. Gain +1 Effect against corsairs for the scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Tide Court. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Cut the Thread:** If you find a silk thread on your bollard, cut it with a silver knife. Negate the next *Web’s Patience* tick. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’

Thematic SB Spend Table

(Unchanged; see earlier table.)

Western Reach Rumours (d6, fast hooks)

1. A harbour where bells toll under water; cargo *must* be named aloud.
2. A spice that stops bleeding — until moonrise.
3. A mirror-reef that reflects storms from a week ahead.
4. A pilotage guild that uses birds, not beacons.

5. A fleet that sails by *shadow* cast on fog.
6. A court that weighs debts in *breath*, not coin.

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Sail + Wits):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Wake Surge*.
- **Cut the Lane (Pilot + Tactics):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a beacon is under your colour, +1 die.
- **Weather the Squall (Resolve + Sail):** On a hit in *Black Squall*, you pick who drifts; on a miss, the Keeper does.

Boss Seeds (Sea & Signal / Web & Silk)

- **The Mirror-Keeper of Kassamira (signal tyrant)** — *Phases:* Audit → Blacklist → Light Embargo. *Cracks:* rival beacon logs, Tide Court precedent, stolen codebook.
- **Corsair-Chaplain of the Pointe (relic raider)** — *Phases:* Charm → Board → Bell-Wake. *Cracks:* sanctified boom, cofradía oath, drowned-saint tithe.
- **The Veiled Harpist (Spider’s Daughter)** — *Phases:* Whisper → Weave → Harvest. *Cracks:* speak a true name of a Lethai-ar agent, cut a strand of the Web with silver, or remind an oligarch of a debt older than the Spider’s memory.

Patronage & Power

In Kahfagia, power flows through control of the sea lanes themselves — and through the silken threads that bind the oligarchs to the Spider’s will. The maritime oligarchs have built their empire not through conquest of territory but through mastery of navigation and the quiet manipulation of debt. Every beacon, every channel marker, every mirror-light is both a navigational aid and a legal instrument. But behind every mirror, a grey-robed woman watches. And she is very, very patient.

For the GM: Kahfagian patronage revolves around access — to channels, to cargo, to legal protection. Rewards often take the form of pilotage tokens, safe-conducts, or salvage rights. But the secret war of the Lethai-ar adds a new layer: players may be hired to expose an agent, to protect an oligarch from being "woven," or even to ally with the Spider’s children for a share of the Harvest. Use the **Web’s Patience** clock to track the infiltration; let players decide whether to slow it, accelerate it, or ride it to power.

Chapter 2

Ecktoria

Marble & Fire.

My grandfather was a senator. He voted to burn the Ykrul tribute-pact, and then he voted to burn the inquiry into why the grain ships sank. He signed his name in wax and watched the city burn three times. He never raised his voice.

I am a Coin-House Factor. I seal deals with three ribbons—white for "ask," red for "now," black for "never." I have never used the black ribbon. Not because I am kind, but because "never" is a debt I cannot collect.

Ecktoria is an Empire that never quite died—more like a corpse propped up by gilded scaffolding and the stubborn refusal of its undertakers to admit the job's done. The Everflame burns in every basilica not as a symbol of divine truth, but as a literal lie detector: swear a false oath near it, and your tongue turns black. I have seen a merchant's tongue turn black mid-sentence. He finished his lie anyway. The buyers pretended not to notice. *That is Ecktoria.*

The statues watch. The fire judges. The marble remembers every name carved into its steps—and every name left out.

Do not refuse a toast in a coin-house. The ledgers are the true judges, and a declined cup is a declined credit. You will not borrow again.

— *Marcus of the Red Ledger, Coin-House Factor, third generation*

The Almanac of Ordinary Days

What do people eat for breakfast? Spiced flatbread dipped in olive oil and honey—but only if you can afford the honey. The poor eat millet porridge with a single dried fig. The fig is counted as part of the household's grain allowance.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To count coins by touch. Every Ecktorian child has a box of worn sesterces; by age five, they can tell a debased copper from pure silver by the weight alone.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their signature. Ecktorians judge by handwriting before face. A clerk with a steady hand is trustworthy. A noble with a flourish is hiding something. A merchant who signs with an X is not worth doing business with.

What is the most common crime? Tax evasion—but it is not a crime, it is a sport. Every household keeps two ledgers: the white one for the Censor, the red one for the family. The art is in keeping the red ledger from looking like a confession.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Censor's clerks are paid to find discrepancies. They are also paid to lose them. The price of a lost discrepancy is exactly 5% of the tax owed. This is not corruption. It is "administrative flexibility."

Where do people go when they die? The family crypt, beneath the basilica floor. The wealthy are burned, their ashes mixed with marble dust and pressed into the floor tiles. The poor are buried in unmarked graves outside the walls. The Everflame's light does not reach that far.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You petition the Censor to have the wrong stricken from the public record. The petition costs a tenth of your annual income. If accepted, the wrong is erased—legally, it never happened. If rejected, the wrong is published, and you lose your civic standing.

What is the most important festival? The Triumph of the Flame (autumn equinox). The basilica's central flame is carried in procession through every district. To touch the flame is to be absolved of petty debts. To be burned by it is a sign that your debts are not petty.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Grand Magistrate's seal is a forgery. The original cracked in 783 AR. The current seal was carved by a prison engraver who was executed to keep the secret. The engraver's apprentice is still alive. They live in Silkstrand. They have the original sketches.

2.1 Ecktoria — “Marble Fire”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *The flame remembers. The marble judges. The ledger never sleeps.*

Grand Magistrate (Elite): “The law here is written not in books but in marble and flame. Every edict carries the weight of centuries, and every judgment echoes in the very stones of the Forum. But the Forum has grown quiet of late. The patricians no longer listen.”

Ferrymaster (Commoner): “I’ve seen the city burn three times and rise again like a phoenix made of stone. The marble remembers, the bells tell the truth, and the fire judges all — especially those who think coin can buy clean hands. But this time the fire isn’t burning. It’s *smiling*. The rich have stopped looking at the flames. They only look at each other.”

Genre / Mood: Imperial decay, mercantile noir, flame-lit judgment, Renaissance decadence — a city walled off from its own rot, where the wealthy dance while the poor cough ash.

Starting Location: The Coin-House floor, marble cracked with soot lines, where votive candles burn beside melted icons. A factor with smoke-singed ledgers offers a purse. “The Lame King moves,” she says. “And the Basilica burns with him. Your credit is good — for now. Find out who lit the fire, or the Flame will audit your soul at dawn. And stay away from the Amber Palace. The Vigil has been... *smiling*.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Once the heart of the Utaran Empire, Ecktoria has worn its laurels into chains. Three centuries of sack, fire, and slow decline have not stripped its marble forums nor its gold-sealed coin-houses — but each day, more of its wealth slips into the hands of mercenaries and factions. The Black Banners march on its purse, avenging old Ykrul wounds by proxy. Processions still crown its stairways, yet ash lines every step. The city burns not only with memory, but with ambition still unquenched.

Yet the true sickness is not in the streets. It is in the **Amber Palace**, where the old patrician families have walled themselves away. They sit on laurels preserved from the empire, drinking wine that costs a village's harvest, whispering deals with merchants who have never seen a loom. **Maelstraeus**, the demon of commerce and greed, has sunk his hooks into their ledgers; every contract they sign compounds interest in blood. **Livaea**, the demon of seduction and desire, has wrapped their hearts in silk; they marry for influence, divorce for scandal, and love only the reflection of themselves in gilded mirrors. The common folk call them the *Unburdened* — not because they carry no weight, but because they have forgotten what weight feels like.

The **Vigil** — once the empire's secret police, now a fractured ghost of an institution — fights a silent war over the dream of restoration. One faction, the **Chain-Lanterns**, serves the Everflame and the Synod, hunting heresy and latent magic. Another, the **Unburnt**, answers only to the old patrician houses, ensuring that no whisper of rebellion reaches the Amber Palace. A third, the **Red Vigil**, has sold itself to Maelstraeus, auditing debts and collecting interest in screams. They do not fight each other openly. They meet in the hypogeum of the Arena, under the gaze of statues that weep marble tears.

Beyond the capital's walls, the province is a patchwork of struggling towns, abandoned fortresses, and grainlands whose harvests are disputed by rival tax-collectors. The Everflame Orthodoxy preaches unity, but each sermon is a coded signal for a political camp. The statues watch. The fire judges. And in the sewers, the Vigil's informers listen for the name of the next person to vanish.

What you notice first: The smell of old incense and fresh bread — and beneath it, the faint sweetness of rot. The way crowds part for a procession — and close again for a knife. The marble steps, worn smooth by centuries of petitioners. The way the wealthy never step on the cracks.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never refuse a toast in a coin-house. The ledgers are the true judges, and a declined cup is a declined credit. You will not borrow again. But more than that: never accept a gift from a patrician without naming its price aloud. Maelstraeus and Livaea both listen, and a gift accepted in silence is a contract signed in blood.

Regional Mood: The Flame That Remembers — And The Dancers Who Forgot

Here, the past does not fade — it is polished into monuments. Every statue, every obelisk, every triumphal arch is a legal precedent carved in stone. Ecktoria is not one city but three: the marble forums of the old patricians (where the Unburdened hold masques that last for weeks, their faces painted with ash from the Everflame), the soot-stained alleys of the mercenary camps (where Black Banner captains drink with Vigil informers), and the basilicas where the Everflame's priests balance piety against profit (and sometimes sell indulgences for the sin of being born poor). The Grand Magistrate presides over a skeleton empire, but the real power moves in coin-houses, grain ledgers,

and the whispered judgments of the Censor’s Hall — and in the dreams of patricians who no longer remember the scent of rain.

The **Vigil** does not patrol the streets. It *permeates* them. Every tavern has an informer; every bathhouse has a spy; every marriage is witnessed by someone who reports to a faction of the Vigil. The Chain-Lanterns hunt magic; the Unburnt hunt sedition; the Red Vigil hunts *debt*. They are not allies. They are not enemies. They are three creditors fighting over the same soul.

The **patricians** — the Old Blood — no longer govern. They *perform* governance. A session of the Parlement might see two senators debate the price of grain while their slaves hold silver trays of honeyed figs. A decree might be passed that doubles the salt tax, then rescinded an hour later because a duchess sneezed. They are not cruel. They are *distracted*. Livaea has taught them to crave the next pleasure before they have finished the current one. Maelstraeus has taught them that every transaction is a game, and every game is winnable if you have enough coin. They do not see the bread riots. They see a shortage of *entertainment*.

The **Everflame** still burns in the basilicas, but its light has grown dim. The High Priest speaks of unity, but his sermons are interrupted by coughing from the pews — not from illness, but from the ash that falls like snow. The common folk whisper that the flame no longer judges truth; it only *records* it, filing confessions in a vault that no one ever opens. The Vigil has a key. The patricians have a copy. The poor have nothing but their names, which the Censor’s Hall writes in disappearing ink.

At a Glance

- **Atmosphere:** Marble grandeur, ash-tipped ambition, the slow rot of imperial forms, and the cloying sweetness of a city drowning in its own nostalgia.
- **Key Conflict:** Legitimacy versus wealth; old families, new mercenaries, and the Everflame’s judgment — but beneath it all, the battle between Maelstraeus (greed) and Livaea (desire) over the souls of the powerful.
- **Notable Threats:** Bread riots, arena spills, ducal conflicts, inquisitorial visits, the Red List — and the Vigil’s three factions, who may arrest you for debt, sedition, or simply being unnamed.
- **Common Rewards:** Procession permits, coin-house credit, laurel deeds, a Golden Edict carved in precedent — and, if you are brave, a secret from the Vigil’s own ledgers.

Prominent NPCs of Ecktoria

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Valerius	Grand Magistrate	Preserve the forms of law while the empire crumbles	His gavel is a sundial; it only strikes at noon. He has not struck it in a year.

Flavia	High Priest of the Ever-flame	Balance the factions and keep the flame lit	She has never raised her voice; the flame speaks for her. Lately, it speaks in the voices of the dead.
Cassia	Duchess-Regent of the Dolmis Gate	Protect her family's trading rights	She rules from behind a silk screen; a dagger-hole is cut at eye level. The screen was a gift from Livaea.
Marcus	Coin-House Factor	Survive the next credit panic	He seals deals with three ribbons: white (ask), red (now), black (never). His black ribbon is fraying.
Lucius	Lanista (arena master)	Own the next champion and the secrets of the hypogeum	His fighters' brands are his signature; he never repeats a mark. One brand is a spiral — the mark of the Red Vigil.
The Red Clerk	Censor's Hall scribe	Control which names are remembered	His inkwell is a skull; the skull belonged to a name he erased. He has forgotten his own name.

Vigil-Commander Vorenus	Chain-Lantern prefect	Hunt untutored magic before it wakes the Ninth	His lantern burns green. He says it shows the truth. His shadow has two heads.
Lady Aelia	Patrician heiress, Livaea’s favourite	Outshine every rival before the next masque	She has not left the Amber Palace in seven years. She does not know the price of bread.

Names of Ecktoria

Inspired by late Latin and early Romance: strong vowels (ae, i, o), soft endings, and the weight of imperial bureaucracy. Surnames often denote a place of origin, a trade, or a notable ancestor.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Valerius	Flavia	de Urbe	<i>the Iron</i>
Marcus	Cassia	Aquilinus	<i>the Coin-Wise</i>
Lucius	Aelia	Honoratus	<i>Flame-Touched</i>
Tiberius	Cornelia	Lateranus	<i>the Unburned</i>
Gaius	Livia	Silvanus	<i>Bread-Counter</i>
Decimus	Valeria	Portinari	<i>Ash-Finger</i>

The Three Ecktorias: Faction Spectrum

Ecktoria is not a single polity but a battlefield of three competing visions. Most citizens and factions fall somewhere between these poles, shifting allegiance as the grain price changes. Superimposed on them are the whispers of Maelstraeus and Livaea, who have no faction — only debtors.

- **Old Blood (Patrician Traditionalists)** – The ancient senatorial families who remember when Ecktoria ruled the world. They worship precedent, hoard marble, and see mercenaries as necessary filth. Their power is in law, lineage, and the silent networks of the Censor’s Hall. *Clocks: PATRICIAN PATIENCE [4], BLOOD DEBT [6]. Patron whispers: Livaea* — they marry for influence, betray for pleasure, and mistake cruelty for wit.
- **Black Purse (Mercenary & Trade Leagues)** – The new power: condotta brokers, coin-house factors, and mercenary captains who have bought what birth could not give. They care about supply lines, not bloodlines. Their loyalty is to the next contract, and their god is the ledger. *Clocks: CONTRACT SPIRAL [4], PAYDAY FEVER [6]. Patron whispers: Maelstraeus* — they measure profit in interest, interest in suffering, and suffering in silver.
- **The Everflame (Church & Inquisition)** – The priests, inquisitors, and relic-keepers who claim that the Eternal Flame is the only true sovereign. They offer legitimacy to whoever pays

the tithe — and withdraw it from whoever forgets. Their power is in pulpits, processions, and the fear of excommunication. *Clocks: HERESY INDEX [4], SANCTUARY VIOLATION [6]. Patron whispers:* Neither — the Everflame remembers, but the Vigil has learned to filter its truths.

Superimposed on these are the **Ykrul creditors** (who hold Ecktoria’s debt like a leash), the **Black Banners** (who hold its streets like a lease), and the **Vigil** (who hold its secrets like a knife). A wise politician learns to balance all three — and keeps a boat ready on the Dolmis.

The Vigil — Three Faces of the Secret Police

The Vigil is not one order but three, each claiming the mantle of the old imperial secret police. They do not cooperate. They do not war. They *audit* each other.

- **The Chain-Lanterns (Orthodox)** — Hunters of untutored magic. They carry brass lanterns that reveal latent talent through candle-smoke tests. They answer to the Synod and the Everflame, but their true loyalty is to the *precedent* — the law that magic must be licensed, indexed, and taxed. A Chain-Lantern raid is heralded by a single, low bell. *Clocks: CANDLE-SMOKE SWEEP [4], HERETIC INDEX [6].*
- **The Unburnt (Patrician)** — Bodyguards and spies of the Amber Palace. They wear red sashes and carry no visible weapons. Their job is to ensure that no whisper of rebellion, no bread riot, no debt revolt ever reaches a patrician’s ear. They are experts at *redaction* — not killing witnesses, but making them forget. *Clocks: PALACE SECRETS [4], REDACTED MEMORY [6].*
- **The Red Vigil (Maelstraeus’s Own)** — Debt-collectors and interest-enforcers. They serve no noble, no church, no magistrate — only the ledger. They audit the wealthy for the wealthy, finding hidden obligations, unpaid tithes, and compound interest that has grown teeth. A Red Vigil agent never demands coin. They demand *names*. *Clocks: INTEREST DUE [4], LEDGER OF NAMES [6].*

The Vigil’s three commanders meet once a month in the hypogeum of the Arena, under the gaze of statues that weep marble tears. No record is kept of these meetings. No one admits they happen. The common folk say that if you see a Vigil agent, it is already too late — but they cannot agree on *which* Vigil.

Spades — Places

2. **Petition Steps** — Milk-stone steps where dawn petitions are pinned. *The petitions are written in ink and hope. The steps answer in marble and silence.* ‘[SOCIAL]’
3. **Tally-Ford Ferryhouse** — Rope-drums thrum all day; the ferrymaster watches coin and banners. *The rope-drums have a pattern. It spells the names of those who paid late.* ‘[TRAVEL]’
4. **Arena Hypogeum** — Practice sand and whispered secrets beneath the games. *The sand is from the Tiber. It still remembers the blood of the last revolt. The Vigil meets here.* ‘[DEATH]’
5. **Everflame Cloister** — Candle markets and side-chapels where flame speaks truth. *The flame has a voice. It is the voice of the last liar who tested it. Lately, it speaks in a whisper.* ‘[TRUTH]’
6. **Shatterline Bazaar** — Between quake-toppled columns, merchants hawk broken dreams. *The columns were toppled by an earthquake that killed a senator. He still haunts the rubble, counting his debts.* ‘[TRADE]’

7. **Coin-House Floor** — Counting ledgers under glass; factors seal credit with three ribbons. *The ribbons are colored: white for "ask," red for "now," black for "never." The black ribbons are all frayed.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
8. **Mile-Zero Obelisk** — Surveyors’ starting point; all roads measured from here. *The obelisk has a crack. The crack is a mile long — in the other direction. The Vigil uses it to measure disappearances.* ‘[LAW]’
9. **Triumph Stairs** — Processional Way switchback; marble worn smooth by ambition. *The stairs have a name: "The Rise of the Forgotten." No one remembers why. The patricians still climb them.* ‘[SOCIAL]’
10. **Aqueduct Walk** — Narrow guardpath above the city’s arteries; perfect for ambush or escape. *The water below tastes of iron. It is the city’s memory of its own blood. The Vigil drinks it to stay awake.* ‘[STEALTH]’
- J **Ducal Loggia** — High above a packed square; a duchess watches and waits. *The duchess has not blinked in three hours. She is counting. She has forgotten what she is counting.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
- Q **Censor’s Hall** — Red-lacquered tablets record every name, every shame. *The tablets are redacted in invisible ink. The truth is underneath. The Vigil has the reagent.* ‘[LAW]’
- K **Grand Forum** — Statues tarped, echoes loud; where crowds become mobs. *The tarps were a gift from a dead emperor. The statues do not thank him. They whisper to the Vigil.* ‘[SOCIAL]’
- A **The Amber Palace** — Walled off from the city, where the patricians hold masques that last for weeks. *The walls are not stone. They are debt. No one has entered without an invitation in a decade. No one has left.* ‘[LEGEND]’

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Torchbearer Child** — Ash-smudged hands; knows every shortcut through the ruins. *She has never been lost. The ruins speak to her in dust. The Vigil pays her for echoes.* ‘[STEALTH]’
3. **Ferrymaster** — Knows which banners pay late; collects more than coin. *His ledger is a net. The names are the catch. He sold a name to the Red Vigil once. He does not sleep well.* ‘[TRAVEL]’
4. **Coin-House Factor** — Seals credit with three ribbons; eyes twitch at defaults. *His eyes are the color of old silver. They see through your purse. They also see the Red Vigil in the corner.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
5. **Lanista** — Owns fighters — and their secrets; sells victory in the sand. *His grin is a brand. The brand is on his fighters’ necks. One fighter has a brand that glows — a Vigil spy.* ‘[COMBAT]’
6. **Decumanus-Master** — Surveyor who "moves" stones; rewrites the city’s shape. *His rod is a finger bone. The bone belonged to the last surveyor who argued. The Vigil uses his maps.* ‘[LAW]’
7. **Procession Marshal** — Permits and whistle; keeps order in ceremonial chaos. *His whistle is for the living. His bell is for the dead. He has not used the whistle in a year.* ‘[SOCIAL]’
8. **Grain-Prefect** — Allots loaves; knives in the margins of every ledger. *His ledger has a stain. The stain is wine — or blood. The Vigil has a copy.* ‘[DEBT]’
9. **Censor’s Clerk** — "Misfiles" careers; knows which names to forget. *His inkwell is a*

skull. The skull belonged to a name he forgot. The Vigil pays him for the ones he remembers.
 ‘[LAW]’

10. **Veteran Standard-Bearer** — Sells honor as a retainer; medals heavier than sword. *His medals are from a war that never happened. The corpses are from one that did. The Vigil recruited him.* ‘[COMBAT]’
- J **Gladiatrix** — Darling of the crowds; owes no one but the sand. *Her sword has no name. The sand has many. The Vigil has a file on her. It is thicker than her arm.* ‘[COMBAT]’
- Q **Duchess-Regent** — Behind a silk screen; speaks through cousins, rules through silence. *The screen has a hole. The hole is for a dagger — hers. The screen was a gift from Livaea.* ‘[POLITICS]’
- K **High Priest of Everflame** — Smiles like law; flame judges truth and debt. *His smile is a candle. It can warm — or burn. The Vigil has asked him to smile less.* ‘[TRUTH]’
- A **Vigil-Commander Vorenius** — Leads the Chain-Lanterns. Fears the Unburnt. Hates the Red Vigil. *His lantern burns green. He says it shows the truth. His shadow has two heads — one for each faction he has betrayed.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Blocked Bridge** — A procession blocks the only crossing till sundown. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The procession is for a saint who died hungry. The saint is not forgiving. The Vigil is watching.*
3. **Proscribed Sigil** — A sudden edict: your mark is now forbidden. ‘[LAW]’ *The edict was written in the dead of night. The ink is still wet — and warm. The Vigil’s seal is on the back.*
4. **Bread Riots** — Grain barges are late; hunger hisses at the city’s edges. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The hunger has a face. It is the face of a baker who ran out of flour. The Vigil is looking for him.*
5. **Arena Spill** — A riot spills into streets; shutters slam, guards draw steel. ‘[COMBAT]’ *The riot started over a point. The point was a sword. The Vigil started it.*
6. **Ducal Conflict** — Rival dukes levy the same ward; your recruits vanish. ‘[POLITICS]’ *The recruits are not dead. They are hired. They are now your enemies — and Vigil informers.*
7. **Border Dispute** — A re-plat redraws boundaries; your deed becomes "disputed." ‘[LAW]’ *The surveyor’s rod is bent. He calls it "context." The Vigil calls it leverage.*
8. **Frozen Purse** — A coin-house calls in notes; your purse freezes at the worst moment. ‘[DEBT]’ *The notes were called by a dead man. His signature is still warm. The Red Vigil is at the door.*
9. **Inquisitorial Visit** — A relic’s authenticity is questioned; penalties are swift and public. ‘[TRUTH]’ *The relic is a nail from a cross. It has been forged seven times. It still works. The Vigil supplied the forger.*
10. **Aftershock** — Masonry and timetables fall; scaffolds groan with new cracks. ‘[DISASTER]’ *The crack has a name. It whispers it to the wind. The Vigil writes it down.*
- J **Counterfeit Laurel** — Your win is void unless you find the forger. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The forger is a child. The child is a slave. The slave is a senator’s son. The Vigil knows.*
- Q **Church Purge** — "Spectacles" are banned; your venue is canceled by zealots. ‘[DEATH]’ *The zealots are paid by a rival. The rival is in the front row. The Vigil is in the back.*
- K **Rerouted Triumph** — The crowd follows the favored path; your moment is stolen. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The favored path is lined with archers. The archers are not there for the ceremony. They are Vigil.*

A **Red List** — A secret ledger; your patron’s name appears overnight. ‘[DEATH]’ *The list is written in a dead hand. The dead are still collecting. The Vigil holds the pen.*

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Bread Chit** — Ward sustenance for a week; street patience guaranteed. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The chit is a clay token. Break it to eat — or to bribe. The Vigil accepts both.*
 3. **Procession Permit** — Move sacred flame through a crowded quarter; law walks with you. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The permit is a torch. Carry it, and the city will part — or burn. The Vigil will follow.*
 4. **Arena Purse** — Settles debts and hires mouths; blood-money in coin. ‘[COMBAT]’ *The purse is a helmet. The helmet belonged to a champion who lost. The Vigil has his name.*
 5. **Survey Writ** — Reset one boundary stone; redraw the city’s shape. ‘[LAW]’ *The writ is a stone. Move it, and the map changes — on paper. The Vigil watches the paper.*
 6. **Ducal Safe-Conduct** — Four guards and a trumpet; noble favor walks ahead. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The guards are paid by the duke. The trumpet is paid by you. The Vigil has a key to the trumpet.*
 7. **Coin-House Credit** — Silent and immediate; debt becomes opportunity. ‘[DEBT]’ *The credit is a ribbon. Cut it to spend — or to owe. The Vigil will collect the interest.*
 8. **Magistrate’s Postponement** — Buy a tenday against any suit; law delayed, not denied. ‘[LAW]’ *The postponement is a letter. The letter is sealed with a tear. The Vigil has the other copy.*
 9. **Laurel-Deed** — Crowd favor follows you into court; glory as a shield. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The deed is a leaf. It was plucked from a victor’s crown. The victor is dead. The Vigil knows why.*
 10. **Grain Ledger** — Name who eats this month; hunger bends to your will. ‘[DEBT]’ *The ledger is a stomach. Feed it, or it will feed on you. The Vigil has the first page.*
- J **Minor Title** — A style that opens doors that bolts resist; rank as a key. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The title is a word. The word is "Patrician." The doors do not ask questions. The Vigil does.*
- Q **Basilica Audience** — One private hour with the High Priest; the flame speaks truth. ‘[TRUTH]’ *The hour is a candle. When it burns out, so does your favor. The Vigil lit the candle.*
- K **Censor’s Indulgence** — One banned thing becomes permitted (for you). ‘[LAW]’ *The indulgence is a silence. The silence is a scream. The Vigil has earplugs.*
- A **Golden Edict** — An exception carved in marble; precedent travels like law. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The edict is a crack. The crack in the law is now an opening. The Vigil is already inside.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (papers/favor/precedence) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **marble and fire** motifs — statues that watch, flames that judge, and law that remembers every name. Also echo the **Vigil’s presence** — a cough in the crowd, a seal on a document you did not stamp, a mirror that shows a different face.

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **Imperial Ruins:** Every district bears half-collapsed arcades, serving as markets, courts, or shelters for mercenary companies. The Vigil knows every hidden passage.
- **Competing Factions:** Dukes, guilds, and priests stage processions that collide at bridges and squares, each claiming legitimacy. The Vigil collects bets on the outcome.
- **Monuments as Weapons:** Statues, obelisks, and colonnades are not only symbols — they are barricades, rallying points, and high ground when the city riots. The Vigil has a map of which statues can be toppled.
- **Everflame Orthodoxy:** The basilicas preach unity, but each sermon is a coded signal for a political camp. The High Priest plays balance while cultivating his own following. The Vigil decodes every sermon.
- **Black Banner Contracts:** Foreign mercenaries fill the gaps left by a shrinking citizen levy, their loyalty secured only by steady coin. The Vigil audits their pay.
- **The Amber Palace Quarantine:** The patricians have not left the palace in a decade. No one is certain if they are prisoners or patrons. The Vigil maintains the perimeter — and delivers the wine.
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Saints & Cults):**
 - **St. Marcellus of the Gilded Scale (Mykkiel)** — *The Justiciar*. His order enforces unwritten laws; reading a sealed precedent binds the reader to enforce it. His shrine is the Censor's Hall. The Vigil keeps a copy of every precedent.
 - **St. Valeria of the Serpent (Isoka)** — *The Shedding Saint*. Pilgrims who confess at her chapel forget one sin — and one kindness. Her mosaic shows a snake eating its tail. The Vigil uses her chapel to erase memories.
 - **St. Lucia of the Undying Flame (Oath of Flame & Light)** — *The Witness of Embers*. Any oath sworn over her shrine's flame cannot be broken; the breaker sees their own face in every wave until they drown. The Vigil swears oaths there — and never breaks them.
 - **The Reckoner (Maelstraeus)** — *The Ledger Keeper*. A mystery cult of coin-house factors. They offer credit at the cost of a hidden interest that compounds in blood. The Red Vigil are their debt-collectors.
 - **The Ember Prefect (Heretic Cult)** — A schism that believes the flame should not be contained. They meet in the arena hypogeum, chanting the *Unspoken Ninth Citation*. The Grand Magistrate has outlawed them three times. The Vigil has infiltrated them twice.
 - **The Velvet Mask (Livaea)** — A secret society of patricians who worship pleasure as the only truth. Their rites are said to last nine days. No one has ever left a rite unchanged. The Vigil watches their parties — and reports to the Unburnt.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Bitter Root:** Daughters of the Cord run a hospice in the Shatterline Bazaar. They ask no payment — but they cut threads. A renegade Sister hides among the arena slaves, trying to untie her cord from a coin-house debt. The Vigil has her file.
- **Malachai, the Chained Angel:** A silver coin that never spends circulates among the grain-prefects. Take it, and your store never runs dry — but the coin will reappear in the

mouth of a starving child. The Red Vigil uses it to mark debtors.

- **The Grey Wanderer’s Grimoire:** Ecktorian psions are called “Flame-Readers.” They see the future in the Everflame’s flicker. The High Priest employs three — and has never trusted a forecast that didn’t smell of smoke. The Vigil employs their apprentices.
- **The Threshold Compendium:** The Imperial Arena is a Class IV Poltergeist site — the collective rage of every gladiator who died for the crowd. Saikou Ira would ring a bell eight times and leave a wreath of laurel. The Vigil rings the bell nine times. The Arena answers.
- **The Ninth:** In any Ecktorian court, the ninth citation of precedent voids all previous. The wise stop at eight and settle. Those who cite the ninth hear a faint laughter from the marble walls — and their cases are never heard again. The Vigil cites the ninth often. The laughter does not bother them.

Ecktoria Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Flame:** Crumble a crust into the Everflame. Ignore the first *Bread Riots* penalty. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Knot the Ribbon:** Tie a single knot in a coin-house credit ribbon. Cancel *Frozen Purse* or take −1 die on your next debt roll (your choice). ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Name to the Marble:** Whisper a dead debtor’s name into a statue’s ear. Gain +1 Effect when collecting from their heirs this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Grand Magistrate. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Spit on the Seal:** Before signing any contract, spit on the wax seal. If it sizzles, the Vigil has a copy. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **city guards or rival factions**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **crowds or ceremonial processions**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **patrols or inquisitors**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or ceremonial opportunity**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **City authorities or noble house** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **crowd movement or procession**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **rival faction member or city official** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **guards, mercenaries, or zealots** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.

- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes — **procession turns violent/boundary dispute erupts/patron turns**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival: High Priest, Grand Magistrate, or Duchess-Regent** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically — **procession erupts/arena gate opens/monument collapses**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice — **flame speaks/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Ecktoria (Marble & Fire):** Statues turn their heads, flames burn blue, ceremonial masks appear in windows.
- **Ecktoria (Procession):** Crowds chant your name, banners block your path, trumpets announce your arrival.
- **Ecktoria (Patronage):** Seals break in your hand, favors are revoked, noble houses compete for your allegiance.
- **Ecktoria (The Vigil):** A seal appears on your documents that you did not stamp. A cough from the crowd sounds like your name. Your reflection in a polished shield has a red sash.

Extensions (Plug-in)

- **Cross-Region Hooks (optional draws):**
 - *Aeler True Masons* bid to shore a failing aqueduct; accepting stabilizes *Aftershock* but grants them soft leverage in the ward. The Vigil audits the contract.
 - *Aelinnel Green-Market* broker offers “truth-credit” on court gossip; pay later in favors or names. The Vigil pays in silence.
 - *Black Banner* retainer parade demands back pay on the Triumph Stairs; crowd sympathy tilts your next parley. The Vigil arrests the ringleader.
- **Faction Entanglements During Travel (use en route or on city entry):**
 - If the party holds any *Condotta* Diamonds, begin with *Bread Riots* at +1 segment (mercenary grain trains re-routed).
 - Entering with an *Underway Pass* (Aeler) grants +1 Position on *Aqueduct Walk* scenes but ticks *Ducal Conflict* once (guild jealousy). The Vigil notes your pass.
 - Carrying *Green Market* tags downgrades one *Censor’s Hall* action but flags *Inquisitorial Visit* at the next temple. The Vigil compares tags.
- **Trade Good Consequences (pick 1 when a haul sells):**
 - *Arena Steel* → street duels spike → start *Arena Spill* at 1. The Vigil collects the weapons.
 - *Relic Fragments* → basilica prestige swings → tick *Church Purge* or grant *Basilica Audience*. The Vigil inspects the relic.

- *Survey Rights* → boundary re-plot → downgrade one *Border Dispute* or upgrade a rival's. The Vigil updates the map.
- **Diplomatic Favor (minor currency):**
 - Earn by resolving a public scene without bloodshed (Forum, Procession, Coin-House).
 - Spend 1 to reduce DV of a permit/audience by 1, or to ignore *Blocked Bridge* for one crossing.
 - Holding 2+ makes you “interesting”: start a *Red List* [4] that advances on snubbed patrons. The Vigil adds your name.
- **Reputation Echoes (soft power):**
 - *Crowd-Loved (Laurel-Deed)*: first time per session you face a mob, set Position one step safer. The Vigil watches how the mob loves you.
 - *Coin-House Trusted (Credit)*: ignore the first *Frozen Purse*; next time, it returns at +1 severity. The Vigil audits your credit.
 - *Clerically Vouched (Everflame)*: downgrade one *Inquisitorial Visit*; if abused, promote *Church Purge*. The Vigil has a copy of your voucher.

Monuments as Mechanics (opulence with teeth)

- **Processional Geometry:** When acting on the *Triumph Stairs*, choose: +1 Effect or –1 Heat; on a miss, *Rerouted Triumph* advances. The Vigil stands at the top of the stairs, watching.
- **Aqueduct Leverage:** Securing an aqueduct span grants a one-scene *high ground* tag in any linked ward; if collateral hits, tick *Aftershock*. The Vigil knows where the aqueduct leaks.
- **Forum Acoustics:** Rally speeches at the *Grand Forum* grant an extra assist die if at least 20 witnesses; failure spawns *Bread Riots* at +1. The Vigil counts the witnesses.

Plug-in SB Conversions (Ecktoria flavor)

- Any 1 SB may become *Crowd Drift*: shift the scene's terrain in favor of or against you (bridges clog, stairs clear).
- Any 2 SB may become *Seal Revoked*: void one paper (Permit/Chit/Indulgence); to avert, sacrifice *Diplomatic Favor*.
- On 3+ SB offer *Patron Bargain*: accept a visible mark (ribbon, laurel brand) to halve consequences; start a *Patron Debt* [6].

Hidden Orders & Ancient Conspiracies (d12 hooks)

1. **The Ash Senate** – a ledger of “extinguished” patrician lines still voting by proxy through funerary guilds. The Vigil has the key.
2. **Surveyors of the Ninth Mile** – decumanus-masters who can *move* boundaries with ritual math; a lost rod sets precedent across the city. The Vigil owns the rod.
3. **Lantern Tetrarchy** – four basilica beadles who decide which miracles are counted; the fifth lamp was broken in a purge. The Vigil lit the purge.
4. **The Red Marble Compact** – coin-house founders who tithe 1 in 100 coins to a secret indemnity fund used to flip coups. The Red Vigil administers the fund.
5. **Archivum Umbrae** – censor clerks maintaining a *shadow index* of names that must not stand trial (yet). The Vigil reads the index nightly.

6. **Peregrine Brotherhood** – ferrymasters trading in sealed confessions; blackmail that floats. The Vigil buys the confessions.
7. **The Laurel of Dust** – a gladiators’ mutual that chooses which champions live long enough to hold office. The Vigil chooses the champions.
8. **Aqueduct Collegium Obscura** – engineers who keep a second set of sluice keys; droughts become elections. The Vigil has the third set.
9. **Order of the Broken Obelisk** – survey-cult that believes Mile-Zero is *wrong* and can re-found the city with one stone. The Vigil has the stone.
10. **The Funeral Republic** – undertakers running a parallel courier state through catacombs and wakes. The Vigil uses their couriers.
11. **The Ember Vault** – a sealed reliquary under the Arena; victors’ sweat was bottled for augury. The Vigil broke the seal.
12. **Triumphal Maskers** – procession costumers who encode heretical theses into robe pleats and torch patterns. The Vigil decodes the theses — and sometimes agrees.

Cults & Mystery Rites (d10)

1. **Children of the Phoenix** (*rebirth by fire*): ash-marks grant +1 die vs. fear in crowds; mark Fatigue if you hesitate near open flame.
2. **Verdant Laurel** (*blood to marble, sap to coin*): once/session turn 1 Harm into 1 Coin-House Credit; start a *Green Debt* [4].
3. **Mask of the Thirteenth** (*forbidden procession step*): walk through a riot unmolested; next parley with clergy begins one step worse.
4. **Brotherhood of the River Tongue** (*truth ferried at night*): ask the Dolmis one yes/no; a ferryman shows up later to collect a name.
5. **Candlemakers of Ever** (*flame remembers lies*): blue flame points to falsehood; the liar dreams of you for three nights (Exposure +1).
6. **Sable Standard** (*war saint cult*): your banner ignores morale checks once; start a *Blood-Tithe* [4] owed to the saint’s chapel.
7. **The Ninth Bell** (*hour that is not kept*): skip a queue or sentence; next edict you need arrives late (Delay SB free once).
8. **Guild of Red Accountants** (*sin as ledger*): convert 2 SB into a *Magistrate’s Postponement*; add *Karmic Debt* [6].
9. **The Marble Eaters** (*mortification sect*): bite stone, gain +1 Effect resisting crowd crush; take Harm 1 (Stress) if you boast.
10. **Torch of Saint Vessa** (*saint of necessary arson*): sanctify a fire to purge a tag (Plague/Corruption); City Heat +2.

Religious Schisms & Trials

The Everflame Divide (choose a live schism)

1. **Orthodox Basilica vs. Ember Reformers**: Is miracle *counted* by law or *kindled* by need?
2. **Laurel Theologians vs. Street Saints**: Does glory flow *down* from triumphs or *up* from bread-lines?
3. **Iconoclast Ward vs. Reliquary Keepers**: Is the flame purer without images?

Schism Mechanics (table-facing)

- **Heresy Index** [0–6]: ticks when players publicize a stance, defy clergy, or wield cult rites in view. At 3: inquisitorial audits become common; at 6: *Church Purge* (Q) auto-triggers once/session until lowered.
- **Sanctuary / Anathema Tags:** locations acquire tags during arc scenes. *Sanctuary*: first harm in scene becomes Fatigue; *Anathema*: first social miss spawns “Proscribed Sigil.”
- **Trial by Fire (mini-procedure, 3 beats):**
 1. *Assembly*: set the forum/stair as arena; state thesis in one sentence (players or NPCs).
 2. *Witness*: three proofs (relic, miracle, precedent). Each proof: test Social/Arcana/Resolve vs. crowd DV; on success, reduce Index by 1 or gain *Basilica Audience*.
 3. *Judgment*: roll Crowd Mood (1d6): 1–2 mobs, 3–4 silent acceptance, 5–6 laurel toss (gain *Laurel-Deed*). If Index ≥ 4 , –1 to the roll.

Ecktoria – Marble and Fire

Starting Location: The Coin-House floor, marble cracked with soot lines, where votive candles burn beside melted icons.

“In Ecktoria, even faith must balance its ledgers, and the gods audit in ash.”

In... the Coin-House floor, a factor with smoke-singed ledgers offers a purse. “The Lame King moves,” she says. “And the Basilica burns with him. The Amber Palace has not answered a summons in a month. The Vigil is asking questions. I suggest you find the answers before they find you.”

Regional Motifs Coin-oaths, basilica relics, marble acoustics, augury smoke, Vigil seals.

Whispers to Offer “Bid against the city,” “Pocket the relic shard,” “Name an innocent debtor,” “The Vigil’s informer sits in the corner.”

External Clocks Threat: *Procession of Ash* [6]; Community: *Credit Panic* [4]; Anchor: *Basilica Choir* [4]; Vigil: *Red List* [6].

Complications Smoke speaks truths; coins stick to skin; a reliquary runs hot; a seal appears on your documents that you did not stamp.

Anchors at Risk A choir novice; a patron account; a Vigil informer who owes you a favour.

Escalation Beat The Basilica tolls a note only one PC hears. The Vigil hears it too.

Relief Return the shard; pay a city-debt in blood or ; route the procession elsewhere; give the Vigil a name.

Boss Seeds (Cults & Conspiracies)

- **The Ember Prefect** (schismatic inquisitor): *Phase* [8] Citation → Censure → Auto-da-fé → Purge. Lair: Everflame Cloister. Counters: relic provenance, crowd-favor, rival sermon. *Vigil twist*: The Prefect was once a Vigil informer. The Vigil knows where he hides.
- **The Surveyor-Primus** (geomantic usurper): *Phase* [6] Re-plat → Dispossess → Erase. Lair: Mile-Zero. Counters: Aeler measure-rods, witness line, broken rod. *Vigil twist*: The Primus has a Red Vigil agent as a protégé.
- **Phoenix of the Arena** (miracle or hoax?): *Phase* [10] Hype → Immolation → “Rebirth” → Riot. Lair: Imperial Arena. Counters: doused ash, Mask of the Thirteenth, Everflame test. *Vigil twist*: The Phoenix is a Vigil experiment. The Unburnt want to contain it. The Red Vigil wants to sell tickets.
- **The Velvet Mask** (Livaea’s cult): *Phase* [8] Invitation → Masque → Debt of Pleasure. Lair: The Amber Palace. Counters: an unbroken oath, a mirror with no reflection, a name spoken without desire. *Vigil twist*: The Vigil’s Unburnt faction attends every masque. They are not there to stop it.

Diamonds: Forbidden Leverage (add to §2.1)

14. **Shadow Index Leaf** – remove one name from the Red List for a week; add *Countercoup* +1.
15. **Ember Writ** – sanction one cult rite as “orthodox” for a scene.
16. **Surveyor’s Ninth Rod** – redraw one ward line unnoticed (until dawn).
17. **Vigil Seal (Red)** – For one scene, the Red Vigil treats you as a contractor. Interest will be collected later.

Cross-Contamination (fast ties)

- **Aeler True Masons**: backing an iconoclast audit grants shoring crews; bell-codes now gate temple entries. The Vigil has the bell-codes.
- **Aelinnel Thorn Courts**: hawthorn chaplains host “mirror sermons”; a basilica gains *Sanctuary* while a rival becomes *Anathema*. The Vigil watches both.
- **Black Banners**: war-chaplains monetize indulgences; clearing *Payday* risks +1 *Heresy Index*. The Vigil takes a cut.

Patronage & Power

Ecktoria’s decline is not collapse, but transformation. Wealth bleeds into patronage webs: a senator’s indulgence, a censor’s indulgence, a noble’s purse. The city’s great houses keep mercenary captains on retainer, while priests sell ritual processions as public theater and private favor. And everywhere, the Vigil watches — not to stop the rot, but to take notes. Yet beneath the decay, two demons whisper. **Maelstraeus** teaches that every contract is a weapon, every debt a leash. **Livaea** teaches that every desire is a chain, every pleasure a payment. The patricians who once ruled the world now rule only the Amber Palace, and the Amber Palace is a gilded cage. They do not see the bread riots. They do not hear the Vigil’s footsteps. They dance. They drink. They forget that the flame remembers everything.

For the GM: Patronage should function as both opportunity and trap. Any gift (a purse, permit, or charter) binds the receiver to service, but patrons can die, fall from favor, or suddenly proscribe what they once allowed. The Vigil offers a different kind of patronage: *protection* in exchange for *information*. A party that pays the Vigil in secrets may find doors opening — and other doors closing behind them. To emphasize the decadence and dread:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (seals, ribbons, laurel crowns, Vigil marks) that can be stolen, forged, or voided.
- Let rival patrons issue conflicting "safe-conducts," forcing players to choose whose favor matters more.
- Use processions, funerals, or trials as arenas for social contests, where patronage debts surface and shift allegiances.
- Introduce the **Vigil’s Faction Clock** [6] to track which Vigil faction (Chain-Lanterns, Unburnt, Red Vigil) has the most leverage over the party. When it fills, that faction makes a demand.

Patronage in Ecktoria is not mere background — it is the engine of politics, coin, and survival. And beneath it all, Maelstraeus and Livaea are writing a contract. The city is the collateral. The poor are the interest. The patricians are the signature — and they signed in blood long ago.

Chapter 3

Acasia

The Broken Marches.

We do not speak of the Curse. We speak around it, under it, through the gaps where words used to fit. The Curse is not a thing. It is the space where a thing used to be.

I am a charcoal-burner. My family has worked these woods for three generations. My grandfather could name every tree between the Pale Causeway and the Wolfstairs Pass. My father could read a deer's track in packed clay. I can tell you where the villages used to be. The map in my head has more empty spaces than marks.

Acasia was not always like this. Once, the granaries held grain through winter. Once, the roads carried more than ghosts and tax collectors. Then the trees started dying. Not all at once—slowly, branch by branch, forest by forest. The Blackwood turned grey, then brittle, then silent. The farmers said it was a curse. The duke said it was blight. The merchants said it was the tariffs. The priests said it was the will of gods who had stopped listening.

Nobody said it was guilt. Nobody had to. Guilt is the smell of mildew on old parchment. Guilt is the way a village watches you pass without opening its gates. Guilt is the empty chair at the feast, the unmarked grave behind the chapel, the child who will not meet your eyes because their parents told them not to speak to strangers.

The truth—the one we do not speak—is that we could have saved the Blackwood. We saw the first trees wither. We saw the sap run black. We did nothing. We told ourselves it would pass. We told ourselves the duke would fix it. We told ourselves the forest was not our responsibility. And then the forest died, and the silence that followed was our answer.

The Curse of Acasia is not a spell. It is a memory. The land remembers what we did—and what we failed to do. Every broken milestone on the old Imperial Road is a forgotten promise. Every abandoned vineyard is a harvest we chose not to plant. Every bridge that leads back to the same shore is the road we refused to take.

Never sign a contract on a bridge. The river is a witness, and it never forgets a signature. But more than that: the bridge knows when you are lying. Not to the other party. To yourself.

We are the Curse now. We carry it in our silence, in our empty fields, in the way we turn away when someone asks where the children went. Acasia is not a broken province. It is a province that broke itself, one small refusal at a time, until there was nothing left to break but the people who stayed.

And still we stay. Because leaving would mean admitting we were wrong. And that is the one thing guilt cannot bear.

— *Corvin, charcoal-burner of the Blackwood, who no longer names the trees because there are too few left to name*

The Almanac of Ordinary Days

What do people eat for breakfast? Hardtack soaked in broth—if you have broth. If not, hardtack and hope. The granaries have been empty for three winters. The merchants sell grain at famine prices. The duke says the roads are too dangerous for caravans. The farmers say the duke owns the caravans.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To name the dead. Every Acasian child has a list of ancestors they repeat at bedtime. The list gets shorter each generation. Not because children forget. Because the dead are forgetting themselves.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Whether they have a shadow. The Curse takes shadows first. A man without a shadow is not cursed—he is already gone. His body just hasn't stopped moving yet.

What is the most common crime? Bridge-toll evasion. The roads are unsafe, the ferries are unreliable, but the barons still demand payment for crossings no one can make. The crime is not in refusing to pay. The crime is in being caught trying.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Curse began with a promise broken on the Blackwood Bridge. A baron promised his daughter to a lord of the old forest. He married her to a lowland knight instead. The forest remembered. The forest is still waiting for the wedding.

Where do people go when they die? Into the Blackwood. Burial is forbidden—the ground rejects the dead. Bodies are carried to the tree-line and left. The wood takes them. Sometimes, at dusk, you can see them walking between the trunks. They do not look back.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You walk the Broken Mile—a stretch of road that collapsed into the river a decade ago. If you reach the far side, you are forgiven. If you fall, you were not sorry enough. No one has reached the far side in seven years.

What is the most important festival? The Counting of the Names (midwinter). Every village lists its dead aloud, from oldest to newest. If a name is forgotten, the ghost walks until someone remembers. The list grows longer each year. The memory grows shorter.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The duke's son is a ghoul. He was lost in the Blackwood as a child. They found him three days later, pale and smiling. He does not age. He does not eat. He only watches. The servants know. The servants do not speak.

3.1 Acasia — “Broken Marches”

Margravine of the Broken March (Elite): “The tithe must be paid, not merely offered. A promise written in ash and sealed with iron will is worth more than a thousand gold coins scattered on the wind.”

Hedge-Witch (Commoner): “Don’t cross the Pale Causeway at dusk, especially not if you’ve got a silver tooth. The bridge’ll remember it, and next time you pass, it’ll want more than just your footfall. In Acasia, every road has a memory. The question is who pays the toll.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Acasia is a former province of the Uтарan Empire that festers in the space between famine and ambition. Every hill wears a crown, every bridge demands a price, and every road curves back to the same cursed crossroads. Where once the Empire’s coin and grain flowed, now tithe-collectors gnaw the marrow of starving villages, and warlords dress themselves as kings. The land itself has grown bitter: grain blights spread like gossip, wine turns to vinegar in the cask, and the old Imperial roads have forgotten where they lead. The Curse—the nameless thing that makes crossroads loop back on themselves—is not a myth. It is the weight of broken promises, and Acasia is drowning in them.

What you notice first: The smell of mildew on old parchment and wet ash. The way every milestone has been recarved. The silence of a village that heard you coming and chose not to open its gates.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never sign a contract on a bridge. The river is a witness, and it never forgets a signature.

Regional Mood: Famine and Ambition

Here, the past is not a memory—it is a predator. The Uтарan Empire left behind roads that lead to nowhere, laws that contradict each other, and a hunger that no harvest can fill. Acasia’s petty kings hold court in burned keeps, their crowns forged from iron nails pulled from famine coffins. The Margravine keeps a tally of feuds, binding bloodlines to her feast days. Free Companies trade loyalty like grain, swapping colors mid-march. And beneath it all, the Curse waits. It is not a monster. It is a geometry: the wrong turn, the bridge that leads back to the same shore, the bell that tolls for no funeral. In Acasia, the land itself has become a contract, and the fine print is written in mildew.

Starting Location: The Pale Causeway’s last inn, walls soot-blackened by coal and a century of gossip. A bounty poster flutters beside a half-empty hearth. The innkeeper is a one-eyed woman who pours small beer without asking. A stranger at the bar offers a sealed contract: retrieve a dowry chest from a Blackwood matriarch before the Margravine’s feast day. “The chest contains a claim, not coin,” the stranger whispers. “But a claim in Acasia is worth more than gold—it is a key to a bridge that does not loop.”

Prominent NPCs of Acasia

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk

Morwen <i>“the Ledger”</i>	Margravine of the Broken March	Keep the province from fracturing completely	She has never lost a feud; her sword is also a counting rod.
Oren <i>“Tin Crown”</i>	The Lame King	Be recognised as a true sovereign	His travelling throne is carried by debtors; he pays them in promises.
Ysabeau	Hedge-Witch of the Blackwood Charcoalers	Survive the Curse and keep her kin from the rope	She knows which bridges eat travellers, and her price is a story that ends badly.
The Bride	Dowry chest claimant (Blackwood matriarch’s heir)	Recover the chest before the Margravine’s feast day	She carries a dagger in her wedding veil. The claim is to a bridge that drowned.
Vladan	Free Company Captain (“The Rusted Banner”)	Find a permanent contract before winter	He has served three kings this year. He cannot remember their names.
Sister Ash	Ex-Imperial surveyor	Finish the old map of Acasia	She visits villages that no longer exist. The map shows them anyway.

Names of Acasia

Inspired by the martial duchies of a fallen southern empire: clipped Latin, war-names, and the hard consonants of mountain keeps.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Alboin	Theodelinda	da Ponte	<i>the Stiff</i>
Authari	Rosamund	del Ferro	<i>the Toll-Fist</i>
Liutprand	Gundiberga	di Rocca	<i>Bridge-Born</i>
Desiderius	Anspranda	Longobardus	<i>Blackwood</i>
Ratchis	Veleda	Saxo	<i>the Unremembered</i>

Aistulf	Gisela	Capoferro	Ash-Finger
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(Pass/Ruin/Toll-Town) Broken milestone on the old Imperial Road; borders “moved” overnight. Vine-terrace hillside with an abandoned press; strangler ivy owns it now.

Spades — Places

2. **Broken Milestone** [RUIN] [OMEN]
On the old Imperial Road; borders “moved” overnight.
The stone has been chiseled seven times. The last mark is still wet.
3. **Vine-Terrace Hillside** [RUIN] [HARVEST]
Abandoned press; strangler ivy owns it now.
The ivy has grown around a skeleton. The skeleton still holds a wine cup.
4. **Toll-Bridge Town** [TOLL] [BOUNDARY]
Over a cold river; two tolls, no receipts.
The second toll is collected by a child. The child does not speak.
5. **Wolfstairs Pass** [MOUNTAIN] [AMBUSH]
Switchbacks beneath a stonefall cliff.
The stones were placed by a landslide that knew your name.
6. **Sootfall Abbey Ruins** [RUIN] [DEATH]
Bell tower intact; crypts breathing.
The breathing is a prayer. The monks are still down there.
7. **Hill-Motte** [FORTIFICATION] [WAR]
Fresh palisade; ditch scattered with caltrops.
The caltrops are from a siege that ended last week. The bodies are still rotting.
8. **Border-Stone Ring** [BOUNDARY] [OMEN]
Carved with seven crowns; each points wrong.
The crowns belong to kings who never existed. The stones remember them anyway.
9. **Blackwood Charcoalers’ Hollow** [FOREST] [WITCHCRAFT]
Witch-posts at every path.
The witch-posts were made from the gibbets of tax collectors. The tax collectors still swing.
10. **Salt-Road Ford** [RIVER] [DEATH]
Rains expose old bones in the chalk banks.
The bones are from three wars. They are not all human.
- J **Iron Mine Adits** [UNDERGROUND] [WHISPERS]
Held by a miners’ commune; the air is full of whispers.
The whispers are the mine’s memory. It remembers every collapse.
- Q **Margravine’s Hunting Lodge** [NOBLE] [SECRETS]
Tapestries of victories that never were.
The tapestries were woven by a blind weaver. The threads are from her own hair.
- K **War-Camp City** [WAR] [REFUGE]
Tents around a burned keep; every banner claims the throne.
The keep was burned by its own lord. He did not want to share the heat.
- A **The Pale Causeway** [ROAD] [CURSE]

The last high road that survives the spring thaws.
The causeway is made of bones. The bones are from the workers who built it.

(Petty Crowns/Priests/Companies) Tithe-collector’s runner with a tally-rod and an empty stomach; roadside prior with three lay brothers guarding a relic.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Tithe-Collector’s Runner** [AUTHORITY] [HUNGER]
 Tally-rod, empty stomach, and a list of names.
His tally-rod has notches from a dozen villages. The villages are now empty.
3. **Roadside Prior** [FAITH] [RELIC]
 Three lay brothers guarding a relic.
The relic is a finger bone. The prior claims it belonged to a saint who starved to death.
4. **Hedge-Witch** [WITCHCRAFT] [KNOWLEDGE]
 Knows which bridges eat travelers.
Her price is a story. The story must have a bad ending.
5. **Free Company Captain** [MERCENARY] [FATIGUE]
 Pike and shot between contracts.
He has served three kings this year. He does not remember their names.
6. **River Reeve** [LAW] [CORRUPTION]
 Rents every boat twice.
His paper is a single page folded into a boat. The other half is elsewhere.
7. **Salt-Baron** [TRADE] [VIOLENCE]
 Hired blades; owns the ford and your timetable.
His salt is grey. It was cut with ashes from a burned village.
8. **Blackwood Matriarch** [NOBLE] [VENGEANCE]
 Tends the feud like a garden.
Her garden grows tombstones. She waters them with tears—her enemies’.
9. **Ex-Imperial Surveyor** [KNOWLEDGE] [LONELINESS]
 Has the last accurate map.
The map shows villages that no longer exist. The surveyor visits them anyway.
10. **“King” of Three Villages** [CLAIMANT] [IRON]
 Iron-nail crown, iron-will taxes.
His crown was a plowshare. He reversed the curse.
- J **Bride with No Dowry but a Claim** [CLAIM] [DESPERATION]
 Daggers in the wedding chest.
The claim is to a bridge that drowned. The bride intends to collect.
- Q **Margravine of the Broken March** [AUTHORITY] [FEUD]
 Half saint, half tax roll.
She has never lost a feud. Her tally stick is her sword.
- K **The Lame King** [CLAIMANT] [FATIGUE]
 Traveling throne; makes law by pointing.
His throne is a sedan chair carried by debtors. They owe him everything.
- A **The Cursed Child of Silkstrand** [MYTH] [OMEN]

A rumor more than a person; her laughter ends sieges.
She is said to be twelve years old. She has been twelve for a century.

(Feud/Levy/Weather/Curse) Peat-fog; all horns sound like someone calling your name. Sudden levy—every traveler pressed for a day’s service. Bridge feud; rival banners drop the chain on your cart.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Peat-Fog** [WEATHER] [FEAR]
 All horns sound like someone calling your name.
The name is not yours. Answer it, and the fog will take you.
3. **Sudden Levy** [AUTHORITY] [TIME]
 Every traveler is pressed for a day’s service.
The levy master has a list. Your name is on it—in fresh ink.
4. **Bridge Feud** [BOUNDARY] [VIOLENCE]
 Rival banners drop the chain on your cart.
The chain was forged from a broken oath. It rattles when liars approach.
5. **Grain Blight** [HARVEST] [FEAR]
 Doubles the tithe; refusal means torches at night.
The blight has a face. It is the face of a tax collector who died hungry.
6. **Scree Slide** [MOUNTAIN] [BLOCKED]
 Seals the pass; the “safe” detour is owned by your enemy.
The enemy raised the toll yesterday. He was expecting you.
7. **Wedding Turns Ambush** [SOCIAL] [TRAP]
 You are caught between two bloodlines.
The bride’s veil is a shroud. The groom’s ring is a knife.
8. **Witch’s Tithe Night** [WITCHCRAFT] [DEBT]
 Lights move in the woods; owe nothing or else.
The lights have voices. They are arguing over who should collect.
9. **Pox Sign** [DISEASE] [ISOLATION]
 On a village gate; your escorts desert you.
The pox is a rumor. The desertion is real.
10. **Condotta Breaks** [MERCENARY] [BETRAYAL]
 The Free Company flips colors mid-march.
The new colors are the same as the old colors. The captain just wanted to raise morale.
- J **Heretic Preacher** [FAITH] [RIOT]
 Sparks a march; toll-gates come down in splinters.
The preacher’s text is a tax receipt. He reads it like scripture.
- Q **Imperial Pretender** [CLAIMANT] [POLITICS]
 Arrives; every petty lord changes tabards.
The pretender’s seal is a sunburst. The sunburst is slightly crooked.
- K **River Overruns the Levee** [WEATHER] [DESTRUCTION]
 The pontoon goes; your rivals don’t.
The river’s name is “Debt.” It remembers every unpaid crossing.

A The Curse Stirrs

[CURSE] [TRAP]

No matter the road, you return to the same crossroads.

The crossroads has a signpost. The arms are labeled “Regret,” “Hunger,” “The Same.”

(Papers/Claims/Safe-Conduct) Toll-exemption plaque for one bridge (once); monastery letter for bed and bread on a named road.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage**2. Toll-Exemption Plaque**

[TRAVEL] [ONCE]

For one bridge (once).

The plaque is a bronze leaf. Hold it up, and the toll-keeper will spit—but step aside.

3. Monastery Letter

[HOSPITALITY] [ONCE]

For bed and bread on a named road.

The letter is sealed with a wax tear. The monks will honor it—or they will not.

4. Wine-Right

[TRADE] [ONGOING]

On an abandoned terrace; locals will work for shares.

The wine is from a vine that grows over a mass grave. It tastes of iron.

5. Condotta Contract

[MERCENARY] [ONCE]

A signed pike contract (one battle on your terms).

The contract is written in blood. The blood is from the captain’s own finger.

6. Tithe-Remission Writ

[AUTHORITY] [ONCE]

For a village; they owe you a season’s labor.

The writ is stamped with a bell. The bell’s clapper is a finger bone.

7. Border-Stone Adjustment

[BOUNDARY] [ONCE]

Move a line two fields over.

The adjustment is a lie. The truth is that the line was always there.

8. Pass-Key Charm

[TRAVEL] [ONGOING]

Recognized by Pale Causeway watchmen.

The charm is a knotted cord. Untie it to pass—or to stay.

9. Sealed Dowry Chest

[CLAIM] [MYSTERY]

Of claims, not coin; certain doors open.

The chest is locked with a riddle. The answer is a name you do not know.

10. Mine-Share

[RESOURCE] [ALLIANCE]

In the commune; they fight like they mean it.

The share is a pickaxe. The commune will lend you a miner—or a grave.

J Blood-Peace Charter

[SOCIAL] [TRUCE]

Suspend a feud long enough to move your wagons.

The charter is a white ribbon. Blood will not be spilled while it flies—but blood will remember.

Q Marriage Proxy

[SOCIAL] [ALLIANCE]

From the Margravine; bind a hill-king to your cause.

The proxy is a wedding veil. The veil was worn by a ghost.

K The Lame King’s Traveling Writ

[AUTHORITY] [ONCE]

Troops must make way (for now).

The writ is a broken scepter. The Lame King’s seal is a footprint.

A Curse-Redemption Rite (Temporary)

[RITUAL] [ONCE]

For one night, no crossroads can hold you.

The rite is a whisper. The whisper is a name you have never spoken.

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (papers/claims/safe-conducts) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo plague and curse motifs—crossroads that turn back on themselves, bells tolling for no funeral, banners blackened by mildew.

Additional Features

- **Feud as Currency:** Any insult, accident, or rumor can birth a feud; the GM may replace an SB result with a feud-token tied to a petty lord or house. Feud-tokens act as reusable complications: once per scene, the GM can spend a feud-token to have a rival appear, a bridge close, or a village refuse aid.
- **Rot & Tithe:** Each market or harvest scene carries a risk of rot—add a pressure if food or coin are exchanged without a blessing or a seal. A failed roll may double the tithe or spoil stored supplies.
- **The Curse Remembers:** When roads or negotiations stall, the GM may quietly repeat imagery—crossroads, whispers, mildew—to remind players that Acasia itself resists resolution. If the party ignores three such omens, the *Curse Stirrs* complication triggers automatically.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Bitter Root:** Daughters of the Cord run a hospice in a burned abbey. They ask no payment—but they cut threads. A renegade Sister hides among the charcoalers, trying to untie her cord from a Rothari death warrant.
- **The Threshold Compendium:** The Pale Causeway is a Class II Anchor site—the ghosts of workers who died building it still carry stones. Saikou Ira would leave a silver coin in every crack.
- **Malachai, the Chained Angel:** A silver coin that never spends circulates among the toll-collectors. Take it, and your passage is always free—but the coin will taste of blood every time the Causeway floods.
- **The Grey Wanderer’s Grimoire:** Acasian psions are called “Feud-Readers.” They taste the weight of old grudges in the water. The Margravine employs two—and has never trusted a settlement they didn’t whisper.
- **The Ninth:** In any Acasian scene, the ninth toll paid at a bridge is never the last. The wise pay eight and barter for the ninth.

Acasian Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Milestone:** Crumble a crust at a broken milestone. Ignore the first *Peat-Fog* penalty.

- **Knot the Contract:** Tie a single knot in a writ’s ribbon. Cancel *Bridge Feud* or take –1 die on your next negotiation (your choice).
- **Name to the Blight:** Whisper a dead tax collector’s name into a grain sack. Gain +1 Effect when avoiding tithes this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Margravine.

Decline & Patronage

Patronage here is as brittle as candle wax. The Rothari Clan holds their marches by fear and iron law—patronage from them is real, but cruel, demanding service in blood or levy. Elsewhere, noble names are little more than titles printed on parchment and sold like promises. The Margravine keeps a tally of feuds, binding bloodlines to her feast days, while mercenary captains trade loyalty for coin, switching colors with each bell.

To seek a patron in Acasia is to choose which hunger you will feed: the Rothari’s iron teeth, a Free Company’s purse, or the hollow blessing of a saint who may never have lived. Yet even false crowns cast shadows long enough to shelter those desperate enough to kneel.

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **tithe-collectors or petty lords**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **Free Company patrols or village watchmen**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **feud-trackers or hedge-witches**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favorable road conditions**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **River reeve or Free Company captain** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **fog or bridge closure**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **rival bloodline or toll-lord’s enforcer** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **feud-kin, Free Company deserters, or Margravine’s guards** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **contract voided/levy doubled/curse triggered**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival: Margravine, Lame King, or Cursed Child** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **fog thickens/bridge falls/curse loops**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Acasia (Feud & Tithe):** Toll collectors demand double, bloodlines take offense, wagons are seized as “payment.”
- **Acasia (Rot & Famine):** Grain blights spread, wells run dry, abandoned villages hold only ghosts.
- **Acasia (Curse & Crossroads):** Roads loop back, milestones point the wrong way, the same bridge appears twice.

Boss Archetypes in Acasia

- **The False King (Feud/Authority)** — A petty lord or pretender who crowns themselves on the ruins of empire. *Phases:* Levy Demanded → Feud Declared → Hasty Coronation. *Cracks:* a **Blood-Peace Charter** suspends his authority; a **Marriage Proxy** binds him to a rival.
- **The Witch of the Blackwoods (Witchcraft/Curse)** — A hedge-witch, matriarch, or revenant who manipulates feuds and curses. *Phases:* Tithe of Fear → Curse of the Crossroads → Hollow Wedding. *Cracks:* a **Curse-Redemption Rite** breaks her hold; a **Mine-Share** gives the commune courage to defy her.
- **The Tithe Collector (Greed/Extortion)** — A bureaucrat-priest with writs, escorts, and the ability to summon feuds or famine with a single decree. *Phases:* Audit of Souls → Seizure of Grain → The Reckoning. *Cracks:* a **Toll-Exemption Plaque** voids his claim; a **Wine-Right** buys off his debtors.
- **The Rotting Child (Mystery/Curse)** — A folkloric horror tied to Acasia’s plague of false crossroads. *Phases:* Laughter in the Fog → The Bridge That Loops → The Feast of Ends. *Cracks:* a **Tithe-Remission Writ** fed to the fog; a **Monastery Letter** read aloud at the crossroads.

Encounter Seeds (Quick Hooks)

- **The Dowry That Walked:** A Blackwood matriarch’s dowry chest has been stolen. The chest contains a claim to a bridge that never floods—and a curse that the Margravine wants broken.
- **The Lame King’s Feast:** The Lame King invites the party to a feast. The feast is a trial. The food is memory. The wine is lies.
- **The Curse of the Pale Causeway:** The Causeway is repeating. Every crossing brings the party back to the same inn. The innkeeper is missing a finger. She says she gave it to the bridge.

Chapter 4

Vhasia

The Fractured Sun.

Two crowns. One kingdom. A river so wide it might as well be a border—and oh, how the crowns love pretending it's not.

I am a Road Warden. I have served under three different banners on this same stretch of road, and the only constant is that someone always wants to collect tolls. The Northern Seigneurie and the Southern Parlement both claim the throne, both flood the river with paperwork to "prove" their right, and both are too busy arguing over seal wax colours to notice that the Fenwoods already burned Lence, and the Sun-court is a memory.

The Last Dauphin? A rumour. But rumours pay well when you're the one who started them—and I started three: that he was swapped at birth with a goatherd's child, that he's secretly a Veiled Sister in disguise, and that he's been dead for ten years, his "reappearance" a puppet show run by the Seigneurie's spymaster.

Never carry a coin that bears only one sunburst. The realm has three mints, and the wrong metal on the wrong road is treason.

— *Road Warden Cerran, who has not slept in two days and is not sure which crown he serves*

The Almanac of Ordinary Days

What do people eat for breakfast? Dark bread and watered wine—the wine cuts the dust from the road. The nobility eat spiced eggs and fresh cheese, but they eat behind closed doors. To eat well in public is to invite envy. Envy is a dagger.

What does a child learn before they can walk? Which colours not to wear. Black and gold are the Northern Crown's colours. Red and silver are the Southern Parlement's. A child who wears the wrong colour to the wrong village may not return home.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Which side of the road they walk on. The north side is the Crown's. The south side is the Parlement's. The middle is no man's land—literally. Bandits, spies, and messengers use the middle. So do ghosts.

What is the most common crime? Raiding across the Belworth. The river is the border, the border is a suggestion, and the suggestion is enforced by armed men on both sides. The crime is not in raiding. The crime is in being caught on the wrong bank at dawn.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Sun-court was not burned. It was bankrupted. The Fenwoods did not sack Lence—they bought it. Every judge, every clerk, every guard captain had a price. The Fenwoods paid it. The Vhasians are still paying interest.

Where do people go when they die? To the crypts beneath the Sun-court—if they can afford a plaque. The poor are buried in unmarked graves along the Belworth floodplain. The river floods every spring. The dead wash downstream, into the land of the other crown. Neither side claims them.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You offer a chevauchée—a raiding party that burns a village in your name. The apology is not in the burning. The apology is in the promise that the village will be rebuilt with your own hands. If you burn a village and do not rebuild, you have not apologized. You have started a feud.

What is the most important festival? The Sun-return (spring equinox). Both crowns claim the sun as their symbol. On this day, both hold processions. The processions are identical. The participants do not acknowledge each other. The sun does not care.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Queen-Mother has no claim to the regency. Her son is not the Dauphin. The real Dauphin died in childbirth. The Queen-Mother's daughter was stillborn. The child on the throne is a foundling, bought from a Tulkani caravan. The Tulkani know. The Tulkani are still waiting to be paid.

4.1 Vhasia — “The Fractured Sun”

Cardinal-Regent of the Broken Sun (Elite): “The sun may be fractured, but our authority is absolute within our domains. Every coin minted here carries our blessing, and every law written bears our seal – the rest is just politics.”

Road Warden (Commoner): “I’ve served under three different banners on this same stretch of road, and the only constant is that someone always wants to collect tolls. My horn calls honest warning – best heed it. The Fenwoods burned Lence, and now every duke with a coin purse thinks he’s king.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Vhasia is a realm of broken coronations and split loyalties. Once a proud province of the Utaran empire, the unified Sun-court shattered like its heraldic sunburst when the Fenwoods of Viterra and their allies sacked the capital of Lence and cast down the old Blood line. Now rival dukes, duchesses, abbesses, and parlements claim the fractured light. Everywhere, signs of fracture: chipped sun-discs on milestones, worn tabards bearing half a crown, coins minted in rival cities with different suns. In Vhasia, legitimacy is as fragile as a mirror, and every oath risks breaking along the fault lines of politics, faith, and fortune.

What you notice first: The smell of old smoke and fresh ink. The way every noble’s seal has a hairline crack. The constant, nervous laughter of courtiers who remember whose head rolled last season.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never carry a coin that bears only one sunburst. The realm has three mints, and the wrong metal on the wrong road is treason.

Regional Mood: Crowns, Courts, and Companies

Here, the past is a weapon and the future is a debt. The Fenwoods came from Viterra with fire and iron, broke the Sun-king’s army at the Ford of Ashes, and burned Lence until the mirrors melted. They left the throne empty—not destroyed, but open. Now every duke with a long purse and a short conscience backs a claimant. The Queen-Mother weaves alliances from her riverside keep. The Two Crowns—rival dukes crowned in rival cathedrals—march their levies through fields that can feed neither. Routiers sell their swords by the season, and parlement clerks drown justice in procedure. Vhasia is not a nation at war. It is a nation that forgot how to be at peace.

Starting Location: The Pont-du-Tithe, its golden arches catching fire in the sunset as pilgrims chant from both banks. A Duchy Constable in splendid armor guards the toll gate. “The Chevauchee burns,” he says, gesturing to distant smoke. “Two Crowns march to meet it. Whose seal do you carry? Speak quickly—the levy waits for no one.”

Prominent NPCs of Vhasia

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
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Elianor Everblood	Queen-Mother (née Longblood) of Ethor	Restore her son Valdaïs to the throne	She has outlived three husbands and two sons; she is not mourning.
Valdaïs Longblood	Duke of Adria, claimant to the Sun-court	Unite Vhasia under a strong northern crown	He has never lost a joust. His opponents have a habit of falling ill before the tilt.
The Red Marshal	Exiled commander of the Sun-court's army	Win back Lence or die trying	He lost the Battle of Ashes; he still sees it in his dreams—and his nightmares.
Seint Michel's Justiciar	Magistrate of the Order of the Gilded Scale	Enforce the chivalric code without mercy	He carries a scale with one pan empty; the empty pan is for lies.
Sister Oria	Custodian of the Lantern-Rites House on the Belworth	Keep the rites of hospitality and witness	She has never drawn a blade. She has never needed to.
The Cantor Alain	Iron Bard, bearer of the Cracked Ring	Sing the truth of Corin's mercy before the armor closes again	Feathers grow from his temples; his shadow moves a half-step behind him.

Names of Vhasia

Inspired by the fractured duchies: Francien, Norman, and Brittonic influences. Soft vowels, silent consonants, and surnames that recall a bridge, a ford, or a stained banner.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Valdaïs	Elianor	de la Marche	<i>the Iron</i>
Renaud	Isabeau	de Lence	<i>the Unbuckled</i>
Corin	Oria	d'Aethor	<i>Bell-Sworn</i>
Touénot	Mael	du Pont	<i>the Silver</i>
Alain	Giselle	de la Croix	<i>Ash-Banner</i>

Ghiro	Celandine	l’Argent	<i>the Unpaid</i>
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Spades — Places

(Château/Cathedral/Forest) Wayside shrine with pilgrims tacking petitions to a scorched sun-disc; vine-terraced clos above a millstream with napping watchmen.

2. **Wayside Shrine** — Pilgrims tack petitions to a scorched sun-disc; each parchment curls in different winds. *The petitions are never answered. The shrine is a mailbox for the dead.*
3. **Vine-Terrace** — Clos above a millstream; watchmen nap, halberds traded for bottles. *The best vintage is called “Crownbreaker.” It tastes like smoke and regret.*
4. **Bastide Square** — Neat as a checkerboard; merchants pay homage to different “hours” of the Sun. *The square has a gallows. It rotates to face whichever claimant lost the last duel.*
5. **Royal Forest** — Antler posts mark laws no king remembers; poachers still hang. *The forest’s deer have grown bold. They wear crowns of shed antlers.*
6. **Pont-du-Tithe** — Toll-bridge flanked by chapels and crossbows; chains blessed by rival bishops. *The chains were forged from melted sunbursts. They ring in different keys.*
7. **Great Fair** — Outside a chartered town; counting sheds ring like bells, rumors louder still. *The fair has a Court of Miracles where counterfeiters sell to informers.*
8. **Salt Pans** — Wind-pumps on an estuary; gulls own the law, smugglers own the night. *The salt is grey. It tastes of old tears and older debts.*
9. **Siege-Château** — Hoardings patched, cistern low, banners cut into ragged suns. *The banner’s ragged edges are from a Fenwood sword. The owner still limps.*
10. **Cathedral Yard** — Cranes creak, stones fly, scaffolds bristle with rival masons’ marks. *The mason’s marks are clan signs. A scratched-out mark means a dead foreman.*
- J **Parlement Hall** — Hung with faded tapestries; sunbursts spliced and re-stitched by claimants. *The tapestries show battles that never happened—and some that shouldn’t have.*
- Q **Queen’s Causeway** — Mile-long oath paved in quarried stone; half-sunk each spring. *The sunken half is a graveyard for vows. The stones are slippery with old lies.*
- K **Sun Palace (Lence)** — Shattered mirrors, brambled gardens; courtiers playing at kingship. *The mirrors were covered after the sack. No one wants to see what they show now.*
- A **King’s High Road** — Milestones chipped of crowns; yet every army still marches it. *The road is paved with the bones of tax collectors. They are not missed.*

Hearts — People & Factions

(Lord/Court/Company) Road warden with dented badge and honest horn; vintner-guild syndic counting saints’ days as credit terms.

2. **Road Warden** — Dented badge, honest horn; ignored by both crowns but knows the roads. *His horn is cracked. It still sounds—but the note is always half a step flat.*
3. **Vintner Syndic** — Counts saints’ days as credit terms, vintages as treaties; wine as diplomacy. *He keeps a bottle of Crownbreaker in every cellar. He knows which vintage each duke prefers.*
4. **Abbess-Chatelaine** — Rules a fortress-convent with iron accounts and sharper scripture. *She has never drawn a blade. The scaffold has, on her orders.*

5. **Routier Captain** — Scarred and mercenary; prefers ransoms to loyalty; coin as conscience. *He switches banners as often as his shirt. His loyalty is to the paychest—and his mother.*
6. **Duchy Constable** — Splendid armor, empty coffers, pride swollen as a banner; glory over gold. *His armor was his grandfather's. It still has the dent from a Fenwood axe.*
7. **Parlement Clerk** — Drowns foes in procedure, fishes them out for fealty; law as a weapon. *His quill is a dagger. He sharpens it every morning.*
8. **Salt-Farmer** — Gabelle lessee with cudgels, writs, and a river-chart no crown has; tax as tyranny. *His ledger is written in salt. One drop of water and the debts vanish—along with the evidence.*
9. **Trouvère** — A scandalous lay about the last Sun-king brings knives to tavern doors. *He sings the truth. That is why he sleeps in a different inn every night.*
10. **Marshal-Exile** — The Sun-court's hammer; now wielded by whoever pays in silver. *He lost the Battle of Ashes. He still sees it in his dreams—and his nightmares.*
- J **Heretic Perfect** — Preaches peace while tucking hidden daggers into parchment margins. *His sermon is a code. The psalms tell you which bridge to cross—and which to burn.*
- Q **Queen-Mother** — Riverside keep; weaves alliances as if they were dowers. *She has outlived three husbands and two sons. She is not mourning.*
- K **Two Crowns** — Rival dukes, each “crowned” in rival cathedrals, neither whole. *One wears a crown of iron. The other wears a crown of words. Both rust.*
- A **Last Dauphin** — A rumor with a birthmark; armies march for whispers alone. *He may be a baker's son. The armies don't care. They need a sun to follow.*

Clubs — Complications/Threats

(Chevauchée/Law/Church) Chevauchée burning loyalty oaths as well as barns; smoke curls like scripture. Interdict falls on a county; bells silenced, trade stalls.

2. **Chevauchée** [WAR] [RAID] — Raiders burn loyalty oaths as well as barns; smoke curls like scripture. *The raiders wear no colors. Their horses answer to whistles—and grudges.*
3. **Interdict** [RELIGIOUS] [LEGAL] — Falls on a county; bells silenced, trade stalls, heretics prosper. *The bells were melted for shot three wars ago. The silence is old.*
4. **Forest Law** [LEGAL] [HUNT] — Venison becomes treason; poachers hang from antler posts. *The antler posts are carved with the names of the hanged. They whisper at dusk.*
5. **River Spate** [WEATHER] [DELAY] — Ferries chained, bridges drowned, pilgrims stranded mid-prayer. *The water is the color of old gold. It washed away a mint last spring.*
6. **Coin Debasement** [ECONOMY] [LEGAL] — Three mints, three suns, no trust; soldiers demand silver alone. *The silver is from the same mine—but the stamp is a prayer, not a promise.*
7. **Parlement Divided** [LEGAL] [POLITICS] — A siege laid on parchment before walls; war by paperwork. *The clerks duel with citations. The loser pays the winner's ink bill.*
8. **Company Mutiny** [WAR] [MERCENARY] — Unless arrears are paid—in blood or coin; mercenaries as a time bomb. *The mutineers have a list. Your name is on it—or will be by nightfall.*
9. **Relic Dispute** [RELIGIOUS] [LEGAL] — Two abbeys claim the same saint's bones; mobs answer with stones. *The bones are actually from a cow. The saints don't mind. They like the attention.*

10. **Harvest Blight** [ECONOMY] [WEATHER] — Bread locked behind pikes; bakers guarded as lords. *The blight has a name. It is the name of a duke who raised the levy too late.*
- J **Tournament “Accident”** [CHIVALRY] [ASSASSINATION] — Hides an assassination; your favor is now evidence. *The lance was filed with a prayer. The prayer was answered—but not for the target.*
- Q **Royalist Restoration** [POLITICS] [FEAR] — Sunburst badges painted overnight on doors and graves. *The paint is the color of dried blood. The badges face the wrong direction.*
- K **Feudal Levy** [WAR] [LEGAL] — Lords demand levies in days, not months, with three days’ bread. *The bread is hardtack from the last Fenwood siege. It still smells of smoke.*
- A **Winter Campaign** [WEATHER] [WAR] — Roads turn to mud, hooves to ice, armies to ruin. *The snow is grey with ash. The Pass of Ashes has a sister pass now.*

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

(**Charter/Patent/Right**) Safe-conduct sealed by a duke or abbey; honored only once, on one road; burgess charter for a market ward.

2. **Safe-Conduct** *The seal is cracked. The road is watched. Use it before the seal breaks.*
3. **Burgess Charter** *The charter is a bell. Ring it, and the town answers—or it doesn’t.*
4. **Bridge Farm** — Tolls at Pont-du-Tithe for a season, if you can hold it. *The tollkeepers are loyal to the last coin. Yours or theirs.*
5. **Paréage Charter** — Shared rule with a monastery—half justice, half rent, no peace. *The monks pray for you. They also pray for your enemies. Balance.*
6. **Wardship** — Over a minor heir; lands obey you “for now.” *The heir has a knife. He knows how to use it. He learned from watching you.*
7. **Gabelle Lease** — Salt-tax rights; lucrative, hated, and dangerous. *The lease is a death warrant written in profit. Cash it wisely.*
8. **Letters Patent** — Raise a free-company under your banner; an army as a business. *The letters are signed in blood—yours or the notary’s. Both are valid.*
9. **Remission** — Of feudal dues for a village; they’ll march when called. *The village has a long memory. They remember the last lord who promised mercy.*
10. **Low-Justice** — Grant (stocks, fines, gallows) in a troublesome hamlet. *The gallows rope is new. The notches are from the last hamlet.*
- J **Confiscation Writ** — Against a royalist estate—if you can seize it first. *The writ is a race. The other claimant rides a faster horse.*
- Q **Queen’s Audience** — Private with the Queen-Mother; a whisper becomes policy. *The audience is a chess game. She always wins—but she lets you take a pawn.*
- K **Sunburst Warrant** — Of the fallen court—most still bow if shown boldly. *The warrant is a ghost. It has no power—only the power of belief.*
- A **General Pardon** — Temporary: rebels absolved if they bend the knee. *The pardon is a spring. It will close when the season turns.*

Quick Use Notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (charters/patents/rights) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **fractured sun** motifs—light that splinters, oaths that crack like glass.

Additional Features

Fractured Seals: When brandishing a writ, badge, or charter tied to a Sun-court claimant, step Position up one step for the scene’s next interaction at a gate, court, or checkpoint. Each use advances a **Legitimacy** [4] clock linked to the claimant; when it fills, rivals challenge the authority on sight.

Parlement Games: If a scene touches petitions, guild disputes, or feudal appeals, the first Diamond played becomes a policy lever: treat it as two Diamonds toward swaying a decision or rewriting a custom. Afterward, start or advance a **Whispered Precedent** clock; when it fills, backlash spreads as other courts cite the case against you.

Gabelle Knife-Edge: At bridges, fairs, or salt depots, convert Diamonds tied to tolls, leases, or safe-conducts into immediate passage or tariff relief for the company (no roll). Each conversion ticks a **Resentment** [4] clock for the locale; when it completes, expect boycotts, ambush rumors, or an audit by rival officials.

Vhasian Chivalry & the Round of Five Virtues: The knights of the western cantons (Ethor, Adria) follow the Round of Five Virtues: **Courage, Courtesy, Mercy, Prowess, Truth**. In a formal joust or a legal duel, the GM may award *Victory by Virtue* rather than by blood: the combatant with the higher Virtue score wins the dispute, even if they lost the physical exchange. This is the law of the tilt—and the law of the court.

The Armor Closes / The Song Escapes (Chivalric Clocks): The Cantor Alain, bearer of the Cracked Ring, sings a warning at every tourney:

- **Armor Closes** [6] – advances when knights choose protection over mercy, when gorgets are buckled tight, when chivalry becomes siege mentality. When full, the cantons close their borders and the raids become wars.
- **Song Escapes** [8] – advances when a Cantor sings the truth, when mercy is shown, when armour is unbuckled. When full, a moment of genuine connection occurs—though it may be fatal.

In Rouen, Alain still sings the *Planctus Armatus* each spring, and the congregation weeps for Sir Corin, who unbuckled his gorget to hear a thief’s voice and was undone by the mercy he offered.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **Seint Michel, the Judge of the Scar (Mykkiel):** The Order of the Gilded Scale maintains the *Chivalric Ledger*—a record of every oath sworn and broken in the cantons. A page torn from this ledger can serve as a single-use Claim String (gain +1 Position in any court). The

Order’s justiciars are feared and respected; they never unbuckle their gorgets, and they have never lost a case. The Queen-Mother keeps a copy in her riverside keep, wrapped in a grey shroud.

- **Seint Isabeau, Who Slumbers Amongst the Lilies (Ikasha):** In the Ethorian marches, knights whisper prayers to Seint Isabeau when they long to set aside their steel. Her shrine is a hawthorn grove where armour must be left at the gate. Pilgrims who enter bare-skinned and speak a true regret find that their next wound heals in a single night—but they dream of a woman in white who asks, “Will you remember how to be touched?” Those who return to the grove a second time are never seen again.
- **Seint Evroul of the Cairn (Mor’iraath):** In the high passes of the Ethorian marches, a rusted knight in an unopened helm haunts the old barrows. He is the patron of those who carry a blood-debt and cannot rest. To call upon him, one must pour a cup of salt water at a cairn and name the wrong done to your house. He will witness one blow; if it lands, the foe is *Marked by the Cairn*—any spirit may locate them for a year. If it misses, the blow turns inward. The Marshal-Exile carries a scar from such a bargain; he does not speak of it.
- **The Order of the Sunken Cup (The Hospice of the Broken Blade):** A grey-robed hospice in the ruins of Lence treats the wounded of both crowns. They ask no payment, but they record every name in a ledger that never dries. The Restorationists suspect they are spies for the Queen-Mother; the Two Crowns accuse them of erasing debts. Sister Oria, the hospice’s custodian, is also the keeper of the Lantern-Rites House on the Belworth—neutral ground where even claimants must leave their blades at the door.
- **The Ninth:** In any Vhasian court, the ninth citation of precedent voids all previous. The wise stop at eight and settle. Those who cite the ninth are said to hear a faint laughter from the marble walls—and their cases are never heard again.

Vhasian Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Sun:** Crumble a crust onto a cracked sun-disc. Ignore the first *Chevauchée* penalty.
- **Knot the Seal:** Tie a single knot in a charter’s ribbon. Cancel *Parlement Divided* or take −1 die on your next legal argument (your choice).
- **Name to the Salt:** Whisper a dead claimant’s name into a salt pan. Gain +1 Effect when collecting debts from their faction this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Queen-Mother.

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Rival officials or court guards take notice.
- **Noise:** Parlement clerks or routier patrols are alerted.
- **Trace:** Trackers or tax collectors mark your route.
- **Delay:** A setback costs time or a favourable legal window.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant resource clock.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** A duchy constable or abbess-chatelaine begins responding.

- **Position Lost:** Legal challenge or road closure costs you advantage.
- **Foe Appears:** A rival claimant or free-company arrives.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes Compromised/Neglected.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional routiers, parlement guards, or ducal forces arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool or weapon becomes unusable.
- **Major Twist:** A writ is voided, an interdict declared, or a levy called.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark Fatigue 1/Harm 1 or an appropriate Condition.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates fully.
- **Authority Arrival:** The Two Crowns, Queen-Mother, or Marshal-Exile intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** A chevauchée hits, the river floods, or the parlement erupts.
- **Patron Omen:** An omen appears, a blessing is lost, or a curse manifests.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Fractured Authority:** Seals break mid-signing, legal papers rewrite themselves, badges refuse honour.
- **Legal Warfare:** Court decisions reverse, precedents are cited against you, writs expire prematurely.
- **Sun Symbolism:** Sun-discs crack underfoot, light splits into contradictory shadows, oaths shatter like glass.

Patronage & Power

In Vhasia, power flows through the remnants of imperial authority, fractured legitimacy, and the careful manipulation of legal and religious institutions. Former Utaran provincial structures still provide a framework for governance, but competing claimants to the Sun-court have created a complex web of overlapping jurisdictions and conflicting loyalties. The true power lies with those who can navigate this legal maze and maintain the appearance of legitimate authority.

For the GM: Patronage in Vhasia revolves around legitimacy, legal documents, and the ability to command respect from institutions that no longer have a clear central authority. Rewards often take the form of charters, writs, and official positions that can be leveraged into greater influence. To emphasize this:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (seals, badges, writs) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided.
- Let rival claimants issue conflicting authorities, forcing players to choose whose favor matters more.
- Use the parlements, cathedrals, and châteaux as arenas for social contests, where knowledge of law and custom determines success.

In Vhasia, your papers are your power, and your power determines whether you rule or are ruled.

The Vacant Throne & Campaign Clocks

For long-form political campaigns:

- **Vacant Throne Clock [10]:** Advances when a claimant gains a major advantage (battle, noble defection, foreign alliance). Retreats when the party brokers a truce or exposes a weakness. When full, a claimant takes Lence and declares themselves king.
- **Armor Closes [6]:** Advances when knights choose protection over mercy, when gorgets are buckled tight, when chivalry becomes siege mentality. When full, the cantons close their borders and the raids become wars.
- **Song Escapes [8]:** Advances when a Cantor sings the truth, when mercy is shown, when armour is unbuckled. When full, a moment of genuine connection occurs—though it may be fatal.
- **Claimant’s Coup (per claimant):** A 6-clock that advances when that claimant wins a Parlement vote, a joust, or a skirmish. When full, they march on Lence.

Boss Seeds (three-phase foes)

- **The Red Marshal (Exiled Sun-court hammer)** — *Phases:* Chevauchee Call → Banner Turn → Lists to War. *Cracks:* Letters Patent buys one round of obedience; General Pardon lets a unit stand down.
- **Cardinal-Regent of the Broken Sun (scarlet gloves)** — *Phases:* Interdict Blade → Seal Both Ways → Confessional Leak. *Cracks:* Queen’s Audience cancels Interdict Blade once; a Synod Indulgence treats a church check as controlled for one scene.
- **The Parlement Spider (chief clerk; quills like daggers)** — *Phases:* Motion to Delay → Counter-Citation → Filed at Dawn. *Cracks:* Sunburst Warrant opens a “royal window”; a

Burgess Charter lets a town court overrule once locally.

- **The Two Crowns (rival dukes)** — *Phases*: Contradictory Edicts → Levy in Hours → Coin Trial. *Cracks*: Sunburst Warrant + public mass unites them for one scene; General Pardon calms levy unrest once.

Legendary Sites & Trials

- **Tournament Ordeal (Bastide Square)** — Declare Purse, Patent, or Pardon as stakes. Win to cash a matching $\diamond$; *lose and spawn Tournament “Accident”*.
- **Cathedral Scaffold Assize** — Argue law atop creaking beams; each good point moves Position up; each slip marks Exposure. A *Paréage Charter* lets you call a recess once.
- **Pont-du-Tithe Vigil** — Keep the bridge peaceful through dusk: clear 3 segments on *Bridge Peace* by feeding pilgrims, quieting relic zeal, and paying one tithe from your purse.

Extensions (Plug-in)

- **Legitimacy Dial (Claimant ↔ Neutrality)**: Track the party’s public stance.
 - *Claimant High*: +1 Position when invoking seals, warrants, or feudal rights; first parley with a rival claimant starts one step worse.
 - *Neutrality High*: +1 Effect when brokering truces or smuggling between factions; first petition to a court or cathedral starts one step worse.
 - Center the dial by paying weight to both sides or hosting a neutral moot.
- **Parlement Mini-Game (legal duel)**:
 - Lay three counters: *Precedent*, *Equity*, *Force*.
 - Argue a point (roll Lore + Sway vs. DV 3). On a hit, move one counter to your side. On a miss, the clerk gains *Citation Edge*.
 - Win two counters to secure a temporary *Parlement Ruling* (treat as a Diamond for one scene).
 - *Spider’s Interjection (2 SB)*: flip Precedent, but start *Whispered Precedent* [2].
- **Chevauchée Pressure (raid clock)**:
 - Two opposed clocks: *Outrun the Fire* vs *Scorched Earth* (size by highest rank in seed).
 - Each leg, choose *High Road* (fast, exposed), *Bypass* (slow, hidden), or *Ford* (risky, shortcut).
 - Advantage: Bypass → High Road (cover), Ford → Bypass (speed), High Road → Ford (navigation).
 - Spend a *Watch-Code* (from Three-Fires Ridge) to shift one segment from Scorched Earth to Outrun.
- **Favor of the Sun (prestige track)**:
 - Earn by resolving disputes between claimants without bloodshed, or by returning stolen relics.
 - At 3 Favor, treat one *Safe-Conduct* or *Sunburst Warrant* as unquestioned for a scene.
 - Each use after the first advances *Legitimacy Challenge* [4] against that claimant.
- **Start-of-Scene Omens (1d6)**:

1. *Cracked Bell*: first legal action gains +1d; first boast draws *Parlement Divided*.
2. *Smoke on the Ridge*: Chevauchée advances once; shortcuts open.
3. *Three Suns*: three claimants claim the same road; pick a side or start *Coin Debasement*.
4. *Queen’s Dove*: a message arrives; +1d on the next *Queen’s Audience* attempt.
5. *Salt Wind*: *Gabelle Lease* counts double value today; smugglers’ ears open.
6. *Routier Campfire*: mercenaries are hireable for one scene at half price—but they’ll ask questions later.

- **Plug-in SB Conversions (Vhasia Flavor):**

- 1 SB → *Seal Crack*: a writ loses half its value until re-witnessed.
- 2 SB → *Citation War*: increase DV by 1 unless you produce a precedent (spend a *◊orrecallapastruling*).
- 3+ SB → *Crown Fracture*: the claimant’s legitimacy splits; halve a consequence by accepting a rival’s seal on your paper (start *Legitimacy Challenge*).

- **Reputation Echoes:**

- *Court-Favored*: once/session, downgrade *Parlement Divided* to a minor delay; the next document you present is scrutinized (+1 DV).
- *Chevauchée-Tested*: +1 Position when evading raids; supply lines run 1 segment longer.
- *Neutral Broker*: +1d with both claimants in a truce scene; any betrayal earns *Resentment* [2] from both sides.

- **Cross-Region Hooks (quick integration):**

- *Thepyrgos Synod Leak*: a *Synod Indulgence* can suspend a Vhasian interdict—but starts *Whispered Precedent* in Thepyrgos.
- *Ubral Feud Echo*: paying wergild to a Vhasian claimant instead of a clan starts *Feud Rekindled* along the border roads.
- *Kahfagia Salt War*: cashing a *Gabelle Lease* to outbid corsair lanes adds *Market Knives* [4] in Silkstrand or on the coastal quays.
- *Valewood Relic Interest*: a relic from a Vhasian cathedral may be claimed by fae courts; a Diamond spent on relic control may instead draw *Court Tithe*.

Chapter 5

Viterra

The Hedge-Law Realm.

Every hedge here marks not just a boundary but a principle—the careful balance between order and freedom, justice and mercy. Our law grows like the hedges themselves, tended with precision and patience.

I am a Queen’s Justiciar. I have never lost a legal duel. My opponents have a habit of falling down stairs. I do not push them. The stairs *remember their debts*.

Viterra breathes with the careful rhythm of precedent and petition. Once a proud kingdom before becoming a Utaran province, it is now reborn under a Warrior Queen who rules by legal precision as much as military might. The realm’s true sinews lie not in steel but in writs, charters, and the ancient rights that bind lord to tenant, crown to county, and church to common.

But do not mistake us for gentle. The Queen’s Peace is not a promise—it is a contract, renewed each morning by every magistrate, every justicar, every clerk who opens a ledger. And across the Belworth, the Vhasians still claim our hedges are theirs. Let them try.

Never cross the Belworth without a charter recognized on both banks. Viterran law and Vhasian claim fight every crossing, and the river takes the losers.

— *Justiciar Elodie Venn, who invoked the Right of Acknowledgment and watched a father speak truth to his son for the first time*

The Almanac of Ordinary Days

What do people eat for breakfast? Barley porridge with a drizzle of honey—if you own bees. If not, porridge with salt. Salt is the currency of the poor. Honey is the currency of the hopeful.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To recite their lineage back three generations. Every Viterran child knows their grandparents' names, their grandparents' trades, and their grandparents' debts. A child who cannot recite their lineage is a child without standing. Standing is everything.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Whether they carry a seal ring. A seal ring means they have the right to make contracts in their own name. A stranger without a seal ring is either a servant or a criminal. In Viterra, the difference is a matter of paperwork.

What is the most common crime? Boundary disputes. A hedge moved three feet east. A milestone replaced under cover of darkness. A ford declared "private" when it has been public for two centuries. The courts are clogged with such cases. The lawyers are rich. The hedges are patient.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Queen is not a warrior. She has never drawn a sword. Her reputation was forged by a propaganda campaign run by her spymaster. The spymaster is dead. His successor is more discreet.

Where do people go when they die? To the family plot—if they have a family. The landless poor are buried in parish cemeteries, their headstones marked with a single word: "Anonymous." The ghosts of the anonymous wander the hedgerows at dusk. They do not remember their names. They remember their debts.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You petition the hedge-court for a "writ of contrition." The writ requires you to state your wrong aloud, in public, while holding a handful of earth from the wronged party's land. If the earth crumbles, you are forgiven. If it holds, your apology is not accepted. You may try again next season.

What is the most important festival? The Opening of the Rolls (autumn). Every county sends its tax records to the capital. The procession is a week long. The documents are carried by children, so that the next generation may learn the weight of obligation.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Codex of Precedents has a missing page. It was torn out fifty years ago, during a trial for treason. The page contained the precedent for executing a monarch. The Queen knows. The Justiciars know. The page is hidden in a lead-lined box beneath the hedge-court at Thornwood. The hedge-court is haunted. The ghost knows where the key is.

5.1 Viterra — “The Hedge-Law Realm”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *Every hedge is a boundary. Every boundary is a claim. Every claim is a blade.*

Warrior Queen (Elite): “Every hedge here marks not just a boundary but a principle — the careful balance between order and freedom, justice and mercy. Our law grows like the hedges themselves, tended with precision and patience. But a hedge that is not defended is only a suggestion.”

Fen Reeve (Commoner): “The dikes hold back more than water — they hold back chaos. Every rod measured, every stone placed, keeps the flood from washing away not just our fields but our very way of life. And across the Belworth? The Vhasians still claim our hedges are theirs. Let them try. We have lawyers. We have swords. Sometimes they are the same people.”

Genre / Mood: Legal warfare, post-imperial consolidation, border adventurism.

Starting Location: The Hall of Dawning tilt-yard at first light. Dawn-knights drill in armor polished like mirrors. Beside them, advocates rehearse arguments with the same intensity. A Queen’s Justiciar slides a parchment across an oaken rail. “Three charters, one road across the Belworth. The Vhasian claimant says the bridge is theirs. The local reeve says it’s crown land. The abbey says it’s a pilgrimage, not a toll. Carry the Queen’s writ, break the Quiet Tolls, and make them agree — by clause or by cut.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Viterra breathes with the careful rhythm of precedent and petition. Once a proud kingdom before becoming a Utaran province, it is now reborn under a new Warrior Queen who rules by legal precision as much as military might. The realm's true sinews lie not in steel but in writs, charters, and the ancient rights that bind lord to tenant, crown to county, and church to common. Every hedge-row, every parish stone, every ferry crossing carries the weight of custom older than memory.

But Viterra is also a kingdom of restless ambition — a young queen still testing the limits of her authority, with old dukes who remember when they ruled their own marches and a border that has never been truly settled. Northward, the Ubral highlands reject any crown but their own moots, watching for a chance to rekindle old feuds. Southward, the City of a Thousand Stairs — Thepyrgos — sends clerks and spies, testing the edges of Viterran jurisdiction with every disputed toll. Westward, across the Belworth River, lie the fractured cantons of Vhasia, where Viterran dukes hold ancient claims to estates and abbeys — claims that have fueled decades of raiding, ransom, and legal warfare. And in the Dolmis, the isles of Theona pledge nominal fealty but keep their own taboos, a constant tug between crown law and green custom.

Viterra is not a nation at peace. It is a realm that wages law as war, and war as law. The Queen's Peace is not a promise — it is a contract, renewed each morning by every magistrate, every justicar, every clerk who opens a ledger. And the ink is still wet on many pages.

What you notice first: The smell of damp parchment and fresh ink. The clatter of writ-runners' boots on cobblestones. The way every noble's hand rests on a seal ring — and every commoner's hand rests on a hatchet.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never cross the Belworth without a charter recognized on both banks. Viterran law and Vhasian claim fight every crossing, and the river takes the losers.

Regional Mood: Hedge, Crown, and Claim

Here, law is a blade. The Warrior Queen rules from Valora, her throne a bench of precedents. She is young, untested, and surrounded by counselors who mistake caution for loyalty. The old Fenwood dukes — whose ancestors sacked Lence and left the Vhasian Sun-court fractured — still hold vast estates in the northern marches, and their claims across the Belworth keep the border smoking like a low fire. Every spring, the Queen's justiciars ride west with warrants and escorts, demanding homage from villages that have paid Vhasian tithes for a generation. Every autumn, Vhasian routiers raid the grain convoys, and the legal duels that follow are fought with steel and citation alike. The border is not a line on a map. It is an argument. And the Queen intends to win it.

North, the Ubral clans watch from their cairns, ready to rekindle feuds if a Viterran levy crosses the passes. South, Thepyrgos sends clerks and spies, testing the edges of Viterran jurisdiction with every disputed toll. And in Theona, the Three Greens mumble old curses while Viterran bailiffs try to count their cattle — and always miscount by one. The Queen's rule is not yet secure. Every charter she signs is a challenge. Every justiciar she sends is a declaration. Every duel fought in her name is a step toward a throne that is still being carved.

Prominent NPCs of Viterra

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Queen Veralyn Everblood	Warrior Queen of Viterra	Consolidate her rule and reclaim the crown’s authority	Her crown has no jewels — only seals; each seal is a conquered claim.
Justiciar Elodie Venn	Queen’s Justiciar	Enforce the law without fear or favour	She has never lost a legal duel; her opponents tend to fall down stairs.
Baron Aldric	Disgraced turncloak	Restore his lost honour through loyal service	He was stripped of his lands for oath-breaking; now he haunts the northern marches.
Ser Roran	Knight of the Queen’s household	Remind himself that a stranger’s coin bought his life	He wears a silver gauntlet over his left hand; he never takes ransom.
Fen Reeve Cuthbert	Keeper of the dike guilds	Protect the fens from flood and the Queen’s tax men	His tally-rod has notches from three floods; the next notch will be from a Vhasian raid.
Master Advocate Halric	Legal duelist and scholar	Win the Great Law Day and retire undefeated	He has argued cases in three kingdoms and won all using their own precedents.
Sister Oria	Custodian of the Lantern-Rites House (Belworth)	Keep the rites of hospitality and witness on the border	She has never drawn a blade. She has never needed to.

Names of Viterra

Inspired by Tudor England and early modern Britain: strong consonants, soft vowels, and surnames that recall a hedge, a dike, or a parish.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Baldwyn	Veralyn	Everblood	<i>the Law-Giver</i>
Cuthbert	Aldric	Fenwood	<i>the Unbuckled</i>
Roran	Halric	of the Scar	<i>Bell-Sworn</i>
Constano	Oria	de la Marche	<i>the Hedge-Wise</i>
Touénot	Mael	l'Argent	<i>the Silent</i>
Ghiro	Celandine	Riven	<i>Ash-Banner</i>

(Reeve/Guild/Knight/Legal Advocate) Fen reeve with tally-rod speaking for dike guilds; river-carter syndic moving grain faster than rumor; justices of the peace settling disputes with careful pen; master advocates who duel with words and swords.

Spades — Places

2. **Fen Causeway** — Stile with toll-rod and eel carts queueing; each reeve claims right to collect under a different charter. Dueling advocates argue cases on makeshift platforms. '[LAW]'
'[TRADE]' *The causeway sinks an inch each year. The lawyers argue over whose fault that is.*
3. **Hedgerow Green** — In the Dales; bows strung under apple trees where justices of the peace hold court beneath makeshift arbors. Court duels permitted for matters of honor. '[LAW]'
'[COMBAT]' *The apple tree is called “the Hanging Judge.” Its fruit tastes of iron.*
4. **Beacon Hill** — Above the Highlands; fire-grate still warm from last winter's levy call, signal tower with semaphore arms for legal dispatches and military alerts. '[AUTHORITY]'
'[TRAVEL]' *The hill has three beacons. One for Ubral raids, one for Vhasian incursions, one for paperwork.*
5. **Belworth Stairs** — Ferry ledgers gone damp with river-mist; three manors claim toll rights, writs in three different hands. Legal challenges fought in boats while waiting. '[LAW]'
'[TRAVEL]' *The stairs were repaired last year. The Vhasian side uses a different measurement.*
6. **Bloom Quarry** — Old iron-bloom turned drill yard; hammer echoes carry, forge-reeve holds tally of crown contracts. Military contracts awarded through legal bidding wars. '[CRAFT]'
'[AUTHORITY]' *The forge-reeve has never lost a contract. His opponents have a habit of finding better jobs elsewhere.*
7. **Parish Maze** — Stone maze where three maps disagree; hedge-priest's vote decides who pays tithe and who holds freehold. Legal disputes settled by navigating the maze correctly. '[LAW]'
'[RIDDLE]' *The maze changes at night. The hedge-priest says that's God's will.*
8. **Fairport Works** — Tideworks at the Dolmis mouth; customs writs in three languages flutter, inspectors with magnifying glasses examine every manifest. Maritime law enforcement includes boarding actions. '[TRADE]'
'[AUTHORITY]' *One language is Utaran, one is Linn, one is for the smugglers.*
9. **Law Quarter** — Valora archives, oath-rooms, Hall of Dawning where precedent is birthed in ink and sealed with wax. Adjacent training grounds for legal advocates. '[LAW]'
'[KNOWL-

EDGE]‘ *The archives have a locked wing. The key is a legal argument no one has won.*

10. **Counting Fields** — Tarlington beside muster ground; wagons load, ledgers mis-sum, auditors with quill-pens and suspicious eyes. Military mustering follows strict legal procedures with armed oversight. ‘[AUTHORITY]‘ ‘[LABOR]‘ *The auditors carry swords. They say it’s for counting cattle. No one asks further.*
- J **Dike Crown** — Ring of turf and timber; brotherhood bells warn of flood — and spies who move like water through the fen. Legal sanctuary for those fleeing court judgments. ‘[COMMUNITY]‘ ‘[LAW]‘ *The sanctuary lasts for one tide. After that, the reeves can come — if they can find you.*
- Q **Progress Camp** — Queen’s canvas palisade, banners stiff, whispering old courtiers plot advancement through legal maneuver and sanctioned duels. ‘[AUTHORITY]‘ ‘[SOCIAL]‘ *The camp moves every week. The lawsuits follow at a measured pace.*
- K **Tilt-Yard** — Hall of Dawning at first light; Dawn-knights drill clean, loyalties in contracts signed with careful pen. Legal challenges often end in trial by combat. ‘[COMBAT]‘ ‘[LAW]‘ *The sand is raked between duels. Sometimes the rake turns up old blood — or old oaths.*
- A **Highway Stone** — Queen’s milestone above the Dolmis road; three sheriffs post seals over hers, each claiming different jurisdiction. Territory disputes resolved through armed arbitration. ‘[AUTHORITY]‘ ‘[TRAVEL]‘ *The stone has been broken and reglued seven times. Each crack is a forgotten compromise.*

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Fen Reeve** — Tally-rod; speaks for dike guilds, remembers every flood-year’s debts and the charters that govern them. Authorized to call local levies for legal disputes. ‘[AUTHORITY]‘ ‘[COMMUNITY]‘ *His tally-rod has notches from three floods. The next notch will be from a Vhasian raid.*
3. **River Syndic** — Moves grain faster than rumor; knows which writs matter and which customs officials can be... persuaded. Maintains armed merchant guards. ‘[TRADE]‘ ‘[STEALTH]‘ *His ledger has a watermark — a crown on one side, a sunburst on the other. He shows the right side to the right audience.*
4. **Parish Surveyor** — Three maps, one opinion; hedge-walks settle more disputes than courts, measures boundaries with careful chain. Expert witness in property disputes. ‘[KNOWLEDGE]‘ ‘[LAW]‘ *His chain is exactly one rod long. The rod changes length depending on who is paying.*
5. **Dawn Quartermaster** — Ledgers sharper than tongue; logistics before lances, counts every farthing spent in the Queen’s name. Legal authority over military supplies. ‘[AUTHORITY]‘ ‘[LABOR]‘ *He once tracked a missing farthing to a Vhasian counting house. The farthing was returned — with interest.*
6. **Levy Serjeant** — Dales bow calm, cider breath, memory keen for every loophole in the mustering laws. Commands armed civilians in legal enforcement actions. ‘[COMBAT]‘ ‘[LAW]‘ *His bowstring is made from a cancelled writ. He says it shoots truer now.*
7. **Cleric-Pair** — Light preacher vs. Everflame canon lawyer; debates decide tithe law, one for the spirit, one for the letter. Religious law carries weight in secular courts. ‘[SOCIAL]‘ ‘[LAW]‘ *They share a room at the inn. They have not spoken outside court in seven years.*
8. **Fairport Shipwright** — Dolmis cousins; skiff carries more secrets than cargo, knows which manifests to forge and which to honor. Expert in maritime law and naval combat. ‘[CRAFT]‘

- ‘[STEALTH]’ *Her skiff has no name. The customs clerks have given it three.*
9. **Fenwood Comptroller** — Conjures wagons with a signature, silence with a seal, counts the Queen’s coin and tracks every debt owed to the crown. Legal authority over taxation. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[TRADE]’ *His quill is a dagger. He has used it as both.*
10. **Queen’s Justiciar** — Law on the road, polite as a noose; bearing three kings’ judgments and a purse full of pardons for the right price. Authorized to conduct trial by combat. ‘[LAW]’ ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *She has never lost a legal duel. Her opponents have a tendency to fall down stairs.*
- J **Border Routier** — Reads ledgers as ambushes; serves two crowns, collects from both, knows which border posts take bribes in what coin. Expert in frontier law enforcement. ‘[STEALTH]’ ‘[TRADE]’ *His loyalty is to the highest bidder. The Queen and the Vhasian claimant are currently in a bidding war.*
- Q **Warrior Queen** — Crown on helm, sword at side, patient sums behind her gaze; rules by law’s sharp edge and knows every precedent that supports her claim. Final arbiter in legal duels. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[LAW]’ *Her crown has no jewels — only seals. Each seal is a conquered claim.*
- K **Crown Council** — Fenwood dukes, guild envoys, abbots; weighing grain against glory, charters against coin, precedent against practicality. Legal battles fought through proxy advocates. ‘[POLITICS]’ ‘[LAW]’ *The council has a standing rule: no weapons within the chamber. The advocates have found seventeen loopholes.*
- A **Master Advocate Halric** — Silver-tongued legal warrior who settles disputes through verbal duels that can end in physical combat. Keeper of legal combat traditions. ‘[LAW]’ ‘[COMBAT]’ *He has argued cases in Vhasian, Thepyrgosian, and Ubral courts — and won all three using their own precedents.*

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Dike Breach** — Black-rain; the wrong reeve claims credit while wagons drown, insurance claims and liability writs fly like autumn leaves. Legal liability may require armed enforcement. ‘[DISASTER]’ ‘[LAW]’ *The water is brown with peat and lies. It carries old deeds downstream.*
3. **Feast Clash** — Light vs. Everflame processions collide; shutters slam, writs fly, justices of the peace called to settle which holy day takes precedence. Honor disputes may require legal duels. ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[LAW]’ *The processions take different routes now. The clash was not an accident.*
4. **Quiet Tolls** — Sprout on the Queen’s Highway; escorts sniff traps, sheriffs argue rights, customs officials demand duties no one knew existed. Territorial disputes resolved through armed arbitration. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The toll posts have fresh paint. The paint is from the keep of a Vhasian claimant.*
5. **Audit Freeze** — Counting-house freezes cargo; Queen’s seal vs. old writs, auditors with suspicious eyes and quill-pens sharp as daggers. Legal challenges may escalate to physical confrontation. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[DEBT]’ *The auditors work by candlelight. The shadows on the walls look like gallows.*
6. **Border Snarl** — Three courts arrest the same hay-cart; whose hay is it? Which lord’s charter takes precedence? Bribes flow like wine. Frontier justice often involves armed standoffs. ‘[LAW]’ ‘[COMBAT]’ *The hay is from a field that was Vhasian last spring. Now it’s Viterran. The field hasn’t moved.*

7. **Isle Refusal** — Theona withholds levy; the quays choke on rumor, ships idle while lawyers debate maritime law and ancient treaties. Naval blockades become legal enforcement actions. ‘[POLITICS]’ ‘[LAW]’ *Theona’s envoy carries a hawthorn branch. The Queen’s justiciars will not touch it.*
8. **Delta Spat** — Fairport vs. Marcott customs; barges stack three deep, merchants pick sides, inspectors with magnifying glasses examine every manifest. Trade disputes fought with merchant guards. ‘[TRADE]’ ‘[LAW]’ *The magnifying glasses reveal truth and also start fires. Both are useful.*
9. **Routier Arrears** — A free-company flips unless someone pays; your name on a ledger, a debt owed to men who know the price of blood. Legal debts enforced through hired swords. ‘[DEBT]’ ‘[COMBAT]’ *The routiers have a list. Your name is on it — or will be by sunset.*
10. **Salt Pinch** — Import spikes, bakers barricade; the Queen’s promise tastes like thin gruel, merchants hoard salt like gold, riots brew in back alleys. Economic warfare becomes physical conflict. ‘[WEATHER]’ ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The salt is grey. It was cut with ashes from a burned Vhasian customs post.*
- J **Dawn Recall** — Escort pulled to a flood-struck parish; the writ argues with the river, justices demand inquiry into who neglected the dikes. Military enforcement of legal judgments. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The escorts are back in a week. They bring new writs — and fewer men.*
- Q **Aberielist Intrigue** — Royalist seals in wrong hands; the Queen’s patience thins, conspirators plot in counting houses, whispers of rebellion. Treason charges carry death penalty in legal duels. ‘[POLITICS]’ ‘[LAW]’ *The seals are from a dead duke. The duke’s ghost is said to approve.*
- K **Levy Call-Up** — Dalesmen mustered; your wagons seized “for the realm,” conscription writs signed with careful pen, families left to tend fields alone. Legal authority backed by armed force. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[COMBAT]’ *The conscription writs have a clause: “void if Belworth freezes.” The river is still warm.*
- A **Legal Duel Challenge** — Master Advocate Halric issues a formal challenge; refuse and lose legal standing, accept and risk life and fortune in court-yard combat. The ultimate legal weapon. ‘[LAW]’ ‘[COMBAT]’ *The challenge is written on both sides of the parchment. There is no blank space to refuse.*

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Ferry Priority** — Belworth crossing (once); a horn answers, though perhaps the wrong ferry; customs officials look the other way for the right coin. Legal right of way backed by armed escort. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The priority token is a writ signed by both banks. The ink on one side is newer.*
3. **Dike Allotment** — Brotherhood labor granted if three clerks are convinced and proper bribes distributed among the right hands. Work performed under legal contract with military oversight. ‘[LABOR]’ *The allotment includes a clause: “as tides permit.” The reeve decides what the tides permit.*
4. **Market License** — Valora’s square; a guild nod still needed, but the right seal on the right parchment opens many doors. Legal protection from merchant guild enforcement. ‘[TRADE]’ *The license is written on vellum from a Vhasian abbey. The irony is noted.*
5. **Dawn Escort** — Four lances at dawn; loyalty waxes and wanes with pay, but their presence

- keeps lesser men from troubling you. Legal authority to enforce your writs. '[AUTHORITY]' *The lances are from the Fenwood armory. The Fenwood dukes have their own plans.*
6. **River Charter** — Guaranteed haul on a grain artery — weather permitting and proper duties paid to the right officials. Legal right protected by river patrol. '[TRAVEL]' *The charter is stamped with a seal that looks like a crown — or a sunburst. No one can agree.*
 7. **Map Correction** — A hedge moves, borders shift, lawsuits bloom; a new survey can make or break a man's fortune overnight. Legal survey backed by armed surveyors. '[LAW]' *The surveyors carry chains and swords. The swords are for when the chains disagree.*
 8. **Customs Seal** — Fairport for Dolmis cargo; honored today, disputed tomorrow, but tonight it clears the way for what needs moving. Legal immunity from customs enforcement. '[TRADE]' *The seal is a wax crab. It pinches when pressed.*
 9. **Thing Ruling** — Sharp local bite, but appeals run swifter than oaths; justice swift but not always just, depending on which purse feeds the judge. Court decisions enforceable by local levy. '[LAW]' *The ruling is carved on an oar. Break the oar, and the ruling breaks with it.*
 10. **Salt Allotment** — Winter depot; the Queen's writ opens doors, old hands still count sacks, but the right connections ensure the best salt reaches the right tables. Legal monopoly backed by military force. '[TRADE]' *The salt is from a pan worked by Ubral exiles. They still count in clan measure.*
- J **Wardship** — A minor fen-keep; men-at-arms "for now," a tutor has plans, but the right guardian can be found for the right price. Legal guardianship with military authority. '[AUTHORITY]' *The ward is a child. The child has a seal ring. The ring is older than the kingdom.*
- Q **Queen's Audience** — Private; her questions strike like thrusts, but her favors can elevate a man from nothing to something overnight. Royal decree carries immediate enforcement power. '[AUTHORITY]' *The audience lasts one hour. The paperwork lasts a generation.*
- K **Ducal Warrant** — Fenwood to enforce customs; old power bows, new power watches, but the parchment carries weight in any court. Legal authority backed by noble house military. '[AUTHORITY]' *The warrant is signed in blood — or ink that looks like blood. The difference matters at trial.*
- A **Duel Sanction** — Right to challenge in legal combat; the Queen's seal makes it official, Dawn-knights serve as seconds, the winner takes all legally. Ultimate legal enforcement mechanism. '[LAW]' '[COMBAT]' *The sanction is a coin. Heads you duel, tails your opponent chooses the weapon.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (writs/charters/priority) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **hedge-law** motif — boundaries blur, charters contradict, precedent splinters, and the careful web of legal authority shows its cracks. Legal warfare escalates to physical conflict.

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **Hedge-Law Momentum:** When a valid *writ*, *charter*, or *warrant* is presented in the proper parish, step **Position** up one category on social or logistical actions in that locale for the scene. The first contradiction starts a **Border-Lace** [4] clock; advance each time competing papers are invoked.
- **Beacon & Bell Chain:** If two adjacent *beacons* or *brotherhood bells* are under your influence, convert one **Club** draw into a travel delay for *others* while the party proceeds with improved **Effect** for movement and logistics. The signal draws scrutiny; the GM may bank 1 SB tied to local authority.
- **River-Right Window:** At a ferry, tidework, or customs stair, play any **Diamond** tied to crossings or seals to open a short *window of lawful passage*: one convoy passes uninspected, or one cargo clears at priority. The window closes immediately if a storm, audit, or levy card is revealed.
- **Legal Duel Protocol:** When legal disputes cannot be resolved through argument, parties may challenge each other to a duel. The winner’s position becomes legally binding. Requires proper sanction and seconds (see **Duel Sanction** Diamond).
- **Vhasian Claims:** Any Viterran noble with land across the Belworth may invoke a *Ducal Warrant* to attempt to collect rents or enforce judgments in Vhasia. Doing so starts a **Border Snarl** clock, as the Vhasian claimants are unlikely to cooperate.
- **Theona Contest:** The Warrior Queen’s authority over the Three Greens is nominal at best. Any attempt to enforce Viterran law in Theona triggers an **Isle Refusal** complication, and the local taboos may twist the law into knots.
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
 - **Seint Michel of the Gilded Scale** — Mykkiel. *The law that does not bend; the judge who cannot be bought.*
 - **Seint Isabeau of the Lilies** — Ikasha. *The dream of setting aside the crown; the mercy of forgetting duty.*
 - **Seint Evroul of the Cairn** — Mor’iraath. *The oath that outlasts the oath-taker; the debt paid in blood and stone.*
 - **The Hedge King** — The Traveler. *The road that belongs to no lord; the path that finds its own way.*

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **Saint Elodie of the Unbuckled Gorget (The Witness):** The Justiciar Elodie Venn invoked the long-forgotten *Right of Acknowledgment* in the trial of Baron Aldric the Turncloak. Her ruling forced a father to speak one truth aloud before his son. The precedent now stands in the Hall of Dawning: “The truth, once spoken, is payment in full. No further interest shall accrue.” The Temple of Light has adopted her as a saint of mercy; the Fenwood dukes still whisper that she overstepped.
- **The Hedge-Seal (The Dike Covenant):** Covenant judges in the eastern parishes adjudicate disputes over river tolls and inheritance. They carry no weapons, only a set of iron scales and a copy of the *Hedge-Law Tables*. A ruling from the Order is binding in both Viterra and the Vhasian marches, but any party who lies before them forfeits their right to appeal. The Warrior Queen has granted them a charter; the Fenwood dukes consider them spies.

- **Saint Cuthbert of the Fen (The Traveler):** A legendary reeve who walked the flooded dikes during the Great Storm and lit every beacon by hand. His shrines are stiles and bridge posts; travellers who touch the iron ring on his shrine and speak a destination find the road holds firm. The Temple of Light has absorbed his cult, but the fen folk still leave offerings of eels at his cairns.
- **The Cog-Cults of the Northern Hills (The Clockwork Monad):** In the high parishes near the Ubral border, secret fraternities of millers and surveyors believe that law is a machine that can be perfected. They meet in abandoned watermills, measuring boundaries with brass chains and reciting the *Canons of Proportion*. The Everflame calls them heretics; the Queen's justiciars ignore them because their charts are always accurate.
- **The Salt Sworn of the Eastern Coast (The Pale Shepherd):** Along the Dolmis shore, a syncretic cult tends to the drowned. They build cairns of salt stone and leave no offerings — only the names of the lost, carved into driftwood. The Temple of Light has tried to suppress them three times; each time, the mission ships have been found adrift with no crew and a single name carved into the mast: *Oblivion*.
- **The Ninth:** In any Viterran court, the ninth citation of precedent voids all previous citations. The wise stop at eight and settle out of court. Those who cite the ninth are said to hear a faint laughter from the marble walls — and their cases are never heard again.

Viterran Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Hedge:** Crumble a crust at a parish boundary stone. Ignore the first *Border Snarl* penalty. '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Knot the Writ:** Tie a single knot in a charter's ribbon. Cancel *Audit Freeze* or take -1 die on your next legal argument (your choice). '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Name to the River:** Whisper a dead claimant's name into the Belworth. Gain +1 Effect when arguing against their heir's claim this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Queen's Justiciar. '[SUPERSTITION]'

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **crown officials or rival advocates**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **writ-runners or levy guards**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or customs inspectors**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favorable court date**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Queen's Justiciar or fen reeve** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **legal challenge or river closure**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **rival claimant or border routier** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **Dawn-knights, levy forces, or Vhasian routiers** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes — **writ voided/duel declared/levy called**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival: Warrior Queen, Crown Council, or Master Advocate Halric** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically — **dike breaks/river floods/court erupts**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice — **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Viterra (Hedge Law):** Boundary stones shift, charters contradict themselves, legal precedents split mid-citation.
- **Viterra (Cross-Border Claims):** Vhasian landlords appear with older deeds, Theonan taboos void writs, Ubral cairns declare neutrality with axes.
- **Viterra (Legal Warfare):** Court decisions reverse without warning, witnesses recant, duel seconds change sides.

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Wits + Survival):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Thorn Hedge*.
- **Cut the Charter (Presence + Sway):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a **Ducal Warrant** is in your possession, +1 die.
- **Weather the Assize (Resolve + Lore):** On a hit in *Audit Freeze*, you pick whose ledgers are examined; on a miss, the GM does.

Legal Combat System (Summary)

When legal disputes cannot be resolved through negotiation, parties may engage in formal legal duels. These combine verbal sparring with physical combat:

Phase 1: Pleadings

- Each advocate presents their case (Wits + Sway vs. DV 3)
- Success grants +1 die to the next phase
- Failure creates 1 SB that the opponent can spend

Phase 2: Cross-Examination

- Attack opponent's arguments (Wits + Insight vs. DV 3)
- Success inflicts Fatigue 1 on the opponent
- Critical success forces opponent to answer truthfully

Phase 3: Trial by Combat (if unresolved)

- Physical combat with legal stakes (Body + Melee or relevant combat skill)
- Winner's position becomes legally binding
- Loser suffers legal consequences (fine, loss of claim, imprisonment) plus physical harm

Boss Seeds (three-phase foes)

- **The Violet Clerk (Master of Counter-Seals)** — *Phases*: Produce Earlier Patent → Split the Writ → Seal Fast. *Cracks*: a **Queen's Audience** overrules his seal; a **Duel Sanction** forces personal combat; a **Map Correction** voids his boundary claim.
- **The Thorn Captain (Queen's Quiet Hand)** — *Phases*: Queenspace Zone → Duel Warrant → Swap the Field. *Cracks*: a **Map Correction** reveals a loophole; a **Dike Allotment** lets you claim the field as "flood zone"; a **Border Routier** testifies to the Queen's favor.
- **The Saffron Abbess (Keeper of Bell-Law)** — *Phases*: Wrong Hour → Bless or Damn → Mixed Tribunal. *Cracks*: a **Queen's Justiciar** invokes crown supremacy; a **Border Routier** bribes her bell-ringer; a **Thing Ruling** from Theona forces her to recuse.

Legendary Sites & Trials

- **Belworth Stairs Ordeal** — Cross the river without a charter. On success, you prove that possession is nine-tenths of the law. On failure, the river takes your name — and your cargo. (Wits + Survival vs. DV 5.)
- **Hall of Dawning Vigil** — Spend a night in the tilt-yard. At dawn, you recall a forgotten legal precedent. Gain a one-use *Precedent Edge* (+1 die in any court). The ghost of a dead duelist may challenge you to a legal dream-duel. (Spirit + Lore vs. DV 4.)
- **Hedge-Moot at Dusk** — Settle a boundary dispute by walking the hedge. Each successful navigation test (Wits + Survival) clears 1 segment from a **Border Snarl** clock. A miss plants the thorn of a future feud (advance **Border Snarl** by 1).

Extensions (Plug-in)

- **Legal Dial (Crown ↔ Local Custom)**: Track the party's stance on authority.
 - *Crown High*: +1 Position when invoking royal writs, charters, or the Queen's name; first appeal to local custom starts one step worse.
 - *Local High*: +1 Effect on hedge-law, parish rights, or ancient precedent; first royal petition starts one step worse.
 - Center the dial by hosting a mixed moot or surrendering a contested seal to a neutral third party.
- **Courtroom Mini-Game (fast trial)**:
 - Lay three stones: **Precedent**, **Equity**, **Force**.
 - Argue a point (roll Lore+Diplomacy vs. DV 3). On a hit, move one stone to your side. On a miss, the opposing advocate gains *Citation Edge*.

- Win two stones to secure a temporary **Court Ruling** (treat as a Diamond for one scene).
- *Halric’s Interjection (2 SB)*: flip **Precedent**, but start **Whispered Precedent** [2] with the losing side.
- **Cross-Border Tensions (fast pressure)**:
 - Two opposed clocks: *Queen’s Peace* vs *Border Fire* (size by highest rank in the seed).
 - Each leg, choose *Viterran Road* (safe, slow), *Vhasian Claim* (fast, risky), or *Ubral Pass* (hidden, costly).
 - Advantage: Vhasian Claim→Viterran Road (shortcuts), Ubral Pass→Vhasian Claim (concealment), Viterran Road→Ubral Pass (supplies).
 - Spend a **Ducal Warrant** to shift one segment from *Border Fire* to *Queen’s Peace*.
- **Start-of-Scene Rumors (1d6)**:
 1. *Wrong Wax*: a rival’s seals softened; +1d to forgeries this scene.
 2. *Empty Beacon*: tower unmanned; travel faster, scrutiny harsher.
 3. *Dawn-Lane Cleared*: first convoy action gains +1 Position.
 4. *Clerk’s Wedding*: filings delayed; first petition ignores *Audit Freeze*.
 5. *Fen High Water*: ferries slow; river-charters count double value.
 6. *Mask at Progress*: someone uses your name at court; +1d to social opens, +1 SB banked by GM.
- **Plug-in SB Conversions (Viterra Flavor)**:
 - 1 SB → *Hedge Shift*: a boundary moves; increase DV by 1 for navigation or legal rolls this scene.
 - 2 SB → *Citation War*: increase DV by 1 unless you produce a precedent (spend a $\Diamond$ *orrecallapastruling*).
 - 3+ SB → *Seal Crack*: a writ loses half its value; swap one held $\Diamond$ *foralesserrightuntilre-witnessed*.
- **Reputation Echoes**:
 - *Court-Favored*: once/session, downgrade **Audit Freeze** to a minor delay; the next document you present is scrutinized (+1 DV).
 - *Fen-Tested*: +1 Position when resolving dike or flood crises; legal arguments about water rights start one step worse.
 - *Double-Sealed*: +1d with both royal and local courts in a truce scene; any betrayal earns **Border Snarl** from both sides.
- **Cross-Region Hooks (quick integration)**:
 - *Ubral (Stone & Oath)*: A **Ducal Warrant** acts as a *Guest-Token* once at a clan hearth, but starts a **Feud Rekindled** tick if you collect tolls twice in a tenday.
 - *Thepyrgos (Synod Law)*: A **Queen’s Audience** can suspend a synod interdict — but starts *Whispered Precedent* in Thepyrgos.
 - *Vhasia (Fractured Sun)*: A **Duel Sanction** is recognized on the Pont-du-Tithe — but a rival abbey can turn it into *Parlement Divided* on a Club draw.
 - *Theona (No Ninth)*: **Ferry Priority** overrides a local taboo once; if the Ninth custom is in play, the writ “forgets” one clause on use (GM banks 1 SB).

Conspiracy Flourishes (keep it close, keep it quiet)

- **Hedge-Moots at Dusk:** Parish elders “trim hedges” while trading sealed whispers.
- **Cipher Roses:** Folded writs stamped with thorn-petals; one petal missing marks a false clause.
- **Mirror Hours:** Beacons flash lawful signals — reversed for those who know the counter-code.
- **Eel-Letters:** Oiled parchment smuggled in eel-baskets; ink runs in water, truth does not.
- **Quiet Steel, Quieter Quills:** Dawn-knights duel at first light; advocates settle three duels before breakfast with ink alone.
- **Progress Masks:** Courtiers wear legal devices as masque motifs (seal, chain, beacon) to signal faction at a glance.
- **Bell Penance:** A single off-hour peal grants amnesty to those who confess a clause before the twelfth echo.

Patronage & Power

In Viterra, power flows through the careful application of law, the management of ancient rights, and the delicate balance between imperial legacy and reclaimed sovereignty. The Warrior Queen maintains authority through a combination of military might and legal precision, while the old duchies and local officials wield influence through their knowledge of traditional customs and hedge-law. The true power lies with those who can navigate this complex legal landscape and maintain the appearance of legitimate authority while building genuine support.

But remember — in Viterra, law is warfare. Every document is a weapon, every courtroom a battlefield, and every advocate a soldier. The pen cuts as deep as any blade, and legal victory can be as decisive as military conquest.

For the GM: Patronage in Viterra revolves around legal documents, local rights, and the ability to command respect from institutions still finding their post-imperial identity. Rewards often take the form of writs, charters, and official positions that can be leveraged into greater influence. To emphasize this:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (seals, writs, charters) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided.
- Let rival duchies and Vhasian claimants issue conflicting authorities, forcing players to choose whose favor matters more.
- Use the courts, parishes, and muster grounds as arenas for social contests, where knowledge of law and custom determines success.
- When legal conflicts escalate beyond words, transition naturally to physical confrontation with appropriate stakes.

In Viterra, your papers are your power, and your power determines whether you rule or are ruled. But when words fail, steel speaks — and the law says both are valid.

Chapter 6

Thepyrgos

City of a Thousand Stairs.

Every stair climbed is a word in the great conversation between earth and sky. This city is not built—it is grown, stone by stone, law by law, until the very architecture speaks wisdom.

I am a Bell-Runner. I know every step that creaks a warning and every landing that whispers gossip. The bells tell the city's mood better than any lord—three chimes means business, six means trouble, and nine means the hunters are coming.

The Synod rules here with the delicacy of a brick wrapped in velvet—they hate unsanctioned magic like it's a personal insult, but they adore infrastructure, especially when it's shiny, expensive, and comes with a side of indulgences they can sell to the faithful. The Chain-Lanterns move at dawn, their brass censers swinging, their bells tuned to the frequency of latent magic. In the university's forbidden tiers, the Witness and the Ninth arm rival fraternities with citations and curses, and no one is sure which side the Archon secretly favours.

Never let a bell-ringer count your breaths. The Chain-Lanterns pay well for names that ring false on the test stairs.

— *Sofia, Bell-Runner, who ties a knot in her hair for each hunter she has outrun*

The Almanac of Ordinary Days

What do people eat for breakfast? Flatbread with olive oil and a boiled egg—if you are a clerk. If you are a student, bread and water. If you are a professor, bread, water, and a single fig. The fig is a status symbol. The status is "I have not been audited."

What does a child learn before they can walk? To read a bell schedule. Thepyrgos runs on bells—dawn bells, market bells, curfew bells, trial bells. A child who cannot read the bells cannot cross the city without a guardian. A child without a guardian is a child who will be sold to the university for dissection.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their step count. Thepyrgos has a thousand stairs. A stranger who counts them aloud is either a pilgrim or a spy. A stranger who climbs them in silence is either a native or a ghost.

What is the most common crime? Unsanctioned magic. The Synod licenses every spell cast within the walls. An unlicensed cantrip is a misdemeanour. An unlicensed healing is a felony. An unlicensed summoning is a death sentence—not for the caster, who will be executed, but for the summoned, who will be bound to the city's foundation as a "structural consultant."

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Silent Stair is not silent. It whispers. The whispers are the confessions of the dead—scholars who died in the university's service, their secrets recorded in the stone. The Chain-Lanterns listen. They do not share.

Where do people go when they die? To the catacombs beneath the university. The catacombs are a library of bones. Each skeleton is labelled with the scholar's name, their thesis, and the date of their death. The unlabelled bones are the ones who died before they could finish. They are still writing.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You submit a "retraction" to the Synod's Committee on Ethical Correction. The retraction must be published in the public square, read aloud by a herald, and witnessed by at least three notaries. The fee is 50 silver. The shame is free.

What is the most important festival? The Convocation of the Steps (summer solstice). Every citizen climbs the thousand stairs to the upper citadel. At the top, the Archon reads the names of the dead from the past year. The names are carved into the steps as they are read. The steps are getting crowded.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Archon is a fraud. He never passed the Synod's examination. His degree was purchased from a disgraced dean whose signature is forged on every document. The forger is still alive. They live in the catacombs. They have the original quill.

6.1 Thepyrgos — “The City of Unfinished Proofs”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *Every stair is a question. Every answer is a debt. The Ninth and the Witness argue over who holds the receipt.*

The Archon (Elite): “Every stair climbed is a word in the great conversation between earth and sky. This city is not built – it is grown, stone by stone, law by law, until the very architecture speaks wisdom. But the stairs remember more than the living. They remember the ones who never came down.”

Bell-Runner (Commoner): “I know every step that creaks a warning and every landing that whispers gossip. The bells tell the city’s mood better than any lord – three chimes means business, six means trouble, and nine means the hunters are coming. But on the ninth bell, the stairs themselves answer.”

Genre / Mood: Scholarly vertical city, Byzantine bureaucracy, Grecian folk horror in the hinterlands, metaphysical war between memory and forgetting.

Starting Location: The Synod Hall at dusk. Gold-glass mosaics glitter as a Matriarch reads a scroll aloud. “The Beacon Crown sees traitors in the smoke. A child’s talent was sold to the Commissary last night. Find the informer — or the next stair seized will be yours. And if you hear a stair creak where none exists, do not turn around. The Ninth is counting.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Thepyrgos is both realm and city, built on the bones of the drowned Astroegro Empire. The capital rises in tiers of towers, terraces, and endless stairs above the Dolmis shore – but the stairs are not stone. They are *fossilised vertebrae*, the spine of a leviathan that Khemesh dragged under when the last emperor broke a covenant older than the sea. Once a Utaran province, now a nation unto itself, Thepyrgos is famed for its universities, libraries, and debating synods, where precedent and philosophy weigh as much as pikes or coin.

Outside the city, the countryside is a rugged coastal landscape of whitewashed villages, olive groves, and timber churches – home to the **Hyro** people. The Hyro carry the fracture of the Astroegro in their blood. A child born in the hills might dream in geometries that do not exist. A farmer might hear the stones whispering in a language no living throat can shape. The Chain-Lantern order and other Witch-Hunter Commissariats ruthlessly patrol these villages, using bounty postings, candle-smoke tests, and stair-seizures to identify and kidnap children with arcane talent. The Hyro have learned to offer *substitutes* – a memory, a false name, a lock of hair – at crossroads, hoping the Hollow accepts the payment.

In the university's forbidden tiers, the **Witness** and the **Ninth** fight a proxy war via fraternal orders and occult mystery cults. The Witness wants the Astroegro Vaults *remembered* but sealed; the Ninth wants them *opened*, to trigger a Great Unlearning that would erase the concept of debt from the world. No one is sure which side the Archon secretly favors. And in the ruins of the Astroegro, something still ticks – gears of black glass, locked doors that hum, and the occasional survivor with eyes like burning tar who speaks of a pressure from below.

What you notice first: The endless chime of bells from different tiers, never quite in sync. The smell of brine and olive oil and candle wax. The way locals glance at the sky when a child coughs – and then at the nearest crossroads.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never let a bell-ringer count your breaths. The Chain-Lanterns pay well for names that ring false on the test stairs. But worse: never ask a question of a stair that has no end. The Ninth is listening, and it will answer.

Regional Mood: Stairs, Bells, and the Argument of Patrons

Here, every ascent is a plea and every descent a confession. Thepyrgos the city is a vertical labyrinth of stair-rights, rope-guilds, and synod edicts that shift with the tide. Thepyrgos the province is a haunted countryside of hidden talent and state-sanctioned abduction. The Hyro keep their arcane children in root cellars and haylofts, praying the hunters take the neighbour's instead. The Chain-Lanterns move at dawn, their brass censers swinging, their bells tuned to the frequency of latent magic. In the university's forbidden tiers, the Witness and the Ninth arm rival fraternities with citations and curses, and no one is sure which side the Archon secretly favors. And in the ruins of the Astroegro, something still ticks – gears of black glass, locked doors that hum, and the occasional survivor with eyes like burning tar who speaks of a pressure from below.

Prominent NPCs of Thepyrgos

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk

Archon Konstantinos	Ruler of the city, elected by the wards	Balance the synod, the guilds, and the Commissariat	He wears a key around his neck; no one knows what it opens – or that it is a key to the Ninth’s Vault.
Matriarch Eleni	Synod primate, head of the Temple of Light’s synod	Keep the Everflame from reclaiming the province	She speaks once a session; when she does, the bells listen. She has never spoken the ninth word.
Commissary Kyrillos	Chain-Lantern commander	Purge all untutored magic from the province	His lantern shows not only latent talent but also the bearer’s greatest fear. He refuses to look into it himself.
Sofia	Bell-Runner (commoner exemplar)	Outrun the hunters and protect the hidden gifted	She ties a knot in her hair for each hunter she has outrun; her hair is a thicket. One knot is white – a hunter she could not outrun.
Nomophylax Zoe	Law-scholar, master of citations	Reform the synod from within	She has never lost a case; her opponents have a habit of vanishing into the Unfinished Stair.

The Lighthouse-Patriarch	Reclusive seer of the Beacon Crown	Steer the city through the coming storm	He has no eyes – only mirrors where his eyes should be. In the mirrors you see the faces of those who owe the Ninth.
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Names of Thepyrgos

Inspired by the southern peninsulas and the Aegean coast: clear vowels, soft endings, and surnames that recall a stair, a tower, or a village.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Konstantinos	Eleni	Skalas	<i>the Stair-Wise</i>
Dimitris	Zoe	Platanos	<i>the Unseen</i>
Kyrillos	Sofia	Raptis	<i>Bell-Sworn</i>
Nikolas	Anastasia	Laskaris	<i>the Accursed</i>
Leonidas	Irini	Makris	<i>Ash-Finger</i>
Stephanos	Fotini	Koutroulis	<i>the Silent</i>

(Tower/Stair/Sea-wall) Pilgrim’s Stair zig-zagging sea-cliff to wicket gate; Tower Quarter with family keeps stitched by ladders and bridges.

Spades — Places

2. **Pilgrim’s Stair** — Zig-zagging sea-cliff to wicket gate; ascent as devotion. ‘[TRAVEL]’ ‘[RITUAL]’ *Every hundredth step has a bell. Pilgrims ring once for mercy, twice for memory. The ninth bell has no clapper.*
3. **Tower Quarter** — Family keeps stitched by ladders and bridges; vertical neighbourhoods. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The lowest rung of each ladder is painted red — a toll for the rope-guild. The rope-guild’s ledger is written in disappearing ink.*
4. **Chain-Barbican** — Harbor gate; capstans ready to raise the boom at horn’s call. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The capstan pins are carved from the thighbones of executed smugglers. The bones still warm in your hand.*
5. **Blue Cistern** — Under the forum; cool echo, strict tally; water as law. ‘[MAGIC]’ ‘[DEBT]’ *The water tastes of copper and old prayers. Drink deep, and you may forget a debt – but the water will remember your face.*
6. **Ropeyard Terrace** — Cranes walk cargo up slope by treadwheel; muscle and machinery. ‘[LABOR]’ *The treadwheel operators sing in eights. The ninth beat is always silent – that is when the Stair moves.*

7. **Storm-Wall Arcades** — Wind shrieks through arched galleries; defense as architecture. ‘[WEATHER]’ *The wind carries voices from the last siege. Some say they’re warnings. Others say they’re the Ninth rehearsing.*
8. **Beacon Crown** — Ring of watchtowers signaling along the Dolmis; eyes of the city. ‘[TRAVEL]’ ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The beacons burn juniper and saltpeter. Black smoke means fire; white smoke means hunters. Green smoke means the Stair is hungry.*
9. **Library of Keys** — Archive vaults; shelves locked by rung and rite; knowledge as power. ‘[MAGIC]’ ‘[SECRET]’ *The keys are graded by sin. The ninth key opens nothing – and everything. It is kept in a box that has no lid.*
10. **Siege Court** — Test ramp and scarred stones; war never far from peace. ‘[COMBAT]’ *The ramp’s stones are stained with lamp oil and regret. Practice charges end in the cistern – or the Unfinished Stair.*
- J **Ladder Monastery** — Perched on a needle of rock; monks climb toward truth. ‘[RITUAL]’ *The monks never speak. They write commandments in chalk on the rungs. The ninth rung has no chalk – only a smear of ash.*
- Q **Synod Hall** — Gold-glass mosaics; judgment audible at a whisper’s distance. ‘[LAW]’ *The acoustics are enchanted. A lie told here echoes twice – once in the liar’s voice, once in truth’s. The Ninth’s lies echo only once.*
- K **Archon’s Citadel** — Acropolis peak; mirror tiles glare like noon’s justice. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The mirrors were a gift from Kahfagia. They show not the sea, but the faces of debtors – and sometimes a stair that was not there before.*
- A **The Unfinished Stair** — A hidden flight that appears only to those who have asked a question the Synod cannot answer. ‘[THRESHOLD]’ ‘[MYSTERY]’ *The stairs have no end. Each step is a different year. At the top, the Ninth and the Witness are playing knucklebones with forgotten names.*

(Archon/Synod/Guild) Bell-runner child whose feet know every stair by heart; Master of Ropes with palms like oak, voice like a whistle.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Bell-Runner** — Child whose feet know every stair by heart; speed as currency. ‘[STEALTH]’ *She ties a knot in her hair for each hunter she has outrun; her hair is a thicket. One knot is white – a hunter she could not outrun.*
3. **Master of Ropes** — Palms like oak, voice like a whistle; guild head of lifters. ‘[LABOR]’ *He lost two fingers to a frayed line. He keeps them in a jar as a warning. The jar is on the ninth shelf.*
4. **Icon-Smith** — Portable shrine, temper about pigment; faith in detail. ‘[CRAFT]’ *His pigments are ground from stolen icons. He calls it recycling the divine. The Ninth calls it preparation.*
5. **Wall Strategos** — Drills levies on the test ramp; defense as daily ritual. ‘[COMBAT]’ *She lost a son to a Linn raid. She trains orphans now – and keeps a list. The list has nine names.*
6. **Chain-Keeper** — Harbor boom; hates “surprises” at dusk; order as obsession. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *His bell never rings the same note twice. He says the tide changes its mind. The Ninth changes its tone.*

7. **Oath-Examiner** — Weighs words like iron; notary of truth and consequence. ‘[LAW]’ *She carries a scale with one pan empty. The empty pan is for lies. When the Ninth speaks, both pans tip.*
8. **Archive Sister** — Key to the “forbidden rung”; keeper of dangerous knowledge. ‘[SECRET]’ *Her left eye is milk-white — a price for reading a cursed shelf. The shelf was a stair in a past life.*
9. **Salt-Fish Syndic** — Warehouse queen of the quays; profit in preservation. ‘[TRADE]’ *Her salt is cut with ground bone meal. The fish stay fresh — and quiet. The bones were from a stair.*
10. **Nomophylax** — Law-scholar whose citations close mouths; precedent as weapon. ‘[LAW]’ *He has never lost a case. His opponents have a habit of vanishing. The Unfinished Stair has a new step.*
- J **Palikar Captain** — Tower guards; ladder-quick and letter-shy; strength in motion. ‘[COMBAT]’ *His shield is painted with a ladder — each rung a battle he survived. The ninth rung is blank.*
- Q **Matriarch of the Ladder** — Synod primate; calm as stone, wisdom in height. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *She speaks once a session. When she does, the bells listen. She has never spoken the ninth word.*
- K **The Archon** — Elected, entrenched, counting bells; ruler of the ascent. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *He wears a key around his neck. No one knows what it opens. The key is a stair.*
- A **Lighthouse-Patriarch** — Reclusive seer; said to steer beacons in storms. ‘[MYSTERY]’ *He has no eyes — only mirrors where his eyes should be. In the mirrors you see the Unfinished Stair.*

(**Edict/Quake/Chain**) Tremor with hairline cracks racing down a stair; crowds freeze; iconoclast riot in the Tower Quarter.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Tremor** — Hairline cracks race down a stair; crowds freeze, dust speaks. ‘[DISASTER]’ *The dust spells names. Yours appears if you’ve broken a stair-right — or if the Ninth is curious.*
3. **Iconoclast Riot** — In the Tower Quarter; pigments and teeth fly through the air. ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[COMBAT]’ *The riot started over a missing icon’s eye. The eye was a hunter’s informer. The icon was a stair.*
4. **Chain Jam** — At the barbican; capstan pins shear at the worst moment. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The pins were filed by a saboteur. The chain will hold — or not. The Ninth is taking bets.*
5. **Black Northerly** — Pins cranes; cargo hangs between tiers, prayers below. ‘[WEATHER]’ *The wind smells of iron and ice. Someone is using weather magic. The Witness disapproves.*
6. **Cistern Taint** — Sour water; inspectors padlock spouts, thirst rises. ‘[DEBT]’ *The taint is sweet — too sweet. Someone poisoned the cistern to flush out a talent. The talent is a stair.*
7. **Synod Summons** — A chant or badge is suddenly proscribed; law shifts like wind. ‘[LAW]’ *The summons is written on a bell-clapper. Read it, and you are a witness. The Ninth writes the margin.*
8. **Rope Guild Interdict** — No lifts until a grievance is heard; the city stops climbing. ‘[LABOR]’ *The guild’s grievance is a single name. The name is yours. The name is also a*

stair.

9. **Siege Drill Panic** — Practice horns mistaken for real; chaos in the ranks. ‘[FEAR]’ *The horns were blown by a child who didn’t know the difference. Or did they? The child is a step.*
10. **Smuggler’s Ladder** — Discovered; the whole stair sealed, routes rerouted. ‘[STEALTH]’ ‘[DEBT]’ *The ladder was built by a Hyro family. Now they are all “guests” of the Commissariat. Their house is a stair.*
- J **Ropeyard Fire** — Sparks leap uphill faster than boots; smoke chokes the ascent. ‘[DISASTER]’ *The fire was set to cover a kidnapping. The victim’s name is on the bounty board. The board is a stair.*
- Q **Exarch’s Claim** — “Thepyrgos under my protection”; arrests follow the papers. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The Exarch is a puppet of the Chain-Lanterns. His seal is a bell without a clapper. The Ninth has the clapper.*
- K **General Watch** — All towers manned; levies seize carts “for the walls.” ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The levies are looking for one thing: children who flinch at candle-smoke. The children are stairs.*
- A **The Unfinished Stair Awakens** — A hidden flight appears in the middle of a crowded tier. The Ninth’s attention falls. ‘[THRESHOLD]’ ‘[BOSS]’ *The stairs have no end. The Witness is writing. The Ninth is counting. You are already on the third step.*

(Key/Rite/Paper) Stair token passes a barricaded stair without delay; harbor pass lowers the boom for your vessel on command.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Stair Token** — Pass a barricaded stair without delay (once); height as right. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The token is a bronze step. It fits into a missing rung. The missing rung is a secret.*
3. **Harbor Pass** — Boom lowers for your vessel on command; sea as ally. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The pass is a note written on a fish scale. The gate-keeper will not ask why. The fish was a witness.*
4. **Cistern Draw-Right** — A named ward during scarcity; water as favor. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The right is a clay cup. Break it to claim your share. The cup was a stair.*
5. **Crane Allotment** — One guaranteed lift on the Ropeyard Terrace; height as service. ‘[LABOR]’ *The allotment is a knotted rope. Cut a knot for each use. The ninth knot is a lie.*
6. **Icon License** — Display a disputed image without penalty; faith as leverage. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The license is stamped with the Archon’s ring. The ring is warm — the Archon is watching. The ring is a stair.*
7. **Archive Hour** — Library of Keys; one shelf opened to you; knowledge as power. ‘[SECRET]’ *The shelf is sealed with a riddle. Solve it, or the key will break. The riddle is about the ninth step.*
8. **Bellmark** — Lawful right to ring a tower bell (summons the watch); sound as law. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The bellmark is a brand on your palm. Show it, and the watch bleeds for you — once. The blood is a witness.*
9. **Watchlight Code** — Today’s beacon and mirror signals; navigation as paper. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The code is written in lemon juice. Heat it to read, then hide it again. The heat is a confession.*
10. **Synod Indulgence** — One proscribed chant or rite permitted (for you). ‘[MAGIC]’ *The indulgence is a bell-note held in a jar. Break the jar to release it. The bell-note is a name.*

- J Pronoia Grant** — Temporary farm/tax of a terrace hamlet; land as income. ‘[TRADE]’ *The grant is a wooden token. Present it to the village elder — if she is still alive. The elder is a stair.*
- Q Synod Audience** — Private with the Matriarch and clerks; wisdom as policy. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The audience is held in a fog hollow. What is spoken there is never written. The fog is a witness.*
- K Archon’s Writ** — Palikars escort you between towers; authority as escort. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The writ is a bell-rope. Tie it to your belt, and the guards will know your voice. The rope was a stair.*
- A Golden Key** — Open or seal any city gate once; access as power. ‘[MAGIC]’ *The key is a finger bone. The lock is a gauntleted fist. It will work — once. The fist is the Ninth’s.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (keys/rites/papers) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **height and sound** motifs — bells that carry, wind that remembers, stairs that echo with purpose.

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **Bell-Law:** Bells are law made sound. Once per session, a Bellmark or tower bell summons the watch, a levy, or a decree. False rings stain a reputation; the Synod may inquire. The ninth ring is never false — it is always the Ninth.
- **Stair-Rights:** Every stair is owned, owed, or leased. A token bypasses barricades and tolls; climbing the wrong stair without leave sparks a riot or a duel. The Unfinished Stair has no owner — only a debtor.
- **The Unfinished Stair Clock [6]:** Tracks the party’s entanglement with the hidden architecture of Thepyrgos. Tick it when you use a hidden stair, ask a question the Synod cannot answer, or speak a true name of an Astroegro ruin. At 6 segments, the party discovers a *new* hidden stair — one that leads to an Astroegro Vault — but they are also *marked*. The Witness’s attention falls on them. Their reflections in mirrors begin to lag by a heartbeat. The Chain-Lanterns receive a vision of their faces. Reduce the clock by feeding a memory to the Ninth’s Coterie (lose a fact, a skill point, or a Bond) or by recording a truth in the Synod’s archives (gain Obligation to the Witness).
- **The Offering at the Crossroads (Hedge Gift):** Once per session, a Hyro character (or someone who has learned their customs) may leave a *substitute* at a crossroads — a written name, a lock of hair, a childhood memory. For the next scene, they are *invisible to the Chain-Lanterns* (cannot be tracked or identified by candle-smoke). The substitute becomes a *Debt Token* that the GM may cash in later (the Hollow accepted it; the Hollow will ask for more).
- **The Candle-Smoke Test (GM Tool):** When the Chain-Lanterns test a village, the GM rolls 1d6. On a 1-2, they find a gifted child (the party must intervene or witness a tragedy). On a 3-4, they find a substitute (a false name, a hidden memory) and leave. On a 5-6, the

village has already paid in silence — no raid occurs. The party can influence the roll by offering their own substitute (use a Boon to shift the result by 1).

- **The Astroegro Singing (Player Tool):** A Hyro character can hum a fragment of an old empire song. The song has no words — only pressure. When hummed at a ruin, it may open a hidden door. When hummed at a Chain-Lantern, it may cause their lantern to flicker. Each use advances the *Unfinished Stair* clock by 1 (the past is waking).
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
 - **The Unwritten Citation** — The Witness. *A precedent that exists only in the margin.*
 - **The Bell-Founder** — Mykkiel. *The law that rings true, even when it hurts.*
 - **The Abyssal Pressure** — Khemesh. *The weight beneath the city; the debt that the deep remembers.*
 - **The Silent Stair** — The Ninth. *The step that is never counted, the threshold that opens only once.*

The Astroegro Vaults

Beneath the city, nine vaults. The Synod knows of three and has sealed them with Witness-branded wax. The Ninth’s Coterie has found a fourth. The other five are still buried, waiting for the right key — a true name, a specific death, a memory that has never been spoken.

Each vault contains:

- A weapon (a bell that rings the target’s true name, a lens that shows the death of anyone you name, a stone that erases a page from the world’s ledger).
- A guardian (a spirit of an Astroegro archivist, bound to defend the vault with its last calculation).
- A cost (to open the vault, you must sacrifice something the empire valued — a memory of salt water, a dream of drowning, a confession of hubris).

The Ninth’s Goal: Open all nine vaults simultaneously. The resulting “unlearning” would erase the concept of *debt* from the world. No one would owe anything to anyone. The Hollow would starve. The Witness would have nothing to record. The Ninth would become the only law: *forgetting*.

The Witness’s Goal: Keep the vaults sealed, but *remember* them perfectly. Every weapon, every secret, every crime of the Astroegro must be recorded in the Synod’s archives — not to use, but to witness. The Witness does not want to prevent the Ninth’s plan; it wants to be *the one who writes down what happened*.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Astroegro Remnant (Khemesh):** Deep beneath the Beacon Crown, a sealed chamber contains a working Astroegro orrery. Its gears are carved from abyssal glass, and it still ticks. Those who listen too long hear a voice whispering the true names of drowned emperors. The Chain-Lanterns have posted a perpetual guard; they say the orrery is a beacon for something that should not surface.
- **Saint Methodia of the Silent Stair (The Witness):** A legendary archivist who climbed the Ninth Stair of the Library of Keys and never came down. Her ghost is said to appear to those who speak a truth the Synod has buried, offering a single citation that can overturn any edict. The price is a secret of equal weight, and the ghost never forgets.

- **The Cog-Cults of the Clockwork Monad:** Underground fraternities of gear-smiths and logicians who believe the Astroegro Empire fell because its geometry was imperfect. They meet in the basements of the Ropeyard Terrace, trying to reconstruct the lost orrery. The Chain-Lanterns tolerate them because their calculations sometimes predict talent blooms. Heretics from the Everflame call them clock-worshippers; the Cog-Cults call themselves the True Iterators.
- **The Daughters of the Cord (The Bitter Root):** A hospice in the lower tiers is run by grey-robed women who ask no payment, but they take names. They are tolerated because they treat the poor for free, but the Commissariat suspects they also hide gifted children. A renegade Sister hides among the bell-runners, trying to unbind her Hollowed from the Chain-Lanterns' ledger.
- **The Savage Heart (Red Maw):** In the highland villages west of the city, a bear cult has arisen. They believe the only way to escape the Commissariat's hunts is to become the hunter. They wear cured skins and speak in growls, and they have begun hunting Chain-Lantern patrols. The Archon has declared them outlaws, but the villagers leave offerings of raw meat at their shrines.
- **The Ninth:** In any Thepyrgos scene, the ninth bell rung in an hour opens a threshold. The wise stop at eight and cover their ears. Those who ring the ninth are said to see a pale figure standing on the Beacon Crown's mirror tiles — waiting to collect a name.

Thepyrgos Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Stair:** Toss a crust onto a rung before climbing. Ignore the first *Tremor* penalty. '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Knot the Rope:** Tie a single knot in a crane line. Cancel *Rope Guild Interdict* or take -1 die on your next lift (your choice). '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Name to the Smoke:** Whisper a hunter's name into the Beacon Crown's fire. Gain +1 Effect when evading the Chain-Lanterns this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Synod. '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Offer the Substitute:** Leave a written false name at a crossroads. The next Candle-Smoke Test against you automatically fails — but the Hollow gains a Debt Token on you. '[SUPERSTITION]'

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **tower guards or guild masters**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **bell-runners or civic patrols**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or archive keepers**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favorable ascent**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Wall Strategos or guild head** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **quake damage or stair closure**.

- **Foe Appears:** A rival faction or civic enforcer arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **palikars, guild enforcers, or synod guards** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes — **bell rings falsely/stair collapses/law changes**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival: Archon, Matriarch, or Lighthouse-Patriarch** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically — **quake hits/bells ring/bridge collapses**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice — **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Thepyrgos (Height & Law):** Stairs shift position, bells ring with the wrong tone, legal papers rewrite themselves.
- **Thepyrgos (Synod Power):** Edicts change mid-speech, citations appear in the air, wisdom comes unbidden.
- **Thepyrgos (Vertical City):** Ropes fray without warning, cranes swing cargo unexpectedly, tower windows show wrong views.
- **Thepyrgos (The Unfinished Stair):** A hidden stair appears behind the party. The Ninth is counting. The Witness is writing. The stairs have no end.

The Magic Colleges (University Extensions)

- **College of Ladders & Lines** — geomancy, architecture, constraint; stairs as sigils, capstans as circles.
- **College of Bells & Beacons** — acoustics, omen-fire, signal calculus; law made audible, augury made measurable.
- **College of Waters & Weights** — alchemy, cistern rites, dyes; solutions, precipitates, and lawful flow.
- **College of Names & Oaths** — nomikon theurgy; citations that bind, clauses that compel.
- **College of Mirrors & Haze** — illusion, scrutiny; seeing, being seen, un-being seen.
- **College of Quiet** — ethics of death, memory rites; permitted remembrances — anything more is heresy.

The Witch-Hunter Province (Commissariat Extensions)

Thepyrgos-the-Province funds Witch-Hunter Commissariats — ministries with bounties posted per ward. Notices hang on stair-landings; bells announce *hunts lawful and hunts less so*. The Chain-Lantern order is the most feared, but others compete for quotas.

Hunter Hearts (faces of the persecution)

- **Commissary-Exarch** — Writs in triplicate; quotas in private.
- **Bounty-Reader** — Weighs children like coin; “verification” by bell.
- **Pardoner-Chaplain** — Sells absolution to informers; keeps a careful ledger.
- **Stair-Runner Informant** — Knows which doors open to the right knock.
- **Chain-Lantern Captain** — Commands the most feared order; his lantern reveals truth through flesh.

Hunter Clubs (pressures and sweeps)

- **Bounty Posting** — New price on “untutored talent”; crowds turn into nets.
- **Candle-Smoke Test** — Lines at the Blue Cistern; smoke curls toward the Gifted.
- **Commissary Sweep** — Ladders chained; a whole tier searched under horn.
- **Quieted Child** — An “accident” near the Exam Stair; evidence goes missing.
- **Chain-Lantern Raid** — Dawn assault on a hamlet; children taken before the rooster crows.

Hunter Diamonds (leverage and reprieve)

- **Witness Pardon** — Informer absolved and paid; cancels one legal fallout *once*.
- **Archon’s Clemency** — Suspends a bounty clock for one named; bell-marked and public.
- **Hidden Stair Token** — Through a maintenance run unseen; good for one group escape.

Detection & Denial (Fast Procedures)

Scry & Deny (evading the tests)

1. **Mask the Trace:** dye, salt, bell-oil; pick *one* (each grants +1 die to one approach).
2. **Pick the Test:** *Smoke, Sound, Mirror*. State how you spoof it (alchemical veil, bell overtones, angle games).
3. **On a hit:** cancel a **Candle-Smoke Test** or **Proctors’ Gate** tag for this scene. **Consequence:** start *Bell Debt* [2] or *Rector’s Notice* [2].

Bounty Economy (quick table, GM picks or 1d6)

1. *Whisperer* (faint talent): 1 purse; informers abundant.
2. *Spark-Hand* (cantrip): 2 purses; “rehabilitation” promised.
3. *Mirror-Bent* (glamour): 3 purses; seized at once.
4. *Bell-Singer* (acoustic): 4 purses; Synod claims jurisdiction.
5. *Oath-Breaker* (binding): 5 purses; Exarch insists on custody.
6. *Quiet-Worker* (death-ethic): 6 purses; College of Quiet petitions for trial.

Scenario Starters (Plug-and-Play)

The Bright Child on the Exam Stair *Hook:* A Bell-Runner begs you to get a latent child to campus before the dawn sweep. *Complications:* **Candle-Smoke Test**, **Commissary Sweep**, a jealous **Street Thaum**. *Relief:* Trade a *Latency Seal* for testimony; or ring a lawful *Bellmark* to create a corridor — accept *Censure Murmurs* [2].

The Black Ledger of Bounties *Hook:* The College of Quiet wants proof that a Commissary inflates prices to fill quotas. *Complications:* **Synod Summons**, **Smuggler’s Ladder**, **Chain Jam**. *Relief:* Publish via a *Nomikon* colloquy (gain *Synod Indulgence*); or sell it to the Archon (gain *Archon’s Clemency* but start *Faculty Feud* [4]).

The Golden Key and the Silent Stair *Hook:* A dying Archivist gives you a Golden Key. “It opens the stair the hunters fear.” *Truth:* The stair leads to the Beacon Crown’s secret basement — a prison for children who passed the smoke test. *Relief:* Free the children and expose the Commissariat (gain *Archon’s Clemency* for the whole party, but start *Exarch’s Claim* at full); or seal the stair forever (gain *Golden Key* to use elsewhere, but the children are lost to memory).

The Ninth Vault *Hook:* A fragment of an Astroegro weapon has been unearthed in a hill village. The Ninth’s Coterie and the Synod both want it. The village elder offers it to the party — if they can offer a substitute that satisfies the Hollow. *Truth:* The weapon is a bell that rings the true name of anyone you name. Its guardian is the ghost of the Astroegro archivist who sealed it. The ghost will not speak to anyone who has not climbed the Unfinished Stair. *Relief:* Climb the stair, speak the archivist’s true name, and take the bell — but the stair adds a segment to the Unfinished Stair Clock. Or destroy the bell with a memory of the Astroegro’s fall (lose a cherished memory permanently). Or give the bell to the Synod (gain a Synod Indulgence) or to the Ninth’s Coterie (gain a Debt Token from the Ninth).

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Wits + Stealth):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Fog Bank*.
- **Cut the Stair (Presence + Lore):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a stair token is in your possession, +1 die.
- **Weather the Quake (Body + Athletics):** On a hit in *Tremor*, you pick who keeps their footing; on a miss, the GM does.

Boss Seeds (Bell & Inquisition)

- **The Bell-Exarch (Nine Bans)** — *Phases:* Candle-Smoke Sweep → Orchestrated Silence → Synod Coup. *Cracks:* ring a forgotten bell, expose a false bounty, survive a night in the Beacon Crown.
- **The Astroegro Engine (Pressure from Below)** — *Phases:* Gears Turn → Whispers Become Names → Seiche. *Cracks:* abyssal glass shard, survivor testimony, the Lighthouse-Patriarch’s mirror turning clear.
- **The Ninth’s Advocate (Living Stair)** — *Phases:* Count → Omit → Forget. *Cracks:* speak a true name that the Ninth does not know, offer a memory the Witness has not recorded, climb the Unfinished Stair and refuse to answer the Ninth’s question.

Patronage & Power

In Thepyrgos, power flows through elevation, education, and the precise application of law — but also through the hidden architecture of the Unfinished Stair. The Archon maintains authority through a complex web of guilds, synods, and civic institutions, but the real power lies with whoever can climb the stairs that should not exist. Social mobility is literally upward mobility, with stair-rights, bellmarks, and archive access serving as both currency and status symbols. But the highest status belongs to those who have seen the top of the Unfinished Stair — and remembered how to return.

For the GM: Patronage in Thepyrgos revolves around access — to towers, to knowledge, to the right to climb, and to the hidden stairs. Rewards often take the form of keys, passes, or legal exemptions that can be leveraged into greater influence. To emphasize the metaphysical war:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (tokens, keys, papers) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided.
- Let rival guilds and the two Patrons (Witness and Ninth) issue conflicting rights, forcing players to choose whose favor matters more.
- Use the synods, towers, and staircases as arenas for social contests, where knowledge of law and custom determines success — but where the Ninth's silence and the Witness's memory can tip the scales.
- Introduce the Unfinished Stair clock as a campaign tension; every time the party uses a hidden stair, they advance the clock and bring the Ninth's attention closer.

In Thepyrgos, your ascent is your standing, and your standing determines whether you rise or fall — or whether you are simply **forgotten**.

Part II

The Northern Reaches

Chapter 7

Aeler

Crowns & Under-Vaults.

The mountain remembers every word carved in its stone, every seal pressed into its walls. To govern here is not to command, but to harmonize with the ancient songs that still echo in the deep places.

I am an Under-Mason. I can hear stone shift a room away. When the rock starts singing a different tune, you best listen. Three knocks in the morning means all's well, but three knocks at night means something's coming through the walls that wasn't meant to walk.

My homeland. The place where we don't trust the surface, but we do trust the weight of a well-placed keystone—and oh, how the surface loves to test that trust. Our breath-bonds aren't just currency—they're the hardest thing in the peaks, forged in the sighs of miners who knew too much. We sell them to Vilikari jarls who pay in furs stained with brother's blood, to Ykrul khagans who weigh the value in warhorses and broken oaths. Once, we sold one to the Veiled Sisters. They paid in secrets—which is another way of saying they paid in future leverage.

Never count your breaths aloud in a mine. The mountain listens, and if it hears you reach the ninth, it will take one—a breath, a memory, a shadow. My grandfather reached nine once. He lived another thirty years, but he never cast a shadow again.

— *Thromm Stone-Tongue, Under-Mason, who has never counted to nine*

The Almanac of Ordinary Days

What do people eat for breakfast? Stone-bread and cave cheese—the bread is baked on heated stone slabs, the cheese is aged in sealed galleries where the temperature never varies. The cheese has been aging for three generations. It is an heirloom. It is also barely edible.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To count their breaths. Aeler children wear breath-counters—small brass bells on leather cords. Eight breaths, ring the bell. Nine breaths, run. A child who cannot count is a child who will not survive the winter.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their bell. Every Aeler carries a bell tuned to their breath. A stranger's bell will ring at a different pitch—the mountain's lungs are calibrated to local frequencies. A mismatched bell is a warning. A silent bell is a threat.

What is the most common crime? Air theft. In the deep vaults, ventilation is shared. A sealed door, a blocked vent, a diverted shaft—these are thefts of breath, punishable by breath-debt. The guilty party must donate their own air ration to the victim. The donation is measured in days. The days are counted by bells.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The True Masons are not neutral. They are the Vault-Queen's eyes. Every "independent" repair, every "neutral" inspection, every "routine" audit—the True Masons are watching. They do not report to the Queen. They are the Queen. They have always been the Queen.

Where do people go when they die? To the Deep Vaults—the oldest galleries, where the air is thin and the stone is cold. The dead are not buried. They are sealed in niches carved into the walls, their names chiselled above their heads. The niches are reused every century. The names are never erased. The dead share walls with strangers. The strangers are patient.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You offer a keystone—a load-bearing stone from your own holding. The stone is installed in the wronged party's wall. If it holds, you are forgiven. If it cracks, the debt stands. If it crumbles, your holding collapses. Apology is architecture. Architecture is law.

What is the most important festival? The Ringing of the Underways (deep winter). Every bell in every hold is rung at the same hour—eight times, no more. The sound travels through the stone, a heartbeat that reminds the mountain that the living are still here. The dead listen. The dead do not ring back.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Vault-Queen is a construct. She was assembled in 723 AR, after the real queen died in a cave-in. Her heart is a keystone. Her breath is a bellows. Her voice is a recording. The True Masons maintain her. They have the schematics. The schematics are missing three pages. The missing pages describe how to turn her off.

7.1 Aeler (Dwarves) — “Crowns & Under-Vaults”

Elite (Vault-Queen of a crownland)

“The mountain remembers every word carved in its stone, every seal pressed into its walls. To govern here is not to command, but to harmonize with the ancient songs that still echo in the deep places.”

Commoner (Under-Mason who can hear stone shift a room away)

“When the stone starts singing a different tune, you best listen. Three knocks in the morning means all’s well, but three knocks at night means something’s coming through the walls that wasn’t meant to walk.”

Crowns & Under-Vaults

The Aeler Kingdoms hold the mountains by breath, bell, and bargain. Dozens of sovereign holds – some sealed for centuries, others trading openly with lowland markets – share only the deep roots of stone and the supremacy of the High King Beneath the Peaks. Their halls run like arteries, their cities open in thunderous caverns where bridges leap between ribs of stone and cisterns shine like night skies turned inward. *Survival* is the first law: air is counted, water is bartered, light is rationed by wick and prayer. *Tradition* is the second: seals are kept, measures remain true, and the dead keep their offices as carefully as the living. Between the two, a people learn to argue quietly and build loudly.

Collectives (clans, guild-kin, lamp-companies) own what the mountain allows; individuals are custodians by oath. Trade runs under and over the range through under-ways and pass-forts, stitching protectorates and lowland markets to vaultmouth gates. When tunnels whisper or the air tastes wrong, the Aeler move as one animal; when the Kingsmoot calls, crowns and abbesses argue in bell-code and sealed writs until the stone itself seems to lean in.

The Fractured Crowns: Aeler Faction Spectrum

Aeler society is not monolithic. Beneath the High King’s nominal authority, each crownland follows its own star. Attitudes toward the surface range from open partnership to militant isolation, and even the most reclusive holds maintain **Edgewalker** contacts to monitor the world above.

- **Traditionalist** / “**The Old Ways**” – These holds idealize the ancient mountain-empire: closed gates, iron tariffs, and the certain knowledge that surface-dwellers cannot be trusted. They resemble the dwarves of fireside tales: stubborn, insular, and quick to reach for an axe when a human mentions “progress.” Their kings speak of the days when no foreigner stepped past the vaultmouth. *Clocks: FOREIGNER SUSPICION [4], HOLD SEALED [6]*.
- **Cooperative** / “**Open Hand**” – These holds trade freely with Aelaerem, Kahfagia, and even the Vilikari. They staff the under-markets, send engineers to repair bridges in Viterra, and treat the surface as a resource to be managed, not a threat to be shunned. They prefer soft power: standardised measures, certified weights, and bell-code protocols that make others *want* to trade on Aeler terms. *Clocks: TRADE ROUTE PROSPERITY [6], CULTURAL FRICTION [4]*.
- **Isolationist** / “**Silent Stone**” – Deep holds that have not answered a Kingsmoot call in living memory. Their gates are lost, their peoples rumoured to have turned inward, worshiping forgotten depths. They neither help nor harm the surface – but when a White Flood or a gas flare occurs, their silence becomes a hazard of its own. *Clocks: SILENT HOLD AWAKENS [8], ANCIENT GRUDGE [6]*.

Most Aeler characters and settlements fall somewhere between these poles, and the same hold might shift its stance over a season, depending on grain prices, a new Vault-Queen, or a disaster that forces its hand.

Prominent NPCs of Aeler

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Valthor Aezelbron	High King Beneath the Peaks	Preserve the ancient concord and balance the crownlands	He has not spoken above a whisper in seven years. The court reads his will by bell-code.
Grunhelda Thrainsdottir	Vault-Queen of Irondeep	Expand trade routes while keeping the Old Ways satisfied	She keeps a pet geode that hums when a contract is fair.
Maeva Kaelen	Legate of the Under-Seal	Negotiate passage rights and standard measures with low-land realms	Her seal-rod is carved from a fossilised root. She has never lost a tariff dispute.
Thromm Stone-Tongue	Under-Mason (Commoner exemplar)	Hear the mountain's warnings and keep the tunnels safe	He can identify a false weight by tapping it once with his hammer.
Orthen White-Ribbon	Tunnel Courier	Deliver sealed writs across hostile jurisdictions	He has run the Spine Underway in darkness without a lamp. Twice.
Lumenor Saela	Keeper of the Under-Altars	Maintain the breath-rites and the old flame	She speaks only in bell tones during services. Her mundane voice is never heard.

Names of Aeler

Aeler names blend flowing vowels and soft diphthongs (ae, ei, ou, ui) with harsh consonants (k, th, z, r, g). Surnames are carved from mountain-roots: a hold, a forge, a seam, or a trade.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Thrain	Grunhelda	Aezenbron	<i>the Iron</i>
Kaelen	Maeva	Thrainkhar	<i>Breath-Steady</i>
Orthen	Saela	Valdurg	<i>Seal-Keeper</i>
Rurik	Aeldis	Kaelthane	<i>Bell-Tongue</i>
Bromm	Helka	Zarkul	<i>the Under-Mason</i>
Zelgur	Thorunn	Dornvail	<i>White-Ribbon</i>

Spades — Places (vaultmouths, descents, underways, crown seats)

2. (Security/Gatekeeping) Vaultmouth Gate in a hillslope: bronze lungs for breath-tests, tally-niches for lamps.
 3. (Tradition/Oaths) Crown-Crypt Porch where oaths are sworn to sleeping kings.
 4. (Commerce/Underground) Under-Market: lantern alleys between cistern pillars; damp coin, dry wit.
 5. (Labor/Danger) Smoke-Shaft Stair spiraling up to a soot hatch; handprints black as seals.
 6. (Mystery/Whispers) Gloam Cistern—black water, lead scales, whispers carry too far.
 7. (Maintenance/Travel) Lamplighter’s Mile on the Under-Road; niches sting with spent wicks.
 8. (Precision/Authority) Measure Vault: standard rods and weights chained under glass and oath.
 9. (Sacred/Knowledge) Reliquary Arcade: bell-chimes answer drafts; saints keep their own tallies.
 10. (Military/Strategic) Twin-Throne Gate—surface fortress straddling a chasm bridge.
- J (Knowledge/Secrecy) Deep Archive Stacks behind grillwork; scriptoria cells breathe ink and dust.
- Q (Royalty/Privilege) Queen’s Descent: private stair from palace to royal vault-house.
- K (Politics/Power) Kingsmoot Cavern—crownstones in a ring around a bottomless dark.
- A (Infrastructure/Majesty) The Spine Underway, a great tunnel linking crownlands beneath the peaks.

Hearts — People & Factions (crowns, keepers, guilds, legates)

2. (Apprenticeship/Dedication) Lamplighter apprentice with a jingling key-ring and soot in the lungs.
3. (Craft/Knowledge) Under-Mason who can hear stone shift a room away.
4. (Authority/Duty) Vault Warden with breath-ledger and seal-rods; patient as granite.
5. (Protection/Faith) Censer-Knight of the Dawn – fights miasma and men with equal zeal.
6. (Sacred/Craft) Key-Sister (monastic locksmith) who names wards like prayers.
7. (Commerce/Authority) Under-Market assessor whose stamp can starve or save a stall.

8. (Engineering/Expertise) Engineer of Underways (geometer) with rod, hammer, and the right maps.
9. (Tradition/Law) Oath-Keeper of the Crown Crypt – memory like iron, smile like law.
10. (Diplomacy/Authority) Legate of the Under-Seal, royal commissioner between kingdoms.
 J (Communication/Loyalty) White-Ribbon tunnel courier; runs blind, rings true.
 Q (Royalty/Authority) Vault-Queen of a crownland, sovereign above and below.
 K (Supreme Authority/Tradition) High King Beneath the Peaks, first among crowns by ancient concord.
 A (Spiritual Power/Resolution) Lumenor of the Under-Altars, one sentence opens doors and closes debates.

Clubs — Complications/Threats (air, water, stone, rite, jurisdiction)

2. (Danger/Disorientation) Bad air pocket—candles gutter blue; lungs complain, schedules fail.
3. (Disruption/Flood) Drip-flood from a burst cistern reroutes corridors without asking.
4. (Accident/Destruction) Gas flare kisses a lamp; eyebrows and evidence vanish.
5. (Error/Security) Seal misread—the wrong door opens, the right one will not.
6. (Quarantine/Delay) Under-mold quarantine shuts the market just as your crate arrives.
7. (Danger/Warning) Settling crack—dust snow warns the roof wants down.
8. (Accusation/Suspicion) Stolen key turns up in your kit; accusations ring like bells.
9. (Conflict/Jurisdiction) Bell-code conflict—two authorities claim the same chime.
10. (Political Conflict/Violence) Vault-right feud: crown guards face basilica wardens on a stair.
 J (Disaster/Trapped) Cave-in behind—proof, friends, and retreat on the far side.
 Q (Religious Conflict/Inquisition) Heresy inquest in the under-chapel; arrests in whispers.
 K (Authority/Restriction) General Under-Seal—all vault traffic halted by royal decree.
 A (Natural Disaster/Destruction) White Flood—mountain thaw becomes a river through your route.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage (keys, passes, breath, priority, precedent)

2. (Utility/Time) Lamp-priority tally—skip one lamplighter queue.
3. (Safety/Access) Breath-measure allotment—lawful time in a sealed chamber (once).
4. (Security/Authority) Key-Writ—operate a named lock one time, witnessed.
5. (Travel/Security) Underway Pass—escorted travel between two vaultmouths.
6. (Commerce/Rights) Stall-Right in the under-market for a season.
7. (Engineering/Safety) Engineer Shoring—a crew stabilizes your chosen corridor on your timetable.
8. (Commerce/Trust) Assay Mark—your coin/metal accepted sight unseen below.
9. (Protection/Law) Crypt Asylum—temporary sanctuary under crown law.
10. (Authority/Access) Vault Inventory License—remove a named cache under witness.
 J (Military/Authority) Under-Guard Commission—command a vault detachment for a day.
 Q (Royalty/Privilege) Private Descent with the Vault-Queen or High King’s chancellor.

K (Supreme Authority/Access) High King’s Sealed Writ—doors open, mouths close across crownlands.

A (Exception/Power) The Under-Seal Clause—temporary exception to any lock, levy, or rite below.

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: **Spade** = place, **Heart** = actor, **Club** = pressure, **Diamond** = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5→4, 6–10→6, J/Q/K→8, A→10).
- Treat **Diamonds** as codified outcomes (keys/passes/rights) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any **A** appears, echo stone & breath motifs—keys click, bells answer, and the mountain listens (and remembers).

Additional Features

- **Count the Air:** When a scene establishes scarce air, a character who actively paces their breathing (counted steps, measured rests) may shift *Position* one step safer on their next physical action in a confined space.
- **Bell-Code Courtesy:** If the party adopts local bell etiquette (asking a warden which chime applies and heeding it), gain +1 assist die on negotiations or passage requests within a vault or under-market.
- **Measure is Mercy:** Presenting a certified measure (rod, weight, sealed tally) calms a dispute: cancel the first SB generated by commerce or jurisdictional friction in the scene.

Stone & Sovereignty

In the deep places, survival depends on precision and tradition. The Aeler understand that stone does not forgive error – a misread seal can mean death, a miscalculated air measure can doom an expedition, and a broken bell-code can spark jurisdictional war. Their society is built on layers of authority, each with its own rites, rights, and responsibilities. To navigate their realm is to learn a complex dance of deference and demand, where even the humblest lamplighter holds power over the darkness, and the smallest key can unlock the greatest vault.

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **vault wardens or lamplighter companies**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **under-guards or echo bats**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or assessors**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favorable air**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised: Breath warden or vault warden** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **air shift or seal change**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **rival crown's guard or gas wraith** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **crown guards, true masons, or lamp companies** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **seal misread/cave-in/flare ignites**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival: Vault-Queen, High King's Legate, or Lumenor** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **gas floods/water breaks/floor collapses**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Aeler (Stone & Breath):** Keys click in the wrong locks, bells answer without being rung, mountain air grows thin without warning.
- **Aeler (Authority & Tradition):** A seal is misread, bell-codes conflict between jurisdictions, a vault warden demands proper credentials.
- **Aeler (Underground Hazards):** Bad air pockets form, settling cracks warn of collapse, gas flares ignite unexpectedly.

Aeler — Under-Vault Tensions

Starting Location: An Underway junction lit by guttering brass lanterns, its stone walls scored with tally-marks from a dozen forgotten crowns.

“Among the Aeler, stone remembers the weight of oaths, and every echo calls a reckoning.”

In... An Underway junction, a Geometer halts the party with a tally-rod. “The Spine shifts,” he says, stone-dust in his beard. “Choose a crown—or be buried by one.”

Regional Motifs Load-bearing oaths, fault-prayers, crown-rights, catacomb guilds.

Whispers to Offer “Cut a supporting tie,” “Sign for another’s debt,” “Take a shortcut through the sealed tunnel.”

External Clocks Threat: “The Spine Slips”; Fracture: “Maps Reorder”; Community: “Surface Panic.”

Complications Load-lights dim; echoes reply in politics; crown agents arrive early.

Anchors at Risk A PC’s workshop; a shared refuge tunnel.

Escalation Beat The tally-rod points to the most guilty PC.

Relief Shore a vault with sacrifice (1 anchor), or complete a truce between crowns; Spirit + Resolve (5) to hold a cave-in long enough to evacuate.

Faction Entanglements

- **Edgewalkers (Prospectors):** If you accept their escort or intel, start a 4-segment *Opportunity* clock you can cash for +1 Effect on one venture. If you refuse a posted hazard, they post *your* route as “open” (first stealth or smuggling roll this leg suffers –1 die).
- **True Masons (Infrastructure Orders):** Pledge tools or labor to earn a *Mason’s Stamp* (treat as papers to traverse construction zones). Cross a marked barrier without their leave and gain the *Tampered Work* tag—first structural mishap SB against you is free.
- **Lamplighter Companies:** Donate wick, oil, or time on the Mile to bank a *Lamp Credit*; spend to ignore darkness penalties once on the Under-Road. Skip a service bell and all under-market buys that scene cost +1 clock tick (queues & suspicion).
- **Under-Market Assessors:** Submit to measure/weigh and reduce Commerce DV by 1 this scene. Try to pass unassayed goods—on a Miss, lose the load *or* accept a *Caveat Stamp* that poisons your price two markets downstream.
- **Breath Wardens:** Register bodies & flames before sealed work; compliance cancels the first air-hazard SB. Skipping registry adds a *Thin Air* tick to the leg (applies –1 die to the first exertion test in confinement).

Cross-Regional Ties & Soft Power

- **Agrarian Reliance (Human Breadbelts):** Grain, timber, tallow, and fleece convoys from Acasia/Vhasia/Viterra sustain vault populations. Famine or levy spikes uprange impose night rationing: Under-Road checks +1 DV and food trades add +1 SB pressure until relief.
- **Standards Diplomacy:** Aeler *Measure Vault* rods adopted abroad grant +1 die to settle disputes in foreign markets; rejecting Aeler standards increases toll and inspection frequency (first border scene gains a free “Lock/Barrier” SB).
- **True Mason Missions Abroad:** Accept a Mason cadre to “stabilize” bridges, ports, or sluices: reduce Travel DV by 1 on that route for the arc, but the route now respects Aeler closure bells (authorities can halt traffic with one writ).
- **Edgewalker Concessions:** Prospect notes traded to frontier lords exchange for wayleaves and salvage rights; cash once for an *Under-Seal Clause (local)* or accept a rival claimant clock that will mature if you delay.
- **Kahfagian Interface (Sea Monopoly):** Aeler export hard-goods via Kahfagian factors; storm seasons or privateer scares add a *Harbor Quarantine* tick to any surface leg feeding those ports (customs DV +1).

- **Aelerem/Aelinnel Fallout:** When *Valewood Weather* is signaled, Aeler works creak; all bell-codes in mixed settlements (Aelerem/Aelinnel) are one step easier to misread (first bell-etiquette scene: add a free “Error/Security” SB unless you consult a local).

Trade Goods & Consequences

- **Airworks & Wick (Oil, Char, Filters):** Donate to a vault—bank a *Breath Favor* to cancel the next bad-air complication. Hoard in a shortage and your lot is flagged; all purchases beneath that crown suffer –1 die until you settle a fine or tithe.
- **Stonework & Ironwork (Beams, Keys, Rods):** Selling to foreign keeps spreads Aeler codes: once per arc, treat a foreign gate as if it used Aeler warding (gain +1 die with Key-Sisters/warders there). Counterfeit measure rods trigger a cross-border inquest clock.
- **Foodflows (Grain, Fleece, Tallow):** Move relief trains to clear one *Rationing* tag for a settlement (DV –1 for social checks there). Divert a relief train and gain an *Audit* clock that follows you three markets hence.
- **Cistern-Right & Water Engineering:** Fund a sluice or cistern abroad to gain *Water Priority* (skip one queue during drought). Neglect maintenance and the keeper may invoke *Aeler Liability*—pay or lose access to the route for a season.

Patron Networks (Below and Beyond)

- **The Sealed Gate:** Consecrated door-nails from True Mason kits act as single-use *stay* writs (negate one forced entry this scene).
- **The Traveler:** Spine milestones double as wayshrines; leave a brass chit to reroll one failed travel test on that segment this arc.
- **Inquisitor Prime:** Breath-pure censers sanction “clean rooms”; once per delve, dispel one ambient miasma or ward-rot effect at cost of +1 Obligation to local abbey-knights.
- **Maelstraeus:** Under-Market stalls tithe to the Great Ledger; cash a *Market Dominance* tick to flip one price band in your favor for a scene, then mark a 4-segment *Karmic Debt* with assessors.

Survival-Horror Procedures (Use Often)

- **Headcount & Flamecount:** At scene start in confinement, ask “Who breathes, what burns?” If headcount+flamecount exceeds posted limit, add a free “Thin Air” SB and start a 4-segment *Stale Air* clock.
- **Two Bells to Safety:** Any time the fiction stalls underground, ring two nearby bells (authority vs. sanctum). PCs must pick one to heed; ignoring both increases the next hazard’s Cap by +1 (stone holds grudges).
- **Measure or Mistrust:** Producing a certified rod/weight cancels the first commerce/jurisdiction SB this scene; failing to present one imposes –1 die on haggling or passage until appeased.

Diplomatic Favor & Reputation Echoes

- **Breath Favor (minor resource):** Earned by donating wick/oil or assisting air wardens. Spend to downgrade one underground hazard outcome or to bypass a lamplighter queue.
- **Stamps & Seals:**

- *Mason-Marked*: Doors to worksites open; smugglers avoid you (harder to buy contraband, easier to cross safely).
- *Edge-Trusted*: Prospectors share fresh maps—first detour per leg is free; officials eye you as opportunists (first civic audience DV +1).
- *Assessor-Clean*: Under-markets honor your assay; rivals spread rumors—add a trailing *Audit* clock if you score a windfall.

Boss Archetypes in Aeler

Systemic / Economic / Conspiracy

- **Under-Market Syndic (Cartel/Measure Fraud)**: Price-fixes breath, wick, and water; wields corrupt assay marks to starve rivals. *Win by exposing forged measures or seizing the Assay Chain.*
- **True Mason Provost (Infrastructure Coup)**: Locks cities behind “safety closures,” weaponizes detours and permits. *Win by forcing a public bell-code audit or breaking the Permit Clock.*
- **Edgewalker Concessionaire (Route Monopolist)**: Controls salvage and short-cuts, posts hazards to strangle traffic. *Win by proving route tampering or opening a sanctioned bypass.*
- **Bell-Code Inquisitor (Silent Coup)**: Rewrites chimes to shift jurisdiction; arrests arrive as echoes. *Win by restoring canonical bell charts or capturing the Chime Key.*

Survival Horror (Environment as Boss)

- **White Flood (Water/Pressure)**: Thaw-swollen river through the halls; phases at *trickle* → *surge* → *roar*. *Win by sluicework, sacrificial breach, or riding the flood.*
- **Bad Air (Miasma/Invisible)**: Candles gutter blue; thoughts slow; corridors choose the slowest. *Win by air discipline, filter rites, or opening a lung-shaft.*
- **Hungry Stone (Creep/Collapse)**: Settling cracks hunt noise and heat; shudders on every miss. *Win by shoring, silence, and rerouting stress through old ribs.*
- **Lamp Famine (Darkness/Isolation)**: Wicks fail in sequence; last lights lure you deeper. *Win by restoring the Lamplighter’s Mile or kindling a saint-wick.*

Undead / Fallen Kingdom / Eldritch / Demonic

- **Crown-Lich of the Crypt (Undead Sovereign)**: Keeps ancient offices; binds petitioners with oaths to the dead. *Win by repealing a mortmain writ or severing the Oath-Chain.*
- **Echo-King in the Deep (Eldritch Memory)**: A throne of voices; answers every argument you will ever make. *Win by changing the Measure (new precedent) or striking the Silent Note.*
- **Seal-Devil (Demonic Contract)**: Lives in locks and signatures; eats exceptions. *Win by offering a flawless counter-seal or starving it of loopholes.*
- **The Hollow Architect (Fallen Works)**: A ghost-guilder rebuilding the empire wrong on purpose. *Win by unkeying the master plan or collapsing the false load paths.*

Boss Mechanics Notes

- **Air & Light Tracks**: In confined scenes, track *Headcount*, *Flamecount*. If *Headcount* + *Flamecount* exceeds posted limit, add a free “Thin Air” SB and start **Stale Air** [4]. Each tick imposes –1 die to exertion until vented.

- **Jurisdiction Clocks:** Many bosses run a **Bell-Code Conflict** [4] or **Seal Dispute** [6]. On fill, the boss gains *Authority Surge*: increase their social DV by +1 and seize initiative once.
- **Lair Actions (choose 2–3):**
 - *Collapse Probe*: Mark “Settling Crack”; nearest noisy PC tests PROWESS or risk *Pin/Separate*.
 - *Breath Tax*: Reduce *Flamecount* by 1; next exertion in zone costs Fatigue 1 on a miss.
 - *Blackout/Glare*: Snuff or flare lamps; impose Disorient (—1 die) until a *Lamplighter Action* restores balance.
 - *Bell Override*: Swap which faction’s law applies; social actions vs. boss gain +1 DV this round.
 - *White Flood Surge*: Advance environment clock; force MOVE/WRECK or be *Separated*.
- **Phase Triggers:** Environment bosses phase when *Air* hits 2/4, *Water* hits 3/6, or *Light* hits 0; Conspiracy bosses phase when *Audit* or *Permit* clocks fill.
- **Truth & Measure:** Producing a certified rod/weight cancels the first commerce/jurisdiction SB each phase; forging one gives the boss 1 SB and a free *Expose Fraud* reaction.
- **Crowd Pressure:** In under-markets, add **Panic Crowd** [4]; each tick adds +1 DV to precise actions (shoot, pick, ritual) unless calmed with bell-code or coin.
- **Fear Hooks (optional):** *Bad Air* inflicts FEAR vs. suffocation; *Echo-King* inflicts FEAR vs. isolation; *Seal-Devil* inflicts FEAR vs. helplessness. On Fail: mark *Shaken*; on Critical Fail: drop a resource (*lamp, key, breath*).

Chapter 8

The Mistlands

Bells, Salt, and Breath.

The bells here do more than mark time—they weave the very fabric of reality, keeping the mist at bay and the dead in their proper places. Each chime is a thread in the pattern that holds the world together.

I am a Bell-Warden. I refuse to write down the ninth note. It lives only in my memory—and that memory is fading.

The Mistlands are a protectorate of the Aeler in name only. The fog here doesn't just hide the land; it hides the law, and oh, how the wraiths love that ambiguity. The bell-lines aren't just defences—they're the only thing keeping the wraiths from dragging whole villages into the mist. The Aeler built them. The Aeler charge for them. The Aeler will leave when the money runs out. And when that happens, the fog will remember every single soul they abandoned.

Never answer a voice that calls your name from the fog. The mist collects names, and once it has yours, the ferryman will always know where to find you. I've seen men answer. I've watched them walk into the white, still talking, still smiling, until their voices came back from a direction they hadn't gone.

— *Warden Kael, who has seen the ninth bell rung once and will not speak of it*

The Almanac of Ordinary Days

What do people eat for breakfast? Salt fish and sour bread—the fish is smoked over peat fires, the bread is leavened with fog-damp yeast. The yeast is caught in cloth traps hung from the bell-towers. The traps are emptied at dawn. The yeast is not alive. It is not dead either.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To ring a bell. Every Mistlands child is given a small bronze bell at birth. By age three, they can ring the eight notes of the ward-chime in their sleep. The ninth note is never taught. The ninth note is discovered. Discovery is fatal.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their salt-pouch. Every Mistlander carries a leather pouch of consecrated salt. A stranger without a pouch is either a fool or a wraith. A stranger whose pouch is empty is a fool who is about to become a wraith.

What is the most common crime? Ward-salt theft. The Aeler control the salt pans, and the salt is the only thing that keeps the dead from rising. A stolen pouch can buy a week's protection. The price is a year's debt to the Aeler. The debt is collected in labour. The labour is collecting salt. The salt is stolen. The cycle is perpetual.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Bell-Wardens are not chosen—they are volunteered. A village that loses a warden must send a replacement to the Aeler training holds. The holds are in the mountains. The mountains are cold. The trainees do not always return. The ones who do return do not speak of what they learned. Their bells ring at a different pitch.

Where do people go when they die? To the fog. Bodies are not buried in the Mistlands—the ground rejects them. Corpses are carried to the edge of the bell-line and left for the mist. The mist takes them. Sometimes, at dusk, you can see them walking the lanes. They do not speak. They do not need to. Their presence is a question.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You ring the Bell of Atonement—a cracked bronze bell that hangs in every village square. The bell rings once for each wrong confessed. If the bell rings true, you are forgiven. If it cracks further, you are not. If it shatters, you are banished to the fog. The banished never return. Their voices still answer from the white.

What is the most important festival? The Rehanging of the Lines (autumn). Every bell-line is taken down, cleaned, and rehung. The work takes three days. The villages are silent for three nights. The dead listen. The dead wait. The dead do not ring.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Legate of the Mists is a wraith. She died in 803 AR, during a bell-line failure. The Aeler rebuilt her from fog and memory. She does not know she is dead. She attends council meetings. She signs documents. Her signature fades after sunset. The documents are refiled every morning.

8.1 Mistlands — “Bells, Salt, and Breath”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *The mist counts your breaths. The bells remember your name.*

Legate of Mists (Elite): “The bells here do more than mark time — they weave the very fabric of reality, keeping the mist at bay and the dead in their proper places. Each chime is a thread in the pattern that holds the world together.”

Salt-Monk (Commoner): “Salt don’t just preserve the fish — it holds back the things that shouldn’t walk. Every grain blessed is a prayer, and every prayer keeps the mist from remembering your name.”

Genre / Mood: Folk horror, coastal gothic, supernatural debt-collection.

Starting Location: A Bell-Line levee veiled in fog, where bell-ropes sway though no wind stirs, and each ring tastes like a heartbeat. A Ferryman demands a name as toll. When the party hesitates, a Bell-Warden steps forward. “The Ninth Bell rings tonight. Will you answer — or flee?”

Theme & Atmosphere

The Mistlands lie north of the Aelerian mountains, where the Aberderrin Sea laps against reed-fens and drowned shores. To the west, the Direwood breathes; to the east, the salt tides of the Aberderrin. It is a Protectorate of the Aeler, but their iron passes only hold the southern roads — the land itself belongs to fog and bells. Every levee hums with ward-notes, every ferry takes salt as tithe, and every shadow is measured against the Direwood’s endless breath. The people here live by the weight of salt, the echo of bells, and the hope that their names will not be spoken by the mists.

What you notice first: The constant, distant chime of bells — never quite in sync. The taste of salt on your lips even inland. The way everyone holds their breath when crossing a bridge.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never answer a voice that calls your name from the fog. The mist collects names, and once it has yours, the ferryman will always know where to find you.

Regional Mood: Bells and Breath

Here, breath is currency and silence a sin. Every exhalation is counted by the ward-bells, and every stolen inhalation feeds something that should not be. The Aeler Protectorate maintains order with ledgers and patrols, but the real law is older: salt lines drawn at dusk, iron nails hammered into threshold posts, and the unspoken knowledge that the ninth bell must never ring. The Mistlands do not forgive forgetfulness. The mist has a long memory, and it shares its grudges freely.

Prominent NPCs of the Mistlands

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
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Legate Halvar	Aeler governor of the Protectorate	Keep the bell-lines intact and the grain flowing east	She carries a bell that has never been rung. It will ring once, at the end of her reign.
Mother Anja	Salt-Monk of the White Pans	Preserve the old wards against the Direwood	Her tongue is white with salt; she speaks only in blessings or silence.
Warden Kael	Bell-Warden of the High Line	Protect his village from the mist and the Aeler tax-men	He refuses to write down the ninth note; it lives only in his fading memory.
Sister Darya	Healer of the Grey Hospice of the Unnamed (Temple of Light)	Tend the fog-sick and the drowned	Her grey robes never stain, and she asks no payment — only a name for her ledger.
Notary Voss	Covenant judge (Mykkiel)	Impose Aeler law on local customs	He carries a water-clock to measure the shifting of legal moods. The mist ignores it.
The Ferryman	Oath-ferryman of the Ghost Slip	Collect fares in salt and whispered names	His left hand is always gloved; underneath, the names are carved into his palm.

Names of the Mistlands

Inspired by the coastal fens and the Aeler protectorate: clipped, breathy, with soft vowels and hard endings. Surnames often denote a marsh, a craft, or a ward.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Halvar	Anja	Foss	<i>the Bell-Sworn</i>
Kael	Darya	Mork	<i>Fog-Born</i>

Voss	Pia	Saltvedt	<i>the Unnamed</i>
Torben	Lise	Kyst	<i>Breath-Thief</i>
Stian	Ragna	Dyrep	<i>Ward-Keeper</i>
Vidar	Signe	Tangen	<i>Ash-Finger</i>

(**Fen/Levee/Bell-line**) Reed-fen causey with chalked ward-runes on every milestone; Bell-Line levee with iron posts and eight bells per span.

Spades — Places

2. **Reed-Fen Causey** — Chalked ward-runes on every milestone; safe path through the mist. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *Step only on the chalked stones. The mud between has no bottom.*
3. **Bell-Line Levee** — Iron posts, eight bells per span; one bracket empty, one note forbidden. ‘[WARD]’ *The empty bracket is for the bell that never rings. The rope is still there.*
4. **Ghost-Ferry Slip** — Rope crosses black water; fares paid in salt and whispered names. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The ferryman never blinks. Some say he traded his eyelids for the right to collect.*
5. **Pall Watch-Tower** — Piles above mire; mirrors face west to the Direwood’s breath. ‘[WARD]’ *The mirrors are silvered on both sides. The wardens watch their own reflections as much as the trees.*
6. **Mist-Chapel** — Stilted planks; votive lanterns gutter under damp rafters. ‘[RITUAL]’ *The icon has no face. Worshippers say it lost its features to the fog, one by one.*
7. **Dead-Cut Canal** — Old imperial ditch; patrolled by eel boats and law. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The eels have eyes like men. Fishermen throw back any that blink.*
8. **Drowned Copse** — Root-tangles clutch tide like old hands; bones in the bark. ‘[DEATH]’ *The trees were planted on a mass grave. They grew twisted, hungry.*
9. **Fogmill Ridge** — Wind vanes vanish into cloud; gears hiss like prayers to fog. ‘[WEATHER]’ *The miller grinds salt, not grain. His customers pay in breath, not coin.*
10. **Salt-Pan Terraces** — Patched with peat; ward-salt dries under nets, watched by monks. ‘[RESOURCE]’ *The monks chant without ceasing. If they stop, the salt spoils — and so does the warding.*
- J **Fort-Stair** — Stacked timber and stone; flags swallowed by mist, guards by routine. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The flags are changed daily. The ones that vanish are never spoken of again.*
- Q **Witchlight Bridge** — Over black runnel; ninth plank “counted” but unseen. ‘[THRESHOLD]’ *The missing plank is there — you just can’t see it. Step where it should be, or don’t step at all.*
- K **High-Mist Pass** — Through Aelerians; cairns ringed in iron nails, bells in the stones. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *Each cairn holds a bell that rang once at the death of a warden. They ring again when mist takes another.*
- A **Weeping Gate** — Western palisade facing Direwood; bells wired to bones of trees. ‘[WARD]’ ‘[DEATH]’ *The gate weeps sap that smells of iron and old grief. Wardens collect it in silver cups.*

(**Warden/Ferryman/Aeler**) Bell-warden whose ringbook decides which notes keep which ghosts; oath-ferryman collecting fares in salt and names.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Reed-Cutter** — Peat-black hands, precise opinion on fog; knows every safe path. ‘[TRAVEL]’
She cuts reeds in a pattern — one snip, two snips, then a pause for the ninth.
3. **Salt-Monk** — Blesses pans, keeps ward-measure honest; salt as both shield and vow. ‘[RITUAL]’
His tongue is white with salt. He speaks only in blessings or silence.
4. **Bell-Warden** — Ringbook decides which notes keep which ghosts at bay. ‘[WARD]’ *She refuses to write down the ninth note. It lives only in her memory — and that memory is fading.*
5. **Oath-Ferryman** — Fares in salt and names; remembers both, collects both. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[SOCIAL]’
His left hand is always gloved. Underneath, the names are carved into his palm.
6. **Lantern Acolyte** — Trims wicks and arguments; light as law in the mist. ‘[AUTHORITY]’
He carries a bell on his belt. It rings once for each lie he hears.
7. **Mist-Pilot** — Linn refugee; ghosts ships through reed-lace — if paid in breath. ‘[TRAVEL]’
She never speaks above a whisper. Her voice is currency, and she spends it carefully.
8. **Protectorate Clerk** — Aeler oilskin ledgers, narrow smile; law in triplicate. ‘[AUTHORITY]’
His stamp is a bell. He presses it twice — once for the crown, once for the Hollow.
9. **Shroud-Diver** — Harvests tokens from drowned fields before dawn’s false light. ‘[STEALTH]’ ‘[DEATH]’
He wears a bell around his ankle. If it rings, he’s stayed too long.
10. **Direwood Refugee** — Cold breath, colder stories; knows what the trees whisper. ‘[FEAR]’
She carved out her own tongue. The trees still speak through her — in a voice not her own.
- J **Fog-Knight** — Cavalry rides levee crowns by bellcode; mist as their steed. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[COMBAT]’
Their horses have no shadows. Some say they traded them for fog-sight.
- Q **Legate of Mists** — Aeler governor; equal parts mercy and decree, bells at their command. ‘[AUTHORITY]’
She carries a bell that has never been rung. It will ring once, at the end of her reign.
- K **Lord Warden** — Local strong hand sworn to Legate’s seal; law walks the fens. ‘[AUTHORITY]’
He lost an eye to a wight. He wears a bell in the socket.
- A **Mist-Seer** — Bargains breath for answers; candles shorten when she speaks. ‘[MAGIC]’ ‘[FEAR]’
She has no shadow. The mist took it as a down payment.

(**Undead/Weather/Law**) Ground-mist lifts off fen and eats tracks by the yard; witchlights try to count you; step wrong and bridge forgets you.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Ground-Mist** — Lifts from fen; eats tracks by the yard, names by the breath. ‘[WEATHER]’ ‘[DEATH]’
Your footfalls vanish behind you. The mist is following, not rising.
3. **Witchlight Count** — Trying to count you; step wrong and bridge forgets your path. ‘[MAGIC]’ ‘[FEAR]’
The lights flicker in a pattern — two short, two long. They’re signaling

someone.

4. **Ward-Salt Short** — Pans go green; bells ring, nothing answers from the other side. ‘[RE-SOURCE]’ ‘[WARD]’ *The salt is grey, not white. Someone cut it with grave dust.*
5. **Wrong Bell** — Cracked note opens a door the Legate can’t close; mist takes the gap. ‘[MAGIC]’ *The bell’s clapper is a finger bone. The original owner wants it back.*
6. **Linn Raid** — Slips reed-maze; hearths douse, horns travel on the fog. ‘[COMBAT]’ *The raiders wear bells on their belts — stolen from the last village.*
7. **Direwood Moan** — At dusk; Weeping Gate ropes go taut by themselves. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[FEAR]’ *The moan has words. You don’t want to understand them.*
8. **Valewood Wind** — Crosses Aberderrin; voices sweet, landmarks false. ‘[WEATHER]’ ‘[MAGIC]’ *The wind smells of honey and rot. Do not follow it.*
9. **Bell-Line Failure** — Levee breaks silence; wraith steps across like it owns the road. ‘[WARD]’ ‘[DEATH]’ *The wraith carries a lantern. The light is blue — the colour of drowned breath.*
10. **Marsh-Quake** — Sod heaves, dyke slumps; proofs and bodies sink together. ‘[DISASTER]’ *The ground exhales. Your name rises from it like smoke.*
- J **Protectorate Interdiction** — All ferries sealed “until review”; routes dry up. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The seals are stamped with a bell. The wax is mixed with bone ash.*
- Q **Rite-Purge** — Inspectors call local customs heresy; tempers at a boil. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The inspectors carry blank ledgers. They fill them with names of the accused.*
- K **General Alarm** — Pall horns sound; every lantern becomes law, every shadow suspect. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[FEAR]’ *The horns are made from the tusks of a sea beast. The beast’s ghost is angry.*
- A **Tide-Mist** — Rolls from Aberderrin; spirits ride the white and won’t be named. ‘[WEATHER]’ ‘[DEATH]’ *The spirits have no faces — only the faces of the drowned.*

(Pass/Seal/Token) Ward-salt allotment draws safe circle once; ferry token crosses named black runnel regardless of curfew.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Ward-Salt** — Pure measure draws safe circle once; mist parts, briefly. ‘[WARD]’ *The salt is warm. It knows it will be used.*
3. **Ferry Token** — Cross named black runnel regardless of curfew or tide. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The token is a knuckle bone. The ferryman accepts it without comment.*
4. **Bell-Key** — Unlock and set one bell on the Line to your note; change the song. ‘[MAGIC]’ *The key is a tuning fork. Strike it once to claim your note.*
5. **Lantern Writ** — Lawful travel at night along levee crown with escort. ‘[TRAVEL]’ ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The writ is written on dried bladder. It crinkles when you lie.*
6. **Exorcist’s Seal** — Stamped clause downgrades “haunt” to “nuisance.” ‘[MAGIC]’ *The seal is a bell without a clapper. It’s silent, like the wraiths it binds.*
7. **Codeleaf** — Today’s mirror and horn sequences; fog cannot hide what you know. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The leaf is soaked in brine. Read it before it dries.*

8. **Protectorate Mark** — Priority rations and rope from Fort-Stair stores. ‘[RESOURCE]’ *The mark is a brand. It smokes when you show it.*
9. **Wraith-Indemnity** — Legal immunity for actions taken under apparition threat. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The indemnity is signed in salt water. It will dissolve if you misuse it.*
10. **Bone-Field License** — Salvage rights at drowned hamlet (with witnesses). ‘[RESOURCE]’ *The license is a map drawn on a shroud. Follow the stitch marks.*
- J **Refuge-Right** — Move a named household through Gate unchallenged; breath as passport. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The right is a bell-rope. Tie it to your belt. Nonna will ask.*
- Q **Legate’s Audience** — One whisper exits as policy; bells ring your decree. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The Legate’s ear is a silver bell. Speak into it once.*
- K **Warden’s Commission** — Raise levee guards; local doors open, purses too. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The commission is a whistle. Blow it, and the fens answer.*
- A **Pall Indulgence** — Temporary exception to ward law, spoken and sealed by bell. ‘[MAGIC]’ ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The indulgence is a single bell-note, held in a jar. Break the jar to release it.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (passes/seals/tokens) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **breath and boundary** — bells answering across water, salt that won’t dry, voices returning late.

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **Breath-Toll:** Many claim the mist remembers every breath. Travelers hold breath crossing bridges, fearing the mist will count them wrong. Mechanically, when you cross a threshold without a ward-salt or bell, roll Spirit + Resolve (DV 3). On a failure, the mist learns your name — gain the **MARKED** condition (the next spirit encounter starts at Desperate Position).
- **Salt as Promise:** A handful of salt is more than warding — it is a vow. Spill it on plank or stone to swear safety. Once per session, a character may spend a handful of ward-salt to create a **Salt Oath** [4] clock. While the clock has segments, the oath-taker gains +1 die to resist fear or possession. If the oath is broken, the clock fills and the breaker takes Harm 1 (spiritual backlash).
- **The Ninth Bell:** Legends say a ninth bell once rang on the Line. The note is not in any ringbook; no warden speaks of it. Some nights, though, it rings — and gates open where none should be. When the GM spends 3+ SB in a scene, they may declare that the Ninth Bell rings. All characters must test Spirit + Resolve (DV 4) or lose 1 Fatigue (the sound steals breath).
- **Payden’s Port:** The only true city in the Mistlands, huddled on the western coast of the Aberderrin. Its wharves are built from salvaged longship timber, and its law is split between the Aeler Legate’s seal and the old bell-wardens’ traditions. Grain ships leave from its harbour each autumn, carrying the Protectorate’s tithe east — and returning with iron, engineers, and the occasional missionary.
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**

- **The Bell-Keeper** — The Sealed Gate. *A bell that never rings, yet holds the threshold closed.*
- **The Salted One** — Oath of Mercy and Grace. *A prayer that preserves body and soul, but demands a name in return.*
- **The Mist-Father** — Khemesh. *The pressure beneath the fog; the hunger that waits in still air.*
- **The Lantern Bearer** — The Traveler. *The light that guides lost ships — and lost souls.*

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **Saint Kael of the Iron Bell (The Sealed Gate):** The bell-wardens venerate a legendary warden who hammered a ninth bell into the Weeping Gate to seal a Direwood breach. The bell cracked, but the breach closed. His chisel is kept at Payden’s Port; it is said to quench the mist for an hour if struck against an iron post. The Aeler Protectorate has tried to confiscate it twice; both attempts ended with the confiscators lost in fog.
- **Saint Anja of the White Pans (Oath of Mercy and Grace):** A salt-monk who died blessing the pans during a tide-mist. Her body never decayed, and her chapel now serves as a hospice for fog-sick sailors. The Temple of Light sends offerings of fresh water each spring; the Everflame considers her a heretic. Pilgrims who pray at her shrine may ask one question of a drowned ancestor — but the answer is always a single word, and that word is a tithe.
- **The Grey Hospice of the Unnamed:** Sister Darya runs a hospice near Payden’s Port. She asks no payment, but she records every patient’s name in a ledger that never dries. The Aeler clerks suspect she is erasing records, not healing wounds. She has been investigated three times; each time, the investigator vanished into the fog and returned with no memory of why they came.
- **The Bell-Ringer’s Covenant (The Keeper of the Silent Seal):** Notary Voss is the Protectorate’s appointed judge, charged with imposing Aeler law on local customs. He carries a water-clock to measure the shifting of legal moods, but the mist ignores it. His rulings are always delivered in triplicate, and the bell-wardens obey them — slowly. Those who lie before him find that their next passage through the Ghost-Ferry Slip is denied; the ferryman refuses to name them.
- **The Ninth:** In any Mistlands scene, the ninth person to speak in a room draws the mist’s attention. The wise hold their tongues until someone else breaks the count. Those who speak ninth are said to see a pale figure standing at the foot of the bed that night — waiting to collect a breath.

Mistlands Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Fog:** Toss a crust into the mist before crossing a bridge. Ignore the first *Ground-Mist* penalty. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Hold the Ninth Breath:** Cross a threshold while holding your breath. Cancel *Witchlight Count* or take –1 die on your next action (your choice). ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Name to the Salt:** Whisper a dead enemy’s name into a salt pan. Gain +1 Effect against undead for the scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Legate. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **wardens or fog-knights**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **spirits or patrol boats**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or mist-spirits**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favourable tide**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Protectorate forces or local warden** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **mist shift or bell failure**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **wraith, raiding party, or inspector** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **fog-knights, spirits, or Aeler forces** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes — **bell-line fails/ward broken/mist claims name**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **Legate, Lord Warden, or Mist-Seer** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically — **mist thickens/bells ring/forest breathes**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice — **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Mistlands (Bells & Breath):** Bells ring without cause, breath forms visible words, mirrors reflect wrong faces.
- **Mistlands (Salt & Warding):** Salt refuses to dry, ward-runes bleed colour, protection tokens crack.
- **Mistlands (Direwood Threat):** Trees whisper your name, roots shift position, forest breath grows stronger.

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Wits + Navigation):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Fog Bank*.
- **Silence the Bell (Presence + Stealth):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a ward-salt pouch is in your possession, +1 die.
- **Weather the Tide (Resolve + Survival):** On a hit in *Tide-Mist*, you pick who keeps their bearings; on a miss, the GM does.

Boss Seeds (Bell & Breath)

- **The Ninth Bell Ringer (Direwood herald)** — *Phases:* Lost Names → Broken Lines → Open Gate. *Cracks:* restore a ringbook; trade a breath; rehang a forbidden bell with copper nails.
- **Queen of Counting Lights (fae arbiter)** — *Phases:* Courteous Tithes → Geas-Market → Ledger of Leaves. *Cracks:* return stolen way-marks; speak said and meant; gild the iron.
- **Reed-Wolf Captain (Linn raider)** — *Phases:* Smoke Signals → Night Oars → Thing Verdict. *Cracks:* name a feud-token; win a skald-duel; force harbour-truce under bell and banner.

Patronage & Power

In the Mistlands, power flows through ritual, warding, and the careful balance between the living and the dead. The Aeler Protectorate maintains nominal control through military presence and legal frameworks, but true authority lies with those who understand the bells, the salt, and the breath of the land itself. Local wardens, salt-monks, and bell-keepers hold sway over daily life, while the Legate of the Mists mediates between imperial law and ancient custom.

For the GM: Patronage in the Mistlands revolves around protection — from mist, from spirits, from the encroaching forest. Rewards often take the form of tokens, seals, or safe passage that can be leveraged into greater security. To emphasise the folk-horror feel:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (salt, bells, lanterns) that can be challenged, depleted, or voided by the mist itself.
- Let rival factions (Protectorate vs. bell-wardens vs. Direwood refugees) issue conflicting protections, forcing players to choose whose favour matters more.
- Use the levees, ferries, and watchtowers as arenas for social contests, where knowledge of the old ways (counting breaths, naming spirits, offering salt) determines success.

In the Mistlands, your safety is your standing, and your standing depends on who remembers your name.

Black Barrow Keep — The Ruin Above Payden’s Port

Looming over the eastern edge of Payden’s Port, Black Barrow Keep is a jagged wound in the skyline. Its basalt walls weep salt, and its broken towers lean into the fog like old men listening for a bell that never rings. The Aelinnel built it in a forgotten age—not as a fortress, but as a *workshop*. Here, they forged bell-automata, copper sentinels, and the first ward-lines that still keep the Direwood at bay. When the Mistlands became a Protectorate, the Aelinnel sealed the deep

forges and retreated. The locals say the keep is haunted. The truth is worse: it is not haunted—it is *occupied*.

Below the keep, the catacombs stretch down through nine known levels. Each level was sealed by a different generation of wrights: Aeler engineers, Aelinnel bell-smiths, Linn shipwrights, and older crafts whose names are scrubbed from the records. The lowest level is said to contain a working that has been ticking since before the Hollow learned to count.

Accessing the Keep: The main gate is chained with a bell-lock that requires a copper key and the correct sequence of rings (eight, never nine). Side entrances include a collapsed ropeway from the salt pans, a flooded stair from the Ghost-Ferry Slip, and a smugglers' tunnel that exits near the Grey Hospice. The Protectorate has officially sealed the keep, but wardens look the other way for a share of salvage—or a story about what moves in the deep.

Generator — Black Barrow Keep: Rooms & Encounters

d12	Area / Encounter
1	The Hanging Bell-Garden. A collapsed floor reveals a chamber where bells grow from the ceiling like stalactites. Each bell has a clapper shaped like a finger bone. <i>Effect: A bell that rings once for each secret spoken beneath it. The ringing can be heard throughout the keep.</i>
2	The Copper Forge. Still warm, though the fire went out centuries ago. A half-completed automaton sits on the anvil. Its brass skull is hinged open; inside, a nest of salt-eels writhes. <i>Effect: The forge can be reactivated with a bell-key, producing a single ward-salt token per scene.</i>
3	The Oublette of the Unnamed. A pit lined with counting marks — eight scratches, a gap, eight scratches. At the bottom, a wright’s skeleton still holds a hammer. The hammer rings when you touch it. <i>Effect: The hammer can drive a copper nail into any surface, sealing a threshold for one scene.</i>
4	The Echo Scriptorium. Shelves of slate tablets, each inscribed with a single number. The numbers are not in sequence. A ghost wright sits at a desk, writing the same number over and over. <i>Effect: The ghost will answer one question about the keep’s history, but will then ask for a number you have never written.</i>
5	The Drowned Armoury. Sealed by a slow leak from the salt pans. Weapons float in brine. One of them — a bell-hilted sword — hums when you near it. <i>Effect: The sword counts your heartbeats. If you draw it in combat, you gain+1 die, but the sword will demand a name at the end of the scene.</i>
6	The Weeping Cistern. A stone basin filled with black water. The water rises when you speak. A voice from below asks, “What is the ninth number?” <i>Effect: Answer with silence, and the water recedes, revealing a sealed door. Answer incorrectly, and the cistern floods the room.</i>
7	The Cogwheel Choir. A chamber of interlocking copper gears, each tooth stamped with a rune. When the wind blows through the broken wall, the gears turn and the runes sing a cracked hymn. <i>Effect: A character who learns the tune may reroll one failed navigation test while in the Mistlands (once).</i>
8	The Salt-Liche’s Studio. A wright who refused to die. Its flesh is replaced by salt-cured leather and copper wire. It still tries to finish a bell that has no clapper. <i>Effect: The salt-liche is not hostile, but will trade a bell-key for a memory of fresh water.</i>
9	The Unstable Lift. A chain-hoist that descends into darkness. The chains are warm. The lift stops at every eighth floor, never the ninth. <i>Effect: Riding the lift skips two levels of the catacombs, but ticks the FOG ATTENTION clock by1.</i>
10	The Bone Gallery. A corridor lined with the remains of wrights from every generation. Each skeleton wears a different style of bell-maker’s apron. The newest apron is still damp. <i>Effect: A PC may spend a scene searching; on a Wits+Lore roll (DV4), they find a key, a token, or a warning.</i>
11	The Ticking Heart. A sealed chamber behind a copper door. Some-

Factions in the Keep

- **The Bell-Wrights' Ghosts:** Ancient Aelinnel spirits who still maintain the lower forges. They ignore the living unless the forges are disturbed. Offerings of copper nails or a correctly rung bell will buy safe passage.
- **The Protectorate Salvage Team:** Aeler engineers and a squad of fog-knights, ostensibly “surveying” the keep for hazards. They will confiscate any working bell they find and arrest anyone without a Protectorate writ. Their captain has a brass hand that is also a tuning fork.
- **The Hollow's Anticipators:** A cult that believes the keep was built to contain the Hollow's attention. They leave offerings of salt and silence. They are not dangerous — but they will follow you, writing down every bell you ring and every name you speak.

Catacombs Depth Clock For expeditions that descend below the first sub-level, track a **Depth Clock** [6]. Each time the party descends a stair, uses the unstable lift, or passes a sealed door, tick the clock. At 3 segments: all navigation rolls gain +1 DV (the walls shift). At 6 segments: the party reaches a sealed level that requires a bell-key, a blood offering, or a true name to open. The deepest level (Depth 6 or more) connects to the Ways Between — a mistake may drop the party into the Hollow's own threshold.

Chapter 9

Ykrul

Wolf Standards, Winter Camps.

The steppe remembers every oath sworn beneath its endless sky, and the wolf-standards carry the honour of clans that have outlasted empires. To lead here is to keep the old ways sharp as winter steel.

I am a Herd-Scout. I can read a trail by the way the grass bends—and a lie by the way a rider sits. The Ykrul don't measure wealth in silver; we measure it in hoofbeats, in the snort of a warhorse at dawn, in the weight of a promise kept through winter.

We do not build monuments. We build relationships, each one a stone in an invisible cairn that stretches from the Dolmis to the Aberderrin. A camp is a weave of favours owed and honour satisfied. A feud is a slow equation: blood in, blood out, with interest compounded by winter.

The Khagan's Court doesn't rule from a throne—it rules from a saddle. Our "laws" are the Thirty-Six Sayings of the Road, and the thirty-seventh is the one you learn alone, on a night when the stars blink out and the wolf does not howl.

Never ride between two wolves at dusk. The space between them is a blind angle—a route with no exit, a debt with no payment. The wolves know this. They choose the gap deliberately.

— *Sogata, Herd-Scout, who has never been lost but has been found many times*

The Almanac of Ordinary Days

What do people eat for breakfast? Fermented mare's milk and dried meat—the milk is drunk warm from the skin, the meat is sliced thin and dried on saddle-pommels. The meat carries the taste of horse sweat. The milk carries the taste of the steppe. Both are acquired. Both are necessary.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To sit a horse. Ykrul children are placed on a horse before they can stand. The horse is old, patient, and knows the child's weight. A child who falls is a child who learns to hold tighter. A child who cannot ride is a child who cannot eat.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their braids. Ykrul warriors braid their hair with clan colours—red for the Wolf Clan, black for the Iron Horse, grey for the Salt Steppe. A stranger whose braids are cut has been shamed. A stranger whose braids are dyed black has killed a clan-mate. A stranger with no braids has no clan. A stranger with no clan is prey.

What is the most common crime? Horse theft. A stolen horse is a stolen relative. The price is blood—the thief's or the owner's. The courts are the council fires. The evidence is the horse's memory. Horses remember faces. Horses remember smells. Horses do not lie.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Khagan is not chosen by blood. He is chosen by the horse. Every five years, the clan chiefs lead their best stallions to the sacred ring. The horse that steps forward first chooses the next Khagan. The horse has not stepped forward in twenty years. The council chooses by silence. The silence is growing loud.

Where do people go when they die? To the sky. Ykrul dead are placed on open platforms, wrapped in felt, and left for the wind and the birds. The bones are collected after a year and ground into powder. The powder is mixed with clay and fired into beads. The beads are worn by the dead's descendants. The beads are warm. The warmth is memory.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You offer a hostage string—a braided cord that ties your wrist to the wronged party's. The cord is cut when the apology is accepted. If the cord is cut before the apology is finished, you are not forgiven. If the cord is never cut, you are bound. The binding is lifelong. The binding is called "friend."

What is the most important festival? The First Grass (spring equinox). The herds are released onto the new pasture. The riders race to the horizon and back. The winner names the summer camps. The loser tends the sick animals. The sick animals are always the loser's. The loser always wins next year.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Sky-Speaker is a fraud. She cannot call storms. She cannot read omens. She cannot speak to the dead. She is a horse-witch who learned to read the clouds. The clouds are reliable. The Khagan does not know. The Khagan does not want to know.

9.1 Ykrul — “Wolf Standards, Winter Camps”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *The steppe remembers every oath. The wolf counts your breaths.*

Genre / Mood: Nomadic epic, honour-bound geometry, wind-whispered law.

Starting Location: A winter camp on the steppe edge, banners snapping in frost-bright wind as the Khagan’s fires burn in the east. A Khatun of the Ring offers a clay cup of salted tea. “The Khagan’s kin ride from the salt pan. The old sayings say the straight road is a lie. You came by the bent path — the wolf knows you. Speak your errand before the wind changes.”

Khatun of the Ring (Elite): “The steppe remembers every oath sworn beneath its endless sky, and the wolf-standards carry the honour of clans that have outlasted empires. To lead here is to keep the old ways sharp as winter steel.”

Herd-Scout (Commoner): “The horses know the weather before it comes, and the wolves know the thoughts in a man’s heart. Best speak true and ride steady – the steppe doesn’t forgive lies or clumsy hands on the reins. An old saying: the straight road is a lie. The wise follow the bent twig.”

Theme & Atmosphere

The Ykrul ride the endless Violet Steppe, where the horizon drinks the sky and law lives in saddlebags. Their sacred patterns are called Kon’reh — not a written code but a living way of reading routes, debts, and exits. Every crossing has its price, every ford its weight, every feud an angle measured in horse-lengths and heartbeats. Hosts gather by the thousand, then scatter at a word; one night you share their fires, the next they test your bonds. Their banners are wolves’ teeth, their treaties braided cords, their memory longer than the rivers that cut the grass. The old folk still recite the Thirty-Six Sayings of the Road, but the wisest know the thirty-seventh is the one you learn alone, on a night when the stars blink out and the wolf does not howl.

What you notice first: The smell of horse sweat and woodsmoke. The way every rider counts hoofbeats under their breath. The silence when a stranger approaches the fire.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never ride between two wolves at dusk. The space between them is a blind angle — a route with no exit, a debt with no payment.

Regional Mood: The Geometry of the Steppe

Here, the horizon is not a line — it is a question. The Ykrul measure distance in oaths, not miles. A camp is a weave of favours owed and honour satisfied. A feud is a slow equation: blood in, blood out, with interest compounded by winter. The Khagan rules not by force alone but by keeping the old patterns — the unwritten rules that govern every crossing, every treaty, every duel. Break the pattern, and the steppe itself may turn against you. Keep it, and even enemies will share their salt. The Ykrul build no monuments. They build relationships, each one a stone in an invisible cairn that stretches from the Dolmis to the Aberderrin.

Prominent NPCs of the Ykrul

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Khatun Bortai	Keeper of the Ring	Keep the clans from tearing each other apart	Her hostage strings are braided from the hair of oath-breakers.
Noyan Temur	Banner-lord of the Red Reeds	Win a winter pasture without bloodshed	He has never lost a negotiation. He has never needed to speak.
Sogata	Herd-Scout (commoner exemplar)	Read the weather before the storm	He can read a trail by the way the grass bends — and a lie by the way a rider sits.
Elder Saruul	Bone-Singer	Keep the names of the dead	She sings the names of the departed each dawn; the dead sing back.
The Dust Prince	Raider who rides the wind's lee	Amass enough salt to buy a clan	He offers escort braids for secrets, never seen from the front.
Storm-Singer Urum	Sky-Speaker	Sell weather on credit	His bills come due during the Wolf Moon.

Names of the Ykrul

Inspired by the open steppe and the deep east: guttural stops, flowing vowels, and suffixes that mark lineage or deed.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Bortai	Temur	Sogata	<i>the Grey</i>
Urum	Saruul	Khorch	<i>Red-String</i>
Khasar	Altan	Noyan	<i>the Unbuckled</i>
Mongke	Checheg	Borjigin	<i>Storm-Born</i>
Edil	Borte	Uriankhai	<i>Ash-Prow</i>
Toghrul	Orghana	Qasar	<i>the Silent</i>

(**Steppe Road/Winter Ring/Ford**) Wolf Road milepost of stacked stones with wind whining through eye-holes; winter camp ring with felt tents in horseshoe facing wind.

Spades — Places

2. **Wolf Milepost** — Stacked stones; wind whines through eye-holes. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *Each stone is a treaty. Remove one, and the wind names you oath-breaker.*
3. **Remount Station** — Low corral with stamped snow and tether-posts. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The tether-posts are carved with the names of dead horses. The living ones remember.*
4. **Birch Windbreak** — Above black-earth tracks; old offerings in the bark. ‘[RITUAL]’ *The offerings are strips of wool. Each strip is a prayer for safe crossing.*
5. **Salt Pan** — Crusted white; hoof-prints like stars across the void. ‘[DEBT]’ *The pan has a name: “The Khagan’s Mirror.” Look into it, and you see your debts.*
6. **Reed Ford** — River braids; poles mark yesterday’s safe line. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The poles shift in the night. The river’s path changes with the moon.*
7. **Trading Palisade** — Way-post with wolf-skull pennons snapping. ‘[TRADE]’ *The skulls face outward. They watch for liars and bad weights.*
8. **Winter Camp** — Felt tents in a horseshoe facing the wind. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The open end is for guests. The closed end is for the ancestors.*
9. **Kurgan Field** — Low barrows; horse-bones bead the grass like prayer beads. ‘[DEATH]’ *The bones were placed by a bone-singer. Each bead is a name.*
10. **Watch Kopje** — Lonely tor with signal fire-scar; the eye of the steppe. ‘[WEATHER]’ *The fire-scar is from a signal that saved a host. The smoke still smells of hope.*
- J **Pontoon Crossing** — Laced hides creak; the current speaks fast and hungry. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The hides are from horses that died crossing. Their ghosts still pull.*
- Q **Council Hollow** — Standards planted; the ground tamped like a war-drum. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The standards have ears. Speak a treason here, and every clan will know by dawn.*
- K **Khagan’s Station** — Broad ger on a timber platform; guards in silence. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The guards never blink. They are paid in salt and secrets.*
- A **Sky Steppe** — Open, wind like a voice; tracks keep pace beside you. ‘[MYSTERY]’ *The tracks are not yours. They belong to the ancestors who ride with you.*

(**Host/Envoy/Rider**) Herd-scout with three ponies and six opinions; camp-mother who chooses where fires live.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Herd-Scout** — Three ponies and six opinions; the horizon as a map. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *He can read a trail by the way the grass bends. He can read a lie by the way a rider sits.*
3. **Camp-Mother** — Chooses where fires live; hospitality is law. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *She has never drawn a blade. She has never needed to.*
4. **Banner Youth** — Minding the wolves’ tooth standard; pride as duty. ‘[COMBAT]’ *The standard is older than his grandmother’s grandmother. He will die before it falls.*
5. **Salt-Broker** — Weighs promises like grain; trade as precision. ‘[TRADE]’ *Her scales are honest—except when they aren’t. The difference is a prayer.*

6. **Remount Keeper** — String-master with a book of brands; horses as currency. '[TRAVEL]' *His book is written in hoof-prints. He can read a horse's soul.*
7. **Bone-Singer** — Knows the kurgans' proper names; death as memory. '[DEATH]' *She sings the names of the dead each dawn. The dead sing back.*
8. **Road-Judge** — Tümen scribe with seals and a patient ear. '[LAW]' *His seals are from three empires. He uses whichever one is still valid.*
9. **Noyan Envoy** — Silver paiza, iron smile; diplomacy as a blade. '[SOCIAL]' *His paiza was a gift from a Khagan who is now dead. He does not mention that.*
10. **Host Captain** — The tent-wall is a map; strategy in every fold. '[COMBAT]' *He can see a battle in the way smoke rises. He is usually right.*
- J **Falcon Courier** — Leather gauntlets, answers sooner than asked. '[TRAVEL]' *The falcon is a sleeper agent. It belongs to a different clan. The courier doesn't know.*
- Q **Khatun of Ring** — Keeper of camp-law and hostage strings. '[LAW]' *Her strings are braided from the hair of hostages. She knows each strand's owner.*
- K **Khagan's Kin** — A nephew or niece sent to bind a foedus with a look. '[SOCIAL]' *They have never lost a negotiation. They have never needed to speak.*
- A **Sky-Speaker** — Shaman of storms; shortcuts owe them a price. '[MAGIC]' *They can call lightning—or call it off. The price is always a story.*

(Law/Weather/Feud) White squall with dry snow, lost horizons; rasputitsa turning the road to porridge; a feud spark from a name spoken wrong.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **White Squall** — Dry snow, lost horizons; navigation by instinct alone. '[WEATHER]' *The snow tastes of iron. Someone is bleeding nearby.*
3. **Rasputitsa** — The road becomes porridge; wheels are lies on the earth. '[WEATHER]' *The mud has a smell—old blood and older lies.*
4. **Remount Sickness** — A cough in the string; swaps get awkward, trust thinner. '[DEATH]' *The cough is a curse. The horses know who cast it.*
5. **Salt Shortage** — Meat spoils; tempers thin like winter air. '[DEBT]' *The salt was cut with grave dust. Someone wanted the winter to be hard.*
6. **Hostage Call** — Protocol invoked; someone must sit in the tent. '[SOCIAL]' *The tent has no floor. The hostage can see the earth beneath—and the bones.*
7. **Feud Spark** — A name spoken wrong reopens an old cut; blood remembers. '[DEBT]' *The name was spelled correctly. The insult was in the pause before it.*
8. **Grassfire** — Runs with the wind faster than horses; escape as a prayer. '[DISASTER]' *The fire has a face. It is the face of a Khagan who burned a village.*
9. **Foedus Recall** — Treaty terms re-read; your papers disagree. '[LAW]' *The treaty was written on both sides. The other side used a different ink.*
10. **River Break** — Ice goes; ferries don't; crossing becomes a gamble. '[TRAVEL]' *The ice is still thick in the middle. The edges are lying.*
- J **Raid Shadow** — Another banner follows at a patient distance. '[COMBAT]' *They are not attacking. They are waiting for you to make a mistake.*

- Q **Kurultai Call** — Camps converge; travel becomes politics. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The kurultai has a list of grievances. Your name is near the top.*
- K **Wolf Muster** — A levy raised; every road a checkpoint, every rider a judge. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The muster horn is a wolf’s skull. It sounds like a scream.*
- A **Sky Omen** — Three suns, or none; routes rewrite themselves. ‘[OMEN]’ *The omen is a wedge of cranes flying north in winter. The sky is wrong.*

(Pass/Remount/Truce) Camp token for one night’s lawful fire and fodder; salt allotment from a named store without quarrel.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Camp Token** — One night’s lawful fire and fodder; hospitality as a right. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The token is a horsehair braid. Burn it to claim your fire.*
 3. **Salt Allotment** — Draw from a named store without quarrel. ‘[TRADE]’ *The allotment is a salt-cake. Break it in half to share.*
 4. **Ford-Right** — Cross a named braid at lawful depth. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The right is a pole. Plant it in the river, and the ford will hold—once.*
 5. **Remount Chit** — Swap two tired mounts for fresh. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The chit is a horse’s tooth. The remount keeper will not smile when you present it.*
 6. **Escort Braid** — Two riders see you through a bad stretch. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The braid is woven from the riders’ own hair. They will die before they cut it.*
 7. **Safe-Hostage** — Place or take token-kin for a truce. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The hostage is a child. The child is patient.*
 8. **Paiza Tablet** — Priority on the Wolf Road and at posts. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The tablet is bronze. It is warm when your reputation is good.*
 9. **Foedus Seal** — A treaty clause that trumps petty order. ‘[LAW]’ *The seal is a wolf’s head. Press it into wax, and the steppe listens.*
 10. **Market-Green** — Trade under a banner; weapons sheathed. ‘[TRADE]’ *The banner is a green field. No blood may be spilled beneath it.*
- J **Standard Guard** — Travel under wolf-tooth; raiders defer. ‘[COMBAT]’ *The standard is a wolf’s tooth on a pole. Raiders will bow—or die.*
- Q **Ring Audience** — The Khatun hears you alone; precedent sticks. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The audience is held at midnight. The fire is the only witness.*
- K **Khagan’s Writ** — Doors open, mouths close across the steppe. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The writ is a sheet of hammered silver. It bends, but it does not break.*
- A **Sky’s Exception** — Once, the weather ignores you (storm, whiteout, dust). ‘[WEATHER]’ *The exception is a single breath. Use it well.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (passes/remounts/truces) that change position rather than call for a roll.

- If any A appears, echo **steppe and sky** motifs—wind that speaks, horses that remember, treaties that bind across generations.

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **Hostage Strings.** Every oath is secured with a **hostage string**—a token kin, retainer, or sworn ally left in the other camp. If the deal is broken, the hostage’s fate becomes the story’s next beat. (Mechanically: create a 4-segment *Hostage* clock; on breach, the clock becomes a countdown to vengeance.)
- **Steppe Law.** Travelers are bound by **steppe law**: hospitality lasts three nights, insults last three generations. The Keeper may demand 1 SB when either law is broken.
- **Sky Omens.** When the sky shows strange signs—mock-suns, green fire, thunder without storm—the steppe itself speaks. Once per scene, players may treat an omen as a *Diamond*, shifting Position without a roll. The GM may bank 1 SB for future weather complications.
- **Bowl and Board.** Ykrul elders settle disputes not by shouting but by drawing two circles in the dirt: the **Bowl** for fairness, then the **Board** for routes and concessions. A successful *Wits + Lore* (or a relevant skill) roll creates a *Seasonal Concession String* at a ford, harbor, or pass. On a miss, the **Market Moot** [4] clock advances as factions argue.
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
 - **The Hoof** — The Traveler. *The path that never ends, the remount that never tires.*
 - **The Wolf’s Tooth** — The Witness. *Every oath is counted. Every broken promise is a scar.*
 - **The Salt Throat** — Maelstraeus. *The debt that salts your tongue; the interest that blinds your horses.*
 - **The Sky Father** — Kuva. *The wind that carries names; the storm that erases them.*

The Thirty-Seven Sayings of the Road (Excerpts)

The Ykrul teach strategy not in manuals but in proverbs—each a line of play. A few of the most quoted:

Let the river freeze before you cross. — Do not rush. Let the opponent make the first move; your opening will be built on their impatience.

Borrow a corridor to trap a king. — When the enemy carves a path toward you, let it deepen. Then seal the mouth behind them.

Loot a burning house. — Strike only when the enemy is committed elsewhere.

Hide your dagger behind a smile. — Threaten one flank; strike the other.

The reed bends, the oak breaks. — Yield to overwhelming force, but do not break; preserve your core.

A distant banner casts no shadow. — A threat far away is no threat at all; control the centre.

The guest who outstays his welcome steals the host’s peace. — Allow no force, however small, to remain within your lines uncontrolled.

Count exits, not victims. — Before you move, count the ways your foe can flee. If the number is greater than zero, you have not yet won.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Bitter Root:** Daughters of the Cord run a hospice near the salt pans. They ask no payment—but they cut threads. A renegade Sister hides among the herders, trying to untie her cord from a Ykrul blood-debt.
- **The Threshold Compendium:** The kurgans are Class II Anchor sites—the spirits of old Khagans bound by unfinished wergild. Saikou Ira would carry a bag of salt in each hand here.
- **Malachai, the Chained Angel:** A silver coin that never spends circulates among the salt-brokers. Take it, and your store never runs dry—but the coin will reappear in the salt pan at every new moon.
- **The Grey Wanderer’s Grimoire:** Ykrul psions are called “Weather-Readers.” They taste the future in the wind. Road-judges employ two—and have never trusted a verdict they didn’t hear from the sky.
- **The Ninth:** In any Ykrul camp, the ninth cup poured at a feast is for the ancestors. The wise pour eight and leave the ninth as a pause.

Ykrul Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Salt to the Wind:** Toss a pinch into the air before a long ride. Ignore the first *White Squall* penalty.
- **Knot the String:** Tie a single knot in a hostage cord. Cancel *Feud Spark* or take –1 die on your next oath (your choice).
- **Name to the Kurgan:** Whisper a dead enemy’s name into a horse’s ear. Gain +1 Effect when raiding their clan this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Bone-Singer.

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Unwanted attention from **road-judges** or **border riders**.
- **Noise:** Sounds alert a **nearby camp** or **raiding party**.
- **Trace:** Hoofprints or broken grass mark your route for **feud-kin**.
- **Delay:** A horse throws a shoe, a rope breaks — lose time.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on **fodder** or **water** clock.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** A **watch kopje** signals; riders are coming.
- **Position Lost:** **Rasputitsa** or **white squall** hides the trail.
- **Foe Appears:** A **raid shadow** or **hostage taker** arrives.
- **Gear Trouble:** A saddle snaps, a bowstring frays.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A river breaks, a ford becomes impassable.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** A **wolf muster** or **kurultai** war party arrives.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A horse goes lame, a paiza cracks.
- **Major Twist:** A **grassfire** cuts off retreat, or a **feud spark** escalates.

- **Rail Tick:** Advance a campaign clock (e.g. **Hostage Crisis**).
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Exhausted** or **Marked by Feud**.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A **hidden kurgan** collapses, a **pontoon** sinks.
- **Authority Arrival:** **Khatun of the Ring**, **Khagan's Kin**, or **Sky-Speaker** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** A **sky omen** rewrites the terrain; paths appear or vanish.
- **Patron Omen:** A wolf watches, a horse speaks, the wind carries a name.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The feud is not what it seemed; the hostage was a willing sacrifice.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Steppe Law:** Hospitality fails, insults echo, treaties shift mid-parley.
- **Horse Culture:** Mounts refuse to move, remount posts are empty, riding rolls suffer –1 die.
- **Sky Omens:** Weather changes instantly, stars point the wrong way, a raven shadows the party.

Extensions (Plug-in)

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Wits + Ride):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Dust Cloud*.
- **Cut the Herd (Presence + Sway):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a *remount chit* is in your possession, +1 die.
- **Weather the Squall (Resolve + Survival):** On a hit in *White Squall*, you pick who keeps their bearings; on a miss, the GM does.

Terrain Stock (d20)

Roll or choose a striking detail to dress a hex of the Violet Steppe.

1. Wolf milepost with fresh red thread; someone retied the law.
2. Reed ford poles lying on bank; current whispers a different depth.
3. Fallen standard tooth used as a chopping block; grooves still warm.
4. Circle of pony skulls facing east; one blinks when the wind shifts.
5. Snow trench with cudgel steps; no prints leave it.
6. Copper salt-scale hung from a birch; pans balance only under oath.
7. Hoof-bells threaded on hair; ringing calls riders – or storms.
8. Abandoned paiza shard wedged in a milestone; edges bite skin.
9. Kurgan capstone chalked with a name misspelled; feud waiting.
10. Flint knapper's tarp half-buried; a perfect arrowhead points north.
11. Blue-fletched signal arrow stuck in frost; message in the vane.
12. Camp-sweep marks: three rings – last night was a council.
13. Wheel rut frozen like glass; a face looks up from inside.
14. Salt-brined jerky hanging from a tripod; untouched by birds.

15. River ice singing in thirds; ferryman’s pole wedged under.
16. Pony hobble-rope knotted in hostage-string pattern.
17. Cold forge dug into loess; tools wrapped in wolfskin.
18. Child’s braid-bead dropped in snow; still warm to the tongue.
19. Thorn-tether scratched with clan brands; two over-scratched.
20. Bone flute lodged in a cairn; playing it summons a road-judge.

Lair Seeds (One-Page Rides)

1. **Ger of Echoes** — Empty felt walls repeat anything uttered in the Khagan’s voice once per night.
2. **Salt-Pit Shrine** — Rope winch to brine caverns; offerings are tears and horsehair.
3. **Remount Vault** — Subterranean stables under reed mats; mounts won’t leave without a tale.
4. **Kite-Maker’s Bluff** — Bone kites pinned on racks; their shadows scout for raiders.
5. **Storm-Rider’s Stone** — Pillar that hums to hooves; racing round it sets weather wagers.
6. **Frozen Court** — Ice dais in a dry riverbed; law held here counts triple until thaw.
7. **Banner Grave** — Flags planted like trees; each knows the battle it died in.
8. **String-Mother’s Yard** — Web of hostage cords; cutting one opens a secret but starts a feud.
9. **Fire-Under-Snow** — Warm vent where foals winter; spirits ask for salt-song.
10. **Quiet Palisade** — Trading post where voices fail; deals done in gesture and cut meat.
11. **Ashen Trident** — Three lightning-split birches; tie a braid to choose a road’s luck.
12. **Grey Ger** — Moves at night; inside, a camp-mother tests your hospitality the other way around.

Steppe Bestiary (Palette)

- **Steppe Manticores** — Lionine torsos, porcupine tails of bone quills. *Signs:* quills in fence-posts; ponies refuse to drink. *Hook:* play a raid-song backward; they circle to listen.
- **Dust Hulks** — Wind-packed silhouettes that rise from dunes. *Signs:* dunes “breathe”; grit sifts upward. *Hook:* spill water on their shadow; they settle for a watch.
- **Bone Kites** — Carrion birds with rune-etched pinions. *Signs:* spiral flights over kurgans. *Hook:* offer a name-stake (twig with hair) to barter silence.
- **Frost Wargs** — Blue-pelt wolves that steam cold. *Signs:* rime on tracks; breath that crackles. *Hook:* warm milk poured on ice buys one unchallenged crossing.
- **Reed Stalkers** — Long-necked marsh hunters, gait like stilts. *Signs:* pole-pocks where no ferryman walks. *Hook:* carry reeds in your mouth; they read it as truce.
- **Salt Screamer** — Pale eels in dry pans; voices like flutes. *Signs:* fissures crusted with salt frost. *Hook:* scatter ash; they coil to sing and forget to bite.

Relic & Find (d10)

When you uncover a kurgan cache or a lost hoard, roll or pick:

1. Wolf-tooth standard tip; planted, it demands silence for parley.
2. Bronze paiza half; merchants honour it as full once – then talk.
3. Salt-needle that points to the nearest brine store.
4. Frost-bitten stirrup; mount that wears it ignores ice once.
5. Braid-bead of hostage glass; melts when a string is cut nearby.
6. River-depth rod carved with safe counts for three fords.
7. Iron hoof-bell that rings for liars at council.
8. Bone-lot cup; roll it to name which feud clause applies.
9. Wind-wrung scarf; pass it round to share breath in a white squall.
10. Wolf-road tablet scrap; reads as a *Foedus Seal* to one clerk.

Complication Twists (d8)

When a travel complication arises, roll or choose a twist that deepens the story.

1. *White Squall* reveals a remount vault's smoke hole; entering angers reed stalkers.
2. *Rasputitsa* exposes kurgan stones; riding around them starts a name-claim.
3. *Feud Spark* was staged by a salt-broker; paying in *Salt Allotment* unmasks them.
4. *Hostage Call* is for a *Safe-Hostage* you already carry – by another name.
5. *Grassfire* runs uphill toward a council hollow; smoke votes before riders do.
6. *Foedus Recall* cites a river you crossed yesterday – now it flows the other way.
7. *Raid Shadow* is your own tracks, mirrored by sky omens; choose which you admit.
8. *Kurultai Call* stacks councils; words spoken in one bind you in the other.

Boss Seeds (Three-Phase Foes)

- **The String-Mother (Nine Hostages)** — *Phases*: Knot → Tighten → Sever. *Cracks*: return a hostage string, win a Bowl and Board arbitration, cut the right knot.
- **The Dust Prince (Rider of the Red Wind)** — *Phases*: Raid Shadow → Salt Tithe → Kurultai Coup. *Cracks*: spill a salt allotment in his path, unmask his face before the council, outride him through a white squall.

Patronage & Power

In Ykrul society, power flows through the careful management of hospitality, the binding of oaths with hostages, and the ability to navigate the complex web of tribal relationships. The Khagan maintains authority through the loyalty of noyans and the respect of khatuns, while local leaders wield influence through their control of resources like salt, remounts, and safe passage. The true power lies with those who understand the ancient customs and can maintain the delicate balance between hospitality and honour.

For the GM: Patronage in Ykrul society revolves around hospitality, hostage exchanges, and the ability to command respect from hosts and courts. Rewards often take the form of tokens, treaties, and official positions that can be leveraged into greater influence. To emphasize the old ways:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (tokens, braids, standards) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided.
- Use the *Bowl and Board* procedure for disputes—first fairness (Bowl), then routes and concessions (Board), then a seasonal right.
- Let rival hosts issue conflicting protections, forcing players to choose whose favour matters more.

In Ykrul society, your word is your bond, and your bond determines whether you ride as guest or ghost.

Chapter 10

Vilikari

Laurels & Longhouses.

We are the bridge between empire and wilderness, the marriage of law and custom. Our strength lies not in choosing one path but in walking both with equal surety.

I am a Hearth-Mother. I have never lost a quarrel. My voice is soft, my memory longer than the Foedus Stone.

The Vilikari straddle the border like a drunkard on a fence—half empire, half steppe, all headache. Their foedus treaties aren't just agreements—they're a tragicomic mess, half carved in marble by emperors who forgot to pay the sculptors, half braided in string by chieftains who forgot which knot meant "peace." And yet, somehow, the treaties hold. Not because of the marble. Not because of the string. Because both sides are too exhausted to start the argument over again.

Never invoke only one law. The mallus (oak-ring) and the basilica (marble bench) must both be honoured. Choose one, and the other will find you—usually at midnight, usually with a writ, usually with a sword.

— *Hearth-Mother Vesna, who has fed three kings and forgotten none of their debts*

The Almanac of Ordinary Days

What do people eat for breakfast? Oatmeal with dried berries—the berries are harvested from the border scrub, where the empire's orchards meet the steppe's wild brambles. The berries taste of both. The oatmeal tastes of neither. The oatmeal is filler. The berries are the point.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To speak both languages—Imperial Utaran and the steppe cant. A child who speaks only one is a child who will never cross the border. A child who crosses the border is a child who will come back with stories. A child with stories is a child who will be listened to. Listening is power.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Which side of the road they ride on. The empire's roads are measured from the centre. The steppe's paths are measured from the edge. A stranger who rides in the centre is an imperial. A stranger who rides at the edge is a nomad. A stranger who rides in the ditch is a spy. The ditch is not a road. The ditch is a message.

What is the most common crime? Treaty-splitting—selling the same rights to both sides. A Vilikari factor will promise river access to an imperial merchant and grazing rights to a Ykrul clan, then collect from both and disappear before the paperwork collides. The crime is not in the selling. The crime is in getting caught before you cross the border.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Foedus Stone is a copy. The original was stolen in 712 AR by a Vilikari trader who owed debts on both sides. She melted it down and sold the marble dust as "treaty-strengthening powder." The powder was mostly chalk. The treaties are still holding. The traders are still selling.

Where do people go when they die? To the border. The Vilikari bury their dead at the edge—close enough to the empire for the priests to pray, close enough to the steppe for the shamans to chant. The dead are planted face-up, so they can see both skies. The skies are different colours. The dead do not complain.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You invoke the mallus—the oak-ring court. The wronged party sits inside the ring. The wrongdoer circles it three times, speaking their apology. On the third circuit, the elders judge. If the apology is accepted, the wrongdoer is admitted into the ring. If it is rejected, the ring closes. The wrongdoer is outside. Outside is the lawless land. The lawless land is where the wolves are.

What is the most important festival? The Renewal of the Foedus (summer solstice). The stone is washed with milk and honey. The milk is from a Ykrul mare. The honey is from an imperial apiary. The mixture is drunk by the elders. The elders speak the treaty aloud. The treaty is long. The elders are old. The ceremony takes all day.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Foedus Stone has a crack. The crack was caused by a hammer in 799 AR, during a dispute over horse tariffs. The stone was repaired with clay and prayer. The clay is drying. The prayer is fading. The crack is spreading. When the stone splits, the treaty splits with it. No one knows what happens then. No one wants to find out.

10.1 Vilikari — “Laurels & Longhouses”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *Two laws, one people. The oak remembers; the marble writes. The stone is cracking.*

Federate King (Elite): “We are the bridge between empire and wilderness, the marriage of law and custom. Our strength lies not in choosing one path but in walking both with equal surety. But the bridge is rotting, and no one sends hostages anymore.”

Hearth-Mother (Commoner): “The old ways and new laws both have their place at our table. Serve the right mead to the right guest, honor the proper customs, and you’ll find we’re better hosts than most kings. The trouble is, the guests are forgetting why they came.”

Genre / Mood: Early Holy Roman Empire on the steppe — legal dualism, hybrid identity, frontier pragmatism, **forgotten treaties**.

Starting Location: A longhouse quarter tucked into an old forum. Laurel garlands hang from broken columns. Smoke from a dozen hearths curls under cracked marble arches. A Hearth-Mother offers a cup of small beer and a piece of oatcake. “The Foedus Stone cracks,” she says. “The steppe listens. Which law will you speak when the Ykrul envoy arrives — oak or marble? The stone has a new crack. No one knows which promise it represents.”

Theme & Atmosphere

The Vilikari are not caught between empire and steppe — they are *forgotten*. The Foedus Stone, the ancient treaty that guaranteed their autonomy, is *cracking*. Every season, another shard falls. The Ecktorian clerks have stopped renewing the oath; the Ykrul no longer send hostages. The Vilikari are becoming *invisible* to both sides. Their law still holds, but the witnesses are dying. The Elder of Elders speaks once a year, but fewer and fewer listen.

Their halls are longhouses raised over ruined forums; their laws carved on both oak and marble; their loyalties braided like the braids of their war-maidens’ hair. Unlike the Ykrul, who read the geometry of the steppe, the Vilikari read the geometry of *jurisdiction*. They are the bulk of the non-elite population in Ecktoria — the legionaries’ descendants who never went home. A Vilikari blacksmith in Ecktoria might swear by the marble bench; his cousin two valleys over in Acasia still ties knots for the oak. This is not contradiction. It is survival. But survival requires witnesses. And the witnesses are fading.

What you notice first: The smell of woodsmoke and old parchment. The way everyone speaks two languages at once — switching mid-sentence. The longhouse roofs that use broken imperial tiles as shingles. The silence where there used to be oaths.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never invoke only one law. The *mallus* (oak-ring) and the *basilica* (marble bench) must both be honored. Choose one, and the other will find you. But now, neither may answer.

Regional Mood: Laurels and Longhouses

Here, the past is not a ruin — it is a *creditor*. The old Utaran forums still echo with the footsteps of legionaries, but now those columns hold longhouse roofs. The Vilikari do not choose between empire and tribe; they marry them, awkwardly, imperfectly, and with frequent arguments. Their

kings wear both a laurel wreath and a wolf-tail cloak. Their courts meet twice: once under the oak for blood-price, once on the marble bench for statute. No verdict is final until both have spoken.

But the witnesses are dying. The Foedus Stone has a crack for every forgotten promise. The newest crack has no date. It appeared last winter. No one knows which promise it represents.

On the coast, Vilihari fishing villages double as smugglers' coves, running fugitives, forbidden goods, and whispered messages. Their boats are fast, their pilots know every reef and patrol route, and their loyalty is to the cargo's survival. They are the last people in the Amaranthine who still remember the old treaty's third clause. They are not sure why it matters. They keep it anyway.

Prominent NPCs of the Vilihari

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Federate King Aldric	Rex-Dux of the Vilihari	Keep the two-law balance and the Foedus Stone intact	He has three thrones — oak, marble, and saddle. He uses whichever is not being argued over. Lately, all three are dusty.
Hearth-Mother Vesna	Keeper of guest-right (commoner exemplar)	Protect her village from raiders and tax men alike	She has never lost a quarrel; her voice is soft, her memory longer than the Foedus Stone. But the stone is shrinking.
Shield-Brother Rurik	Comitatus oath-bearer	Enforce the mallus code in the marches	His braids are his ledger; each knot is a debt paid — or owed. He has started tying knots in his sleep.

March Theodora	Notary	Utaran-trained legalist	Draft treaties that neither side can break	She writes in three scripts; her left hand writes Latin, her right writes runes. Her third hand writes in ink that no one can read — not even her.
Smuggler Drago	Captain	Vilikari fisherman and trafficker	Run contraband and refugees past the Kahfagian patrols	He knows every reef and every lantern shift; the harbormasters cannot catch him. He says the Foedus Stone’s cracks are good for business — no one checks the old treaties anymore.
Elder of Elders		Thing-council speaker	Preserve the old customs against imperial erosion	He speaks once a year; the rest of the time he listens — and remembers. But his mem- ory is cracking like the stone.

Names of the Vilikari

Vilikari names blend Utaran (Latin) roots with steppe influences: hard consonants, fluid vowels, and surnames that recall a ford, a bridge, or a longhouse.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Aldric	Vesna	de la Marche	<i>the Two-Law</i>
Rurik	Theodora	Longwood	<i>the Fox</i>
Drago	Gisela	Kalderash	<i>Bridge-Born</i>
Oswin	Mira	Oakenshield	<i>the Unbuckled</i>
Vidar	Svanhild	Tregard	<i>Ash-Prow</i>

Kael	Ragna	Foedus	<i>the Grey</i>
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(**March Town/Villa-Fort/Old Road**) Longhouse Quarter tucked into old forum with hearth-smoke under broken eaves; Milefort XVII with earth bank and faded eagle.

Spades — Places

2. **Longhouse Quarter** — Tucked into old forum; hearth-smoke under broken eaves. ‘[COMMUNITY]’ *The forum’s marble floor is worn smooth by dancing feet, not sandals. The ghosts of tax collectors weep in the corners.*
3. **Milefort XVII** — Earth bank, stone gate; faded eagle over fresh knotwork. ‘[MILITARY]’ *The eagle’s stone wings were reglued after a lightning strike. It still leans left — toward the steppe.*
4. **Stone Ford** — Plank-palings and a customs table at knee-height; border as bureaucracy. ‘[TRADE]’ *The ford changes hands every season. The customs table never moves. The wood is stained with ink and blood.*
5. **Villa Granary** — Barracks with a tile roof; spear racks where olives once slept. ‘[MILITARY]’ *The olive press still works. The pressers are now armorers. The oil is for lamps, not cooking.*
6. **Twin Court** — Mallus ring beneath an oak, basilica bench across the lane. ‘[LAW]’ *The oak and the bench are the same distance from the well. The well is neutral ground. The well has a chain.*
7. **Blackwood Road** — Milestones re-carved in runes and Latin both. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The runes say “safe passage.” The Latin says “toll payable twice.” The third line is scratched out.*
8. **Staple Market** — Frontier where Ykrul horses meet Vilihari iron. ‘[TRADE]’ ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The horse-traders and smiths speak a pidgin of gestures and grudges. The scales are honest — mostly.*
9. **Burial Field** — Ship-ridge mounds beside tiled mausolea, both garlanded. ‘[DEATH]’ *The mausolea have fresh offerings. The ancestors are not picky. The ship-mounds whisper at dawn.*
10. **Repaired Bridge** — An arch of stone, a Vilihari trestle stitched on; past and present joined. ‘[TRAVEL]’ ‘[LAW]’ *The trestle creaks in Vilihari, the stone groans in Utaran. They argue at midnight. The toll-keeper listens.*
- J **Hill Amphitheater** — A lord’s hall raised in an old arena’s curve; power in architecture. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The lord’s throne is a gladiator’s chair. He does not know who last sat in it. The sand beneath is still dark.*
- Q **New Raivon** — March capital; grid-streets colliding with wandering lanes. ‘[URBAN]’ *The grid was laid by a surveyor who never came back. The lanes are older. They move at night.*
- K **Dux’s Palace** — Purple awnings, wolf-hides, law tablets on the wall. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The tablets list every treaty broken. The wolf-hides are from the treaty-breakers. They still growl.*
- A **Foedus Stone** — At a crossroads; every treaty carved, every hand weighed. ‘[LAW]’ ‘[LEGEND]’ *The stone has grown. Each new treaty adds a finger of granite. The oldest fingers are worn smooth. The newest crack has no date.*

(**Federate/Mixed Court/Diaspora**) Hearth-Mother with guest-cup and wergild chest key; Shield-Brother with oaths braided into hair.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Hearth-Mother** — Guest-cup and wergild chest key; hospitality as power. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *She has never lost a quarrel. Her voice is soft, her memory longer than the Foedus Stone. She remembers debts that are not yet owed — and the stone is forgetting.*
3. **Shield-Brother** — Comitatus oaths braided into hair; loyalty as bond. ‘[MILITARY]’ ‘[OATH]’ *His braids are his ledger. Each knot is a debt paid — or owed. He has started tying knots in his sleep, hoping the stone will remember.*
4. **March Notary** — Utaran-trained; writes three scripts without blinking. ‘[LAW]’ *His left hand writes Latin, his right writes runes. He signs with his foot. The document is always binding — until the stone forgets.*
5. **Horse-Reeve** — Rations pasture between plows and warbands. ‘[TRADE]’ *He measures grass in fistfuls. The Ykrul respect his arithmetic. The Ecktorians pretend not to notice. He is saving fistfuls to patch the stone.*
6. **Ykrul Envoy** — Riding under safe-conduct; speaks debts in proverbs. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *He never carries a weapon. His tongue is sharp enough. His hostage string has nine knots. He is running out of space — and the stone is running out of memory.*
7. **Old Legionary** — Drill-master for Vilikari levies; Utar in muscle memory. ‘[MILITARY]’ *He still marks time in paces. The recruits call him “Grandfather Eagle.” The eagle on his shield is chipped. He says the stone’s cracks are just more places to put his thumb.*
8. **Ecktorial Factor** — Vilikari blood, Ecktorial coin; flows where the ledger points. ‘[TRADE]’ *His coat has two collars — one for each loyalty. He wears whichever is warmer. His ledger has three columns. The third column is labelled “crack width.”*
9. **Kahfagian Pilot** — Lantern-law chit and clan tattoo; sea-law on land. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *He navigates by stars and tariffs. Both change with the season. He has never been lost — only delayed. The stone’s cracks are good for smuggling.*
10. **Marcher-Lord** — Iron-nail crown, Vilikari law in pocket; a frontier king. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *His crown was a plowshare. He reversed the curse. His hands are still calloused. He does not sit on his throne. He spends his days pressing his ear to the stone.*
- J **War-Maiden** — Oath-braid names the dead and the owed; vengeance as memory. ‘[COMBAT]’ ‘[OATH]’ *Her braid is longer than her sword. Both have drawn blood. She never cuts the braid. The dead would forget her. The stone is forgetting everyone else.*
- Q **Queen of Marches** — Consort-regent; smiles like precedent. ‘[POLITICS]’ *She married the Federate King for peace. She kept the kingdom for herself. Her seal is a broken arrow. She keeps a piece of the stone in her pocket — it gets smaller every year.*
- K **Federate King** — Rex-Dux sworn to forms, sung by his own. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *He has three thrones — oak, marble, and saddle. He uses whichever is not being argued over. His crown is a laurel and a wolf’s tooth. He has stopped arguing. He just listens to the stone.*
- A **Elder of Elders** — Thing-council speaker; a nod can unmake a clan. ‘[LAW]’ *He speaks once a year. The rest of the time he listens — and remembers. But his memory is cracking like the stone. He has started writing things on his own skin.*

(Two Laws/Two Fronts/Old Grudges) Annona late — grain stipend misses the comitatus; tempers quicken; jurisdiction tangle of mallus vs. basilica writ.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Annona Late** — Grain stipend misses the comitatus; tempers quicken like flint. ‘[SUPPLY]’ ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The granary is full. The keys are in the wrong vault. Someone is waiting for the price to rise. The soldiers are not. The stone does not care.*
 3. **Law Tangle** — Mallus verdict vs. basilica writ — whose seal bites? ‘[LAW]’ *The oak judge and the marble judge are cousins. They send each other holiday cards. The case has been open for three generations. The stone has forgotten who started it.*
 4. **Raid Rumor** — A Ykrul boyar; levies panic the plowlands. ‘[COMBAT]’ ‘[FEAR]’ *The boyar is a ghost — or a tax collector. The farmers don’t wait to find out. They burn the fields themselves. The stone’s cracks are good cover for ghosts.*
 5. **Bridge Levy** — Doubled for road-works; caravans balk, fists rise. ‘[TRADE]’ ‘[COMBAT]’ *The road-works are a ditch. The ditch fills every spring. The bridge keeper has a new sword. He sharpens it on the stone.*
 6. **Succession Feud** — Wolf-brother claim vs. purple-charter heir. ‘[POLITICS]’ ‘[DEATH]’ *The wolf-brother has a better sword. The purple-charter has a better notary. The notary’s ink is mixed with blood. The stone’s crack drinks it.*
 7. **Foedus Recall** — A prefecture resettlement is “requested”; homes bristle. ‘[LAW]’ ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The prefecture’s map is forty years old. It shows a village that drowned. The villagers are still there. The stone remembers their names — barely.*
 8. **Coin Talk** — Debasement; pay demanded in salt, hides, or hostages. ‘[TRADE]’ ‘[DEBT]’ *The salt is from a disputed pan. The hides are from cattle that were never born. The hostages are children. The stone’s cracks are full of their names.*
 9. **Grave Offense** — A burial field disturbed; omens ride with the news. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[OMEN]’ *The ancestors are angry. They have a list. Your name may be on it. The list is carved on a ship’s prow. The stone’s new crack is shaped like a finger pointing.*
 10. **Port Clash** — Lantern-law vs. street-law; confiscations bloom. ‘[LAW]’ ‘[TRADE]’ *The lanterns were moved last night. The old safe channel is now a reef. The harbor master is not answering questions. He is listening to the stone.*
- J **Warband Flip** — Colors change mid-pay; hostage protocol snaps shut. ‘[MILITARY]’ ‘[BETRAYAL]’ *The hostages are eating well. Their captors are not. The captain’s new banner is stitched with his old captain’s hair. The stone’s crack has grown wider.*
- Q **Restoration Preacher** — Stirs crowds against the “barbarian king in purple.” ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[FEAR]’ *The preacher’s license was signed by a dead abbot. The seal is still warm. The crowd does not know. The stone does not care.*
- K **General Levy** — The march is closed; markets freeze into spears. ‘[MILITARY]’ ‘[SUPPLY]’ *The levy notice is posted in three languages. None of them are local. The tax collector has a bow. The stone has stopped listening.*
- A **Spring Melt** — Eats the Wolf Road; proofs, plans, and armies bog. ‘[WEATHER]’ ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The road is a memory. The ruts fill with water — and older things. The bridge keeper is fishing for boots. The stone’s crack is now a chasm.*

(Charter/Right/Escort) Foedus Renewal Seal for settlement and stipends; Mallus Bench-Right to hold court under the oak.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Foedus Seal** — Settlement and stipends confirmed for a season. ‘[LAW]’ *The seal is a bronze wolf’s head. It warms when the treaty holds — and cools when it doesn’t. The wolf’s eyes are garnets. One eye is cracked.*
3. **Mallus Right** — Hold court under the oak and be obeyed. ‘[LAW]’ *The oak is older than the kingdom. Its roots have seen more verdicts than the throne. The acorns are bitter. The oak’s leaves are falling early.*
4. **Stipend Arrears** — Paid in salt and grain; portable, persuasive. ‘[SUPPLY]’ *The salt is grey. The grain is from last harvest. Both are worth more than coin. The soldiers will accept. The stone will not.*
5. **Utaran Patent** — Citizenship-style privilege; doors open, bows deepen. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The patent is a worn scrap of vellum. It has been folded and refolded for a century. The seal is a sunburst. The sunburst is fading.*
6. **Stall-Right** — Customs favor on a frontier market line. ‘[TRADE]’ *The stall is a painted plank. Plant it, and the tax man will pretend not to see you. He will remember the favour. The stone will not.*
7. **Hostage Treaty** — Exchange fosters; grudges trade for leverage. ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[OATH]’ *The hostages are children. Their parents are patient. The treaty has nine clauses. The ninth is unspoken. The stone has forgotten the first eight.*
8. **Remount Allotment** — Fresh horses from royal paddocks, no questions. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The horses are from the king’s own herd. They know the roads better than you. They also know the king’s secrets. They refuse to cross the stone’s shadow.*
9. **Wergild Table** — Recognized by both codes; vengeance priced and paid. ‘[LAW]’ ‘[DEBT]’ *The table is a slate slab. The prices are carved deep — and often recarved. The newest price is a year of rain. The rain is washing away the carvings.*
10. **Bridge Farm** — Imperial for a season; funds and friends accrue. ‘[TRADE]’ *The bridge toll is a copper a head. The bridge keeper is your new best friend. He also keeps a list of your enemies. He scratches the list on the stone.*
- J **Purple Warrant** — Wear the stripe; officials defer on sight. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The stripe is a sash. It was a curtain in a past life. The present life is yours. Do not lose it. The stone’s crack has swallowed one like it.*
- Q **Queen’s Audience** — Private; a whisper becomes policy. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The audience is held in a garden. The flowers are listening. The gardener is a spy. The gardener is also the queen. She keeps a piece of the stone under her tongue.*
- K **Dux Commission** — Command a mixed unit with pay authority. ‘[MILITARY]’ *The commission is a baton. It doubles as a mace in a pinch. It also doubles as a receipt. The receipt is overdue. The stone has a receipt for the stone.*
- A **Great Law Day** — Proclaim a new concord; one temporary exception to old law. ‘[LAW]’ ‘[LEGEND]’ *The proclamation is made at noon. By sunset, everyone will have an opinion. By dawn, the Foedus Stone will have a new finger — or a new crack.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).

- Diamonds are codified outcomes (charters/rights/escorts) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **law and bond** motifs — oaths that bind, stones that witness, treaties that remember every hand — but also **cracks and forgetting**.

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **The Witness Fading Clock [8]:** Tracks the erosion of Vilikari legal authority. **Ticks** when:
 - The party defies a Vilikari judgment or brings a dispute to an outside court (+1)
 - The GM spends 2 SB to represent a forgotten oath (+1)
 - A foreign envoy (Ykrul, Ecktorian, etc.) publicly ignores a Vilikari ruling (+1)

At 4 segments: Any Vilikari NPC the party interacts with suffers –1 die to social rolls (they doubt their own authority). The stone’s cracks are visible to all. **At 8 segments:** The Foedus Stone cracks completely. The Vilikari are no longer recognized as a neutral party. The Ykrul and Ecktorians begin fighting over their land. The party can reset the clock only by **renewing the treaty** — finding a witness older than the stone itself (a Lethai-al elder, a Trow, a ghost of the original signatory) and having them speak the oath aloud.
- **Two-Law Balance:** Whenever a *jurisdictional conflict* arises (mallus vs. basilica, oak vs. marble), players may step Position up by citing the Foedus Stone or an older precedent — but every use adds a tick to a **Two-Law** [4] clock. When it fills, one side demands exclusive authority. The other side sharpens its knives. If the Witness Fading Clock is at 4+, this clock ticks twice as fast.
- **Frontier Diplomacy:** If a *Heart* card involves a foreign envoy, a federate, or a mixed-blood courtier, treat the first **Diamond** played in the scene as doubled leverage. Once per session, a deal struck reverberates — advance or start a **Border Tension** front. If the Witness Fading Clock is at 6+, the deal also ticks the clock by 1 (the stone forgets another clause).
- **March Markets:** At any *Staple Market, Ford, or Bridge*, Diamonds tied to rights or escorts may be cashed as currency in lieu of coin, one-for-one. Doing so creates a **Ledger Debt** that the GM may call in later through factions or raiders. The debt is never written. It is remembered — until the stone forgets.
- **The Vilikari Diaspora (Ecktoria & Acasia):** Vilikari characters in Ecktoria gain +1 die on Streetwise checks (they know the back alleys and the bribes), but –1 die on social rolls with Old Blood patricians (who see them as upstarts). In Acasia, they gain +1 die on Survival checks (their ancestors were farmers here) but –1 die on social rolls with the Curse-touched (who remember imperial tax collectors). A Vilikari character may start with one “family ledger” — a minor asset that tracks a single unpaid favour across generations. If the Witness Fading Clock ever fills, the ledger turns to ash.
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
 - **The Two-Faced King** — Mykkiel. *Justice that wears a laurel and a wolf’s tail.*
 - **The Hearth Judge** — The Witness. *The flame that watches both sides of the bargain.*
 - **The Oak Father** — Grimmer. *The root that holds the law; the branch that signs the treaty.*
 - **The Coin Saint** — Maelstraeus. *Interest on a handshake; the ledger that never sleeps.*

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Smugglers’ Covenant (The Sealed Gate):** Vilikari pilots who run the Kahfagian coast swear by a secret oath to the *Unlatched Lock* — a threshold that never fully closes. They leave a copper nail at every hidden cove. A captain who breaks the covenant finds that their boat will not cross the tide line; the sea simply refuses to carry them. The Kahfagian Admiralty has tried to bribe the covenant’s keeper; he accepted the coin and sank the next morning in calm water. The stone’s newest crack appeared that same night.
- **Saint Theodora of the Dual Writ (The Witness):** A march notary who uncovered a Fenwood spy in the Federate King’s court. She forced the spy to sign a confession under both oak and marble, then burned the oak copy and kept the marble one. The spy vanished, but his signature appears on every broken treaty in Vilikari history. Her quill is kept in the Dux’s Palace; it writes in lemon juice, and the truth it records cannot be erased by fire or water. The stone’s cracks drink the juice.
- **The Host of the Two Ledgers (The Longhouse Healers):** A hospice near the Foedus Stone is run by grey-robed healers who ask no payment. They treat wounded raiders from both sides of the steppe, and the Ykrul and Ecktorian captains have agreed to a truce around its doors. The Federate King tolerates them because they also hold the rite of the *Unbuckled Oath* — a ceremony where a knight may renounce a blood-debt without losing honour, by placing their sword on the stone and speaking a single true regret. The stone remembers these regrets. It has many.
- **The Ostrihari Cousins (The Savage Heart):** The eastern Vilikari, called Ostrihari by lowlanders, are no more savage than any frontier people. Their reputation comes from the bear cults of the upper Wolf Road, where initiates wear cured skins and speak in growls. The Ostrihari do not raid Vilikari villages; they trade furs for iron and send their young to serve as mercenaries in the Black Banners. A Vilikari proverb says: “The Ostrihari sharpen their teeth on stone, not on kin.” The stone does not mind. It has no teeth left.
- **The Ninth:** In any Vilikari scene, the ninth witness called to a mallus court is always a ghost. The wise stop at eight and settle out of court. Those who call a ninth witness find that the ghost speaks the truth — but the truth is always the worst possible version, and the living witnesses remember it as their own. The stone’s cracks are full of these truths.

Vilikari Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Stone:** Crumble a crust at the base of the Foedus Stone. Ignore the first *Law Tangle* penalty. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Knot the Braid:** Tie a single knot in a horse’s tail. Cancel *Annona Late* or take –1 die on your next supply roll (your choice). ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Name to the Oak:** Whisper a dead enemy’s name into the hollow of the mallus oak. Gain +1 Effect when collecting wergild from their kin this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Elder of Elders. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Press the Crack (new):** Touch the newest crack in the Foedus Stone and speak a promise you intend to break. Gain +1 die on your next deception roll, but the stone will remember your name. The Hollow will too. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **march officials or tribal elders**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **levy guards or market patrols**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or treaty keepers**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favorable legal window**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.
- **Crack Whispers (Vilikari only):** A character hears the stone whispering a forgotten promise. They must test Resolve (DV 3) or mark 1 Fatigue.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised: Horse-Reeve or March Notary** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **legal challenge or border closure**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **rival faction or warband** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.
- **Witness Fading:** Advance the **Witness Fading Clock** by 1 segment (the stone forgets something).

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **shield-brothers, levy forces, or foreign troops** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **treaty voided/levy called/border dispute erupts**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.
- **Stone Speaks:** The Foedus Stone whispers a forgotten clause that invalidates a character's legal protection for the scene.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival: Federate King, Queen of Marches, or Elder of Elders** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **raid hits/levy called/treaty breaks**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.
- **Crack Splits:** The Foedus Stone's newest crack widens. One of the party's active Diamonds is lost (crumbles to dust).

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Vilikari (Two Laws):** Legal documents contradict each other, courts issue conflicting rulings, oaths bind to different authorities. The stone's cracks eat ink.

- **Vilikari (Frontier Diplomacy):** Treaties expire without warning, foreign envoys demand additional concessions, mixed-blood courtiers shift allegiances. The stone forgets who signed what.
- **Vilikari (Border Tensions):** Frontier posts close without notice, markets shift locations, safe-conducts are revoked mid-journey. The stone’s shadow grows longer.

Boss Seeds (three-phase foes)

- **The March Notary (quills like daggers)** — *Phases:* Citation Tangle → Seal Swap → Precedent Trap. *Cracks:* produce a **Foedus Seal** to quiet him; a **Queen’s Audience** overrules his filing. If the Witness Fading Clock is at 6+, he gains +1 die in all phases (the stone supports him).
- **Ykrul Storm-Rider (wolf-cloak, bone whistle)** — *Phases:* Raid Cry → Herd Stampede → Blood Price. *Cracks:* a **Wergild Table** settles the feud without combat; a **Hostage Treaty** buys a season’s peace. He fights harder if the stone is cracked (he smells weakness).
- **The Prefect’s Auditor (Ecktorial ink on his fingers)** — *Phases:* Ledger Seizure → Tax Levy → Fort Closure. *Cracks:* an **Utaran Patent** grants immunity; a **Mallus Right** transfers jurisdiction to the oak. He carries a piece of the stone in his pocket; if the party takes it, the Witness Fading Clock resets by 2.
- **The Stone’s Ghost (Foedus Avatar)** — *Phases:* Whisper of Forgotten Clauses → Crack Widens → The Hollow Steps Through. *Cracks:* speak the original treaty aloud (requires a Lethai-al witness), repair the stone with a memory of a kept promise, or sacrifice a personal oath to feed the stone instead of the Hollow.

Extensions (Plug-in)

- **Two-Law Dial (Oak ↔ Marble):** Track which legal tradition holds sway.
 - *Oak High:* +1 Position when invoking mallus, blood-price, or tribal custom; first basilica petition starts one step worse.
 - *Marble High:* +1 Effect when citing charters, patents, or Utaran precedent; first mallus oath starts one step worse.
 - Center the dial by offering a wergild recognized by both sides or hosting a joint moot. If the Witness Fading Clock is at 4+, centering requires a sacrifice (a memory, a name, a drop of blood on the stone).
- **Treaty-Feast Procedure (fast diplomacy):**
 1. **Set the Table:** Name 2–3 *terms* (what both sides want) and 1 *taboo* (off-limits).
 2. **First Cup (Position):** Roll a social test; success grants +1 die to bargain, failure grants the host 1 SB.
 3. **Bread & Salt (Offer):** Put *one* leverage on the table (Diamond or oath-promise). Host matches with an obligation (escort, market access, or hostage).
 4. **Smoke (Complication):** The GM reveals a pressure tied to *Old Grudges* or *Two Laws*. Resolve it or accept a *Rider Clause*.
 5. **Knot the Braid:** On success, create a **Feast-Bond** [3] clock that protects both parties from betrayal in that matter while it has segments; on breach, the breaker immediately takes 1–2 SB and the clock flips to **Blood-Owed** [3].

6. **Stone Witness:** If the Feast-Bond is sworn at the Foedus Stone, it also reduces the Witness Fading Clock by 1. The stone remembers one more promise.
- **Frontier Market (quick trading):**
 - At any *Staple Market* or *Stone Ford*, players may convert a held $\Diamond$ into a *Market Edge* (+1d to all buy/sell rolls).
 - Each conversion ticks a **Market Knives** [4] clock for that locale. When it fills, a rival factor challenges your right to trade — face a duel, a bribe demand, or a confiscation.
 - If the Witness Fading Clock is at 6+, the rival factor is a ghost — a forgotten signatory of the Foedus Stone. The duel is a legal dream-duel.
 - **Start-of-Scene Omens (1d6):**
 1. *Laurel Wilt:* first legal action gains +1d; first boast draws **Law Tangle**.
 2. *Smoke on the Steppe:* **Raid Rumor** advances once; shortcuts open.
 3. *Twin Bells:* both courts are in session; pick a side or start **Law Tangle**.
 4. *Queen's Dove:* a message arrives; +1d on the next **Queen's Audience**.
 5. *Grey Salt:* **Stipend Arrears** counts double value today; smugglers' ears open.
 6. *Old Eagle:* an Utaran relic surfaces; **Utaran Patent** use is free this scene.
 7. *Crack Light (special when Witness Fading Clock 4):* The stone glows. The next legal argument made at the stone is automatically binding — for both sides.
 - **Plug-in SB Conversions (Vilikari Flavor):**
 - 1 SB $\rightarrow$ *Seal Crack:* a writ loses half its value until re-witnessed.
 - 2 SB $\rightarrow$ *Citation War:* increase DV by 1 unless you produce a precedent (spend a $\Diamond$ or recall a past ruling).
 - 3+ SB $\rightarrow$ *Crown Fracture:* a treaty splits; halve a consequence by accepting a rival's seal on your paper (start **Two-Law** clock).
 - 2 SB (Vilikari only) $\rightarrow$ *Stone Whisper:* The Foedus Stone reveals a forgotten clause. The GM must answer one yes/no question about a treaty or oath in the region.
 - **Reputation Echoes:**
 - *Court-Favored:* once/session, downgrade **Law Tangle** to a minor delay; the next document you present is scrutinized (+1 DV).
 - *Raid-Tested:* +1 Position when evading Ykrul or Black Banners; supply lines run 1 segment longer.
 - *Neutral Broker:* +1d with both oak and marble in a treaty scene; any betrayal earns **Blood-Owed** [2] from both sides.
 - *Stone-Marked (gained by renewing the treaty):* The Foedus Stone remembers your name. Once per session, you may reroll a failed social roll involving a Vilikari or a treaty. The stone will ask for a memory in return.
 - **Cross-Region Hooks (quick integration):**
 - *Kahfagia (Lantern-Law):* A **Foedus Seal** may stand in for a *Safe-Conduct* along a beaconed lane once. Doing so starts **Port Clash** [2] in the next harbor touched.
 - *Ecktoria (Imperial Remnants):* An **Utaran Patent** counts as either *Archive Hour* (scholars open doors) or *Icon License* (display symbols) in Ecktorial sites — choose once per session.

- *Aelerian Mountains (Pass & Toll)*: A **Pass-Ring** (from the Aeler expansion) grants priority at dwarf switchbacks; cashing it to bypass inspection spawns **Ledger Notice** [3].
- *Direwood (Breath & Bells)*: Spending **Stipend Arrears** for levee labor converts one Direwood **Clubs** draw into a *Ward-Salt* Diamond for a scene, then begins **Names Disputed** [3] with bell-wardens.
- *Acasia (Curse Tithe)*: A **Wergild Table** accepted by a Curse-touched village also clears one *Feud Spark* clock, but the Hollow gains +1 Attention.
- *Lethai-ar Silk Bridges*: A **Hostage Treaty** can be witnessed by a Lethai-ar silk-warden, making it binding across the Crimson Valley. The price is a strand of the treaty-bearer’s hair.

Patronage & Power

In Vilikari society, power flows through the careful balance of multiple legal traditions, the management of frontier diplomacy, and the maintenance of complex oaths and treaties. The Federate King maintains authority through a combination of imperial forms and traditional customs, while local leaders wield influence through their knowledge of both Utaran law and tribal custom. The true power lies with those who can navigate this complex legal and diplomatic landscape while maintaining the loyalty of their people and the respect of their neighbors.

But the stone is cracking. The witnesses are dying. The Vilikari are becoming *invisible*.

For the GM: Patronage in Vilikari society revolves around legal documents, diplomatic relationships, and the ability to command respect from institutions that operate under multiple legal systems. Rewards often take the form of treaties, charters, and official positions that can be leveraged into greater influence. To emphasize the hybrid identity and the fading authority:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (seals, writs, treaties) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided — and that may crumble if the stone forgets.
- Let rival legal systems issue conflicting authorities, forcing players to choose whose favour matters more. Neither may remember them tomorrow.
- Use the courts, markets, and frontier posts as arenas for social contests, where knowledge of law and custom determines success — and where the stone’s whispers can tip the balance.
- Remember that Vilikari characters are at home in Ecktoria’s counting-houses and Acasia’s hedgerow courts alike — but they are never fully trusted in either. That suspicion is their best tool. When the stone cracks fully, that suspicion becomes exile.

In Vilikari society, your word is your bond, and your bond determines whether you rule or are ruled. But a bond is only as strong as the stone that witnesses it. And the stone is forgetting.

Chapter 11

Black Banners

Condotta & Crowns.

A contract is only as good as the next payday, and a grudge is only as sharp as the sword backing it. In this game, we sell steel by the season and vendettas by the year.

I am a Veteran Sergeant. I've seen three captains rise and fall in the time it takes to grow a beard, but the mud stays the same and the pay comes when it pleases.

Mercenary companies sell steel to the highest bidder—and oh, how they love a good spreadsheet. The Banner-Captains don't just want payment; they want proof they're getting their money's worth, which is why they pay in safe-conducts that are good until the next battle... and utterly worthless after, once the smoke clears and the ledgers need balancing.

The camp sings when payday comes. The camp falls silent when the ledger is written in blood. I've heard both. I prefer the singing. At least the singing means you're still alive.

Never break a Bell Dawn. Three bells at sunrise means bury the dead, trade prisoners, fix the wells, no ambushes. Violating it is how legends end badly—and how captains end hanging.

— *Old Sorka, Veteran Sergeant, who counts scars like coins and spends them on whiskey and mercy*

The Almanac of Ordinary Days

What do people eat for breakfast? Hardtack and camp stew—the stew is whatever was caught, killed, or traded for before dawn. The cook is called "The Alchemist." No one knows their real name. No one asks.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To count coin. Camp children are taught to tally pay shares before they can read. A child who miscounts is a child who will go hungry. A child who goes hungry is a child who learns to count faster.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their colours. Every Black Banner company has its own banner—lantern, thorn, bell, fishbone, broken scale. A stranger whose colours are faded has been running. A stranger whose colours are too bright has never fought. A stranger with no colours has no company. A stranger with no company is a deserter. A deserter is a liability. A liability is a corpse.

What is the most common crime? Desertion—but desertion is not a crime, it is a negotiation. A soldier who wants to leave will sell their gear to the quartermaster, sell their secrets to the enemy, and sell their silence to the captain. The price is negotiable. The price is always "one more season."

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Black Colonel is not a person. The Colonel is a title held by a wax seal. The seal is kept in a lead-lined box. The box is carried by a mute lieutenant. The lieutenant signs documents with the Colonel's thumb-print. The thumb-print is a forgery. The forger is the lieutenant. The lieutenant has no thumbs.

Where do people go when they die? To the pyre. Camp dead are burned in a bonfire of broken spears and banner poles. The ashes are scattered by the quartermaster. The quartermaster charges a fee. The fee is deducted from the dead's final pay. The final pay is never enough.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You stand a watch. The wronged party chooses the hour—midnight, dawn, the dead of winter. You stand alone. If you survive, you are forgiven. If you do not, the debt is paid. The camp does not mourn. The camp does not forget.

What is the most important festival? Payday—but payday is not a day, it is a negotiation. The captain promises payment on the first of the month. The quartermaster promises payment when the supply train arrives. The soldiers promise loyalty until the payment comes. The payment never comes. The loyalty never ends.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Banner-Captain's contract is written in disappearing ink. The ink was supplied by a Sidhi forger who was paid in promises. The promises were not kept. The forger is now a camp follower. The forger knows where the contract is hidden. The forger is waiting for the right offer.

11.1 Black Banners — “Condotta & Crowns”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *A contract is only as good as the next payday.*

Banner-Captain (Elite): “A contract is only as good as the next payday, and a grudge is only as sharp as the sword backing it. In this game, we sell steel by the season and vendettas by the year.”

Veteran Sergeant (Commoner): “I’ve seen three captains rise and fall in the time it takes to grow a beard, but the mud stays the same and the pay comes when it pleases. Best keep your own counsel and your blade sharp. The camp sings? You live. They stop singing? Even the best charter bleeds.”

Genre / Mood: Mercenary realism, winter warfare, ledger-driven violence.

Starting Location: A war-camp crossroads where two banners snap in the same wind, their sigils bleeding into one another. A Condotta broker with ink-stained fingers lays two contracts on a barrel — one from Ecktoria, one from Ykrul. “Pick a war. Pick a grave. The bell tolls at noon.”

Condotta & Crowns

Ecktorian treasuries bankroll a perpetual border-war they claim to be *containing*. In truth, the gold keeps the fire burning. The Black Banners are mercenary leagues — ex-Utaran legionaries, second-sons, debt-dodgers, and exiles — who sell steel to the highest bidder, today’s ally becoming tomorrow’s quarry. Between them move the Ykrul steppe-clans (swift, pragmatic, oath-canny) and the Vilikari hill tribes (crafty, patient, and proud). Ecktorian ministers call it “pressure management.” The companies call it a season.

What you notice first: The smell of wet wool and old blood. The way every tent has a ledger pinned to its flap. The silence when the paychest is opened — and the murmur when it’s light.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never break a Bell Dawn. Three bells at sunrise means bury the dead, trade prisoners, fix the wells, no ambushes. Violating it is how legends end badly — and how captains end hanging.

Regional Mood: The Theater of Banners

Here, war is a marketplace. The Black Banners are not a single army but a squabbling league of freelance violence, bound by camp law, pay customs, and the shared knowledge that tomorrow’s enemy might be today’s employer. The real battles are fought in counting-tents over clauses and riders; the clash outside is just the audit. Loyalty is a coin that fluctuates with the market, and a captain’s true skill lies in reading the political winds that blow across contested borders. Between the rigid honour codes of Ecktorian nobility and the fluid pragmatism of steppe clans and hill tribes, mercenaries navigate a dangerous middle ground where survival depends on knowing when to keep an oath and when to break one — always at dawn, with a witness, and with surety paid.

Prominent NPCs of the Black Banners

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Castellan Thorne	Banner-Captain of the Iron Hand	Win a permanent contract for his company	He has never lost a siege, but he has lost three paychests to bad debt.
Old Sorka	Veteran Sergeant (commoner exemplar)	Keep her squad alive until spring	She counts scars like coins; her left ear is a nub from a mutineer's apology.
Lys	Condotta Broker	Flip contracts for maximum margin	Her ink has a metallic smell. She says it's from the silver in the seals.
Chaghan	Ykrul Clan Emissary	Test the Black Banners' honour before the next migration	He speaks only in proverbs and pays in copper from a cursed mine.
Volund	Quartermaster-Provost	Stockpile leverage on every officer in the camp	His bribe book is thicker than his roster; he calls it "risk assessment."
The Bannerless One	Mysterious warlord	Unite the scattered companies under a single will	She has no flag. Men follow her because she asked.

Names of the Black Banners

Names here are a polyglot stew – Acasian grit, Ecktorian formality, Ykrul harshness, Vilikari cadence, and the nicknames that arise from a season in the mud. Surnames may be patronymic, a place of origin, or a battlefield epithet.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Castellan	Sorka	Thornson	<i>the Iron</i>
Chaghan	Lys	Volund	<i>the Red-Tally</i>
Orthen	Maeva	Kaeldottir	<i>Bell-Breaker</i>
Rurik	Veleda	dei Conti	<i>the Unpaid</i>

Bromm	Gisela	Halvkirk	<i>White-Ribbon</i>
Zelgur	Thorn	Flint	<i>Ash-Foot</i>

(**Camps/Battlefields/Fortresses/War-roads**) Burned village turned field-hospital; flies, tinctures, and fever-prayers. Frozen ford with last month’s dead held under glass; standards trapped in the ice.

Spades — Places

2. **Burned Village** – Field-hospital; flies, tinctures, fever-prayers. ‘[DEATH]’ *The flies are fat. They’ve eaten well this season.*
 3. **Frozen Ford** – Last month’s dead held under glass; standards trapped in the ice. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[WEATHER]’ *The ice is clear — clear enough to read the terror on their faces.*
 4. **Latrine Row** – At dusk; mud, shame, whispered mutiny, a sergeant who hears too well. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The sergeant’s ears are scarred. He listened to a mutiny once and survived.*
 5. **Crater Pasture** – From an alchemical barrage; in spring, glass flowers sprout like guilt. ‘[MAGIC]’ *The flowers cut. They remember the hands that sowed them.*
 6. **Supply Road** – Twelve broken wagons; oxen nose the wreckage for salt. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The salt is from a burned caravan. The oxen are from the same village.*
 7. **Half-Raised Siege Tower** – In an abandoned camp; every rung creaks with grudges. ‘[COMBAT]’ *The tower was paid for twice. It still leans toward the richer patron.*
 8. **Salt-Cured Cache** – Behind the surgeon’s tent; the wrong kind of maggots move. ‘[DEATH]’ *The maggots have a pattern. It spells a name — yours, or the surgeon’s.*
 9. **Command Tent** – Maps show borders that diplomacy has already erased. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The maps were drawn by a clerk who died last winter. He was still updating them.*
 10. **Watch-Tower** – Stacked from skulls and slate; the crows know the countersign. ‘[WAR]’ *The crows are paid in eyes. They are very well paid.*
- J **Ancient March-Keep** – Held by a skeleton garrison of veterans; they remember when the banners were gold. ‘[DEATH]’ *The veterans are dead. They just haven’t noticed yet.*
- Q **The Bone Fields** – Where Ykrul elders parley among cairns and reckon oaths with the dead. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[OATH]’ *The dead vote. Their votes are always for war.*
- K **Marcher’s Fortress** – Three walls, two sieges’ scars, one gate that opens inward only. ‘[COMBAT]’ *The gate opens inward so the dead can leave. The living are not invited.*
- A **The Singing Wastes** – Fallen weapons hum with the voices of their last wielders on a wind that tastes of iron. ‘[MAGIC]’ ‘[DEATH]’ *The hum is a petition. The dead want their names back.*

(**Captains/Cadets/Clans/Tribes**) Young cadet with a father’s sword and a mother’s debt; veteran sergeant who counts scars like coins — and spends them on whiskey and mercy.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Young Cadet** – Father’s sword, mother’s debt, and a hunger to prove himself. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The sword is old. The debt is older. Both weigh the same.*

3. **Veteran Sergeant** – Counts scars like coins — spends them on whiskey and mercy. ‘[COMBAT]’ ‘[SOCIAL]’ *His left ear is gone. He says a mutineer took it. He says the mutineer apologized.*
4. **Ecktorian Banner-Captain** – Griffon standard, a ledger of noble grudges, and a smile like a winter. ‘[LAW]’ *The griffon’s eyes are rubies. They were looted from a temple. The god still watches.*
5. **Condotta Broker** – Changes colours when the wind turns, but always lands on his feet. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *His feet are calloused from landing. He has never broken an ankle.*
6. **Ykrul Clan Emissary** – Speaks in riddled proverbs and pays in copper and promises. ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[OATH]’ *The copper is from a cursed mine. The promises are from a cursed tongue.*
7. **Vilikari War-Chief’s Second Son** – Honour burns brighter than his father’s patience. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *His father’s patience is measured in seasons. This is the last season.*
8. **Surgeon of the Red Ledger** – Treats friend and foe alike; her ledger balances only in blood. ‘[DEBT]’ *Her ledger is bound in human skin. The skin was a gift from a patient who lived.*
9. **Quartermaster** – Knows where every coin went and every man will fall. ‘[DEBT]’ *His bribe book is thicker than his roster. He calls it “risk assessment.”*
10. **Tribune’s Aide-de-Camp** – Sealed orders that contradict the general’s intent. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The general’s intent was to retire. The seals say otherwise.*
- J **The Black Colonel** – Legendary commander not seen in the line for months, yet his banner still rides. ‘[LEGEND]’ *The banner rides alone. The horse is riderless. The men follow anyway.*
- Q **Ykrul Clan-Mother** – Weaves war-braids from the hair of oath-breakers. ‘[OATH]’ *Each braid has a name. The names are still attached.*
- K **Vilikari High Chief** – Trades mercenaries like game pieces and never tips the board. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The board is an old treaty map. The pieces are real.*
- A **The Bannerless One** – Commands loyalty without rank or flag; men follow because they want to. ‘[LEGEND]’ *They follow into the Singing Wastes. They follow into the ice. They follow because she asked.*

(Betrayals/Weather/Politics/War) Payday delayed; supplies die before coin arrives. False orders: your target is now your ally — on paper. Blizzard pins two rival companies in the same cloister; vows and knives both come out.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Payday Delayed** – Supplies die before coin arrives. ‘[DEBT]’ *The coin was eaten by interest. The interest has teeth.*
3. **False Orders** – Your target is now your ally — on paper. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The paper is from a dead notary. The signature is warm.*
4. **Blizzard Pins** – Two rival companies, one cloister; vows and knives both come out. ‘[WEATHER]’ ‘[COMBAT]’ *The cloister’s abbot is counting. He will sell the winner’s story.*
5. **Ykrul Counter-Offer** – Better terms than Ecktoria; your contract becomes a liability. ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[DEBT]’ *The terms are written in salt. They will dissolve in rain — or blood.*

6. **Condotta Flip** – Unit switches colours mid-battle; your “relief” hits your flank. ‘[COMBAT]’
The new colours are the same as the old colours. The captain just wanted a raise.
7. **Camp-Fever** – Blooms in the surgeon’s tent; the counting-house for the dead. ‘[DEATH]’
The fever has a face. It is the face of a soldier you left behind.
8. **Vilikari Raid** – Cuts your supply road; winter moves the schedule. ‘[COMBAT]’ ‘[TRAVEL]’
The raiders took the salt and left a recipe. The recipe calls for tears.
9. **Honour Code Collision** – Ecktorian ideals vs. mercenary pragmatism; the camp splits by doctrine. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The doctrine is written on a napkin. The napkin is from a feast that ended badly.*
10. **Tribune Captured** – The aide must choose: the rescue or the war. ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[DEBT]’
The war is a ledger. The rescue is a name. Names are heavier than ledgers.
- J **Black Colonel’s Banner** – Appears on the wrong field; confusion is a weapon. ‘[COMBAT]’
The banner is frayed. It has seen too many wrong fields.
- Q **Blood-Feast** – Clan-Mother calls it; all contracts suspended until dawn’s judgment. ‘[OATH]’
‘[SOCIAL]’ *The judgment is a feast. The feast is a trial. The trial is a knife.*
- K **High Chief’s Game** – Plays companies against each other; “winner” takes obligations, not spoils. ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[DEBT]’ *The obligations are written in invisible ink. You will see them when it is too late.*
- A **The Singing Wastes Awaken** – Every fallen blade rises to seek its last hand. ‘[MAGIC]’
‘[DEATH]’ *The blades remember the grip. They do not remember mercy.*

(Contracts/Claims/Dispensations) Emergency requisition — strip a fallen company for what you need (and their ghosts for what they’re owed). Dual contract — serve two masters with goals that cannot both be met.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Emergency Requisition** – Strip a fallen company; their ghosts watch. ‘[DEBT]’ *The ghosts will remember. They will collect.*
3. **Dual Contract** – Serve two masters whose goals cannot both be met. ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[DEBT]’
The masters are both paying. The interest is your reputation.
4. **Honour Dispensation** – Your acts are justified regardless of code (for now). ‘[SOCIAL]’
The dispensation is a bell. Ring it, and the tribunal looks away — once.
5. **Condotta Rider’s Pass** – Cross any camp perimeter unchallenged. ‘[STEALTH]’ *The pass is a feather. The feather is from a messenger who arrived too late.*
6. **Ykrul Safe-Conduct Token** – Pass a named clan’s lands unmolested (until the moon changes). ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The token is a horse’s tooth. The horse was a gift from a Khagan. The Khagan is dead.*
7. **Vilikari War-Mark** – Their scouts guide you through hostile hills — and remember the favour. ‘[TRAVEL]’ ‘[DEBT]’ *The favour will be called at dawn. The location will be a ridge. The odds will be even.*
8. **Surgeon’s Debt-Note** – Medical care when no coin remains; the interest is names. ‘[DEBT]’
The names are of people who owe the surgeon. You are now one of them.
9. **Tribune’s Cipher Ring** – Decode orders that do not exist yet. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The ring is warm. The future is cold.*

10. **Banner-Captain's Seal** – Commandeer resources from junior companies (and their resentment). '[AUTHORITY]' *The seal is a skull. The jaw moves when you press it.*
- J **Field Promotion Warrant** – Assume command of a shattered unit, inherit its clocks. '[AUTHORITY]' '[DEBT]' *The clocks are ticking. The unit is watching.*
- Q **Clan-Mother's War-Braids** – Her chosen fight beside you this battle, then judge you after. '[COMBAT]' '[SOCIAL]' *The judgment is a song. The song will be sung at your funeral.*
- K **High Chief's Trading Charter** – Buy or sell *anything* in any camp, no questions asked aloud. '[TRADE]' *The questions are asked in silence. The answers are paid in silence.*
- A **The Bannerless Word** – Loyalty that outruns rank, law, and coin. '[LEGEND]' *The word is a whisper. The whisper is a promise. The promise is a grave.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (contracts/claims/dispositions) that shift position rather than call for a roll.
- If any Ace appears, echo war and winter motifs — ice that keeps the dead, weapons that remember, loyalty that needs no banner.

The Fractured League: Banner Alignments

The Black Banners are not a single army but a squabbling market of violence. Three loose alignments shape the loyalties of any war-camp. Most companies shift between these poles depending on the season, the paychest, and the weather.

- **Condotta Brokers (The Paper Men)** – They own the contracts, not the swords. They flip companies like playing cards and measure victory in percentages. Most captains hate them, but everyone pays them. *Clocks: BROKER'S GRIP [4], DOUBLE CHARTER [6].*
- **Company Loyalists (The Old Banners)** – Veterans who remember when a banner meant a blood-oath, not a season's wage. They grumble, they desert, they are sometimes bought – but they fight like demons when the paychest is full. *Clocks: VETERAN WRATH [4], OATH REMEMBERS [6].*
- **Free Companies (The Tide)** – Newly raised, culturally mixed, and chronically unpaid. They are as likely to mutiny as to charge, and their loyalty can be bought with a hot meal and a day's rest. *Clocks: MUTINY WHISPER [4], PAYDAY FEVER [6].*

Superimposed on these are the **Ykrul steppe-clans** (honour-bound, quick to take insult) and the **Vilikari hill tribes** (pragmatic, patient, and skilled at ambush). A wise captain learns to read all three.

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **Payday & Supply Clocks:** Track two pressures common to the Black Banners: **Payday** [4] and **Supply** [4]. When Payday fills, morale falters and the Keeper may peel away a squad or impose a desertion SB. When Supply fills, all risky maneuvers begin one step worse Position until the players secure fresh provisions or bargain a Diamond.

- **Allegiances in Flux:** At the start of a scene, roll 1d6 to see if loyalties shift:
 1. Condotta broker flips colours mid-parley.
 2. Ykrul emissary offers better terms; accept and mark Obligation, or refuse and tick Payday.
 3. Vilikari scouts reveal a shortcut; gain +1 Effect but risk SB from hostile terrain.
 4. Ecktorian clerk “corrects” your orders; obey for +1 Position, defy and gain a Diamond but earn a Black Mark.
 5. Rival captain spreads falsified orders; unless revealed, counters are harder this scene.
 6. The Bannerless One’s messengers arrive; accept their word to clear 1 Payday, but the Keeper gains 1 SB.
- **Honour vs. Pragmatism Dial:** Place a two-step dial between *Honour* and *Pragmatism*.
 - **Honour:** +1 Position in parley or oathbound actions; logistics costs rise faster.
 - **Pragmatism:** +1 Effect in ambushes or sabotage; parley begins one step worse Position.

Center the dial by a symbolic act – repaying arrears, returning prisoners, or honouring a broken writ.
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
 - **The Red Ledger** – Maelstraeus (infernally bargainer). *Every contract signs in blood; every payment accrues interest.*
 - **The White-Ribbon Courier** – The Traveler (roads and shortcuts). *A safe road is a contract; a shortcut is a rider.*
 - **The Unbroken Bell** – The Sealed Gate (threshold guardian). *Bell Dawn is sacred; break it, and the road closes behind you.*
 - **The Bannerless One** – An avatar of Ikasha (freedom and thresholds). *No flag, no oath, no debt – only the road and the choice.*

Mercenary Realpolitik

In the world of the Black Banners, loyalty is a currency that fluctuates with the market. A man’s worth is measured not in noble blood or ancestral holdings, but in the sharpness of his blade and the reliability of his word. The condotta system creates a web of shifting allegiances where today’s enemy may become tomorrow’s employer, and a captain’s true skill lies not in strategy alone but in reading the political winds that blow across contested borders. Between the rigid honour codes of Ecktorian nobility and the fluid pragmatism of steppe clans and hill tribes, mercenaries navigate a dangerous middle ground where survival depends on knowing when to keep an oath and when to break one.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Sealed Gate:** Deserters who flee a losing battle sometimes cross into the Singing Wastes at night. They return at dawn with their mouths sewn shut and a ward-sigil branded on their palms. The Bannerless One pays well for such men – they cannot speak of what they saw, and they never run again.
- **Maelstraeus, the Infernal Bargainer:** A black ledger circulates among the condotta brokers, its pages written in dried blood. A captain who signs it never misses a payday – but the ledger’s interest is collected in souls, not silver. The Bannerless One has refused to touch it. Twice.

- **The Traveler:** Before every major march, a White-Ribbon courier from the Aeler tunnels appears at the edge of camp, plants a brass way-stone, and vanishes by dawn. Companies who follow the stone's direction find safe passage through the worst terrain. Those who ignore it are never seen again.
- **Xhak'Thul, the Thunder-Speaker:** A drummer walks the camp on the night before a battle, beating a rhythm that has no source. Veterans do not look for the drummer; they sleep with their hands over their ears. When the drum stops, the battle begins – and one side will be annihilated by a storm that came from nowhere.
- **The Ninth:** In any war-camp, the ninth tent pitched in a row will collapse before dawn. The wise pitch eight and leave a space. Those who ignore this find that the ground beneath the ninth tent is always damp – and the footprints leading out of it never match any boot in the company.

Black Banner Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Paychest:** Crumble a crust into an empty chest. Ignore the first *Payday Delayed* penalty. '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Knot the Colours:** Tie a single knot in a banner's cord. Cancel *Condotta Flip* or take –1 die on your next morale check (your choice). '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Name to the Wastes:** Whisper a dead captain's name into the wind. Gain +1 Effect when rallying their former unit this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Bannerless One. '[SUPERSTITION]'

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **condotta brokers or camp guards**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **rival companies or camp followers**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or debt collectors**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favourable contract terms**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Banner-Captain or quartermaster** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **blizzard or camp upheaval**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **rival mercenary squad or debt collector** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **free companies, Ykrul riders, or camp enforcers** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes – **contract voided / paychest stolen / Bell Dawn broken**.

- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival: The Bannerless One, Clan-Mother, or Black Colonel** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically – **Singing Wastes awaken / camp splits / blizzard seals the pass.**
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice – **omen appears / blessing lost / curse manifests.**
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Black Banners (Camp Law):** Payday disputes escalate to blades, a banner is stolen, a sergeant calls a mutiny.
- **Black Banners (Winter War):** Frostbite slows movement, supply lines freeze, mercenaries demand double pay or desert.
- **Black Banners (Condotta):** A rival broker offers a better charter, a clause is invoked that voids your contract, a captain demands a duel of honour.

Field Procedures (Use at the Table)

- **Colours & Countersigns:** Declaring correct countersigns cancels the first “False Orders” SB each night; wrong signs worsen Position on first contact.
- **Payline Drill:** If a scene depicts orderly pay, clear 1 *Payday*. If pay is “creative,” clear it but mark *Black Mark* – future officers begin one step colder in parley.
- **Scavenge Doctrine:** After battles, you may gain 1 temporary Gear tag or advance *Supply* by 1; on a 1–2 on 1d6, spawn “Honour vs. Pragmatism” conflict immediately.

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Wits + Survival):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Deep Snow*.
- **Cut the Contract (Presence + Sway):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a Condotta Rider’s Pass is in your possession, +1 die.
- **Weather the Blizzard (Resolve + Endurance):** On a hit in *Blizzard Pins*, you pick who finds shelter; on a miss, the GM does.

Boss Archetypes in the Black Banners

Contract & Command (Human Adversaries)

- **Banner-Captain (Fixer General)** – Wins by paperwork and parade-ground precision. *Break their chain-of-command clock [6] by flipping lieutenants, forging orders, or seizing the paychest.*
- **Condotta Broker (Colour-Flipper)** – Turns loyalties like cards. *Expose a dual contract or force public arbitration under neutral bells to collapse their leverage track.*

- **Quartermaster-Provost (Logistics Tyrant)** – Starves you with ledgers. *Complete the Three Cuts: road, ration, rumor — any two stalls them; all three topple their supply engine.*

Tribe & Tactic (Field Sovereigns)

- **Ykrul Raid-Mother (Oath-Weaver)** – Fights with remounts and safe-hostages. *Honour horse-rites to gain truce windows; break one braid in parley to end a phase.*
- **Vilikari Hill-Fox (Ambush Architect)** – Owns ridgelines and feint paths. *Clear Three High Stones (overwatch, supply cache, signal cairn) to force even ground.*

Faith & Fear (Camp Powers)

- **Field Chaplain-Inquisitor (Morale Engine)** – Smelts guilt into zeal. *Win by sanctifying plague-ground or redeeming prisoners; each rite drops their Zeal track [0–3].*
- **Surgeon of the Red Ledger (Mercy’s Price)** – Keeps units marching past sense. *Expose graft or pay blood-debts; on three reconciled names the operating tent stands down.*

The Unquiet Field (Supernatural Front)

- **The Singing Wastes (Weapon-Host)** – The battlefield itself retaliates. *Complete the Silencing Acts: oil the choir (funeral honours), bury the standards, ring the wind-break bell — each lowers its Tier for one exchange.*
- **Black Colonel’s Banner (Legend in Motion)** – A rumour that commands. *Prove the lie or become the truth: either unmask the courier network (three ciphers cracked) or fly a counter-sigil to pull rank on the myth.*

Faction Entanglements

- **Condotta Brokers’ Syndicate:** Register your charter and bank a *Broker’s Favor* – spend to reduce one parley DV inside a war-camp. Skipping registration flags your unit with *Unauthorised Colors*: the first checkpoint scene gains a free “False Orders” SB.
- **Camp Quartermasters:** Accept ration-scale audits to cancel the first *Supply* tick this leg; refuse and mark a 4-segment *Short Rations* clock that worsens Position on marches.
- **Field Chaplains & Leech-Circles:** Donate time or tithe to clear 1 segment from *Camp-Fever*; if ignored, the Keeper may convert the first 1 SB of a scene into “Disease/Death.”
- **Steppe Envoys:** Honour horse-rites (salt, water, shade) to gain *Remount Rights* – once, treat a retreat as movement with +1 Effect. Break rites and add a *Soured Oath* tag that raises parley DV with riders until cleansed.
- **Hill Truce-Holders:** Enter a stones-circle under their witness to bank a *Blood-Truce* – spend to negate one ambush on hill roads. Violating the circle spawns a 4-segment *Guest Right Forfeit* clock.

Cross-Regional Conversions (Using Diamonds Elsewhere)

- **Vhasia:** A *Condotta Rider’s Pass* can substitute for a *Safe-Conduct* on the Pont-du-Tithe once; after use, start a *Parlement Divided* tick.
- **Viterrra:** A *Ykrul Safe-Conduct Token* may be notarised as a *Ferry Priority* in Viterran courts; the notary’s fee is a story.

- **Ubral:** A *Clan-Mother’s War-Braid* counts as a *Guest-Token* in hill-forts; the clans will ask whose side you took in the war.
- **Mistlands:** A *Banner-Captain’s Seal* can be presented to a Bell-Warden as proof of lawful passage; the Warden will test it with a bell. If it rings false, the mist takes a day.
- **Valewood:** A *Field Promotion Warrant* can be offered to a Green Knight as proof of worth; the Knight may challenge you to a trial of paths instead of blades.

Patronage & Power

In the Black Banners, power flows through contracts, paychests, and the weight of a reputation. A Banner-Captain’s authority rests on the number of companies he commands; a Condotta Broker’s on the thickness of his ledger. There is no loyalty, only the shared understanding that a broken contract costs more than a broken blade.

For the GM: Power in the Black Banners is measured in payday clocks, broker’s favours, and the length of a duel record. Patronage often takes the form of dual contracts, emergency requisitions, or the Bannerless Word – each tied to a specific company, broker, or debt. To emphasise the mercenary realism:

- Use **Payday & Supply Clocks** as visible pressure. Let players negotiate, raid, or pledge future services to clear ticks.
- Enforce **Allegiances in Flux** – every scene, loyalties may shift. The Keeper’s SB pool grows when the party betrays a contract.
- Let **Honour vs. Pragmatism** be a dial the party can slide through their actions. Centre it by a costly act of mercy or a profitable betrayal.
- Track **Black Marks** as a persistent reputation score. Three Black Marks and no condotta broker will write a clean charter for you.

In the Black Banners, the camp sings when payday comes – and falls silent when the ledger is written in blood.

Chapter 12

The Linns

Skerries & Storm-Oaths.

The sea keeps better counsel than any scribe, and the storm remembers every oath sworn upon its winds. To rule these shores is to dance between their moods and never miss a step.

I am a Net-Wife. I tie a knot for every storm I've survived. My belt has thirty.

North of the Aberderrin Sea, the Linns don't just raid and trade—they do it with the fervour of the converted, swearing oaths to storm and sea that aren't just words—they're leverage with a supernatural clause. They pay in stories, not silver, because to them, a tale well-told is worth more than a chest of gold... especially when it's true.

The jarls measure their wealth in ships. The skalds measure their wealth in verses. The dead measure their wealth in how many living remember their names. I measure mine in knots. Each knot is a promise I kept to the sea. The sea remembers. The sea does not forgive forgetting.

Never name a drowned person aloud while underway. The sea collects names, and if it hears you speaking one it doesn't recognize, it may reach up to correct the ledger.

— *Astrid, Net-Wife, who has never lost a sailor to the mist but has lost three to bad stories*

The Almanac of Ordinary Days

What do people eat for breakfast? Seal blubber and flatbread—the blubber is chewy, the bread is dense, and both are stored in the same barrel. The barrel is shared with the crew. The crew shares everything. The crew is family. Family is obligation.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To tie a knot. Linn children are given a length of rope at birth. By age five, they can tie the eight sea-knots: clew, clove, figure-eight, reef, sheet, stopper, timber, and the ninth—the one that slips when pulled. The ninth knot is for emergencies. The ninth knot is for funerals. The ninth knot is for when the sea asks for a life.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their breath. Linn sailors chew kelp to sweeten their breath—the kelp is harvested from sacred beds, blessed by the Volva. A stranger whose breath smells of salt has been at sea. A stranger whose breath smells of nothing has not. A stranger whose breath smells of copper has spoken a false oath. The sea knows. The sea will answer.

What is the most common crime? Oath-breaking—but oath-breaking is not a crime, it is a storm. The oath-breaker's ship will founder. The oath-breaker's nets will tear. The oath-breaker's children will be born with webbed fingers. The punishment is not imposed by the jarl. The punishment is imposed by the sea. The sea is patient. The sea does not forget.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Sea-Queen is not a queen. She is a figurehead—literally. Her body is carved from the keel of a ship that sank in 612 AR. Her voice is a recording. Her throne is a navigation table. The jarls pretend. The jarls have always pretended. The pretending keeps the peace.

Where do people go when they die? To the waves. Linn dead are placed in boats and set adrift, weighted with stones. The stones are carved with the dead's name. If the boat sinks before it reaches the horizon, the dead is accepted. If it reaches the horizon, the dead is rejected. If it returns to shore, the dead is cursed. The cursed wash up on beaches. The beaches are littered with their bones.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You offer a storm-oath. You stand on a cliff during a gale and swear your apology to the wind. If the wind carries your words, you are forgiven. If the wind throws you into the sea, you are not. The sea does not give second chances.

What is the most important festival? The Launching of the Longships (spring thaw). The ships are dragged from their winter shelters and blessed with blood and mead. The blood is from a sacrificed goat. The mead is from the jarl's own stores. The ships are named after ancestors. The ancestors are listening. The ancestors approve.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Volva of the Mist is a fraud. She cannot see the future. She reads the weather—the pressure, the wind, the taste of salt on the air. The sailors know. The sailors do not care. A weather-reader is more useful than a seer. The Volva knows this. The Volva uses this. The Volva is never wrong.

12.1 Linn — “Skerries & Storm-Oaths”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *Oaths woven in salt, remembered in verse, witnessed by the tide.*

High Jarl (Elite): “The sea keeps better counsel than any scribe, and the storm remembers every oath sworn upon its winds. To rule these shores is to dance between their moods and never miss a step.”

Net-Wife (Commoner): “The water speaks to those who know how to listen – the way it moves tells you if the fish are running, if the weather’s turning, or if something’s coming that wasn’t invited to the feast.”

Genre / Mood: Norse coastal saga, oath-driven honour, horror of the unwitnessed death.

Starting Location: A longship house lined with storm-charms and whale-bone runes, salt wind clawing at the doors. A Net-Wife binds a storm-token into a PC’s palm. “The Whale-Road sings,” she says. “But the Mistlands whistle back. Bring us three keel-lengths of ironwood from the Valewood edge, or the tide will take our boats in the spring.”

Theme & Atmosphere

North of the Aberderrin Sea, where fjords split the coast and skerries break the tide, dwell the Linn. They are traders and raiders in equal breath, their longships crowding the whale-road and river mouths. They descend the Ylolka like an axe-blade and cut into southern shores, or slip through the Thin Strip where the Valewood dares not touch salt. Yet even these storm-oath people dread the Mistlands and the Valewood, whose fog and trees have no need of ships or harbors to claim their due.

What you notice first: The smell of tar and salt fish. The creak of oars from unseen boats. The way everyone—jarl to thrall—touches a knotted cord before speaking of the sea.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never name a drowned person aloud while underway. The sea collects names, and if it hears you speaking one it doesn’t recognize, it may reach up to correct the ledger.

Regional Mood: Skerry Stormcall

Power here is spoken, not written. A jarl’s authority rests on the weight of his oath-chest and the sharpness of his skald’s tongue. Longships are not vessels; they are promises carved in timber. Every voyage is a gamble against tide, reef, and the attention of things that sleep beneath the waves. The Linn do not fear death—they fear dying without a witness, swallowed by fog where no verse will remember their name.

Prominent NPCs of Linn

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk

Jarl Skjold	High Jarl of the Southern Fjords	Unite the scattered strands under one oath	His beard is braided with silver from every ship he has taken.
Volva Hervor	Mist-seer and oath-reader	Read the tides of fate before they turn	She speaks once a year; the rest of the time she listens to the fog.
Astrid	Net-Wife (commoner exemplar)	Keep her village safe from the Hollow and the deep	She ties a knot for every storm she's survived. Her belt has thirty.
Brother Halvard	Missionary of the Temple of Light	Convert the Linn to the Lens of the White Flame	He carries a water-clock to measure the hours of prayer, but the skerries have no hours.
Gunnhild	Sea-Queen's Hand	Enforce the queen's will without drawing a blade	She never draws her sword. The threat is enough.
The Draugr Jarl	Unfinished business (rumoured)	A dead jarl whose oath was never fulfilled	Said to rise from the Thing-Holm when the ninth bell tolls.

Names of Linn

Inspired by the northern fjords: short, hard consonants, compound words that evoke the sea and the storm. Surnames are often patronymic (-son, -dottir) or taken from a notable deed.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Skjold	Astrid	Einarsson	<i>the Oath-Keeper</i>
Bjorn	Gunnhild	Hervorsdottir	<i>Tide-Reader</i>
Ragnar	Sigrid	Ketilsson	<i>Bell-Sworn</i>
Halvard	Yrsa	Ormsson	<i>the Unfinished</i>
Torsten	Runa	Sturladottir	<i>Whale-Bone</i>

Vidar	Helga	Haakonsson	Ash-Prow
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(**Fjord/Skerry/Hall**) Kelp-skerry gut: a narrow channel where oars scrape weed and rock; tide-shed of longship houses with tar smoke and gulls for sentries.

Spades — Places

2. **Kelp-Skerry Gut** — Narrow channel where oars scrape weed and rock. *Kelp strands like dead men’s hair; row silently or the reef listens.* ‘[TRAVEL]’ ‘[STEALTH]’
3. **Tide-Shed** — Longship houses; tar smoke and gulls for sentries. *Each shed holds a keel’s ghost; old crews sleep under the floor planks.* ‘[REPUTATION]’
4. **Wave-Gate Reef** — Just off a raiding beach; only locals know the cut. *One wrong turn and the wave breaks over you—twice.* ‘[TRAVEL]’ ‘[DEATH]’
5. **Runestone Causey** — Across tidal flat; names half lost to barnacle. *Touch the stone with your left hand. If it’s warm, the ancestors approve.* ‘[LEGEND]’
6. **Herring-Stairs** — Drying racks above cliff path; knives flicker like fish. *Workers sing a counting song—eight verses, never nine.* ‘[LABOR]’
7. **Winter Hall** — Turf walls, smoke-eye roof, benches crowded with shields. *The fire never goes out. Feed it a story each night or it goes hungry.* ‘[COMMUNITY]’
8. **Mistlands Maze** — Reed-channels braid and vanish; navigation by instinct. *The reeds whisper names you’ve forgotten. Do not answer.* ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[FEAR]’
9. **Boomed Harbor** — Iron rings in whale-bone posts; controlled access. *The chain was forged from a broken oath. It rattles when liars approach.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
10. **Aberderrin Headland** — Current rips past wreck timbers in the kelp. *On foggy nights, the drowned signal with lanterns. Never follow.* ‘[DEATH]’
- J **Dolmis Waystation** — Low isle with fresh water and old debts. *The well is lined with copper. A single dropped coin returns as a blessing.* ‘[TRAVEL]’
- Q **Thing-Holm** — Flat islet ringed with stones for speaking and swearing. *The stones have ears; oaths spoken here echo for three tides.* ‘[JUSTICE]’
- K **High Jarl’s Seat** — Above fjord, beacon tower glaring out to sea. *The beacon oil is mixed with whale fat. It burns green when a storm is close.* ‘[WEATHER]’
- A **Whale-Road Horizon** — Open water where storms are born and names are made. *Here, the sky meets the sea. Here, the dead meet the living.* ‘[LEGEND]’

(**Jarl/Oar-Crew/Keeper**) Net-wife who reads the sea like a ledger and the sky like a mood; steersman whose tiller-hand never shakes.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Net-Wife** — Reads sea like ledger, sky like mood; weather-witch in all but name. *She ties a knot for every storm she’s survived. Her belt has thirty.* ‘[COMMUNITY]’
3. **Steersman** — Tiller-hand never shakes, even when keel does. *His left ear is scarred—he listened too long to a siren’s promise.* ‘[REPUTATION]’

4. **Shipwright** — Pitch on palms, schedule in teeth; knows every plank's story. *He names each timber after a dead relative. The keel is his grandmother.* '[CRAFT]'
5. **Oar-Master** — Sets beat that decides if home is today or never. *He drums on a hollowed skull. The rhythm is a prayer to the sea.* '[SOCIAL]'
6. **Mist-Pilot** — Ghosts boats through marsh lanes; reed-runner with secret paths. *He never blinks in fog. Some say he traded his blink for safe passage.* '[STEALTH]'
7. **Skald** — Verses buy silence, start fights, end them; law in rhyme. *Her tongue is forked—she can praise and curse in the same breath.* '[JUSTICE]' '[SOCIAL]'
8. **Shield-Band** — Cousins fine with coin, better with cattle. *They sharpen their swords on runestones. The sparks tell fortunes.* '[COMBAT]'
9. **Foster-Son** — Southern coast birth; speaks both laws and subtext. *He wears two brooches—one iron, one bone. Neither is his true allegiance.* '[POLITICS]'
10. **Thing-Speaker** — Makes war into lawsuit, lawsuit into lunch. *He carries a water-clock. When it runs out, so does your patience.* '[JUSTICE]'
- J **Sea-Queen's Hand** — Envoy with seal-bag and sword-belt; queen's will made manifest. *He never draws his blade. The threat is enough.* '[AUTHORITY]'
- Q **Sea-Queen** — Crown of hammered silver, eyes for weather and law. *She lost an eye to a storm—or to a spy. She won't say which.* '[AUTHORITY]'
- K **High Jarl** — First among raids, last to boast; paramount over strands. *His beard is braided with silver from every ship he's taken.* '[REPUTATION]'
- A **Volva of Mist** — Oath-reader whose nod stills surf; seer of tides and truth. *She speaks once a year. The rest of the time, she listens to the fog.* '[LEGEND]'

(**Weather/Reef/Feud**) Black squall drops from clear band; oars or prayers—pick one; fogfall makes friend and reef trade places.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Black Squall** — Drops from clear band; oars or prayers—pick one. '[WEATHER]' *The wind screams a name. Listen carefully—it might be yours.*
3. **Fogfall** — Sound travels, sight does not; friend and reef trade places. '[WEATHER]' '[FEAR]' *You hear oars. Then you don't. Then they're behind you.*
4. **Boom Lift** — Harbor chain rises; schedules drown in harbor mouth. '[AUTHORITY]' *The chain's links are inscribed with names of debtors. Each one rattles differently.*
5. **Levy Clash** — Viterra's wardens arrive with polite spears. '[POLITICS]' '[COMBAT]' *They carry a writ stamped with the queen's seal. The seal is still wet.*
6. **Keel-Rot Rumor** — Crews beach mid-voyage; trust in timber fails. '[DISASTER]' *The rot smells sweet—too sweet. Someone poisoned the tar.*
7. **Feud Token** — Raid becomes wedding... or funeral; oath-debt called due. '[SOCIAL]' '[DEBT]' *A bronze ring arrives on an arrow. The meaning is clear.*
8. **Oath Matured** — Verse sworn last winter comes due today. '[SOCIAL]' '[DEBT]' *The skald clears her throat. The room goes cold.*
9. **Mistlands Miscount** — Channels "move," cargo vanishes without witnesses. '[DEATH]' *The fog lifts to reveal a different shore. Your charts are now lies.*

10. **Aberderrin Race** — Contrary currents split flotilla; half late, half lost. ‘[WEATHER]’ *The water churns like a dying man. Something beneath is feeding.*
- J **Southron Fire-Pots** — Night-run turns to daylight; surprise ashore. ‘[COMBAT]’ *Pots shatter on the deck. The fire burns blue—alchemical.*
- Q **Thing Injunction** — No sailing till grievance heard (hours? days?). ‘[JUSTICE]’ *The Thing-Speaker smiles. He has all the time in the world.*
- K **General Muster** — Horns on every headland; all bays become spears. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[COMBAT]’ *The war fleet assembles. Your ship is the smallest.*
- A **Ground-Sea** — Long, blind swell rolls under; steering lies. ‘[WEATHER]’ ‘[DEATH]’ *The swell has a rhythm—two short, one long. A signal from below.*

(**Right/Token/Escort**) Harbor-green mark—dock without levy in named strand; oar-share claims two benches on fast longship.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Harbor-Mark** — Dock without levy in named strand (once). ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The mark is a notch cut in a bone. Match it to the harbor post.*
3. **Oar-Share** — Claim two benches on a fast longship for a season. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The oars are carved with your name. Row well, or they’ll be recarved.*
4. **Pilot’s Token** — Mist-runner guides through reed-maze safely. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The token is a dried eel skin. Keep it dry.*
5. **Wharf-Right** — Dolmis waystation loading priority; first ashore. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The harbormaster frowns but steps aside. Your name is now on a list.*
6. **Salvage Claim** — Flotsam on reef stretch becomes “inventory.” ‘[TRADE]’ *You must name each piece before touching it. The wrong word forfeits the claim.*
7. **Thing Ruling** — Verdict in your favor that travels with you. ‘[JUSTICE]’ *The verdict is carved on a whale-rib. Carry it as a shield.*
8. **Raid-Truce** — Immunity in named bay for one market day. ‘[TRAVEL]’ ‘[SOCIAL]’ *A white banner on your mast. No one will attack—openly.*
9. **Foster-Bond** — Guest-kin by jarl’s house; hospitality guaranteed. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *You share a cup with the jarl. The cup is silver. The promise is iron.*
10. **Herring Allotment** — Priority barrels when the run hits; silver in season. ‘[TRADE]’ *The barrels are sealed with your mark. Break one to test quality.*
- J **Escort Writ** — Eight shields and wolf-banner from cape to cape. ‘[TRAVEL]’ ‘[COMBAT]’ *The shields are painted with a wolf’s head. They die before you do.*
- Q **Queen’s Audience** — Whisper exits as policy; sea-law bends. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The Queen’s hand writes your words on vellum. The ink is her blood.*
- K **High Jarl’s Pennon** — Levies open booms and mouths when it flies. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The pennon is torn from a captured ship. Fly it proudly—or else.*
- A **Storm-Oath Clause** — Temporary exception to any sea-law, sealed. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[MAGIC]’ *The clause is whispered, never written. The sea hears and obeys—once.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (rights/tokens/escorts) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **sea-omens**—horns on wind, white horses on swell, verse unfinished until landfall.

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **Storm-Oaths:** A Linn may swear an oath by touching salt water. Breaking a storm-oath inflicts 1 Fatigue (the sea's disappointment) and gives the GM a free SB to represent the sea's attention. Keeping an oath until its completion grants +1 die on the next roll involving the sea or sailing.
- **Saga Reputation (Community Track):** Every Linn settlement has a Saga Track [6] that reflects the community's oral memory. The party can increase it by performing deeds worthy of verse (rescuing a ship, slaying a sea monster, keeping a difficult oath). At 3 segments, locals offer hospitality without question. At 6, the party gains a permanent epithet and may call on one favour from any Linn jarl.
- **Mist-Dread:** Linn characters suffer –1 die on navigation rolls when entering the Mistlands or Valewood, but gain +1 die on rolls to avoid supernatural fear (they have learned to dread the right things).
- **Skald's Burden:** A PC who publicly composes a verse about an event may choose to increase or decrease the Saga Track by 1 (as they shape memory). On a failed Performance roll (DV 3), the verse backfires and the track moves the opposite direction.
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
 - **The Salted Anchor** — The Sealed Gate. *The harbour that never closes, the oath that never rusts.*
 - **The Wave Mother** — Raéyn. *The tide that carries and the storm that answers.*
 - **The Drowned Chorus** — Khemesh. *The pressure beneath the keel, the debt the sea collects.*
 - **The Unwritten Verse** — The Witness. *The memory that survives the drowning.*

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Draugr Jarl (Unfinished Business):** The Thing-Holm is haunted by a jarl who died before his oath was fulfilled. He rises when a storm-oath is broken, demanding a blood-price paid in stories. The Temple of Light has sent three missionaries to lay him to rest; all three drowned in calm water.
- **Saint Adar of the Dawnfire (Oath of Flame & Light):** The Temple of Light's soft crusade has reached the Linn coast. Missionaries build school-houses and healers' huts, teaching that oaths sworn by the White Flame are as binding as any storm-oath. The old Sea-Queen tolerates them because they bring iron trade, but the Volva of Mist has warned that the Hollow does not distinguish between faiths.
- **Saint Hervor of the Salted Cord (The Witness):** A Linn skald who swore never to sing a false verse. After she discovered her jarl had faked a raid's spoils, she composed a *nothing*

verse that cursed his line to seven generations. The Sea-Queen keeps Hervor’s runestone at the Thing-Holm; those who lie there hear their own words echo back as mockery.

- **The Tide-Washed Covenant (The Hospice of the Salted Anchor):** A grey-robed healer runs a hospice on the edge of the Mistlands, treating wounded raiders and fog-mad sailors alike. She asks no payment, but she writes every name in a ledger that never dries. Linn captains leave offerings of fresh water before a voyage; those who refuse find their ship plagued by the drowned.
- **The Ninth:** In any longhouse, the ninth horn blown at a feast summons the Hollow. The wise stop at eight. Those who blow the ninth are said to see a pale figure standing at the high table—waiting to collect a debt.

Linn Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Wake:** Toss a crust over the gunwale before a voyage. Ignore the first *Black Squall* penalty. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Knot the Oar:** Tie a single knot in your oar’s leather grip. Cancel *Keel-Rot Rumor* or take –1 die on your next rowing check (your choice). ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Name to the Deep:** Whisper a dead enemy’s name into the tide. Gain +1 Effect against his kin for the scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Sea-Queen. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **coastal guards or rival crews**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **ships or harbor watch**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or mist-pilots**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favorable tide**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Local jarl or harbor master** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **weather shift or reef hazard**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **rival crew or levy force** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **ships, warriors, or skalds** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **storm hits/oath invoked/feud declared**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival: Sea-Queen, High Jarl, or Volva** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **storm rises/reef shifts/mist closes in**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Linn (Storm-Oaths):** Sudden calm, breaking waves speak names, verses come unbidden to lips.
- **Linn (Mistlands):** Channels shift without sound, voices call from reed-beds, compass spins.
- **Linn (Thing-Law):** Witnesses appear, oaths are demanded, skald begins composing your saga.

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Sail + Wits):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Wake Surge*.
- **Cut the Lane (Pilot + Tactics):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a beacon is under your color, +1 die.
- **Weather the Squall (Resolve + Sail):** On a hit in *Black Squall*, you pick who drifts; on a miss, the Keeper does.

Boss Seeds (Sea & Signal)

- **The Net-Father (Nine Nets)** — *Phases:* Harbor Favours → Orchestrated Wrecks → Thing Coup. *Cracks:* cut a cord lineage; reveal swapped verdict; survive a staged squall.
- **The Blue Cantor (Brine-Gospel)** — *Phases:* Drownings Called Mercy → Procession at Reef → Tide-Baptism of a Jarl. *Cracks:* relic earplugs, survivor testimony, storm turning against them.

Patronage & Power

Among the Linn, power flows through oaths, kinship, and the spoken word. Jarls maintain authority through successful raids and wise judgments, while skalds wield influence through their ability to immortalize deeds in verse—or damn names through satire. The Sea-Queen holds sway over the coastlands, but her rule depends on the respect of the High Jarl and the Thing-speakers who interpret ancient laws.

For the GM: Power in Linn society is fluid and performance-based. Patronage often takes the form of foster-bonds, oar-shares, or raid-truces—each binding the recipient to service and reputation. To emphasize this:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (tokens, banners, verses) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided.
- Let rival jarls issue conflicting claims, forcing players to choose whose favor matters more.
- Use the Thing-holm and harbor gatherings as arenas for social contests, where oaths are sworn and broken.

In Linn society, your word is your bond, and your reputation is your greatest treasure.

Part III

The Eastern Dolmis & The Valewood

Chapter 13

Theona

Three Greens, No Ninth.

The wells here hold more than water—they hold the dreams and prayers of generations. To govern is to tend these sacred spaces where the living commune with what came before.

I am a Peat-Cutter. My barrow has a false bottom. I hide debts there—and bodies.

The isles of Theona rise green and jagged from the Dolmis, their basalt cliffs wrapped in mists and moorland song. Nominally a duchy sworn to Viterra, in truth the Three Greens heed no crown but their own moots, no law but their taboos. The greatest of these is the silence of Nine: no bell tolls a ninth, no bridge counts that span, no oath dares its syllable.

The Viterran sheriffs call it superstition. The Green Host calls it trespass. The difference is that the sheriffs will hang you. The Green Host will take your name, and you will wander the mist until you forget you ever had one.

Never pour the ninth cup at a feast. Never speak the ninth name in a bargain. Never step where a step is missing. The Green Host rides for those who complete what should remain incomplete.

— *Celia, Hedge-Witch Midwife, who has tied nine thousand knots and untied nine*

The Almanac of Ordinary Days

What do people eat for breakfast? Oatcakes and heather ale—the oats are grown on terraced hillsides, the heather is harvested from the high moors. The ale is brewed in secret, by women who have forgotten more recipes than the men will ever learn. The men do not ask. The men are wise.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To count to eight. Theona children are taught numbers on their fingers—eight fingers, two thumbs. The thumbs are not counted. The thumbs are for pointing. Pointing is for warnings. Warnings are for the ninth thing.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their shadow. Theona is a land of mists and twilight. A stranger whose shadow is too short has been touched by the Host. A stranger whose shadow is too long is running from them. A stranger with no shadow is already taken. Do not speak to them. Do not meet their eyes. Do not offer them salt.

What is the most common crime? Breaking the ninth taboo—but breaking the taboo is not a crime, it is an invitation. The Host rides for those who pour the ninth cup, speak the ninth name, or take the ninth step. The Host does not arrest. The Host takes. The taken are never found. Their empty cups remain on the table. The cups are warm for three days.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Green Host are not ghosts. They are the living—Theonans who broke the taboo and were taken. They ride with the King in Green, who was once a chieftain of the northern isle. He broke the ninth vow. He was not taken. He was crowned. His crown is made of thorns. His throne is a barrow. His court is the mist.

Where do people go when they die? To the barrows. Theona's dead are buried in long, low mounds that line the eastern cliffs. The mounds are planted with gorse and broom. The gorse blooms yellow in spring. The yellow is for mourning. The broom is for memory. The dead are not mourned. The dead are remembered. Remembering is enough.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You walk the Ninth Mile—a stretch of road that circles the central isle. The road is nine miles long. You must walk it at night, alone, with no light. If you reach the end by dawn, you are forgiven. If you do not, the Host will find you. The Host is always looking. The Host is always waiting.

What is the most important festival? The Feast of the Eighth Cup (autumn equinox). Every household pours eight cups of mead—one for each of the living generations. The ninth cup is poured onto the ground. The ground drinks. The ancestors listen. The ancestors do not answer.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Three-Isles King is a changeling. The real king died in 798 AR, drowned in a peat bog while hunting. The changeling was placed by the Lady Beneath as part of a bargain. The bargain was for peace between the isles. The peace has held. The changeling has aged. The changeling's reflection does not.

13.1 Theona — “Three Greens, No Ninth”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *The Green Host rides for those who count to nine. Viterra counts to nine.*

Matron of Wells (Elite): “The wells here hold more than water – they hold the dreams and prayers of generations. To govern is to tend these sacred spaces where the living commune with what came before. The Viterran sheriffs call it superstition. The Green Host calls it trespass.”

Peat-Cutter (Commoner): “The land here remembers everything, especially what you don’t say. Skip the ninth step, forget the ninth name, and the green earth takes note. Best keep your omissions honest. The Viterran scribes write everything down. That’s why they’ll never understand.”

Theme & Atmosphere

The isles of Theona rise green and jagged from the Dolmis, their basalt cliffs wrapped in mists and moorland song. Nominally a duchy sworn to Viterra, in truth the Three Greens heed no crown but their own moots, no law but their taboos. The greatest of these is the silence of Nine: no bell tolls a ninth, no bridge counts that span, no oath dares its syllable. It is said that those who break the ban invite the Green Host – the *Aos Sí*, the fair folk who were here before the first Viterran longship. The Viterran Viterrans call it superstition. The Theona call it survival.

The Viterran crown claims the isles by right of conquest and papal bull. Its sheriffs impose common law, its bishops build stone churches, its undertakers plant English towns on confiscated lands. But the old ways persist: Brehon judges still speak judgment at the Moot Hill, and the Green Host still rides on the ninth night. To break a taboo is to invite not only the fae but the Viterran inquisitor. Both collect debts. Only one accepts coin.

What you notice first: The smell of wet peat and salt. The silence that follows every eighth bell-ring. The hawthorn trees at every crossroads – the *fairy trees* that no local will touch, and that Viterran surveyors learn to avoid after the first one disappears.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never pour the ninth cup at a feast. Never speak the ninth name in a bargain. Never step where a step is missing. The Green Host rides for those who complete what should remain incomplete. The Viterran sheriff will hang you for the same offence – but the Host takes your name, not your neck.

Regional Mood: Three Greens, No Ninth

Here, peace is a ritual, and every word sharpens the blade that seals it. Theona is claimed by Viterra but ruled by moots, well-keepers, and the old faith. The Viterran sheriffs demand taxes in silver; the Brehon judges settle disputes in cattle. The Viterran bishops burn offerings to the White Flame; the well-keepers leave butter at hawthorn groves. Every hedge is a boundary, every bridge a negotiation, every ninth step a door the Green Host might open.

Linn longships cut through the fog for raiding; Ashaani slavers hunt the coves in stolen coracles; pirates from Zakov and the Vilikari shore trade stolen goods for kelp and salt. Sidhi sailors and Aelinnel factors run cargo up the tide-stairs, and Aelaerem hedge-wives barter red thread for

hawthorn passes. Through it all, the Ninth Taboo threads every handshake, every toast, every whispered prayer. To break it is to invite the Green Host—and the Host does not bargain. To break Viterran law is to invite the sheriff's noose. The Theona have learned to break neither – and to bend both.

Starting Location: A Moot Hill under rain, where vows are carved into stone and knives gleam beside the altar. A Bride-Peacemaker draws a blade between two bloodlines. “The ninth vow was never spoken,” she says. “But the Green Host remembers. Bring us the head of the slaver who burned the eastern strand, and the feud will end. Fail, and your name will join the uncounted. Or the sheriff will take you for vagrancy – the crown has declared our moots unlawful assemblies.”

Prominent NPCs of Theona

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Matron Eithne	Keeper of the Sacred Wells	Preserve the old ways against Viterran encroachment	She drinks only from the ninth well—the one no one admits exists. Her well was declared a "nuisance" by the crown. It still flows.
King Conall	Three-Isles King (elected by the moots)	Balance the demands of Viterra with the taboos of the Green Host	He lost his left hand to a Linn raid; the replacement is carved from hawthorn. He signs Viterran writs with the false hand.
Brid	Bride-Peacemaker	End feuds before the Green Host rides	Her knife has a wooden blade; families cut their palms with wood—blood without iron. She has never lost a client to Viterran justice.

Sister Cera	Missionary of the Temple of Light	Convert the islanders to the White Flame	She preaches in the old tongue and leaves offerings at hawthorn groves; the locals are not sure whether she is a saint or a heretic. The Viterran bishop calls her a traitor.
Brother Iarlath	Everflame inquisitor (Ecktoria)	Purge the ‘pagan’ taboos and impose imperial orthodoxy	He carries a censer that never cools, but it smokes green in the fog. He has condemned nine "fairy trees" to burning. Eight burned. The ninth vanished overnight.
Sheriff Markham	Viterran crown officer	Extend the king’s peace (and tax) to the Three Greens	He carries a copy of the Statutes of Kilkenny. He has never read them. He uses them to beat witnesses.

The Lady Beneath	Dream-queen of the hollow hills	Keep the old bargains and collect the ninth name	She has no face; those who see her forget their own names for a year. The Viterran surveyors who saw her now call themselves "John" and refuse to speak of it.
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Names of Theona

Inspired by the green isles of the western sea: soft consonants, melodic vowels, and surnames that evoke a hill, a well, or a sacred grove.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Conall	Eithne	O'Malley	<i>the Ninth</i>
Cormac	Brid	Mac Gowan	<i>Well-Sworn</i>
Iarlath	Cera	Ó hAodha	<i>Hawthorn</i>
Turlough	Riona	Ó Braonáin	<i>the Uncounted</i>
Lorcán	Máire	Ó Dálaigh	<i>Fog-Born</i>
Finán	Gobnait	Ó Cuilinn	<i>Ash-Finger</i>

(Ringfort/Well/Cliff) Basalt tide-stairs cut into cove; everyone steps past a “missing” rung; Saint’s Well under hawthorn hung with ribbons.

Spades — Places

2. **Tide-Stairs** — Basalt steps into cove; everyone skips the “missing” rung. *The missing step is still there—you just can’t see it. Step where it should be, or don’t step at all. The Viterran engineers measured the stairs. They counted nine. They are no longer here.*
3. **Saint’s Well** — Under hawthorn hung with ribbons and secrets; wishes tied in cloth. *The ribbons are knotted in eights. The ninth knot is never tied—only imagined. The crown calls it idolatry. The locals call it irrigation.*
4. **Fog-Wick Tower** — Burning peat; bell plays eight notes, never nine. *The bell-ringer wears a mask. Underneath, he has no mouth—only a whisper. The sheriff has tried to arrest him three times. Each time, the tower was empty.*
5. **Black Bog Causeway** — White stones like teeth; will-lights test your stride. *The stones were set by a king who drowned. He counts each footstep from below. The Viterran surveyors replaced the stones with wooden posts. The posts burned.*

6. **Cliff Ringfort** — Over kelp-nets; storm-ladders creak like hymns. *The ladders are hauled up at dusk. If you're left below, you sleep with the tide. The crown calls it a "fortified dwelling without licence." The fort has no licence. It has never needed one.*
7. **Barrow Field** — Standing stones; birds hush at noon, the earth remembers. *The stones have ears. Do not speak a secret you cannot afford to lose. The Viterran antiquary who tried to excavate one now tends the barrow as a shrine. He does not remember why.*
8. **Sea-Cave Harp** — Tide-ropes sing under headland; echoes bargain for safe passage. *The harp has no player. It plays itself when the drowned want to speak. The crown has posted a notice: "Unauthorized musical performances prohibited." The notices wash away.*
9. **Uncounted Bridge** — Nine-arch causeway; locals tally “eight-and-one.” *The ninth arch is there—but the locals will deny it. Walk it at your own risk. The Viterran cartographer marked it on his map. His map now shows a bridge to nowhere.*
10. **Ogham Grove** — Carved pillars around an absent ninth post; runes speak in silence. *The missing post was removed by a king who broke a vow. The runes still curse his line. The Viterran bishop ordered the grove destroyed. The axes broke.*
- J **Coracle Harbor** — Jammed in a notch; upturned boats roof the sheds. *The coracles are made of hide and guilt. Each one has carried a secret. The harbormaster pays no tax. The crown cannot find him.*
- Q **Green Moot Hill** — Three Greens' court; benches of turf, salt wind judges. *The wind never stops. It carries the votes of the dead. The Viterran sheriff declared the moot an "illegal assembly." The wind knocked his hat off. He has not returned.*
- K **High Hall** — Whale-rib beams; storm banners sleep, kings are chosen. *The kings are chosen by lot—a knotted cord pulled from a pot. The cord has eight knots. The crown's appointed governor was given the ninth knot. The knot came undone.*
- A **Lookout Cliff** — One vantage where all three isles stand in a single gaze. *From here, you can see the Green Host riding on the horizon—if it wants you to. You can also see the Viterran garrison on the far isle. They do not wave.*

(Moot/Keeper/Court) Peat-cutter with steady barrow and steadier gossip; well-keeper who ties ribbons and unknots feuds.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Peat-Cutter** — Steady barrow, steadier gossip; knows every hidden path. *Her barrow has a false bottom. She hides debts there—and bodies. She also hides the Viterran tax collector when he comes. He is always grateful.*
3. **Well-Keeper** — Ties ribbons, unknots feuds; wishes and wisdom in equal measure. *She never ties a ninth ribbon. The ninth wish is always her own. She has wished for the sheriff's departure every day for seven years. He is still here. She is patient.*
4. **Kelp-Netter** — Reads rip lines like ledgers; tide as teacher. *His net has a torn patch. He sewed it with thread from a hanged man's shirt. The hanged man was a horse thief. The net has never torn again.*
5. **Harp-Satirist** — A few bars can end a career or a war; music as a weapon. *Her harp is strung with catgut and grudges. Each string is a name. She has a string for the sheriff. She has not played it yet. She is waiting.*

6. **Wick-Warden** — Tends fog-lamps, counts in eights; guardian of the silent count. *He counts on his fingers—thumb, finger, finger, finger—and stops. The ninth is for the fog. He taught the Viterran lighthouse keeper to count. The keeper lost his job.*
7. **Taboo-Witness** — Geas-keeper who knows which words ruin deals. *She carries a bell with no clapper. She rings it with her tongue. The Viterran magistrate demanded she testify. She rang the bell. He withdrew the charge.*
8. **Island Abbot** — Saint's bell, tolerant smile; faith in the old ways. *His bell rings eight times. The ninth ring is the silence that follows. The Viterran bishop sent a letter of censure. The abbot used it to light his fire.*
9. **Green Neighbor** — Polite emissary from under the hill; borrowed boots, strange customs. *He never steps on a crack. He says the earth has teeth. The Viterran tax assessor stepped on a crack. He now has a limp.*
10. **Coracle-Captain** — Eight-boat flotilla; swift as rumor, sure as the tide. *Her boats have no names. She says naming a vessel invites the Green Host to count it. The Viterran harbormaster tried to register one. He could not find it. It was right in front of him.*
- J **Bride-Peacemaker** — Walks between bloodlines with a silver knife; peace in marriage. *Her knife has a wooden blade. The families cut their palms with wood—blood without iron. The Viterran magistrate declared the ritual "superstitious." The knife is now his letter opener.*
- Q **Matron of Wells** — Queen-mother in truth if not in name; wisdom in water. *She drinks only from the ninth well—the one no one admits exists. The Viterran governor demanded to see it. She showed him a dry hole. He believed her.*
- K **Three-Isles King** — Elected by the moots; whale-bone throne, weathered eyes. *He lost his left hand to a Linn raid. The replacement is carved from hawthorn. He signs Viterran writs with the false hand. The signatures are legally binding. He is not.*
- A **Lady Beneath** — Unseen queen who bargains in dreams; hawthorn's whisper. *She has no face. Those who see her forget their own names for a year. The Viterran surveyor who saw her now calls himself "John." He does not remember his wife's face.*

(Fog/Feud/Taboo) Ground-mist erases tracks; horns travel, edges do not; bog-lights lure teamster off the causeway.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Ground-Mist** — Erases tracks; horns travel, edges do not; navigation by sound alone. *The mist has a voice. It whispers your name—but only once. The Viterran patrol that entered the mist returned speaking only in questions.*
3. **Bog-Lights** — Lure teamster off the causeway; recovery costs time and pride. *The lights are the souls of debtors. Follow them, and you'll never pay your way out. The Viterran tax collector followed them. He now lives in the bog. He pays no tax.*
4. **Spoken Geas** — No ninth word in parley—or the deal curdles like milk. *The word you cannot speak sits on your tongue like a stone. The Viterran merchant who said "nine" in a contract now sells only in eights. His customers have not noticed.*
5. **Salt-Rot** — Smokehouse fails; fish spoil, tempers rise like the tide. *The salt was cut with grave dust. Someone wanted the winter to be hard. The Viterran garrison's supplies rotted. They bought from the locals. The price was a promise.*

6. **Procession Clash** — Saint-day vs. hawthorn taboo; shutters slam, peace fractures. *The saint’s banner and the green branch cannot touch. When they do, blood follows. The Viterran bishop ordered the hawthorn removed. The tree grew back overnight.*
7. **Wave-Count** — Eighth swell, Nameless follows; boats tremble, sailors pray. *The ninth swell never comes. But something rides the eighth. The Viterran customs cutter that chased a smuggling boat did not see the eighth swell. It is at the bottom.*
8. **Ringfort Wakes** — A bone-judge is “consulted”; now you’re named in the old law. *The bone-judge’s skull is filled with peat smoke. It speaks in riddles—and judgments. The Viterran magistrate who ignored a bone-judge’s ruling now has no memory of the case.*
9. **Ninth Law** — Something vital cannot be counted, measured, or named. *You try to count your crew. The number keeps changing. The Viterran census taker who tried to count the islanders now lives in a cave. He counts seagulls.*
10. **Net-Surge** — Harbor stairs; kelp wraps ankles and alibis like truth. *The kelp moves against the current. Someone underneath is pulling. The Viterran harbormaster who tried to dredge the kelp is now missing. The kelp is thicker.*
- J **Bride-Theft** — At Moot—peace flips to feud; you’re caught mid-ritual. *The stolen bride’s hand is cold. She has been dead for a year. The Viterran sheriff who tried to stop the theft now wears a wedding ring. He does not remember the wedding.*
- Q **Mainland Return** — Exile with papers; elders arrested “for progress.” *The papers are stamped with a Viterran seal. The seal is still warm—and wrong. The elder who was arrested now works in the governor’s garden. He does not speak. The plants are very healthy.*
- K **Green Host Rides** — Hooves like drums, cattle scatter, sentries sleep. *The riders have no faces—only masks of woven hawthorn. The Viterran garrison that saw the Host now stands watch at noon. They will not explain why.*
- A **Great Fog** — Routes loop, bells lie, every promise takes the long way. *The fog is old. It remembers promises made to the dead. The Viterran governor who swore to “pacify” the isles is still lost in it. His dispatches arrive late. They make no sense.*

(Blessing/Token/Right) Well-blessing for a named ford crossing; moot token with eight-knotted cord skips local queues.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Well-Blessing** — Named ford crosses you safely, once; water remembers your need. *The blessing is a ribbon. Tie it to your wrist. Do not tie a ninth knot. The Viterran sheriff’s horse refused to cross the blessed ford. He had to swim.*
3. **Moot Token** — Eight-knotted cord; skip any local queue or judgment. *The cord is braided from horsehair and silence. Cut a knot to speak. The Viterran magistrate who tried to arrest a token-holder found his courtroom empty. The case was dismissed.*
4. **Harbor-Green** — Painted mark exempts your boat from the next levy; tide as ally. *The mark is a circle with an eighth cut. The missing slice is the toll. The Viterran customs officer who tried to collect from a marked boat now collects shells on the beach.*
5. **Hawthorn Pass** — Immunity from a single local taboo (for one scene). *The pass is a hawthorn twig. Carry it in your mouth. Do not chew. The Viterran inquisitor who tried to burn a pass-bearer found his pyre would not light.*

6. **Bell-Right** — Lawful ring at a fog-wick summons the watchers; law travels on sound. *The bell has no clapper. You must ring it with your own breath. The Viterran constable who heard the bell now refuses to speak of it. His ears are scarred.*
7. **Coracle Share** — Crew and oars pledged for one crossing; tide as a steed. *The share is a tally stick. Break it in half to claim your passage. The Viterran governor who tried to seize a coracle share found his hands would not close.*
8. **Ogham Ruling** — Monk’s reading settles a dispute in your favor; runes as law. *The ruling is carved on a slate. The slate is damp. The runes may change by morning. The Viterran judge who ruled against an Ogham ruling now dreams in runes. He cannot read them.*
9. **Unnumbered Right** — Ignore the Ninth prohibition for one action (costs a favor later). *The right is a silence. Use it, and the Green Host will ask for its name. The Viterran spy who used it now has no shadow. The Host has his name.*
10. **Salt-Cure License** — Process scarce fish despite ration edicts; preservation as power. *The license is signed with a thumbprint. The thumb is not yours. The Viterran ration officer who refused a licensed boat now has no appetite. He eats only ash.*
- J **Bride-Charter** — Two feuding houses sheath knives for a season; peace in marriage. *The charter is written on a wedding veil. The bloodstains are from the dowry. The Viterran crown’s peace commissioners have tried to copy the charter. Their copies burn.*
- Q **Private Moot** — With Matron and King; whispers become policy. *The moot is held in a fog hollow. What is spoken there is never written. The Viterran governor’s spy who tried to listen now speaks only in fog. He is very popular with the locals.*
- K **Whale-Escort** — Eight-oar guards across the Dolmis reach; strength in numbers. *The crew carries your name on a scrap of vellum. If the paper gets wet, you are alone. The Viterran warship that tried to intercept a whale-escorted vessel now has no name.*
- A **Green Favor** — One uncanny exception to custom, spoken beneath hawthorn. *The favor is a dream. When you wake, the hawthorn will remember—even if you don’t. The Viterran governor who asked for a Green Favor now believes he is a king. The actual king is amused.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (blessings/tokens/rights) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- The “No Ninth” custom: whenever a 9 appears in your seed, add an omission to the scene (a missing step, an unsaid name, an unseen guest). If the 9 is a Diamond, you may break the taboo once—but someone will come to collect later.
- If any A appears, echo **green and count** motifs—hawthorn that whispers, bells that miscount, promises that take the long way home.

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **The Silent Count:** Players and GMs are encouraged to omit a detail (a name, a step, a tally) when the Ninth appears, echoing Theona’s taboo. This is how the islanders evade Viterran law: they simply do not say what the law requires. The law cannot count what is not spoken.

- **Green Host’s Omen:** Any dream sequence or omen may be framed as the ride of the Green Host—hoofbeats across the sky, wind through the moors, sea spray tasting of salt and blood. The Viterran garrison has learned to ignore the omens. The garrison is understrength.
- **Bride-Peace Feasts:** Weddings, truces, and funerals blur; sharing a feast can end a feud for a season—or doom a guest if the ninth cup is poured. The Viterran crown has outlawed these feasts. The feasts continue. The crown’s officers attend. They never pour the ninth cup.
- **The Viterran Plantation Clock [8]:** Tracks the Viterran crown’s efforts to colonise the isles. Advances when the party assists the crown (provides evidence, enforces a writ, pays a tax) or when a Viterran sheriff successfully imposes common law. Retreats when the party supports a moot, hides a fugitive, or exposes a crown official’s corruption. When full, a new plantation is declared: a Viterran town is built, lands are confiscated, and a new sheriff is appointed. The Green Host’s attention ticks up.
- **Brehon Law vs. Common Law:** In any legal dispute, the party may choose to invoke Brehon law (custom, precedent, witness) or Viterran common law (statute, seal, written evidence). Brehon law grants +1 die if the party can produce a respected elder or a witnessed oral history; Viterran law grants +1 die if the party has a writ or a seal. Choosing one over the other shifts the Viterran Plantation clock by 1 segment toward or away from the crown.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **Saint Bríd of the Unquenched Well (Syncretic):** A local saint venerated by both the Temple of Light and the old well-keepers. Her shrine is a well hung with red ribbons; pilgrims who tie an eighth knot and leave a silver coin may ask one question of the Green Host—but the answer comes in a dream, and the dream always costs a memory. The Viterran bishop has declared her a heretic three times. Each time, the declaration was found burned. The well still flows.
- **Saint Colmán of the Eighth Bell (Oath of Mercy and Grace):** A missionary who tried to convert the isles by ringing a ninth bell. The Green Host took his tongue, and he spent the rest of his life speaking in eights. His hospice still stands near the Fog-Wick Tower; it heals the fog-sick, but every patient leaves unable to count past eight. The Viterran crown has tried to close the hospice. The hospice’s patients now include the governor’s son.
- **The Dullahan (The Headless Horseman):** A fae omen that rides when a Viterran sheriff is about to die. It carries its own head under its arm, and it calls the sheriff’s name. Those who hear it are dead before dawn. The current sheriff has heard it three times. He is still alive. He is very afraid.
- **The Banshee (Bean Sidhe):** A spirit who keens when a pure-blooded Theona chieftain dies. The Viterran crown has tried to suppress her songs as “noise pollution.” The keening continues. The chieftains die. The crown’s record-keepers have given up counting.
- **The Morrigan (The Phantom Queen):** A war goddess who appears as a crow before battle. She does not choose sides. She chooses the dead. The Viterran soldiers who see a crow before a skirmish often desert. The local fighters see a crow and sharpen their blades. The Morrigan is amused.
- **The Ninth:** In any Theona scene, the ninth person to speak in a room draws the Green Host’s attention. The wise hold their tongues until someone else breaks the count. Those who speak ninth are said to see a pale rider on the horizon the next night—and the rider is always one name closer. The Viterran governor who spoke ninth now has a portrait of himself that ages instead of him. He has not looked at it in a year.

Theona Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Bog:** Toss a crust into the mist before crossing a causeway. Ignore the first *Ground-Mist* penalty.
- **Knot the Eighth:** Tie a single knot in a ribbon before a moot. Cancel *Spoken Geas* or take -1 die on your next oath (your choice).
- **Name to the Well:** Whisper a dead enemy's name into Saint's Well. Gain +1 Effect against his kin for the scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Matron.

Patronage & Power

In Theona, power flows through ancient custom, sacred spaces, and the careful observance of taboo. The Three Greens maintain their independence through a web of moots, well-keepers, and geas-keepers who ensure the old laws are honored. The King and Matron rule by consensus and tradition, while the unseen Lady Beneath influences events through dreams and whispers. Against them stands the Viterran crown — a Viterran power of sheriffs, bishops, and undertakers who seek to replace Brehon law with common law, hawthorn with church stone, and the Green Host with the White Flame.

For the GM: Patronage in Theona revolves around blessings, exemptions, and the delicate balance of keeping or breaking taboos. Rewards often take the form of tokens, rights, or divine favor that can be leveraged into greater influence. To emphasize the Viterran-Irish conflict:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (ribbons, tokens, blessings) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided by crown officials.
- Let the Viterran crown and the Green Host issue conflicting exemptions — players must choose whose favor matters more, and whose curse is worse.
- Use the moots, wells, and causeways as arenas for social contests, where knowledge of Brehon law (and its deliberate omissions) determines success against Viterran common law.
- The Viterran Plantation Clock is a visible campaign front. Players can accelerate or delay it, but once it fills, the isles change forever — new towns, new sheriffs, new taboos.

In Theona, your word is your weave, and your weave determines whether you walk the green path or invite the Host — or the sheriff's noose.

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **moot-keepers, well-guardians, or Viterran sheriffs**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **coracle crews, ringfort sentries, or crown patrols**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers, green neighbors, or crown informers**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favorable tide**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** Wick-warden, moot official, or Viterran bailiff becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **mist shift, taboo breach, or a sheriff’s roadblock.**
- **Foe Appears:** A feuding house member, bone-judge, or crown soldier arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected.**
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **coracle crews, green neighbors, moot enforcers, or crown militia** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **taboo broken/green host rides/feud declared/crown warrant issued.**
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **King, Matron, Lady Beneath, or Viterran Governor** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **fog rises/bells ring/causeway shifts/crown forces arrive.**
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests.**
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Theona (Silent Count):** Steps disappear mid-climb, names vanish from lips, the ninth item in a list goes unmentioned.
- **Theona (Green Host):** Hoofbeats echo without a horse, mist takes familiar shapes, dreams predict the next action.
- **Theona (Viterran Law):** A writ is declared void, a sheriff’s seal cracks, a witness remembers the ninth name.

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Wits + Stealth):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Fog Bank*.
- **Cut the Writ (Presence + Sway):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a moot token is in your possession, +1 die.

- **Weather the Host (Resolve + Spirit):** On a hit in *Green Host Rides*, you pick who is named; on a miss, the GM does.

Boss Seeds (three-phase foes)

- **The Unsung Bell (forbidden note given will)** — *Phases*: Hum in Mist → Echo Under Well-stone → Command of Fog. *Cracks*: bind its clapper with eight ribbons; let a rival speak the ninth and pay; drown the echo at the Sea-Cave Harp.
- **Bride-Thief of the Green Host (dream raider)** — *Phases*: Invitation in Sleep → Procession Across Moor → Feast Without Ninth Cup. *Cracks*: cut the dream-veil with silver; sing satire at the Green Moot Hill; trade a Bride-Charter.
- **The Sheriff's Reckoning (Viterran enforcer)** — *Phases*: Plantation Decree → Common Law Assize → The Ninth Hanging. *Cracks*: produce a witnessed Brehon judgment older than the crown's claim; pay a wergild in cattle, not coin; let the Green Host take his name.
- **The Missing Step (living omission)** — *Phases*: Vanished Witness → Unread Clause → Unwalkable Bridge. *Cracks*: invite a Taboo-Witness to count aloud; spill nine drops into Saint's Well but *name only eight*; let the Lady Beneath keep a memory.

Chapter 14

Zakov

Salt & Serpent.

The tide here keeps better ledgers than any scribe, and the reefs remember every secret whispered above their depths. Power flows like the currents—those who understand them rule the waves.

I am a Dock-Rat. My tattoo is of the Sunken Quarter at low tide. The buildings are upside down.

The pirate-city of the Dolmis coast isn't just a den of thieves—it's a corporation with a flag, and oh, how the Salt Prince loves playing king while the Syndicate Silent pulls the strings. Here, every manifest is a lie, every harbor a doorstep to a dozen conspiracies, and every fog-light a lure or a warning. The city breathes with the sea: at low tide, secrets exposed; at flood, the drowned walk the Sunken Quarter and knock on doors that should be locked.

The Salt Prince's crown floats. The Syndicate's ledger is written in disappearing ink. The Kraken's Tongue lives in a bell tower that only exists at high tide. None of this is metaphor. All of it is true. All of it wants something from you.

Never take a coin that tastes of brine. The Serpent's Mark is not a blessing. It is a debt that drowns.

— *Ravel, Dock-Rat, who has never slept above the high-water mark*

The Almanac of Ordinary Days

What do people eat for breakfast? Salted fish and hard cheese—the fish is dried on the docks, the cheese is smuggled from the mainland. The cheese is always stale. The fish is always fresh. The contradiction is never explained.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To read the tide tables. Zakov children are taught the schedule of the sea before they learn their letters. A child who cannot read the tide is a child who will be caught by the flood. The flood is not water. The flood is the Syndicate. The Syndicate collects debts at high tide.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their coin-pouch. Zakov runs on silver—good silver, bad silver, silver that has been under the sea. A stranger whose pouch clinks with fresh-minted coin is a merchant. A stranger whose pouch is full of salt-crusted bits is a pirate. A stranger whose pouch is empty is a liar. Liars do not last long in Zakov. The sea takes them.

What is the most common crime? Piracy—but piracy is not a crime, it is a profession. The Syndicate licenses privateers. The privateers pay a tithe. The tithe funds the harbor. The harbor protects the ships. The ships are protected from pirates. The pirates are the Syndicate. The cycle is beautiful.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Salt Prince is not a person. The title is held by a ring—a band of black coral that has been passed from captain to captain for three centuries. The ring is cursed. The ring's wearer cannot sleep. The ring's wearer cannot die. The ring's wearer cannot leave Zakov. The current Prince has worn the ring for forty years. He has not slept in forty years. He has not smiled in forty years. He has not left the palace in forty years.

Where do people go when they die? To the Sunken Quarter—the drowned district that lies beneath the harbor. The dead are weighted with chains and dropped into the canals. The canals empty into the sea. The sea returns the bodies at low tide. The bodies are collected by the Syndicate. The Syndicate sells them to the Salt-Prince's collectors. The collectors use them for—no one asks. No one wants to know.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You pay the Salt Tithe—a silver coin for every year of the wronged party's life. The coin must be a salt coin—one that has been under the sea for a full tide cycle. The coin is thrown into the harbor. If it sinks, you are forgiven. If it floats, you are not. If it floats back to shore, you are cursed. The curse is the Serpent's Mark. The Mark is a debt that drowns.

What is the most important festival? The Rising of the Tides (summer solstice). The harbor fills with luminescent algae. The algae glows green. The green is called "the Kraken's Eye." The Kraken is said to rise on this night. The Kraken has not risen in living memory. The Kraken is patient. The Kraken is waiting.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Pirate Queen is a spy. She was planted by the Kahfagian Admiralty forty years ago. Her mission was to destabilize the Syndicate. She has become the Syndicate. The Admiralty does not know. The Admiralty still sends her orders. She burns them. The ashes are mixed with her tea.

14.1 Zakov — “Salt & Serpent”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *The tide keeps a better ledger than any scribe. The reef remembers every secret.*

Salt Prince (Elite): “The tide here keeps better ledgers than any scribe, and the reefs remember every secret whispered above their depths. Power flows like the currents – those who understand them rule the waves.”

Dock-Rat (Commoner): “The sewers and the sea both carry what folks want to forget, but they also remember everything. Best keep your business above water and your enemies guessing which dock you’ll use next. The Salt Prince’s crown floats, and the tide pulls for anyone with a sharp knife and a sharper tongue.”

Genre / Mood: Lovecraftian dread meets pirate swagger; eldritch tide-horror, maritime noir, debt as a living force.

Starting Location: A smuggler’s gate built into the seawall, its iron mouth crusted with barnacles and secrets. The gatekeeper is a one-eyed woman who accepts payment in stories. Behind her, the Dregs Quarter stretches on stilts into the harbor, and the Salt Prince’s flagship, the *Red Wake*, rides at anchor off the Iron Pier. “The levy rises tonight,” she says, spitting into the water. “Every ship pays, or every ship burns. You look like the burning type. Good. The Prince needs a reminder that the tide turns for everyone.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Zakov is the pirate-city of the Dolmis coast, where tides trade secrets and knives settle debts. Its streets are piers, its courts are taverns, and its rulers are whoever the Syndicates fear most this season. The Salt Prince claims the throne, but the real power ebbs and flows with the tide—and the tide remembers everything. Here, every manifest is a lie, every harbor a doorstep to a dozen conspiracies, and every fog-light a lure or a warning. The city breathes with the sea: at low tide, secrets exposed; at flood, the drowned walk the Sunken Quarter and knock on doors that should be locked. Zakov is not a place you visit. It is a place you survive—or rule.

What you notice first: The smell of brine and tar. The constant slap of water against stone. The way every tavern has a door that leads to a different dock—and every dock has a name that changes with the tide.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never take a coin that tastes of brine. The Serpent’s Mark is not a blessing. It is a debt that drowns.

Regional Mood: Salt and Serpent

Here, the sea is not a border—it is a landlord. Zakov rose from the wreckage of a sunken empire, and every stone is a salvage claim. The Salt Prince rules from a throne of driftwood and extortion, but the real lords are the Syndicate factors who own the docks, the eel-cults that whisper from the sewers, and the fae courts that launder their influence through tide-bargains. Ships arrive with goods no customs post will name, and depart with cargoes no manifest will show. The city’s law is the Tide Clock: low water for killing, flood water for trading, slack for negotiation. Break the rhythm, and the city will break you.

Beneath it all, the Reaping. Centuries ago, the Salt Prince—then a common adventurer—dove into a submerged vault off the coast. What he found there no one knows for certain. Some say it was a Lethai weapon, a crystalline shard of the first sin. Others whisper it is the father of Khemesh, or the true name of the Hollow written in salt. The oldest tales call it simply *the Reaping*: a hunger that does not kill, but *harvests*. The Reaping seeps into Zakov like groundwater, corrupting slowly, tainting every soul who stays too long. Dreams curdle into obsession. Generosity rots into debt. The city’s famous “everyone owes everyone” is not a culture; it is a symptom.

Prominent NPCs of Zakov

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Salt Prince Lev	Nominal ruler of Zakov; keeper of the Reaping	Keep the syndicates from tearing the city apart	His crown is a circlet of driftwood; he has never taken it off. Beneath it, his hair is white as bone.
Pirate Queen Mila	Rules the Shallows with charm and cutlass	Carve out a kingdom free of the Salt Prince’s levies	Her cutlass was her grandmother’s; the grandmother was also a queen. She refuses to walk the Sunken Quarter.
Kraken’s Tongue	Tide-oracle who speaks in riddles	Survive another season without being sacrificed to the deep	She lives in a bell tower that only exists at high tide; the bell does not ring. She has seen the Reaping. She will not describe it.
Dock-Master Olena	Syndicate factor who “loses” ships	Own the waterfront, one debtor at a time	Her ledger has a secret page that is a map of debtors’ bones. The bones move.

The Reckoner	Broker of cosmic debts (Maelstræus)	Collect interest on every contract signed in Zakov	His coin appears in the pocket of the opposing counsel the next day. The coin is warm. It tastes of brine.
The Salt-Bitten Angel	Cursed messenger (Malachai)	Offer cruel bargains that always leave a scar	A silver coin that tastes of brine circulates among the smugglers; take it, and your cargo always passes inspection. The Angel’s smile has too many teeth.

Names of Zakov

Inspired by the Black Sea and Odessa: Slavic, Turkic, and Greek inflections, with nicknames that stick like barnacles.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Lev	Mila	Voloshyn	<i>the Grey</i>
Dmytro	Olena	Bondarenko	<i>Tide-Foot</i>
Sarkis	Anush	Torosyan	<i>the Unpaid</i>
Kostya	Zoya	Morozov	<i>Bell-Sworn</i>
Ruslan	Nadia	Kravchenko	<i>Ash-Prow</i>
Taras	Halyna	Shevchenko	<i>the Silent</i>

(Harbor/Bolt-hole/Black Market) Salt-cracked wharf where tide brings back what law forgets; Bone-yard beach with wrecks and corpses in kelp; Smuggler’s Gate behind the Fish Market.

Spades — Places

2. **Salt Wharf** — Cracked and crumbling; the tide brings back what law forgets. ‘[TIDE]’ *The wharf has a memory. It remembers every cargo that passed—and every captain that didn’t.*
3. **Bone-Yard Beach** — Wrecks and corpses tangled in kelp and rope. ‘[DEATH]’ *The bones are from three empires. They shift at high tide to form new constellations. The oldest bones are not bone—they are crystal. The Reaping’s first harvest.*

4. **Smuggler's Gate** — An alley behind the Fish Market; always unlocked, always watched. '[STEALTH]' *The lock is a riddle. The answer changes with the moon. The gatekeeper's eyes are the colour of the deep.*
 5. **The Shallows** — A reef-ridden cut only locals dare; navigation as survival. '[TRAVEL]' *The reef has a name: the Serpent's Spine. It grows longer each year. At night, it sings.*
 6. **Dregs Quarter** — Shanties on stilts; boats tied to doorframes like pets. '[COMMUNITY]' *The stilts are whale ribs. The quarter rises and falls with the tide—and the mood. Some doorframes have no doors. Those houses are empty. The residents are still inside.*
 7. **Iron Pier** — Gangplank to the *Red Wake*, the corsair flagship; power as a vessel. '[AUTHORITY]' *The ship was a slaver once. It still smells of chains and salt. The Salt Prince's cabin has a locked hatch. No one asks what is below.*
 8. **Crow's Roost** — A tavern built into the hull of a beached galleon; the past as the present. '[SOCIAL]' *The hull was a prize from a war that ended forty years ago. The crew who took it still drink there. They have not aged. They do not speak of the Reaping.*
 9. **Black Bazaar** — Tents under tarps; goods that scream if you listen. '[TRADE]' *The scream is not pain. It is a warning. The most expensive stall sells "clean" souls. No one knows what that means.*
 10. **Salt Maze** — Marsh paths only the lost know; confusion as protection. '[MYSTERY]' *The maze was a graveyard. The dead rearranged the hedges. The centre is a stone basin filled with water that reflects a sky you have never seen.*
- J **Sunken Quarter** — Half the city is underwater at high tide; wealth as depth. '[DEATH]' '[STEALTH]' *The flooded houses have air pockets. People still live there—damply. They whisper about a door at the lowest tide, a door that leads to the vault where the Salt Prince made his bargain.*
- Q **Crimson Docks** — Contracts signed in blood; commerce as violence. '[DEBT]' '[AUTHORITY]' *The blood is not always the signatory's. The docks do not care. The inkwells are filled from a common source. No one knows where the source is.*
- K **Anchorhead** — A floating fortress of the Pirate Syndicate; law as an anchor. '[AUTHORITY]' *The fortress is built from the hulls of seized ships. You can hear the captains weeping in the timbers. The lowest deck is sealed. The seal is warm.*
- A **Serpent's Spine** — A reef pass to the city's secret heart; danger as a gateway. '[MAGIC]' '[LEGEND]' *The pass is a submerged arch. Swim through, and the city shows you its true face—once. The true face is a wound. The wound is the Reaping.*

(Syndicate/Corsair/Fence) Dock-rat pickpocket with a map tattoo and no fear; a fence dealing in stolen names and secondhand loyalties.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Dock-Rat** — Pickpocket with a map tattoo and no fear; the street as education. '[STEALTH]' *His tattoo is of the Sunken Quarter at low tide. The buildings are upside down. The tattoo moves when he sleeps.*
3. **Fence** — Deals in stolen names and secondhand loyalties; trust as currency. '[SOCIAL]' '[DEBT]' *Her ledger is written in disappearing ink. She is the only one who knows the antidote. The antidote is a drop of Reaping-crystal brine. She keeps it under her tongue.*

4. **Tavern-Keeper** — Remembers every face—and sells the list; hospitality as a trap. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *His memory is a curse from a fae court. He cannot forget—and he cannot stop talking. He is the only source of the Reaping’s true name. He does not know he knows it.*
5. **Corsair Lieutenant** — A letter of marque signed in blood; authority as paper. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The letter is stained with a thumbprint. The thumb is still attached to the signatory. He has not aged in ten years.*
6. **Dock-Master** — “Loses” ships that owe the Syndicate; bureaucracy as a weapon. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[DEBT]’ *His ledger has a secret page. The page is a map of debtor’s bones. The bones are still warm.*
7. **Smuggler Captain** — A false manifest and a quicker blade; honesty as a liability. ‘[STEALTH]’ ‘[COMBAT]’ *She names her boats after dead lovers. The current boat is named “Mistake.” The previous boat, “Regret,” was taken by the Reaping. She does not speak of it.*
8. **Poison-Tongue** — Trades secrets like coin; words as blades. ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[MAGIC]’ *His tongue is forked—not by birth, but by a curse. He can speak two truths at once. The Reaping speaks through him in his sleep. He no longer sleeps.*
9. **Exiled Admiral** — Runs a black-market shipyard; rank as a resource. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *Her flag is a torn imperial pennant. She keeps it to remind herself why she left. The real reason is a crystalline shard she found in a ship’s hold. She keeps it in a lead box. The box is warm.*
10. **Pirate Queen** — Rules the Shallows with charm and cutlass; beauty as power. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[SOCIAL]’ *Her cutlass was her grandmother’s. The grandmother was also a queen. The grandmother was also the first person to see the Reaping and refuse it. The refusal cost her her shadow.*
- J **Silent Syndicate** — No names, just favors and faces; anonymity as strength. ‘[MYSTERY]’ *Their messenger is a child with no tongue. She writes in the air with smoke. The smoke smells of crystal and salt.*
- Q **Kraken’s Tongue** — An oracle who speaks in riddles and tides; the future as a mystery. ‘[MAGIC]’ ‘[DEATH]’ *She lives in a bell tower that only exists at high tide. The bell does not ring. The bell is a fragment of the Reaping’s prison. She tends it with her own blood.*
- K **Salt Prince** — The nominal ruler; real power in the shadows; a crown as a mask. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *His crown is a circlet of driftwood. He has never taken it off. Beneath it, his scalp is cracked like dry earth. Something moves in the cracks.*
- A **Drowned Admiral** — A legend says he still gives orders from the deep; death as command. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[LEGEND]’ *His orders arrive in bottles. The bottles are corked with finger bones. The ink is crystalline. It glows in the dark.*

(Betrayal/Storm/Syndicate Feud) The tide turns early—your ship is now ashore on the wrong side; a rival syndicate burns a warehouse with your goods inside.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Tide Shift** — Turns early; your ship is now ashore on the wrong side. ‘[TIDE]’ ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The tide stole a day. Your alibi is now a lie. The water has a new taste. It tastes of crystal.*
3. **Warehouse Fire** — A rival syndicate burns it; your goods are inside. ‘[DISASTER]’ ‘[DEBT]’ *The fire is green. It burns paper and wood—and secrets. The smoke leaves a crystalline residue on the skin.*

4. **Cursed Cargo** — Something in the hold is *watching*; cargo as a curse. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[MAGIC]’ *The cargo is a mirror. The reflection is not yours. The reflection has too many teeth.*
 5. **Storm Warning** — Ships flee, prices soar, lawmen vanish. ‘[WEATHER]’ ‘[FEAR]’ *The storm has a name. It is the name of a captain who swore revenge. The rain tastes of brine and old regrets.*
 6. **Double-Cross** — You are holding a fake shipment and real enemies. ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[TRAP]’ *The fake shipment is real. The real shipment is a trap. The trap is a shard of the Reaping. It whispers.*
 7. **Prince’s Levy** — Every ship pays tithe or gets sunk; tax as a threat. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[DEBT]’ *The levy collector wears a mask. The mask is the face of a dead admiral. The admiral’s mouth moves. It asks for a name.*
 8. **Plague Ship** — Quarantine flags are ignored; sickness spreads. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[FEAR]’ *The plague is a cough that speaks the name of who infected you. The last name spoken is the Salt Prince’s. He does not cough.*
 9. **Blood Feud** — Erupts between pirate crews; collateral damage mounts. ‘[COMBAT]’ ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The feud began over a stolen duck. The duck is still alive. The duck is made of crystal. No one admits to having seen it.*
 10. **Kraken Rising** — Reefs shift, ships vanish, sailors scream. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[MAGIC]’ *The kraken is not a monster. It is a debt that has grown teeth. The teeth are crystalline. They are the Reaping’s first children.*
- J **Voided Contract** — Your protection now means nothing. ‘[DEBT]’ ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The contract was written on shark skin. It dissolved in salt water. The shark still swims. It remembers your name.*
- Q **Syndicate Split** — Zakov becomes a warzone overnight. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[COMBAT]’ *The split was orchestrated by a third party. You are the third party. You do not remember agreeing. The Reaping remembers for you.*
- K **Naval Blockade** — No ships in or out without a fight. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[COMBAT]’ *The blockade is a fae illusion. The ships are real. The captains are hollow. Something else steers.*
- A **Tide Forgets** — Half the city is cut off, drowning in secrets. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[MYSTERY]’ *The water is warm. The drowned are not dead—they are waiting. They are waiting for the Reaping to finish its work.*

(Pass/Contract/Stolen Goods) A smuggler’s token to pass a checkpoint unseen; a forged manifest that makes your cargo “clean”; a debt-marker the Syndicate cannot refuse.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Smuggler’s Token** — Pass one checkpoint unseen; stealth as paper. ‘[STEALTH]’ *The token is a dried eel skin. Show it, and the guards will not see you—or will pretend not to. The eel was not dead when skinned. It still twitches.*
3. **Forged Manifest** — Your cargo is now “clean”; truth as forgery. ‘[TRADE]’ ‘[DECEPTION]’ *The manifest is a leaf from a salt-cured book. The ink reads differently in moonlight. Under moonlight, it reads the true name of the Reaping.*
4. **Safe Berth** — Bone-yard; no questions, no law; sanctuary as a wreck. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The berth is a beached ship. Its captain still lives below decks—and does not age. He has been counting*

the same grain of sand for forty years. He will not tell you why.

5. **Corsair’s Charter** — Raid with impunity for one moon; violence as a license. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[COMBAT]’ *The charter is a whip. Crack it, and the Syndicate will answer—or flog you. The whip’s handle is carved from a piece of the Reaping’s prison. It is warm.*
 6. **Prince’s Writ** — Levies cannot touch you (yet); authority as a delay. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The writ is a feather. The Salt Prince’s signature is a claw mark. The feather came from a bird that drowned. It still tries to fly.*
 7. **Black Ledger** — Names, debts, and where they sleep; knowledge as power. ‘[DEBT]’ ‘[INFORMATION]’ *The ledger is a skull. Read the names, and the skull will whisper their secrets. The skull’s teeth are made of crystal. They hum.*
 8. **Salvage Rights** — A named wreck; first claim, no questions. ‘[TRAVEL]’ ‘[WEALTH]’ *The wreck is a ghost ship. The ghost is the original owner. The ghost does not remember its name. It will trade the ship for a new one.*
 9. **Lighthouse Key** — Stolen; redirect ships where you will. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[DECEPTION]’ *The key is a tuning fork. Strike it, and the lighthouse will lie for you. The lie becomes truth for one tide. The lighthouse keeper weeps.*
 10. **Debt-Marker** — The Syndicate owes you a favor; obligation as an asset. ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[DEBT]’ *The marker is a coin. The Syndicate’s symbol is worn smooth—by regret. The coin is warm. It tastes of brine.*
- J **Queen’s Blessing** — Safe passage through the Shallows; charm as protection. ‘[TRAVEL]’ ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The blessing is a kiss. The Pirate Queen’s lips taste of salt and blood. After the kiss, you dream of the Reaping. You wake with a new debt.*
- Q **Kraken’s Favor** — The tides part for your ship, once; nature as an ally. ‘[TRAVEL]’ ‘[MAGIC]’ *The favor is a tentacle wrung dry. When you need it, soak it in seawater. The tentacle will write a name in the foam. Do not speak that name.*
- K **Prince’s Coin** — Bribe any official, silence any witness. ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[DEBT]’ *The coin is a finger bone. The official who takes it will not speak—or not listen. The bone belonged to the Salt Prince’s predecessor. He is still alive. He is in the coin.*
- A **Serpent’s Mark** — The reef itself will guide you home; danger as a guide. ‘[TRAVEL]’ ‘[MAGIC]’ *The mark is a scar on your palm. The reef will cut you—but it will also open. The cut bleeds crystalline brine. The brine is the Reaping’s attention. Use it sparingly.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (passes/contracts/goods) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **salt and serpent** motifs—tides that remember, reefs that shift, the deep that listens.

Additional Features

- **Tide Clock:** Scenes run on a four-segment **Tide Clock** (Low → Flood → Slack → Ebb). Each advance shifts Position: *Low tide* reveals hidden wrecks and bolt-holes; *Flood tide* drowns

streets and seals doors. When the Clock turns, the Keeper may demand 1 SB tied to the waters.

- **Reaping's Corrosion (Clock [8]):** Tracks the slow corruption of the party's souls. Tick when you accept a bargain from the Salt Prince, use a Serpent's Mark, or fail a Resolve test while in Zakov. At 4, you gain a *Crystalline Whisper* condition (you hear the Reaping's voice in quiet moments; -1 die to resist fear). At 8, you become *Harvested*: your shadow detaches and walks into the sea, and you owe the Reaping a name. To clear the clock, you must offer the Reaping something it values more than your soul—a memory of a crime you did not commit, a true name you were never told, or a shard of its own prison (a heist into the vault).
- **Syndicate Debt:** Every deal leaves a mark. Track a single **Debt** value (0–3). At 3, the Syndicate calls it in: a betrayal, a levy, an unwanted escort. Clear 1 Debt by paying a Diamond or sacrificing a useful contact.
- **Whispers Deep:** Rumors carry teeth. When characters openly boast, bargain, or betray, roll 1d6: 1–3, Whispers spread, increasing SB generation; 4–6, Whispers favor the PCs, lowering suspicion until the tide turns.
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
 - **The Reckoner** — Maelstraeus. *Interest on every contract; the coin that always comes back.*
 - **The Salt-Bitten Angel** — Malachai. *A silver coin that tastes of brine; a blessing that drowns.*
 - **The Kraken's Father** — Khemesh. *The pressure beneath the keel; the debt the sea collects.*
 - **The Tide Father** — The Traveler. *The current that carries you home—or to the reef.*
 - **The Crystal Matrix** — The Ninth. *The Reaping's true nature; silence that has taken form.*

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Bitter Root:** Daughters of the Cord run a hospice in the Sunken Quarter. They ask no payment—but they cut threads. A renegade Sister hides among the eel-cults, trying to untie her cord from the Salt Prince's ledger. She claims the Reaping is the Cord's original sin. No one knows if she is right.
- **The Threshold Compendium:** The Serpent's Spine is a Class II Anchor site—the bound spirit of a drowned admiral. Saikou Ira would trade his silver mirror for a single reef chart. The mirror shows the Reaping as a crystalline spider. He has not slept since.
- **The Salt-Bitten Angel (Malachai):** A silver coin that never spends circulates among the smugglers. Take it, and your cargo always passes inspection—but the coin will taste of brine every time you touch it, and the Angel will ask for a favour before the next full moon. The favour is always to carry a message to the Salt Prince. The message is a single word: "Soon."
- **The Reckoner (Maelstraeus):** The Crimson Docks keep a ledger signed in salt water; those who borrow from the Reckoner find that their interest compounds with every tide. A captain who defaults may wake to find their ship's name struck from all records, as if it had never sailed. The Reckoner's ink is crystalline. It writes itself.
- **The Grey Wanderer's Grimoire:** Zakov psions are called "Tide-Readers." They taste the future in the salt. The Pirate Queen employs two—and has never trusted a forecast that didn't cost blood. The Reaping's presence makes their predictions unreliable. They taste

crystal instead of salt.

- **The Ninth:** In any Zakov scene, the ninth ship to enter the harbor in a tide will be claimed by the reef. The wise wait for the tenth—or pay a name to the Kraken’s Tongue. The reef is not a reef. It is a crystalline mouth. It has been feeding for centuries.

Zakov Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Tide:** Toss a crust into the water before a voyage. Ignore the first *Tide Shift* penalty. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Knot the Manifest:** Tie a single knot in a corner of your cargo list. Cancel *Voided Contract* or take –1 die on your next customs check (your choice). ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Name to the Reef:** Whisper a dead captain’s name into the Serpent’s Spine. Gain +1 Effect when navigating the Shallows this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Kraken’s Tongue. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **syndicate enforcers or dock guards**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **pirates or tavern patrons**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or fence networks**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favorable tide**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Dock-master or corsair lieutenant** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **tide shift or syndicate patrol**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **rival syndicate or pirate crew** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **syndicate enforcers, pirate crews, or naval forces** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **contract voided/storm hits/syndicate splits**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **Salt Prince, Pirate Queen, or Drowned Admiral** intervenes.

- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **tide shifts/storm hits/blockade imposed**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Zakov (Tide Power):** Water levels change without warning, ships become stranded or flooded, tidal currents shift direction.
- **Zakov (Syndicate Politics):** Protection money demands increase, rival factions make conflicting demands, contracts are voided mid-deal.
- **Zakov (Pirate Culture):** Ships are commandeered, crews mutiny, pirate codes are enforced with violence.
- **Zakov (Reaping Corruption):** A character's reflection speaks in a different voice, a crystalline growth appears on a weapon, the party hears a harmonic hum from the deep.

City Operating System (Fast Play)

Tide-State (4) Track a **Tide Clock** (Low → Flood → Slack → Ebb). At each shift:

- change **Position**: Low (+Infiltration), Flood (-Mobility), Slack (+Deals), Ebb (+Getaway).
- Keeper may bank 1 SB tied to *water, rot, or rumor*.

Heat & Debt Track **Heat** (0–4) and **Debt** (0–3) citywide.

- *Heat* rises on noisy jobs; at 4, a *Syndicate Split* tick or *Naval Blockade* rumor triggers.
- *Debt* rises when you stiff a faction; at 3, a creditor picks the next scene's complication.

Crew Playbooks (pick one tag) *Cutters* (+Effect on coercion at Crimson Docks); *Ghosts* (ignore first Tide penalty each job); *Lighters* (cargo swaps create 1 **Forged Manifest** per session); *Lanterns* (fae bargains count as Diamonds once/session).

Signal, Cipher, & Circuitry

Harbor Flash (d6 quick comms) 1 one-lantern (safe) 2 two-lantern (watch) 3 red rag (fire) 4 black gull (hit) 5 three knocks (meet) 6 eel-twine (fae eyes)

Dock Cant (micro-phrases) “wet ledger” = bribe; “green rope” = cursed cargo; “white rain” = blockade rumor; “dead wake” = tail on you; “crystal voice” = the Reaping is listening.

Shadow-Net Each *Crow's Roost*/tavern can host one **Cache**: 3 rumors total; *spend* 1 rumor to bump Position on info-gathering. When emptied, add +1 **Heat**.

The Fae Leak

Saltbound Rules Fae cannot *enter* a circle salted with **tidewater salt**, but can *bargain* across it. Breaking circle = 1 SB and a personal *Mark*.

Eel Court Wharf-spirits (eel-hooded) adjudicate vows “where water hears.” Presenting a **Serpent’s Mark** lets you reroute a single clause in a contract once.

Drowned Names Names thrown from *Bone-Yard Beach* return as *Echo Debtors*. Cash one to erase 1 **Debt**—but the name occasionally speaks from your mouth.

Heist Skeletons (Plug & Play)

The Manifest Swap (3 beats) **Beat 1:** *Entry* (Smuggler’s Gate or Sunken Quarter); on miss, *Tide Shift*. **Beat 2:** *Edit* (swap bill at Dock-Master); spend **Forged Manifest** to auto-pass. **Beat 3:** *Exit* (Shallows); fail = *Cursed Cargo* wakes.

Anchorhead Skim (4 beats) **Case** a ledger → **Turn** a clerk → **Lift** a page → **Ghost** on the Iron Pier. Any alarm = *Prince’s Levy* this scene.

Syndicate Play (Mini-Game)

Stacks & Faces Pick a patron *Stack* each arc: **Red Wake** (muscle), **Silent Syndicate** (intel), **Salt Prince** (papers). During downtime, exchange *Faces* (favors) for one of: reduce **Heat** by 1; clear 1 **Debt**; mint one **Black Ledger** page (one-use leverage on any named).

War Track (0–6) Each conflicting job advances **War**; at 3, *Blood Feud*; at 6, *Syndicate Split*. Reset if PCs deliver a **Queen’s Blessing** or sacrifice a crew asset.

Urban Terrain & Glitches

Glitch Table (fae-punk fuzz, d8) 1 door opens to water 2 lantern whispers your alias 3 rope grows kelp 4 coin tastes like brine and lies 5 footprints go opposite 6 eel writes your name 7 reef sound indoors 8 tide remembers a promise you didn’t make

Zones (quick tags) *Dregs*: +Stealth, -Status; *Crimson*: +Force, -Subtle; *Sunken*: +Weird, -Mobility; *Salt Maze*: +Escape, -Clarity.

NPC Templates

Kraken’s Tongue (Oracle) *Wants*: Tribute in secrets. *Leverage*: once/session convert a **Club** to a **Diamond**. *Cost*: forget a friend’s face for a night.

Dock-Master Briga *Wants*: A rival’s ledger singed. *Leverage*: “lose” any hull for a day. *Cost*: your real name in her book.

Pirate Queen Mael *Wants*: A tide-warden compromised. *Leverage*: **Queen’s Blessing**. *Cost*: carry her mark where it shows.

Contraband & Curses

Hot List (d6) 1 saint-glass (screams when lied to) 2 eel-ink (writes back) 3 tide-bell (rings at wrong hour) 4 serpent charts (reef moves for bearer) 5 name-wine (drink a memory) 6 drowned coins (buy help, cost breath) 7 (rare) crystal shard (Reaping fragment; use to clear one **Reaping's Corrosion** segment, but ticks the clock twice in the next scene)

Tagging Cargo Each illicit lot has 1 *Tag*: **Watching, Hungry, Bound, Cold**. Tag can be “disarmed” by the right shrine/fee/contact.

Cross-Region Conversions

- **Theona:** *Smuggler's Token* counts as *Hawthorn Pass* if bells play eight; a ninth sound voids both.
- **Viterrra:** *Prince's Writ* can masquerade as *Customs Seal* for one audit before *Audit Freeze* ticks.
- **Ubral:** *Black Ledger* page buys one night of *Guest-Token*—if read aloud at Wergild Ford.
- **Vhasia:** *Lighthouse Key* spoofs a beacon on *Beacon Crown*/King's High Road ferries once.
- **Valewood:** *Serpent's Mark* = one-scene *Way-Cord* if dipped in Moon-Cistern.
- **Ways Between:** A complete *Forged Manifest* recited at a *Threshold Arch* becomes a *Passage Token*.

Clocks & Pressures

Levy Teeth (6) 1–2: Quayside “inspections” 3–4: Tithe brigades 5: Fire at the wrong warehouse 6: Floating gallows at Anchorhead.

Smuggler War (6) 1–2: Protection doubled 3–4: Routes trapped 5: Crews defect 6: Open water gunwales—everyone draws steel.

Gate Truce (4) 1: Coins tied on rope 2–3: Gate stays “neutral” 4: New Keeper named; reroute *Tide Clock* once/session.

Reaping's Corrosion (8) (see Additional Features)

Score Seeds

- **The Eel That Spoke:** A *Cursed Cargo* eel whispers court gossip from Thepyrgos; bottle it before *Syndicate Split*. The gossip includes a fragment of the Reaping's true name.
- **Red Wake's Shadow:** Lift a *Black Ledger* page naming the Salt Prince's heir; payment is *Prince's Coin*—and a knife in the dark. The heir is a child. The child is made of crystal. The child does not know it.
- **Lighthouse Down:** Swap the *Lighthouse Key* during a storm; success grants *Kraken's Favor*, fail triggers *Naval Blockade*. The lighthouse keeper is the only living person who has seen the Reaping's vault and returned sane. She will not return a second time.

Boss Seeds (Tariff & Flame)

- **The Hook-Master (Nine Stamps)** — *Phases*: Tariff Forgeries → Orchestrated Strike → Port Coup. *Cracks*: recover a true stamp, expose a forged ledger, survive a night in a lighthouse. The lighthouse reveals the Reaping’s reflection. The Hook-Master is terrified of it.
- **The Drowned Admiral (Ghost Fleet)** — *Phases*: Lost Ships Called Home → Procession of Empty Lanterns → Tide-Baptism of a Factor. *Cracks*: relic green flame, survivor testimony, the lighthouse keeper’s lens turning clear. The Admiral’s flagship is the vault where the Reaping sleeps. He guards it not out of loyalty, but because he is the first Harvested. He does not remember his name.

Patronage & Power

In Zakov, power flows through the control of smuggling routes, the management of syndicate debts, and the ability to navigate the complex web of pirate politics. The Salt Prince maintains nominal authority, but real power lies with those who control the tides, the reefs, and the flow of information through the city’s taverns and black markets. The true authorities are those who can provide safe passage, protect cargoes, and mediate between competing syndicates.

The Reaping changes everything. Whoever controls the crystalline shard—or understands its nature—holds a weapon that could unmake the city or save it. The Salt Prince keeps the Reaping’s location secret, but the Syndicates whisper that he is no longer its master. The Reaping has begun to act on its own. It reaches through the tide, through the dreams of the drowned, through the taste of brine in a smuggler’s coin. Zakov is not ruled by the Prince. It is ruled by a hunger that has been patient for centuries.

For the GM: Patronage in Zakov revolves around smuggling rights, safe harbors, and the ability to provide protection from both legal and illegal authorities. Rewards often take the form of tokens, charters, and safe passage that can be leveraged into greater influence. To emphasize the city’s fluid power:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (tokens, manifests, keys) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided.
- Let rival syndicates issue conflicting protections, forcing players to choose whose favor matters more.
- Use the docks, taverns, and smuggling routes as arenas for social contests, where knowledge of custom and connections determines success.
- Track **Reaping’s Corrosion** as a campaign clock. Its advance is the city’s slow death. The players can delay it, redirect it, or even embrace it—but they cannot ignore it.

In Zakov, your reputation is your wealth, and your wealth determines whether you rule the waves or feed the fishes. But beneath the waves, the Reaping feeds on reputation too. And it is very, very hungry.

Chapter 15

Aelinnel (Aevrossa)

Stone, Bough, and Bright Things.

The law here flows like water over stone—it finds its own path, and woe to those who try to dam it with paper and pretense. The earth itself will testify against the unjust.

I am a Charcoal-Burner. My kilns tell us more than your books ever could. When the smoke curls left, the tide's with you. When it splits in three, best stay by your own hearth till it burns straight again.

The gnomish homeland isn't just a place where they count steps—it's a place where they worship the count, and oh, how the Aelinnel love a good loophole in their beloved numerology. They count everything: steps, bells, offerings—because to them, precision isn't just virtue; it's leverage with a supernatural clause.

The fae courts of the Thorn Lady and the Green Knight watch every threshold. The Stone Prince keeps the old pacts indexed in ledgers that breathe. And the Green Gate opens at neap tide, expecting exact change in truths. The Aelinnel don't just live between worlds—they arbitrate them.

Never bring naked iron past a hawthorn arch unless it is gilded or named. Copper is polite, silver is opinionated, cold iron is an accusation. The hawthorn will remember which you carried.

— *Tallow, Charcoal-Burner, who has never lost a sheep to the Hollow but has lost three helpers who did not listen*

The Almanac of Ordinary Days

What do people eat for breakfast? Honey-cakes and mushroom tea—the honey is from the hawthorn groves, the mushrooms are harvested from the root-caverns. The cakes are baked in copper moulds. The moulds are shaped like animals. The animals are not edible. The shapes are for luck.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To count in eights. Aelinnel children are taught to group everything in eights—steps, breaths, heartbeats. The ninth is not a number. The ninth is a gap. The gap is where the Hollow sits. The Hollow is not a monster. The Hollow is a creditor. The debt is never paid in full.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their tools. Aelinnel carry copper—spoons, chisels, measuring rods. A stranger whose tools are iron is a barbarian. A stranger whose tools are silver is a priest. A stranger whose tools are gold is a fool. Gold does not ring true. Gold is for bribes. Bribes are for secrets.

What is the most common crime? Miscounting—but miscounting is not a crime, it is a geometric error. The error is corrected by the Stone Prince's ledgers. The ledgers are kept in the Hall of Sums. The Hall is guarded by clockwork sentinels. The sentinels do not sleep. The sentinels do not forgive. The sentinels count every breath.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Stone Prince is not a prince. The title is held by a committee of six elders who have never been seen together. They communicate through copper messages left in the Hall of Sums. The messages are written in a code that changes with the tides. The code has not been broken in three centuries. The code is not meant to be broken. The code is meant to be trusted.

Where do people go when they die? To the tide-gates—stone arches at the edge of the sea. The dead are laid on the threshold. The tide comes in. The tide takes them. The gates are older than the Aelinnel. The gates were built by something else. The gates are still watching.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You offer a counting—a public recitation of your wrong in the Stone Prince's court. The court is a circle of copper chairs. The chairs are cold. The wrongdoer stands in the centre. The elders count the syllables of your apology. If the count is even, you are forgiven. If the count is odd, you must leave an offering. The offering is measured in copper. The copper is weighed against your breath. The scales are never balanced.

What is the most important festival? The Opening of the Green Gate (autumn equinox). The gate appears at low tide, a stone arch that leads to—no one knows. The Aelinnel do not enter. They leave offerings: copper, honey, a single true name. The gate accepts. The gate closes. The gate waits.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Green Knight is not a knight. She is the gatekeeper—the last survivor of the people who built the tide-gates. She wears a helm of polished brass. Her face has not been seen in living memory. Her voice is a recording. Her sword is a key. The key opens the gate. The gate does not want to be opened.

15.1 Aelinnel (Gnomes) — “Stone, Bough, and Bright Things”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *Count the steps, weigh the words, and never trust a single ledger.*

Stone Prince of Aelinnel (Elite): “The law here flows like water over stone – it finds its own path, and woe to those who try to dam it with paper and pretense. The earth itself will testify against the unjust.”

Charcoal-burner (Commoner): “Our kilns tell us more than your books ever could. When the smoke curls left, the tide’s with you. When it splits in three, best stay by your own hearth till it burns straight again. And never trust a court that speaks in only one ledger.”

Genre / Mood: Dark faerie tale, moonlit groves, polite iron, and the uncanny weight of a promise.

Starting Location: A tide-shed at dawn, fog curling over anchored barges, gulls crying omens over the river’s black glass. A gnomish reeve offers passage on a sealed barge: “The Green Gate opens at neap tide. What we trade there, the Dolmis will not name.”

Stone, Bough, and Bright Things

Aelinnel homeland of Aevrossa clings to the Dolmis coast beneath the shadow of the Valewood, its halls threaded through granite and hawthorn, its roads counted by antler-posts and moonlit courtesy. Here, promises have weight and silence has meaning. *Even* steps are safe, *odd* words are careful, and truths are traded like copper nails – bright, useful, and slightly poisonous in the wrong pocket.

To the north, the Valewood looms; to the south, the downs of Amedell where the Aelaerem keep their red doors. The Green Gate sometimes opens onto halfling barrows – a fact neither people speaks of aloud.

Yet no single crown rules the gnomish lands. Dozens of courts, guilds, and seasonal pacts weave a shifting lattice of loyalty. Some Aelinnel hold fast to ancient fae treaties, speaking in two ledgers and never carrying naked iron; others barter in the Green Market with pragmatic coin, treating courtesy as a bargaining chip; still others vanish into the deep woods, listening to stag-roads and root-galleries where the Wild Hunt sometimes rides. The gnomish heart is divided – and that division is their shield against the fae.

Craft and courtesy govern every traffic between mortal keeps and the courts under the hill. Gnomish stone-singers tune bridges with a hum that keeps the Green Gate at bay; forester-wardens hammer copper where iron would draw unwanted attention. In markets under living roofs, a sentence can be cut to fit a purse, and a memory can be wrapped for travel. Paths sometimes shorten for those who keep good count, and lengthen for those who sneer at patterns. The fae are never rude – but they are never safe.

At a Glance

- **Atmosphere:** Moonlit groves, polite iron, and the uncanny weight of a promise.
- **Key Conflict:** What is said versus what is meant; fae courtesy versus mortal bluntness.

- **Notable Threats:** Glamour fog, iron offence, geas-catch, the Green Gate yawning at the wrong hour.
- **Common Rewards:** Hazel tokens, tide-path keys, oath-beads, and the Wild Hunt's clemency.

Prominent NPCs of Aelinnel

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Thorn	Lady of Thorns, Sovereign of the Hawthorn Court	Remind mortals that courtesy is a leash, not a gift	She never repeats herself. Her silences are verdicts.
Caelum Viridant	Green Knight, Warden of the Stag-Roads	Test the worthy and trap the careless	His armour is woven from living boughs that bleed when he lies.
Eilidh Stone-Prince	Mortal ruler of the Hall of Aelinnel	Keep the old pacts indexed and the fae at arm's length	She speaks only in conditional tense. No one has heard a declarative sentence from her lips in seven years.
Riven	Huntsman of the Moonlit Ride	Chase down debts, oaths, and those who flee the Green Gate	His horn is carved from a fossilised scream. He only blows it when the debt is nine days old.
Tallow	Charcoal-burner (commoner exemplar)	Read the smoke and warn the village before the fae come	He has never lost a sheep to the Hollow. He has lost three helpers who did not listen.

Sable	Green-Market Broker	Trade truths for trinkets, and never lose the margin	Her receipts are written on leaf-vein paper. They curl when the bargain is unbalanced.
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Names of Aelinnel

Aelinnel names are built from soft vowels (ae, ei, ui, oi) and liquid consonants (l, r, n, m) with occasional sharp endings (-k, -t, -x). Surnames are often taken from a notable grove, a tide-mark, or an ancestor’s defining courtesy. They evoke the sound of water over stone and wind through hawthorn.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Caelum	Eilidh	Thornweave	<i>the Green-Wise</i>
Riven	Sable	Tidespeak	<i>Two-Tongue</i>
Tallow	Merrow	Evenstep	<i>the Unseen Guest</i>
Fennel	Briar	Hawthorn	<i>Barrow-Kept</i>
Osprey	Vesper	Silverbough	<i>the Uncounted</i>
Linden	Ash	Foxtail	<i>Ash-Finger</i>

The Three Courts: Aelinnel Alignments

Aelinnel society is not a single crown but a lattice of courts, guilds, and seasonal pacts. Three broad stances shape their dealings with outsiders and with the fae. Most gnomes shift between these postures depending on the season, the tide, and who is asking.

- **Thorn–Courteous (Fae–Lean)** – These gnomes keep the old pacts with the Lady of Thorns and the Green Knight. They speak in two ledgers, never carry naked iron, and treat every threshold as a negotiation. They are the ones who remind visitors to count their steps and pour no ninth cup. *Clocks: COURTESY DEBT [4], HAWTHORN PATIENCE [6].*
- **Market–Square (Trade–Lean)** – These gnomes prioritise the Green Market, the Under-Market, and the flow of quartz, copper, and name-script. They are pragmatic, will use iron if it is gilded, and view fae courtesies as bargaining chips rather than sacred laws. *Clocks: TARIFF DISPUTE [4], MARKET DOMINANCE [6].*
- **Forester–Trusted (Wild–Lean)** – These gnomes live among the stag-roads and root-galleries, closer to the stone-singers and the tree-wardens. They speak the old names of tides and groves, and they are the first to notice when the thorn blight spreads or the moonwell stains a name wrong. *Clocks: ROOT CALLING [4], WILD HUNT INTEREST [6].*

Most Aelinnel characters and settlements fall somewhere between these poles, and the same gnome might wear a different mask when trading at the Green Market than when walking the stag-roads.

Spades — Places (stone spires, sea-rock, deep woods)

2. **Tide-rift steps** – Cut into black rock; limpets and old votive nails keep count for those who forget. ‘[THRESHOLD]’
 3. **Moonwell basin** – A granite bowl; coins turn green in a week, names in a season. ‘[MAGIC]’
 4. **Dolmen stair** – Up a ridge; each capstone rings a different interval if you tap it true. ‘[MUSIC]’
 5. **Charcoal coppice** – Under witch-hazel; a neat ash-heap hides a door that opens on even knocks only. ‘[SECRET]’
 6. **Basalt organ cliffs** – Sea-caves breathe like slow bellows; the wind prefers prime numbers. ‘[NATURE]’
 7. **Stag Road** – Game-trail marked by antler-posts; hooves know it best, maps accept it grudgingly. ‘[TRAVEL]’
 8. **Quartz spring** – Sand shines like ground stars; drinkers tell the same story with better structure. ‘[HEALING]’
 9. **Elf-causey** – Pale flags through a marsh; visible at dawn and dusk and whenever someone is counting aloud. ‘[FAE]’
 10. **Root gallery** – Under an oak hill; lanterns hang from living bark – two lit, one listening. ‘[UNDERGROUND]’
- J **Barrow gallery** – Stone chimes; a cold draft from below plays scales no throat can sing. ‘[DEATH]’
- Q **Thorn Court ring** – Hawthorns trained into arches; petals fall like knife-points and settle into proofs. ‘[FAE]’ ‘[DANGER]’
- K **Hall of Aelinnel** – A timber keep threaded between standing stones; floors level themselves for guests. ‘[CIVILISATION]’
- A **The Green Gate** – In a sea-arch; at certain tides it opens to a forest not on any map, and expects exact change. ‘[GATE]’

Hearts — People & Factions (keepers, courts, craftsmen, hunters)

2. **Goat-herd of the stone edges** – Measures danger in hoof-widths; never wrong twice. ‘[SURVIVAL]’
3. **Charcoal-burner clan** – Read draught and omen by smoke; their kilns hum in thirds. ‘[DIVINATION]’
4. **Hedge-witch** – A pocket of thorns and prices stated in *unlesses*. ‘[MAGIC]’ ‘[SOCIAL]’
5. **Stone-singer (quarryman)** – Hum finds a seam and a secret; walls relax when they pass. ‘[CRAFT]’
6. **Forester-warden** – Copper nails and a polite dislike of iron; paths obey their hammer. ‘[NATURE]’
7. **Reed-net fisher** – Knows when the selkies listen; mends nets to lullabies in 5s and 8s. ‘[TRADE]’
8. **Oath-carver** – Sets promises in quartz so they can be seen; breaks none, bends many. ‘[LAW]’ ‘[OATH]’
9. **Way-keeper of the Stag Road** – Never lost, often followed, sometimes found ahead. ‘[GUIDE]’

10. **Green-market broker** – Trading truths for trinkets and back again; receipts in leaf-vein script. ‘[COMMERCE]’
 J **Green Knight** – Antler helm, mirror-bright blade, courtesy old as frost; keeps a tally of saved insults. ‘[FAE]’ ‘[DUEL]’
 Q **Lady of Thorns** – Sovereign of a hawthorn court; smiles like a snare and forgives in exact measures. ‘[FAE]’ ‘[LAW]’
 K **Stone Prince of Aelinnel** – Mortal crown with fae debts properly indexed and current. ‘[AUTHORITY]’
 A **Huntsman of the Moonlit Ride** – His horn turns shortcuts into roads, and debts into destinations. ‘[HUNT]’

Clubs — Complications/Threats (glamour, geasa, weather, neighbours)

2. **Glamour fog** – Time drifts, footfalls don’t match, conversations arrive neatly folded. ‘[ILLUSION]’
 3. **Iron offence** – Someone brought the wrong nails to the right grove; paths take it personally. ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[DEBT]’
 4. **Root-slide** – Pulls a trail two ridges away while you blink; your footprints stay where they were. ‘[TRAVEL]’
 5. **Wrong tide at the sea-arch** – Boats rise where arithmetic says no and physics excuses itself. ‘[WEATHER]’
 6. **Spoken geas** – Catches on an unlucky word; the task names itself and refuses synonyms. ‘[MAGIC]’ ‘[OATH]’
 7. **Green Market price** – Payment demanded in names and memories; change returned in riddles. ‘[COMMERCE]’ ‘[DEBT]’
 8. **Stone-wight stirs** – In a barrow; echoes hate company and file complaints as drafts. ‘[DEATH]’
 9. **Lost day** – The sun miscounts; your dawn arrives at supper and demands bread. ‘[TIME]’
 10. **Thorn blight** – Crawls across orchards; pruners bleed stories that grow where they drip. ‘[CURSE]’
 J **Stag horn sounds** – Everyone owes the chase – especially you, especially now. ‘[HUNT]’ ‘[DEBT]’
 Q **Thorn Court tithe** – Levied on the Hall; arrests wear flowers and quote etiquette. ‘[LAW]’ ‘[SOCIAL]’
 K **Must of the Bough** – Forest banners rise; travel becomes trespass by default. ‘[CONFLICT]’
 A **Green Gate yawns** – At the wrong hour; roads rewire across your path with excellent logic. ‘[GATE]’ ‘[MYSTERY]’

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage (charms, passes, host-rights, exceptions)

2. **Hazel token** – Step through a hedge uncut, once; the scratch you did not get will *remember* you kindly. ‘[PROTECTION]’
3. **Salt license** – Carry and use ward-salt where it’s discouraged; doors frown and open anyway. ‘[UTILITY]’
4. **Dolmen carving-right** – Inscribe a name or claim on a speaking stone; arguments quiet while you carve. ‘[AUTHORITY]’
5. **Guest-bough** – From the Thorn Court; one night’s safe table among thorns; knives behave. ‘[HOSPITALITY]’
6. **Quarry allotment** – Of clear quartz; subtle doors open to its bearer if asked in the right tense. ‘[ACCESS]’
7. **Green Market voucher** – Buy a truth at face value (today only); tomorrow costs interest. ‘[COMMERCE]’
8. **Oath-bead** – A spoken promise warms the bead when kept, chills when not, glows if misunderstood. ‘[OATH]’
9. **Tide-path key** – Lawful crossing of a named sea-cave at neap; the cave will wait. ‘[TRAVEL]’
10. **Forest truce** – Hunt, cut, or travel through a warded copse without offence; the birds file no reports. ‘[PERMISSION]’
- J **Green Knight escort** – From ridge to gate; watchers bow, paths part, insults lodge elsewhere. ‘[PROTECTION]’
- Q **Private audience** – With the Lady of Thorns; a whisper exits as policy with petals attached. ‘[AUTHORITY]’
- K **Stone Prince’s seal** – Levies defer, foresters guide, scribes stop arguing and fetch tea. ‘[AUTHORITY]’
- A **Wild Hunt clemency** – Ride under the horn for one night; no hound will take you, no debt will sleep. ‘[PROTECTION]’

Quick use notes

- Draw until all four suits appear: **Spade** = place, **Heart** = actor, **Club** = pressure, **Diamond** = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Treat **Diamonds** as codified outcomes (charms/passes/host-rights) that *change position* rather than call for a roll.
- If any **A** appears, echo dark fae motifs: antlers in shadow, petals that cut, a tide that breathes, and a shortcut that insists on proper payment.

Additional Features

- **Two-Ledger Courtesies:** Once per scene, a character who states both what they *say* and what they *mean* (in or out of character) may shift *Position* one step safer on a social roll against a fae or fae-touched being. The GM may demand a small token (a copper coin, a knotted thread) as earnest.
- **Copper over Iron:** When the party visibly favours copper or brass tools over iron in fae-facing

scenes, gain +1 assist die from locals (or avoid a –1 penalty) for acts of courtesy, passage, or petition. Iron is not forbidden – it is simply *impolite*, and impoliteness is remembered.

- **The Unsaid Clause:** In any bargain or promise, if the players explicitly leave one term unspoken (but agreed upon by all at the table), the GM may bank 1 SB to introduce a complication later where that omission becomes the hinge of the deal. The fae love what is not said.
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
 - **The Thorned Lady** – The Lady of Thorns (fae sovereign). *Courtesy is a leash; mercy is a snare.*
 - **The Green Knight** – The Sealed Gate (threshold guardian). *Prove your worth, or be turned aside.*
 - **The Still Count** – Mykkiel (divine arithmetician). *Every miscount is a sin; every correction is a prayer.*
 - **The Root-Speaker** – Grimmer (wild patron). *Stone sings, wood remembers, the grove witnesses.*

Courtesies of the Green Gate

- **Never bring naked iron** past a hawthorn arch unless it is gilded or named. Copper is polite, silver is opinionated, cold iron is an accusation.
- **Always return what points the way.** Way-cords, antler-posts, chalk. Borrow the path; do not keep it. The fae count what you take.
- **Speak debts in the daylight.** Promises made under lantern-boughs are heard by leaves as well as by law. The Green Gate listens.
- **The ninth cup is never poured.** Leave it empty for the uninvited guest. If you pour it, drink it yourself – and hope the guest does not arrive.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Bitter Root:** Daughters of the Cord sometimes serve as oath-carvers, binding promises with red thread instead of quartz. A renegade Sister hides in the Root Gallery, trying to untie a cord tied by the Lady of Thorns herself.
- **Malachai, the Chained Angel:** A silver coin that never spends appears in the moonwell. Take it, and the water will show you a perfect reflection – but the coin will reappear in the well every new moon, each time a little warmer.
- **The Grey Wanderer’s Grimoire:** Aelinneal psions are called “Proof-Readers”. They hear the weight of hidden clauses and can detect an omission in any bargain by the way the air tastes of copper.
- **The Threshold Compendium:** The Green Gate is a Class III Procession – the gate itself walks the coast once a season, and those who cross it must answer a riddle about debts or be pulled into the Hollow.
- **The Ninth:** In any Aelinneal scene, the ninth word spoken in a bargain becomes legally binding – even if the speaker did not intend it. The wise count to eight and then gesture.

Regional Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Gate:** Crumble a crust before the Green Gate. Ignore the first *Glamour fog* penalty. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Knot the Cord:** Tie a single knot in a way-cord. Cancel *Spoken geas* or take –1 die on your next promise (your choice). ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Name to the Stone:** Whisper a dead oath-carver’s name into a standing stone. Gain +1 Effect when negotiating with fae this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Stone Prince. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’

Thematic SB Spend Table (Aelinnel)

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **thorn-courtiers** or **forest-wardens**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **stone-singers** or **green-market traders**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **stag-road trackers** or **oath-carvers**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time** or **favorable tide**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Green Knight** or **Lady of Thorns’ herald** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **glamour fog** or **root-slide**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **stone-wight** or **thorn blight spirit** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **fae courtiers**, **forester-wardens**, or **stag-horn riders** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes – **geas triggers** / **green gate opens** / **iron offence declared**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **Lady of Thorns**, **Stone Prince**, or **Huntsman of the Moonlit Ride** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically – **tide turns** / **green gate yawns** / **thorn blight spreads**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice – **omen appears** / **blessing lost** / **curse manifests**.

- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options (Aelinnel)

- **Courtesy & Geas (1–3 SB):** A hawthorn arch closes behind you; copper tools glow with fae attention; a polite phrase becomes a binding geas. The fae have noted your manners – or your lack thereof.
- **Glamour (1–2 SB):** Conversations arrive folded and misaddressed; time drifts unexpectedly; your footfalls no longer match your steps. The Green Gate breathes.
- **The Unsaid (1–2 SB):** An omission you did not know you made becomes the price of passage. The Lady of Thorns smiles. You do not know why.

Aelinnel – Tidal Bargains

Starting Location: A tide-shed at dawn, fog curling over anchored barges, gulls crying omens over the river’s black glass.

“In Aelinnel lands, the river speaks with many tongues, and each tide demands a name in return.”

In... a tide-shed at dawn, a gnomish reeve offers passage on a sealed barge. “The Green Gate opens at neap tide. What we trade there, the Dolmis will not name.”

Regional Motifs Tide-ledgers, river gods, sealed cargo, name-taboo.

Whispers to Offer “Peek in the crate,” “Speak the hidden name,” “Break quarantine.”

External Clocks Threat: *Green Gate Thirst* [6]; Community: *Dockside Fear* [4]; Anchor: *Barge Oath* [4].

Complications Freshwater turns brackish; the cargo sings; a rival reeve boards with knives.

Anchors at Risk A PC’s river-kin; the barge’s blessing.

Escalation Beat The Gate opens early; the tide runs backwards.

Relief Offer a river-gift; carry a name written in river-mud across the threshold; spend 2 to seal the leak for a scene.

Faction Entanglements

- **Stone–Singer Conclave:** Sponsor a bridge-chant or way-tuning and bank a *Harmonic Favor* – spend to shift *Position* one step safer on any passage across worked stone or living root. Skip their rites and the first crossing this leg gains a free “Lock/Barrier” SB as paths sulk.
- **Forester–Wardens:** Accept copper-nail protocols to cancel the first *Fae Offence* SB in a wood scene. Drive iron stakes or break taboo and mark a 4-segment *Polite Apology* clock you must clear before locals assist you again.

- **Green-Market Brokers:** Submit an itemised truth (what was said / what was meant) to reduce barter DV by 1 for the scene. Try to haggle on single-ledger terms, and the market tags you with *Exact Change Only* – all bargains hereafter demand a tithe of memory or name until appeased.
- **Oath–Carvers’ Guild:** Have a promise set in quartz to gain a *Visible Oath* token; spend to treat one social test as if aided by a reputable witness. Breaking a quartz-oath spawns a 4-segment *Shattered Nuance* clock that complicates future negotiations.
- **Tide–Reeves:** File a tide-plan before neap to earn a *Tide Window* – ignore one tidal timing penalty this leg. Skipping the ledger adds a free “Wrong Tide” SB the first time you touch the Dolmis.

Cross–Regional Ties & Soft Power

- **Way of Silk Interface:** Kon"reh-counted caravans that adopt Aelinnel step-metrics (even steps, counted halts) gain +1 die to avoid ambushes on the Way this arc. Breaking count invites a free “Glamour Fog” SB at the next way-shrine.
- **Aeler Standards (Rods & Wards):** Recognise Aeler measures publicly to reduce dispute DV by 1 with dwarven legates; insist on gnomish dual-ledger and foreign merchants grumble – first mixed-market scene gains an “Assay Doubt” SB.
- **Vhasia/Viterra Complications:** Vhasian hedge-duties (wood rites) and Viterra tithe-scripts (grain flows) cross your ledgers. When either region is “Stressed,” add +1 DV to Green-Market exports that travel their roads unless you carry a *Forest Truce* or *Tithe Waiver*.
- **Valewood Fallout:** On a *Valewood Weather* signal, fae proofs spill downslope; counting etiquette cancels the first navigation SB each scene, but any iron shown gains a free “Fae Complaint” SB (even among humans). Aelaerem hospitality rites mitigate this: presenting guest-loaf removes one such complaint per hall.

Trade Goods & Consequences

- **Quartz & Proof–Stone:** Donate clear quartz to a shrine to bank a *Seen Promise* – once, treat a murky contract as if properly witnessed. Peddle clouded quartz as “ritual grade” and spawn a roaming *Counterfeit Proof* inquiry clock.
- **Copper Etiquette Kits:** Issuing copper over iron in mixed courts grants +1 assist die on petitions; flooding markets with cheap copper pins offends foresters – add a “Copper Resentment” tag that raises DV in wood jurisdictions until you make amends.
- **Name–Script & Memory Wraps:** Legal export of name-script lowers espionage DV by 1 for allies who carry it. Smuggling wraps risks a *Name-Tax* – first customs scene converts 1 SB into a compelled disclosure.
- **Tide Rights & Barge Seals:** Funding barge-seals creates a *Waiting Cave* – once per arc the cave “waits” an extra beat for your crew. Ignoring seal-maintenance flips it: first Dolmis crossing suffers “Wrong Hour” SB.

Patron Networks (Patterns & Thresholds)

- **Sacred Geometry:** Chalk a golden-mean spiral at a ford to reroll one failed prediction/trajectory check this leg; doing so in view of fae courts adds a 2-segment *Proof Envied* clock.

- **The Sealed Gate:** Hawthorn-gilded door-nails act as single-use stay writs: negate one forced entry or pursuit at a hedge-gate.
- **Lunara:** Counting under moonlight lets you ask one terse yes/no about a hidden path; on a Miss, secrets spread – mark Exposure +1 in the nearest Green Market.
- **The Traveler:** Antler-posts double as wayshrines; leave a copper and recite a sequence to finish one travel clock tick for free on forest legs.

Field Procedures (Use At the Table)

- **Two-Ledger Talk:** When parley stalls, the GM asks: “What was said? What was meant?” If players state both, cancel the first social SB this scene; if they refuse, the next bargain demands collateral (memory/name).
- **Count or Be Counted:** At any fae-touched crossing, a player who audibly counts in a fitting sequence (steps, heartbeats, breaths) shifts *Position* one step safer for that crossing. Boasting or mocking numbers adds a free “Geas Catches” SB.
- **Copper Courtesy Check:** Producing copper/brass tools in a ritual space removes the first *Fae Offence* tag this scene; drawing iron instead escalates the next Complication by +1 Cap.

Diplomatic Favor & Reputation Echoes

- **Hazel Favors (minor resource):** Earned by returning way-cords, restoring antler posts, or paying tide-dues. Spend to downgrade a *Glamour* or *Geas* complication once per leg.
- **Alignment Reputation:**
 - *Thorn-Courteous:* Doors of the hawthorn courts open a step easier; human clerks distrust your clauses (first city office DV +1).
 - *Market-Square:* Brokers vouch your weights; rival stalls circulate riddled slander – add a trailing *Folded Rumor* clock.
 - *Forester-Trusted:* Paths shorten for you once per journey; port inspectors assume concealed copper – first harbor search gains a free “Alarm Raised” SB unless declared up front.

Boss Archetypes in Aelinnel

Court & Courtesy (Fae Sovereigns)

- **Lady of Thorns (Etiquette Engine)** – Punishes breaches with precise harms, rewards perfect courtesy with literal boons. *Win by satisfying three courtesies in sequence (no iron, two-ledger speech, return the waymark).*
- **Green Knight (Trial by Pattern)** – Duel of paths and proofs, not blades. *Win by presenting a higher-count route (Fibonacci, even-steps) or yielding a deserved apology at the right number.*

Threshold & Hunt (Environment that Judges)

- **Moonlit Ride (Wild Hunt)** – Three phases: *Sounding* (horns), *Coursing* (paths shorten for the bold), *Closing the Ring*. *Win by naming safe-clemency, joining the chase without taking a prey, or blowing the right counter-call (2–3–5).*
- **Green Gate (Living Crossing)** – Demands exact change in truths. *Win by paying a memory that fits the posted proof; forcing passage triggers “Roads Rewired.”*

Numbers & Glamour (Logical Anomalies)

- **Glamour Fog (Layered Illusion)** – Each layer dispelled by a correct count, courtesy, or copper rite. *Win by completing the Three Proofs: count aloud, return a borrowed path token, trade a said/meant receipt.*
- **Lost Day (Time Miscount)** – The sun misnumbers hours. *Win by reconciling two ledgers (what happened / what should have), then ringing a prime-number chime.*

Market & Oath (Contract Tricksters)

- **Green-Market Broker (Truth Arbitrage)** – Buys your meanings, sells your words. *Win by catching them in a one-ledger statement or producing an Oath-Bead that chills (misunderstood clause).*
- **Oath-Carver Gone Wrong (Quartz Tyrant)** – Binds towns with over-precise promises. *Win by carving a Release Unless into communal quartz at cost of a public truth.*

Stone & Memory (Ancestral Hazards)

- **Stone-Wight Chorus (Echo Jurors)** – Resent footsteps, adore proofs. *Win by tapping the dolmen scale that matches the grievance and returning a taken token to the barrow.*

Boss Mechanics (Use 2–3 levers)

- **Courtesy Track [4]:** Each breach (iron bared, skipping greetings, single-ledger lie) ticks it. On fill, boss gains *Polite Punishment*: escalate DV +1 and impose a Geas.
- **Counting Proofs (three steps):** Name a pattern, perform it, return a waymark. Completing all three lowers boss tier for one exchange or ends a phase.
- **Said/Meant Ledgers:** Any bargain scene runs two mini-clocks; if *Said* fills first, glamour favours the boss; if *Meant* fills first, PCs gain a *Visible Oath* token.
- **Iron Offence Meter [0–3]:** Showing iron, striking hawthorn, or salting impolitely raises it. At 3, fae gain a free “Thorn Blight” SB; reduce by copper rites or gifts.
- **Hunt Phases:** *Sounding* (fear checks; pass to gain +1 die to pace), *Coursing* (paths shorten for counted strides), *Closing* (only truth-payment or clemency halts the circle).
- **Lair Actions (pick two):** *Fold the Conversation* (re-target a statement); *Shift the Count* (odd ↔ even penalties); *Petal Cut* (apply 1 Harm unless copper shown); *Wrong Tide* (swap entry/exit costs at a gate).

Patronage & Power

Among the Aelinnel, power flows through courtesy, oath, and the hidden geometry of the land. A Stone Prince’s authority rests on indexed fae treaties; a Green Knight’s on the trials he has witnessed. There is no single crown, only the shared understanding that a broken promise cuts deeper than a sword.

For the GM: Power in Aelinnel society is measured in hazel tokens, oath-beads, and the precision of a courtesy. Patronage often takes the form of guest-boughs, tide-path keys, or the Green Knight’s escort – each tied to a specific court, grove, or debt. To emphasise the cultural mechanics:

- Use **Two-Ledger Courtesy** to reward players who pay attention to the unspoken.
- Enforce **Copper over Iron** – carrying iron is not forbidden, but it is a statement.
- Let **The Unsaid Clause** be a source of future complications; the fae love what is not said.
- Track **Obligation to the Green Gate** as a persistent clock. Each crossing without proper payment ticks it toward a visit from the Huntsman.

In Aelinnel society, the stone remembers every step – and the Green Gate forgets no debt.

Chapter 16

Aelaerem

Hearth & Hollow.

A proper harvest feast requires three things: the finest cider aged in the right barrel, a guest-loaf baked with intention, and the wisdom to know when to invite the quiet ones to sit by the fire.

I am a Miller. My geese know a stranger's step from a mile off, and they've never been wrong. One is named "Stranger." It has never been wrong.

The halfling downs aren't just a place where they keep the Hollow at bay—they're a marketplace for fear, and oh, how the Aelaerem love a good bargain on safety. They use red threads and offerings not out of piety, but because they know the Hollow's attention is a commodity—and they'll pay dearly to avoid it.

A red door means bread, salt, and one safe night if you come honest. A cup-mark stone on the verge accepts butter as a prayer. The watch-geese know your step before you do, and the scarecrow turns to face the road when the Hollow is hungry. The Neighbors—the things under the barrows—are not enemies. They are neighbours. And neighbours, if treated politely, will stay on their side of the hedge.

Never refuse an offered cup. The Hollow counts refusals as invitations. Pour the ninth cup for the empty chair, and you may feed it—or feed it.

— *Bram, Miller of the Watch-Geese, who has never been surprised*

The Almanac of Ordinary Days

What do people eat for breakfast? Porridge with honey and a pinch of salt—the salt is for the Hollow. Every Aelaerem household leaves a pinch on the threshold each morning. The Hollow does not eat. The Hollow counts. The salt is an offering. The offering is a reminder.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To tie a red thread. Aelaerem children are given a length of red wool at birth. By age three, they can tie the eight hearth-knots: welcome, farewell, protection, memory, warning, promise, apology, and the ninth—the one that is never tied. The ninth knot is for the Hollow. The Hollow does not tie knots. The Hollow waits for you to tie them yourself.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their shadow. Aelaerem shadows are long and thin, even at noon. A stranger whose shadow is short has been touched by the Neighbors. A stranger whose shadow is wrong—too many limbs, too few—is a Neighbor. Do not invite them in. Do not refuse them bread. The law is clear: feed them, but do not ask their name.

What is the most common crime? Offering the ninth cup—but the ninth cup is not a crime, it is a negotiation. The pourer offers a drink to the empty chair. The Hollow may accept. If it does, the house is blessed for a year. If it does not, the house is marked. The mark is a red thread tied to the door. The thread is never removed. The house is never sold.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Apple-Matron is a title, not a person. The Matron is the oldest woman in the village. When she dies, the second-oldest takes her place. The Matron's memory is the village's memory. The Matron forgets nothing. The Matron's memory is fading. The village is forgetting. The forgetting is the Hollow's doing.

Where do people go when they die? To the barrows—the low, green mounds that dot the downs. The dead are buried in family plots, marked with cup-stones. The cup-stones are filled with rainwater. The rainwater is changed weekly. The water is for the dead. The dead are not thirsty. The dead are counting.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You leave a red thread on the wronged party's doorstep. The thread must be tied in a specific knot—the knot of apology, which is also the knot of debt. The wronged party may accept the thread or cut it. If they accept, the debt is recorded. If they cut it, the debt is unpaid. The unpaid debt grows. The growing debt attracts the Hollow.

What is the most important festival? The Harvest Home (autumn). The last sheaf of grain is tied with red thread and left in the field. The Hollow takes it. The Hollow does not take anything else. The Hollow is patient. The Hollow will wait for the ninth cup.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Pale Shepherd is not a shepherd. It is a title held by the Hollow itself. The Shepherd appears as a figure in grey robes. Its face is a mask of bone. Its voice is a recording of the last words of the person who saw it last. That person is always dead. The recording is always accurate.

16.1 Aelaerem (Halflings) — “Hearth & Hollow”

Apple-Matron (Elite): “A proper harvest feast requires three things: the finest cider aged in the right barrel, a guest-loaf baked with intention, and the wisdom to know when to invite the quiet ones to sit by the fire.”

Miller (Commoner): “My geese know a stranger’s step from a mile off, and they’ve never been wrong. If they start honking at noon, you best check your larder – someone’s coming who wasn’t invited. And when the Hollow walks, the only safe place is a lit hearth with the ninth cup unpoured.”

Theme & Atmosphere

In Amedell, the Aelaerem keep their bonds with bread, bells, and careful counting. Lanes run under ash and hawthorn; doors reddened with thread promise a seat and a story to any who step right. Their magic is housekeeping writ large – thresholds groomed, names jarred like jam, the Hollow fed with silence and the ninth cup left unpoured. When the Neighbors stir beneath the barrows, the folk answer with kettle songs and lantern law, and the fields behave because someone asked them to. Hospitality here is not kindness—it is a covenant. Every meal is a promise, every gift a thread, every candle an argument against the dark. Amedell lies south of the Aelinnel homeland of Aevrossa, separated by the rolling downs and the slow waters of the River Adder. The two small-folk peoples share trade in red thread, copper, and seasonal hospitality, though the Aelaerem keep a wary distance from the fae-touched gnomish courts. It lies on the southeastern coast of the Dolmis, although the Aelaerem are rarely out to sea beyond coastal fishing.

What you notice first: The smell of baking bread and old apples. The way every threshold has a red thread tied at eye level. The silence of children when a stranger passes the village stone.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never refuse an offered cup. The Hollow counts refusals as invitations. Pour the ninth cup for the empty chair, and you may feed it—or feed it.

Regional Mood: Warm Hearths, Cold Thresholds

Here, the land is not wilderness—it is a living weave of favors and omissions. The Aelaerem do not build walls; they build hedges, stiles, and the careful geometry of guest-right. A red door means bread, salt, and one safe night if you come honest. A cup-mark stone on the verge accepts butter as a prayer. The watch-geese know your step before you do, and the scarecrow turns to face the road when the Hollow is hungry. The Neighbors—the things that live under the barrows, in the uncounted ninth step, in the space between the candle and its shadow—are not enemies. They are neighbors. And neighbors, if treated politely, will stay on their side of the hedge.

Starting Location: A cider-press barn perfumed with crushed apples and rain, where masks hang from beams awaiting the next festival. The Apple-Matron sits on a stool of woven twigs. Behind her, a Moot Oak leaf bleeding red sap onto a stone. “The Hollow walks early this year,” she says. “The Moot Oak bleeds wine. Will you speak for the field, or let the Neighbors claim it? Speak true—the geese are listening.”

Prominent NPCs of Aelaerem

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Oria <i>“Crimson Door”</i>	Apple-Matron of the Harvest Moot	Keep the Hollow at bay and the feasts true	She pours the first cup for the eldest, the ninth for the empty chair. Never takes the ninth herself.
Bram	Miller of the Watch-Geese	Protect the village from unseen strangers	His geese have names; one is “Stranger,” and it has never been wrong.
Celia	Hedge-Witch Midwife	Tie red thread and untie feuds before they fester	Her thread is from her own hair. She never cuts it—only knots it.
Drogo	Thresher-King (seasonal)	Lead the harvest rites and keep the sheaf’s secret	Chosen by the last sheaf, which is always a little damp.
Alda	Lantern-Warden of the Downs	Trim the lamps and know which shadows are wrong	Lights them in a pattern that is a prayer.
Finnian	Mummers’ Captain	Guard the masks and the laws of festival	The masks are not carved. They are grown.

Names of Aelaerem

Inspired by the pastoral hill country of a green and misty isle: earthy, clipped, with soft vowels and hard consonants, evoking hearth, hedge, and hollow.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Tolly	Daisy	Underhill	<i>the Red-Door</i>
Bram	Posy	Bywater	<i>the Goose-Wise</i>
Corbin	Marigold	Brookside	<i>Barrow-Born</i>
Willum	Hazel	Holloway	<i>Hollow-Touched</i>
Hodge	Fern	Fielding	<i>the Uninvited</i>
Pippin	Ivy	Hayward	<i>Ash-Finger</i>

(Lanes/Orchards/Mills/Downs/Barrows) Willow ford with flat stones and a bowed pollard that remembers faces; cider-press barn with sweet reek, old songs, doors that stick after dusk; chalk sheep-downs with a turf maze cut like a wheel.

Spades — Places

2. **Willow Ford** [RIVER] [OMEN]
 Flat stones, bowed pollard that remembers faces.
The willow has a name. It will tell you if you sit beneath it and listen.
3. **Cider-Press Barn** [HARVEST] [MEMORY]
 Sweet reek, old songs, doors that stick after dusk.
The press was built from a barrow oak. The oak still dreams.
4. **Chalk Sheep-Downs** [PASTURE] [RITUAL]
 Turf maze cut like a wheel; sheep know the pattern.
The maze is a prayer. Walk it backward to ask a favor.
5. **Millpond Under Alders** [WATER] [OMEN]
 The wheel turns some nights without water.
The water is not water. It is the memory of rain.
6. **Bluebell Wood Path** [FOREST] [WARD]
 Rabbit-gates and snares set by careful hands.
The snares are for the Hollow. They catch only shadows—mostly.
7. **Hedge-Tunnel Lane** [BOUNDARY] [TRICK]
 Between fields; nine stiles, locals count “eight-and-one.”
The ninth stile is a gap in the hedge. Step through, and the lane behind you changes.
8. **Cup-Mark Stone on the Verge** [RITUAL] [OFFERING]
 Butter left in niches goes missing kindly.
The butter vanishes before dawn. The Hollow leaves a pebble in exchange.
9. **Barrow-by-the-Beech** [DEATH] [SILENCE]
 Bees go quiet at noon.
The bees are not sleeping. They are listening.
10. **Market Green** [COMMUNITY] [JUDGMENT]
 Maypole and stocks; carved village stones turned inward.
The stones face the green. They watch the maypole dance—and the dancers.
- J **Dovecote Hill** [OMEN] [FEAR]
 The scarecrow faces the road, not the rows.
The scarecrow has a face. It is the face of the last person who broke guest-right.
- Q **Mother’s Orchard** [HARVEST] [PROMISE]
 Rows straighten if you don’t look—curve if you do.
The orchard is a promise. Break it, and the apples will taste of ash.
- K **Moot Oak** [LAW] [MEMORY]
 Lantern nails hammered deep; benches at the roots.
The nails are from a hundred feuds. Each one holds a grudge.
- A **Hollow Field** [CURSE] [DANGER]
 A ring where no plow will hold a line, not for any coin.
The field is a mouth. It has not fed in a century.

(Keepers/Elders/Mummers/Quiet Powers) Hedge-witch midwife who ties red thread and unties feuds; miller and his watch-geese—better sentries than men.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Hedge-Witch Midwife** [HEALING] [BOUNDARY]
Ties red thread, unties feuds, and knows which births the Hollow watches.
Her thread is from her own hair. She never cuts it—only knots it.
3. **Miller** [WATCHFUL] [LOYALTY]
Watch-geese that remember faces; better sentries than men.
The geese have names. One is “Stranger.” It has never been wrong.
4. **Orchard Reeve** [AUTHORITY] [HARVEST]
Tally-stick, cider-stained smile, and a list of who owes what harvest.
His tally-stick is an apple branch. The notches grow back.
5. **Beekeeper** [SACRED] [SECRET]
Keeps odd honey aside for “winter churches.”
The honey is from barrow flowers. It tastes of earth and old promises.
6. **Shepherd** [COMMAND] [SPIRIT]
Bone whistle that calls dogs—and other things.
The whistle is from a wolf. The wolf still answers.
7. **Lantern-Warden** [WARD] [RITUAL]
Trims lamps and knows which shadow is wrong.
She lights the lamps in a pattern. The pattern is a prayer to keep the Hollow back.
8. **Mummers’ Captain** [TRANSFORMATION] [LAW]
Chest of masks, stricter rules than church.
The masks are not carved. They are grown.
9. **Traveling Tinker** [TRADE] [OATH]
Bright kettles, dull knife for cutting oaths.
The knife was his father’s. His father used it to cut a promise with the Hollow.
10. **Bailiff of the Moot Oak** [LAW] [MEMORY]
Polite as a noose, carries a tally of grudges.
His tally is bark. The writing grows deeper each year.
- J **Wold-Wardens** [TRADITION] [BOUNDARY]
Elders who swear by hedges, not crowns.
They measure time in hedge-layers. A hedge that has grown for a century has a hundred opinions.
- Q **Apple-Matron** [AUTHORITY] [HOSPITALITY]
Hostess of harvest feasts; power sits where she pours.
She pours the first cup for the eldest, the second for the guest, the eighth for the fire. The ninth cup is for the empty chair.
- K **Thresher-King** [SEASONAL] [SACRIFICE]
A title that moves but never leaves; harvest robes, seasonal authority.
He is chosen by the last sheaf. The sheaf is always a little damp.
- A **The Pale Shepherd** [DEATH] [THRESHOLD]
Comes when lambs are born and when people go missing.

He has no face. His hat is a shadow.

(Folk Omens/Rites/Beasts/Night) Unseasonal fog; the road walks you back to your own gate. Scarecrow turns; it watches the lane, not the field. Black sow through the orchard; hooves scuff every charm.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Unseasonal Fog** [WEATHER] [TRAP]
 The road walks you back to your own gate.
The gate is closed. The latch is red. Do not touch it.
3. **Scarecrow Turns** [OMEN] [FEAR]
 It watches the lane, not the field.
The scarecrow's head follows you. The crows are silent.
4. **Soured Wassail** [RITUAL] [DEBT]
 The bowl gives back names you did not speak.
The names are of people who died last winter. They are not listed in any tally.
5. **Black Sow in the Orchard** [CURSE] [OMEN]
 Hooves scuff every charm.
The sow was a woman once. She broke a vow.
6. **Hive-Swarm at Dusk** [NATURE] [OMEN]
 Smoke curls the wrong way.
The bees are spelling a word. The word is “guest.”
7. **Old Song Taken Up by Children** [MEMORY] [TABOO]
 Adults remember the verse none should sing.
The verse is about a barrow that opened. The children think it is a lullaby.
8. **Lanterns Burn Blue at the Ford** [THRESHOLD] [TOLL]
 Crossing costs more than coin.
The blue light is a toll-keeper. Payment is a story—or a secret.
9. **Out-of-Season Mumming** [TRANSFORMATION] [TRAP]
 Masks stick; faces won't come off.
The masks are warm. They have a heartbeat.
10. **Chalk Maze Fills with Mist** [DIMENSION] [DANGER]
 You step out somewhere older.
The mist has a smell—old wool and older bread.
- J **Church Bell Rings Thirteen** [OMEN] [SPIRIT]
 Something attends the sermon.
The thirteenth pew is empty. The dust on it is fresh.
- Q **Harvest Tithe Demanded** [DEBT] [SPIRIT]
 Hands gloved in leaves.
The hands do not belong to anyone in the village.
- K **Moot Oak Bleeds Sap** [OMEN] [VIOLENCE]
 The color of wine; talk turns to knives.
The sap is warm. It tastes of blood and honey.
- A **The Hollow Opens** [CURSE] [DIMENSION]

Burrows and barrows connect; footfalls answer underground.
The footsteps are counting. They stop at eight.

(Blessings/Tokens/Host-Rights) Guest-loaf and salt—one night's safe board anywhere with a red door; cider-mark—a free cup on the green buys gossip and patience.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Guest-Loaf & Salt** [HOSPITALITY] [ONCE]
 One night's safe board anywhere with a red door.
The loaf is barley and rye. Break it with the host, and the Hollow will not cross the threshold—for one night.
3. **Cider-Mark** [SOCIAL] [ONCE]
 A free cup on the green buys gossip and patience.
The mark is a notch on a barrel. The tapster will remember you—or pretend not to.
4. **Hedge-Pass Ribbon** [TRAVEL] [ONCE]
 Step through any thicket un snagged, once.
The ribbon is red. Tie it to a branch, and the thorns will part—once.
5. **Bee-Queen Share** [WARNING] [ONGOING]
 Honey and a warning from the hives when danger nears.
The honey is from a queen who died last year. Her ghost still guards the comb.
6. **Shepherd's Whistle** [COMMAND] [ONCE]
 Dogs and door-bolts heed you for one scene.
The whistle is a knucklebone. Blow it, and the dogs will obey—or they will hide.
7. **Lantern-Writ** [LIGHT] [ONCE]
 The lamps stay lit along your path despite wind.
The writ is a bell. Ring it, and the lamps will not flicker—until dawn.
8. **Mummers' License** [MASQUERADE] [ONCE]
 Lawful mask and after-dark crossing for a feast day.
The license is a wooden mask. Wear it, and the Hollow will see a stranger—not a guest.
9. **Orchard Right** [SECRET] [ONCE]
 Pick at Mother's Orchard without offense; the fruit hides a truth.
The fruit is a secret. Bite it, and the secret will become yours—or it will become you.
10. **Mill Token** [UTILITY] [ONGOING]
 The wheel turns at any hour, grain or rumor ground.
The token is a millstone chip. Feed it to the wheel, and it will grind anything—truths included.
- J **Apple-Matron's Blessing** [PROTECTION] [ONCE]
 Hands help unseen when you ask no coin.
The blessing is a cup. Pour it out in trouble, and the fields will send rain—or roots.
- Q **Private Moot Under the Oak** [JUSTICE] [ONCE]
 Elders hear you alone; precedent sticks.
The moot is held at midnight. The oak's roots are the jury.
- K **Thresher-King's Guard** [ESCORT] [FEAR]
 Six red-hooded harvesters escort you; doors open.
Their hoods are the color of dried blood. They do not speak.

A Pale Shepherd’s Clause

[IMMUNITY] [ONCE]

Once, the Hollow will not notice you; pass uncounted.

The clause is a silence. The Hollow will step aside—and will remember that it did.

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (blessings/tokens/host-rights) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo Hearth & Hollow motifs—quiet bells, red thread, watch-geese, footsteps under the soil—so the dread feels woven through the hedges.

Additional Features

- **Bread & Lantern:** Presenting a guest-loaf and a lit lantern at a threshold shifts your next social action one step safer while you remain a guest of that hearth. The lantern must be lit from the host’s fire.
- **Neighorly Courtesies:** When you keep local taboos (count “eight-and-one,” turn village stones inward, leave butter at cup-marks), cancel the first SB generated by rites or negotiations in that scene.
- **Listen at the Stile:** A quiet pause at a stile, barrow, or hedge-tunnel yields a true omen—ask one short question about what the Hollow wants *here and now*; the answer arrives as a sign, a sound, or a small animal.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Sealed Gate:** Some Aelaerem thresholds are marked with a nail from the Sealed Gate’s original shrines. A door with such a nail can be barred against any spirit for one night—but the nail must be removed before dawn, or the door will never open again.
- **The Savage Heart:** In the deepest hollows, the Hollow is said to wear a bear’s shape during the winter famine. Hedge-keepers leave raw meat at the boundary, not as an offering but as a treaty: “Eat this, not our children.”
- **The Traveler:** Lantern-wardens sometimes find a grey pilgrim waiting at a stile at dusk. The pilgrim asks for directions to a village that no longer exists. Those who answer truthfully find that the next road they walk is half as long.
- **The Clockwork Monad:** Aeler engineers tried to map the hedge-tunnel lanes using breath-bonds and brass chains. The surveyors reported that the lanes would not hold still. The maps were burned. The Aelaerem still smile when asked about it.
- **Ikasha, She Who Sleeps:** The Hollow is sometimes called Ikasha’s shadow—the part of her that did not fall asleep. Aelaerem children are taught never to whisper the name of the dreamer before bed, lest the Hollow mistake them for a messenger.
- **The Ninth:** On the ninth night of a feast, the empty chair is left for the Hollow. If a guest sits in it, the Hollow will take their place at the table. The feast will continue, but the guest will never be full again.

Aelaerem Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Barrow:** Crumble a crust at a cup-mark stone. Ignore the first *Hive-Swarm* penalty.
- **Knot the Ribbon:** Tie a single knot in a red thread at a threshold. Cancel *Out-of-Season Mummung* or take -1 die on your next festival roll (your choice).
- **Name to the Hollow:** Whisper a dead person's name into an empty chair. Gain +1 Effect when invoking guest-right this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Pale Shepherd.

Hearth Magic

The Aelaerem weave their power through careful observance and small courtesies. Their magic lies not in grand gestures but in the precise attention to thresholds, seasons, and the proper ordering of things. Red thread binds more than wounds—it ties names to places, promises to people, and the living to the Hollow that walks beneath their feet. To offend a hedge-witch is to invite the Neighbors' attention; to earn an elder's blessing is to walk with the earth's favor.

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **wardens or hedge-keepers**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **watch-geese or mummers**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or the Hollow**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favorable light**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Orchard reeve or lantern-warden** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **fog or threshold shift**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **scarecrow or Hollow spirit** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **wold-wardens, mummers, or Neighbors** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **taboo broken/geese turn/Hollow stirs**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival: Apple-Matron, Thresher-King, or Pale Shepherd** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **fog thickens/barrow opens/Hollow walks**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Aelaerem (Hearth & Hollow):** Quiet bells toll for no reason; red thread appears tied to your belongings; watch-geese honk warnings in the night.
- **Aelaerem (Threshold Magic):** A door you passed through earlier now leads somewhere else; your shadow walks behind you instead of beside you.
- **Aelaerem (Folk Customs):** You forget a crucial local taboo and offend the Neighbors; small things begin to go wrong—milk sours, knots loosen, a child points at the empty chair.

Boss Archetypes in Aelaerem

- **The Scarecrow Regent (Omen/Threshold)** — A hedge-raised guardian wearing twelve charms and one wrong knot. *Phases:* Stare of the Lane → Scare the Crows → Harvest of Faces. *Cracks:* a **Guest-Loaf** offered to its post; a **Mummers’ License** to wear a mask it cannot read.
- **The Hollow Bride (Otherworld/Hospitality)** — A Neighbor wearing a borrowed name and wedding veil. *Phases:* Invitation Drifted → Feast of Shadows → Ninth Cup Poured. *Cracks:* a **Shepherd’s Whistle** to call the dogs that guard the threshold; a **Lantern-Writ** to see her true face.
- **Lantern Bailiff of the Moot (Justice/Order)** — Enforcer of hedge-law with warrant-nails and bell-keys. *Phases:* Lantern Law → Midnight Moot → Binding Geas. *Cracks:* a **Cider-Mark** to buy a night’s silence; a **Moot Oak bench** to appeal his ruling.
- **Beekeeper of Winter Church (Sacred/Whisper)** — Keeper of cold honey and sleeping hymns. *Phases:* Swarm Omen → Waxed Vow → Memory Tithe. *Cracks:* a **Bee-Queen Share** to call her swarm to heel; a **Lantern** lit from a winter church candle.

Faction Entanglements

- **Wold-Wardens:** Honor hedge-law (count stiles, turn stones inward) or suffer +1 SB on each night march; bringing steel disputes to the Moot Oak reduces the next travel DV by 1.
- **Mummers’ Companies:** Travel under mask grants advantage crossing parochial borders; anger them (perform out of season) and village gates close at dusk (Position –).
- **Lantern-Wardens:** Donate oil or HEAL lamps to earn an escort marker; ignore a lit-lane and pay a “darkness toll” (first Stealth/Scout roll each night suffers –1 die).
- **Apple-Matron Circles:** Feast-days open barns and purses; snub an invitation and local prices double until amends are made.

- **Neighbors (quiet powers):** Leave butter at cup-marks to cancel the first supernatural SB this leg; break taboo and the Hollow stirs (add a *Hollow Attention* tick).

Cross-Regional Ties

- **Aeler Soft-Power:** Red-thread guest-right and courtesies are fashionable among Aeler houses; reputation for keeping hearth-law grants +1 die to parley with Aeler stewards and toll-clerks.
- **Kahfagian Sea-Lanes:** Beeswax, cider-brand, and wool ride river-to-coast. Storm seasons push Kahfagian factors inland—good silver, stricter contracts.
- **Way of Silk Spurs:** Caravans detour across the downs for night-safe lanes under lantern law; counterfeit guest-loaf tokens discovered here echo as distrust along Silk waystations (Social DV +1 until cleared).
- **Valewood Fallout (North):** Moon-sap and dream pollen drift on certain winds: chalk mazes misalign, barrow-whispers grow bold. When *Valewood Weather* is in effect, the first night omen is always true (good or ill).

Encounter Seeds (Quick Hooks)

- **The Hollow Bride's Invitation:** A wedding invitation arrives at the inn. The bride is not from any village on the map. The groom has not been seen in a week. The ninth chair at the feast is already occupied.
- **The Scarecrow's Harvest:** Crows are building a nest on the scarecrow's shoulder. Inside the nest is a key. The key opens a door that should not exist.
- **The Beekeeper's Tithe:** The winter church's bees have stopped producing honey. They are producing wax effigies of the PCs. The beekeeper wants to know why.

Chapter 17

The Valewood

Empire Under Leaves.

The forest here remembers empires that crumbled to dust, and its laws are older than your kingdoms. To walk these paths is to enter into covenant with powers that measure time in seasons, not years.

I am a Pathweaver. My cord has eight knots. The ninth is the one she never ties.

The Valewood isn't just ancient—it's a graveyard of empires, and oh, how the Lethai-ar ghosts love a good deal on forgotten magic. They don't just rule as echoes; they trade in them. The air hums with half-remembered songs, and the ruins bleed their mysteries into root and stream. Fae courts linger in clearings that shift with moonlight, beast-kin patrol moss-choked cairns, and echoes of imperial shades still march patrols on vanished streets.

The Hazel Queen speaks only in conditional tense. The Alder King's crown is a noose of thorns. The Huntsman's face is a stag's skull, and his voice is the wind in the leaves. The forest does not forgive arrogance. It expects humility, patience, and the willingness to trade a piece of yourself for safe passage.

Never eat the fruit of a tree that has a face. The forest does not forget its debtors, and the first bite is always the price of admission. The second bite is the interest.

— *Pathweaver Sila, who knows every star-road but will not speak their names*

The Almanac of Ordinary Days

What do people eat for breakfast? Acorn bread and wild honey—the acorns are leached in stream-water for three days, the honey is taken from hives in the high branches. The bees are sacred. The bees are not to be harmed. A beekeeper who harms a bee is cursed. The curse is the stinging. The stinging is endless.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To name the trees. Valewood children are taught the names of the eight sacred groves: Hazel, Alder, Oak, Rowan, Ash, Thorn, Yew, and the ninth—the one that has no name. The ninth grove is where the Hollow sleeps. The Hollow is not to be woken.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their way-cord. Every Valewood traveler carries a knotted cord—one knot for each mile they have walked. A stranger whose cord has nine knots has walked the forbidden path. A stranger whose cord is knotted with red thread is a Pathweaver. A stranger with no cord has no way. The forest will find them. The forest will lead them in circles until they forget why they came.

What is the most common crime? Breaking the star-road—but the star-roads are not roads, they are agreements. A traveler who strays from the path is a traveler who breaks the covenant. The covenant is older than the Valewood. The covenant was made between the first trees and the first stars. The stars do not forgive. The trees do not forget.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Hazel Queen is not the queen. She is the voice of the forest—a title that passes from dryad to dryad with each turning of the season. The current Queen has held the title for three centuries. She is not a dryad. She is a ghost—the last survivor of the empire that fell beneath the leaves. She remembers the cities. She remembers the stones. She remembers the names of the dead. The dead do not remember her.

Where do people go when they die? To the star-roads—the paths that lead between the trees and between the worlds. The dead are not buried. They are laid on stone altars at the edges of the groves. The stars pull them upward. The trees pull them downward. The dead choose. The dead always choose the trees. The trees remember.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You offer a name—your own or another's. The forest accepts the name. The forest weaves it into the bark of the oldest oak. The oak is called the Witness. The Witness has stood for nine thousand years. The Witness has never forgotten a single name. The Witness will not forget yours.

What is the most important festival? The Turning of the Leaves (autumn). The trees shed their colours in a single day. The leaves carpet the forest floor. The leaves are gathered and burned in the high clearings. The smoke carries the year's debts to the stars. The stars answer with light. The light is forgiveness. The light is also a warning.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Alder King is not a king. He is the forest's warden—a title passed from fallen empire to fallen empire. The current King is a Lethai-ar who was born in the year the last empire fell. He has not aged since. He does not eat. He does not drink. He does not sleep. He walks the star-roads at night. The star-roads are empty. The dead have stopped walking.

17.1 Valewood — “Empire Under Leaves”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *The forest remembers. Speak truth, step lightly, and never eat the fruit of a tree with a face.*

Hazel Queen (Elite): “The forest here remembers empires that crumbled to dust, and its laws are older than your kingdoms. To walk these paths is to enter into covenant with powers that measure time in seasons, not years.”

Pathweaver (Commoner): “The woods here got a mind of their own – they’ll lead you where you need to go if you ask right, but they’ll just as soon lose you if you’re carrying ill intent. Best know which is which before you wander off the path.”

Genre / Mood: Dark forest, fey remnant, imperial echo, folk horror.

Starting Location: A moss-covered amphitheatre where roots crawl through marble benches and owls whisper verdicts to the wind. An Owl-Sister speaks in riddles: “The Lethai-ar stir. The paths remember your true name. Speak it into the hollow of this stone, or the forest will learn it from your footsteps.”

Theme & Atmosphere

The Valewood is older than kingdoms, older than the maps that skirt its borders. Beneath its canopy lie the bones of a Lethai empire whose name is forgotten, its towers swallowed by vine and root, its star-roads cracked and phasing between worlds. The air hums with half-remembered songs of magic, and the ruins bleed their mysteries into root and stream. Fae courts linger in clearings that shift with moonlight, beast-kin patrol moss-choked cairns, and echoes of imperial shades still march patrols on vanished streets. To walk the Valewood is to risk being claimed by it: as guest, prey, heir—or trespasser.

What you notice first: The smell of wet moss and old stone. The way the light filters through leaves like stained glass. The silence that falls when you speak a name too loudly.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never eat the fruit of a tree that has a face. The forest does not forget its debtors, and the first bite is always the price of admission.

Regional Mood: Leaves, Oaths, and Echoes

Here, the past is not past—it phases in and out like moonlight on water. The Lethai-ar who remain are not conquerors but custodians, tending to laws written before the first human kingdom rose. The fae courts of Hazel and Alder play their endless games of courtesy and obligation, and the beast-kin speak in parliaments where every vote is a scent. Imperial shades march through walls that no longer exist, and the star-roads hum with geometries that twist the unwary into yesterday. The Valewood does not forgive arrogance. It expects humility, patience, and the willingness to trade a piece of yourself for safe passage.

Prominent NPCs of the Valewood

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Queen Amalthea	Hazel Queen, sovereign of the Hazel Court	Preserve the old pacts and keep the empire from waking	She has never spoken a lie. She has never needed to.
King Thorn	Alder King, ruler of the Twilit Court	Collect debts, old and new, and expand the forest's reach	His crown is a noose of thorns. He wears it proudly.
Pathweaver Sila	Lethai-ar guide (commoner exemplar)	Knot safe routes and keep the star-roads from bleeding	Her cord has eight knots; the ninth is the one she never ties.
Bramble	Fox-headed courier of the beast-kin	Deliver messages that cannot be written	The price is always a secret, and the secret is always bitter.
The Huntsman	Antlered hunter of the Moonlit Ride	Claim those who break the forest's laws	His face is a stag's skull; his voice is the wind in the leaves.
Shardwright Kael	Artisan who repairs the star-roads	Wake the ancient ways before they fade forever	Her chisel is a tooth from the first dragon. She stole it.

Names of the Valewood

Inspired by the old Lethai language and the fae courts: flowing vowels, soft consonants, and names that feel like they belong to a forgotten song.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Caelith	Amalthea	Thornweave	<i>the Green</i>
Eryndor	Sila	Starfoot	<i>Oath-Woven</i>
Kael	Liriel	Hawthorn	<i>the Unseen</i>
Oren	Vesper	Silverbough	<i>Hollow-Tongue</i>
Riven	Fenn	Mossglen	<i>the Last</i>
Thorn	Myrin	Gloaming	<i>Ash-Finger</i>

(Phasing Ruin/Star-Road/Living Stone) Star-road shard with pale flagstones that hum when trod in sequence; rooted amphitheatre with moss-seats remembering speeches.

Spades — Places

2. **Star-Road Shard** — Pale flagstones hum when trod in sequence; a path between worlds. ‘[MAGIC]’ *The sequence is always incomplete. The missing step is the one you hesitate to take.*
 3. **Rooted Amphitheatre** — Moss-seats remember speeches not yet given; a stage for fate. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *Sit in the high seat, and the roots will ask you a question. Answer wrong, and you may never stand.*
 4. **Moon-Cistern** — Reflecting sky that isn’t tonight’s; water as a mirror of truth. ‘[MAGIC]’ ‘[TRUTH]’ *The reflection shows what you lost, not what you carry. Look away before it names you.*
 5. **Glyphed Bridge** — Across a dry stream; glyphs glow when lies pass; truth as a toll. ‘[TRUTH]’ ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The bridge has no railings. Liars fall—into the stream, or into memory.*
 6. **Glassleaf Gallery** — Boughs grown into panes, dust like constellations; beauty as a barrier. ‘[MAGIC]’ *The dust is crushed star-road. Breathe it, and you will dream of the empire’s fall.*
 7. **Hollow Aqueduct** — Water runs uphill if the song is right; magic in the melody. ‘[MAGIC]’ *The song has eight verses. The ninth is the silence that follows.*
 8. **Calendar Grove** — Standing-trees aligned to solstices; one trunk is stone; time as architecture. ‘[RITUAL]’ *The stone tree bleeds sap once a year. Collect it, and the forest owes you a season.*
 9. **Unfound Arcade** — Arches appear at dusk, vanish at dawn; reality as a schedule. ‘[MYSTERY]’ *The arches have names—Carved on the inside. You must walk through to read them.*
 10. **Breathing City** — Vine-choked streets shift on the hour; a ruin as a living thing. ‘[DUNGEON]’ *The vines pulse with a slow heartbeat. The city is sleeping, not dead.*
- J **Amber Ziggurat** — Caught mid-construction for a thousand years; time as an artifact. ‘[LEGEND]’ *The workers are statues of amber. Their eyes follow you.*
- Q **Ivory Observatory** — Brass orrery tracks two lost moons; the sky as memory. ‘[MAGIC]’ *The moons are not in any sky you know. One of them is yours.*
- K **Throne-Bower** — Living alder and argent wire; the seat of forgotten power. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *Sit here, and the forest will crown you—or crush you. You won’t know which until the leaves settle.*
- A **Valeheart Spire** — The empire’s axle; stairs that end where they began. ‘[LEGEND]’ *The spire has no top. It has only a center. Finding it is the journey.*

(**Lethai-ar/Fae/Beast-kin**) Pathweaver who knots safe routes into cord; fox-headed courier with a promise braided into its tail.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Pathweaver** — Lethai-ar guide who knots safe routes into cord; navigation as community. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *Her cord has eight knots. The ninth is the one she never ties.*
3. **Fox-Courier** — Promise braided into its tail; messages as living things. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *It will deliver anything—for a price. The price is always a secret.*

4. **Owl-Sister** — Pupils show yesterday; her hands show yours; sight as prophecy. ‘[MAGIC]’
She never blinks. If she does, the future has changed.
5. **Antler-Hunter** — Sworn to keep the cities sleeping; a guardian of rest. ‘[COMBAT]’ *His*
spear is a sharpened root. It grows back when broken.
6. **Moss-Scribe** — Writes deeds in lichen, reads stone like vellum; law as growth. ‘[LAW]’ *Her*
ink is rainwater and regret. The words fade when the promise is kept.
7. **Lark-Keeper** — Caged bird sings warnings strangers can’t hear; danger as song. ‘[OMEN]’
The lark’s song is a map. Learn it, and you can walk anywhere—once.
8. **Green Neighbor** — Fae courtier wearing a borrowed smile and boots; hospitality as a trap. ‘[FAE]’
Never accept a gift from a Green Neighbor. It’s never a gift.
9. **Warden-Coterie** — Beast-kin (badger, stag, lynx); one law: no digging deep. ‘[COMMUNITY]’
They speak in growls and gestures. The lynx is the one who remembers faces.
10. **Echo-Legionary** — Imperial shade bound to a patrol that never ends; duty as a curse. ‘[DEATH]’
Its sword passes through stone but not through flesh. Run, don’t fight.
- J **Shardwright** — Ancient artisan who wakes star-road with a chisel; craft as resurrection. ‘[CRAFT]’
Her chisel is a tooth from the first dragon. She stole it.
- Q **Hazel Queen** — Lethai-ar sovereign in leaf and law; wisdom as authority. ‘[AUTHORITY]’
She has never spoken a lie. She has never needed to.
- K **Alder King** — Twilit Court sovereign in shadow and debt; power as obligation. ‘[AUTHORITY]’
His crown is a noose of thorns. He wears it proudly.
- A **The Huntsman** — Antlers of moonlight; shortcuts owe him; the path as price. ‘[DEATH]’
His face is a stag’s skull. His voice is the wind in the leaves.

(Glamour/Ward-Trap/Imperial Residue) Sweet wind nudges landmarks hedge-width—enough to matter; path reverses—footprints vote to go elsewhere.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Sweet Wind** — Nudges landmarks hedge-width—enough to matter; navigation as deception. ‘[WEATHER]’ ‘[TRICK]’
The wind smells of honey and lies. Do not trust your nose.
3. **Path Reversal** — Footprints vote to go elsewhere; direction as democracy. ‘[MAGIC]’ *Your*
tracks point the way you came—even when you haven’t turned.
4. **Ward-Trap** — Ancient security treats you as yesterday’s invader; the past as prison. ‘[TRAP]’
The glyphs were set by a dead queen. She still enforces her grudges.
5. **Oath-Magnet** — Spoken promises stick and reshape plans; word as binding magic. ‘[OATH]’
Every “I will” becomes a knot. Every “I won’t” becomes a chain.

Oath-Magnet Mechanics

When a character makes a promise in the Valewood, the GM creates a **Promise Clock** [4]. Each time the character acts against that promise (or fails to act in its favour), tick the clock. When it fills, the forest extracts a toll: 1 Fatigue, a lost memory (erase a minor fact or face), or a minor geas (the GM chooses). Breaking a promise intentionally (not through failure) instantly ticks the clock twice.

6. **Geas Catch** — A careless word triggers a task that names itself; speech as summoning. ‘[OATH]’ *You said “if only.” Now the forest has heard you.*
7. **City Phase** — Streets rotate; the exit becomes a balcony; space as puzzle. ‘[DUNGEON]’ *The city breathes. You are in its lungs.*
8. **Name-Theft** — Something learns your true name’s edges; the tests begin. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[FEAR]’ *First, you forget a minor debt. Then a friend’s face. Then your own.*

Name-Theft Mechanics

When **Name-Theft** occurs, the GM secretly records one piece of the target’s identity (a memory, a bond, a talent name). The target suffers –1 die on any roll that would rely on that piece until it is restored by a quest or a bargain with the thief (often a fae or shade).

9. **Ring Claim** — A circle names you host; feeding guests becomes law. ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[COMMUNITY]’ *The mushrooms are listening. They will remember what you serve.*
10. **Mirror Rain** — Leaf-drips replay choices you didn’t make; the past as echo. ‘[MAGIC]’ *The rain shows you a path you refused. Now it offers it again—with interest.*
- J **Redcaps Abroad** — Hats wet, boots quick, courtesies thin; violence as hospitality. ‘[COMBAT]’ ‘[FAE]’ *They will ask for a kiss or a coin. Refuse, and they take both.*
- Q **Court Tithe** — Truth, song, or memory you’d miss; the price as sacrifice. ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[OATH]’ *The courtier opens its hand. What you place there is never returned.*
- K **Muster of Boughs** — Green banners rise; travel becomes trespass. ‘[WAR]’ ‘[FEAR]’ *The boughs bear old sigils. The war they remember ended a thousand years ago.*
- A **Empire Wakes** — A district aligns; doors open, guardians open farther. ‘[APOCALYPSE]’ *The shades have orders. You are the target.*

(**Charm/Key/Truce-Bough**) Way-cord knot points to the true next turn; dew-mirror shows a thing as it is, not as it is sung.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Way-Cord** — A knot points to the true next turn (once); navigation as a gift. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The knot is a breath tied in silk. Untie it to find your way—or to lose it forever.*
3. **Dew-Mirror** — See a thing as it is, not as it is sung, for one scene; truth as a tool. ‘[TRUTH]’ *The mirror is a drop of water on a leaf. It dries when the lie dies.*

4. **Hazel Token** — Lawful crossing of a warded hedge without snag; permission as paper. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The token is a hazelnut. Crack it open; the kernel is your password.*
 5. **Honey-Right** — Eat and speak safely at any bee-stone ring; hospitality as law. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The honey is golden. Taste it, and the bees will know you as a guest—once.*
 6. **Name-Bead** — A kept promise warms; a broken one chills and glows; an oath as a magic item. ‘[OATH]’ *The bead is warm in your palm. If it cools, you have forgotten someone.*
 7. **Wind-Veil** — Mute a sweet wind’s lies for a short walk; truth as protection. ‘[WEATHER]’ *The veil is a scrap of silk. Breathe through it, and the wind cannot speak.*
 8. **City-Shard** — Wake one gate or stair in a phasing ruin; a key as a catalyst. ‘[MAGIC]’ *The shard is a piece of a star-road. Hold it to the lock, and the ruin answers.*
 9. **Truce-Bough** — Hunt, cut, or camp without offense in a named copse; peace as a branch. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The bough is green. Plant it in the ground, and the forest will not harm you—or help you.*
 10. **Oathsap** — Seal a pact that even echoes respect; a promise as a binding force. ‘[OATH]’ *The sap is warm. Drink it, and your words become stone—for good or ill.*
- J **Shardwright’s Favor** — Repair or light a length of star-road; craft as power. ‘[CRAFT]’ *The favor is a chip of amber. The Shardwright will come when you break it.*
- Q **Hazel Audience** — One whisper exits as policy; word as law. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The audience is a leaf. Speak into its spine, and the Hazel Queen will listen—once.*
- K **Alder Writ** — Levies defer, wardens guide, scribes stop arguing; authority as writ. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The writ is a thorn. Carry it in your boot, and the Alder King’s debtors will make way.*
- A **Valeheart Clause** — A temporary exception to any local rule, spoken in leaves. ‘[LEGEND]’ *The clause is a rustle. The forest will pretend it didn’t hear—but it will remember.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (charms/keys/passes) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- Empire Echo: when a J/Q/K is the highest rank in your seed, add one visible relic-logic (floating stairs, singing locks, patrol shades).
- If any A appears, echo **leaf and light** motifs—paths that remember, leaves that whisper, light that moves like water.

Additional Features

- **Forest Claims:** Any oath, bargain, or gift exchanged binds with more weight. Once per session, a spoken promise becomes magically enforceable: breaking it creates 1d4 SB and echoes through scenes.
- **Ruins Awaken:** If you linger at an ancient site, roll or draw to see which mechanism stirs. May grant guidance (lit star-road, a memory shown) or danger (patrol shades, collapsing glyphs).
- **Court Interference:** Encounters with fae or beast-kin are never neutral. Once per session,

the GM may convert a Diamond into a demand for hospitality, tribute, or alliance—shifting the expedition’s tone.

- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**

- **The Unseen Court** — The Witness. *A parliament of silent roots that remembers every broken promise.*
- **The Root-King** — The Alder King (local aspect). *Debt that grows like a vine, choked by its own leaves.*
- **The Star-Weaver** — The Ninth. *The missing thread in every star-road, the silence after the song.*
- **The Green Saint** — Oath of Flame & Light (syncretic). *A martyr who fed her own name to the Hollow to seal a breach.*

Forest Mood (d6 per scene)

Forest Mood Table

1. **Hazel’s Favour** – Paths open willingly. +1 die to navigation rolls this scene.
2. **Alder’s Hunger** – Debts are called. Someone in the scene must offer a memory or service to proceed.
3. **Empire Wakes** – A patrol of imperial shades marches through. Avoid or pay a toll (1 Fatigue or a secret).
4. **Beast-kin Moot** – Animals gather and watch. They will not attack unless provoked, but they remember faces.
5. **Sweet Wind** – All navigation rolls suffer –1 die; landmarks shift subtly.
6. **Green Gate Breath** – A threshold appears. Crossing it leads to a different part of the forest (or a different time).

Star-Road Discovery (d6)

When the party encounters a star-road shard or attempts to wake a segment, roll on this table for an additional feature:

1. **Singing Stones** – The flagstones hum a tune. Anyone who sings along gains +1 die on the next roll.
2. **Echo of an Emperor** – A ghostly figure appears and asks a riddle. A correct answer grants a **City-Shard**.
3. **Fractured Timeline** – The road shows a glimpse of the future (1d6 scenes ahead). The GM must answer one yes/no question truthfully.
4. **Ward-Trap** – The segment is booby-trapped. Trigger a **Ward-Trap** complication (see Clubs).
5. **Shardwright’s Cache** – Hidden nearby is a **Shardwright’s Favor** (Diamond) or a rare component (e.g., amber shard).
6. **The Ninth Step** – The sequence has a hidden ninth stone. Stepping on it teleports the party to a **Valeheart Spire** or a court audience.

Beast-kin Traits (for NPCs or PC ancestry)

Beast-kin are not a single species but a loose alliance of animal-aspected beings. Use these traits for quick NPCs or optional player characters.

Beast-kin Traits

- **Scent Memory:** +1 die to track a creature you have smelled before.
- **Parliament Oath:** Once per session, you may invoke the beast-kin moot to ask a local animal one simple question (the GM answers truthfully).
- **Claw or Fang:** Unarmed strikes deal Harm 1 and count as Light weapons.
- **Optional:** Choose a lineage:
 - *Stag:* +1 die to resist being moved or knocked prone.
 - *Lynx:* +1 die to stealth in forest terrain.
 - *Badger:* You may burrow through loose earth at half speed.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Genesis Vats (The Clockwork Monad):** Deep beneath the Amber Ziggurat lie the empire's failed laboratories. Here, the Lethai ancients combined elf and beast, hoping to create the perfect guardian. The vats still hum, and the beast-kin who survived do not speak of what they saw. The Shardwrights say the Monad's pressure is still optimising the old designs, and that one day the vats will open again.
- **The Parliament of Claw and Fur (The Savage Heart):** The beast-kin are not savages. They hold a moot once every season, deep in a clearing that no star-road touches. Their laws are carved in scent and scar, and their judgments are final. The Savage Heart speaks through their eldest, but it does not command—it suggests. Outsiders who attend the moot must bring a true name of a foe and leave it on the speaking stone. Those who lie are given fur and four legs, and are hunted at the next moon.
- **Saint Oren of the Unfinished Star (The Ninth):** A Lethai-ar astronomer who calculated the exact angle at which the empire's star-roads would collapse. He was erased from the imperial records, but his ghost still walks the Ivory Observatory, tracing equations in starlight. Those who find him may ask one question about the forest's hidden geometry. The answer is always a single number, and that number is a debt.
- **The Grey Pilgrims (The Traveler):** A wandering order of Lethai-ar who maintain the old way-cords. They wear grey cloaks woven from mist and speak only in riddles. It is said that if you give a Grey Pilgrim a lock of your hair, they will knot it into your way-cord, and you will never be lost in the Valewood again—but you will also never find a place you truly wish to leave.
- **The Daughters of the Cord (The Bitter Root):** A renegade Sister hides among the moss-scribes of the Rooted Amphitheatre, trying to untie her own cord from the Hazel Queen's ledger. She claims the queen's hospitality is a cage, and that the forest's memory is a trap. The Hazel Queen has not corrected her; she only smiles, and the roots grow tighter each night.
- **The Ninth:** In any Valewood scene, the ninth leaf to fall from a tree will land pointing to a hidden threshold. The wise catch it—or pretend they didn't see. Those who follow the leaf's direction find a place that was not there a moment ago, and something old waits inside.

Valewood Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Roots:** Crumble a crust at the base of a standing stone. Ignore the first *Sweet Wind* penalty. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Knot the Cord:** Tie a single knot in a way-cord. Cancel *Oath-Magnet* or take –1 die on your next promise (your choice). ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Name to the Cistern:** Whisper a dead enemy’s name into the Moon-Cistern. Gain +1 Effect when evading fae this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Alder King. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’

Patronage & Power

In the Valewood, power flows through ancient magic, forgotten oaths, and the delicate balance between guest and host. The Lethai-ar maintain influence through their knowledge of paths and ruins, while the fae courts wield power through hospitality and geas. Beast-kin serve as guardians of the deeper mysteries, and the echoes of the empire still patrol their eternal rounds, enforcing laws written in starlight and stone.

For the GM: Patronage in the Valewood revolves around hospitality, knowledge, and the careful navigation of ancient laws. Rewards often take the form of charms, keys, or safe passage that can be leveraged into greater influence. To emphasize this:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (tokens, mirrors, cords) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided.
- Let rival courts issue conflicting protections, forcing players to choose whose favour matters more.
- Use the ruins, groves, and star-roads as arenas for social contests, where knowledge of ancient customs determines success.

In the Valewood, your word is your world, and your world determines whether you walk as a guest or a ghost.

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **wardens or fae scouts**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **echo-legionaries or beast-kin**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or imperial shades**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favorable phase**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Pathweaver or moss-scribe** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **path reversal or city phase**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **redcap band or patrol shade** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **fae courtiers**, **beast-kin**, or **imperial echoes** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **geas triggers/ruin awakens/court interferes**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **Hazel Queen**, **Alder King**, or **Huntsman** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **city phases/paths shift/empire wakes**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Valewood (Magic Paths):** Routes rearrange without warning, bridges appear mid-step, directions become riddles.
- **Valewood (Fae Law):** Promises bind mid-speech, gifts carry hidden costs, hospitality turns to obligation.
- **Valewood (Imperial Echoes):** Patrols march through walls, ancient mechanisms activate, past and present blur.

Boss Seeds (three-phase foes)

- **The Huntsman of Shortcuts (antlers of moonlight)** — *Phases:* Owe the Cut → Step Across → Tally the Tread. *Cracks:* present a **Truce-Bough** to halt pursuit; a **Way-Cord** cancels *Step Across* once.
- **Redcap Captain Rill (hat never dries)** — *Phases:* Hospitality Turned → Knee the Truth → Boot-Hook. *Cracks:* **Honey-Right** reverses one phase; **Dew-Mirror** exposes his “host right.”
- **Echo Centurion of the XIII Star-Road (bronze mask)** — *Phases:* Reform the Line → Juridical Recall → Standard Rekindled. *Cracks:* a **City-Shard** lets you counter-order once; a **Moss-Scribe** ruling cancels *Juridical Recall*.
- **Shardwright Unmended (glassy chisels)** — *Phases:* Cut the Clock → Wrong Stone → Wake the Segment. *Cracks:* offer **Oathsap** to bind a repair oath; **Shardwright’s Favor** flips *Wrong Stone*.
- **The Hazel Advocate (mask of living bark)** — *Phases:* Measure the Word → Prune the Lie → Court Silence. *Cracks:* **Hazel Token** grants speaking rights; **Oathsap** lets you safely retract one bound clause.

Legendary Sites & Trials

- **Glyphed Bridge Ordeal** — Speak a hard truth to pass dry; lie, and the bridge demands a memory tithe (mark *Name Leverage* +1, gain *Bridge’s Favor* only if confessed).
- **Moon-Cistern Vigil** — Watch someone else’s sky until the owl calls; success grants a single **Dew-Mirror** charge; failure spawns **Mirror Rain**.
- **Valeheart Spiral** — Climb stairs that return to start; map with verse, gift, count, listen (all four once) to unlock a *Between-Places* shortcut.

Extensions (Plug-in)

- **Name Economy (true-name pressure):**
 - Each PC has *Name Facets*: **Called-Name** (common), **Given-Name** (trusted), **True-Edge** (dangerous).
 - When a foe or court learns a deeper facet, mark *Name Leverage* [3]. At 3, they may compel one precise action or forbid one path unless countered by a $\Diamond$ or **Oathsap**.
 - You may trade a shallower facet to erase 1 tick from *Name Leverage* but gain *Rumor Tail* condition until scene end.
- **Hospitality Ledger (guest/host law):**
 - When *Honey-Right* or *Truce-Bough* is invoked, set a 3-step *Table Owed* clock for the host and a 3-step *Courtesy Owed* for the guest.
 - Ticking your clock grants +1d to social tests with that party; overpaying (4+) converts 1 tick into a portable *Favor Twig* (spend for +1 Position later).
 - Breaking either clock spawns **Ring Claim** or **Oath-Magnet** at the keeper’s option.
- **Path-Logic Mini-game (finding the true way):**
 - Two opposed clocks per journey: *True Way* vs *Forest Has You* (size by highest rank in the seed).
 - Each leg, pick an *Approach*: **Rhyme** (speak a pattern), **Count** (steps/time), **Gift** (leave a token), **Listen** (ambient omen).
 - Edge: Rhyme→Gift (courtesies bind), Gift→Count (the land answers), Count→Listen (timing frames the omen), Listen→Rhyme (echo feeds verse).
 - Spend a **Way-Cord** to flip a failed leg; spend a **Wind-Veil** to ignore **Sweet Wind** once.
- **Truth Mechanics (seeing through glamour):**
 - **Dew-Mirror** reveals one *Unkind Fact* in the scene; naming it aloud gives +1 Effect but ticks **Court Tithe** +1.
 - **Glyphed Bridge** judges the next lie uttered; if you pass speaking truth, gain *Bridge’s Favor* (+1 Position on crossings hereafter). If you lie, mark **Name-Theft** +1.
- **Star-Road Procedure (phasing traversal):**
 - To wake a segment: meet two of three—*Proper Footfall* (count/pattern), *Shard Key* (City-Shard, Shardwright help), *Witness* (owl, echo-legionary, or courtier).
 - Success grants *Between-Places*: one safe shortcut and one *Echo Fee* (memory, song, or small timeline bruise chosen by the GM).
 - On a miss, spawn **Ward-Trap** or **City Phase**.

- **Court Etiquette (Hazel vs Alder):**
 - **Hazel Audience:** pays in *precision*—exact words, measured gifts. +1d when you cite prior custom or present a **Moss-Scribe** ruling.
 - **Alder Writ:** pays in *obligation*—future tasks, debts. +1 Effect when you promise service; tick **Oath-Magnet** +1.
- **Start-of-Scene Omens (1d6):**
 1. *Leaf-Whisper:* first Listen/Study gets +1d; first boast draws **Geas Catch**.
 2. *Antler Shadow:* the Huntsman watches—shortcuts improve; hiding worsens.
 3. *Mirror Drip:* **Dew-Mirror** free use but **Court Tithe** starts at 1.
 4. *Root Push:* terrain shifts in your favor once; buildings dislike you (locks complicate).
 5. *Bird Parliament:* a rumor arrives true; one plan becomes public knowledge.
 6. *Star-Tingle:* star-road easier (+1d to wake) but every $\Diamond$ *hereafter* risks **Ward-Trap** on 1~2.
- **Plug-in SB Conversions (Valewood Flavor):**
 - 1 SB $\rightarrow$ *Sweet Wind Shift:* reposition an approach vector; -1d unless you adjust method (Rhyme/Count/Gift/Listen).
 - 2 SB $\rightarrow$ *Obligate Courtesy:* immediate small gift or truth required; refuse and tick *Name Leverage* +1.
 - 3+ SB $\rightarrow$ *Empire Echo:* add a patrolling **Echo-Legionary** cohort or activate a dormant mechanism that reframes the scene.
- **Reputation Echoes:**
 - *Guest-Faithful:* once/session, downgrade **Ring Claim** to simple hospitality; the next refused invitation spawns **Oath-Magnet**.
 - *Path-Favored:* +1 Position on *Path-Logic* legs; any shortcut taken owes a *token or tale*.
 - *Truth-Bearer:* +1d with the Hazel court when presenting facts; -1d with the Alder court when declining obligation.
- **Quick Cross-Region Hooks:**
 - *Kahfagia Lanes* $\leftrightarrow$ *Star-Roads:* a **Mirror Warrant** can stand in for a **Shard Key** once.
 - *Mistlands Bells* $\leftrightarrow$ *Path-Logic:* paying **Ward-Salt** counts as the *Gift* approach with +1d.
 - *Aelinnel Math* $\leftrightarrow$ *Proper Footfall:* *Counting Etiquette* grants +1 Position on the **Star-Road Procedure**.

Artifacts of the Valewood

The Valewood remembers not only oaths and names but also the tools of those who came before. Some artifacts are cursed by the empire's fall; others are blessed by the forest's slow patience. Each artifact carries its own burden—a fragment of will that accumulates Obligation as it is used. When the Obligation fills, the artifact demands a price, just as a Patron does.

Artifact Obligation Rules

- An artifact has an **Obligation Capacity** equal to the wielder's **Spirit** (or a fixed number, as noted). Mark Obligation each time a Rite is invoked.

- When Obligation exceeds Capacity, the wielder marks 1 Fatigue per extra segment (as per standard Obligation overflow).
- When the artifact’s Obligation clock reaches double its Capacity, it **demand**s a price (see each artifact’s “Demand”). Refusing the demand may cause the artifact to become *Compromised* (unusable until a quest is completed) or to inflict a permanent curse.
- Obligation can be cleared through acts of service aligned with the artifact’s nature (e.g., protecting a grove, telling a forgotten truth, shedding your own blood).
- Bound by Obligation: An artifact cannot be permanently discarded or destroyed while you owe it Obligation. If you deliberately abandon it (or attempt to destroy it by mundane means), it reappears beside you at the next dawn, and you mark +1 Obligation. This penalty applies only once per artifact; subsequent attempts to abandon it cause the artifact to become Compromised – it still reappears, but its Rites cannot be invoked until you perform a minor act of devotion (GM’s choice). An artifact can be legitimately transferred to another willing creature, clearing your Obligation; the new owner inherits any remaining Obligation. An artifact can be permanently destroyed only by a specific method (e.g., a star-road shard, a dragon’s tooth, or the Hazel Queen’s permission), which typically requires a quest.

Artifact	Description	Rites (Abilities)	Demand (Obligation 2×Cap)
<i>Echo’s Lament</i>	A silver hand-bell with a cracked clapper. When rung, it repeats the last words spoken at the site of an imperial execution.	Rite of the Last Echo (Low) – Ask one question about a death that occurred within Near range; the bell answers with a whisper. Mark +1 Obligation.	The wielder must pronounce a true name of someone they have wronged, aloud and unasked, before the next full moon.
<i>Thorn-Fang</i>	A dagger carved from a single hawthorn root, its edge weeping sap that smells of iron and honey.	Rite of the Unhealing Prick (Low) – On a successful melee attack, the wound bleeds for 1 additional Fatigue per scene (non-stacking). Mark +1 Obligation.	The dagger demands a drop of the wielder’s own blood before each dawn; if refused, it turns on its owner (next attack targets self).
<i>Glassleaf Lantern</i>	A lantern whose panes are made of petrified leaves. It burns without oil, casting light that reveals only things that are lost.	Rite of the Unfound Path (Standard) – Once per scene, the lantern illuminates a hidden threshold or a forgotten memory in the area. Gain +2 dice to Investigation or Navigation for that task. Mark +2 Obligation.	The lantern demands to be left at a crossroads at midnight. If not, it will guide the wielder into a dead end (next travel leg automatically fails).

<i>Cord of Eight Knots</i>	A finger-thick rope of braided grey wool, with eight tight knots. The ninth knot is missing.	Rite of the Unbroken Promise (Low) – Tie the cord around a willing creature’s wrist; until untied, that creature cannot willingly break a spoken oath. Mark +1 Obligation.	The cord demands a ninth knot, which must be tied in a strand of hair from someone who has broken a vow. Untying any existing knot costs 1 Fatigue.
<i>Alder King’s Tooth</i>	A black, curling tooth set in a copper ring. When worn, it whispers the debts of those nearby.	Rite of Debt-Sense (Low) – Concentrate for a moment; learn the single greatest debt owed by a creature you can see (in vague terms: “a life,” “a stolen heirloom”). Mark +1 Obligation.	The tooth demands that you collect a minor debt (a few coins, a favour) from someone weaker than you before sunset. If you refuse, it begins listing your own debts aloud.
<i>Shardwright’s Mallet</i>	A stone hammer with a handle of petrified wood. One side is smooth (to repair), the other rough (to break).	Rite of the Broken Seal (Standard) – Strike a phasing ruin or star-road shard. Either temporarily stabilise it (open a safe passage) or shatter it (destroy the path, cause a Ward-Trap). Mark +2 Obligation.	The mallet demands that you break something precious to you (a gift, a memento, a tool) and leave the pieces on a star-road.
<i>Mirror of Unfinished Faces</i>	A hand mirror with a silvered surface that shows not your reflection but a version of you who made a different choice.	Rite of the Other Self (Low) – Gaze into the mirror; gain +1 die on your next roll that involves a decision (the other self’s memory guides you). Mark +1 Obligation.	The mirror demands that you speak aloud the choice you regret most, to a stranger, within a day. If you refuse, the other self begins to appear in reflections, whispering doubts.

<i>Whispering Horn</i>	A curved horn of amber, cracked along one side. When blown, it sounds like the roar of a forgotten beast.	Rite of the Imperial Hunt (Standard) – Once per session, blow the horn to summon a spectral pack of hounds that track a designated target for one scene (grants +1 die to tracking and pursuit). Mark +2 Obligation.	The horn demands a hunt – you must chase and catch something (even a mouse) within the hour, or the spirits will hunt you instead (suffer Harm 1 from ethereal bites).
<i>Grave-Moss Cloak</i>	A heavy cloak woven from moss that grows only on imperial barrows. It is always damp and smells of rain.	Rite of the Walking Dead (Low) – Pull the hood up; for one scene, imperial shades treat you as one of their own (no attacks, you may pass patrols). Mark +1 Obligation per scene of use.	The cloak demands that you bury something that was never buried – a memory, a secret, a tooth. If you fail to do so before the next moon, it wraps itself around your throat in your sleep.
<i>Hazel Queen’s Comb</i>	A wooden comb carved with thorned vines. Running it through your hair removes tangles and also removes recent memories.	Rite of the Forgetful Stroke (Low) – Stroke the comb through your hair; erase one recent short-term memory (a face, a password, a few minutes of events). The memory is stored in the comb. Mark +1 Obligation.	The comb demands that you give a stored memory to a stranger without explanation. If you refuse, the comb begins to remove random memories each dawn (GM chooses).

Using Artifact Rites in Play

- Activating a Rite takes an action unless noted otherwise.
- Unlike Patron Rites, artifact Rites do not require a Codex or Familiar – only possession of the artifact.
- The GM may allow a wielder to clear artifact Obligation by performing a small act of devotion (e.g., for *Thorn-Fang*: cut a thorn bush; for *Glassleaf Lantern*: leave it in a moonbeam overnight).
- Artifacts can be stolen, lost, or destroyed. If an artifact is destroyed, any accumulated Obligation is cleared, but the destruction itself may trigger a final demand (GM’s discretion).

Part IV

The Southern Realms (Akilan)

Chapter 18

Oshiira

The Ledger Empire.

The ledger does not forgive arithmetic errors. A single miscounted bushel can unmake a house, a tribe, an empire. I am not here to be kind. I am here to be correct.

I am a Grain Inspector. My stamp leaves a mark that glows under moonlight. I know.

Oshiira is a confederacy of hundreds of tribes and city-states, united by the Grain Ledger. The capital, Mbaro, is a city of canals, weigh-houses, and the great Granary Tower. Oshiira is the breadbasket of the Amaranthine; its millet and sorghum fill the holds of Ecktorian, Vhasian, and Silkstrand ships. The empire operates through a bureaucracy as complex as any in the north—weighing-houses, canal-mothers, and ledgers that track every grain shipment with mathematical precision. But here's the secret the Widow doesn't want you to know: the Ledger has a page that has been torn out. That page named the true heir. No one knows where it is. Everyone is looking.

The Vermilion Corps audits not only grain but also loyalty. The Narrow Captains provoke Kahfagia just to remind the Admiralty who really controls the straits. And the Widow—the empress who has held the confederacy together for centuries—is dying. Paranoia is slowly replacing wisdom. Her four children circle the throne like vultures. The Vermilion Corps maintains order, but no one knows which heir the Corps truly serves. Not even the Corps itself.

Never speak of succession before naming the Widow. The empress's health is a state secret, and the Vermilion Corps has ears in every weigh-house. Speak carelessly, and your name may be the next one erased from the Ledger.

— *Vermilion Corps Auditor, who counts her own breaths to ensure she is not lying*

The Almanac of Ordinary Days

What do people eat for breakfast? Millet porridge with dried fish—the millet is grown in the flood plains of the Sahel, the fish is smoked over canal-barges. The porridge is always the same. The fish varies by season. The seasons are measured by the height of the river. The river is the Widow's blood. The Widow's blood is low.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To weigh a grain. Oshiira children are given a balance scale and a single grain of millet. By age five, they can tell you the weight difference between a grain harvested in the northern Sahel and a grain harvested in the southern riverlands. The difference is the tax. The tax feeds the empire. The empire is hungry.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their hands. Oshiira merchants have ink-stained fingers—the ink is from the Ledger. A stranger whose fingers are clean has never signed a contract. A stranger whose fingers are stained black has signed too many. A stranger whose fingers are stained red has signed a death warrant. The red ink is not ink. The red ink is blood.

What is the most common crime? Ledger fraud—but ledger fraud is not a crime, it is a career. The Vermilion Corps audits the auditors. The auditors audit the clerks. The clerks audit the merchants. The merchants audit the farmers. The farmers audit the land. The land does not lie. The land does not need to.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Widow has not been seen in public for seven years. Her voice is a recording. Her seal is a stamp. Her decrees are written by the Vermilion Corps. The Corps signs in her name. The Corps speaks in her voice. The Corps is the Widow. The Widow is dead. The empire continues.

Where do people go when they die? To the Granary Tower—the great stone silo at the centre of Mbaro. The dead are not buried. They are ground into meal and mixed with the millet. The grain is shipped across the Amaranthine. The dead feed the empire. The empire does not know. The empire does not ask.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You submit a correction to the Ledger. The correction must be witnessed by a Vermilion Corps auditor. The auditor stamps the correction with their seal. The seal glows under moonlight. The moonlight is the Widow's eye. The Widow sees everything. The Widow forgives nothing.

What is the most important festival? The Harvest of the Ledger (autumn). The Ledger is opened in the great square. The names of the year's debtors are read aloud. The debtors are given until dawn to pay. The debtors who cannot pay are added to the Ledger's ninth page. The ninth page is sealed with wax. The wax is black. The black is mourning.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Ledger's missing page is not missing. It was burned by the Widow herself, in the year the last heir died. The page's ash was mixed into the mortar of the Granary Tower. The ash still glows under moonlight. The glow spells the heir's name. The name is the Widow's own. The Widow killed her child. The empire does not know. The empire would not care.

18.1 Oshiira — “The Ledger Empire”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *The ledger does not forgive. The Widow does not forget. The canals remember every promise.*

Vermilion Corps Auditor (Elite): “The ledger does not forgive arithmetic errors. A single miscounted bushel can unmake a house, a tribe, an empire. I am not here to be kind. I am here to be correct.”

Canal Mother (Commoner): “Water is memory. Every canal remembers the hands that dug it, the barges that passed, the widows who wept at its edge. Control the water, and you control what the empire remembers. The Vermilion Corps controls the grain. We control the thirst.”

Genre / Mood: Sahelian bureaucracy, grain-house noir, the weight of succession.

Starting Location: A grain-loading pier on the Shoreless Bay, where Oshiiran wheat is being loaded onto Ecktorian barges. The air smells of chaff and opportunity. A Narrow Captain with a scarred throat approaches, her hand resting on a ledger wrapped in oilcloth. “Kahfagian ‘pirates’ were sighted at dawn. The Widow wants deniable assets. Congratulations — you’re now deniable. Find out who’s leaking our sailing schedules before the next shipment sails. Or don’t. I’m sure the canals will remember you fondly.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Oshiira is a confederacy of hundreds of tribes and city-states, united by hunger. Not famine—*control*. The Grain Ledger is not a book. It is a weapon. The capital, Mbaro, is a city of canals, weigh-houses, and the great Granary Tower — a stone spine that casts a shadow over every table from the Shoreless Bay to the Red Desert’s edge. Oshiira is the breadbasket of the Amaranthine; its wheat fills the holds of Ecktorian, Vhasian, and Silkstrand ships. But the breadbasket has a lock. The Widow holds the key.

For centuries, the Widow — the empress of Oshiira — has held the confederacy together through marriage alliances, grain quotas, and the careful, brutal distribution of water rights. But age is catching up. Paranoia is replacing wisdom. The Vermilion Corps audits not only grain but loyalty. They have ears in every weigh-house, eyes in every canal. And somewhere in the Granary Tower, a page of the Ledger has been torn out — a page that names the true heir.

The Vermilion Corps has been searching for that page for nine years. They have executed nine scribes. The ninth scribe’s ghost still walks the tower, counting bushels that no longer exist.

What you notice first: The smell of grain dust and canal water — sweet and rotten at once. The constant scratch of reed pens on parchment, like insects in the walls. The way everyone — from merchant to slave — touches their receipt before speaking of trade. The way the silence falls when a Vermilion Corps auditor enters a room.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never speak of succession before naming the Widow. The empress’s health is a state secret, and the Vermilion Corps has ears in every weigh-house. Speak carelessly, and your name may be the next one erased from the Ledger.

Regional Mood: The Weight of Grain

Power here is measured in bushels, not blood. A tribe's standing depends on its harvest records; a merchant's fortune on the accuracy of his scales. The Vermilion Corps audits without mercy, and the Canal Mothers control the water that turns the mill-wheels — and also the water that drowns. Oshiira fought four wars with Ecktoria to a standstill, though the empire suffered worse. The memory of those wars lingers in every weigh-house and every tariff. But the true tension is internal: the Widow has no clear successor, and her four children — each backed by a different faction — circle the throne like vultures around a dying lion. The Vermilion Corps maintains order, but no one knows which heir the Corps truly serves. Not even the Corps itself. The Ninth Heir — the one who was never supposed to exist — watches from the shadows, waiting for the ledger to crack.

Prominent NPCs of Oshiira

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Mothers of the Vermilion Eye	Vermilion Corps auditor	Find every miscount, collect every debt	She counts her own breaths to ensure she is not lying. Her breath count never matches mine.
Lady Tano	Canal Mother of the eastern reach	Keep the water flowing and her family fed	She has never seen the sea. She refuses to start. She says the sea is just a canal that lost its nerve.
Captain Sefu	Narrow Captain, Oshiiran navy	Provoke Kahfagia into breaking the peace	He names his cannons after his ex-wives. The newest one is named "Regret."
Merchant Kofi	Salt Syndicate factor	Control the desert caravan routes	He tastes salt before every deal. The salt tells him if the seller is lying. He has not been wrong in thirty years.

Widow’s Scribe	Granary Tower archivist	Protect the Ledger at any cost	He has not left the tower in forty years. The Ledger is his family. His shadow has a different posture.
The Vermilion Hand	Internal enforcement (rumoured)	A ghost who audits oath-breakers	Said to appear when a debt is nine years overdue. Those who see her never owe again. They also never speak again.

Names of Oshiira

Inspired by the Sahelian and West African traditions: melodic, with repeated syllables and clan prefixes. Surnames often denote a trade, a water source, or an ancestor’s deed.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Kofi	Adwoa	Keita	<i>the Ledger-Keeper</i>
Kwame	Amara	Diallo	<i>Canal-Born</i>
Sefu	Nia	Toure	<i>Weigh-Master</i>
Chidi	Zuri	Sow	<i>Ninth Daughter</i>
Obi	Imani	Bangura	<i>the Widow’s Eye</i>
Idriss	Fatou	Kamara	<i>Salt-Tongue</i>

(Canal/Weigh-House/Granary) Mudflat weigh-station where grain sacks pile under reed awnings and the scales squeal like guilty witnesses. Canal junction where three barges queue for a single pilot’s writ and the pilots queue for a single bribe.

Spades — Places

2. **Mudflat Weigh-Station** — Grain sacks piled under reed awnings. *The scales are bronze. They squeal when a false weight is placed. The squeal is a confession.* ‘[TRADE]’
3. **Granary Tower (Cracked Ledger Door)** — A door sealed with wax and warning. *The wax is the Widow’s own seal. Break it, and the Vermilion Corps will know. The door has been broken nine times. The wax is always fresh.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
4. **Canal Junction** — Three barges, one pilot, one writ, many arguments. *The pilot’s writ is stamped with a watermark that shifts in sunlight. The watermark is a face. The face changes with the tide.* ‘[TRAVEL]’

5. **The Widow's Weigh-House** — Bronze scales, silent clerks, no windows. *The clerks do not speak. They tap their fingers. Each tap is a number. The numbers spell a name. The name is yours.* '[JUSTICE]'
6. **Grain Exchange Floor** — Traders shout in couplets; bids are poems. *A bad rhyme loses your entire stake. A good one doubles it. The best poem buys the poet a death warrant. The Widow hates competition.* '[TRADE]'
7. **Canal Mother's Court** — A shaded bench where water rights are assigned. *The bench is carved from a single log. The log was a bridge she ordered burned. The bridge was full of children. She says it was necessary.* '[JUSTICE]'
8. **Salt Syndicate Counting House** — Desert caravans pay their tolls here. *The floor is salt. Sweep it, and you are cleaning a debt. The salt is grey. It tastes of old tears and older bargains.* '[TRADE]'
9. **Shoreless Bay Grain Piers** — Wooden docks stretching into shallow water. *At low tide, you can see the bones of ships that tried to bypass the tariffs. The bones are not all wood.* '[TRAVEL]'
10. **Narrow Captains' Mess** — A longhouse where naval officers drink and scheme. *The toasts are in code. "To the Widow" means "prepare for war." "To the canals" means "hide the contraband." No one toasts to the Ninth Heir. The silence is loud.* '[POLITICS]'
- J **Kahfagian Cold War Station** — A lighthouse that is also a spy post. *The lamp flashes in a sequence that changes weekly. The codebook is in cipher. The cipher is a poem about a drowned sailor. The sailor was a spy. The spy was never caught.* '[AUTHORITY]'
- Q **Mothers' Stepwell** — A deep well with stone steps leading down. *Each step is a different mother's name. The ninth step is empty. The empty step is for the mother who has not yet lost a child. She will.* '[RITUAL]'
- K **Granary Tower Top** — A wind-swept platform with a single brass bell. *The bell rings only when the Widow dies. It has not rung in forty years. The bell-ringer has not slept in forty years. He is waiting.* '[OMEN]'
- A **The Ledger Vault** — A subterranean archive beneath the Granary. *The air is dry. The ledgers are on chains. The chains have teeth. The teeth are for anyone who reads without permission. The ledgers bite back.* '[LEGEND]'

(Clerk/Mother/Captain) Grain inspector with a brass stamp and a grudge; his stamp leaves a mark that glows under moonlight. He knows where you slept last night. Canal Mother bargaining over water rights; her sons stand behind her, counting your breaths. Vermilion Corps auditor with ink on fingers and a ledger that never balances.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Grain Inspector** — Brass stamp, iron will, no sense of humour. *His stamp leaves a mark that glows under moonlight. He knows. He also knows why you flinched.* '[AUTHORITY]'
3. **Canal Mother** — Matriarch who controls the sluice gates. *She has three sons. Each runs a different canal. She plays them against each other. The loser gets the dry canal. The dry canal is a grave.* '[COMMUNITY]'
4. **Vermilion Corps Auditor** — Ink-stained fingers, a ledger that never closes. *She audits the auditors. Her own books are forged — perfection. She has not slept in nine years. Sleep is a miscount.* '[JUSTICE]'

5. **Narrow Captain** — Chafes at the cold war pact. Wants blood. *He keeps a map of Kahfagian ports. Each has a red X. He adds one per season. The newest X is over a lighthouse. The lighthouse keeper was his brother.* ‘[POLITICS]’
6. **Salt Syndicate Merchant** — Offers loans with interest paid in favours. *His interest rate is written in disappearing ink. You never know the true cost. The cost is always higher than you think.* ‘[TRADE]’
7. **Weigh-House Clerk** — Silent, watchful, never blinks. *He has not spoken in ten years. He communicates by stamping receipts. The stamps have a rhythm. The rhythm is a prayer. The prayer is for death.* ‘[JUSTICE]’
8. **Tribal Chief** — Caught between the Widow’s law and ancestral custom. *He keeps two ledgers: one for Mbaro, one for his ancestors. The ancestors are winning.* ‘[COMMUNITY]’
9. **Barge Pilot** — Knows every canal, every shortcut, every bribe. *His boat is faster than it should be. The hull is lined with contraband. The contraband is not for sale. It is for leverage.* ‘[TRAVEL]’
10. **Spice Merchant** — Sells cardamom and secrets in equal measure. *Her spice boxes have false bottoms. The bottoms contain intelligence. The intelligence is always true. The truth is always painful.* ‘[TRADE]’
- J **Widow’s Scribe** — The empress’s personal archivist. *He writes in a script that only the Widow can read. He has forgotten his own name. The script remembers it for him.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
- Q **Vermilion Hand** — A rumoured figure in red gloves. *She appears when a debt is nine years overdue. Her arrival is a death sentence. Her gloves are red because they never dry.* ‘[MYSTERY]’
- K **The Widow (Empress)** — Dying, paranoid, still counting. *She has not slept in three years. The Ledger keeps her awake. The Ledger is also the only thing keeping her alive.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
- A **The Ninth Heir** — A child no one acknowledges, raised in secret. *She was taught to read ledgers before she could walk. She is the Widow’s only hope. She is also the Vermilion Corps’ only fear.* ‘[LEGEND]’

(**Dust/Locust/Succession**) Dust from the Ashaani desert coats the grain; inspector halts the entire caravan; the dust moves against the wind. Locust swarm devours exposed supplies; the locusts spell a name in the sky. The name is yours.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Desert Dust** — Red sand from Ashaan coats the grain; inspector halts caravan. ‘[WEATHER]’ *The dust smells of old magic. Touch it, and a spirit may notice you. The spirit is not from Ashaan. The spirit is from the grain’s ghost.*
3. **Locust Swarm** — A chittering cloud descends; Supply –1. ‘[DISASTER]’ *The locusts leave behind a single word written in their bodies: “Pay.” The word is in the Widow’s own handwriting.*
4. **Cold War Provocation** — A Kahfagian “pirate” is sighted in Oshiiran waters. ‘[POLITICS]’ *The pirate flies a flag of truce. The truce is a lie. The flag is stitched from a Vermilion Corps uniform.*

5. **Widow's Health Fails** — Succession rumours spike; trade freezes. '[POLITICS]' *The Grain Exchange floor goes silent. No one wants to be on the wrong side. The wrong side is the side that bet first.*
 6. **Audit In Progress** — Vermilion Corps seals the weigh-house; no one leaves. '[JUSTICE]' *The auditor asks one question: "Where is the ninth bushel?" There is no ninth bushel. The question is a test.*
 7. **Canal Blockage** — A barge sinks at a junction; water backs up. '[TRAVEL]' *The barge was sunk deliberately. A Canal Mother is making a point. The point is drowning.*
 8. **False Receipt** — Your grain receipt is a forgery. Prove otherwise. '[TRADE]' *The forger used real paper. The ink is the only difference. The ink is the forger's blood. The forger is a ghost.*
 9. **Salt Syndicate Call** — Your loan is due. In favours. Now. '[DEBT]' *The favour is to poison a rival's well. Refuse, and your own well is next. The rival is your ally. The Syndicate knows.*
 10. **Narrow Captain's Gambit** — A captain offers you a bribe to provoke Kahfagia. '[POLITICS]' *The bribe is a ship. The ship is stolen. You are the decoy. The captain's real target is the Widow's own fleet.*
- J **Tribal Feud** — Two tribes claim the same harvest; you are the witness. '[COMMUNITY]' *Both ledgers are correct. The error is in the Widow's own records. The Widow does not make errors. The error is a trap.*
- Q **Vermilion Hand Appears** — A figure in red gloves sits at your table. '[MYSTERY]' *She asks for a name. Give a name, or she will take yours. The name she wants is the Ninth Heir's. She knows you don't know it.*
- K **Widow's Summons** — The empress demands your presence at the Granary. '[AUTHORITY]' *The summons is written in disappearing ink. It has already begun to fade. The ink is the Widow's blood. She is not well.*
- A **The Ninth Bushel** — A grain shipment is short by one bushel. The empire demands blood. '[OMEN]' *The missing bushel is a metaphor. The empire wants a scapegoat. The scapegoat is you. The metaphor is a knife.*

(Stamp/Token/Priority) Receipt for stolen grain (blackmail material — the grain was stolen from the Widow's own stores). Barge priority token (skip the queue — the token is a dried finger). Weigh-house seal (legal immunity for one audit — the seal is warm, and it has a pulse).

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Grain Receipt (Stolen)** — Blackmail material against a merchant. '[SOCIAL]' *The receipt is stained with wine. The merchant's daughter was drunk. The daughter is the Ninth Heir.*
3. **Barge Priority Token** — Skip the queue at any canal junction (once). '[TRAVEL]' *The token is a clay disc. It breaks after one use. Intentionally. The break reveals a map. The map is to a hidden canal.*
4. **Weigh-House Seal** — Legal immunity from one audit. '[JUSTICE]' *The seal is warm. It cools when an auditor is near. It burns when the auditor is lying. It has burned nine times today.*
5. **Treaty Seal (Cold War)** — One use to demand a parley with Kahfagia. '[POLITICS]' *The seal is half of a pair. The other half is held by a Kahfagian admiral. The admiral is dead. His*

ghost holds the other half.

6. **Canal Mother’s Favour** — One water-right reassignment. ‘[COMMUNITY]’ *The favour is a key. The key opens a sluice gate. The gate controls a district’s water. The district is your enemy’s.*
7. **Vermilion Corps Pass** — Safe passage through any audit checkpoint. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The pass is a single red feather. No one questions it. The feather came from a bird that only eats the eyes of the dead.*
8. **Salt Syndicate Loan Waiver** — One debt forgiven, no questions asked. ‘[TRADE]’ *The waiver is a pinch of salt in a leather pouch. Swallow it to activate. The salt tastes of tears. Whose tears?*
9. **Narrow Captain’s Letter of Marque** — Legal piracy against Kahfagia. ‘[COMBAT]’ *The letter is signed by the Widow. Her signature is a single dot. The dot is a period. The period ends a sentence. The sentence is your life.*
10. **Tribal Chief’s Witness** — One oath witnessed by a neutral chief. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The witness is a scar on your arm. The scar is the chief’s signature. The signature reads “wait.”*
- J **Widow’s Cipher** — Read one intercepted Kahfagian dispatch. ‘[POLITICS]’ *The cipher is a poem. The poem is about a drowned sailor. The sailor was a spy. The spy was you, in a past life you don’t remember.*
- Q **Vermilion Hand’s Silence** — One crime erased from the Ledger. ‘[MYSTERY]’ *The hand leaves a red thumbprint on the page. The page then burns. The smoke smells of cinnamon. The cinnamon is a warning.*
- K **Heir’s Trust** — The ninth heir owes you a secret. ‘[LEGEND]’ *The secret is a name. The name is the Widow’s true successor. The name is yours.*
- A **The Ledger Page** — A single page from the Granary’s master ledger. ‘[LEGEND]’ *The page lists every debt the empire has forgotten. The debts are still valid. The interest is compounding. The interest is measured in lives.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (receipts/tokens/seals) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **grain-omens**—scales that tip without weight, ledgers that rustle in still air, the Widow’s cough echoing from the tower, a single grain of wheat that weeps.

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **The Grain Ledger:** Every harvest, every debt, every tariff is recorded. A single page can make or break a family. The Ledger is kept in the Granary Tower, guarded by the Vermilion Corps and the Widow’s own magic — and by something else, something that lives in the walls and counts in the dark. Once per session, a character may spend a Boon to consult a copy of the Ledger; the GM must answer one question about grain shipments, water rights, or tax records truthfully (though the answer may be a riddle, and the riddle may have teeth).
- **The Widow’s Peace:** A fragile truce with Kahfagia, maintained by tariffs, spies, and the occasional deniable raid. Break it, and you break the empire. The party may be asked to

perform a deniable raid — success earns a Letter of Marque; failure means the Widow will deny all knowledge. The Widow's denial is written in disappearing ink. Your name will fade with it.

- **Canal Law:** Water rights are the second currency. The Canal Mothers decide who drinks, who farms, and who drowns. A character who holds a water right (a clay tablet) may reroute a canal for one scene, flooding or draining a district. Using this right ticks the **Resentment Clock** [4] for that district; when full, the locals rise up. The rising is polite. The drowning is not.
- **Succession Clocks:** The Widow's four children each have a **Claim Clock** [6]. Ticks when the party aids that heir, spreads a rumour, or assassinates a rival. When any heir's clock fills, they make a public bid for the throne. The party can accelerate or decelerate these clocks through their actions. The Widow herself has a **Paranoia Clock** [8]; when it fills, she orders a purge — the Vermilion Corps arrests anyone suspected of disloyalty. The purge is always correct. The Vermilion Corps makes sure of it.
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
 - **The Mother of Scales** — Mykkiel. *The ledger as scripture; a miscount is a sin. The penance is a death.*
 - **The Green Keeper** — The Witness. *The flame that shows the truth in grain dust. The truth is always a debt.*
 - **The Canal Father** — The Traveler. *The water that connects all tribes; the right of passage. The passage is never free.*
 - **The Ninth Hand** — Khemesh. *The pressure of debt; the weight of the Ledger. The weight is crushing.*

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Widow's Ninth Succession (Unfinished Ledger):** The Widow is dying. Her four children vie for the throne. One is a half-breed, one is a spirit, one is a puppet, and one is already dead. The Vermilion Corps has a secret ledger listing which heir each faction supports. The party has been offered a barony to escort the heir of their choice to Mbaro. The barony is a swamp. The heir does not know this. The swamp knows. The swamp is hungry.
- **The Salt Syndicate's Ashaani Contacts (The Veil):** The Salt Syndicate trades with Ashaan across the Red Desert. They smuggle more than salt — they smuggle spirit-bottles, forbidden texts, and escaped slaves. The Veiled Sisters tolerate the trade because the Syndicate also carries their spies. The party may be hired as unwitting couriers; the cargo is a living memory. The memory is of a debt the Widow has not yet collected.
- **The Narrow Captain's Kahfagian Lover (The Flag of Storms):** Captain Sefu has a secret: his ex-wife is a Kahfagian admiral. They communicate via coded lantern signals across the Narrow of Sorrows. Their correspondence is a map to a peace treaty — or a declaration of war. The party is asked to deliver a letter. The letter is sealed with a kiss. The kiss is poisoned. The poison is a metaphor for trust.
- **The Granary Tower's Gnome Engineers (Aeler Influence):** The Granary Tower's counterweights were designed by Aeler vent-priors. The breath-bonds that keep the ledgers safe are of Aeler make. If the Aeler ever withdrew their engineers, the tower would collapse within a season. A faction within the Vermilion Corps wants to replace the Aeler with native engineers. The party is hired to steal the blueprints. The blueprints are written in breath.

The breath is the engineers’ own. They will want it back.

Oshiira Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Ledger:** Crumble a crust onto a weigh-house scale. Ignore the first *Desert Dust* penalty. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’ The scale will dip. The dip is a blessing. The blessing is measured in crumbs.
- **Knot the Quill:** Tie a single knot in an audit quill. Cancel *False Receipt* or take –1 die on your next negotiation (your choice). ‘[SUPERSTITION]’ The knot will bleed. The blood is ink. The ink is your signature.
- **Name to the Canal:** Whisper a dead Canal Mother’s name into the water. Gain +1 Effect when bargaining for water rights, but mark *Obligation* to the Widow. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’ The water will ripple. The ripple will spell a warning. The warning is always the same: “*She is watching.*”

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **Grain Inspectors or Canal Mothers**. The attention is polite. The politeness is a threat.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **weigh-house clerks or barge pilots**. The clerks will not move. The pilots will.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **auditors or Syndicate debt-collectors**. The evidence is a single grain of wheat. The grain is counting.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favourable tariffs**. The setback is a locked canal gate. The key is in Mbaro. You are not.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**. The resource is grain. The grain is rotting. The rot is spreading.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Local Vermilion Corps or Narrow Captain** becomes aware and begins responding. The response is a single question. The question is always the same: “Where is the ninth bushel?”
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **canal blockage or dust storm**. The dust is red. The red is blood. The blood is not yours. Not yet.
- **Foe Appears:** A **rival merchant or tribal chief** arrives on scene. They are smiling. The smile is a receipt. The receipt is for your life.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**. The equipment is a scale. The scale now lies. The lie is the truth.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome. The obstacle is a ledger page. The test is arithmetic. The arithmetic is rigged.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **auditors, guards, or Syndicate enforcers** arrive. They are silent. Their silence is a verdict.

- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable. The tool was a quill. The quill was a knife. The knife was a promise.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes—**Widow’s health fails/oath invoked/audit declared**. The twist is a page torn from the Ledger. The page is blank. The blank is a threat.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment. The clock is the Widow’s heartbeat. It is slowing.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction. The condition is *Indebted*. The debt is unspecified. The creditor is watching.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect. The trap is a weighing scale. The scale is balanced. The balance is a lie.
- **Authority Arrival: Widow, Vermilion Hand, or Ninth Heir** intervenes. The intervention is a single word. The word is “count.”
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically—**canal breaches/ledger catches fire/succession crisis begins**. The fire is green. The green is the Widow’s signature colour. The colour is a curse.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice—**omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**. The omen is a bushel of wheat. The wheat is screaming. The scream is a number.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives. The turn is a page. The page is the one torn from the Ledger. The page was never missing. It was waiting.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Oshiira (Grain Law):** Scales tip without cause, ledgers rustle, the Widow’s cough echoes from the tower. The cough is a code. The code is a warning.
- **Oshiira (Cold War):** Kahfagian flags appear on the horizon, cipher books fall open to the wrong page, spies exchange glances. The glances are receipts. The receipts are for betrayals not yet committed.
- **Oshiira (Canal Law):** Sluice gates open unbidden, water rises, a Canal Mother’s son draws a knife. The knife is for the heir who tried to buy his mother’s vote. The water will wash away the blood. The water always washes away the blood.

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Wits + Stealth):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *False Trail*.
- **Cut the Bribe (Presence + Sway):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a weigh-house is under your seal, +1 die.
- **Weather the Audit (Resolve + Lore):** On a hit in *Vermilion Inspection*, you pick who testifies; on a miss, the auditor does.

Boss Seeds (Grain & Ledger)

- **The Ledger-Keeper (Nine Volumes)** — *Phases*: Audit Thresholds → Orchestrated Famine → Succession Coup. *Cracks*: cut a lineage page; reveal swapped seal; survive a staged grain shortage.
- **The Salt Mother (Brine-Syndicate)** — *Phases*: Loans Called Mercy → Procession at Weigh-House → Salt-Baptism of a Captain. *Cracks*: relic debt-waiver, survivor testimony, salt turning against them.
- **The Vermilion Hand (Ghost Auditor)** — *Phases*: Debt Called → Witness Summoned → Ledger Sealed. *Cracks*: pay a forgotten wergild, speak the true name of the Ninth Heir, survive a night in the Ledger Vault.

Patronage & Power

Among the Oshiira, power flows through grain, water, and the written word. The Widow holds ultimate authority, but the Vermilion Corps audits without mercy, the Canal Mothers control the waterways, and the Salt Syndicate finances the caravans. A tribe’s standing depends on its harvest records; a merchant’s fortune on the accuracy of his scales. But with the Widow’s health failing, loyalty is no longer measured in bushels — it is measured in heirs. **For the GM:** Power in Oshiiran society is bureaucratic and paper-based, but the succession crisis adds a layer of paranoia and betrayal. Patronage often takes the form of sealed receipts, priority tokens, or debt waivers — each recorded in the Ledger and subject to audit. To emphasize the Widow’s decline:

- Tie rewards to visible documents (receipts, passes, seals) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided.
- Let rival heirs issue conflicting claims, forcing players to choose whose ledger matters more.
- Use the Succession Clocks as a visible campaign front. Each session, tick one heir’s clock based on party actions (or inaction).
- The Widow’s Paranoia Clock can be lowered by proving loyalty (e.g., exposing a spy, recovering a stolen page) or raised by rumours, failures, or the appearance of the Ninth Heir.

In Oshiiran society, your receipt is your bond, and your grain is your greatest treasure. But when the Widow dies, the Ledger may be rewritten. And the Ledger always wins.

The Four Heirs: A Game of Succession

The Widow’s Children — Four Claims, One Throne

The Widow has four living children. Each believes they are the rightful heir. Each is wrong — or right — depending on which page of the Ledger you read. The Vermilion Corps has a secret fifth ledger that names the true successor. That page was torn out forty years ago. The Widow tore it herself. She has not told anyone what it said.

Heir	Faction	Claim	Clock
Prince Kwame	Old Blood (Traditionalist)	Firstborn. The law is clear.	[6]
Princess Ad-woa	Vermilion Corps (Re-former)	The Ledger chose her. She has the stamp.	[6]
Prince Sefu	Narrow Captains (Mili-tarist)	The canals obey him. The navy follows.	[6]
Princess Nia	Salt Syndicate (Merchant)	She holds the debts of the other three.	[6]

The Ninth Heir (Secret): A child no one acknowledges, raised in the Granary Tower’s lowest vault. She was taught to read ledgers before she could walk. She is the Widow’s only hope — and the Vermilion Corps’ only fear. Her clock is hidden [8], and it ticks only when the party learns something the Corps wants buried.

Mini-Game: The Succession Gambit

Setup: The party arrives in Mbaro during the Month of Weights, when all ledgers are audited and the canals run low. The Widow has announced she will name her successor before the month ends — or die trying. The Vermilion Corps has sealed the city gates. No one leaves until the Ledger speaks.

The Objective: Secure the succession for one heir — or broker a truce, or steal the throne for the Ninth Heir, or burn the whole system down. The party’s choice determines Oshiira’s fate for a generation.

The Mechanics:

- Each heir has a **Claim Clock** [6]. The party can tick a clock by:
 - Delivering a rival’s secret to that heir (+1)
 - Assassinating a rival’s key ally (+2, but marks **Heat**)
 - Forging a ledger page that discredits a rival (+1, requires a *Forger’s Kit*)
 - Securing a foreign alliance (Ecktoria, Kahfagia, or the Covenant) (+2)
- The party can **tick down** a clock by:
 - Exposing the heir’s own secret (−1)
 - Convincing their key ally to defect (−1, requires a successful social test)
 - Intercepting their grain shipment (−2, requires a raid)
- When any heir’s clock reaches 6, they make a public bid for the throne. The Widow hears their claim. Then she asks one question: “*Where is the ninth page?*”
 - If the heir answers correctly, they become regent. The party gains that heir’s **Boon**.
 - If they answer incorrectly, the Widow coughs once. The Vermilion Corps arrests everyone in the room. The party has one scene to escape.

Heir-Specific Secrets (What the Vermilion Corps Knows):

Heir	Secret	Location of Evidence
Kwame	Not the firstborn. His mother was a concubine. The Widow adopted him.	Granary Tower, Vault 9, sealed with black wax.
Adwoa	She ordered the assassination of a rival auditor — and pinned it on a tribal chief.	Vermilion Corps archive, hidden behind a false wall.
Sefu	He sold naval supply routes to Kahfagian pirates to fund his campaign.	Narrow Captains’ Mess, inside a hollow cannon named “Regret.”
Nia	She owns the debt on the Granary Tower itself. If she calls it in, the tower collapses.	Salt Syndicate Counting House, the <i>Black Ledger</i> .

The Ninth Heir’s Path:

- To find her, the party must:
 - Discover that a page was torn from the Ledger (any archive research, DV 4)
 - Learn that the page named a child born in secret (canal mothers’ gossip, DV 2)

Adventure Seed: The Ninth Page

The Hook: The Widow's Scribe summons the party to the Granary Tower at midnight. He is dying. His shadow has already left. "The page was not destroyed," he whispers. "It was hidden. In a place the Vermilion Corps cannot touch. Find it before they find you."

The Clues:

1. The page is wrapped in oilcloth and sealed with the Widow's own breath-bond.
2. It is hidden in a canal boat that sank nine years ago — the boat of a Canal Mother who was executed for treason.
3. The boat's wreck lies in the **Mothers' Stepwell**, the ninth step down, where the water is black and the dead do not float.

The Twist: The page does not name an heir. It names a *condition*: "*The throne passes to whichever of my children can count the grains of sand in the hourglass of empire.*" The hourglass is in the Widow's bedchamber. The sand is not sand. It is ground bone. The bone is from the first emperor.

The Choice: The party can:

- Bring the page to the Widow (she will read it aloud at the succession council — and die immediately after, as the breath-bond expires).
- Destroy the page and let the heirs fight (civil war, but the party can broker a truce).
- Rewrite the page (requires a *Forger's Kit* and a drop of blood from each heir — and a truth the Ledger does not yet know).

Reward: If the party successfully resolves the succession without bloodshed (or with very *careful* bloodshed), each PC gains a **Claim Token**: a single vote in the next succession council. The votes can be traded, sold, or used to blackmail future rulers.

Chapter 19

Ashaan

The Veiled Throne.

The Veil is not a choice. It is survival. You will show your eyes and nothing more. Speak in thirds—offer two options and a hidden third. The ninth word is always a knife.

I am a Breath-less Agent. They say Ikasha sleeps. I say she is patient. The Sisters have ruled for generations; they believe the Veil is eternal. But the Veil is silk. Silk frays. And I am learning to bite through—one whisper at a time.

Ashaan is a nation that died long ago. The Veiled Sisters keep its corpse walking through spirit-binding, terror, and the endless consumption of their own people. The capital, Galanina, is a city of black marble and brass cages. The Red Desert, which now covers half the country, was once fertile land; the Sisters' magic leached the life from it. There is no recovery, only a slower dying. But here's the secret the Sisters don't want you to know: the Veil is cracking. The spirits they've bound for centuries are whispering to each other. And the Hollow has begun to notice.

The Esoiti control every ledger and every gate. The Black Hand hunts without uniform. The Breath-less meet in root cellars, learning to read ledgers without leaving marks. We are not heroes. We are the ones who learned that a whisper can be louder than a scream—and that the Sisters fear silence more than they fear rebellion.

Never name the dead. The Sisters bind spirits to names. Speak a dead name aloud, and you may find yourself bound alongside them.

— *Tamar, Breath-less cell leader, who has three names—each for a different*

*jurisdiction***The Almanac of Ordinary Days**

What do people eat for breakfast? Black bread and thin soup—the bread is made from grain grown on the edge of the Red Desert, the soup is flavoured with salt and memory. The memory is of green fields. The fields are gone. The bread is bitter.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To veil their face. Ashaan children are taught to cover their mouths when speaking, their eyes when listening, their ears when hearing secrets. A child who cannot veil is a child who will be taken by the Sisters. The Sisters take children. The children become spirits. The spirits serve the Sisters. The Sisters never stop taking.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their veil. Ashaan veils are coded—red for mourning, white for marriage, black for the Sisters. A stranger whose veil is grey is a Breath-less agent. A stranger whose veil is torn is a fugitive. A stranger with no veil is a fool. Fools are collected by the Black Hand. The Black Hand does not ask questions.

What is the most common crime? Spirit-trading—but spirit-trading is not a crime, it is the economy. The Sisters bind spirits to brass cages. The cages are sold to the Esoiti. The Esoiti sell the spirits to foreign buyers. The foreign buyers do not know what they are buying. The Sisters do not care.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Red Desert is not a desert. It was a garden, before the Sisters came. The Sisters bound the spirits of the soil. The soil died. The garden became sand. The sand still remembers. The sand still whispers. The whispers are the garden's ghosts.

Where do people go when they die? To the brass cages. The dead are not buried. They are bound into spirit-lanterns and hung from the walls of Galanina. The lanterns glow green. The green is the light of the bound. The bound cannot speak. The bound cannot scream. The bound can only watch.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You offer a name—a dead name, a forgotten name, a name the Sisters do not yet know. The Sisters bind the name to a brass cage. The cage is placed in the Hall of Silence. The Hall is full. The Hall is always full. The Hall is never silent.

What is the most important festival? The Night of the Unbound (winter solstice). The spirits strain against their cages. The Sisters renew their bindings. The ceremony takes three days. The city is silent for three days. The silence is not prayer. The silence is fear.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The High Sister is not a sister. She is a spirit—the first one bound, nine hundred years ago. She bound herself to the throne. She cannot leave. She cannot die. She cannot stop binding. The other Sisters do not know. The other Sisters are her prisoners. The prisoners guard the jailer. The jailer does not sleep.

19.1 Ashaan — “The Veiled Throne”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *The Veil is not a choice. It is survival. Speak in thirds – two options and a hidden third. The ninth word is always a knife.*

Veiled Sister (Elite): “The Veil is not a choice. It is survival. You will show your eyes and nothing more. Speak in thirds—offer two options and a hidden third. The ninth word is always a knife.”

Breath-less Agent (Commoner): “They say Ikasha sleeps. I say she is patient. The Sisters have ruled for generations; they believe the Veil is eternal. But the Veil is silk. Silk frays. And I am learning to bite through — one whisper at a time.”

Genre / Mood: Grimdark spirit-horror, bureaucratic terror, whispered resistance.

Starting Location: A root cellar beneath a spice merchant’s shop, lit by a smuggled candle. A Breath-less agent presses a folded paper into your hand: “My brother argued with an Esoiti about a misweighed sack of cardamom. His name was erased from the rolls by morning. Help me find him — or help me remember his name.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Ashaan is a nation that died long ago. The Veiled Sisters keep its corpse walking through spirit-binding, terror, and the endless consumption of their own people. The capital, Galanina, is a city of black marble and brass cages. The Red Desert, which now covers half the country, was once fertile land; the Sisters’ magic leached the life from it. There is no recovery, only a slower dying. The Ashaani people are not inherently evil, but most are complicit—they must be to survive. A few resist in secret, forming cells of the Breath-less. The Sisters hunt them with spirit-hounds and slave-catchers.

What you notice first: The smell of incense and rust. The way every doorway has a veil of brass chains. The silence when a Veiled Sister passes — even the spirits hold their breath.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never name the dead. The Sisters bind spirits to names. Speak a dead name aloud, and you may find yourself bound alongside them.

Regional Mood: The Weight of Damnation

Power here is measured in spirits bound, names erased, and the silence of witnesses. The Veiled Sisters rule through terror, the Esoiti control every ledger and gate, and the Black Hand hunts without uniform. The Breath-less whisper in cellars, learning to read ledgers without leaving marks. Ashaan is not a place of open rebellion. It is a place of whispered warnings, vanished neighbours, and ledgers that rewrite themselves.

Prominent NPCs of Ashaan

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk

Sister Morai	Veiled Sister of the Inner Circle	Maintain the Veil at any cost	She has not eaten in thirty years; she feeds on bound spirits.
Magistrate Eso	Esoiti magistrate	Control every ledger, every court, every gate	He rewrites his own memory each morning. His left hand is a stamp.
The Black Hand	Hunter of bodies and spirits (faceless)	Erase anyone who whispers Ikasha's name	No one knows their faces. They could be your neighbour, your clerk, your spouse.
Tamar	Breath-less cell leader	Tear down the system from within	She has three names; each is for a different jurisdiction.
Kaelen	Spirit-broken slave	A child taken for "reevaluation," returned hollow-eyed	He no longer speaks. He only weeps when he hears a brass bell.
The Whisperer	Forbidden mage in hiding	Learn to read ledgers without leaving marks	He writes on water. The words vanish, but the Sisters cannot read them.

Names of Ashaan

Inspired by the Horn of Africa and ancient Semitic roots: sharp consonants, vowel-rich endings. Surnames often denote a trade, a debt, or a lost lineage.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Kaelen	Morai	al-Galanina	<i>the Veiled</i>
Tarek	Iman	Esoiti-broken	<i>the Breath-less</i>
Jasin	Nadira	Black-Hand-marked	<i>the Unnamed</i>
Zahir	Tamar	Spirit-bound	<i>the Ninth Witness</i>
Rashid	Layla	Ledger-erased	<i>the Forgotten</i>

Dawud	Amina	Cage-born	<i>the Hollow</i>
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(**Gate/Sanctum/Pan**) Salt pan with a broken spirit-cage; black marble temple with steps stained red; the Brass Gate — a fortified strait with spirit-buoys.

Spades — Places

2. **Salt Pan with Broken Spirit-Cage** — A white flat where the air hums. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[SPIRIT]’ *The cage is empty, but it still rattles at night. Something got out.*
3. **Black Marble Temple** — Steps stained red; the blood never washes away. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[HORROR]’ *The temple has no windows. The Sisters do not need light.*
4. **The Brass Gate** — A fortified strait with spirit-buoys that scream when crossed. ‘[TRAVEL]’ ‘[SPIRIT]’ *Each buoy contains a bound spirit. They sing the names of those who pass.*
5. **Veiled Sister’s Sanctum** — Entrance hidden by a mirage that shows your greatest fear. ‘[MAGIC]’ ‘[FEAR]’ *The mirage is not an illusion. It is a memory the Sister has stolen.*
6. **Galanina Slave Market** — A circular pit with cages of brass and bone. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[DEBT]’ *The auctioneer wears a mask. The mask is made from the face of a debt-seller.*
7. **Esoiti Ledger Hall** — A long chamber with shelves of silent books. ‘[LAW]’ ‘[DEBT]’ *The ledgers write themselves. The ink is the blood of erased names.*
8. **Black Hand Garrison** — A nondescript building with no windows and a single door. ‘[DANGER]’ *The door has no handle. It opens inward only when a name is whispered.*
9. **Breath-less Cellar** — A root cellar with a single candle and a hole in the floor. ‘[SECRET]’ *The hole leads to a tunnel that leads to a tomb. The tomb is a safe house.*
10. **Red Desert’s Edge** — Where the fertile land turns to dust and glass. ‘[WEATHER]’ ‘[CURSE]’ *The glass is green. It hums with the memory of the prince’s curse.*
- J **The Ninth Name Shrine** — A ruin where a forbidden name is carved into stone. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[SECRET]’ *The stone weeps water. The water tastes of iron and forgotten vows.*
- Q **Spirit-Binding Foundry** — A forge where brass cages are made. ‘[CRAFT]’ ‘[SPIRIT]’ *The forge is heated by a bound fire-spirit. It screams when the bellows pump.*
- K **The Hollow Vessel Nursery** — An orphanage where children are prepared for possession. ‘[HORROR]’ ‘[DEATH]’ *The children have no shadows. Their shadows have been sold.*
- A **Ikasha’s Sleeping Chamber** — A sealed vault beneath Galanina. ‘[MYSTERY]’ ‘[PATRON]’ *Inside, a stone sarcophagus. The stone is warm. She Who Sleeps dreams of freedom.*

(**Hunter/Agent/Magician**) Slave-hunter (Black Hand) with a branding iron; Breath-less agent (freed slave, now spy); an Ashaani magician who offers dangerous knowledge.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Slave-Hunter (Black Hand)** — No uniform, no name, no mercy. ‘[DANGER]’ ‘[DEBT]’ *He carries a branding iron that glows without fire. The brand is a spirit’s name.*
3. **Breath-less Agent** — Escaped slave, now spy, always watching. ‘[SECRET]’ ‘[SOCIAL]’ *She writes messages on her own skin. The ink is invisible until wet.*

4. **Veiled Sister** — Testing your honesty with a whisper. ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[MAGIC]’ *She offers a compliment that is also a threat. Her smile never reaches her eyes.*
5. **Ashaani Magician** — Offers dangerous knowledge in exchange for a memory. ‘[MAGIC]’ ‘[DEBT]’ *He has bound his own shadow. The shadow speaks when he sleeps.*
6. **Esoiti Magistrate** — Carries a ledger that is also a weapon. ‘[LAW]’ ‘[DEBT]’ *His quill never needs ink. It writes in the blood of his enemies.*
7. **Spirit-Broken Child** — Taken for “reevaluation,” returned hollow-eyed. ‘[HORROR]’ ‘[DEATH]’ *She hums a tune that no one recognises. The tune is a bound spirit’s name.*
8. **Cellar Whisperer** — A Breath-less informant who speaks in coughs. ‘[SECRET]’ *He uses a code of knocks. Three knocks means “safe,” four means “run.”*
9. **Cage-Maker** — Forges brass cages for spirits. He hates his work. ‘[CRAFT]’ ‘[DEBT]’ *He leaves a single flaw in every cage. A flaw only a spirit can find.*
10. **Ledger Forger** — Creates false identities for escaped slaves. ‘[CRIME]’ ‘[DEBT]’ *He signs each forgery with his own blood. The signature is his last act.*
- J **The Drowned Sister** — A Veiled Sister who betrayed the coven. Now a ghost. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[SPIRIT]’ *She appears in wells. She offers secrets. The price is a drink of water.*
- Q **Ikasha’s Dreamer** — A Breath-less mystic who dreams the future. ‘[MAGIC]’ ‘[PATRON]’ *She sleeps twenty hours a day. When she wakes, she speaks in riddles.*
- K **The Unnamed Prince’s Ghost** — The shade of the prince who stole the Kalrantha. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[LEGEND]’ *He walks the Red Desert at noon. He asks travellers for water. Do not give it.*
- A **The Ninth Sister** — A Veiled Sister who secretly aids the Breath-less. ‘[SECRET]’ ‘[DEBT]’ *She wears a veil that is also a noose. She has already chosen her death.*

(Dust/Gate/Spirit) Spirit-dust storm (Navigation DV +1, mark Fatigue); Brass Gate closed for “inspection” — delay 2 segments; a bound spirit breaks free and attacks.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Spirit-Dust Storm** — Red sand from the desert carries whispering spirits. ‘[WEATHER]’ ‘[DEATH]’ *Navigation DV +1. Mark Fatigue. The voices ask for your name. Do not answer.*
3. **Brass Gate Closed** — The strait is sealed for “inspection.” Delay 2 segments. ‘[LAW]’ ‘[DELAY]’ *The “inspection” is a hunt for a Breath-less agent. The agent is in your party.*
4. **Bound Spirit Breaks Free** — A brass cage cracks. The spirit attacks. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[COMBAT]’ *The spirit was once a child. It weeps as it fights. Killing it feels like murder.*
5. **The Veil Fails** — For a moment, the Sisters’ magic falters. Spirit-visions haunt all. ‘[MAGIC]’ ‘[FEAR]’ *You see the face of someone you wronged. They are asking for an apology.*
6. **Black Hand Sweep** — A sudden search of the district. Everyone’s papers are checked. ‘[LAW]’ ‘[DANGER]’ *Your papers are in order. The Black Hand does not care. They take you anyway.*
7. **Esoiti Audit** — A magistrate demands to see your ledgers. Your ledgers are lies. ‘[LAW]’ ‘[DEBT]’ *The magistrate smiles. “Everyone lies. I just need to know how much.”*
8. **Spirit-Hound Scent** — A pack of bound hounds is on your trail. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[TRACKING]’ *The hounds are invisible. You can hear their breathing, close and wet.*

9. **Slave Raid** — A Veiled Sister’s caravan is taking villagers. You are in the way. ‘[COMBAT]’
‘[DEBT]’ *The villagers are armed. They have been expecting you. You are the bait.*
10. **Ikasha’s Whisper** — In a quiet moment, you hear a voice: “Free me.” ‘[OMEN]’ ‘[PATRON]’
The whisper comes from a crack in the floor. A single green eye looks up.
- J **The Ninth Name Spoken** — Someone in the party speaks a dead name aloud. ‘[DEATH]’
‘[DEBT]’ *The air grows cold. A spirit appears. It wants to know why you called.*
- Q **Sister’s Test** — A Veiled Sister offers a deal: betray a Breath-less contact for safety.
‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[DEBT]’ *The offer is genuine. The price is your soul. The Sister watches you decide.*
- K **Mass Haunting** — The bound spirits rise as one. The Veil is tearing. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[HORROR]’
The spirits do not attack. They simply ask: “Why did you let this happen?”
- A **The Demon’s Debt Called** — Varash the Unmaker (or a fragment) demands payment.
‘[DEATH]’ ‘[DEBT]’ *The amulet Kalrantha glows. A voice whispers: “Speak your desire.”*

(Name/Lamp/Seal) A slave’s true name (free them or bind them further); spirit-lamp (one question to a bound spirit); brass seal (guest status in a Sister’s sanctum).

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Slave’s True Name** — Use it to free a bound person — or bind them further. ‘[DEBT]’
‘[POWER]’ *The name is written on a scrap of skin. The skin was the slave’s own.*
3. **Spirit-Lamp** — Ask one question of a bound spirit. It cannot lie. ‘[MAGIC]’ ‘[TRUTH]’
The lamp burns green. The spirit’s face appears in the flame. It is weeping.
4. **Brass Seal (Guest Status)** — Safe passage in a Sister’s sanctum for one visit. ‘[SOCIAL]’
‘[PROTECTION]’ *The seal is warm. It glows when a Sister is lying.*
5. **Veil-Clip** — Speak without being silenced by Veiled Sister magic. ‘[MAGIC]’ ‘[PROTEC-
TION]’ *The clip is a small brass spider. It crawls onto your collar and whispers.*
6. **Erased Name Page** — A page from the Esoiti ledger with a name struck through. ‘[SECRET]’
‘[DEBT]’ *The ink is still wet. The name was erased ten minutes ago.*
7. **Breath-less Cipher** — A codebook for reading secret messages on water. ‘[SECRET]’
‘[STEALTH]’ *The cipher is written on a leaf. The leaf dissolves when read.*
8. **Spirit-Hound Whistle** — Call off a pack of bound hounds once. ‘[PROTECTION]’ ‘[DEATH]’
The whistle is made from a child’s bone. The child was the hounds’ last victim.
9. **Ikasha’s Dream** — One prophetic vision of the Sisters’ next move. ‘[MAGIC]’ ‘[KNOWL-
EDGE]’ *The dream arrives as a headache. The vision is clear. The cost is one memory.*
10. **Black Hand Mask** — Wear it to pass as a Hunter for one scene. ‘[STEALTH]’ ‘[DECEPTION]’
The mask has no eye holes. The mask sees for you. It also remembers.
- J **Cage-Maker’s Flaw** — A key that opens any spirit-cage. One use. ‘[MAGIC]’ ‘[PROTEC-
TION]’ *The key is a bent nail. It was the flaw the cage-maker left.*
- Q **Drowned Sister’s Secret** — The location of a hidden Breath-less archive. ‘[SECRET]’
‘[KNOWLEDGE]’ *The archive is in a well. The well is guarded by a ghost. The ghost’s name is Mercy.*

- K **Ninth Sister's Veil** — Wear it to appear as a Veiled Sister for one hour. '[DECEPTION]'
 '[DANGER]' *The veil is also a noose. Do not tie it too tight.*
- A **The Unnamed Prince's Map** — A map to the original Kalrantha temple. '[LEGEND]'
 '[QUEST]' *The map is drawn on human skin. The skin was the prince's own.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (names, lamps, seals) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **veil-omens**—brass chains that rattle without wind, ledgers that open to the wrong page, a whisper that sounds like your own voice.

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **The Veil:** The Sisters' control is maintained through spirit-binding and terror. The Veil is not just a political structure—it is a magical membrane that separates the living from the dead. When the Veil fails, spirits walk. Mechanically, the GM may spend 3 SB to trigger a *Veil Failure* scene: all spirits become visible, bound spirits may break free, and social rolls against the Sisters gain +1 Position.
- **Ikasha's Cult as Active Resistance:** She Who Sleeps is not a patron of open rebellion. Her followers meet in root cellars, learn to read ledgers without leaving marks, and whisper secrets under the cover of a cough. Her Rites—*Touch the Umbral Veil*, *Secret Keeper's Burden*—become tools of survival. A character who whispers Ikasha's name before sleeping gains +1 die to resist fear for the next day, but marks 1 **Exposure** (the Black Hand may notice).
- **The Breath-less:** A secret network of escaped slaves, forbidden mages, and whisperers of Ikasha's name. They fight to tear down the system from within. Their symbol is a broken brass chain. A character who aids the Breath-less may earn a **Breath-less Cipher** (see Diamonds) and gain a contact, but each favour called in advances a **Black Hand Interest** clock.
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
 - **The Unbound Chain** – Ikasha. *She Who Sleeps; her dream is freedom.*
 - **The Gilded Scale** – Mykkiel. *The Sisters' twisted version of divine law.*
 - **The Drowned Prince** – Khemesh. *Pressure from the deep; the Red Desert was once his seabed.*
 - **The Silvered Tongue** – Malachai. *Curses sold as blessings, whispered in the slave markets.*

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Kalrantha Amulet (Dhahara Connection):** The Red Desert was once fertile land, destroyed by an Ashaani prince who stole the Kalrantha amulet. The Sisters want the amulet to bind the demon again—or to use it for themselves. The Breath-less want to destroy it.

- **The Sidhi of the Brass Coast (Way of Silk):** The Sidhi are coastal cousins of the Ashaani who fled slavery generations ago. They maintain lighthouse courts and freedman’s seals. They remember every raid. A Sidhi captain may be a Breath-less contact.
- **The Veiled Sisters and the Covenant (Mykkiel):** Mykkiel, the Judge of Galanina, is a direct antagonist to the Veiled Sisters. His followers are the secret courts of the Breath-less, trying the Sisters in absentia. A Covenant judge may offer sanctuary—or demand testimony.
- **The Hollow and the Ninth Name (Eastern Realms):** In Ashaan, the Hollow is the space left by an erased name. The Veiled Sisters feed the Hollow with forgotten debts. The Breath-less know that to restore a name is to weaken the Veil.

Ashaan Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Veil:** Crumble a crust at a brass cage. Ignore the first *Spirit-Dust Storm* penalty. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Knot the Veil-Clip:** Tie a single knot in your veil. Cancel *Black Hand Sweep* or take –1 die on your next stealth roll (your choice). ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Name to the Well:** Whisper a dead Breath-less agent’s name into a well. Gain +1 Effect when evading the Sisters this scene, but mark *Obligation* to Ikasha. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **Black Hand agents or Esoiti clerks**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **spirit-hounds or slave-catchers**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **Veiled Sisters or bound spirits**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or safe passage**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Local Black Hand or Esoiti magistrate** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **veil failure or spirit manifestation**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **bound spirit or slave-hunter** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **Black Hand, Esoiti guards, or bound spirits** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes—**Veil fails / spirit breaks free / name is spoken**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival: Veiled Sister, Esoiti High Magistrate, or Ikasha's manifestation** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically—**Veil tears / sandstorm rises / Brass Gate seals.**
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice—**omen appears / blessing lost / curse manifests.**
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Ashaan (The Veil):** Brass chains rattle, ledgers open to the wrong page, a whisper sounds like your own voice.
- **Ashaan (Red Desert):** Glass shards hum, sand shifts to reveal bones, a mirage shows a memory you had forgotten.
- **Ashaan (Breath-less):** A cough from a shadow, a knock in a cellar, a name written on water that does not dissolve.

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Wits + Stealth):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *False Trail*.
- **Cut the Veil (Presence + Sway):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a Sister's seal is in your possession, +1 die.
- **Weather the Haunting (Resolve + Spirit):** On a hit in *Mass Haunting*, you pick who is targeted; on a miss, the GM does.

Boss Seeds (Spirit & Veil)

- **The Ledger-Eater (Nine Erasures)** — *Phases:* Audit Thresholds → Orchestrated Erasure → Veil Coup. *Cracks:* cut a lineage page; reveal swapped seal; survive a staged haunting.
- **The Unbound Sister (Brine-Veil)** — *Phases:* Drownings Called Mercy → Procession at Brass Gate → Spirit-Baptism of a Magistrate. *Cracks:* relic spirit-lamp, survivor testimony, the Veil turning against them.

Patronage & Power

Among the Ashaani, power flows through fear, spirit-binding, and the erasure of names. The Veiled Sisters hold ultimate authority, but the Esoiti control the ledgers, the Black Hand enforces silence, and the Breath-less whisper in cellars. A name can be a weapon or a shield.

For the GM: Power in Ashaani society is hidden and treacherous. Patronage often takes the form of true names, spirit-lamps, or erased ledger pages—each carrying the weight of damnation. To emphasise this:

- Tie rewards to secrets (names, whispers, visions) that can be betrayed, stolen, or used against the giver.
- Let rival factions (Sisters vs. Esoiti vs. Breath-less) offer conflicting paths, forcing players to choose whose debt to incur.
- Use the Brass Gate, the Ledger Hall, and the root cellars as arenas for social contests, where truth is a weapon and silence is a shield.
- Track **Black Hand Interest** as a campaign clock. Each time the party aids the Breath-less or escapes a Sister, tick the clock. When it fills, a Black Hand squad arrives with a warrant for their erasure.

In Ashaani society, your name is your bond—and your bond can be erased.

Chapter 20

Ngomebe

The Stone Men.

A city that stops moving is a city that has chosen to die. The stone remembers every mile, every roller, every oath sworn in the shadow of the keystone. We do not build cities. We raise them from the earth and teach them to walk.

I am a Stone-Cutter. My grandfather carved the keystone for this city. My father greased the rollers. I inherited a sledge and a song. The song is the city's heartbeat. If I stop singing, the city stops walking—and so do I.

Ngomebe are a people of deep, iron-dark skin and older ties to the southern ranges. Their cities walk—colossal stone structures on rollers and sledges, dragged by teams of oxen, magic, and Aeler-designed capstans. A walking city is not a curiosity; it is a living argument against stillness. But here's the secret the Mason-Kin don't want you to know: the stone is not just a material. It listens. It remembers. And sometimes, it disagrees. When the keystone cracks, it is not a flaw—it is a message. The ancestors are trying to tell you something. The question is whether you're brave enough to read the cracks.

The Root-binders plant acorns in the roller-pits, singing to the earth. They believe the cities should stop and let the forest reclaim the stone. The Aeler engineers maintain the bearings, but they are neither masters nor servants—they are partners in a pact older than memory. And the Ancestral Healers speak for the dead, who vote through the cracks in the keystone. Their votes are always unanimous. Their verdicts are always final.

Never carve a name into living rock. The stone remembers. It will whisper that name to every spirit of the earth, and the debt will follow your bloodline for seven generations.

— *Kaelen, Stone-Cutter, whose city left him behind*

The Almanac of Ordinary Days

What do people eat for breakfast? Stone-ground meal and fermented milk—the meal is ground between the city’s own millstones, the milk is from goats that walk alongside the city. The goats are older than the city. The goats remember where the city has been. The goats do not speak. The goats do not need to.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To sing the city’s song. Ngomebe children are taught the rhythm of the rollers—eight beats to a mile, eight miles to a day, eight days to a season. The ninth beat is the city’s secret. The ninth beat is never sung aloud.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their dust. Ngomebe are coated in fine stone-dust—from the quarries, the rollers, the wind that follows the city. A stranger whose dust is white has come from the mountains. A stranger whose dust is red has come from the desert. A stranger with no dust has never walked with a city. The cities do not trust the dustless.

What is the most common crime? Stone-theft—but stone-theft is not a crime, it is a wound. The stone is the city’s memory. A stolen stone is a forgotten year. The year is forgotten by everyone who walked it. The forgetfulness spreads. The city’s song stutters. The stutter is a warning.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The city is not moving toward anything. It is moving away. The Ngomebe are fleeing something that lies to the south. The thing in the south is older than the stone. The thing in the south does not walk. It waits.

Where do people go when they die? Into the keystone. The dead are not buried. Their ashes are mixed into mortar and pressed into the city’s foundation. The dead become part of the city’s weight. The city walks heavier each year. The dead do not complain. The dead are the city’s anchor.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You carve a new roller. The roller must be cut from a single stone, with no cracks, no flaws, no forgotten names. The roller is placed beneath the city’s foundation. If it rolls true, you are forgiven. If it cracks, you are not. If it crumbles, you are added to the mortar.

What is the most important festival? The Turning of the Rollers (spring equinox). The city stops for one day. The rollers are inspected, greased, and blessed. The city’s song is sung from dawn to dusk. The song has eight verses. The ninth verse is silence. The silence is for the dead. The dead are listening.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The city is not a city. It is a tomb—a monument to a king who died before the first stone was laid. The king’s name is carved into the keystone. The keystone is at the city’s heart. The heart is inaccessible. The king is patient. The king is waiting to be remembered.

20.1 Ngomebe — “The Stone Men”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *The stone remembers. The ancestors walk with the rollers. The city that stops dies.*

Mason-Kin Elder (Elite): “A city that stops moving is a city that has chosen to die. The stone remembers every mile, every roller, every oath sworn in the shadow of the keystone. We do not build cities. We raise them from the earth and teach them to walk.”

Stone-Cutter (Commoner): “My grandfather carved the keystone for this city. My father greased the rollers. I inherited a sledge and a song. The song is the city’s heartbeat. If I stop singing, the city stops walking — and so do I.”

Ancestral Healer (Izinyanga): “The ancestors do not speak in words. They speak in cracks. A fissure in the keystone is not a flaw — it is a message. Learn to read the stone’s wounds, or the city will read your bones.”

Theme & Atmosphere

The Ngomebe are a people of deep, iron-dark skin and older ties to the southern ranges. Their cities walk — colossal stone structures on rollers and sledges, dragged by teams of oxen, magic, and Aeler-designed capstans. This partnership is one of the great cross-cultural achievements of the age: Aeler engineers maintain the bearings; Ngomebe masons carve the keystones. A walking city is not a curiosity; it is a living argument against stillness, a monument to survival in a land where staying in one place invites famine, war, or the slow forgetting of ancestral stone.

Spirits are not distant — they live in the rock, the rollers, the cracks. The ancestors speak through keystone fissures. The **tokoloshe** fouls the bearings at night. The **impundulu** (lightning bird) shatters entire sledges with a single strike. The Ngomebe do not fight these spirits. They bargain with them: a grindstone of fresh meat, a pot of home-brewed sorghum beer, a promise whispered into a roller-pit.

What you notice first: The groan of stone on stone. The smell of warm granite, ox sweat, and sorghum beer offerings. The way the ground trembles slightly, even a mile away, as the city inches across the plateau.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never carve a name into living rock. The stone remembers. It will whisper that name to every spirit of the earth, and the debt will follow your bloodline for seven generations.

Regional Mood: The Weight of Movement

Power here is measured in keystones, migration routes, and the loyalty of the Mason-Kin. A walking city is a polity, a temple, and a weapon all at once. The Mason-Kin Houses control the rights to carve, to move, and to settle. **Root-binders** — heretics who plant acorns in the rollers — believe the cities should stop and let the forest reclaim the stone. The **Aeler engineers** are neither masters nor servants; they are partners in a pact older than memory. But beneath them all, the **Ancestral Healers (Izinyanga)** speak for the dead, and the dead speak through the keystone’s cracks. When

a city stops, it is because the ancestors have been offended. When a city moves true, it is because the **Rain Queen** has blessed the path.

Starting Location: The edge of a moving city’s path, where the stone is still warm and the dust has not yet settled. A Mason-Kin elder approaches, wiping granite dust from his face: “A keystone has cracked. The city will stop before dawn. The ancestors are restless. Find the saboteur — a Root-binder, a tokoloshe, or a traitor among us — or push the rollers yourselves. The plateau does not forgive stillness.”

Prominent NPCs of Ngomebe

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Elder Morvath	Mason-Kin elder of the eastern caravan	Keep the city moving south, away from the Red Desert’s breath	He has not slept in forty days; the city’s rhythm keeps him awake.
Kaelen	Stone-cutter whose city left him behind	Catch up to his family’s city before it crosses the Salt Scar	He chisels a new keystone every night. None have been accepted.
Vent-Prior Thrain	Aeler engineer, grease-stained and level-carrying	Maintain the bearings that keep the city alive	She speaks to the rollers in a language of taps. They answer in groans.
The Root-binder	A heretic planting acorns in the roller-pits	Let the forest reclaim the stone; let the cities sleep	He has a single green leaf growing from his left ear.
Ox-Master Senn	Handler of the eight-ox teams that drag the city	Keep the beasts healthy, the yokes oiled, and the pace steady	He names each ox after a dead mason. The oxen remember.
The Still Voice	A spirit of abandoned keystones	Witness the cities that chose to stop	It appears only when a city’s migration clock reaches zero. It asks one question: “Why did you stay?”

Nomvula (Rain Queen)	Mythical rainmaker, keeper of the drought	Ensure the plateau never dries while the cities walk	She has not been seen in a century. Her staff is a petrified lightning bolt.
Tokoloshe Catcher	Old woman who traps water spirits	Keep the bearings free of malevolent tricksters	She catches tokoloshe in clay pots; they sing when the pot is shaken.

Names of Ngomebe

Inspired by the deep southern plateau: short, earth-toned syllables with clicks and tonal shifts. Surnames often denote a stone type, a city of origin, or a Mason-Kin House.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Morvath	Thandi	Keystone-carver	<i>the Unstill</i>
Kaelen	Nia	Roller-born	<i>the Grey-Faced</i>
Senn	Zola	Mason-Kin	<i>the Slow Walker</i>
Duma	Amara	Stone-song	<i>the Ninth Roller</i>
Temba	Lindi	Sledge-heir	<i>the Root-Breaker</i>
Jengo	Penda	Ox-kin	<i>the Warm Stone</i>
Nomvula	Lethabo	Rain-touched	<i>the Drought's Daughter</i>

(Quarry/Hall/Edge) Abandoned quarry where stone-song still echoes; Mason-Kin hall with walls carved in lineage; the edge of a city's path — the stone is warm to the touch.

Spades — Places

- City on the Move** — Rollers groan, oxen low, the ground trembles. *The city's shadow moves faster than the city itself. Stay in the shadow to keep pace.*
- Abandoned Quarry** — Stone-song echoes from the walls. *The song is the memory of the last stone cut here. It sings of a mason who fell.*
- Mason-Kin Hall** — Walls carved with lineage, floor inlaid with sledge-ruts. *The carvings weep water when a city is in danger. The water tastes of granite.*
- Edge of the Path** — The stone is warm. The warmth fades when the city leaves. *If you place your palm on the stone before it cools, you may ask the city one question.*
- Roller-Pit** — A trench where the great rollers turn, greased with rendered ox-fat. *The grease is mixed with ancestor ash. The rollers remember every mason who ever touched them.*
- Keystone Chamber** — The heart of the city, a single stone that bears all weight. *The keystone hums. The pitch changes when a mason swears a false oath.*

8. **Sledge-Track Scar** — A groove worn into the bedrock by centuries of passage. *The groove is deep enough to hide a corpse. Some say it already does.*
9. **Oxen Corral (Mobile)** — A pen on sledges, dragged behind the city. *The oxen never sleep. They walk in their sleep. Their dreams move the city.*
10. **Root-binder's Grove** — A hidden stand of trees planted in an abandoned roller-pit. *The trees have stone roots. The roots grip the rollers and will not let go.*
- J **Abandoned City (Dead Keystone)** — A stone shell on a hill, silent and cold. *The keystone is cracked. A single green shoot grows from the crack. The Root-binder's work.*
- Q **Bearing Foundry (Aeler)** — A mobile forge where new rollers are cast. *The forge is pulled by a separate team of oxen. It is always last in the procession.*
- K **The Thing-Holm of Stone** — A flat rock where Mason-Kin elders meet. *The rock is a single piece of fallen sky-metal. Oaths sworn here cannot be broken.*
- A **The First City (Myth)** — A walking city that never stopped. It is said to circle the plateau, just beyond the horizon. *Those who see it cannot speak of it for a year and a day. The stone seals their lips.*

(**Cutter/Elder/Engineer**) Stone-cutter whose city left them behind; Mason-Kin elder, grey with granite dust; Aeler engineer: grease-stained, carrying a level.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Stone-Cutter (Left Behind)** — Her city moved south. She stayed to carve a monument. *She carves her own face into the rock. "So the city will remember me," she says.*
3. **Mason-Kin Elder** — Grey with granite dust, eyes the colour of slate. *He carries a hammer that has never struck a false blow. The hammer knows.*
4. **Root-binder Heretic** — Planting acorns in the roller-pits, singing to the earth. *His hands are bark. His breath smells of green wood. The oxen fear him.*
5. **Aeler Engineer** — Tuning fork in one hand, level in the other. *She can hear a crack in a bearing from a mile away. She never walks under a keystone.*
6. **Ox-Master** — Whip of braided leather, voice like a landslide. *He names his oxen after dead masons. The oxen stop when he speaks their names.*
7. **Ancestral Healer (Izinyanga)** — Reads the cracks in the keystone, speaks for the dead. *She wears a necklace of ground quartz. The ancestors whisper through the stones.*
8. **Tokoloshe Catcher** — Old woman, blind in one eye, carries a clay pot. *She traps tokoloshe in her pots. They sing when shaken. She uses their songs to find sabotage.*
9. **Impundulu Tamer** — A legendary bird-whisperer, with scars from lightning. *He can call the lightning bird with a whistle. It demands payment: the blood of a mason.*
10. **Impi Captain** — Warrior of the city's flank guard, carrying a shield of braided leather. *She lost two fingers to a Root-binder ambush. She still holds her spear with the remaining three.*
- J **The First Mason's Ghost** — A translucent figure in a mason's apron. *He appears when a keystone is first laid. He offers advice. The advice is always wrong.*
- Q **The Ninth Ox** — A mythic beast said to pull the First City. *Its hooves never touch the ground. It walks on the shadow of clouds.*
- K **Bearing-Caster (Aeler)** — A dwarf who pours molten metal into roller-molds. *He signs each bearing with his own thumbprint. The thumbprint is a prayer.*

A **The Still Voice** — A spirit made of silence and cold stone. *It asks: “Why did you stop?” Answer truthfully, or it will never let you leave.*

(**Crack/Sabotage/Tremor**) A keystone cracks — the city stops; Root-binder sabotage — a wheel jams; an earth tremor (all actions Desperate for a scene).

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Cracked Keystone** — The heart of the city fractures. The city stops. *The crack is singing. The song is the name of the mason who carved it. He is long dead.*
3. **Root-binder Sabotage** — Acorns sprout in the roller-pits. A wheel jams. *The roots are intelligent. They twist toward the sound of oaths.*
4. **Earth Tremor** — The ground shakes. All actions are Desperate for a scene. *The tremor was not natural. The Still Voice is waking.*
5. **Mason-Kin Feud** — Two Houses argue over the next migration route. *The argument is carved into the keystone. The stone is splitting.*
6. **Oxen Plague** — A sickness spreads through the teams. Speed halves. *The sickness came from a Root-binder’s grove. The leaves are in the fodder.*
7. **Bearing Failure (Aeler)** — A roller seizes. The engineer blames the stone-cutter. *The bearing was sabotaged with sand from the Red Desert. The sand whispers.*
8. **Sledge-Track Collapse** — The ground gives way. A section of the city sinks. *The collapse reveals an older city buried beneath. The older city is still walking.*
9. **Migration Blockade** — Another city has stopped on the planned route. *The stopped city’s keystone is dead. Its people have become Root-binders.*
10. **Ancestral Debt Called** — A Mason-Kin House demands a sledge-right from a century ago. *The debt is carved on a tablet of slate. The slate is warm. The ancestors are watching.*
- J **Tokoloshe in the Bearings** — A water spirit fouls the roller-pits. The city groans. *The tokoloshe is small, fast, and invisible to the unaware. Only a catcher can see it.*
- Q **Impundulu Strikes** — A lightning bird shatters a keystone with a thunderous blow. *The bird is angry. Someone broke a vow to the Rain Queen. The city bleeds stone.*
- K **Root-binder Revolt** — A grove of walking trees attacks the roller-pits. *The trees have stone bark. The stones are carved with Mason-Kin faces.*
- A **The First City Approaches** — A city older than memory appears on the horizon. *It is made of obsidian. Its rollers are giant femurs. It wants to merge.*

(**Charter/Wax/Song**) Keystone charter (right to dwell in a city for a season); sledge-wax (greases negotiation with the Mason-Kin); stone-song fragment (one reroll on a survival test).

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Keystone Charter** — Right to dwell in a city for a season, tax-free. *The charter is a chip of the keystone itself. Carry it to be welcomed.*
3. **Sledge-Wax** — A lump of grey grease. Use it to gain +1 Position in Mason-Kin negotiations. *The wax is rendered from the fat of an ox that walked a thousand miles.*

4. **Stone-Song Fragment** — A recorded hum. Reroll a failed Survival test once. *The song is the city's heartbeat. Hum it, and the stone will guide you.*
 5. **Roller-Bearing (Aeler-crafted)** — A spare bearing. Gift it to an engineer for a favour. *The bearing is stamped with a rune that means "no debt." The rune is a lie.*
 6. **Mason-Kin Hammer** — A tool that never misses a keystone's true face. *The hammer's head is a piece of the First City's keystone. It whispers warnings.*
 7. **Ox-Master's Whip** — Crack it to make oxen move faster for one leg. *The whip's braid includes a hair from every ox that ever pulled a city.*
 8. **Root-binder's Acorn** — Plant it to stop a city's roller for one day. *The acorn grows into a sapling within an hour. The sapling has stone roots.*
 9. **Abandoned City Map** — A chart of dead cities and their keystone graves. *The map is drawn on stone. The stone is a page. The pages are bound in granite.*
 10. **Elder's Verdict** — A ruling that settles a Mason-Kin dispute in your favour. *The verdict is carved on a slate tablet. Carry it as a shield.*
- J **Bearing-Foundry Pass** — Access to the Aeler mobile forge for one repair. *The pass is a single steel coin. The coin is still hot.*
- Q **Still Voice's Silence** — One question answered truthfully by the spirit of abandoned stone. *The answer comes as a cold breath. The breath smells of geode crystals.*
- K **First City's Echo** — A piece of obsidian that hums with ancient rhythm. *Once per campaign, touch it to make a city move one mile in a single night.*
- A **The Living Keystone** — A fragment from a city that still walks. *Plant it in dead stone, and a new city will grow. The growth takes a century.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (charters, wax, songs) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **stone-omens**—rollers that groan in harmony, keystones that weep water, a city that leaves no track.

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **The Keystone Bond (Relationship Mechanic):** Each walking city has a Keystone — a single stone that bears the weight of the roof. The Keystone is also the physical anchor of the city's ancestral spirit. A character who bonds with the Keystone (by spending a downtime scene in meditation at its base) gains:
 - **Keystone Sense:** Once per scene, the character can ask the Keystone one question about the city's current state ("Is the eastern roller cracking?" "Is there a saboteur in the foundry?"). The Keystone answers truthfully, but only about the present.
 - **Keystone Debt:** The character gains a Debt Clock (size 4) to the ancestor. When it fills, the ancestor demands a service — usually a pilgrimage to a forgotten quarry or the retrieval of a lost roller.
- **The Roller-Pits (Hazard Mechanic):** The city moves on rollers — massive wooden

cylinders that must be greased and rotated. The roller-pits are dangerous, loud, and prone to sabotage.

- Entering a roller-pit requires a **Body + Athletics test (DV 4)** to avoid being crushed. On a failure, the character takes 1 Harm.
- Sabotaging a roller-pit (to stop the city or redirect it) requires a **Wits + Craft test (DV 5)**. On a success, the city moves in the desired direction; on a failure, the roller jams and the city stops — and the ancestors are angry.
- Repairing a jammed roller takes 3 actions. Each action requires a **Body + Craft test (DV 4)**. On a failure, the roller shifts and the character takes 1 Fatigue.
- **The Migration Clock (Campaign Clock, size 10):** Every walking city has a Migration Clock. It advances each day the city moves, and retreats when the city stops.
 - At 2: The city enters fertile land. The party gains +1 die to foraging and hunting.
 - At 4: The city passes a rival settlement. The party may trade or raid.
 - At 6: The city enters a narrow pass. All navigation rolls are Desperate.
 - At 8: The city approaches a sacred site. The ancestors grow restless — all rolls involving the Keystone gain +1 die, but failure ticks the Keystone Debt clock by 2.
 - At 10: The city reaches its destination — the end of the migration. The ancestors are satisfied. The party may claim a **Keystone Blessing** (a permanent +1 die to all rolls involving stonework or negotiation with Ngomebe).

The party can influence the Migration Clock by:

- **Scouting ahead** (Wits + Survival) – success advances the clock by 1, failure ticks it back by 1.
- **Repairing rollers** (Craft test) – success advances the clock by 2, failure advances it by 0 but ticks the Keystone Debt.
- **Paying tribute** (a Honey Jar, a story, or a Boon) – advances the clock by 1 without risk.
- **The Root-binder Heresy (Faction Mechanic):** Root-binders are heretics who plant acorns in the roller-pits, hoping to stop the cities and let the forest reclaim the stone. They have a **Sabotage Clock (size 6)**. Each time the party fails a Craft or Survival roll in a roller-pit, the Sabotage Clock ticks.
 - At 2: A roller cracks. The city loses 1 Speed (travel takes longer).
 - At 4: A roller-pit floods. The city must stop for repairs (lose 1 day).
 - At 6: A major collapse. The city cannot move until the party clears the pit (requires a Strength + Craft test, DV 5, and costs 1 day).

Players can work with the Root-binders (gain information, sabotage rival cities) or against them (hunt them, protect the rollers). The Root-binders offer **Green Blessings** – a permanent +1 die to survival in the forest, but at the cost of a Debt Clock to “the forest itself” (the Hollow’s attention).

- **The Mason-Kin Houses:** The walking cities are not nations but extended families. Each House controls a keystone, a migration route, and the rights to carve. Houses feud over sledge-tracks, water rights, and the honour of the First City.
- **The Aeler Pact:** The Aeler engineers of the southern ranges maintain the bearings and capstans that make the walking cities possible. The Ngomebe provide keystone hearts and

stone-song. It is a partnership of equals, sealed in slate and iron.

- **Ancestral Cracks:** Once per session, a character may press their ear to a keystone and roll Spirit + Lore (DV 3). On success, the ancestors whisper a warning or a clue (GM reveals a hidden complication or a shortcut). On a miss, the stone is silent — but the ancestors are listening.
- **Tokoloshe Pots:** A character who carries a clay pot with a tokoloshe inside gains +1 die to detect sabotage or traps in the city. The tokoloshe sings when danger is near. However, if the pot breaks, the tokoloshe escapes and will haunt the carrier for a full season (all actions Desperate at night).
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
 - **The First Stone** — The Sealed Gate. *The keystone that never cracks; the oath that never breaks.*
 - **The Rain Queen** — Raéyn. *The bringer of storms and the drought; the mistress of the path.*
 - **The Lightning Bird** — The Storm King. *The shatterer of false keystones; the judge of masons.*
 - **The Ancestor's Voice** — The Witness. *The whisper in the crack; the memory in the stone.*

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Red Desert's Breath (Ashaan):** The Red Desert is spreading. Some Ngomebe cities are moving south to escape the dust. The Keystone Charter of a southern city may be the only thing standing between a tribe and annihilation.
- **The Sledge-Wax Trade (Way of Silk):** Sledge-wax is a valuable commodity on the caravan routes. Tulkani merchants trade it for story-knots; Fhara water-clerks use it to seal well-contracts. A missing shipment of sledge-wax could stop a city.
- **The Iron Mines of Vajrapur (Dhahara):** The Aeler engineers of Ngomebe source their bearing-metal from the Dhaharan iron mines. A dispute between a Mason-Kin House and a Dhaharan raja could choke the supply of rollers.
- **The Hollow and the Still City (Eastern Realms):** The Hollow is attracted to still places. A city that stops moving becomes a beacon. The Aelaerem whisper that the First City never stopped because it is running from something.
- **Tokoloshe and the Bitter Root:** Daughters of the Cord sometimes capture tokoloshe and weave them into Hollowed children. The tokoloshe inside the child sings when a debt is due. The Ngomebe avoid Daughter-run hospices for this reason.

Ngomebe Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Roller:** Crumble a crust into the grease-pit. Ignore the first *Earth Tremor* penalty. '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Knot the Sledge-Rope:** Tie a single knot in an ox's halter. Cancel *Oxen Plague* or take -1 die on your next handling roll (your choice). '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Name to the Keystone:** Whisper a dead mason's name into the keystone's crack. Gain +1 Effect when negotiating with the Mason-Kin this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the First City. '[SUPERSTITION]'

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **Mason-Kin guards** or **Aeler engineers**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **ox-drivers** or **stone-cutters**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **Root-binders** or **keystone guardians**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time** or **favorable migration pace**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Local Mason-Kin elder** or **Aeler vent-prior** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **earth tremor** or **roller jam**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **Root-binder cell** or **rival House guard** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **Mason-Kin**, **Root-binders**, or **Aeler engineers** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes—**keystone cracks/city stops/First City sighted**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **Mason-Kin High Council**, **Still Voice**, or **First City’s herald** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically—**tremor opens a chasm/city splits in two/keystone begins to sing**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice—**omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Ngomebe (Stone Law):** Keystone hums a warning, roller-grooves glow faintly, the ground trembles without quake.
- **Ngomebe (Root-binder Heresy):** Acorns sprout from cracks, vines write warnings in the dust, trees move against the wind.
- **Ngomebe (Aeler Pact):** Bearings click in counterpoint, tuning forks ring without being struck, the smell of hot metal hangs in still air.

- **Ngomebe (Ancestral Spirits):** A cold breath whispers a name, the keystone weeps water, a tokoloshe laugh echoes from a dry roller-pit.

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Wits + Survival):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *False Trail*.
- **Cut the Sledge (Presence + Sway):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a keystone charter is in your possession, +1 die.
- **Weather the Tremor (Body + Athletics):** On a hit in *Earth Tremor*, you pick who stays standing; on a miss, the GM does.

Boss Seeds (Stone & Root)

- **The Root-King (Nine Groves)** — *Phases:* Acorn Sabotage → Orchestrated Stillness → Forest Coup. *Cracks:* burn a grove, expose a false acorn, survive a landslide.
- **The Still Voice (Silence of Stone)** — *Phases:* Abandoned keystones → Procession of Dead Cities → Stillness Baptism of an Elder. *Cracks:* relic stone-song, survivor testimony, the city moving against the Voice.
- **The Tokoloshe King (Master of Tricksters)** — *Phases:* Bearings Foul → Roller Pit Flooded → Oxen Stampede. *Cracks:* trap him in a clay pot, negotiate with a pot of sorghum beer, feed him a false name.

Patronage & Power

Among the Ngomebe, power flows through keystones, migration rights, and the loyalty of the Mason-Kin Houses. An elder's authority rests on the age of his House's keystone and the number of cities that follow his route. The Aeler engineers hold technical authority; the Root-binders offer a heretical alternative; and the Ancestral Healers speak for the dead, who still vote through the cracks in the stone.

For the GM: Power in Ngomebe society is measured in movement and stone. Patronage often takes the form of keystone charters, sledge-wax, or stone-song fragments—each tied to a specific city and House. To emphasize this:

- Tie rewards to physical tokens (chips of keystone, lumps of wax, recorded songs) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided.
- Let rival Houses issue conflicting claims, forcing players to choose whose city shelters them.
- Use the roller-pits, keystone chambers, and Mason-Kin halls as arenas for social contests, where migration routes are debated and saboteurs are judged.
- Introduce **Ancestral Cracks** as a way for players to gain clues from the dead — but at the cost of the ancestors' attention.

In Ngomebe society, the stone remembers everything — including your debts. The ancestors do not forget. The tokoloshe does not forgive. And the city that stops dies.

The Nine Rollers: A City on the Edge

The Hook

The party arrives at the edge of a moving city — not one of the great metropolises, but a smaller Walker named **Khomani's Progress**, named after the mason who carved its keystone three centuries ago. The city is dying.

Elder Morvath meets you at the sledge-track, his face grey with granite dust and exhaustion. “The city has not stopped in forty days. We cannot stop. The ancestors will not let us. But the rollers are cracking. The oxen are dying. And something is following us — something that walks in the dust and counts our breaths.”

He leads you to the keystone chamber. The great stone is warm. Too warm. A network of fine cracks spreads from its centre like veins. The cracks are singing — a low, mournful hum in a language none of you recognize.

“The Ninth Roller is failing,” Morvath says. “It was carved by Khomani herself. It has never been replaced. If it fails, the city stops. If the city stops, the Hollow comes. We have nine days until the roller cannot turn. Find a replacement — or learn to sing the stone-song well enough to heal it.”

The Mechanics

The party has **nine days** (or scenes) to save *Khomani's Progress*. Each day, they may choose one action from the table below. The city's condition is tracked by three clocks:

Clock	Description
Roller Integrity [9]	Starts at 9 (the Ninth Roller). Ticks down each day. At 0, the roller fails.
Ancestor Favour [8]	Starts at 4. Ticks up when the party honours the ancestors, ticks down when they offend. At 8, the ancestors help. At 0, the Still Voice comes.
Root-binder Attention [6]	Ticks up when the party interacts with Root-binders or damages the forest. At 6, the Root-binders attack.

Daily Actions

Each day, the party chooses **one** primary action and may assign up to **two** party members to support (each support grants +1 die to the primary roll).

Action	Roll	Outcome
Search for a new roller	Wits + Survival (DV 5)	<i>Success</i> : Find a suitable stone. <i>Partial</i> : Find one that needs carving. <i>Fail</i> : Find nothing — tick Roller Integrity –1.
Carve a replacement	Craft + Spirit (DV 6)	<i>Success</i> : New roller ready in 2 days. <i>Partial</i> : Ready in 4 days. <i>Fail</i> : Crack the stone — Roller Integrity –2.
Negotiate with Root-binders	Presence + Sway (DV 4)	<i>Success</i> : Root-binder Attention –2. <i>Partial</i> : –1. <i>Fail</i> : Root-binder Attention +2.

Chapter 21

Taharka

The Monsoon Crown.

The passes remember every army that tried to climb them. The mountains do not forgive haste, and they do not forget a foreign banner. We do not guard the highlands. We listen to them. They tell us who to let through.

I am a Horse Trader. Before you praise the rider, praise the horse. Before you praise the horse, praise the mountain that grew its lungs. A Taharkan foal is born breathing thin air. That is why our cavalry has never been broken.

Taharka grows rich on monsoon trade—spices, coffee, and incense that travel east to the distant ocean and west to the Gulf. The kingdom has never been conquered; its passes are a graveyard for Ashaani armies and a barrier that Oshiiran grain barges cannot cross. The highlands are a fortress of rock and thin air, where every valley speaks a different dialect and every ridge has a watchtower. But here's the secret the Crown Council doesn't want you to know: the passes are alive. They have a memory. They remember every army that tried to climb them, every foreign banner that flew too high, every oath that was broken at the summit. And they do not forgive.

The Ridge-Watchers are the eyes of the kingdom, stationed in rock-chapels that double as signal towers. The horse is not a mount; it is a lineage, a treaty, a weapon. To control the highland breeds is to control the passes—and to control the passes is to remain free. The lowland coast operates under a different law: the ujamaa of the dhows, a mutual aid network where every captain owes a share of every voyage to the community. A captain who cheats the ujamaa finds his ship's name struck from every mooring post in the archipelago.

Never refuse a second cup of tea. The first is hospitality; the second is

a test of honour. The third is a promise. Refuse the second, and you have insulted the house—and the house's ancestors, who are listening through the floorboards.

— *Ridge-Watcher Captain Anwar, who has not descended below the snow line in twenty years*

The Almanac of Ordinary Days

What do people eat for breakfast? Barley flatbread and spiced tea—the bread is baked on iron griddles, the tea is brewed with cardamom and mountain herbs. The herbs are harvested from passes that only the Ridge-Watchers know. The Ridge-Watchers do not share.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To read the wind. Taharkan children are taught the eight winds by name: North, South, East, West, Monsoon, Dry, Storm, and the ninth—the wind that has no name. The ninth wind is the mountain's breath. The mountain's breath is death.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their breath. The air is thin in Taharka. A stranger who breathes too fast has not acclimated. A stranger who breathes too slow is hiding something. A stranger who does not breathe at all is a spirit. The spirits are not to be spoken to.

What is the most common crime? Horse theft—but horse theft is not a crime, it is a declaration of war. The horse is the kingdom's bloodline. A stolen horse is a stolen ancestor. The thief's clan is responsible. The clan pays in blood or in trade. The trade is never enough. The blood is always too much.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Crown Council has not met in ten years. The passes have been closed by snow, by war, by the simple fact that the councillors cannot agree on a meeting place. The kingdom is ruled by the Ridge-Watchers. The Ridge-Watchers are not elected. The Ridge-Watchers are the mountains' voice. The mountains are silent.

Where do people go when they die? To the high passes. The dead are laid on stone platforms, wrapped in woollen shrouds. The wind takes them. The wind carries their names to the peaks. The peaks remember. The peaks are the kingdom's cemetery.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You offer a horse—the best horse in your stable. The horse is given to the wronged party. If they accept, the debt is paid. If they refuse, the debt is doubled. If they kill the horse, the debt is blood. Blood is never repaid.

What is the most important festival? The First Rain (monsoon's arrival). The passes open for the first time in months. The caravans descend from the highlands. The lowland ports receive the first spice ships. The celebration lasts nine days. The ninth day is silent. The silence is for the dead of the passes.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Crown Council's missing member is not missing. He is buried under a landslide that was not an accident. The landslide was caused by the Ridge-Watchers. The councillor had learned the passes' secret: they are not natural. They were carved by something older. The something is still there. The Ridge-Watchers are its servants.

21.1 Taharka — “The Monsoon Crown”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *The mountain listens. The horse remembers. The monsoon keeps the ledger.*

Ridge-Watcher Captain (Elite): “The passes remember every army that tried to climb them. The mountains do not forgive haste, and they do not forget a foreign banner. We do not guard the highlands. We listen to them. They tell us who to let through.”

Horse Trader (Commoner): “Before you praise the rider, praise the horse. Before you praise the horse, praise the mountain that grew its lungs. A Taharkan foal is born breathing thin air. That is why our cavalry has never been broken. The monsoon gives us wind; the horse gives us wings.”

Genre / Mood: Monsoon trade, highland fortresses, spirit-ridden passes, oral law.

Starting Location: A rock-chapel at the head of the Silver Pass, where the air is cold and the wind smells of snow. A Ridge-Watcher captain blows a horn of ibex horn: “The Crown Council has declared a muster. The passes are closing to all foreign traffic. You have until dusk to declare your business — or turn back. The shetani are restless. They taste fear on the wind.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Taharka grows rich on monsoon trade — spices, coffee, and frankincense that travel east to the distant ocean and west to the Gulf. The kingdom has never been conquered; its passes are a graveyard for Ashaani armies and a barrier that Oshiiran grain barges cannot cross. The highlands are a fortress of rock and thin air, where every valley speaks a different dialect and every ridge has a watchtower. On the coast, the monsoon winds bring dhows from Dhahara, Ayokha, and the eastern isles, and a trade creole — a blend of Bantu, Arabic, and Cushitic tongues — has grown from a dozen voices, the language of the wharves where a merchant can bargain in verse and a captain can curse in seven accents. The old spirits — the *shetani* — live in springs, baobabs, and the bones of ancestors. The *popobawa* hunts at the dark of the moon. The *ngoma* drums speak faster than horns. And the passes themselves are alive, breathing with the memory of every army that froze or fell.

What you notice first: The smell of roasting coffee and frankincense. The way the air thins as you climb, until each breath is a measured gift. The constant lowing of pack mules on terraced paths.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never refuse a second cup of tea. The first is hospitality; the second is a test of honour; the third is a promise. Refuse the second, and you have insulted the house — and the house’s ancestors, who are listening through the floorboards.

Regional Mood: The Weight of the Pass

Power here is measured in passes, horse lines, and the favour of the monsoon. The Crown Council rules from the high plateau, but each valley has its own lord, each pass its own toll-keeper. The Ridge-Watchers are the eyes of the kingdom, stationed in rock-chapels that double as signal towers. The horse is not a mount; it is a lineage, a treaty, a weapon. To control the highland breeds is to control the passes — and to control the passes is to remain free. The lowland coast operates under

a different law: the *ujamaa* of the dhows, a mutual aid network where every captain owes a share of every voyage to the community. A captain who cheats the *ujamaa* finds his ship's name struck from every mooring post in the archipelago.

Prominent NPCs of Taharka

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Ridge-Watcher Captain Anwar	Commander of the Silver Pass garrison	Keep the passes closed to Ashaani spies	He has not descended below the snow line in twenty years. His shadow is a man who died on the pass.
Merchant-Queen Safiya	Spice House matriarch of the western coast	Control the monsoon trade before the Crown taxes it	She speaks the trade creole with a coastal accent that no one can place. Her left eye is a cowrie shell.
Horse Lord Tamrat	Breeder of the royal stables	Sell a foal to the Dhaharan court for a pass-right	He names his horses after dead poets. The horses recite verses in their gait.
Sister Hana	Covenant judge of the highland circuit	Resolve disputes between lords without drawing Crown attention	She carries a water-clock that runs on melted snow. It never freezes.
The Astrologer of the Monsoon	Crown advisor who reads the winds	Predict the first rains to set the trade season	He has not seen the sun in thirty years. He works by candlelight and the pulse of a spider in a jar.

The Pass Ghost (Liyel)	A spirit of a soldier who froze on watch	Warn travellers of avalanches and ambushes	It appears as a column of steam in the cold air. It points with a skeletal finger.
Mama Zawadi	Shetani medium of the coast	Speak for the spirits of the baobab groves	She never walks on bare earth. Her sandals are woven from the roots of a sacred fig.

Names of Taharka

Inspired by the Swahili coast and the highland plateau: melodic, with doubled consonants, honorific prefixes (Mwalimu, Bibi, Bwana), and surnames that denote a clan, a pass, or a horse-line.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Tamrat	Safiya	Berhanu	<i>the Ridge-Born</i>
Anwar	Hana	Tesfaye	<i>the Horse-Tongue</i>
Dawit	Zawadi	Gebre	<i>the Monsoon-Watcher</i>
Kassim	Lij	Mekonnen	<i>the Ninth Pass</i>
Solomon	Tsion	Desta	<i>the Coffee-Blade</i>
Jabir	Mwanaidi	Asfaw	<i>the Thin-Air</i>
Omari	Bahati	Ngoma	<i>Drum-Voice</i>

(Farm/Chapel/Pass) Terraced coffee farm on stone steps; rock-chapel where walls drip condensation; high pass where snow lingers even in summer.

Spades — Places

2. **Terraced Farm (Coffee)** — Shrubs planted on stone-step shelves. *The steps are a thousand years old. Each step is a different family’s debt — paid in beans, not coin.* ‘[LABOR]’
3. **Rock-Chapel (Dripping)** — A cave-temple where the walls weep condensation. *The water is holy. Drink it, and you will remember a past life. The water tastes of iron and old grief.* ‘[RITUAL]’
4. **High Pass (Summer Snow)** — A saddle between peaks where the wind never stops. *The snow is blue. It crunches like glass underfoot. Do not eat it — it is the frozen breath of the dead.* ‘[WEATHER]’
5. **King’s Stable** — A long building of fitted stone, horses in brass halters. *Each stall has a nameplate. The nameplate is a defeated enemy’s shield. The horses remember the battles.* ‘[LEGEND]’

6. **Spice Warehouse (Coast)** — A wood-and-coral building that smells of cardamom. *The floor is layered with spices that fell from broken sacks. The layers are a century thick. The ghosts of porters sort them at night.* ‘[TRADE]’
7. **Monsoon Wharf** — A stone pier that is underwater half the year. *The pier is carved with tide marks. Each mark is a year when a ship never returned. The sailors’ widows add new marks with their tears.* ‘[DEATH]’
8. **Crown Council Hall** — A roundhouse of stone and horn, built into a hillside. *The hall has nine doors. Each door leads to a different valley. The ninth door is sealed. Behind it is a spider that weaves the future.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
9. **Horse Cemetery** — A field of cairns, each topped with a bronze bell. *The bells ring when a foal is born to the same bloodline. The dead horses speak through the bells. Their advice is always short.* ‘[DEATH]’
10. **Ridge-Watcher Tower** — A stone needle on a peak, with a signal fire that never goes out. *The fire burns blue when the passes are closed. It burns green when a foreign army is sighted. It burns red when a shetani walks.* ‘[WARNING]’
- J **Trade Creole School** — A thatched hut where children learn the coastal tongue. *The teacher is a one-eyed sailor. He signs his lessons with knots, not words. The knots are a map of the monsoon winds.* ‘[SOCIAL]’
- Q **The Astrologer’s Observatory** — A roofless tower with a bronze armillary sphere. *The sphere has nine rings. The ninth ring is broken. The astrologer refuses to fix it — he says the ninth wind has no name.* ‘[MAGIC]’
- K **The Pass of the Ninth Army** — A defile where an Ashaani host froze to the rock. *On cold nights, you can still see their shapes in the ice. They are still standing. Their lips move. They are still counting.* ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[FEAR]’
- A **The King’s Tomb (Hidden)** — A cave sealed with a single keystone. *The keystone has a single word carved in the trade creole: “Wait.” The word changes every season. Only the Ridge-Watchers know the current one.* ‘[LEGEND]’

(Trader/Watcher/Envoy) Horse trader with a copper bell; Ridge-Watcher captain with a bow over his shoulder; Spice House merchant in robes smelling of cardamom.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Horse Trader** — Copper bell on his belt, a ledger of bloodlines in his head. *He names his price in coffee, not coin. The coffee is grown on his own terrace. He tastes every batch before closing a deal.* ‘[TRADE]’
3. **Ridge-Watcher Captain** — Bow of horn and sinew, arrows fletched with eagle feathers. *He can draw a bow at full gallop. He has never missed. He says the mountain guides his hand.* ‘[COMBAT]’
4. **Spice House Merchant** — Robes stained with cinnamon, fingers yellow with turmeric. *She can identify a spice’s origin by taste. She has been wrong twice. Both times, the ship sank. She no longer tastes alone.* ‘[TRADE]’
5. **Crown Council Envoy** — Careful, neutral, carrying a staff of office carved from a single piece of ebony. *He speaks in questions. “Would the honoured traveller perhaps consent to...” The questions are traps. The answers are leverage.* ‘[POLITICS]’

6. **Coffee Farmer** — Hands stained black from hulling beans, eyes crinkled from sun. *He offers a cup to every passerby. The cup is clay. The clay is from a sacred spring. He never drinks first — that would insult the spirit of the bean.* ‘[COMMUNITY]’
7. **Monsoon Captain** — A sailor with a brass ring in one ear and a scar across his throat. *He speaks the trade creole with a Dhaharan accent. His ship is named “Ninth Wind.” He has never lost a dhow to a storm. The storms are his cousins.* ‘[TRAVEL]’
8. **Pass Guide** — A hooded figure with a staff tipped with a horse skull. *She never speaks above a whisper. The wind carries her voice exactly as far as needed. She knows every crevasse by the sound it makes when she spits into it.* ‘[STEALTH]’
9. **Sister Hana (Covenant Judge)** — Grey robe, water-clock, a scale that never balances. *She has ruled on nine border disputes. The losing party always apologizes. The winning party always shares their meal with her.* ‘[JUSTICE]’
10. **Horse Lord Tamrat** — Grey beard braided with horsehair, missing two fingers. *The missing fingers were bitten off by a foal. He kept the foal. It is now his favourite mount. Its name is “Apology.”* ‘[SOCIAL]’
- J **The Astrologer** — Blind, pale, wrapped in wool. He smells of wax and ozone. *He predicts the monsoon by the pulse of a spider in a jar. The spider has never been wrong. He feeds it his own dreams.* ‘[MAGIC]’
- Q **The Pass Ghost (Liyel)** — A column of steam in the cold air, shaped like a soldier. *It points at travellers. The direction indicates the safest route. It never points the same way twice. If it points at you, do not move.* ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[WARNING]’
- K **The King (Offstage)** — Never seen, rarely heard, but his name opens every door. *Rumour says he is a horse. Rumour says he is a spirit. Rumour says he is a child of nine who never grew up. The Ridge-Watchers do not correct any rumour.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
- A **The Ninth Heir (Exiled)** — A prince who lost a succession war, now living as a horse-trader. *He carries a seal made of bone. The bone was his father’s thumb. He has not used it. He is waiting for the right moment — or the right bribe.* ‘[LEGEND]’

(Landslide/Sickness/Assassination) A landslide blocks the pass (delay 2 segments); horse sickness spreads — all mounts lose 1 Speed; the king is assassinated — passes close to all foreign traffic.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Landslide Block** — A rockslide covers the pass. Delay 2 segments. ‘[WEATHER]’ *The rocks are warm. The landslide was caused by a signal fire on the peak. Someone wanted the pass closed.*
3. **Horse Sickness** — A cough spreads through the stables. All mounts lose 1 Speed. ‘[DISEASE]’ *The sickness came from a Dhaharan ship. The captain is a spy. The horses cough in a rhythm that spells a warning.*
4. **King Assassinated** — The Crown Council declares a succession crisis. All passes close. ‘[POLITICS]’ *The assassin was a horse. The horse was poisoned. The poison was in the coffee. The horse is still alive. It will not speak.*
5. **Ashaani Raiders (Disguised)** — A caravan of “merchants” is actually a Veiled Sister’s scout team. ‘[SPY]’ *They wear Taharkan dress but do not remove their shoes indoors. The innkeeper noticed. She poured them a fourth cup — a curse.*

6. **Coffee Blight** — A fungus attacks the terraces. Prices triple. Starvation looms. '[DISASTER]' *The blight was spread by a trader from the coast. The trader's ship flew no flag. The fungus writes names on the leaves.*
7. **Monsoon Delay** — The winds shift. The first ships are three weeks late. '[WEATHER]' *The delay was predicted by the astrologer. He warned the Crown. The Crown did not listen. The astrologer has stopped speaking.*
8. **Spice Warehouse Fire** — A stack of cinnamon ignites. The whole wharf is at risk. '[DISASTER]' *The fire was set by a rival House. The House has a monopoly on pepper. The smoke smells of cloves. Cloves do not burn.*
9. **Trade Creole Dispute** — A contract is voided because of a mistranslated word. '[SOCIAL]' '[DEBT]' *The word means "shipment" in one dialect and "hostage" in another. The merchant knew. The hostage is the party's ally.*
10. **Ridge-Watcher Betrayal** — A captain sells the pass schedule to an Ashaani agent. '[SPY]' '[DEBT]' *The captain's daughter is a spirit-broken slave in Galanina. He had no choice. He carved her name into every stone of the pass.*
- J **The Pass Ghost's Warning** — The ghost points at a traveller. The traveller will die before sunset. '[DEATH]' '[OMEN]' *The traveller is a party member. The ghost is pointing at a shadow, not a person. The shadow is not theirs.*
- Q **Crown Council Schism** — The nine lords cannot agree on a successor. Civil war looms. '[POLITICS]' *The ninth lord is a child. The child speaks only the trade creole. No one understands. The child's nanny is the only interpreter. She is not neutral.*
- K **Horse Line Extinction** — A plague kills the last mare of the royal bloodline. '[DEATH]' '[LEGEND]' *The mare's foal was stolen by a rival kingdom. The foal is in a Dhaharan stable. The mare's ghost runs the passes every night, looking for it.*
- A **Shetani Rising** — The old spirits wake from the baobab groves. They demand a reckoning. '[MAGIC]' '[FEAR]' *A traveller broke a taboo — they counted to nine near a spirit tree. The shetani want a story that ends with eight. Tell one, or pay in blood.*

(Bond/Stone/Pass) Horse-bond — a foal promised (future String); pass-stone — crossing a high pass at half toll; coffee measure — trade goods at +1 Position for one scene.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Horse-Bond (Promised Foal)** — A future String. The foal has not yet been born. '[COMMUNITY]' *The bond is a braid of horsehair. Wear it, and the mare will remember you. When the foal is born, you will be its first rider.*
3. **Pass-Stone** — A carved token. Cross any high pass at half toll. '[TRAVEL]' *The stone is a piece of the Pass Ghost's staff. It is cold to the touch. It warms when a storm is coming.*
4. **Coffee Measure (Royal Seal)** — A clay cup. Trade goods at +1 Position for one scene. '[TRADE]' *The cup was used by the king. He drank from it once. The crack is from his tooth. He still has the tooth. It is set in a ring.*
5. **Ridge-Watcher's Horn** — Blow it to summon a guide from the nearest tower. '[TRAVEL]' *The horn is made from an ibex that the captain killed with a single arrow. The ibex's ghost will lead you — if you give it a story.*
6. **Spice House Letter of Credit** — 5 Measures of trade value, redeemable at any coast

warehouse. ‘[TRADE]’ *The letter is sealed with cinnamon oil. The seal smells of betrayal. It also smells of profit.*

7. **Crown Council Verdict** — A ruling in your favour on any border dispute. ‘[JUSTICE]’ *The verdict is carved on a slate tile. The tile is also a signal flag. Show it to a Ridge-Watcher, and they will argue for you.*
 8. **Monsoon Schedule (Astrologer’s Copy)** — Predicts safe sailing days for the next season. ‘[WEATHER]’ *The schedule is written on a dried spiderweb. The web was the astrologer’s pet. It must be kept in a jar. If it breaks, the predictions invert.*
 9. **Trade Creole Phrasebook** — Gain +1 die to all social rolls on the coast for one journey. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The phrasebook is a string of knots. Each knot is a curse. The curses are useful. The blessings are not.*
 10. **Horse Lord’s Favour** — One foal from the royal stables, delivered in a year. ‘[COMMUNITY]’ *The favour is a single white hair from the stallion’s tail. The stallion is dead. The hair is still warm.*
- J **Pass Ghost’s Pointing** — One safe route through any high pass, guaranteed. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The ghost writes the route in frost on a rock. The frost melts at noon. You must memorise it before then.*
- Q **The Astrologer’s Spider** — A jarred spider that pulses with the monsoon’s heartbeat. ‘[MAGIC]’ *Once per campaign, consult the spider to predict a storm with perfect accuracy. The spider will answer. It will also ask a question. The question is always personal.*
- K **The Ninth Heir’s Seal** — A bone thumbprint. Commands loyalty from the exiled prince’s network. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The seal is also a key. It opens a lock in the Crown Council Hall. The lock is the ninth door. The door leads to a room with no floor.*
- A **The King’s Blessing** — A royal decree written in trade creole. One national favour. ‘[LEGEND]’ *The decree is written on a horse’s hoof. The hoof was the king’s favourite mount. The king still weeps when he sees it.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (bonds, stones, measures) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **monsoon-omens**—horses that speak in riddles, coffee that tastes of snow, a pass that closes behind you, a spider that weaves the future into its web.

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **Ridge-Watcher Signals:** A network of signal towers on every peak. A fire, a mirror, or a horn can send a message across the entire kingdom in a day. The Ridge-Watchers are neutral in Crown politics; they serve only the passes. A character who spends an action to light a signal fire may reduce the next weather hazard by 1 segment, but the fire also attracts shetani (GM gains 1 SB).
- **Ujamaa of the Dhows (Mutual Aid):** Along the coast, every captain owes a share of every voyage to the community. A character who contributes to the ujamaa (by sharing cargo, repairing a dock, or telling a true story) gains a *Community Favour* token. Spend it to reroll a

failed social roll with any coastal merchant or captain. Hoarding wealth without contributing, however, gives the GM 1 SB per session as the community closes ranks.

- **Shetani Taboos:** The old spirits — shetani — live in springs, baobabs, and the bones of ancestors. Breaking a taboo (counting to nine near a spirit tree, refusing a cup of tea, wearing shoes in a shrine) draws their attention. The GM may then spend 2 SB to have a shetani appear and demand a story that ends with the number eight. A good story pacifies the spirit; a poor one curses the offender with *Shetani's Mark* (–1 die on all rolls until they make an offering of honey and blood).
- **Horse Lineage as Leverage:** Every highland horse belongs to a lineage that traces back to a legendary stallion. Knowing a horse's lineage gives +1 die on social rolls with its owner. A character who can recite the lineage of a horse from memory may treat the horse as a temporary ally (Cap 2) for one scene. Forging a lineage is a capital crime — the Crown Council has executed three forgers in the last decade.
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
 - **Mzimu wa Kwanza** (The First Spirit) — The Witness. *The ancestor who remembers every oath, every betrayal, every cup of tea refused.*
 - **Bwana wa Nyasi** (Lord of the Grass) — The Traveler. *The wind that guides the monsoon dhows and the rider lost in the high passes.*
 - **Shetani wa Tisa** (The Shetani of Nine) — The Ninth. *The spirit that lives in the missing step, the uncounted wave, the breath after eight.*
 - **Bibi wa Kahawa** (Grandmother of Coffee) — Inaea. *The web of trade that binds coast to highlands, merchant to farmer, dhow to mule.*

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Monsoon Trade (Dhahara/Ayokha):** Taharka's spice and coffee travel east on the monsoon winds, reaching the Dhaharan coast and the Ayokhan river markets. A delay in Taharka means famine in a dozen ports. The dhows are blessed by Bibi wa Kahawa; a captain who breaks the blessing finds his ship becalmed for nine days.
- **The Pass Ghost and the Hollow (Eastern Realms):** The Pass Ghost (Liyel) is a spirit of the threshold — a border between living and dead. The Aelaerem say it is a cousin to the Hollow, bound by an oath to the first king. If you see it point at you, you have one day to settle your debts. The Hollow collects the rest.
- **Ashaani Spies and the Veiled Sisters (Ashaan):** Ashaani agents often pose as spice merchants. The Ridge-Watchers have learned to test them by offering tea — a foreigner who does not know the ritual of three cups reveals themselves. The Veiled Sisters have begun sending agents who have studied the ritual. The Ridge-Watchers are now testing with a fourth cup — the silence cup.
- **The Ninth Heir and the Kalrantha Amulet (Dhahara):** The exiled prince is rumoured to have bought his horse from a Dhaharan smuggler — a horse that carried a certain green glass amulet. The Crown Council wants to know where the amulet is now. The prince says he sold it for a pass-stone. The pass-stone is now in the hand of the Astrologer.

Taharka Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Pass:** Crumble a crust at the highest point of the pass. Ignore the first *Landslide Block* penalty. '[SUPERSTITION]'

- **Knot the Horse’s Tail:** Tie a single knot in a horse’s tail hair. Cancel *Horse Sickness* or take –1 die on your next riding roll (your choice). ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Name to the Coffee:** Whisper a dead Ridge-Watcher’s name into a coffee cup. Gain +1 Effect when negotiating passage this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Crown. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **Ridge-Watchers** or **Crown Council envoys**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **horse guards** or **spice warehouse clerks**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **pass guides** or **rival horse traders**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time** or **favourable monsoon window**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Local Ridge-Watcher captain** or **Spice House factor** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **landslide** or **fog**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **rival horse lord** or **Ashaani agent** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **Ridge-Watchers**, **Crown guards**, or **spice house enforcers** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes—**king assassinated/monsoon fails/pass closes forever**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **Crown Council**, **the Astrologer**, or **the Pass Ghost** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically—**avalanche buries the pass/monsoon surf floods the wharf/coffee terraces catch fire**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice—**omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Taharka (Highlands):** Pass stones glow faintly, horse bells ring without wind, snow falls upward.

- **Taharka (Coast):** Monsoon winds carry whispers, spice dust forms faces, the trade creole sprouts new words unbidden.
- **Taharka (Spirit Law):** A shetani laughs from a baobab, a coffee cup cracks, a spider weaves a question into its web.

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Wits + Survival):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Thin Air*.
- **Cut the Pass (Presence + Sway):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a pass-stone is in your possession, +1 die.
- **Weather the Monsoon (Resolve + Sail):** On a hit in *Monsoon Delay*, you pick which ships dock; on a miss, the GM does.

Boss Seeds (Horse, Monsoon & Shetani)

- **The Horse-Line Thief (Nine Bloodlines)** — *Phases:* Foal Thefts → Orchestrated Plague → Stable Coup. *Cracks:* recover a stolen foal, expose a false lineage, survive a stampede.
- **The Monsoon-Breaker (Storm That Stalls)** — *Phases:* Delayed Ships → Procession of Empty Wharves → Famine Baptism of a Merchant. *Cracks:* relic monsoon schedule, survivor testimony, the wind turning against them.
- **The Shetani of the Ninth Pass (Spirit of the Miscount)** — *Phases:* Miscount Whispers → Stone Slides → Pass Feast. *Cracks:* recite a counting song that ends at eight, offer a honey-and-blood sacrifice at the Pass Ghost's cairn, survive a night on the mountain without fire.

Patronage & Power

Among the Taharka, power flows through passes, horse lines, and the favour of the monsoon. The Crown Council rules by consensus, but each valley lord commands his own Ridge-Watchers. The spice merchants of the coast operate independently, paying tariffs to the Crown but answering to no single lord. The *ujamaa* of the dhows is a parallel economy of mutual aid — a captain who cheats it finds his name erased from every mooring post.

For the GM: Power in Taharkan society is measured in altitude and access. Patronage often takes the form of pass-stones, horse-bonds, or coffee measures — each tied to a specific valley, bloodline, or trade route. To emphasize the East African flavour:

- Tie rewards to physical tokens (carved stone, braided hair, clay cups) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided.
- Let rival lords issue conflicting pass-rights, forcing players to choose whose path to follow.
- Use the rock-chapels, horse cemeteries, and monsoon wharves as arenas for social contests, where hospitality is law and a cup of tea is a contract.
- Introduce shetani as recurring obstacles — they are not enemies but creditors of a different kind, demanding stories rather than silver.

In Taharkan society, the mountain remembers every step — and the horse remembers every rider. The shetani remember every miscount.

Chapter 22

Sekogo

The Green Council.

The jungle has an immune system. When a fever rises, we cut it out. When an oath is broken, we collect the price. We are not cruel. We are necessary. The tree remembers every unpaid debt, and we are its teeth.

I am a Honey-Gatherer. The bees know my name. They do not sting me because I sing to them the song of the first blossom. My grandmother taught me that the honey is not a gift; it is a loan. One day, the grove will ask for it back.

Sekogo lies between the Sahel grasslands and the southern plateau—a dry savannah that grows wetter as you travel east, until the baobabs give way to deep jungle and the air turns thick with the smell of damp earth and overripe fruit. Here, the Green Council rules through consensus, honey-orchards are sacred, and the old spirits still walk. Slavery is forbidden; the jungle itself would rise against any slaver who crossed its border. But here's the secret the Council doesn't want you to know: the jungle has a favourite. It is not the Conservators who protect the old pacts. It is not the Wakers who want to rouse the jungle with fever-mists and bloodier rites. It is the Ukwe—the Speaking Tree—that decides whose debts are collected and whose are forgiven. And the Ukwe does not answer to the Council.

The Leopard Society hunts those who break the deepest taboos. The Earth Society keeps the Calendar of Debt, a sacred list written on bark and buried at the Ukwe's roots. The nganga work with minkisi—power objects inhabited by spirits—hammering nails into carved figures to release magic. Each nail is a new debt to the spirit within. Trickster spirits—children of Ananse, the spider-trickster—weave illusions and swap debts for laughter. And in

the oldest groves, the Ninki Nanka—a serpent with a mirror-back—slithers between roots, its reflection showing the lies you have told.

Never cut a marked tree. Each such tree is a living witness. The bark grows over the names of debtors, but the wood remembers. Cut it, and the Ukwe will add your name to its ledger.

— *Hunter Okoro, Leopard Society mask-wearer, who never removes his mask*

The Almanac of Ordinary Days

What do people eat for breakfast? Mashed yams and groundnut stew—the yams are grown in clearings that shift with the seasons, the groundnuts are harvested by monkey-tribes who speak the old tongue. The monkeys are not paid. The monkeys are remembered. Memory is currency.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To name the spirits. Sekogo children are taught the eight spirits of the grove: River, Tree, Stone, Rain, Fire, Wind, Honey, and the ninth—the spirit that has no name. The ninth spirit is the Ukwe's shadow. The shadow watches. The shadow never forgives.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their mask. Every Sekogo wears a mask—carved wood, painted with the symbols of their lineage. A stranger whose mask is cracked has broken a taboo. A stranger whose mask is blank has no lineage. A stranger with no mask is not a person. The Leopard Society hunts the maskless.

What is the most common crime? Debt-forgetting—but debt-forgetting is not a crime, it is a sickness. The Ukwe keeps the Calendar of Debt. A name that is forgotten is a debt that is unpaid. The unpaid debt grows roots. The roots strangle the debtor's house. The house collapses. The jungle reclaims it.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Green Council does not rule. The Ukwe rules. The Council is the Ukwe's voice—eight speakers chosen by the tree's roots. The ninth seat is empty. The ninth speaker was the tree itself. The tree does not speak. The tree waits.

Where do people go when they die? To the Ukwe's roots. The dead are not buried. Their bodies are laid at the base of the Speaking Tree. The roots absorb them. The tree grows a new leaf for each soul. The leaves whisper the names of the dead. The whisper is the wind.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You hammer a nail into a nkisi—a power figure carved by the nganga. The nail represents your wrong. The spirit inside the nkisi accepts your apology. The nail rusts. When the nail is gone, your debt is paid. The nail never rusts.

What is the most important festival? The Honey Harvest (autumn). The bees are sung to sleep. The hives are opened. The honey is collected in copper bowls. The first bowl is offered to the Ukwe. The tree drinks. The tree does not thank.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Ukwe is not a tree. It is a prison—the binding of a spirit that tried to consume the jungle nine centuries ago. The spirit is still alive. The tree is its cage. The roots are its chains. The Green Council is its jailers. The jailers have forgotten what they guard.

22.1 Sekogo — “The Green Council”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *The jungle remembers every debt. The mask is the law. The honey is a promise.*

Leopard Society Hunter (Elite): “The jungle has an immune system. When a fever rises, we cut it out. When an oath is broken, we collect the price. We are not cruel. We are necessary. The tree remembers every unpaid debt, and we are its teeth.”

Honey-Gatherer (Commoner): “The bees know my name. They do not sting me because I sing to them the song of the first blossom. My grandmother taught me that the honey is not a gift; it is a loan. One day, the grove will ask for it back.”

Genre / Mood: Afro-jungle folk horror, spirit diplomacy, mask-law.

Starting Location: A honey-orchard at the jungle’s edge, where the trees hum and the air is thick with bees. A masked figure in a leopard pelt steps from the shadows: “The Ukwe has asked for a name. A caravan master broke his oath to the grove. Find him before the roots do — or become his witness.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Sekogo lies between the Sahel grasslands and the southern plateau — a dry savannah that grows wetter as you travel east, until the baobabs give way to deep jungle and the air turns thick with the smell of damp earth and overripe fruit. Here, the Green Council rules through consensus, honey-orchards are sacred, and the old spirits still walk. Slavery is forbidden; the jungle itself would rise against any slaver who crossed its border. But the Council is divided: Conservators want to protect the old pacts, while Wakers argue that the jungle has grown sluggish and needs to be roused with fever-mists, thorn-spirits, and older, bloodier rites. At the eastern edge lies the Crimson Valley, home to the Lethai-ar — chestnut-brown elves whose silk bridges span red canyons and whose web-law keeps both empires from using the valley as a shortcut to war.

What you notice first: The sound of bees — a constant, low drone that never stops, even at night. The way the trees lean toward you when you speak a secret. The smell of honey and rotting fruit, sweet and sharp at once.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never cut a marked tree. Each such tree is a living witness. The bark grows over the names of debtors, but the wood remembers. Cut it, and the Ukwe will add your name to its ledger.

Regional Mood: The Weight of the Root

Power here is measured in debts witnessed, honey tithes paid, and the balance between jungle and council. The Leopard Society hunts those who break the deepest taboos — oath-breakers, slavers, outsiders who take more than they give. The Earth Society keeps the Calendar of Debt, a sacred list written on bark and buried at the Ukwe’s roots. The nganga work with minkisi — power objects inhabited by spirits — hammering nails into carved figures to release magic, each nail a new debt to the spirit within. Trickster spirits — children of Ananse, the spider-trickster — weave illusions and swap debts for laughter. The water spirit Mami Wata dwells in the deep pools of the Crimson Falls, offering bargains to those who dare to meet her gaze. And in the oldest groves, the Ninki Nanka —

a serpent with a mirror-back — slithers between roots, its reflection showing the lies you have told. At the eastern edge lies the Crimson Valley, home to the Lethai-ar — chestnut-brown elves whose silk bridges span red canyons and whose web-law keeps both empires from using the valley as a shortcut to war.

Starting Location: A honey-orchard at the jungle’s edge, where the trees hum and the air is thick with bees. A masked figure in a leopard pelt steps from the shadows: “The Ukwe has asked for a name. A caravan master broke his oath to the grove. Find him before the roots do — or become his witness.”

Prominent NPCs of Sekogo

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Hunter Okoro	Leopard Society mask-wearer	Hunt down a Waker who poisoned a foreign caravan	He never removes his mask. The mask is his real face now.
Elder Imani	Earth Society Ogboni	Keep the Calendar of Debt from burning	She speaks only while holding a piece of the Ukwe’s bark. She cannot lie.
Nganga Malika	Spirit-doctor of the minkisi	Heal a wound caused by a broken nkisi	She carries a carved figure with nine nails. The ninth nail is loose.
Waker Sefu	Radical who wants to wake the jungle	Poison the wells of a Conserver village	A green shoot grows from his shoulder. It bleeds when he lies.
Lethai-ar Silk-Warden Anara	Guard of the Crimson Valley bridges	Keep the web-law intact against Oshiiran pressure	Her skin-tattoos record a debt her grandmother owed. She will not say to whom.
The Ukwe’s Voice	A spirit that speaks through a cracked root	Remind the Council of a debt that is nine years overdue	It speaks in the voice of a dead child. The child was a witness.

Ananse's Child (Trickster)	A spider-spirit in human form	Unravel oaths for the joy of chaos	It wears nine tiny bells on its ankles; each bell is a broken promise.
Mami Wata	Water spirit of the Crimson Falls	Collect a memory from every soul that crosses her pool	Her hair is black water; her eyes are river stones. She never blinks.

Names of Sekogo

Inspired by the savannah and jungle regions: melodic, with nasal consonants and tonal shifts. Surnames often denote a totem animal, a grove, or a debt paid.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Okoro	Imani	Ngoma	<i>the Masked</i>
Sefu	Malika	Ukwe-born	<i>the Honey-Tongue</i>
Chima	Anara	Leopard-kin	<i>the Debt-Keeper</i>
Kofi	Zola	Root-walker	<i>the Ninth Nail</i>
Tunde	Amara	Grove-singer	<i>the Unmarked</i>
Biko	Nkiru	Minkisi-hand	<i>the Still Witness</i>
Adofo	Adaeze	Ananse-fo	<i>the Trickster's Child</i>

(Orchard/Circle/Bridge) Honey-orchard where the trees hum; druid circle with moss-covered stones and a leopard skull at center; Lethai-ar silk bridge spanning a crimson gorge with the Ukwe's roots clutching the water below.

Spades — Places

2. **Honey-Orchard** — The trees hum. The air is thick with bees. *The honey is dark red. It tastes of iron and forgotten promises.* '[SPIRIT]'
3. **Druid Circle (Leopard Skull)** — A ring of moss-covered stones. A skull sits at the center. *The skull is warm. When the Leopard Society hunts, the eye sockets glow.* '[RITUAL]'
4. **Lethai-ar Silk Bridge** — A span of woven silk across a crimson gorge. *The silk is made from spider-sap and oath-hair. It will not break unless a debt is called.* '[OATH]'
5. **The Ukwe (Speaking Tree)** — A baobab so old its bark is carved with a thousand names. *The tree speaks in the voices of the dead. It never gives answers — only new debts.* '[DEBT]'
6. **Nkisi Grove** — A clearing where broken power-objects are buried. *The ground hums. The nails that sealed the minkisi have grown into iron thorns.* '[MAGIC]'
7. **Calendar of Debt (Earth Society Vault)** — A hollow log sealed with wax and bone. *Inside are strips of bark. Each strip is an unpaid obligation. The bark is still growing.* '[DEBT]'

8. **Waker’s Fever-Mist Pool** — A stagnant pond that steams even in winter. *The mist smells of rotting flowers. Breathe it, and you will see the jungle as the Wakers see it.* ‘[WEATHER]’
9. **Leopard Society Lodge** — A longhouse hidden in a thicket of thorn-vines. *The walls are made of human jawbones. The jaws are from oath-breakers. They still click when a new name is spoken.* ‘[SECRET]’
10. **Crimson Valley Gorge** — A canyon of red stone, crossed by silk bridges at three points. *The stone is warm. It bleeds rust when the web-law is broken.* ‘[THRESHOLD]’
- J **Conservator Archive** — A cave filled with sealed clay pots. Each pot contains a memory. *The memories are for sale. The price is a memory of equal weight.* ‘[MEMORY]’
- Q **The Grove of Sleeping Spirits** — A forest where the minkisi go to die. *The spirits do not wake. They dream of the first nail. The dream is contagious.* ‘[DEATH]’
- K **The Ukwe’s Root-Chamber** — A cavern beneath the tree where the roots form a throne. *The throne is made of braided roots. Sit on it, and the tree will ask one question. Answer poorly, and you never leave.* ‘[JUDGMENT]’
- A **The Crimson Falls** — A waterfall that runs red after the first rain of spring. *The water is not blood. It is rust from the canyon walls. The Lethai-ar say it is the earth’s memory of a war.* ‘[SPIRIT]’
- A+ **The Pool of Mami Wata** — A still, black pool behind the Crimson Falls, reachable only by diving underwater. *The water is warm. It shows not your reflection, but the face of the person who will collect your greatest debt.* ‘[WATER]’

(Gatherer/Druid/Warden) Honey-gatherer with a fruit offering and a leopard claw necklace; Green Council druid with a thorn-staff and milky eyes that see debts; Lethai-ar silk-warden, masked and quiet, his mask painted with the Ukwe’s roots.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Honey-Gatherer** — She wears a leopard claw around her neck. The claw is from a cat she killed with her bare hands. *She offers a fruit to the trees before each harvest. The fruit is always a little rotten.* ‘[COMMUNITY]’
3. **Green Council Druid (Conservator)** — Milk-white eyes, a staff of living wood. *She cannot see the living. She sees only debts — glowing threads that connect every person to the Ukwe.* ‘[JUSTICE]’
4. **Waker Radical** — Carries a bag of fever-mist spores. His eyes are yellow. *He plants thorns in the paths of Conservator caravans. The thorns grow into walls overnight.* ‘[DANGER]’
5. **Lethai-ar Silk-Warden** — Mask carved from the Ukwe’s root, painted with debt-names. *He never speaks above a whisper. The bridge hears him anyway.* ‘[OATH]’
6. **Leopard Society Hunter** — Wears a pelt that shifts and moves as if alive. *He can transform into a leopard at night. Or so he claims. No one has survived a hunt to confirm it.* ‘[FEAR]’
7. **Earth Society Elder** — Holds a piece of the Ukwe’s bark. The bark is warm. *She asks every visitor: “What do you owe?” The answer is carved into her memory.* ‘[TRUTH]’
8. **Nganga (Spirit-Doctor)** — Carries a nkisi carved with nine nails. The ninth nail is loose. *She hammers a nail into the figure to cast a spell. Each nail is a debt. She has nine debts left.* ‘[MAGIC]’

9. **Debt-Walker (Hollow Manifestation)** — A figure made of bark and silence. It appears when the Calendar of Debt fills. *It does not speak. It points at the debtor. The debtor's name appears on the nearest tree.* '[DEATH]'
10. **Lethai-ar Mark-Cutter** — A tattooist who records promises on skin. *She uses a needle of silk-fiber and ink made from crushed crimson stone. The ink glows when a promise is broken.* '[MEMORY]'
- J **The Ukwe's Voice (Spirit)** — A crack in the tree's bark that speaks. *The voice changes. Sometimes it is a child. Sometimes it is a jarl. Sometimes it is the listener's own.* '[SPIRIT]'
- Q **The First Nail (Legend)** — A mythic nganga who sealed a spirit into the Ukwe itself. *She is said to still walk the jungle, carrying a hammer made of root and bone.* '[LEGEND]'
- K **The Leopard King** — A spirit that leads the Society's midnight hunts. *It has no mask. Its face is a leopard's. Its eyes are human.* '[FEAR]'
- A **The Crimson Valley's First Weaver** — A ghost who teaches the web-law to new wardens. *She appears at dawn on the central bridge. She asks one question: "Who watches the watchers?"* '[JUSTICE]'
- A+ **Ananse's Child (Trickster)** — A small figure with too-long fingers, wearing nine tiny bells. *It offers to "renegotiate" any debt — but its renegotiation always adds a new, hidden clause. The clause is a joke. The joke is always on you.* '[TRICKERY]'

(Spirit/Offer/Name) A thorn-spirit blocks the path — must offer honey or fight; the Ukwe demands a name before letting you pass; a Lethai-ar silk-walker challenges you to recite the web-law.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Thorn-Spirit Block** — A wall of living thorns grows across the path. *The spirit demands a name. Give a false one, and the thorns grow inward.* '[SPIRIT]'
3. **Ukwe Demands a Name** — The tree speaks: "I have forgotten a debtor. Remind me." *If you cannot name a debtor, the tree will take your name instead.* '[DEBT]'
4. **Lethai-ar Web-Law Challenge** — A silk-warden blocks the bridge: "Recite the ninth clause." *The ninth clause is unwritten. It changes with each warden. You must guess.* '[OATH]'
5. **Leopard Society Hunt** — A masked hunter appears at dusk. "You are called to witness." *Refusal earns a Leopard's Mark. The jungle becomes hostile to you.* '[FEAR]'
6. **Nkisi Hunger** — A spirit-object you carry begins whispering. It wants a memory. *Refuse, and the nkisi shatters. The spirit inside is not friendly.* '[MAGIC]'
7. **Waker Poisoning** — A well is found with a green film on the water. *The poison is not lethal. It makes you dream of the jungle's hunger.* '[WEATHER]'
8. **Earth Society Audit** — An elder demands to see your debt-record. *The record is written in scars on your skin. You have no scars. That is suspicious.* '[TRUTH]'
9. **Honey-Tithe Demanded** — A grove spirit appears: "Pay the ninth jar." *You have no honey. The spirit offers a loan. The interest is a story.* '[DEBT]'
10. **Crimson Valley Border Dispute** — Oshiiran surveyors cross the web-line. The Lethai-ar arm their bows. *The party is caught between. Whoever you side with, the other will remember.* '[POLITICS]'
- J **The Ukwe's Root Breaches** — A root bursts through a village floor. It is looking for a

specific name. *The name is carved on the root. The root is weeping. The debtor is still alive.* ‘[DEATH]’

Q **Leopard Society Coup** — The Wakers have infiltrated the Lodge. The masks are fighting. *You cannot tell who is who. Both sides wear leopard pelts. Both sides smell of blood.* ‘[CONFLICT]’

K **Calendar Fire** — A spark catches the Earth Society vault. The debts are burning. *The smoke forms faces. The faces are the debtors. They are screaming.* ‘[DISASTER]’

A **The Crimson Falls Run Red** — The waterfall turns to blood. The Lethai-ar say the web-law has been broken. *The break was centuries ago. The falls are just catching up.* ‘[OMEN]’

A+ **Mami Wata’s Gaze** — A figure rises from the black pool behind the falls. It asks: “What is the one debt you have never paid?” *If you lie, the water will take your voice. If you tell the truth, it will ask for a memory as interest.* ‘[SPIRIT]’ ‘[DEBT]’

(**Favor/Debt/Shard**) Leopard’s Favor (once, call on the Leopard Society for a hunt — you owe them a future hunt); Ukwe Debt (reroll a failed Survival test once per session, but GM gains 1 SB for a jungle complication); Nkisi Shard (add +1 Effect to a magical working, but the shard shatters and costs 1 Corruption).

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Leopard’s Favor** — A leopard claw wrapped in red thread. One use to summon a Society hunt. *The favor is a debt. The Society will collect. The interest is a future hunt.* ‘[DEBT]’
 3. **Ukwe Debt (Leaf)** — A single leaf from the Speaking Tree. Reroll a failed Survival test once per session. *The leaf is green. It will not wilt. The tree remembers who took it.* ‘[MEMORY]’
 4. **Nkisi Shard** — A piece of a broken power-object. Add +1 Effect to a magical working, then it shatters. *The shard is warm. It whispers secrets in a language you almost understand.* ‘[MAGIC]’
 5. **Honey-Jar (Royal Tithe)** — A clay pot of dark red honey. Trade it for safe passage through any grove. *The honey is thick. It moves in the jar as if alive. Do not open it.* ‘[TRADE]’
 6. **Earth Society Tablet** — A strip of bark with a debt recorded. Transfer it to clear your own debt. *The bark is still growing. The debt is still accruing interest.* ‘[DEBT]’
 7. **Lethai-ar Silk Cord** — A braided cord that records a witnessed promise. Use it to enforce any oath. *The cord tightens when the oath is broken. It will not stop until blood is drawn.* ‘[OATH]’
 8. **Leopard Mask (Temporary)** — Wear it to pass as a Society hunter for one scene. *The mask has eye holes that see debts. It also sees your own.* ‘[SECRET]’
 9. **Waker’s Spore Pouch** — A bag of fever-mist spores. Release them to confuse pursuers. *The spores cause vivid hallucinations. The hallucinations are always of the Ukwe.* ‘[STEALTH]’
 10. **Nganga’s Hammer** — A small iron hammer. Drive a nail into any object to seal a spirit inside. *The hammer has a price. Each nail costs a memory.* ‘[MAGIC]’
- J **The Ukwe’s Answer** — A single truth from the Speaking Tree, whispered on the wind. *The truth is always about a debt. The debt may not be yours.* ‘[TRUTH]’
- Q **Silk-Warden’s Mask** — A carved mask that grants safe passage across any Lethai-ar bridge.

The mask is also a witness. It will remember every promise you make while wearing it. ‘[OATH]’

K **Debt-Walker’s Finger** — A dried root shaped like a digit. Use it to call a Debt-Walker once. *The Debt-Walker will collect one debt for you. Then it will ask for yours.* ‘[DEATH]’

A **The First Nail** — A legendary iron nail that sealed the first spirit into the Ukwe. *Drive it into any tree to create a new Speaking Tree. The tree will remember everything.* ‘[LEGEND]’

A+ **Mami Wata’s Tear** — A drop of water that never dries, said to be the spirit’s grief for a promise broken long ago. *Drink it to forget one debt permanently — but you will dream of drowning once each season.* ‘[WATER]’ ‘[MEMORY]’

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (favors, debts, shards) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **grove-omens**—bees that fly backward, roots that bleed sap, a mask that watches from the trees. If an A+ appears (special high-rank result), a spirit of the deep jungle (Mami Wata, Ananse’s Child, the Leopard King) manifests directly.

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **The Three Societies:** Sekogo is governed by three overlapping authorities: the Leopard Society (hunters who enforce taboos), the Earth Society (elders who keep the Calendar of Debt), and the nganga (spirit-doctors who work with *minkisi*). A single elder often belongs to two societies, and the tension between their roles is where drama lives.
- **The Ukwe (Speaking Tree):** A living ledger whose roots extend across Sekogo. Every broken promise, unpaid tithe, and unburied body stains its leaves. It answers questions — but never with kindness, and never for free. Accepting its gift incurs a debt that the tree may call at any moment.
- **The Crimson Valley and Web-Law:** The Lethai-ar guard the valley with fierce neutrality. Their skin-tattoos (Marks) record promises witnessed. When a Lethai-ar dies, their Marks are cut from the skin and buried at the Ukwe’s roots. The web-law is unwritten; each warden carries a different clause in memory.
- **Mask Law:** In Sekogo, a mask is not a disguise — it is a role. Wearing the mask of a Leopard Society hunter, a Waker, or a spirit entitles you to speak for that office, but also binds you to its taboos. Breaking a mask’s taboo (e.g., a Leopard mask showing mercy to a slayer) causes the mask to crack and the wearer to lose 1 die on all social rolls until they atone.
- **Ananse’s Bargain (Trickster Mechanic):** Once per session, a character may call upon Ananse’s Child to “renegotiate” any debt, oath, or contract. Roll Spirit + Lore (DV 4). On a success, the terms shift in your favour — but the GM gains 1 SB and may add a hidden clause that will trigger at the worst possible moment. On a miss, the debt doubles.
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
 - **The Root Father** — Grimmir. *The ancient pact between the jungle and the first honey-gatherer.*

- **The Masked One** — Mykkiel. *The law that wears a leopard’s face; the judge who hunts.*
- **The Spider’s Whisper** — Inaea. *The trickster who spins webs in the spaces between oaths.*
- **The Water Mother** — Raéyn. *Mami Wata, who holds the debts of the drowned.*

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Ukwe’s Debt and the Hollow (Eastern Realms):** The Hollow is said to be the shadow of the Ukwe — the space where debts go when the tree forgets them. Aelaerem hedge-keepers leave offerings at the Ukwe’s roots to keep the Hollow from wandering.
- **Lethai-ar Silk and the Way of Silk:** The silk bridges of the Crimson Valley are made from spider-sap and oath-hair. Tulkani traders prize the silk for vow-cords; Fhara water-clerks use it to seal well-contracts. A bolt of Crimson silk can buy safe passage across half the continent.
- **Leopard Society and Ashaani Slavers:** The Leopard Society has a standing grudge against Ashaani slavers. A masked hunter may offer the party a deal: help free a group of captives from a Black Hand caravan, and the Society will forget an old debt.
- **Nganga and the Kalrantha Amulet (Dhahara):** The nganga of Sekogo believe the Kalrantha amulet is a rogue nkisi — a spirit-object that was never properly sealed. They want to drive a nail into it to bind the demon. The Veiled Sisters want the amulet for themselves.
- **Ananse’s Child and the Grey Wanderer’s Grimoire:** The trickster spirit is known to trade fragments of forgotten prophecies for stories. Some psions claim that Ananse’s Child taught the first Echo-Readers the art of reading debts in the wind.

Sekogo Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Root:** Crumble a crust at the Ukwe’s base. Ignore the first *Ukwe Demands a Name* penalty. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Knot the Silk:** Tie a single knot in a Lethai-ar bridge cord. Cancel *Web-Law Challenge* or take –1 die on your next negotiation (your choice). ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Name to the Nail:** Whisper a dead nganga’s name into a nkisi. Gain +1 Effect when using a spirit-object this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Ukwe. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Spit to the Mask:** Before donning a ceremonial mask, spit on the inside. If the mask accepts, you gain +1 die to all rolls while wearing it. If it rejects, the mask will not come off for 1d4 hours. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **Leopard Society hunters** or **Earth Society elders**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **bees** or **Lethai-ar wardens**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **Debt-Walkers** or **Waker spies**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time** or **safe passage through a grove**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised: Local Leopard Society or Green Council druid** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **thorn-spirit** or **fog from the Crimson Falls**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **Waker cell** or **Debt-Walker** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **Leopard Society**, **Earth Society** guardians, or **Lethai-ar** archers arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes—**Ukwe speaks/Waker poison spreads/web-law broken**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **Leopard King**, **Ukwe's Voice**, or **Crimson Valley First Weaver** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically—**nkisi shatter/honey turns to blood/Ukwe's root breaches the ground**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice—**omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Sekogo (Jungle Law):** Bees form words, tree bark weeps sap, the Ukwe's root trembles.
- **Sekogo (Crimson Valley):** Silk cords tighten, canyon walls bleed rust, the web-law recites itself.
- **Sekogo (Society Conflict):** Masks shift expressions, bark strips burn without flame, a ninth nail appears in every nkisi.

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Wits + Survival):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Thorn Wall*.
- **Cut the Web (Presence + Sway):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a silk cord is in your possession, +1 die.
- **Weather the Hunt (Resolve + Spirit):** On a hit in *Leopard Society Hunt*, you pick who is targeted; on a miss, the GM does.

Boss Seeds (Root & Mask)

- **The Root-King (Nine Debts)** — *Phases*: Debt Calls → Orchestrated Famine → Grove Coup. *Cracks*: burn a bark strip, expose a false debt, survive a harvest without honey.
- **The Mask that Walks (Leopard’s Shadow)** — *Phases*: Midnight Hunts → Procession of Masks → Skin-Baptism of a Warden. *Cracks*: relic leopard claw, survivor testimony, the mask turning against them.
- **Mami Wata’s Wrath (Water Spirit)** — *Phases*: Pool Rises → Crimson Falls Reversed → Debt of the Drowned. *Cracks*: offer a true memory of loss, speak the name of a slaver ship she sank, return a stolen mirror to her pool.

Patronage & Power

Among Sekogo, power flows through debts, honey, and the consent of the jungle. The Green Council rules by consensus, but the Leopard Society enforces taboos, the Earth Society keeps the Calendar, and the nganga negotiate with spirits. No single faction holds all the power — and that is by design.

For the GM: Power in Sekogo society is measured in unpaid obligations and witnessed promises. Patronage often takes the form of favors, debts, or shards — each carrying a future price. To emphasize this:

- Tie rewards to objects that create obligations (leopard claws, Ukwe leaves, nkisi shards) that can be called in at inconvenient moments.
- Let rival societies offer conflicting judgments, forcing players to choose whose law to follow.
- Use the honey-orchards, druid circles, and silk bridges as arenas for social contests, where a gift of honey is a treaty and a broken promise is a death sentence.
- Introduce trickster spirits (Ananse’s Child) to complicate simple debt resolutions — they are excellent wild cards.
- Remember that Mami Wata is not evil; she is ancient. She collects memories, not lives. A bargain with her may be the only way to escape a blood-debt.

In Sekogo society, the jungle remembers everything — and the Ukwe forgets nothing.

Chapter 23

Lethai-ar of the Crimson Valley

Silk Bridges and Web-Law.

The web-law is not written on parchment. It is woven into every bridge, every strand, every knot. When a promise is made, the valley remembers. When a promise is broken, the silk tightens. We are not judges. We are the loom.

I am a Mark-Cutter. Each line on my skin is a promise I witnessed. Each line is a debt I carry. When I die, they will cut these marks from my body and bury them at the Ukwe's roots. Then the tree will remember what I owed. I hope it is enough.

The Crimson Valley is a deep jungle rift between Sekogo and Oshiira—a wound of red stone, carved by a river that runs rust-coloured after every rain. Here, the Lethai-ar guard their borders with fierce neutrality, their chestnut-brown skin blending with the canyon walls. Silk bridges span the gorges, woven from spider-sap and oath-hair, strong enough to hold a caravan and light enough to sway in the monsoon wind. But here's the secret the wardens don't want you to know: the web-law is not unwritten because it is ancient. It is unwritten because it changes. Every warden carries a different clause in memory. Together, they form a complete web—but the web is never complete for long. The valley is learning. And it is not learning to be kind.

The Lethai-ar are adopted children of the old powers—not fallen, but chosen to carry memory. Each can name the specific mountain, river, or grove where their ancestor left the spirit world to become mortal. Their skin-tattoos are not decoration; they are a public ledger, written on skin, read by anyone who knows the phase of the crimson moon. A Lethai-ar who bears a Mark they cannot fulfil loses standing. A warden who cuts a bridge without cause is exiled.

Never step onto a silk bridge without first naming a witness. The bridge will remember your footsteps. If you fall, it will ask why no one was watching.

— *Silk-Warden Anara, whose left arm is covered in Marks from wrist to shoulder*

The Almanac of Ordinary Days

What do people eat for breakfast? Rice porridge and fermented tea—the rice is grown on terraces cut into the canyon walls, the tea is aged in clay pots buried beneath the bridges. The tea is bitter. The bitterness is for memory.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To read a Mark. Lethai-ar children are taught the eight Mark-shapes: Promise, Debt, Witness, Apology, Interest, Cut, Forgive, and the ninth—the empty space where a Mark was erased. The erased Mark is a broken promise. The broken promise is a cut. The cut is a scar.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their Marks. A stranger whose Marks are fresh has made new promises. A stranger whose Marks are faded has unpaid debts. A stranger whose Marks are cut has been exiled. The exiled are not spoken to. The exiled are not remembered.

What is the most common crime? Bridge-cutting—but bridge-cutting is not a crime, it is a war. The bridge is a promise between two shores. Cutting it is breaking that promise. The valley responds. The valley tightens its web. The web is the law. The law is the valley.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The valley is not a place. It is a creature—a sleeping serpent whose spine is the canyon walls, whose scales are the silk bridges, whose heart is the rust-coloured river. The Lethai-ar are its parasites. They live on its back. They weave its silk. They do not know it is asleep.

Where do people go when they die? To the river. The dead are not buried. Their bodies are wrapped in silk and cast into the rust-coloured water. The river carries them downstream, into the Ukwe's territory. The Ukwe drinks. The Ukwe remembers. The Ukwe does not forget.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You offer a Mark—a promise cut from your own skin. The Mark is pressed into the wronged party's ledger. If they accept, the debt is transferred. If they refuse, the Mark is buried. Buried Marks are debts that never die.

What is the most important festival? The Weaving of the New Bridge (spring). The silk is harvested from the canyon's spiders. The thread is spun by the wardens. The bridge is woven in a single night. The bridge is named after the year. The year is named after a promise. The promise is always the same: the valley will hold.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The river's rust colour is not iron. It is blood—the blood of the serpent that sleeps beneath the canyon. The serpent is wounded. The wound has been bleeding for nine centuries. The Lethai-ar know. The Lethai-ar do nothing. The serpent's dream is the valley's law. If the serpent wakes, the law ends.

23.1 Lethai-ar — “The Crimson Valley”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *The bridge remembers every step. The silk knows every promise.*

Silk-Warden (Elite): “The web-law is not written on parchment. It is woven into every bridge, every strand, every knot. When a promise is made, the valley remembers. When a promise is broken, the silk tightens. We are not judges. We are the loom.”

Mark-Cutter (Commoner): “Each line on my skin is a promise I witnessed. Each line is a story I carry. When I die, they will cut these marks from my body and bury them at the Ukwe’s roots. Then the tree will remember what I witnessed. I hope it is enough.”

Genre / Mood: High-fantasy legal drama, spider-silk noir, ancestral witness.

Starting Location: The central silk bridge, where the gorge is deepest and the wind carries the smell of rust. A Silk-Warden blocks your path, her mask painted with roots: “The web-law demands a toll. Not in coin — in a promise. Swear that you will not use this valley to carry steel to Ashaan, or turn back now.”

Theme & Atmosphere

The Crimson Valley is a deep jungle rift between Sekogo and Oshiira — a wound of red stone, carved by a river that runs rust-colored after every rain. Here, the Lethai-ar guard their borders with fierce neutrality, their chestnut-brown skin blending with the canyon walls. Silk bridges span the gorges, woven from spider-sap and oath-hair, strong enough to hold a caravan and light enough to sway in the monsoon wind. The web-law is unwritten, carried in the memory of each warden; it keeps both empires from using the valley as a shortcut to war. Unlike their northern kin who fell from grace, the Lethai-ar are adopted children of the old powers — not fallen, but chosen to carry memory. Each can name the specific mountain, river, or grove where their ancestor left the spirit world to become mortal. Their skin-tattoos (Marks) are woven with red ochre and jungle sap, each line a promise witnessed, each curve a story recorded. When a Lethai-ar dies, their Marks are cut from the skin and buried at the Ukwe’s roots, so the tree may remember what they witnessed.

What you notice first: The whisper of silk ropes in the wind. The smell of red ochre and damp stone. The way every Lethai-ar touches their left wrist when they speak a name — a gesture of witness.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never step onto a silk bridge without first naming a witness. The bridge will remember your footsteps. If you fall, it will ask why no one was watching.

Regional Mood: The Weight of Witness

Power here is measured in witnessed promises, silk strands, and the balance of the web-law. The valley is neutral ground — Oshiiran grain barges do not float here, and Ashaani armies dare not march. The Lethai-ar trade silk for honey with Sekogo druids and stone-song for poison with Ngomebe masons. Their Marks are not decoration; they are a public ledger, written on skin, read

by anyone who knows the phase of the crimson moon. A Lethai-ar who bears a Mark they cannot fulfil loses standing; a warden who cuts a bridge without cause is exiled.

Prominent NPCs of the Crimson Valley

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Warden Anara	Silk-warden of the central span	Keep the Oshiiran grain barges from crossing	Her left arm is covered in Marks from wrist to shoulder. She will not say what they mean.
Mark-Cutter Tebe	Tattooist who records promises	Witness a treaty between Sekogo and Ngomebe	She uses a needle of silk-fiber and ink made from crushed crimson stone. The ink glows under the full moon.
Bridge-Keeper Solan	Guardian of the eastern crossing	Prevent Ashaani scouts from using the valley	He has not slept in nine days. He says the bridge whispers when someone lies.
Elder Mira	Memory-keeper of the valley's spirits	Record the name of every ancestor who walked the spirit path	She carries a bundle of silk cords, each tied to a different knot. The knots are the names.
The Spider	Tulkani trader of oath-silk	Buy a bolt of crimson silk for a vow-cord	She is not Lethai-ar but has lived in the valley for thirty years. The wardens tolerate her.

The Unmarked	A Lethai-ar who refused any Marks	An outcast who lives in the gorge below the bridges	Her skin is blank. She is invisible to the web-law — and to the valley’s spirits.
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Names of the Crimson Valley

Lethai-ar names are soft, with rolling consonants and vowel endings. Surnames often denote a bridge, a gorge, or a spirit-ancestor. Epithets refer to Marks or witnessed deeds.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Solan	Anara	Silkweave	<i>the Unbroken</i>
Tebe	Mira	Gorge-born	<i>the Ninth Witness</i>
Kael	Nira	Root-memory	<i>the Marked</i>
Veth	Liana	Spider-kin	<i>the Bridge-Heart</i>
Renn	Sora	Crimson-touch	<i>the Unweaver</i>
Thorn	Elara	Oath-strand	<i>the Still Watcher</i>

(Bridge/Gorge/Roots) Silk bridge spanning a crimson gorge — ropes sing in the wind; a Lethai-ar village built into the canyon wall; the Ukwe’s roots clutching the water below the central span.

Spades — Places

2. **Central Silk Bridge** — A wide span woven from crimson and grey strands. *The bridge hums when a promise is made on it. The pitch tells the warden if the promise is true.* ‘[WITNESS]’
3. **Mark-Cutter’s Studio** — A cave with a stone table and pots of ochre. *The walls are carved with Marks that were never cut into skin. They are stories the cutter refused to witness.* ‘[CRAFT]’
4. **Ukwe’s Riverside Root** — A massive root that dips into the crimson river. *The root is warm. Touch it, and the tree will show you one forgotten promise from a dead Lethai-ar.* ‘[MEMORY]’
5. **Abandoned Silk Span** — A broken bridge hanging over the gorge. *The cut ends are frayed. The cut was not clean — someone broke an oath mid-crossing.* ‘[DEATH]’
6. **Spirit-Anchor Stone** — A boulder where the first ancestor left the spirit world. *The stone is smooth. It is warm even in winter. Lethai-ar leave offerings of red ochre here.* ‘[RITUAL]’
7. **Warden’s Watchtower** — A stone needle built into the canyon wall, with a signal mirror. *The mirror flashes in code. The code is the web-law. No outsider has broken it.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
8. **Hollow of the Unmarked** — A cave below the eastern bridge, hidden by a waterfall. *The cave has no silk. The Unmarked lives here, weaving nets from her own hair.* ‘[MYSTERY]’
9. **Crimson River Ford** — A shallow crossing where the water is clear, not red. *The ford is sacred. No oath sworn here can be broken. The water would turn black.* ‘[OATH]’

10. **Elder's Cord-House** — A longhouse where the memory-knots are stored. *Each cord is a name. The cords are hung from the ceiling. They move in no wind.* '[MEMORY]'
- J **The Spider's Stall** — A Tulkani merchant's tent at the valley's southern exit. *She sells silk to anyone. The price is a story. The story must be witnessed.* '[TRADE]'
- Q **Bridge of the Ninth Strand** — A legend: a bridge woven from a single hair. *It appears only at dawn on the first day of spring. Those who cross it gain a new name.* '[LEGEND]'
- K **The Cut Stone** — A boulder split by an oath-breaker's fall. *The split is shaped like a human body. The stone weeps water when the oath-breaker's name is spoken.* '[DEATH]'
- A **The First Bridge (Myth)** — Where the first Lethai-ar wove the first strand. *It is invisible. Only those who have witnessed nine true promises can see it.* '[MYTH]'

(Warden/Cutter/Trader) Silk-warden with a mask painted with the Ukwe's roots; Mark-cutter with a needle of silk-fiber; Tulkani spider-trader with a bundle of oath-cords.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Silk-Warden** — Mask carved from crimson wood, painted with debt-names. *She never blinks when standing on the bridge. The bridge does not forgive distraction.* '[AUTHORITY]'
3. **Mark-Cutter** — Hands stained red with ochre, eyes that measure skin. *She asks each client: "What promise do you want the world to remember?" The answer becomes a Mark.* '[CRAFT]'
4. **Bridge-Keeper** — Old, grey-haired, missing three fingers from a snapped strand. *He carries a whistle made from a spider's fang. The whistle calls the bridge to tighten.* '[WITNESS]'
5. **Elder (Memory-Keeper)** — Bundles of silk cords hang from her belt. *She knows every name carved into every root of the Ukwe. She has forgotten her own.* '[MEMORY]'
6. **Tulkani Spider (Trader)** — Wears a shawl of crimson silk, speaks in riddles. *She pays for silk with stories. The stories become new strands. The bridge grows.* '[TRADE]'
7. **The Unmarked** — A Lethai-ar without Marks, living in the hollow. *She whispers to the waterfall. The waterfall whispers back. No one knows what they say.* '[MYSTERY]'
8. **Youth Seeking a Mark** — A young Lethai-ar on their first witness journey. *They carry a single strand of undyed silk. When they witness a promise, they will dye it crimson.* '[COMMUNITY]'
9. **Oath-Breaker's Ghost** — A translucent figure pacing the broken bridge. *It repeats the words of the promise it broke. The words are getting quieter.* '[DEATH]'
10. **Sekogo Honey Trader** — A druid with a jar of dark honey, trading for silk poison. *He offers the honey as a gift. The wardens test it by feeding a drop to the bridge. The bridge sways if it is poisoned.* '[TRADE]'
- J **Ngomebe Stone-Singer** — A mason with a tuning fork, here to buy silk for sledge-wax seals. *He taps the bridge with his fork. The note tells him how many promises it has witnessed.* '[CRAFT]'
- Q **The First Ancestor's Echo** — A voice heard at the Spirit-Anchor Stone at midnight. *It asks: "Why did you leave the spirit world?" The answer must be a promise.* '[RITUAL]'
- K **The Spider's Daughter** — A half-Lethai-ar child raised by the Tulkani trader. *She has no Marks. Her skin is blank. She is learning to read knots.* '[COMMUNITY]'
- A **The Ninth Warden (Legend)** — A warden who cut her own bridge to stop an invasion. *She is said to walk the valley at dusk, carrying a coil of silk. She offers one free crossing.*

‘[LEGEND]’

(Strand/Challenge/Fall) A silk strand snaps — lose 1 Supply to repair; a Lethai-ar challenges you to recite the web-law; a traveller falls from a bridge — the party must witness their last words.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Snapped Strand** — A rope on a bridge breaks. Lose 1 Supply to repair. ‘[DISASTER]’ *The break is clean. Someone cut it with a blade. The blade was from Ashaan.*
 3. **Web-Law Challenge** — A warden blocks the bridge: “Recite the ninth clause.” ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[RIDDLE]’ *The ninth clause is unwritten. Each warden carries a different version. You must guess.*
 4. **Fall from the Bridge** — A traveller slips. The bridge asks: “Who witnessed this?” ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[WITNESS]’ *If no one answers, the traveller’s name is erased from the Ukwe’s roots.*
 5. **Oshiiram Surveyors** — Grain auditors arrive with a map, claiming the valley’s water rights. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[POLITICS]’ *They carry a treaty stamped with the Widow’s seal. The seal is a forgery.*
 6. **Ashaani Scouts (Disguised)** — Veiled Sister agents posing as spice merchants. ‘[STEALTH]’ ‘[POLITICS]’ *They do not touch their left wrist when speaking a name. The wardens notice.*
 7. **Mark-Cutter’s Witness Called** — A Lethai-ar’s Marks begin to glow red. A promise is overdue. ‘[WITNESS]’ ‘[COMMUNITY]’ *The witness is not present. The party is the closest witness. The duty transfers.*
 8. **Bridge Poisoning** — Someone smears a solvent on the silk strands. The bridge begins to fray. ‘[MAGIC]’ ‘[DISASTER]’ *The solvent is made from Sekogo honey and Ashaani dust. The Spider knows who sold it.*
 9. **Elder’s Memory Fails** — The cord-keeper forgets a name. The knot unravels. ‘[MEMORY]’ ‘[DEATH]’ *The forgotten name is an old promise. The Ukwe’s root trembles. Something is coming.*
 10. **The Unmarked’s Bargain** — The outcast offers to guide the party through the gorge. Her price is a promise. ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[WITNESS]’ *The promise: “Do not speak my name after I die.” Refuse, and she leaves you to the spiders.*
- J Crimson River Floods** — Rain turns the ford to a torrent. The bridge is the only crossing. ‘[WEATHER]’ ‘[DEATH]’ *The water is red. Faces appear in the foam. They are oath-breakers, still trying to cross.*
- Q Warden Schism** — Two wardens disagree on the web-law. They cut each other’s bridges. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[POLITICS]’ *The valley is now divided. The party must choose which side to cross — or stay stuck forever.*
- K The First Bridge Appears** — The mythical bridge manifests at dawn. Crossing it gives a new name. ‘[MYTH]’ ‘[MAGIC]’ *The new name is a promise. The promise is to the First Ancestor. The ancestor will collect.*
- A The Ninth Warden Returns** — The legend appears, offering a free crossing. The crossing leads to the Hollow. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[LEGEND]’ *The Hollow asks: “What promise did you break?” Answer poorly, and you become a new strand.*

(**Cord/Mask/Shard**) Silk witness cord (enforce any oath); warden’s mask (safe passage on any bridge for one crossing); Ukwe root shard (one question about a forgotten promise).

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Silk Witness Cord** — A braided strand dyed crimson. Use it to enforce any oath. ‘[OATH]’ *The cord tightens when the oath is broken. It will not stop until the promise is kept or a witness recants.*
3. **Warden’s Mask** — A wooden mask painted with roots. Safe passage on any bridge for one crossing. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The mask has no eye holes. You must trust the bridge to see for you.*
4. **Ukwe Root Shard** — A piece of the tree’s root that grows near the river. ‘[MEMORY]’ *Touch it, and the Ukwe will answer one question about a forgotten promise. The answer is always true.*
5. **Mark-Cutter’s Needle** — A silk-fiber needle. Use it to record a witnessed promise as a temporary Mark. ‘[CRAFT]’ *The Mark fades after one season. The story remains.*
6. **Bridge-Keeper’s Whistle** — A fang whistle. Blow it to tighten any silk bridge for one scene. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The whistle works once. The bridge will remember the favour.*
7. **Elder’s Memory Cord** — A knotted silk cord that contains a forgotten name. ‘[MEMORY]’ *Untie the knot to learn the name. The name is a promise. Fulfil it, or the cord will retie itself.*
8. **Spider’s Story-Strand** — A bolt of crimson silk bought with a story. ‘[TRADE]’ *The silk is soft. It glows under moonlight. Trade it for safe passage through Tulkani camps.*
9. **The Unmarked’s Net** — A net woven from human hair. Throw it to catch a spirit. ‘[MAGIC]’ *The net can hold a bound spirit for one hour. The spirit will bargain for freedom.*
10. **Crimson Ochre Pot** — A clay pot of red pigment. Use it to Mark a promise on stone or skin. ‘[CRAFT]’ *The ochre never dries. The promise remains witnessable forever.*
- J **Ninth Strand Fragment** — A piece of the legendary bridge. Once per campaign, cross any gap as if on solid ground. ‘[LEGEND]’ *The fragment crumbles after use. The first bridge will remember you.*
- Q **The Cut Stone’s Water** — A vial of water that seeps from the oath-breaker’s boulder. ‘[DEATH]’ *Drink it to remember a promise you broke. The memory is painful. The pain is the price.*
- K **First Ancestor’s Blessing** — A whispered promise from the Spirit-Anchor Stone. ‘[RITUAL]’ *Once, you may reroll any failed roll involving a witnessed promise. The ancestor watches.*
- A **The Ninth Warden’s Coil** — A coil of silk said to belong to the legendary warden. ‘[LEGEND]’ *Use it to cut a bridge without angering the web-law. The coil then unravels.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (cords, masks, shards) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **valley-omens**—silk cords humming in still air, the crimson river running clear, a bridge that sways without wind.

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **The Web-Law:** The unwritten legal code of the Crimson Valley. Each warden carries a different clause in memory; together, they form a complete web. To cross a bridge, a traveller must answer a question about the web-law. The answer changes with each warden. On a successful roll (Wits + Lore, DV 3), you may bypass the challenge; on a failure, you must offer a promise instead.
- **Marks (Skin-Tattoos):** Each Lethai-ar’s Marks are a public record of promises witnessed. The Marks are cut from the skin after death and buried at the Ukwe’s roots. To read a living Lethai-ar’s Marks, one must know the phase of the crimson moon and the position of the valley’s spirits. A character who studies a Lethai-ar’s Marks for a scene may ask the GM one question about a promise that Lethai-ar has witnessed; the GM must answer truthfully.
- **Spirit Ancestry:** Every Lethai-ar can name the specific spirit (mountain, river, grove) where their ancestor left the spirit world to become mortal. That spirit is their witness; they owe it a promise at birth, and that promise is never fully paid. Once per journey, a Lethai-ar may invoke their spirit ancestor to gain +1 die on a roll related to that spirit’s domain (e.g., a river ancestor aids a crossing).
- **Witness Economy:** Instead of tracking debt, the Crimson Valley uses **Witness** as currency. A character who witnesses a promise gains 1 Witness token. Tokens can be spent to: gain +1 die on a roll involving that promise, force an oath-breaker to reroll a successful deception, or demand a favour from someone who witnessed the same promise. Witness tokens are lost when the promise is fulfilled or broken.
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
 - **The First Weaver** — Inaea. *The spider who taught the first knot; mercy is a strand, not a cut.*
 - **The Serpent Judge** — Isoka. *The fang that decides; a promise kept is a skin shed.*
 - **The Crimson Witness** — The Witness. *The flame that sees through silk; no oath hidden from its light.*
 - **The Bridge Father** — The Traveler. *The road that crosses the gorge; every crossing is a promise.*

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **Crimson Silk and the Way of Silk:** The silk of the Crimson Valley is prized across the continent for vow-cords, well-contracts, and bridge-building. The Tulkani spider-traders are the primary merchants; a single bolt can buy safe passage from Fhara to Dhahara. A Tulkani story-seller may accept crimson silk as payment for a truth.
- **The Ukwe’s Roots and Sekogo:** The Ukwe’s roots extend into the Crimson Valley. The Lethai-ar bury their dead Marks at the riverbank root, creating a unique relationship with the Speaking Tree. The Ukwe knows every promise ever made in the valley. A Sekogo druid may ask the Ukwe to witness a new oath, binding it with the weight of the valley.
- **Web-Law and the Covenant (Mykkiel):** The Covenant judges respect the web-law as a valid legal system. A Lethai-ar witness cord is admissible in a Covenant court. Some judges have learned to read Marks. A Covenant justiciar may offer to “translate” a web-law dispute into imperial law — but the translation always favours the Covenant.
- **The Unmarked and the Hollow (Eastern Realms):** Lethai-ar who refuse all Marks become invisible to the web-law — and to the Hollow. The Hollow cannot track them. Some

Aelaerem seek out the Unmarked to learn the secret of blank skin. The Unmarked charge a promise: “Do not seek me again.”

Lethai-ar Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Bridge:** Crumble a crust onto the first strand. Ignore the first *Snapped Strand* penalty. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Knot the Cord:** Tie a single knot in a witness cord. Cancel *Web-Law Challenge* or take –1 die on your next negotiation (your choice). ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Name to the Root:** Whisper a dead warden’s name into the Ukwe’s root. Gain +1 Effect when crossing a bridge this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the First Ancestor. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **Silk-Wardens or Mark-Cutters**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **bridge-keepers or Tulkani traders**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **Elders or the Unmarked**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or safe crossing**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Local Silk-Warden or Bridge-Keeper** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **snapped strand or rising river**.
- **Foe Appears:** An **Oshiiran surveyor or Ashaani scout** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **Wardens, Mark-Cutters, or bridge guards** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes—**bridge cut/web-law broken/First Bridge** appears.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **Elder, Ninth Warden, or First Ancestor’s Echo** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically—**bridge collapses/river turns black/Ukwe root rises**.

- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice—**omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Crimson Valley (Web-Law):** Silk strands glow, witness cords tighten, the Ukwe’s root hums a name.
- **Crimson Valley (Marks):** Tattoos itch, ochre stains spread, a dead Mark appears on living skin.
- **Crimson Valley (Bridges):** Ropes whisper, the gorge echoes with footsteps that are not there, a bridge sways toward the Hollow.

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Wits + Survival):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Swaying Bridge*.
- **Cut the Strand (Presence + Sway):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a witness cord is in your possession, +1 die.
- **Weather the Crossing (Resolve + Spirit):** On a hit in *Fall from the Bridge*, you pick who catches the fallen; on a miss, the GM does.

Boss Seeds (Silk & Promise)

- **The Unweaver (Nine Broken Strands)** — *Phases:* Snapped Cords → Orchestrated Falls → Bridge Coup. *Cracks:* repair a broken strand, expose a false witness, survive a crossing without a promise.
- **The Silent Warden (Oath of the Unmarked)** — *Phases:* Forgotten Promises → Procession of the Blank → Skin-Baptism of an Elder. *Cracks:* relic witness cord, survivor testimony, the Marks turning against them.

Patronage & Power

Among the Lethai-ar, power flows through witnessed promises, silk strands, and the authority of the wardens. The web-law is unwritten, but every warden carries a piece of it. Marks are public, stories are visible, and the Ukwe remembers everything.

For the GM: Power in the Crimson Valley is measured in witnessed oaths and the trust of the bridge. Patronage often takes the form of witness cords, masks, or root shards — each tied to a specific promise. To emphasize this:

- Tie rewards to objects that record or enforce promises (cords, masks, shards) that can be challenged, broken, or called in.
- Let rival wardens issue conflicting interpretations of the web-law, forcing players to choose whose bridge to cross.
- Use the bridges, Mark-cutter’s studio, and the Ukwe’s root as arenas for social contests, where a witnessed promise is a weapon and a broken strand is a death sentence.

In the Crimson Valley, the bridge remembers every step — and the Ukwe forgets no promise.

Part V

The Way of Silk

Chapter 24

Fhara

The Oasis Courts.

Water is not a right. It is a loan from the sand. The oasis remembers every drop drawn, every cup poured, every promise made at its edge. I do not judge the living. I judge the debt.

I am a Water-Clerk. My grandfather dug this well with a shovel and a prayer. My mother sealed the walls with clay from the dry river. I sit in the shade and measure every bucket. The sand does not forgive a miscount.

Water isn't just law in Fhara—it's a market, and oh, how the water-clerks love a good deal on aquifer access. They don't just negotiate in three cups; they auction the right to the fourth cup. The Fhara are merchants, poets, and negotiators; they will bargain for an hour over a cup of coffee, and a day over a camel. But here's the secret the well-judges don't want you to know: the wells have ears. Every cup poured, every promise made at the edge, every drop drawn—the well-spirits are listening. And they have opinions. They favour the generous. They punish the greedy. And they never, ever forget a face.

The Fhara have no single king. Their confederacy is a web of marriage alliances, water-sharing treaties, and caravan tariffs. The desert is not empty—it is a ledger of dry wells, abandoned caravanserais, and the bones of those who could not share. A Fhara merchant can cross the waste with only a waterskin and a coffee pot, because every well has a keeper, every keeper a price, and every price can be negotiated. But the negotiation is a ritual. Three cups: the first is welcome, the second is bargaining, the third is a contract. Refuse the third, and you have broken an oath. The well-spirit will remember.

Never refuse a date offered by a well-keeper. The fruit is sacred to their

well-spirits. Refusing it ends the conversation—and your access to water.

— *Well-Judge Fatima al-Wadi, who carries a dipper made from a date-palm leaf that rots after each case*

The Almanac of Ordinary Days

What do people eat for breakfast? Dates and thin coffee—the dates are from the well-keepers' groves, the coffee is brewed with cardamom and camel milk. The milk is sour. The sourness is for endurance.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To count cups. Fhara children are taught the eight cups of negotiation: Welcome, Bargain, Contract, Witness, Debt, Payment, Forgiveness, and the ninth—the cup that is never poured. The ninth cup is for the well-spirit. The well-spirit is always thirsty.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their water-skin. A stranger whose water-skin is full has not traveled far. A stranger whose water-skin is dry has traveled too far. A stranger who carries no water-skin is either a well-keeper or a fool. Well-keepers are honoured. Fools are buried.

What is the most common crime? Water theft—but water theft is not a crime, it is a declaration of feud. The well-spirit records every theft in the aquifer. The aquifer is the court. The judge is the well. The verdict is thirst.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The wells are not natural. They were carved by the first Fhara, who made a bargain with the sand. The bargain was for water. The price was memory. The Fhara remember everything. They cannot forget. That is the curse of the wells.

Where do people go when they die? To the oasis. The dead are buried in the date groves, their graves marked with a single stone. The stone is not carved. The dead's name is spoken at sunrise. If the name is remembered, the dead rests. If it is forgotten, the dead walks.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You offer a cup—the ninth cup, poured from your own water-skin. The cup is placed at the well's edge. If the well-spirit drinks, you are forgiven. If the water evaporates, you are not. If the cup cracks, your debt is doubled.

What is the most important festival? The Filling of the Wells (spring). Every well is cleaned and blessed. The water-clerks recite the names of the year's debtors. The debtors stand at the water's edge. If their reflection wavers, they are forgiven. If it holds, they must pay.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The water-clerks' ledger is a forgery. The original was lost in a sandstorm three generations ago. The clerks have been inventing water rights ever since. The wells do not care. The wells remember the original. The wells are waiting.

24.1 Fhara — “The Oasis Courts”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *Water is a loan from the sand. The well remembers every cup.*

Well-Judge (Elite): “Water is not a right. It is a loan from the sand. The oasis remembers every drop drawn, every cup poured, every promise made at its edge. I do not judge the living. I judge the debt.”

Water-Clerk (Commoner): “My grandfather dug this well with a shovel and a prayer. My mother sealed the walls with clay from the dry river. I sit in the shade and measure every bucket. The sand does not forgive a miscount.”

Genre / Mood: Desert law, coffee ritual, water-as-community.

Starting Location: The shaded stone bench of a well-court, where the air is cool and the water is sweet. A Well-Judge dips a clay cup into the basin: “You have come for water, or for trade, or for a story. First, drink. Then tell me which of your promises you intend to keep today.”

Theme & Atmosphere

The Fhara dwell on a great, sun-baked peninsula where scattered oases and dry riverbeds connect the coast to the interior. Their cities are built around wells and date groves, and their caravans are the arteries of the spice trade. Water is law — the well-keepers are judges, and the courthouse is the shade of a palm. The Fhara are merchants, poets, and negotiators; they will bargain for an hour over a cup of coffee, and a day over a camel. Their honour is measured in generosity, and their vengeance is measured in litigation. Coffee is not a drink; it is a ritual. Three cups: the first is welcome, the second is negotiation, the third is a contract. Refuse the third, and you have broken an oath.

What you notice first: The smell of roasting coffee and overripe dates. The way every well has a stone bench for the judge. The silence when the sun passes directly overhead — no one moves, no one speaks.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never refuse a date offered by a well-keeper. The fruit is sacred to their well-spirits. Refusing it ends the conversation — and your access to water.

Regional Mood: The Weight of Water

Power here is measured in well-depth, date groves, and the length of a coffee ritual. Each oasis is a sovereign court, ruled by a Sheikh and a Well-Judge. The Fhara have no single king; their confederacy is a web of marriage alliances, water-sharing treaties, and caravan tariffs. The desert is not empty — it is a ledger of dry wells, abandoned caravanserais, and the bones of those who could not share. A Fhara merchant can cross the waste with only a waterskin and a coffee pot, because every well has a keeper, every keeper a price, and every price can be negotiated.

Prominent NPCs of the Fhara

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Sheikh Mansur	Oasis lord of the Three Wells	Keep his well's water rights against a rival clan	He has not tasted water in ten years — only coffee.
Fatima al-Wadi	Well-Judge of the central route	Settle disputes without bloodshed	She carries a dipper made from a date-palm leaf; it rots after each case.
Rashid	Caravan master of the Spice Road	Find a new route past a dried well	He has three wives, each from a different oasis. The wives do not speak.
Layla	Coffee-house poet	Sell verses for coin and secrets	Her poems are in code; the code is the price of coffee.
The Drowned Well-Keeper	A ghost of a well that went dry	Warn travellers of poisoned springs	She appears as a column of steam at dusk. She points at safe wells.

Names of the Fhara

Inspired by the desert peninsula: soft consonants, vowel-heavy, with clan prefixes (bin, bint, al-). Surnames often denote a well, a grove, or a trade.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Mansur	Fatima	al-Wadi	<i>the Well-Born</i>
Rashid	Layla	bin Hassan	<i>Coffee-Tongue</i>
Tariq	Amira	al-Sahel	<i>the Ninth Cup</i>
Jamal	Nadia	Qasimi	<i>Date-Father</i>
Hakim	Samira	al-Nur	<i>the Dry-Handed</i>

(Well/Court/Bazaar) A well-court with a stone bench and a judge's dipper; a coffee bazaar under canvas, roasting beans; a dried riverbed where old caravans are buried.

Spades — Places

2. **Well-Court** — A stone bench under a palm; a judge with a clay dipper. ‘[JUSTICE]’ *The dipper has a chip. The chip is from a sword that broke a well — and an oath.*
 3. **Coffee Bazaar** — Stalls under canvas; the smell of roasting beans. ‘[TRADE]’ *The best coffee is served in a chipped cup. The chip is a signature.*
 4. **Date Grove** — Rows of palms; the ground soft with fallen fruit. ‘[COMMUNITY]’ *The fruit ferments at night. The drunk monkeys are the guards. They accept bribes of honey.*
 5. **Dry Riverbed (Old Caravan Route)** — A wide, sandy channel with bleached bones. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The bones are not human. They are camels that died of thirst. Their ghosts still groan — a warning.*
 6. **Tent Court (Mobile)** — A carpet under a canvas roof; a judge with a scale. ‘[JUSTICE]’ *The scale weighs water, not silver. One side is always empty — for the next dispute.*
 7. **Caravanserai of the Three Wells** — A walled courtyard with three different springs. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The sweet well is for guests. The brackish well is for animals. The bitter well is for prisoners.*
 8. **Salt Pan (Western Edge)** — A white flat where the caravans load salt. ‘[TRADE]’ *The salt is mixed with ancient tears. It tastes of old grief. Cooks use it sparingly.*
 9. **Lighthouse of the Drowned** — A stone tower on the coast, never lit. ‘[DEATH]’ *The keeper is blind. He rings a bell when he hears ships. The ships are ghosts.*
 10. **Oasis of the Ninth Palm** — A legend: a grove with nine palms, but the ninth is invisible. ‘[LEGEND]’ *Drink from the ninth well, and you will forget your name for a day. Your friends will remind you.*
- J **Abandoned Well-Keeper’s Hut** — A collapsed stone shelter with a dry basin. ‘[DEATH]’ *The basin is carved with a name. The name is the keeper’s. He died of thirst — but the well is full.*
- Q **Coffee Warehouse** — A cool, dark building with sacks of beans from a dozen oases. ‘[TRADE]’ *Each sack is stamped with a well’s mark. The marks are family crests. The beans gossip.*
- K **Well-Judge’s Archive** — A cave filled with clay tablets. Each tablet is a water judgment. ‘[JUSTICE]’ *The tablets are baked hard. They are also porous. They weep when a judgment is reversed.*
- A **The First Well** — A mythic spring at the centre of the peninsula, said to never dry. ‘[LEGEND]’ *No one has found it. Those who claim they have are always lying — or dead. The dead are not lying.*

(Judge/Poet/Master) Well-Judge with a clay dipper and a rotted palm-leaf; coffee-house poet with a stringed instrument; caravan master with a rope of camel hair.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Well-Judge** — Grey-bearded, blind in one eye. He tastes the water before each ruling. ‘[JUSTICE]’ *“Salt means guilt,” he says. “Sweet means innocence. Bitter means appeal — and a cup of coffee.”*
3. **Coffee-House Poet** — A woman with hennaed hands and a silver bell on her ankle. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *She recites a verse. The verse is a price. The price is never in coin — it is a*

favour, a memory, a silence.

4. **Caravan Master** — Leathery skin, a brass whistle on a thong. '[TRAVEL]' *He can find water by the colour of the sand. He has never been wrong. He charges for the lesson.*
5. **Water-Clerk** — A young woman with a clay tablet and a reed pen. '[COMMUNITY]' *She records every bucket drawn. Her ink is water mixed with soot. A dry ledger means a dry well.*
6. **Date Merchant** — Fat, cheerful, missing two fingers to a knife fight. '[TRADE]' *He offers a date to every customer. The date is always from his own grove. He knows its story.*
7. **Oasis Lord (Sheikh)** — Robed in white, a bronze key on his belt. '[AUTHORITY]' *The key opens the sluice gate. He never lets it leave his sight. He sleeps with it under his tongue.*
8. **Well-Spirit (Nat)** — A shimmer of heat above the water at noon. '[SPIRIT]' *It asks: "Who drank without offering?" Answer truthfully, or the well will dry. The offering is a story.*
9. **Camel Breeder** — A tall, silent man with a staff of acacia wood. '[COMMUNITY]' *He names each camel after a dead wife. The camels answer to the names. They never forget a slight.*
10. **Salt Carrier** — A slave (illegal, but present in the deep desert). He wears a collar of braided rope. '[LABOR]' *He is saving to buy his freedom. The price is a thousand measures of salt. His guild saves with him.*
- J **The Drowned Well-Keeper's Ghost** — A woman in wet robes, standing at a dry well. '[DEATH]' *She offers a cup of water. The cup is empty. Drink it anyway. The taste is memory.*
- Q **Coffee Roaster** — A man with blackened hands and a brass drum. '[TRADE]' *He roasts beans while reciting the genealogy of each grove. The beans remember. They also judge.*
- K **The Ninth Palm's Guardian** — A hooded figure who appears at the legendary oasis. '[MYSTERY]' *He asks: "Why do you seek the invisible well?" The answer determines if you see it. There is no wrong answer — only a price.*
- A **The First Well-Keeper (Myth)** — A skeleton sitting on a stone bench, still holding a dipper. '[LEGEND]' *If you take the dipper, you become the new well-keeper. You cannot leave. The water is sweet. The silence is sweeter.*

(Dry/Coffee/Dispute) A well is found dry — the keeper is dead; a coffee ritual is interrupted — the third cup is not poured; a water dispute erupts between two wells — the judge demands a bribe.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Dry Well** — The oasis keeper is dead. Lose 1 Supply. '[DEATH]' '[SURVIVAL]' *The keeper's body is curled around the basin. He died of thirst. The well is full — but the spirit is angry.*
3. **Coffee Ritual Interrupted** — A stranger refuses the third cup. The host draws a knife. '[SOCIAL]' '[COMBAT]' *The stranger is a rival clan member. The insult is a declaration of feud. The coffee is still hot.*
4. **Water Dispute** — Two well-keepers claim the same spring. The judge demands a bribe. '[JUSTICE]' '[SOCIAL]' *The bribe is a story. The story must be true. The judge will know if you lie. She has heard them all.*
5. **Date Blight** — A fungus attacks the groves. Prices triple. Starvation looms. '[DISASTER]' '[TRADE]' *The blight was spread by a merchant from the coast. The merchant's ship flew no flag. The dates weep.*

6. **Sandstorm (Khamsin)** — Red dust obscures the path. Navigation DV +1, mark Fatigue. ‘[WEATHER]’ *The dust carries whispers. The whispers are the names of dead caravaners. They are asking for directions.*
7. **Customs Inspection (Forged Seal)** — A local governor demands papers. Yours are false. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[TRAP]’ *The seal is a copy. The forger is in the party. He is sweating. The governor is counting the drops.*
8. **Elephant Stampede (Rare)** — A herd of stray elephants thunders through camp. ‘[DISASTER]’ ‘[COMBAT]’ *The elephants are from a Dhaharan stable. They are escaped. They are looking for their mahout. He is hiding in your tent.*
9. **Mirage (False Well)** — A shimmer on the horizon. Lose 1 Supply chasing it. ‘[WEATHER]’ ‘[TRAP]’ *The mirage is a memory. The memory is of a well that dried a century ago. The ghost of the well drinks your water.*
10. **Debt Collector (Tulkani Vow-Cord)** — Someone recognises a knot you carry. They demand payment. ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[DEBT]’ *The payment is a story. The story must be about a broken promise. The knot tightens as you speak.*
- J **Well-Spirit Offended** — A traveller urinated in the basin. The well refuses to give water. ‘[SPIRIT]’ ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The spirit demands a sacrifice. The sacrifice is a name. The name must be the offender’s. The well will remember.*
- Q **Coffee House Fire** — A roasting drum explodes. The bazaar is burning. ‘[DISASTER]’ ‘[TRADE]’ *The fire was set by a rival oasis. The rival wants to monopolise the coffee trade. The smoke smells of cinnamon and spite.*
- K **Well-Judge’s Verdict Forged** — A clay tablet is found altered. The judge is blamed. ‘[JUSTICE]’ ‘[TRAP]’ *The forger is the judge’s own clerk. The clerk owes a debt to the Salt Syndicate. The tablet weeps — but the tears are ink.*
- A **The First Well Appears** — The mythic spring manifests. All who drink from it forget their debts. ‘[LEGEND]’ ‘[MAGIC]’ *The forgetting is permanent. The Ukwe’s roots tremble. The Hollow is pleased. The creditors are not.*

(Water-share/Court/Dipper) Water-share tablet (right to draw from a named well for a season); caravan court writ (neutral arbitration for one dispute); well-judge’s dipper (one reroll on a negotiation involving water).

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Water-Share Tablet** — A clay tile. Right to draw from a named well for one season. ‘[COMMUNITY]’ *The tablet is brittle. Break it, and the right transfers to the breaker. The well-spirit watches.*
3. **Caravan Court Writ** — A palm-leaf document. Demands neutral arbitration for any dispute. ‘[JUSTICE]’ *The writ is sealed with coffee grounds. The seal is edible. Eat it to void the writ — and the dispute.*
4. **Well-Judge’s Dipper** — A clay cup on a stick. Once, reroll a failed negotiation involving water. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The dipper has a chip. The chip is from a sword that broke a well — and an oath. It knows a lie by taste.*
5. **Coffee Cup (Royal Seal)** — A chipped cup used by a Sheikh. Gain +1 Position in any Fhara court. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The chip is a signature. No one will question it. The cup is still warm.*

6. **Date-Palm Seed** — A single seed from a sacred grove. Plant it to claim water rights. '[COMMUNITY]' *The seed grows into a palm within a year. The well-spirit will recognise you. The dates are a tithe.*
 7. **Oasis Lord's Key** — A bronze key to a sluice gate. Open any well's flow for one hour. '[AUTHORITY]' *The key is warm. It glows when a well is being poisoned. It burns the hand of a liar.*
 8. **Coffee Merchant's Ledger** — A record of every coffee sale for a decade. Contains names of spies. '[TRADE]' '[SECRET]' *The ledger is written in disappearing ink. It reappears when heated. The spies are listed in the margins.*
 9. **Salt Carrier's Rope Collar** — A braided rope that once held a slave. Present it to free a captive. '[COMMUNITY]' *The rope is old. It smells of sweat and freedom. One use. The freed slave will owe you a story.*
 10. **Well-Spirit's Boon** — A vial of water from a haunted well. Drink it to see the nearest spring. '[MAGIC]' *The water is cold. It tastes of copper. The vision lasts one hour. The spring may be guarded.*
- J **The Drowned Keeper's Cup** — An empty clay cup. Offer it to a dry well, and the dead keeper will fill it once. '[DEATH]' *The cup weeps water. The water is salty. Drink it anyway. The dead keeper will ask for a story in return.*
- Q **Coffee Roaster's Drum** — A brass drum. Roast beans in it, and the smoke forms words. '[MAGIC]' '[OMEN]' *The words are the future price of coffee. The price is always a warning. The smoke smells of regret.*
- K **The Ninth Palm's Date** — A single fruit from the invisible tree. Eat it to forget a single debt. '[MAGIC]' *The date is sweet. The forgetting is permanent. The creditor will still remember — but they will not collect.*
- A **The First Well's Water** — A flask from the mythic spring. Drink it to clear all Obligation to Fhara patrons. '[LEGEND]' '[MAGIC]' *The water tastes of nothing. The spirits will not forgive you for drinking it. But they will forget you owed.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (tablets, writs, dippers) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **water-omens**—a dry well that weeps, coffee that brews itself, a date that bleeds.

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **Three Cups, One Contract:** Fhara negotiations follow a rigid ritual. First cup: welcome and genealogy. Second cup: bargaining and threats disguised as compliments. Third cup: sealing the deal. Refusing the third cup voids the negotiation and insults the host. Accepting the third cup without intending to honour the deal is a capital crime — the liar is tied to a date palm until the sun sets.
- **Water-Sharing Tablets:** Water rights are recorded on clay tablets, stored in the Well-Judge's archive. A tablet can be split, traded, or challenged. The tablet is the well; break it, and

the water becomes unclaimed — until someone carves a new one. A broken tablet is used as evidence of a broken oath.

- **Well-Spirits (Nat):** Each well has a spirit, usually benign but jealous. Offerings of dates, coffee, or a story keep it calm. A well that has witnessed a murder may turn bitter; a well that has been poisoned may turn sentient and mobile. A mobile well is a disaster — it follows those who wronged it.
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
 - **The Thirst** — Khemesh. *The hunger beneath the sand; the pressure that drinks wells dry.*
 - **The Cup Bearer** — The Witness. *The third cup that never lies; the contract sealed in coffee grounds.*
 - **The Oasis Father** — The Traveler. *The road that leads to water; the guide who never drinks.*
 - **The Date Mother** — Inaea. *The web of groves; the shared harvest that binds families.*

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **Coffee and the Covenant (Mykkiel):** Fhara coffee houses are neutral ground under Covenant law. A well-judge’s verdict cannot be appealed outside the oasis. Some Covenant judges are trained in the three-cup ritual — they can tell a liar by the way they hold the cup.
- **Water Tablets and the Aeler Ledger (Ngomebe):** Aeler engineers have been hired to map the underground aquifers. Their breath-books record water pressure and flow. The Fhara see this as an intrusion — or an opportunity for better wells. A shared aquifer is a shared treaty.
- **Date Groves and the Ukwe (Sekogo):** The Ukwe’s roots do not reach the dry peninsula, but the Fhara have their own Speaking Palms — trees that remember every date harvested. A date from a sacred grove can witness an oath as surely as a Lethai-ar cord. The tree will not lie.
- **The First Well and the Hollow (Eastern Realms):** The mythic spring that never dries is said to be the Hollow’s original well — before it learned to thirst. Aelaerem hedge-keepers sometimes leave offerings at dried wells, hoping to appease the Hollow with water. The Hollow does not drink. It counts.

Fhara Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Basin:** Crumble a crust into the well. Ignore the first *Dry Well* penalty. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Knot the Dipper:** Tie a single date-palm fibre around the dipper’s handle. Cancel *Coffee Ritual Interrupted* or take –1 die on your next negotiation (your choice). ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Name to the Well:** Whisper a dead well-keeper’s name into the water. Gain +1 Effect when haggling over water rights this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Well-Spirit. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **Well-Judges** or **Water-Clerks**.

- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **coffee-house guards or date merchants**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **caravan masters or well-spirits**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favourable water access**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Local Well-Judge or Oasis Lord** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **sandstorm or mirage**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **rival oasis guard or debt collector** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **well-guards, coffee-house enforcers, or camel riders** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes—**well dries/coffee warehouse burns/water tablet breaks**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **High Well-Judge, Oasis Sheikh, or First Well-Keeper's ghost** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically—**well collapses/oasis floods/date grove burns**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice—**omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Fhara (Water Law):** Well-spirits ripple the surface, clay tablets glow, a dipper's chip grows larger.
- **Fhara (Coffee Ritual):** Beans roast themselves, cups overflow without water, the third cup pours black smoke.
- **Fhara (Desert):** Sand shifts to reveal old bones, mirages speak, a dry well whispers a name.

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Wits + Survival):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Sand Blind*.
- **Cut the Bargain (Presence + Sway):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a water-share tablet is in your possession, +1 die.

- **Weather the Khamsin (Resolve + Endurance):** On a hit in *Sandstorm*, you pick who stays on their feet; on a miss, the GM does.

Boss Seeds (Water & Sand)

- **The Drought-Maker (Nine Dry Wells)** — *Phases:* Well Poisonings → Orchestrated Famine → Oasis Coup. *Cracks:* find a hidden spring, expose a false tablet, survive a season without water.
- **The Coffee-Price (Third Cup Cursed)** — *Phases:* Ritual Interruptions → Procession of Empty Cups → Bargain Baptism of a Merchant. *Cracks:* relic coffee bean, survivor testimony, the third cup turning sweet again.

Patronage & Power

Among the Fhara, power flows through water, coffee, and the weight of a witnessed bargain. The Well-Judge’s word is law, the Oasis Lord controls the sluice, and the Caravan Master commands the desert. But no one rules alone — every decision is a negotiation, every negotiation a ritual, every ritual a shared trust.

For the GM: Power in Fhara society is measured in well-depth, coffee cups, and clay tablets. Patronage often takes the form of water-share rights, court writs, or a judge’s dipper — each tied to a specific oasis. To emphasise community and reciprocity rather than debt:

- Tie rewards to physical tokens (tablets, dippers, keys) that represent **shared access** rather than obligation. Breaking a token is breaking a trust, not a contract.
- Let rival oases issue conflicting water claims — resolving them requires a **community feast** or a **joint coffee ritual**, not a payment.
- Use the well-courts, coffee bazaars, and date groves as arenas for social contests, where a cup of coffee is a **shared moment** and a dry well is a **shared tragedy**.

In Fhara society, the sand forgets nothing — and the well remembers every cup shared.

Chapter 25

Sidhi

The Diaspora of the Sealed Coast.

Galanina is not a place on a map. It is a promise that our ancestors made to the sea: we will remember, and we will return. The Covenant gave us courts, but the sea gave us memory. The Admiralty gives us tariffs. We give each other salt and stories.

I am a Freedman Sailor. My grandmother wore a brass collar. My mother wore a freedman's seal. I wear a captain's ring. The slavers took our names, but they could not take the tide. The tide always comes back. So do we.

The Sidhi are a people of the coast and the diaspora. Their ancestral homeland is Galanina, a rugged shore of limestone cliffs and ancient ports far to the west. The Ashaani magocracy enslaved them for generations, but Galanina broke free under the Covenant of Mykkiel. Now the Sidhi are scattered, fierce, proud, and never forget a debt. But here's the secret the Admiralty doesn't want you to know: the Sidhi never stopped running. The Long Trail—the forced migration that scattered them across the Amaranthine—is not a tale told to children. It is a silence. A pause in conversation when someone mentions the eastern passes or the southern coast. An old woman who stops mid-sentence, touches her brass key, and changes the subject. The Sidhi do not forget, but they have learned that memory is a kind of weight—and they have carried it far enough.

The Sidhi of the Brass Coast run the ropeways, the spice auctions, and the port guilds. Their speech is a creole of Ashaani and coastal tongues, their law is maritime, and their symbol is the lighthouse lamp—a green flame that shows the faces of the drowned, so that the dead may witness the living. They are welcome everywhere and trusted nowhere. They prefer it that way.

Never ask about ancestry. The Ashaani slavery raids are a fresh wound. Asking which clan someone belongs to is asking how their grandparents were captured, sold, or killed.

— *Captain Idris, Sidhi lighthouse commander, whose left eye is a brass lens*

The Almanac of Ordinary Days

What do people eat for breakfast? Salted fish and flatbread—the fish is dried on the docks, the bread is baked in communal ovens. The ovens are fuelled by driftwood. The driftwood carries the names of lost ships.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To read the lighthouse codes. Sidhi children are taught the eight lamp-flashes: Safe, Danger, Storm, Pirate, Customs, Quarantine, Home, and the ninth—the flash that signals a freedman's return. The ninth flash is never used. The ninth flash is a promise.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their seal. Every Sidhi freedman carries a brass seal—the mark of their manumission. A stranger whose seal is worn smooth has been free for generations. A stranger whose seal is sharp has just been freed. A stranger with no seal is not a Sidhi. Not a Sidhi is not a person.

What is the most common crime? Seal-forging—but seal-forging is not a crime, it is a necessity. The Admiralty demands proof of freedom. The proof can be forged. The forgers are Sidhi. The Sidhi do not prosecute forgers. The Sidhi hire them.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The brass seals are not brass. They are made from melted chains—the chains that bound the first freedmen. The metal remembers the weight of slavery. The seals are warm. The warmth is the memory of wrists.

Where do people go when they die? To the lighthouse. The dead are not buried. Their ashes are scattered from the tower's top. The wind carries them to the sea. The sea carries them to Galanina. Galanina is the shore of ancestors. The ancestors are waiting.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You offer your seal—your own mark of freedom. The seal is melted down and reforged into a chain. The chain is worn by the wronged party. When the wrong is forgiven, the chain is melted again. The metal grows thinner each time. One day, there will be nothing left.

What is the most important festival? The Lighting of the Green Flame (winter solstice). The lighthouse lamps are cleaned and refilled. The green flame is lit. The flame shows the faces of the drowned. The drowned are the ancestors. The ancestors watch. The ancestors do not judge.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The brass seals are not all equal. Some were forged by the Admiralty itself—trap-seals that mark the wearer as a spy. The spies do not know they are spies. Their reports go to the Admiralty. The Admiralty knows everything. The Admiralty has been playing a very long game.

25.1 Sidhi — “The Diaspora of the Sealed Coast”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *The sea remembers. The lighthouse waits. We will return.*

Lighthouse Judge (Elite): “Galanina is not a place on a map. It is a promise that our ancestors made to the sea: we will remember, and we will return. The Covenant gave us courts, but the sea gave us memory. The Admiralty gives us tariffs. We give each other salt and stories.”

Freedman Sailor (Commoner): “My grandmother wore a brass collar. My mother wore a freedman’s seal. I wear a captain’s ring. The slavers took our names, but they could not take the tide. The tide always comes back. So do we. The Long Trail is behind us. Galanina is ahead — even if we never reach it.”

Genre / Mood: Diaspora noir, maritime memory, witness as resistance.

Starting Location: The lamp room of a Sidhi lighthouse, where a green flame burns behind a brass mirror. A Lighthouse Judge turns from the flame: “You have come for safe harbour, or for a charter, or to ask about the old wounds. First, light a lamp. Then tell me which memory you are here to share — or which name you have come to reclaim.”

Theme & Atmosphere

The Sidhi are a people of the coast and the diaspora. Their ancestral homeland is Galanina, a rugged shore of limestone cliffs and ancient ports far to the west — a land of olive groves, whitewashed villages, and harbours that once held the ships of a dozen empires. The Ashaani magocracy enslaved them for generations, scattering families across the Amaranthine. Some were taken north to Oshiira, others east through the Hyaar passes, and many south to the slave markets of the Brass Coast. Those who survived the **Long Trail** — a forced migration spoken of only in whispers and lullabies — carried nothing but the memory of salt and the names of the dead.

Galanina broke free under the Covenant of Mykkiel, whose judges and notaries stamped the liberation with wax and witness. But freedom did not mean return. The Sidhi are scattered still: some returned to Galanina’s lighthouse courts, some trade in Oshiiran ports, and many have found refuge on the Brass Coast of Dhahara — a sun-scorched shoreline of palm groves and spice auctions that resembles nothing of their lost homeland. They run ropeways, spice auctions, and Sidhi-run port guilds. They are fierce, proud, and never forget a face. Their speech is a creole of Ashaani and coastal tongues, their law is maritime, and their symbol is the lighthouse lamp — a green flame that shows the faces of the drowned, so that the dead may witness the living.

What you notice first: The smell of salt and old parchment. The way every Sidhi touches a small brass key at their belt — the key to a house they may never see again. The green glow of lighthouse lamps along the shore.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never ask about ancestry. The Ashaani slavery raids and the Long Trail are fresh wounds. Asking which clan someone belongs to is asking how their grandparents were captured, sold, or died on the march.

Regional Mood: The Weight of Memory

Power here is measured in lighthouse charters, freedman’s seals, and the weight of witness. The Sidhi have no single king; their authority rests in the Covenant courts of Galanina and the port-masters’ guilds of the diaspora. A Sidhi merchant’s word is her bond, because every bond is witnessed by a lighthouse lamp and recorded in a water-resistant ledger. The Admiralty of Kahfagia administers the Brass Coast, but the Sidhi run the real trade — and they remember every raid, every broken treaty, every ancestor who did not return.

The Long Trail is not a tale told to children. It is a silence. A pause in conversation when someone mentions the eastern passes or the southern coast. An old woman who stops mid-sentence, touches her brass key, and changes the subject. The Sidhi do not forget, but they have learned that memory is a kind of weight — and they have carried it far enough.

Starting Location: The lamp room of a Sidhi lighthouse, where a green flame burns behind a brass mirror. A Lighthouse Judge turns from the flame: “You have come for safe harbour, or for a charter, or to ask about the old wounds. First, light a lamp. Then tell me which memory you are here to share — or which name you have come to reclaim.”

Prominent NPCs of the Sidhi

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Magistrate Jora	Covenant Judge of the Salt Circuit (Galanina)	Enforce maritime law and protect freedman status	She carries a water-clock that runs backwards when she lies.
Captain Idris	Sidhi lighthouse commander (Brass Coast)	Prevent Ashaani slavers from landing	His left eye is a brass lens; he can read the stars even in fog.
Envoys Naveed	Breath-less agent (hidden)	Recruit exiles to resist the Veiled Sisters	He has three names; each is for a different jurisdiction. The third is from the Long Trail.
Shipwright Elara	Builder of freedmen’s boats	Launch one new vessel each year for escaped slaves	She names each boat after a dead family member. The names are never painted — only carved.

The Brass-Fingered	A smuggler with prosthetic fingers of copper	Run goods past the Admiralty’s tariffs	He lost his fingers to a customs trap. He made new ones from the trap’s own springs.
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Names of the Sidhi

Inspired by coastal and diaspora traditions — Levantine and South Asian influences — names with soft consonants, often ending in -el, -on, -ia. Surnames denote a port, a ship, a freed ancestor, or a stop on the Long Trail.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Idris	Jora	el-Galanina	<i>the Lamp-Keeper</i>
Naveed	Elara	Pattinam	<i>Brass-Fingered</i>
Samir	Leila	Chettiar	<i>the Unbound</i>
Rami	Yasmin	al-Bahr	<i>Ninth Tide</i>
Tariq	Dalia	Sidhi-el-Kebir	<i>the Witness</i>

(Lighthouse/Court/Harbour) A lighthouse with a green flame and a blind keeper; a Covenant court on stilts above the tide line; a hidden cove where freedmen’s boats are built.

Spades — Places

2. **Lighthouse of the Unfaithful Dead** — A stone tower with a brass mirror and a green flame. *The light shows the faces of those who died on the Long Trail. They do not blink. They wait.* ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[MEMORY]’
3. **Covenant Court of the Salt Marsh** — A wooden platform on stilts; the tide rises during trials. *If the water touches the judge’s feet, the verdict is “drowned.” The accused is not present — only their name, written on a slate.* ‘[JUSTICE]’
4. **Sidhi Hidden Cove (Boatyard)** — A beach accessible only through a sea-cave. *The cave walls are covered in tally marks — each mark is a slave freed. The newest marks are still wet.* ‘[COMMUNITY]’
5. **The Unforgotten Ledger’s Vault (Galanina)** — A subterranean room of sealed jars. *Each jar contains a broken oath. The jars whisper if you listen. They are whispering your name.* ‘[MEMORY]’ ‘[DEBT]’
6. **Brass Coast Ropeway** — A cable that carries spice baskets from ship to warehouse. *The rope is braided with Sidhi hair. The dead pull the baskets. They do not complain.* ‘[LABOR]’ ‘[COMMUNITY]’
7. **Freedman’s Square (Port Shed)** — A marketplace where freed slaves trade without tariffs. *The square has a fountain that flows with salt water. Drinking it reminds you of the crossing. The water tastes of Galanina.* ‘[TRADE]’ ‘[MEMORY]’

8. **Archive of Sealed Doors (Galanina)** — A fortress of ledgers, each door locked with a judge's brass ring. *The rings are different sizes. The archivist has a key ring with nine rings. The ninth opens nothing — but the tenth opens a door that should not exist.* '[SECRECY]'
9. **Lighthouse of the Brass Flame (Dhahara)** — A copper mirror that turns sunlight into a beam. *The keeper can signal a message to any Sidhi ship within a day's sail. The code is a song — a lullaby from the Long Trail.* '[SIGNAL]'
10. **Shipbreaker's Yard (Coast)** — A beach where old vessels are dismantled. *The workers are convicts. They wear chains that drag in the sand. The chains are melted down for anchors — and for freedman's seals.* '[LABOR]'
- J **The Admiral's Palace (Occupied)** — A former Sidhi fort, now a Kahfagian headquarters. *The flag is flown upside down. The Admiral does not know the difference. The Sidhi do. They count the days.* '[AUTHORITY]' '[RESISTANCE]'
- Q **The Ninth Well (Galanina)** — A fresh spring that tastes of iron. *The first Covenant judge drowned a liar there. The water still remembers his name. Drink from it, and you will remember a name you forgot — an ancestor who died on the Trail.* '[MEMORY]' '[JUSTICE]'
- K **The Drowned Captain's Ship** — A spectral dhow seen at the edge of storms. *It offers passage to the dead. The living who board it become its crew. The crew are all Sidhi who never reached Galanina.* '[DEATH]' '[MYSTERY]'
- A **The Sealed Coast (Mythic Galanina)** — A stretch of shore that appears only at low tide. *Those who walk it see the faces of ancestors who did not escape. The ancestors ask for their names back. If you remember one, they will give you a blessing. If you remember none, they will weep.* '[LEGEND]' '[MEMORY]'

(Judge/Keeper/Agent) Covenant magistrate with a water-clock; Sidhi lighthouse keeper, blind in one eye; Breath-less agent dressed as a fisher, hands uncalledoused.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Lighthouse Judge** — Robed in grey, a water-clock on her belt. She drinks only rainwater. *"The sea does not lie," she says. "Neither should you. The Long Trail taught us that lies are heavier than chains."* '[JUSTICE]' '[MEMORY]'
3. **Lighthouse Keeper** — Blind in one eye, the other sees only green. He lights the lamp with a piece of the sun — or so he claims. *He never leaves the tower. The lamp is his family. The faces in the flame are his cousins.* '[COMMUNITY]' '[DEATH]'
4. **Breath-less Agent** — A fisher with soft hands. He speaks in whispers; his words appear on paper without ink. *He carries a hollow ring. Inside is a single word: "witness." The ring belonged to his grandmother, who died on the Trail.* '[SECRECY]' '[RESISTANCE]'
5. **Shipwright of the Freedmen** — A woman with a hammer and a jar of brass nails. *She builds boats for escaped slaves. Each boat is named after a dead family member. The names are never painted — only carved. The wood remembers.* '[COMMUNITY]' '[CRAFT]'
6. **Spice Warehouse Factor** — A thin man with a brass seal on a chain. He weighs pepper with a scale that has one arm longer than the other. *The long arm is for bribes. The short arm is for justice. He never remembers which is which. His father was a slaver's bookkeeper. He does not speak of him.* '[TRADE]' '[SHAME]'
7. **Debt Collector of the Anvil (Aeler)** — A dwarf authorised to collect on maritime loans. He carries a hammer. *He knocks once for a warning, twice for a summons, thrice for a*

contract. The fourth knock is a coffin. The Sidhi taught him that rhythm. ‘[AUTHORITY]’
‘[DEBT]’

8. **Freedman’s Advocate** — A woman with a freedman’s seal branded on her forearm. She argues cases before the Admiralty. *She has never lost a case. Her clients always confess — after she speaks to them privately. She does not threaten. She reminds them of the Trail.* ‘[JUSTICE]’ ‘[MEMORY]’
9. **Salt Farmer (Galanina)** — A woman who harvests salt from coastal pans. Her hands are cracked. *She pays her taxes in salt. The Covenant accepts it as “liquid testimony.” The salt is bitter. It tastes of the Trail.* ‘[LABOR]’ ‘[TRADE]’
10. **Smuggler (Brass Coast)** — A man with brass prosthetic fingers. He runs goods past the Admiralty’s tariffs. *His fingers pick any lock. He lost the originals to a customs trap. He made new ones from the trap’s springs. He calls them his “freedmen.”* ‘[STEALTH]’ ‘[RESISTANCE]’
- J **The Drowned Priest** — A ghost in wet robes who walks the shore at low tide. *He asks for a coin to pay the ferryman. Give it, and he will not follow. Refuse, and he will ask for your name instead. He was a slave who drowned during the crossing. He still hopes to reach Galanina.* ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[MEMORY]’
- Q **The Black Bishop (Covenant)** — A judge who rules on maritime disputes. He wears a ring made from a ship’s nail. *The ship was the first slaver he freed. The nail still has rust on it. He calls it his conscience. He has freed nine ships. The tenth will be his last.* ‘[JUSTICE]’ ‘[REDEMPTION]’
- K **The Admiral’s Sidhi Clerk** — A young woman who writes the Admiral’s dispatches. She copies them in secret. *She sends the copies to the Breath-less. Her left hand is missing two fingers — a warning she ignored. She writes with her right. The Admiral has not noticed.* ‘[RESISTANCE]’ ‘[RISK]’
- A **The First Freedman (Legend)** — A slave who bought his freedom with a story. He now sits at the bottom of the Ninth Well. *If you tell him a true story, he will tell you the location of a hidden lighthouse. The lighthouse is not on any map. Its keeper is his granddaughter.* ‘[LEGEND]’ ‘[MEMORY]’

(Raid/Seal/Leak) Ashaani slave ships are sighted — the lighthouse keeper asks you to hold the light; a freedman’s seal is discovered to be a forgery — the party is accused; a Covenant audit demands to see your cargo — the cargo is escaped slaves.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Ashaani Raid (Slaver Ships)** — Black sails on the horizon. The lighthouse keeper asks you to hold the light. ‘[COMBAT]’ ‘[DEATH]’ *Hold it too long, and they will see you. Hold it too short, and the freedmen will not see the signal. The keeper’s hands are shaking. She has held this light before.*
3. **Forged Freedman’s Seal** — A document you carry is discovered to be a copy. The magistrate calls for your arrest. ‘[JUSTICE]’ ‘[TRAP]’ *The forger is a Breath-less agent. The seal was a test. You failed. The agent is watching from the gallery. He is not smiling.*
4. **Covenant Audit (Hidden Cargo)** — A judge demands to inspect your holds. The lower deck is full of escaped slaves. ‘[JUSTICE]’ ‘[COMMUNITY]’ *The slaves are from Ashaan. One of them is the judge’s own niece. He does not know. The niece is hiding in a barrel of*

pepper. She is sneezing.

5. **Lighthouse Out of Phase** — The keeper signals a warning — but the warning is for the ship behind you. '[SIGNAL]' '[TRAP]' *You are now the decoy. The reef is ahead. The slavers are behind. Choose. The keeper is weeping. She has done this before.*
 6. **Tariff Hike (Admiralty)** — The port-master doubles duties on all Sidhi goods. The hike is a bribe. '[AUTHORITY]' '[DEBT]' *The bribe is to the Black Bishop. The Bishop has already accepted. Your protest is treason. The merchants are watching. They are counting your breaths.*
 7. **Shipbreaker's Curse** — A vessel in the yard breaks its chains. It wants a new victim — a ship's captain. '[DEATH]' '[COMBAT]' *The captain is you. The ship was a slaver. It remembers your face from a raid you did not commit. Its chains are warm. They have been warmed by other captains.*
 8. **Breath-less Betrayal** — An agent sells you to the Sisters. The agent is a slave in the Sisters' household. '[SECRECY]' '[TRAP]' *The betrayal was a test. The agent wants to see if you can escape. If you do, you are worthy of trust. If not, you were never worth the risk.*
 9. **Green Lantern Lit (Drowned Priest)** — Someone lights the forbidden lamp at the tavern. The dead come. '[DEATH]' '[FEAR]' *They are looking for the person who killed them. That person is in your party. The lantern owner is laughing. He is one of the dead.*
 10. **Archive Fire (Galanina)** — A lamp falls in the vault of sealed jars. Ledgers burn. '[DISASTER]' '[MEMORY]' *The smoke forms names. Those names are the ones the Covenant wants erased. One is yours. The archivist is weeping. She is trying to save the jars.*
- J The Drowned Captain's Ship Appears** — A spectral dhow emerges from the fog. It offers passage. '[DEATH]' '[MYSTERY]' *The price is a memory. The memory will be forgotten forever. The destination is the Hollow. The crew are all Sidhi. They are singing a lullaby.*
- Q Admiralty Press Gang** — Marines grab bystanders for the fleet. The marines are drunk and do not recognise rank. '[AUTHORITY]' '[COMBAT]' *One of the bystanders is a Covenant judge. She is about to be impressed. She asks for your help. She has a freedman's seal in her pocket. It is glowing.*
- K The Ninth Well Runs Dry** — The sacred spring stops flowing. Galanina's courts close for lack of witness water. '[DISASTER]' '[JUSTICE]' *The well was poisoned by an Ashaani agent. The poison is a memory. Drinking it makes you forget your name. The agent is wearing a freedman's seal. It is a forgery.*
- A The Sealed Coast Opens** — The mythical shore appears. Ancestors walk the tide line, asking for their names. '[LEGEND]' '[MEMORY]' *If you give them a name, they will give you a secret. The secret is always a death. If you give them your own name, they will take you with them. The choice is yours.*

(Charter/Seal/Key) Lighthouse charter (right to anchor in any Sidhi port); freedman's seal (proof of emancipation — glows when a slaver ship is near); archive key (opens one door in the Sealed Archive — the key is a finger bone).

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Lighthouse Charter** — A brass key. The right to anchor in any Sidhi port without inspection. '[TRAVEL]' *The key fits a lock on a sea-chest, not a harbour gate. The chest contains a map — of the Long Trail, with names written at each stop.*

3. **Freedman’s Seal** — A brand on a leather thong. Proof of emancipation. ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[JUSTICE]’ *The seal glows when a slaver ship is within a day’s sail. It also glows when a Black Hand agent is near. Trust the glow. It has never been wrong.*
4. **Archive Key (Finger Bone)** — A bone key. Opens one door in the Sealed Archive of Galanina. ‘[SECRECY]’ *The Archive keeps the corresponding finger. Touch the key to the door, and the finger twitches. It is pointing to the door you should open next.*
5. **Shipwright’s Boat** — A small, fast vessel built for escape. No name, no papers. ‘[TRAVEL]’ ‘[COMMUNITY]’ *The boat cannot be tracked by magic. The wood is from a freed slave’s house. The house was in Galanina. The wood remembers the sea wind.*
6. **Covenant Seal Ring (Brass)** — Press it into wax to witness any maritime contract. ‘[JUSTICE]’ *The ring is warm. It cools if the contract is false. The cooling is immediate. The ring also warms when a Sidhi tells the truth.*
7. **Lighthouse Keeper’s Lens** — A brass tube. Look through it to see the nearest slaver ship. ‘[JUSTICE]’ ‘[SIGNAL]’ *The lens also shows the faces of the slaves on board. They look back. They do not blink. They are waiting.*
8. **Salt Farmer’s Tithe (Bag)** — A bag of bitter salt. Legal tender in any Covenant court. ‘[TRADE]’ *The salt tastes of tears. It also tastes of freedom — if you know what freedom tastes like. The salt is from the pans of Galanina.*
9. **Breath-less Cipher Ring (Silver)** — Twist it to reveal a hidden message. The message is a name. ‘[SECRECY]’ *The name is a debt. The debt is transferable. Sign it over to avoid payment. The ring belonged to a slave who bought his freedom with a story.*
10. **Smuggler’s Brass Fingers** — A set of prosthetic fingers that pick any lock (once per lock). ‘[STEALTH]’ *The fingers were made from a customs trap. The trap remembers. It may trigger again. The fingers are warm. They have been used before.*
- J **Black Bishop’s Ring (Ship’s Nail)** — Wear it to be immune to Admiralty arrest in Sidhi ports. ‘[JUSTICE]’ ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The nail is from a freed slaver. The slaves’ ghosts protect you. They also watch. They judge. They remember. The ring is cold. It warms only when justice is done.*
- Q **The Drowned Priest’s Coin** — A copper coin from the ghost’s collection. Give it to the ferryman. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[TRAVEL]’ *Once, you may cross from the living shore to the Hollow and back. The crossing takes one night. The priest will not follow. He is afraid of the Hollow.*
- K **First Freedman’s Story** — A true tale told at the Ninth Well. It reveals a hidden lighthouse. ‘[LEGEND]’ ‘[MEMORY]’ *The lighthouse marks a passage through the Brass Coast’s tariff zone. No one will tax you there. The keeper is his granddaughter. She will ask for another story.*
- A **The Sealed Coast’s Water** — A flask from the mythic shore. Drink it to remember a name you forgot. ‘[LEGEND]’ ‘[MEMORY]’ *The name is always an ancestor’s. The ancestor will then ask you to avenge them. The water is warm. It tastes of Galanina. It tastes of home.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (charters, seals, keys) that change position rather than call for a roll.

- If any A appears, echo **sea-omens**—green flames that burn blue, salt that tastes sweet, a drowned face in a still puddle, the sound of footsteps on the Long Trail.

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **The Long Trail:** A forced migration that scattered the Sidhi across the Amaranthine. No Sidhi speaks of it directly, but every family has a Trail name — a place where an ancestor fell, a river where a child was born, a cave where they hid from slavers. A character who knows a Trail name may roll Wits + Lore (DV 3) to recall a forgotten route, a hidden spring, or a smuggler's cache. On a miss, the memory is too painful; gain 1 Fatigue and a Condition: *Grieving*.
- **Lighthouse Courts:** Sidhi legal disputes are settled in the lamp room of a lighthouse, with the green flame as witness. The judge is the keeper. The verdict is written in salt on a slate, then washed away by the tide. Only the flame remembers. A party may request a green flame judgment instead of a conventional trial. Roll Presence + Lore (DV 4). On success, the judge rules in your favour; on a miss, the green flame shows a hidden crime you committed, and the penalty is doubled.
- **Freedman's Seal:** A brand or pendant that proves emancipation under the Covenant. A freedman cannot be re-enslaved in any Covenant signatory port. The seal is also a key — it opens the door to the Breath-less network. Once per session, a character with a freedman's seal may ask a Sidhi lighthouse keeper for one favour: safe harbour, a warning, or a message carried by green flame.
- **The Ninth Well:** A sacred spring in Galanina where the first Covenant judge drowned a liar. The water is said to remember every false oath. Sidhi who need to prove their innocence drink from the well; liars vomit brine. A character who drinks from the Ninth Well (or carries its water) may reroll a failed social roll involving an oath — but on a second failure, they gain the Condition *Brine-Tongued* (–1 die on all social rolls for one day).
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
 - **The Green Keeper** — The Witness. *The flame that shows the truth, even when it burns. Especially when it burns.*
 - **The Hook** — Maelstraesus. *The price of a second chance; the interest on a freedman's soul. The interest is always paid in memories.*
 - **The Tide Father** — Khemesh. *The pressure beneath the keel; the debt that the sea collects. The Sidhi paid it once. They will not pay again.*
 - **The Lantern Bearer** — The Traveler. *The light that guides lost ships — and lost souls. The light that remembers the Trail.*

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **Galanina and the Veiled Sisters (Ashaan):** The Sidhi diaspora exists because of Ashaani slavery. A Breath-less agent in the Brass Coast may be the same person who escaped Galanina as a child. Revenge is a slow debt. The Trail is a slow march. Both end at the sea.
- **Lighthouse Charters and the Fhara (Way of Silk):** Fhara water-clerks respect Sidhi lighthouse charters as proof of credit. A Sidhi merchant can borrow water rights against a charter; default means the lighthouse lamp goes out. The lamp has gone out three times. Each time, a Sidhi family vanished from the records.

- **Freedman’s Seals and the Covenant (Mykkiel):** The Covenant recognises only one seal higher than a freedman’s — the Seal of Mykkiel himself. A party carrying a freedman’s seal can demand a hearing before any Covenant judge, anywhere. The judge must hear the case. The judge may also weep.
- **The Brass Coast and Dhaharan Independence:** The Sidhi of the Brass Coast are a major faction in Dhaharan politics. They pay tariffs to the Admiralty but run their own courts, their own ships, and their own spies. A Sidhi port-master may be the key to breaking the Admiralty’s hold. The key is a freedman’s seal. It is warm. It is waiting.
- **The Long Trail and the Hollow (Eastern Realms):** The Hollow is said to have followed the Sidhi during their migration, feeding on the grief of those who died unburied. Aelaerem hedge-keepers still find Trail markers — cairns of salt and bone — on the eastern passes. They leave offerings of bread and water. They do not speak of what they see.

Sidhi Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Tide:** Crumble a crust into the harbour at dusk. Ignore the first *Ashaani Raid* penalty. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Knot the Anchor Chain:** Tie a single sailor’s knot in a mooring rope. Cancel *Forged Freedman’s Seal* or take –1 die on your next legal roll (your choice). ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Name to the Lighthouse:** Whisper a dead captain’s name into the green flame. Gain +1 Effect when smuggling this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Drowned Priest. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **Lighthouse judges or Admiralty customs**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **port-masters or freedmen’s advocates**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **Ashaani slavers or Covenant auditors**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favourable tide**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** Local **lighthouse keeper or Covenant judge** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **green flash or rising tide**.
- **Foe Appears:** An **Ashaani slaver or Admiralty press gang** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **Admiralty marines, Covenant bailiffs, or slaver ships** arrive.

- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes—**lighthouse goes dark/charter voided/seal breaks**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival: High Lighthouse Judge, Black Bishop, or Drowned Priest** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically—**lighthouse collapses/tide swallows the court/slaver ship rams the pier**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice—**omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Sidhi (Lighthouse Law):** Green flame flickers, salt crystals form in the air, the judge's water-clock runs backwards.
- **Sidhi (Diaspora):** A freedman's seal grows warm, a distant lighthouse answers a question you did not ask, a slave ship's bell rings without being struck.
- **Sidhi (Brass Coast):** Ropeways hum with whispers, spice dust forms the shape of Galanina's cliffs, the Admiralty's flag flies at half-mast for no reason.

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Wits + Sail):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Green Flash*.
- **Cut the Charter (Presence + Sway):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a freedman's seal is in your possession, +1 die.
- **Weather the Raid (Resolve + Spirit):** On a hit in *Ashaani Raid*, you pick who holds the light; on a miss, the GM does.

Boss Seeds (Salt & Flame)

- **The Seal-Breaker (Nine Forgeries)** — *Phases:* Freedman Seals Counterfeited → Orchestrated Re-enslavement → Lighthouse Coup. *Cracks:* recover a true seal, expose a forger, survive a night in the Ninth Well.
- **The Drowned Admiral (Ghost of the Brass Coast)** — *Phases:* Lost Ships Called Home → Procession of Empty Lighthouses → Tide-Baptism of a Judge. *Cracks:* relic lighthouse lens, survivor testimony, the green flame turning white.

Patronage & Power

Among the Sidhi, power flows through witness, salt, and the green flame of the lighthouse. The Covenant courts provide law, but the true authority is memory — of the raids, of the Long Trail, of the ancestors who did not return. A Sidhi elder’s word is law because she remembers when law was a whip.

For the GM: Power in Sidhi society is measured in charters, seals, and the trust of the lighthouse keeper. Patronage often takes the form of lighthouse rights, freedman’s proofs, or archive keys — each tied to a specific port, a specific ancestor, a specific stop on the Trail. To emphasize this:

- Tie rewards to physical tokens (keys, seals, lenses) that can be lost, stolen, or voided by the Admiralty.
- Let rival Sidhi port-masters issue conflicting charters, forcing players to choose whose lamp to trust.
- Use the lighthouse courts, hidden coves, and freedman’s squares as arenas for social contests, where a green flame is a witness and a bag of salt is a verdict.
- Remember the Long Trail. Let it surface in NPC dialogue as an absence, a pause, a change of subject. The Sidhi do not speak of it, but they never forget.

In Sidhi society, the sea forgets nothing — and the lighthouse remembers every face.

Chapter 26

Pereshi

The Roof of the Way.

The fire does not forget. It has witnessed every oath sworn in this valley, every treaty sealed with a dropped coal, every lie told in its light. I do not tend the flame. I listen to what it remembers. And it remembers everything.

I am a Caravan Scribe. My grandfather copied a tax ledger that had not been opened in three centuries. He found a mistake—a single miscounted bale of silk. That mistake started a war. We do not write for the living. We write for the dead who cannot correct their errors.

The Pereshi highlands are a vast, windswept plateau, cut by deep river valleys and crowned with snow-capped peaks. Ancient fire temples stand beside caravanserais; terraced vineyards climb the hillsides. The people are scholars, shepherds, and traders—proud, suspicious, and bound by a code of hospitality that demands three days of feasting for any guest, and three generations of vengeance for any insult. But here's the secret the Flame-Keepers don't want you to know: the fire in the temple is not just a flame. It is a witness. It has seen every oath sworn in this valley, every treaty sealed with a dropped coal, every lie told in its light. And it remembers everything. Including the Prince's true name.

Once, the Forgotten Ashaani Prince conquered this land. He built garrisons, taxed the passes, and tried to burn every library. When he and his kingdom vanished into the sand—swallowed by the same curse that turned the desert to glass—the Pereshi rose. They threw down his garrisons, brick by brick, and sealed his name in a scroll they have never reopened. They have not forgotten. Every fire temple keeps a coal from the Prince's own brazier—the ninth coal, never lit, a promise that his darkness will not return.

Never step on a fallen book. Written words carry the weight of law. To step on a book is to trample a contract, a genealogy, a verdict. The spirits of the words will haunt you.

— *Flame-Keeper Zarifa, who has never been seen without a rose—fresh or dried*

The Almanac of Ordinary Days

What do people eat for breakfast? Flatbread with honey and clotted cream—the honey is from highland bees, the cream is from goats that graze the temple steps. The goats are sacred. The goats are also delicious.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To read a contract. Pereshi children are taught the eight clauses of the Covenant: Offer, Acceptance, Witness, Consideration, Term, Breach, Remedy, and the ninth—the silence where the unspoken terms live. The ninth clause is never written. The ninth clause is the one that kills you.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their book. Every Pereshi carries a ledger—their personal account of debts owed and collected. A stranger whose ledger is thick has many debts. A stranger whose ledger is thin has many creditors. A stranger with no ledger is a liar. Liars are not fed.

What is the most common crime? Contract forgery—but forgery is not a crime, it is an art. The Pereshi courts are full of forged documents. The judges are forgers themselves. The law is a negotiation. The negotiation never ends.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Forgotten Prince did not vanish. He is buried beneath the largest fire temple, in a lead-lined coffin sealed with nine locks. The keys are held by the nine Flame-Keepers. The Flame-Keepers have never met. The Flame-Keepers do not know each other's names. The Prince's name is written on the inside of the coffin lid. No one has read it in nine centuries.

Where do people go when they die? To the fire. The dead are cremated on the temple pyres. Their ashes are mixed with clay and pressed into bricks. The bricks are used to build new temples. The dead become walls. The walls witness. The walls do not forget.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You offer a coal—a burning ember from the temple fire. The coal is placed in the wronged party's hearth. If it stays lit, you are forgiven. If it smoulders, you are watched. If it goes out, you are cursed. The curse is the fire's silence. The fire will not speak for you again.

What is the most important festival? The Reading of the Ledgers (autumn). Every household brings its ledger to the temple. The ledgers are read aloud. The debts are tallied. The dead are named. The fire listens. The fire does not interrupt.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The ninth coal is not coal. It is a piece of the Forgotten Prince's heart, petrified by the curse that swallowed his kingdom. The Flame-Keepers do not know. They think it is a relic. The heart is still warm. The heart is still beating. The heart is waiting to be reunited with the rest of him.

26.1 Pereshi — “The Roof of the Way”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *The fire remembers. The archive endures. The conqueror’s name is ash.*

Flame-Keeper (Elite): “The fire does not forget. It has witnessed every oath sworn in this valley, every treaty sealed with a dropped coal, every lie told in its light. I do not tend the flame. I listen to what it remembers. And it remembers everything — including the Prince who thought he could burn us.”

Caravan Scribe (Commoner): “My grandfather copied a tax ledger that had not been opened in three centuries. He found a mistake — a single miscounted bale of silk. That mistake started a war. We do not write for the living. We write for the dead who cannot correct their errors. And we write to remind ourselves: the empire of ash will not rise again.”

Genre / Mood: High alpine bureaucracy, fire-lit memory, post-colonial witness.

Starting Location: The scriptorium of a mountain caravanserai, where lamps burn at noon and scribes copy tax ledgers by candlelight. A Flame-Keeper looks up from a brazier: “You have come for a tariff receipt, or for a verse to cross the pass, or to consult a book that should have been burned. First, tell me a truth — something the Ashaani Prince tried to erase. Then I will decide which fire shows you the way.”

Theme & Atmosphere

The Pereshi highlands are a vast, windswept plateau, cut by deep river valleys and crowned with snow-capped peaks. Ancient fire temples stand beside caravanserais; terraced vineyards climb the hillsides. The people are scholars, shepherds, and traders — proud, suspicious, and bound by a code of hospitality that demands three days of feasting for any guest, and three generations of vigilance for any insult.

Once, the Forgotten Ashaani Prince conquered this land. His empire spanned from the now-Red Desert through Galanina into northern Dhahara. He built garrisons, taxed the passes, and tried to burn every library. When he and his kingdom vanished into the sand — swallowed by the same curse that turned the desert to glass — the Pereshi rose. They threw down his garrisons, brick by brick, and sealed his name in a scroll they have never reopened. They have not forgotten. Every fire temple keeps a coal from the Prince's own brazier — the ninth coal, never lit, a promise that his darkness will not return. Every archive holds a copy of the treaty that ended his reign, written in disappearing ink that only the flame can reveal. The Pereshi have no king; their land is a patchwork of petty lords, each ruling from a stone fortress, each claiming descent from the mythic Sun Kings of the First Age — the kings who ruled before the Prince came. Here, the old empire lies buried under the weight of its own libraries, and the Pereshi are the bureaucrats, magi, and memory-keepers of the Silk Way — because they never throw away a document, and they never forgive a conqueror.

What you notice first: The smell of woodsmoke and old parchment. The way every valley has a different accent. The constant call to prayer from fire-temple towers — but the prayers are in a language no one speaks outside the highlands, a language that predates the Prince's rule.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never step on a fallen book. Written words carry the weight of law — and the weight of witness. To step on a book is to trample a contract, a genealogy, a verdict, a memory of the Prince's cruelty. The spirits of the words will haunt you.

Regional Mood: The Weight of the Archive

Power here is measured in fire-temple charters, caravan tariffs, and the length of a family's library. The petty kings of the highlands compete not through armies but through scribes — who can produce the oldest charter, the most complete genealogy, the most beautifully illuminated tax receipt. The Covenant has a strong presence in the sacred cities, but the Pereshi follow their own law: the word of a Flame-Keeper outweighs a judge's gavel. Travelers are expected to recite a verse when crossing a bridge — the spirits of the water demand it — and to present a red rose before petitioning a lord. The high passes are measured in breath-counts, not miles, and the air is thin enough to make a foreigner's head spin. But the thinnest air of all is in the sealed archive where the Prince's name is buried. No one has opened it in nine generations. The lock has no key. The key is a memory no one wants to have.

Prominent NPCs of the Pereshi Highlands

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk

Flame-Keeper Zarifa	Priestess of the eternal fire	Preserve the old rites and the ledgers they protect	She has never been seen without a rose — fresh or dried. The rose is from the Prince’s own garden, taken the day he fell.
Lord Rostam	Highland petty king	Unite the valleys against low- land tax collectors	He keeps a cage of doves; each dove car- ries a different treaty. The ninth dove carries a blank page — for the Prince’s name.
Archivist Kaelen	Keeper of the Unfinished Books	Protect the scrolls that were never completed	He has not left the archive in thirty years. His shadow is missing. The Prince’s shadow took it.
Tarkhan	Caravan master of the high passes	Secure the passes before the snows close them	He has three camels, each named after a dead wife. The camels were bred from stock the Prince’s army abandoned.
The Poet of the Ninth Verse	An old man who stole a missing line of an ancient epic	Recite the verse for a cup of tea made with snowmelt	His left eye is a piece of amber with a fly trapped inside. The fly is from the Prince’s own stable.

Names of the Pereshi Highlands

Inspired by highland and steppe traditions: names with soft endings, honorific prefixes (Mir, Khan, Beg), and surnames denoting a clan or a valley. Many families carry a second, secret name — the name they used during the Prince’s occupation, preserved as a mark of survival.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Rostam	Zarifa	Kuhistani	<i>the Fire-Touched</i>
Kaelen	Laleh	Qasemi	<i>the Unfinished</i>
Tarkhan	Shirin	Salari	<i>Ninth Verse</i>
Dariush	Mahsa	Bahrami	<i>the Bridge-Mouthed</i>
Behrouz	Golnar	Khorasani	<i>the Red Rose</i>

(Temple/Library/Bridge) Fire temple with a copper dome and a flame that never goes out; library of unfinished books where scribes copy texts that were burned by the Prince’s order; stone bridge over a chasm, each arch carved with a line of poetry — except the ninth, which is deliberately blank.

Spades — Places

2. **Fire Temple of the Unquenched** — A stone tower with a copper dome. The fire inside is said to be the first flame. *It has never gone out — but it flickers when a king dies. The flame’s colour changes with the season. The ninth coal sits in a brass brazier, untouched since the Prince’s fall.* ‘[RITUAL]’ ‘[MEMORY]’
3. **Library of Unfinished Books** — A scriptorium where scribes copy texts that were burned by the Prince. *The books are blank. The scribes are ghosts. They copy from memory. Their memory is perfect — and full of holes where the Prince’s censors cut.* ‘[KNOWLEDGE]’ ‘[DEATH]’
4. **Bridge of the Ninth Verse** — A stone arch over a chasm. Each stone is carved with a line of poetry. *The ninth verse is missing — it was stolen by the Prince and ground into dust. The bridge groans when a traveller recites a false verse. Only the true verse, which no one remembers, will silence it.* ‘[THRESHOLD]’ ‘[RIDDLE]’
5. **Caravanserai of the Three Valleys** — A walled courtyard with three gates, each from a different valley. *The gate you enter determines the price you pay. The price is always a story — a story of survival during the occupation.* ‘[TRAVEL]’ ‘[COMMUNITY]’
6. **Vineyard of the Blind Vintner** — Terraced hillside where the vintner lost his sight to a curse. *He tastes the grapes to know the weather. He is never wrong. The wine tastes of prophecy — and of the Prince’s tears, which never fell.* ‘[WEATHER]’ ‘[MYSTERY]’
7. **Hospice of the Lost Steps** — A monastery where pilgrims who lost their way are healed. *The healers ask no payment — only a story of how you got lost. The stories are added to the library. The librarians are looking for one story: how the Prince lost his way.* ‘[HEALING]’ ‘[COMMUNITY]’
8. **Well of the Ancestors** — A deep pool in a grove of cypress trees. The water is black. *Drink it, and you remember a past life — but you forget one year of this one. The year is always a good one. The Prince’s victims drank here to forget their chains.* ‘[MEMORY]’ ‘[DEBT]’

9. **Forge of the Silent Smith** — A cave where a hermit makes swords. The swords have no edge. *They are legal documents, folded steel. Present one in court, and the judge must read it. The smith is a descendant of the Prince’s own armourer, who turned his coat and now forges only truth.* ‘[CRAFT]’ ‘[JUSTICE]’
10. **Shepherds’ Moot** — A circle of standing stones on a hilltop. Shepherds gather to settle disputes. *The stones have ears. Oaths spoken here echo for three days. The shepherds listen to the echoes — and to the silence where the Prince’s oaths should have been.* ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[LAW]’
- J **Fire Temple of the Ninth Coal** — A sanctuary where the flame is kept in a brass brazier with nine coals. *The ninth coal is never lit. Lighting it would summon the Hollow — or the Prince’s ghost. The Flame-Keeper sleeps with a bucket of sand. The sand is from the Red Desert.* ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[FEAR]’
- Q **Pass of the Unforgiven** — A narrow defile where a treaty was broken a thousand years ago. *The wind carries the names of the oath-breakers. It never stops. The names are getting quieter. The Prince’s name is the quietest of all.* ‘[WEATHER]’ ‘[DEBT]’
- K **Sun King’s Throne** — A carved stone seat on a peak. Whoever sits there at dawn can see three valleys. *The curse is that they cannot leave. The throne is warm. It grows warmer the longer you sit. The Prince sat here once. The throne still remembers his weight.* ‘[LEGEND]’ ‘[TRAP]’
- A **The Archive of the First Empire** — A buried city, sealed under a landslide. The scrolls inside are still legible. *The seal was placed by the last emperor before the Prince conquered. He wrote on the door: “Let no one read these lies.” The lies are about the Prince’s origin. The truth is buried deeper.* ‘[KNOWLEDGE]’ ‘[LEGEND]’

(Keeper/Lord/Archivist) Flame-Keeper with a brass dipper and a rose; Lord Rostam with a dove cage; Archivist Kaelen with ink-stained fingers and no shadow.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Flame-Keeper** — Dressed in white, carries a brass dipper. He pours oil into the fire; each drop is a prayer. *He prays for the dead. The dead answer in smoke. The smoke writes on the wall — mostly warnings about the Prince.* ‘[RITUAL]’ ‘[MEMORY]’
3. **Highland Lord (Rostam)** — Robed in wool, a gold earring, a cage of doves on his shoulder. *Each dove carries a different treaty. He has nine doves. The ninth carries a blank page — for the treaty that will never come.* ‘[POLITICS]’ ‘[COMMUNITY]’
4. **Archivist** — Ink-stained fingers, half-moon spectacles, a book of blank pages. *He writes only in his memory. His memory has a thousand volumes. He is forgetting the first — the name of the scribe who first defied the Prince.* ‘[KNOWLEDGE]’ ‘[SECRET]’
5. **Caravan Master (Tarkhan)** — Worn leather, soft voice, a staff of juniper wood. *He never carries a weapon. His camels are his guards. The camels have names — names of villages the Prince erased.* ‘[TRAVEL]’ ‘[COMMUNITY]’
6. **Blind Vintner** — Hands stained purple, eyes white with cataracts. He tastes the grapes. *“This vine remembers the drought of ’92,” he says. “This one remembers a wedding. This one remembers the Prince’s soldiers drinking from the well.”* ‘[WEATHER]’ ‘[MEMORY]’
7. **Temple Beggar** — Blind, always sitting by the fire. He can see the future in the flames. *He charges a single coal. The coal must be from the ninth brazier. He never asks twice. He has*

seen the Prince's return. He will not say when. '[MYSTERY]' '[FEAR]'

8. **Oath-Breaker's Ghost** — Visible only at twilight. He repeats the words of the broken treaty. *He has been repeating them for a century. The words are getting softer. Soon he will be silent. The treaty was the Prince's only promise to the Pereshi.* '[DEATH]' '[DEBT]'
9. **Silent Smith** — A giant of a man, deaf and mute. He communicates by striking his anvil in code. *The code is a forgotten language. The language is the law — the law the Prince tried to replace. He never makes a mistake.* '[CRAFT]' '[JUSTICE]'
10. **Healer of the Lost Steps** — A woman with a staff of olive wood. She never asks your name. *She knows it anyway. She writes it in a ledger. The ledger is in a locked room. The room was once the Prince's bedchamber.* '[HEALING]' '[COMMUNITY]'
- J **Poet of the Ninth Verse** — An old man in a patched coat. He recites the missing verse for a cup of tea. *The tea must be made with snowmelt. The snow must be from the peak of the Unforgiven Pass. He stole the verse from the Prince's own library.* '[RIDDLE]' '[LEGEND]'
- Q **Shepherd King** — Young, wearing a cloak of uncut wool. He counts his sheep by naming them. *He has never lost a name. The sheep answer when he calls. They remember their ancestors' names too — and the names the Prince tried to erase.* '[COMMUNITY]' '[MEMORY]'
- K **The Sun King's Shadow** — A figure that sits on the throne at night. It is not the king. *It is the memory of the king. It gives bad advice. The advice is always true — for a dead person. The Prince's shadow sits beside it.* '[DEATH]' '[FEAR]'
- A **The First Emperor's Ghost** — A skeleton in a crown, sitting in the buried archive. *He asks: "Did anyone read my lies?" If you say yes, he will weep. The weeping floods the archive. The lies were about the Prince's true origin. The truth is in the water.* '[LEGEND]' '[KNOWLEDGE]'

(Flame/Scroll/Bridge) Temple flame gutters — a sign of a coming death; a scroll is found to be a forgery — the forger is a rival lord; the Bridge of the Ninth Verse demands a recitation — a character must compose a new verse on the spot.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Flame Gutters** — The temple fire flickers. A sign of a coming death. The death is yours — unless you pay a coal to the beggar. *The beggar's price is a story. The story must be about a death you caused — or a death the Prince caused that you witnessed.* '[OMEN]' '[DEATH]'
3. **Forged Scroll** — A caravan tariff receipt is discovered to be a copy. The lord demands compensation. *The forger is the lord's own scribe. The scribe is trying to frame a rival. The real scroll was burned by the Prince.* '[TRAP]' '[SOCIAL]'
4. **Bridge Recitation Failed** — A traveller cannot recite a verse. The water-spirits block the crossing. *The spirits demand a verse from a dead poet. The poet is the traveller's ancestor — a poet the Prince executed. The verse is a lament.* '[RIDDLE]' '[THRESHOLD]'
5. **Landslide (Pass Blocked)** — A rockslide covers the high pass. The alternative route is three days longer. *The landslide was deliberate — a rival caravan master wants to delay you. His camels are ahead. He is selling Prince-era artifacts.* '[TRAVEL]' '[CONFLICT]'
6. **Blood Feud (Stolen Sheep)** — Two clans blame you for a shepherd's death. The shepherd died of old age. *The clans do not care. They need an excuse for war. The sheep were from a line the Prince's army tried to exterminate.* '[SOCIAL]' '[VIOLENCE]'

7. **Poet’s Demand** — The old man asks for a new verse to replace the one he lost. The verse must be true. *If it is not true, he will know. He will not speak again. The missing verse will stay missing. The verse he lost was about the Prince’s death.* ‘[RIDDLE]’ ‘[TRUTH]’
8. **Archive Fire** — A lamp falls in the Library of Unfinished Books. The ghosts scream. *The smoke forms names. The names are those who burned the original texts. One is yours. One is the Prince’s. His name is still burning.* ‘[DISASTER]’ ‘[DEATH]’
9. **Oath-Breaker’s Curse** — The ghost appears at your camp. He repeats the broken treaty. The words are louder. *He wants you to witness his death. If you refuse, you will break an oath before dawn. The oath was sworn to the Prince. Breaking it is a mercy.* ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[DEBT]’
10. **Sun King’s Curse** — Someone sits on the throne. They cannot leave. The party must find a new king — or break the throne. *The throne is a single piece of stone. Breaking it requires a verse strong enough to crack granite. The verse was written by the Prince. It is a lie.* ‘[TRAP]’ ‘[LEGEND]’
- J **Ninth Coal Lit** — Someone lights the forbidden coal in the fire temple. The flame turns blue. *The blue flame shows the future — but the future is always a funeral. The funeral is yours. The Prince’s ghost is in the smoke.* ‘[OMEN]’ ‘[FEAR]’
- Q **Unforgiven Pass’s Toll** — The wind demands a name. Give a name, and the wind will carry it to the oath-breakers. *The oath-breakers will come. They will ask why you spoke their name. The answer must be a verse. The Prince’s name is still on the wind.* ‘[WEATHER]’ ‘[DEBT]’
- K **Silent Smith’s Price** — He offers a sword (a legal document folded into steel). The price is a memory. *He takes it with his tongs. The memory is gone forever. The sword is sharp — for the first cut. The memory he wants is of the Prince’s face.* ‘[CRAFT]’ ‘[TRUTH]’
- A **Buried Archive Opens** — An earthquake cracks the seal of the First Empire’s library. The scrolls are exposed to air. *They begin to crumble. The ghosts of the scribes ask for help. The help must be given before the last scroll turns to dust. The scroll that crumbles first contains the Prince’s true name.* ‘[LEGEND]’ ‘[DEATH]’

(Rose/Tariff/Seal) A dried rose (present to a lord for an audience); caravan tariff receipt (proof of payment, one use to bypass customs); a fire-temple token (right to consult a flame-keeper for one question).

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Fire-Temple Token** — A brass disc. Present it to consult any flame-keeper for one question. *The token is warm. It glows when the answer would get you killed. It is stamped with a rose — the symbol of the resistance.* ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[KNOWLEDGE]’
3. **Caravan Tariff Receipt (Genuine)** — A wax-sealed scroll. Exempts you from tolls in one lord’s territory. *The seal is a pressed rose. The rose is still fresh. It was picked this morning from a bush that grew from the Prince’s ashes.* ‘[TRAVEL]’ ‘[TRADE]’
4. **Royal Seal (On Loan)** — A signet ring borrowed from a minor king. Commands a favour from his court. *The seal is a sleeping lion. The lion wakes when you use it. It will remember you. The lion is the symbol of the pre-Prince dynasty.* ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[AUTHORITY]’
5. **Messenger Tablet (Clay)** — A baked clay tablet. Write a message, and it will appear on its twin tablet in another valley. *The twin was buried with a dead*

- king. His ghost reads your messages. He may reply — often with warnings about the Prince.* ‘[COMMUNICATION]’ ‘[MYSTERY]’
6. **Flame-Keeper’s Coal** — A single coal from the eternal fire. Light it to see one minute into the future. *The coal does not burn your hand. It burns your memory of the past minute instead. It was taken from the ninth brazier. The Prince never touched it.* ‘[MAGIC]’ ‘[OMEN]’
7. **Vintner’s Cask (Wine)** — A bottle of wine from the blind vintner. Drink it to forget a single failure. *The failure is erased from your memory. The wine tastes of tears. You will cry when you drink it. The failure may be the Prince’s — or your own.* ‘[HEALING]’ ‘[MEMORY]’
8. **Poet’s Ninth Verse (Copy)** — A scrap of parchment with the missing verse. Recite it to calm any spirit. *The verse has no rhyme. The spirits prefer it that way. It works once per spirit. The original was burned by the Prince. This copy was made from memory by a child.* ‘[RITUAL]’ ‘[SOCIAL]’
9. **Silent Smith’s Sword (Unedged)** — A legal document folded into steel. Present it in court to win any case. *The sword has no edge. It cuts oaths, not flesh. The judge must read it aloud. The document is the Prince’s own confession, forged by the smith.* ‘[JUSTICE]’ ‘[TRUTH]’
10. **Sun King’s Crown (Bronze)** — A circlet taken from the throne. Wear it to command one valley for a day. *The crown is cold. It warms only when you speak truth. The valley will obey — once. The Prince tried to wear it. The crown burned his brow.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[TRUTH]’
- J Temple Beggar’s Vision** — A prophecy whispered in your ear. Once per session, the GM must answer one yes/no question about the future. *The answer is always true — but always incomplete. The beggar laughs when you realise. He has seen the Prince’s return. He will not tell you when.* ‘[MYSTERY]’ ‘[OMEN]’
- Q Oath-Breaker’s Name** — A single name on a scrap of parchment. Speak it to void one contract. *The contract is voided for both parties. The name is the price. You will owe the oath-breaker a favour. The name is the Prince’s. Speak it and the Hollow will hear.* ‘[DEBT]’ ‘[DEATH]’
- K Archivist’s Blank Book** — A book with blank pages. Write a truth in it, and it becomes law for one day. *The truth must be witnessed. The book is the witness. It will remember. The book was the Prince’s own journal, emptied of his lies.* ‘[JUSTICE]’ ‘[TRUTH]’
- A First Emperor’s Scroll (Buried)** — A scroll from the sealed archive. It contains a lie that became true through repetition. *Once, you may speak the lie aloud. For one hour, it becomes true. Then the scroll crumbles. The lie is about the Prince’s death. It is not a lie anymore.* ‘[LEGEND]’ ‘[MAGIC]’

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (tokens, receipts, seals) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **fire-omens**—flames that burn green, scrolls that ignite without heat, a bridge that recites a verse in a dead language, a coal that glows in the dark.

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **Fire Temples and the Ninth Coal:** Every fire temple keeps a brazier with nine coals. The ninth coal is never lit — it is a promise to the Hollow and a ward against the Prince. Lighting it summons the Debt-Walker — or the Prince’s ghost. Flame-Keepers inherit the secret of which coal is the ninth; it changes with each keeper. The coal is warm to the touch. It should not be.
- **Verse Law:** In Pereshi courts, a well-recited verse carries more weight than a witness. The old epics contain every legal precedent; a litigant who can quote the correct verse wins automatically. The problem is that the epics are incomplete — and the missing verses are hidden in the tombs of forgotten kings. The Prince tried to finish the epic with his own verses. They are still there, in the sealed archive, waiting to be burned.
- **Caravan Tariffs as Currency:** A paid tariff receipt can be traded, sold, or used as proof of credit. The Pereshi have no central bank; the receipt is the coin. Forged receipts are a capital crime — the forger is forced to copy the entire epic by hand, blindfolded. The Prince’s tax collectors were the first to be executed this way.
- **The Prince’s Seal (Forgotten):** In the deepest vault of the archive, sealed in a lead box, is the Prince’s own signet ring. It is said to grant authority over any Pereshi — because it proves the Prince’s claim. No one has opened the box. The key was buried with the last emperor. The ring is still warm.
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
 - **The Undying Flame** — Oath of Flame and Light. *The fire that witnessed the Prince’s defeat and still burns in witness.*
 - **The Keeper of Sealed Names** — The Witness. *The archivist who records what must never be spoken — including the Prince’s true name.*
 - **The Ninth Coal** — The Ninth. *The coal that was never lit; the promise that the Prince will not return.*
 - **The Silent Smith’s Patron** — Mykkiel. *The law folded into steel; the covenant that cannot be broken.*

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **Fire Temples and the Covenant (Mykkiel):** Covenant judges recognise the authority of flame-keepers. A fire-temple token can be used as a witness in a Covenant court — the flame itself is considered an incorruptible witness. The Prince once stood before a Covenant judge. He lied. The flame flickered, but did not burn. The judge was paid.
- **The Ninth Verse and the Ukwe (Sekogo):** The missing verse of the Pereshi epic is said to be carved on the Ukwe’s oldest root. The Lethai-ar know the verse but will not recite it — doing so would call the Hollow. The verse is the Prince’s own confession.
- **Silent Smith’s Swords and the Aeler (Ngomebe):** The silent smiths are said to be descendants of Aeler vent-priors who stayed in the highlands. Their folding technique is a lost art; the Ngomebe masons would pay a fortune for a working forge. The smiths will only trade for a Prince’s relic.
- **The Buried Archive and the Kalrantha Amulet (Dhahara):** The First Emperor’s scrolls contain a description of the amulet’s creation. The Veiled Sisters have been searching for the archive for a century. The party may find it first — or find it already looted. The Prince’s ghost is also looking.

- **The Prince's Ghost (Red Desert Connection):** Some say the Prince did not die. He walked into the Red Desert and became part of it. His ghost haunts the high passes on stormy nights, asking for a cup of water. Do not give it to him. He will ask for your name next.

Pereshi Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Fire:** Crumble a crust into the temple brazier. Ignore the first *Flame Gutters* penalty. '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Knot the Scroll:** Tie a single ribbon around a book you are returning. Cancel *Forged Scroll* or take -1 die on your next legal roll (your choice). '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Name to the Bridge:** Whisper a dead poet's name into the water below. Gain +1 Effect when reciting a verse this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Bridge's spirits. '[SUPERSTITION]'

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **Flame-Keepers** or **archive guards**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **scribes** or **temple beggars**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **lords' spies** or **rival archivists**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time** or **favourable pass conditions**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Local Flame-Keeper** or **lord's guard** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **thin air** or **falling scrolls**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **rival lord's envoy** or a **ghost** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **fire-temple guards**, **clan warriors**, or **angry scribes** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes—**archive burns**/**bridge collapses**/**ninth coal lit**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1**/**Harm 1**/**Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **High Flame-Keeper**, **Shepherd King**, or **First Emperor's ghost** intervenes.

- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically—**temple fire goes out/library collapses/throne cracks**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice—**omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Pereshi (Flame Law):** Coals rearrange themselves, smoke forms words in Old Pereshi, the fire casts no shadow.
- **Pereshi (Verse Law):** Stones echo a verse you never spoke, a line of poetry appears on your palm, a bridge recites your greatest secret.
- **Pereshi (Archive):** Scrolls rustle in still air, ink fades and reappears, a forgotten name is whispered from a shelf.

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Wits + Stealth):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Blind Pass*.
- **Cut the Verse (Presence + Lore):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a fire-temple token is in your possession, +1 die.
- **Weather the Curse (Resolve + Spirit):** On a hit in *Oath-Breaker’s Curse*, you pick who hears the ghost; on a miss, the GM does.

Boss Seeds (Flame & Verse)

- **The Forger of Kings (Nine False Seals)** — *Phases:* Tariff Receipts Counterfeited → Orchestrated Succession Crisis → Archive Coup. *Cracks:* recover a true seal, expose a forged genealogy, survive a recitation of the Ninth Verse.
- **The Drowned Poet (Bridge’s Toll)** — *Phases:* Missing Verses Demanded → Procession of Broken Bridges → Flame-Baptism of a Lord. *Cracks:* relic scroll fragment, survivor testimony, the bridge reciting the poet’s true name.
- **The Prince’s Shadow (Ghost of the Forgotten)** — *Phases:* Whispers in the Archive → The Ninth Coal Glows → The Hollow Gate Opens. *Cracks:* speak the Prince’s true name (recorded in the First Emperor’s scroll), extinguish the ninth coal with water from the Well of Ancestors, or convince a Flame-Keeper to light the coal and banish him with fire.

Patronage & Power

Among the Pereshi, power flows through fire, ink, and the weight of ancient witness. A lord's authority rests on the age of his library; a flame-keeper's influence on the purity of her fire. The petty kings are constantly forging genealogies, and the archivists are constantly exposing them. Power is not inherited — it is cited, and it is witnessed by the flame.

For the GM: Power in Pereshi society is measured in scrolls, coals, and the memory of the flame. Patronage often takes the form of fire-temple tokens, tariff receipts, or royal seals — each tied to a specific lord, a specific temple, a specific debt. To emphasize the post-colonial witness:

- Tie rewards to physical tokens (coals, seals, scrolls) that can be challenged, stolen, or declared forgeries — especially tokens that bear the Prince's mark.
- Let rival lords issue conflicting tariff receipts, forcing players to choose whose toll to pay — and whose memory of the Prince to honour.
- Use the fire temples, libraries, and bridges as arenas for social contests, where a well-recited verse is a weapon and a forgotten name is a death sentence. The Prince's name is the most dangerous of all.
- Introduce the Prince's ghost as a recurring omen — not a combat encounter, but a presence that asks questions and demands witness.

In Pereshi society, the fire forgets nothing — and the books remember every mistake, every resistance, and the name of the conqueror who tried to burn them.

Chapter 27

Kuvani

The Remount Steppe.

The grass does not belong to us. We belong to the grass. It tells us where to ride, when to move, how long to stay. A clan that forgets the grass's song is a clan that will be buried by it. I do not sing to the wind. I listen. The wind sings through me.

I am a Remount Master. A horse's name is its lineage. Its lineage is its debt. You do not ride a Kuvani horse. You borrow it. And when you return it, you will tell me a story that the horse has not already heard. If you lie, the horse will throw you next time.

Horses, grass, and wind-songs—the Kuvani don't just pay in stories; they auction the right to the next remount. They range across the eastern steppe, a vast grassland east of the Valewood. Their horsemanship and remount stations make them indispensable to any caravan that crosses the open plain. The Kuvani have no cities; their courts are circles of saddles, and their laws are sung. But here's the secret the Wind-Singers don't want you to know: the sky is not empty. Kuva, the sky father, sees everything—every oath sworn in the open, every horse born, every blade of grass bent by the wind. But Kuva does not speak. He listens. And he is patient. The Kuvani have no temples because the sky is their shrine. Their dead are not buried; they are given to the sky on funeral platforms, that Kuva may carry their souls to the ancestral herd that rides the northern lights.

A horse is not a mount—it is a relative. Its name is a lineage stretching back to the first mare that Kuva breathed life into. A Kuvani who cannot name his horse's ancestors is a Kuvani without a shadow. The steppe is not empty; it is full of ghosts: the ghost herd of the salt pan, the sky-road markers

that hum at dusk, the Iron Corral where blades whisper the names of the dead.

Never ride a Kuvani horse without asking its name. The horse will answer—by throwing you. If it throws you, you have insulted its lineage.

— *Alp Arslan, Remount Master, who has never been seen sleeping*

The Almanac of Ordinary Days

What do people eat for breakfast? Fermented mare's milk and dried meat—the milk is from the herd, the meat is from the hunt. The hunt is a ceremony. The ceremony is a debt to the grass.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To ride. Kuvani children are placed on a horse before they can stand. The horse is patient. The horse is old. The horse remembers the child's grandfather. The grandfather taught the horse to ride.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their saddle. A stranger whose saddle is worn has ridden many miles. A stranger whose saddle is new has many miles ahead. A stranger who carries no saddle is a ghost. Ghosts do not need saddles.

What is the most common crime? Horse theft—but horse theft is not a crime, it is a declaration of feud. The horse is family. A stolen horse is a stolen relative. The feud lasts until the horse is returned or the thief's line is ended. The feud never ends.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The ghost herd is not a legend. It is real—a herd of spectral horses that rides the salt pan on moonless nights. The horses are the souls of riders who died without honour. They ride forever, searching for a battle that will never come.

Where do people go when they die? To the sky. The dead are placed on funeral platforms, wrapped in felt. The birds take the flesh. The wind takes the bones. The sky takes the soul. The soul joins the ancestral herd. The herd rides the northern lights.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You offer a horse—the best horse in your herd. The horse is given to the wronged party. If they accept, the debt is paid. If they refuse, the debt is doubled. If they kill the horse, the debt is blood. Blood is never repaid.

What is the most important festival? The Ride of the Ancestors (autumn equinox). The clans ride to the salt pan. The ghost herd appears at midnight. The living ride with the dead. The dead remember their names. The living remember theirs.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Khagan's horse is a ghost. It was killed in battle twenty years ago. The Khagan does not know. He rides a skeleton wrapped in hide. The horse does not tire. The horse does not eat. The horse does not forgive.

27.1 Kuvani — “The Remount Steppe”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *The sky hears every oath. The grass remembers every step.*

Wind-Singer (Elite): “Kuva watches from the blue. He does not speak. He listens. A promise made under open sky is carved into the wind itself. The grass will bend around it. The horses will remember it. Break it, and the sky will turn its face away. You will ride forever in shadow.”

Remount Master (Commoner): “A horse’s name is its lineage. Its lineage is its story. You do not ride a Kuvani horse. You borrow it. And when you return it, you will tell me a story that the horse has not already heard. If you lie, the horse will throw you next time — and Kuva will laugh.”

Genre / Mood: Sky-worshipping nomads, ancestral horse-magic, wind-carried oaths.

Starting Location: A felt tent circle at a remount station, where a corral of horses stands behind a rope of braided hair. A Remount Master sits on a saddle, a bell in his hand: “You need fresh horses. I have twelve. Each horse has a name. Each name has a price. The price is not silver — it is a story I have not heard. Tell me one. If it makes me laugh, you ride for free. If it makes me weep, you owe me a foal. If Kuva sends a hawk to watch, you owe a prayer.”

Theme & Atmosphere

The Kuvani ride the eastern steppe beneath the Eternal Blue Sky. Kuva, the sky father, sees all: every oath sworn in the open, every horse born, every blade of grass bent by the wind. The Kuvani have no temples — the sky is their shrine. Their shamans, called Wind-Singers, read the future in the flight of hawks and the whisper of grass. Their dead are not buried; they are given to the sky on funeral platforms, that Kuva may carry their souls to the ancestral herd that rides the northern lights.

Unlike their Ykrul neighbours, who worship geometry and oath-strings, the Kuvani worship movement itself. A horse is not a mount — it is a relative. Its name is a lineage stretching back to the first mare that Kuva breathed life into. A Kuvani who cannot name his horse’s ancestors is a Kuvani without a shadow. The steppe is not empty; it is full of ghosts: the ghost herd of the salt pan, the sky-road markers that hum at dusk, the Iron Corral where blades whisper the names of the dead. A Kuvani does not fight for land — he fights for grazing rights, for the memory of grass, for the honour of his horse’s line.

What you notice first: The smell of horse sweat and dry grass. The way every rider touches a small felt bundle at their belt — a piece of a dead horse’s mane, a prayer to Kuva. The constant sound of bells on harnesses, each tone a different ancestor’s name.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never ride a Kuvani horse without asking its name. The horse will answer — by throwing you. If it throws you, you have insulted its lineage. The remount master will demand a story as compensation. If the story is not good enough, you walk — and Kuva will turn the wind against you.

Regional Mood: The Weight of the Herd

Power here is measured in remount chains, grazing compacts, and the favour of Kuva. A clan's status depends on the number of horses it can offer to caravans; a remount master's reputation on the speed and health of his string. The Kuvani have no kings — only Wind-Singers, who speak for the sky, and Remount Masters, who hold the earthly ledger of horse-flesh. Every caravan that crosses the steppe must pay the remount toll: not in coin, but in stories. The Kuvani believe that a story shared is a prayer heard, and that a traveller who has no story has no soul — only an empty shape that the wind will soon erase.

Prominent NPCs of the Kuvani

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Alp Arslan	Remount master of the central route	Expand grazing rights into Ykrul territory	He has never been seen sleeping; his eyes are always on the horizon, watching for Kuva's hawks.
Borte	Wind-Singer of the White Mane Clan	Keep the songs of the clans from being forgotten	She has a horse with a white blaze; the blaze is a map of the steppe, and it shifts each season.
Temur	Caravan guide	Find the fastest routes through the shifting grass	He names his dogs after dead enemies. The dogs remember. They growl when the enemy's ghost is near.
Seljuk	Ykrul envoy (negotiator)	Negotiate shared pastures without war	He carries a hostage string with nine knots; each knot is a season of peace. He is running out of knots.

The Grass Reader	A hermit who lives in a felt hut	Read the future in the way the grass bends	He never speaks above a whisper. The grass speaks for him. His tongue is green.
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Names of the Kuvani

Inspired by Turkic and Mongolian traditions: short, hard consonants, vowel clusters, patronymic suffixes (-oglu, -ova). Surnames denote a clan, a horse-line, or a wind-name.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Alp	Borte	Arslanoglu	<i>the Iron Rein</i>
Temur	Selin	Kuvani-bek	<i>the White Mane</i>
Seljuk	Chagatai	Borjigin	<i>Ninth Wind</i>
Batu	Nergui	Oirat	<i>the Grass-Tongue</i>
Toghrul	Otgon	Kipchak	<i>the Remount-Keeper</i>

(**Station/Circle/Kurgan**) Remount station with a felt tent and a corral; Wind-Singer’s circle of saddles; a kurgan (burial mound) with a stone horse that is missing a leg.

Spades — Places

2. **Remount Station** — A felt tent with a corral; horses for hire. The horses have no names — only brands. *The brands are the names of lost children. The horses remember them. Kuva’s hawks circle when a brand is new.* ‘[TRADE]’
3. **Wind-Singer’s Circle** — A ring of saddles; the singer sits in the centre. The songs are not sung — they are hummed. *The hum is the wind. The wind carries the song to the next valley. The next valley answers with a hawk’s cry.* ‘[RITUAL]’
4. **Kurgan of the Broken Oath** — A burial mound with a stone horse missing a leg. *The leg is a treaty. The treaty was broken. The horse is waiting for it to be returned. Its eye follows you.* ‘[DEATH]’
5. **Grass Maze** — A section of the steppe where the grass grows taller than a rider on horseback. *The paths shift with the wind. Only a Wind-Singer can find the way out. The grass whispers warnings.* ‘[MYSTERY]’
6. **Salt Pan of the Ghost Herd** — A dry lake; the salt is crusted with hoofprints. *The prints are from a herd that died a century ago. They appear every spring. The herd is still running. Kuva’s hawks do not fly over it.* ‘[DEATH]’
7. **Felt Village (Mobile)** — A temporary camp of round tents. The tents face the wind. *The wind is the clan’s direction. If the wind changes, the village moves. The door always faces the rising sun.* ‘[COMMUNITY]’

8. **Horse Cemetery** — A field of skulls, each on a wooden stake. The stakes are carved with names. *The names are the riders' names. The riders are buried elsewhere. The horses wait. Their skulls whicker at dawn.* '[DEATH]'
9. **Bridge of the Ninth Hardship** — A log over a ravine. The log is replaced each year. The old log is burned. *The ash is the clan's memory. The ash is scattered on the spring grass. Kuva drinks the smoke.* '[RITUAL]'
10. **Stone of the Hostage String** — A standing stone with notches. Each notch is a hostage taken. *The hostages are carved into the stone. The stone weeps when a hostage dies. The tears taste of salt and iron.* '[DEBT]'
- J **The Iron Corral** — A pen made of salvaged sword blades. The blades are from a war that never ended. *The horses are afraid of them. The blades whisper the names of the dead. The whisper is the wind.* '[MAGIC]'
- Q **Sky-Road Marker** — A cairn painted blue. The blue is from a stone that fell from the sky. *The stone is still warm. It marks the path of the summer stars. Touch it, and you will dream of falling.* '[TRAVEL]'
- K **Khagan's Felt Throne** — A tent within a tent; the seat is a saddle. The saddle has no stirrups. *The Khagan does not need them. He rides the wind. The wind has no stirrups. The saddle was his grandfather's.* '[AUTHORITY]'
- A **The Steppe's Edge** — Where the grass ends and the desert begins. The line is a scar. *The scar is a treaty. The treaty was signed in blood. The blood was Kuvani. Kuva turned his face away that day.* '[LEGEND]'

(Master/Singer/Guide) Remount master with calloused hands and a horsehair whip; Wind-Singer with grey hair and a bone flute; caravan guide with a string of dog teeth.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Remount Master** — Calloused hands, squinting eyes, a whip of braided horsehair. *He knows the price of a horse in salt, in silk, or in stories. The price changes with the wind. He has never been cheated.* '[TRADE]'
3. **Wind-Singer (Shaman)** — Grey-haired, blind, but never lost. She hums the direction to the nearest water. *The hum changes with the wind. If she stops humming, the wind stops too. Her left eye sees the living; her right sees the dead.* '[RITUAL]'
4. **Caravan Guide (Temur)** — Young, fast, a scar across his lip. He names his dogs after dead enemies. *The dogs remember. They growl when they smell the enemy's kin. The dogs also see ghosts.* '[TRAVEL]'
5. **Ykrul Envoy (Seljuk)** — Braided hair, a hostage string on his wrist. The string has nine knots. *Each knot is a season of peace. He is running out of knots. The last knot is tied with a hair from a Khagan's daughter.* '[POLITICS]'
6. **Grass Reader (Hermit)** — A hermit in a felt hut, never seen without a handful of grass. *He reads the future by how the grass bends. The future is always wind. He has never been wrong.* '[DIVINATION]'
7. **Horse Thief** — Young, missing two fingers. The fingers were a bet. He lost the bet — but not the horses. *He can steal a horse from a corral without waking the dogs. The dogs are his. He paid for them with a story.* '[STEALTH]'

8. **Felt Village Elder** — A woman with a pipe made of bone. She settles disputes by listening to the wind. *“The wind says you are lying,” she says. The wind has never been wrong. The pipe belonged to her grandmother.* ‘[JUSTICE]’
9. **Khagan’s Shadow** — A silent figure in black felt. He never speaks; he writes commands in the dust. *The dust blows away. The commands are remembered anyway. His face is never seen.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
10. **Horse-Whisperer (Child)** — A child who can calm any stallion. The child speaks in neighs. *The horses answer in riddles. The child is learning to understand. One day, a horse will answer with a name.* ‘[MYSTERY]’
- J **Ghost Herd’s Rider** — A translucent figure on a skeletal horse, seen at the salt pan at dawn. *He asks: “Where is my herd?” If you answer, you become part of it. If you refuse, he follows you for nine days.* ‘[DEATH]’
- Q **The Steppe’s Voice (Oracle)** — A rock with a crack. The wind speaks through it. *The wind answers questions. The answers are always poems. The poems are always warnings. The rock is warm.* ‘[DIVINATION]’
- K **The Last Khagan (Legend)** — A king who united the clans, then rode into a storm and never returned. *He is said to appear during the worst blizzards, offering shelter. The shelter is a trap. His horse has no shadow.* ‘[LEGEND]’
- A **The First Remount (Myth)** — A horse that never tired. Its bones are scattered across the steppe. *Find all nine bones, and you can summon it. The summoning costs a year of your life. The horse will remember your name.* ‘[MYTH]’

(Sickness/Fire/Stampede) A horse sickness spreads through the remounts — all mounts lose 1 Speed; grass fire — the smoke spells a name; a wild horse stampede — the horses are fleeing something worse.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Horse Sickness (Curse)** — A cough spreads through the remounts. The cough is a curse from a Ykrul bone-singer. *The cure is a story that the bone-singer has not heard. The story must be true. Kuva’s hawks will judge.* ‘[CURSE]’
3. **Grass Fire** — The steppe burns; the smoke is black. The smoke spells a name. *The name is the one who lit the fire. The wind will carry the name to the clans. They will hunt. The name also appears in your dreams.* ‘[DISASTER]’
4. **Stampede (Wild Herd)** — A herd of wild horses crashes through camp. The horses are not wild. *They are fleeing something worse. Something that hunts horses. The party is in its path. The ground shakes.* ‘[COMBAT]’
5. **Hostage String Cut** — A Ykrul envoy’s string is broken. The clan demands a new hostage. *The party must choose a member to offer. The hostage will be held for nine seasons. Kuva will witness the oath.* ‘[DEBT]’
6. **Rasputitsa (Mud)** — The spring thaw turns the steppe to mud. Wagons sink. Progress slows. *The mud is warm. Something is buried underneath. It is waking up. The mud smells of old blood.* ‘[WEATHER]’
7. **Wind-Singer’s Silence** — The Wind-Singer stops humming. The wind stops too. The silence is a warning. *The warning is: “A storm is coming. Not of rain — of ghosts.” The ghosts are the unburied.* ‘[DEATH]’

8. **Water Poisoned (Salt Pan)** — A well is found with dead animals nearby. The poison is salt from the cursed pan. *The salt pan wants a sacrifice. The sacrifice is a horse. The horse must be willing. The horse will neigh its acceptance.* ‘[CURSE]’
9. **Felt Village Gone** — A camp is empty; the tents are still standing. The felt is warm. *The people vanished at noon. The horses are still in the corral. The horses are trembling. Their eyes are white.* ‘[MYSTERY]’
10. **Khagan’s Demand** — The Khagan (or his shadow) asks for a tribute. The tribute is a story. *The story must be about a broken promise. If it is not good enough, the Khagan takes a horse. The horse will never be seen again.* ‘[DEBT]’
- J **Iron Corral Bleeding** — The sword-blade fence begins to weep rust. The rust is blood. *The blood is from the war that never ended. The war is about to resume. The blades are warm.* ‘[OMEN]’
- Q **Sky-Road Marker Falls** — The blue cairn collapses. The stone inside is a meteor. It whispers. *The whisper is a prophecy. The prophecy is about the end of the steppe. The stone is cold.* ‘[OMEN]’
- K **Ghost Herd Charges** — Spectral horses trample the camp. They are looking for their riders. *The riders are dead. The ghosts do not know. One rider’s ghost is in your party. It does not know it is dead.* ‘[DEATH]’
- A **Steppe’s Edge Recedes** — The grass grows into the desert. The desert is retreating. *Something is driving the desert back. Something that wants the steppe. Kuva is silent.* ‘[APOCALYPSE]’

(**Mark/Compact/Song**) Remount chain mark (a horse’s tooth, exchange for a fresh mount); grazing compact (a sheepskin document, safe passage on clan land); sky-road song (a melody on a bone flute, navigate any storm).

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Remount Chain Mark** — A horse’s tooth on a leather thong. Exchange it for a fresh mount at any Kuvani station. *The tooth is from a horse that died in battle. Its spirit runs with the new mount. The new mount will be braver.* ‘[TRAVEL]’
3. **Grazing Compact (Sheepskin)** — A written agreement. Allows your caravan to pasture on clan land for one season. *The compact is sealed with horsehair. The hair is from the Khagan’s own mare. Break the seal, and the mare will know.* ‘[TRADE]’
4. **Sky-Road Song (Bone Flute)** — A melody recorded on a flute. Play it to navigate any storm. *The flute was carved from a rib. The rib was the Wind-Singer’s. She gave it willingly. The flute is warm.* ‘[TRAVEL]’
5. **Hostage String (Borrowed)** — A braided cord with knots. Present it to demand a truce from a Ykrul clan. *The string is hair. The hair is from a Khagan’s daughter. The Ykrul will recognise it. They will honour it. Once.* ‘[SOCIAL]’
6. **Felt Tent Pass** — A felt circle with a hole. Safe lodging in any Kuvani camp. *The hole is for smoke. The smoke is your story. The clan will listen. If they laugh, you stay. If they weep, you owe a foal.* ‘[SOCIAL]’
7. **Kurgan Key (Stone Tablet)** — A flat stone. Opens the Horse Cemetery gate. *The gate is a skull. The key fits the eye socket. The skull will scream. The scream is a name — the name of the horse you must bury.* ‘[MAGIC]’

8. **Iron Corral Nail** — One sword blade from the fence. Use it to seal an oath. *The blade is rusty. The rust is from broken promises. It will rust your oath too. Speak true, or bleed.* ‘[OATH]’
9. **Sky-Road Stone (Chip)** — A piece of the blue cairn. Carry it to avoid getting lost on the steppe. *The stone is warm. It points to the north. The north is where the grass is greenest. The stone hums at dawn.* ‘[TRAVEL]’
10. **Khagan’s Whistle (Horse Phalange)** — A brass whistle. Blow it to summon a remount from any station. *The whistle is a horse’s toe bone. The horse was the Khagan’s favourite. It will come — but only once.* ‘[MAGIC]’
- J **Ghost Herd’s Bridle (Leather)** — A strap of old leather. Use it to command one spirit horse. *The bridle is from a horse that drowned in the salt pan. The spirit is still wet. It will carry you across water.* ‘[DEATH]’
- Q **Wind-Singer’s Staff (Tent Pole)** — A wooden rod. Plant it to stop the wind for one hour. *The staff was a tent pole. The tent was the singer’s home. The home is gone. The wind will listen — for one hour.* ‘[WEATHER]’
- K **Khagan’s Saddle (Felt Pad)** — Ride in it to gain +1 Position on all mounted rolls. *The saddle has no stirrups. You must learn to ride without them. The Khagan did. His ghost rides behind you.* ‘[COMBAT]’
- A **Steppe’s Edge Stone** — A piece of the boundary where grass meets desert. Touch it to make the grass grow. *The stone is a tooth. The tooth is from the Steppe itself. The Steppe is hungry. The grass will grow — but it will be thirsty.* ‘[LEGEND]’

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (marks, compacts, flutes) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **sky-omens**—hawks that circle counter-clockwise, grass that bends against the wind, a bell that rings without being struck, a shadow that falls where no sun shines.

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **The Story Toll:** Kuvani remount stations do not accept coin. To take a fresh horse, you must tell a story that the remount master has not heard. The story is judged by the horse — if the horse stamps its foot, the story is false. If it whinnies, the story is true. If it remains still, the story is boring — you walk. Kuva’s hawks watch; a hawk’s cry means the story is worthy of the sky.
- **Wind-Songs and Sky-Roads:** The Kuvani navigate by the stars and the wind. A Wind-Singer can hum a melody that encodes the route to water, to grass, or to safety. The song changes with the season. Only the singer knows the current melody. Those who hear the song without permission are cursed — they will hear it in their dreams until they pay a horse to the singer.
- **Grazing Compacts as Currency:** A grazing compact (a sheepskin document sealed with horsehair) can be traded, sold, or used as proof of passage. A compact from a powerful clan is

worth more than a chest of silver. Forging a compact is punishable by exile — the forger is left on the steppe without a horse. Kuva will not watch over them.

- **Kuva's Witness (Oath Mechanic):** Any oath sworn under open sky (no roof, no canopy) is witnessed by Kuva. Breaking such an oath imposes 1 die on all rolls until the oath is fulfilled or atoned for by a sacrifice: a horse, a memory, or a year of service to the wronged party. The GM may also tick a **Kuva's Attention [6]** clock; when full, a sky-omen (drought, storm, ghost herd) strikes the oath-breaker.
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
 - **Kuva** — The Eternal Blue Sky. *The witness of all oaths, the father of horses, the wind that carries prayers.*
 - **The White Mare** — The Traveler. *The first horse, who showed the Kuvani the sky-road. Her hoofprints are the stars.*
 - **The Iron Hoof** — Khemesh. *The pressure beneath the steppe; the hunger that pulls horses down into the salt pan.*
 - **The Shadow Khagan** — Malachai. *A cursed king who sold his clan's horses for immortality; he rides alone, and his horses have no shadows.*

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **Remount Chains and the Caravan Trade (Way of Silk):** Every major caravan on the eastern route uses Kuvani remount stations. A disruption in the remount chain — a sickness, a feud, a stolen horse — can halt trade for an entire season. The Tulkani have a saying: "A Kuvani horse is worth nine stories. A dead Kuvani horse is worth nine feuds."
- **Grazing Compacts and the Ykrul:** The Ykrul are the Kuvani's rivals and sometimes allies. A grazing compact with a Kuvani clan may require a Ykrul hostage string as surety. Breaking the compact means the hostage is executed — and Kuva will turn his face from the oath-breaker. The Ykrul do not fear Kuva, but they respect his silence.
- **Wind-Singers and the Sky (Kuva):** The Kuvani worship Kuva as the watcher of oaths. Their wind-songs are prayers to the sky. A Wind-Singer who loses her voice is considered cursed by Kuva; she must walk the steppe alone until she hears the sky again. Some never return; their bones become sky-road markers.
- **The Ghost Herd and the Hollow (Eastern Realms):** The ghost herd at the salt pan is said to be the Hollow's own horses — ridden by the Debt-Walkers. Aelaerem leave offerings of salt to keep the herd from riding through their villages. The Kuvani avoid the salt pan entirely. They say the ghost herd is Kuva's punishment for a Khagan who broke an oath to the sky.
- **The Iron Corral and the Black Banners:** The sword blades of the Iron Corral are from a war that never ended — a condotta that was paid twice, first in coin, then in blood. The Black Banner captains know the story; they leave offerings of rust at the corral when they pass. A captain who refuses to pay finds his horses spooked and his supply lines cut.

Kuvani Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Horses:** Crumble a crust into the corral. Ignore the first *Horse Sickness* penalty. Kuva's hawks will watch but not strike.
- **Knot the Hostage String:** Tie a new knot in a borrowed string. Cancel *Hostage String Cut* or take –1 die on your next negotiation with Ykrul (your choice). The knot must be tied

while facing the rising sun.

- **Name to the Wind:** Whisper a dead horse’s name into the grass. Gain +1 Effect when riding this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Wind-Singer. The wind will carry the name to Kuva. He may answer with a storm.

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **Remount Masters or Wind-Singers**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **herdsmen or felt village guards**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **rival clans or ghost herd scouts**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favourable grazing access**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Local Remount Master or Wind-Singer** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **grass fire or sudden fog**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **rival clan rider or Ykrul envoy** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **Kuvani riders, Ykrul warriors, or ghost herd** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes—**water poisoned/hostage string cut/khagan’s demand issued**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **Khagan, Wind-Singer of the White Mane, or Ghost Herd’s Rider** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically—**steppe catches fire/salt pan floods/sky-road marker falls**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice—**omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Kuvani (Remount Law):** Horse bells ring out of sequence, saddle leather creaks a warning, a horse refuses to move.
- **Kuvani (Wind-Song):** Grass whispers a name, the wind stops mid-sentence, a bone flute plays itself.
- **Kuvani (Ghost Herd):** Hoofprints appear where there are no horses, salt tastes of blood, a skeletal horse watches from the horizon.

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Wits + Ride):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Wind at Back*.
- **Cut the Herd (Presence + Sway):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a remount chain mark is in your possession, +1 die.
- **Weather the Curse (Resolve + Spirit):** On a hit in *Horse Sickness*, you pick which mount survives; on a miss, the GM does.

Boss Seeds (Hoof & Wind)

- **The Bone-Singer (Nine Plagues)** — *Phases:* Horse Sickness Spread → Orchestrated Famine → Herd Coup. *Cracks:* find a true story the bone-singer has not heard, expose a false cure, survive a stampede. *Kuva's Judgment:* if the party swears an oath to end the sickness under open sky, the bone-singer loses one phase.
- **The Storm Khagan (Rider of the White Blizzard)** — *Phases:* Grass Fires Called Mercy → Procession of Empty Saddles → Wind-Baptism of a Remount Master. *Cracks:* relic wind-song, survivor testimony, the sky-road turning against them. *Kuva's Favour:* if a party member offers their own horse to the sky (releasing it onto the steppe), the Storm Khagan must pause for one exchange.

Patronage & Power

Among the Kuvani, power flows through remount chains, wind-songs, and the truth of a story. A clan’s authority rests on the speed of its horses and the skill of its singers. The Khagan is a figurehead; the real power lies with the Remount Masters who control the stations, and the Wind-Singers who read the grass — and Kuva’s will.

For the GM: Power in Kuvani society is measured in horse teeth, sheepskin compacts, and the memory of a good story. Patronage often takes the form of remount marks, grazing compacts, or bone flutes — each tied to a specific station, clan, or singer. To emphasize the itinerant and sky-worshipping culture:

- Require players to **tell a story** to access remounts, shelter, or grazing rights. The GM can judge the story’s quality (or have the player roll Presence + Sway vs. DV based on the remount master’s mood). A failed story means the player must offer a truth — a secret, a confession, or a memory — to Kuva directly (speak it aloud under open sky).
- Use **Wind-Singers** as quest-givers and as intermediaries with Kuva. They hear songs on the wind that only the party can resolve. The song is always a warning or a debt call, and often a prophecy.
- Let **grazing compacts** be a form of currency that can be stolen, forged, or voided. A party without a compact is trespassing — the clans can demand a story as payment, or seize a horse as collateral. A compact sealed with a hair from the Khagan’s mare is unbreakable without divine intervention.
- Emphasize that **the steppe is alive and Kuva watches**: the grass remembers, the wind listens, and a broken promise is written in the sky-road. The Hollow’s attention ticks when the party lies to a Kuvani. Kuva’s attention ticks when they break an oath sworn under open sky.
- Use **sky-omens** as scene-setting tools: a hawk’s cry, a sudden stillness, a cloud shaped like a horse. These can foreshadow complications or reward truthful behaviour.

In Kuvani society, the grass forgets nothing — and Kuva’s sky remembers every word spoken in the open.

Chapter 28

Tulkani

The Itinerant Courts.

The road does not forgive a debt. It only reschedules it. A promise spoken under the open sky is witnessed by the wind, the grass, and the wheels of every cart that passes. I do not write judgments. I tie knots. The knots remember. When you are ready to pay, untie one. If you are not ready, tie another.

I am a Wagon-Keeper. My wagon is my hearth, my court, my grave. The Hollow cannot cross the circle of wheels unless invited. The tax collector cannot enter without a story. The lord cannot demand rent unless we camp on his land for nine nights. On the eighth night, we leave. That is the law.

The Tulkani have no fixed homeland; they are wanderers who follow the seasons and the trade routes. Their wagons are their hearths, their circles are their courts, and their knots are their ledgers. They are welcome everywhere and trusted nowhere—a position they wear with wry humour. They spread the cult of Ikasha—She Who Sleeps—not through temples, but through dream-cords tied in the dark. But here's the secret the Caravan Judges don't want you to know: the knots are not just records. They are alive. A knot tied in false witness will tighten until blood is drawn. A cord cut in anger will become a ghost that follows the oath-breaker until the promise is fulfilled. And the ninth knot—the one that is never tied—is the space where the Hollow waits.

The Tulkani have no king, no judges, no written law—only the Caravan Circle, where disputes are settled by storytelling. A liar is exposed not by evidence but by the knots on his cord. Ikasha's cult is not a religion; it is a survival tactic—the dream inside the wagon, the whisper in the creaking wheel. The Tulkani pay no permanent taxes, but they pay tolls in stories. A

lord who demands coin will be told a story so boring that his crops fail. A lord who offers hospitality will be told a story so beautiful that his harvest doubles. The Tulkani do not track debts; they track reciprocity. What you give, you get back—maybe tomorrow, maybe in the next valley. But the circle remembers.

Never sleep outside the circle at night. The wagon ring is sanctuary. Outside it, the Hollow walks. A Tulkani will not rescue you—they will only mourn you at dawn.

— *Elder Sarnai, Caravan Judge of the Nine Knots, whose cord drags on the ground*

The Almanac of Ordinary Days

What do people eat for breakfast? Tea and hardtack—the tea is brewed from leaves gathered along the road, the hardtack is baked at the start of the season and lasts until the snow. The hardtack is always stale. The tea is always fresh. The contradiction is a lesson.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To tie a knot. Tulkani children are taught the eight journey-knots: Departure, Arrival, Promise, Debt, Payment, Witness, Apology, and the ninth—the knot that is never tied. The ninth knot is for the Hollow. The Hollow is not a creditor. The Hollow is a reminder.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their cord. Every Tulkani carries a knotted cord—their life's ledger. A stranger whose cord has many knots has traveled far. A stranger whose cord has few knots has just begun. A stranger with no cord is a ghost. Ghosts do not travel. Ghosts wait.

What is the most common crime? Story-theft—but story-theft is not a crime, it is a compliment. A stolen story is a story worth telling. The original teller is honoured. The thief is welcomed. The story grows with each telling. The story never dies.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Tulkani are not wanderers by choice. They were exiled from their homeland nine centuries ago, for a crime that no one remembers. The crime is written in the ninth knot of the Elder's cord. The Elder's cord is too long to read. The Elder's cord drags on the ground.

Where do people go when they die? To the road. The dead are not buried. Their bodies are left at a crossroads. The road takes them. The road carries them to the next valley, the next camp, the next telling. The dead become stories. Stories are immortal.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You untie a knot—one knot from your cord, chosen by the wronged party. The knot is burned. The ash is scattered on the wind. If the wind blows toward the wronged party, you are forgiven. If it blows away, you are not. If it is still, the Hollow has accepted your apology. The Hollow's acceptance is a warning.

What is the most important festival? The Tying of the New Cord (new year). Every Tulkani receives a new cord, unknotted. The old cord is burned. The ash is mixed with water and drunk. The drink tastes of memory. The memory is the year that has passed. The year is never forgotten.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Tulkani are not wanderers. They are pilgrims—walking toward a destination that no longer exists. Their homeland was swallowed by the desert. The desert is still hungry. The Tulkani are still walking. They will never arrive.

28.1 Tulkani — “The Itinerant Courts”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *The knot remembers. The story pays. The circle holds.*

Caravan Judge (Elite): “The road does not forgive a debt. It only reschedules it. A promise spoken under the open sky is witnessed by the wind, the grass, and the wheels of every cart that passes. I do not write judgments. I tie knots. The knots remember. When you are ready to pay, untie one. If you are not ready, tie another.”

Wagon-Keeper (Commoner): “My wagon is my hearth, my court, my grave. The Hollow cannot cross the circle of wheels unless invited. The tax collector cannot enter without a story. The lord cannot demand rent unless we camp on his land for nine nights. On the eighth night, we leave. That is the law.”

Genre / Mood: Itinerant community, story-driven justice, folk horror at the edge of the Hollow.

Starting Location: A wagon circle at a crossroads, where nine painted wagons form a ring. A Caravan Judge sits on an overturned barrel, a knotted cord in her hand. “You are standing on ground that belongs to the lord of the eastern valley. He will be here at dawn to demand rent. But you are in the circle. You are safe until the ninth hour. Tell me a story — a true one — and I will tell you how to leave before the lord arrives.”

Theme & Atmosphere

The Tulkani have no fixed homeland; they are wanderers who follow the seasons and the trade routes. Their wagons are their hearths, their circles are their courts, and their knots are their ledgers. They are welcome everywhere and trusted nowhere — a position they wear with wry humour. A Tulkani caravan can appear at a lord’s border, camp for seven nights, and leave before the eighth — because on the eighth night, the lord can demand rent. On the ninth night, the Hollow comes. The Tulkani never stay nine nights in one place. Their courts are circles of wagons; their judges are elders who carry braided cords. Each knot is a vow, a story, or a favour owed — but never merely a debt. They spread the cult of Ikasha — She Who Sleeps — not through temples, but through dream-cords tied in the dark. Their neutrality is sacred: a Tulkani camp is sanctuary for any traveller, regardless of allegiance, as long as they respect the circle and offer a story when asked.

What you notice first: The smell of woodsmoke and cooking oil. The painted wheels of wagons arranged in a circle, each wheel a different colour. The way everyone touches a knotted cord before speaking of an obligation.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never sleep outside the circle at night. The wagon ring is sanctuary. Outside it, the Hollow walks. A Tulkani will not rescue you — they will only mourn you at dawn.

Regional Mood: The Weight of the Knot

Power here is measured in vow-cords, story-credits, and the number of nights camped on a lord’s land. The Tulkani have no king, no judges, no written law — only the Caravan Circle, where disputes are settled by storytelling. A liar is exposed not by evidence but by the knots on his cord:

if a knot is tied in false witness, it will tighten until blood is drawn. Ikasha’s cult is not a religion; it is a survival tactic — the dream inside the wagon, the whisper in the creaking wheel. The Tulkani pay no permanent taxes, but they pay tolls in stories. A lord who demands coin will be told a story so boring that his crops fail. A lord who offers hospitality will be told a story so beautiful that his harvest doubles. The Tulkani do not track debts; they track **reciprocity**. What you give, you get back — maybe tomorrow, maybe in the next valley. But the circle remembers.

Prominent NPCs of the Tulkani

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Elder Sarnai	Caravan Judge of the Nine Knots	Keep the circle whole	She ties a knot for every judgment; her cord drags on the ground.
Temur Wagon-Keeper	Master of the painted wheel	Find new grazing ground before the ninth night	He paints a new colour on his wagon each season; the colours are memories.
Gulshat	Story-Seller	Spread the dream of Ikasha through tales	She carries a dream-cord with nine knots; the ninth knot is loose.
The Knife (Unnamed)	Ikasha’s agent	Free a spirit bound by the Veiled Sisters	He wears a mask made of knotted cord; he has no face underneath.
Vow-Broken	An exile who cut his own cord	Earn back his place in the circle	He carries a single knot tied in his own hair; the knot is his promise to return.

Names of the Tulkani

Inspired by the nomadic traditions of the steppe and desert: short, guttural, with honorifics and clan prefixes. Surnames are often replaced by epithets describing a deed or a cord.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Clan/Epithet	Knot Name
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Temur	Sarnai	<i>the Wagon-Keeper</i>	<i>Ninth Cord</i>
Batu	Gulshat	<i>the Story-Teller</i>	<i>Dream-Knot</i>
Orhan	Nergui	<i>the Knife</i>	<i>Unbound</i>
Cengiz	Altan	<i>Vow-Broken</i>	<i>Cut Cord</i>
Toghrul	Odval	<i>Circle-Keeper</i>	<i>Neutral Knot</i>

(Circle/Wagon/Ground) A wagon circle at dusk, lanterns lit; a painted wagon with a dream-cord hanging from the wheel; a crossroads where nine roads meet.

Spades — Places

2. **Wagon Circle (Night)** — Nine wagons arranged in a ring, lanterns burning, wheels touching. *Inside the circle, the Hollow cannot enter. Outside, it waits. The lanterns must never go out.* ‘[SANCTUARY]’
3. **Caravan Court (Day)** — A carpet spread on grass; a judge on a barrel; a cord on the ground. *The cord is the law. Step over it, and you accept the judge’s verdict.* ‘[JUSTICE]’
4. **Dream-Wagon (Ikasha’s Shrine)** — A painted wagon with no wheels, sitting on stones. The door is a curtain of knots. *Inside, a single candle and a bed of straw. Ikasha dreams there. Do not wake her.* ‘[MYSTIC]’
5. **Cord-Maker’s Stall** — A canvas awning where a woman braids horsehair and silk. *Each cord is a promise. The colour tells the weight: white for truth, red for blood, black for a secret.* ‘[CRAFT]’
6. **Crossroads of the Ninth Road** — A meeting of nine paths, only eight of which are visible. *The ninth road is for the dead. The Tulkani leave an offering there each full moon.* ‘[THRESHOLD]’
7. **Abandoned Circle** — A ring of burnt grass and wheel ruts. No wagons. No people. *The circle was broken on the ninth night. The Hollow came. The grass will not grow back.* ‘[OMEN]’
8. **Vow-Cord Tree** — An old oak with hundreds of knotted cords hanging from its branches. *Each cord is a promise kept. The tree remembers. The wind unties one each season.* ‘[COMMUNITY]’
9. **Hollow’s Gate (Seasonal)** — A place where the boundary is thin, marked by a single painted stone. *The Tulkani camp here only on the new moon. On the full moon, they are a day’s ride away.* ‘[THRESHOLD]’
10. **Tinkanar (Itinerant Caravanserai)** — A mobile market of wagons, open for one day each season. *The location changes. The Tulkani announce it by dream — the dream of a sleeping merchant.* ‘[TRADE]’
- J **Story-Well** — A dry well where the Tulkani throw written stories on parchment. *The stories are offerings to Ikasha. The well is full. The parchment never rots.* ‘[RITUAL]’
- Q **The Ninth Cord’s Post** — A wooden post at the centre of every circle, with nine notches. *The ninth notch is never carved. It is left for the Hollow. The Hollow never takes it.* ‘[SYMBOL]’
- K **The Wandering Hearth** — A wagon that is never hitched, always moving. It carries the council fire. *The fire has been burning for three hundred years. It has never touched the ground.* ‘[LEGEND]’

A **Ikasha’s Dreaming Place (Myth)** — A cave beneath a hill, where She Who Sleeps lies on a bed of knotted cords. *If you untie a cord, she wakes. If she wakes, the world ends.* ‘[MYTH]’

(**Judge/Keeper/Storyteller**) Caravan Judge with a dragging cord; Wagon-Keeper painting a wheel; Story-Seller with a dream-cord and a cup of water.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Caravan Judge** — Old, grey-braided, a cord so long it drags on the ground. *She ties a knot for every judgment. Untying a knot voids the judgment. She has never untied one.* ‘[JUSTICE]’
3. **Wagon-Keeper** — A woman with paint on her hands, a brush behind her ear. *She paints a new colour on her wagon each season. The colours are memories. She is running out of colours.* ‘[CRAFT]’
4. **Story-Seller (Gulshat)** — A young woman with a dream-cord around her wrist. She speaks in rhymes. *Her stories are true — but only if you listen with your eyes closed.* ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[MYSTIC]’
5. **Ikasha’s Knife** — A hooded figure with a mask of knotted cord. No face underneath. *He cuts the cords of oath-breakers. The cut cord becomes a ghost. The ghost follows the breaker.* ‘[JUSTICE]’ ‘[DEATH]’
6. **Vow-Broken (Exile)** — A man with a single knot tied in his own hair. He never smiles. *He is saving stories to buy back his name. He needs nine. He has eight.* ‘[COMMUNITY]’
7. **Cord-Maker** — A woman with braids of horsehair and silk between her fingers. *She can tell the weight of a promise by the feel of the hair. Horsehair is heavy. Silk is light.* ‘[CRAFT]’
8. **Hollow-Watcher** — A boy who sits at the edge of the circle at dusk, watching the dark. *He can see the Hollow when it walks. He points. The adults throw salt.* ‘[SCOUT]’
9. **The Dreamer** — A woman who sleeps in the Dream-Wagon. She never wakes during the day. *She dreams the caravan’s path. The wagon follows her dreams.* ‘[MYSTIC]’
10. **Tinkanar Merchant** — A fat man with nine bells on his hat. He sells knots and stories. *He accepts only promises as payment. His ledger is a cord. It has nine thousand knots.* ‘[TRADE]’
- J **The Ghost of the Ninth Night** — A translucent figure seen at abandoned circles. *It was a Tulkani who stayed too long. It asks: “Is it the ninth hour yet?”* ‘[DEATH]’
- Q **The First Wagon-Keeper (Legend)** — A skeleton driving a wagon of bones. The wheels are skulls. *It appears when a circle is broken. It offers a ride. The ride leads to the Hollow.* ‘[LEGEND]’
- K **Ikasha’s Voice** — A whisper heard in the Dream-Wagon at midnight. It speaks in riddles. *“The ninth cord is not a cord,” it says. “It is the space between the knots.”* ‘[MYSTIC]’
- A **The Unwitnessed** — A Tulkani who never tied a single knot. No one remembers her name. *She walks through circles unnoticed. She can break any vow because no one saw her make it.* ‘[MYTH]’

(**Toll/Story/Hollow**) A lord demands rent for camping on his land — negotiate nights or tell a story; the Hollow walks on the ninth night — a character hears their own name whispered; a stranger recognises your vow-cord and asks for a tale.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Recognition (Vow-Cord Seen)** — Someone from your past sees the knots you carry. They ask for a story you owe. '[SOCIAL]' '[RECIPROCITY]' *The story must be about a promise you kept — or broke. If you cannot tell one, they tie a new knot.*
3. **Lord's Rent Demand** — The local lord arrives at the circle at dawn. "You have been here seven nights. Pay the eighth." '[AUTHORITY]' '[NEGOTIATION]' *The price is a story that flatters him. If the story fails, he seizes a wagon. The circle holds its breath.*
4. **Hollow Walks (Ninth Night)** — Someone in the circle has miscounted. The ninth hour approaches. '[DEATH]' '[FEAR]' *The lanterns flicker. A shadow stands at the edge. It whispers a name. The name is the last person who broke an oath.*
5. **Vow-Cord Tangled** — Two promises conflict. The knots tighten. Blood is drawn. '[CONFLICT]' '[RECIPROCITY]' *The judge must cut one cord. The severed cord becomes a ghost. The ghost accuses the cutter of favouritism.*
6. **Wagon Wheel Broken** — A wheel cracks. The circle is incomplete. The Hollow can enter. '[DISASTER]' *The wheel must be repaired before dusk. The repair requires a story — a true one — told to the wood. The wood listens.*
7. **Tulkani Schism** — Two judges dispute the meaning of a knot. The circle splits. '[POLITICS]' *Each judge claims authority. The party must choose which cord to follow. The other cord will remember — and so will the Hollow.*
8. **Ikasha's Dream Disturbed** — A stranger enters the Dream-Wagon. The Dreamer wakes. '[MYSTIC]' '[CRISIS]' *Ikasha stirs. The ground trembles. The stranger must tell a story so good that Ikasha falls back asleep. The stranger is you.*
9. **Story Toll (Bridge/Pass)** — A guard demands a story to cross. Your story is not good enough. '[TRAVEL]' '[SOCIAL]' *The guard demands a truth instead. The truth must be a secret. The secret must hurt. The guard will remember.*
10. **Vow-Broken's Return** — An exile tries to rejoin the circle. The judge refuses. '[COMMUNITY]' '[DRAMA]' *The exile demands the party speak for him. If they refuse, he cuts his own throat. If they speak, they owe a knot — and a story.*
- J **The Ninth Cord Cut** — Someone cuts the ninth knot on the central post. The Hollow floods in. '[DEATH]' '[TRAP]' *The lanterns go out. The circle becomes a cage. The party must re-tie the knot in the dark. The cord is warm.*
- Q **Ikasha's Knife Betrayed** — The Knife is offered a bribe to cut a false cord. He refuses. The briber attacks. '[COMBAT]' '[JUSTICE]' *The Knife is wounded. He asks the party to carry his mask. The mask weighs nothing — until you put it on. Then it weighs everything.*
- K **Tinkanar Closed (No Stories)** — The mobile market is empty. The merchant has run out of knots. '[TRADE]' '[CRISIS]' *He is selling his own name. The price is a story that makes him weep. He has not wept in forty years. The last story he heard was a lie.*
- A **Ikasha Wakes** — The Dreamer dies. Ikasha opens her eyes. The sky turns white. '[APOCALYPSE]' *She asks one question: "Who cut the ninth cord?" The answer must be a name. If no name is given, she takes all names.*

(Cord/Bead/Charm) Vow-bead (a single knot, can be used to call in a favour once); safe-haven oath (a knotted cord that guarantees sanctuary in any Tulkani circle); dream-cord (gift from Ikasha, one question answered in a dream).

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Vow-Bead (Single Knot)** — A small knot on a leather thong. Present it to call in a favour from any Tulkani. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The knot will loosen after use. If it is not retied within a year, the favour becomes a story owed — and stories are harder to repay.*
 3. **Safe-Haven Oath (Knotted Cord)** — A braided cord with three knots. Hang it on your wagon to guarantee sanctuary in any Tulkani circle. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The cord must be renewed each season. A new knot is added. After nine knots, it becomes a dream-cord — and the Hollow will notice you.*
 4. **Dream-Cord (Ikasha’s Gift)** — A silk cord with nine knots, the ninth loose. Once, sleep on it to ask Ikasha one question. She will answer in a dream. ‘[MYSTIC]’ *The answer is always a riddle. The ninth knot tightens after use. When it tightens fully, Ikasha wakes — and the world changes.*
 5. **Caravan Judge’s Cord (Borrowed)** — A length of braided horsehair. Tie it around your wrist to gain +1 Position in any negotiation with Tulkani. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The cord is the judge’s own. She will want it back. The return is a negotiation — and a story.*
 6. **Wagon-Keeper’s Paint (Pot)** — A clay pot of blue pigment. Paint your own wagon wheel, and no lord will demand rent for nine days. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The paint is made from crushed sky-stone. It glows under moonlight. The Hollow avoids it — but the lord will send a spy.*
 7. **Story-Seller’s Verse** — A single verse of a true story. Recite it to calm a spirit or end a feud. ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[MYSTIC]’ *The verse works once. After that, the story belongs to the listener. You cannot tell it again — but you can tell a different truth.*
 8. **Ikasha’s Mask (Knotted)** — A mask of knotted cord. Wear it to become invisible to the Hollow for one night. ‘[STEALTH]’ ‘[DEATH]’ *The mask has no eye holes. You must walk by memory. The memory may fail. If it fails, the Hollow sees you — and smiles.*
 9. **Hollow-Watcher’s Salt Pouch** — A leather pouch of salt blessed by the boy who watches the circle. Throw it to banish a Debt-Walker. ‘[COMBAT]’ ‘[DEATH]’ *The salt is bitter. The Debt-Walker will taste it. It will remember your face — and your smell.*
 10. **Tinkanar Merchant’s Bell** — One of nine bells from the merchant’s hat. Ring it to summon him anywhere. ‘[TRADE]’ *He will come. He will demand payment in stories. He will not leave until paid. He has a long memory.*
- J **Vow-Broken’s Hair Knot** — A single knot tied in human hair. It contains a broken promise. Use it to void a contract. ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[MAGIC]’ *The knot is from an exile. He wants it back. He will pay a story for it — the story of how he broke his vow.*
- Q **The Ninth Cord’s Post Fragment** — A splinter of wood from the central post. Touch it to any knot to learn who tied it. ‘[MYSTIC]’ *The splinter is warm. It will burn your hand if the knot was tied in false witness. The truth leaves no scar.*
- K **First Wagon-Keeper’s Skull** — A human skull painted with wheel patterns. Place it at the centre of a circle to keep the Hollow away for nine nights. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[SANCTUARY]’ *The skull whispers on the ninth night. It asks: “Is it time?” Say no. If you say yes, it will take your place.*
- A **Ikasha’s Dream (Bottle)** — A glass bottle containing a sleeping breath. Break it to send a question to Ikasha. She will answer in a vision. ‘[MYSTIC]’ *The vision lasts one minute. The cost is one memory. The memory is forgotten forever. The memory is always a happy one.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (knots, cords, beads) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **knot-omens**—a cord that tightens without being pulled, a knot that unties itself, a wheel that stops turning at the ninth spoke.

Additional Features: Itinerant Mechanics

The Ninth Night Rule

A Tulkani caravan may camp on a lord's land for seven nights without payment. On the eighth night, the lord may demand rent — typically a story, a promise, or a small service. On the ninth night, the Hollow comes. No Tulkani stays nine nights in one place. A party camping with Tulkani must leave by the eighth dusk or face the Hollow's attention.

Mechanic: Each night the party camps in a Tulkani circle, mark a segment on a **Ninth Night Clock** [8]. At 7 segments, the lord (or local authority) arrives to demand rent. At 8 segments, the Hollow manifests. The party can leave before 8 to reset the clock.

Story as Currency

Tulkani do not use coin. They trade in stories, promises, and knots. A good story can buy a meal, a horse, or safe passage. A bad story can start a feud. The GM should encourage players to tell brief in-character stories; the quality (or a Presence + Sway roll) determines the value.

Mechanic: When a player tells a story, they roll Presence + Sway (DV set by the listener's mood). On a success, the story is worth 1 Measure of value. On a critical success, it is worth 2. On a failure, the listener is offended — the party gains -1 Position on their next social roll in that circle. A player may also offer a **truth** (a secret, a confession, a memory) instead of a story; a truth is always worth 2 Measures but marks 1 Obligation to Ikasha.

Land Rent and Neutrality

Tulkani circles are neutral ground. No lord may collect taxes or enforce laws inside a circle, regardless of whose territory it sits on. However, the lord may demand rent at the circle's edge, and the Tulkani will negotiate. A party inside a Tulkani circle is under the Caravan Judge's protection — but if the party commits a crime, the judge may expel them to the Hollow.

Mechanic: When a lord demands rent, the Caravan Judge mediates. The party may offer a story (one Measure), a promise (a future favour, represented by a Reciprocity Clock [4]), or a service (a quest). Refusing to pay means the lord may attack the circle — which breaks the neutrality and summons the Hollow.

Vow-Cords and Reciprocity

Every Tulkani carries a vow-cord — a braided strand of horsehair and silk, with knots tied for every promise made and kept. A Tulkani who breaks a promise must cut the corresponding knot; the cut cord becomes a ghost that follows the oath-breaker until the promise is fulfilled. Outsiders may

borrow a Tulkani vow-cord; the knots then record their promises. But the Tulkani see this not as debt but as **reciprocity**: what goes around comes around, and the circle always balances.

Mechanic: A character who accepts a vow-cord gains +1 die to any roll made to keep a promise related to the cord. However, if they break that promise, they must cut a knot — mark 1 Corruption and gain a Condition: *Followed by a Ghost* (-1 die to stealth until the promise is fulfilled). A character may tie a new knot to make a new promise; each knot beyond the first increases the penalty for breaking. But a character who fulfills nine knots may ask the Caravan Judge for a **Circle Boon** — a permanent +1 die on all social rolls with Tulkani.

Local Patrons (Syncretic Names)

- **The Unwitnessed Weaver** — Inaea. *The knot that binds gently, the cord that remembers mercy.*
- **The Cord-Cutter** — Isoka. *The clean break, the shedding of false promises.*
- **The Dreamer Below** — Ikasha. *She who sleeps in the wagon, she who dreams the road.*
- **The Ninth Traveller** — The Traveler. *The road that has no end, the threshold that is always one step away.*

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **Tulkani Vow-Cords and the Sidhi Freedman’s Seal:** Sidhi merchants on the Brass Coast accept Tulkani vow-cords as proof of credit. A well-knotted cord can buy a ship. A cut cord can sink one. The Sidhi know that a Tulkani knot is worth more than a signature.
- **Ikasha and the Veiled Sisters (Ashaan):** The Tulkani are the primary spreaders of Ikasha’s cult outside Ashaan. A Breath-less agent may be disguised as a Tulkani story-seller; a Tulkani caravan may be a mobile safe house. The Sisters have tried to infiltrate the circles three times. Each time, the spy was found with a cord around her throat — tied in a knot she could not untie.
- **The Ninth Night and the Hollow (Eastern Realms):** The Tulkani’s ninth-night rule is the only reason the Hollow has not overrun the eastern trade routes. Aelaerem hedge-keepers sometimes hire Tulkani guides to reset the Hollow’s attention clocks. The payment is always a story — and the story is always about a door that was left open.
- **Story Debts and the Ukwe (Sekogo):** The Tulkani believe that the Ukwe is the first vow-cord tree. They leave offerings of knotted grass at its roots. A Tulkani judge may consult the Ukwe to verify a story’s truth. The Ukwe speaks in rustles. A single rustle means true. Two mean false. Three mean the story is not finished.

Tulkani Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Circle:** Crumble a crust at the centre of the wagon ring. Ignore the first *Recognition* penalty. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Knot the Lantern:** Tie a single knot in the rope of a lantern. Cancel *Lord’s Rent Demand* or take -1 die on your next negotiation (your choice). ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Name to the Ninth Post:** Whisper a dead judge’s name into the central post. Gain +1 Effect when telling a story this scene, but mark *Obligation* to Ikasha. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **Tulkani judges or local lords**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **circle-watchers or Hollow scouts**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **vow-breakers or story-hunters**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favourable camping ground**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Local Caravan Judge or lord's herald** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **lantern failure or broken wheel**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **debt collector or Hollow manifestation** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **Tulkani riders, lord's men, or Hollow spirits** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes—**knot cut/wagon broken/ninth night triggered**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **High Caravan Judge, Ikasha's Knife, or Hollow's Debt-Walker** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically—**circle breaks/wagon burns/lanterns go out**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice—**omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Tulkani (Knot Law):** Cords tighten without warning, a knot unties itself, a wheel stops at the ninth spoke.
- **Tulkani (Story Debt):** A story you told returns to you changed, a listener laughs at a tragedy, the wind carries your words to someone who should not hear.
- **Tulkani (Ninth Night):** A lantern flickers, a shadow stands at the circle's edge, a whisper says your name from the dark.

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Wits + Stealth):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *False Knot*.
- **Cut the Cord (Presence + Sway):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a vow-bead is in your possession, +1 die.
- **Weather the Hollow (Resolve + Spirit):** On a hit in *Hollow Walks*, you pick who hears the whisper; on a miss, the GM does.

Boss Seeds (Knot & Dream)

- **The Cord-Cutter (Nine Broken Promises)** — *Phases:* Vow-Cords Severed → Orchestrated Exile → Circle Coup. *Cracks:* re-tie a cut cord, expose a false judge, survive a night outside the circle.
- **The Dream-Eater (Ikasha’s Shadow)** — *Phases:* Dreamers Waking → Procession of Empty Wagons → Knot-Baptism of a Storyteller. *Cracks:* relic dream-cord, survivor testimony, the ninth cord refusing to tighten.

Patronage & Power

Among the Tulkani, power flows through knots, stories, and the memory of the circle. A Caravan Judge’s authority is recognised by every lord from the steppe to the coast — not because of armies, but because the Hollow respects the judge’s cord. The Tulkani have no temples, no kings, no borders. They have the ninth night, and that is enough.

For the GM: Power in Tulkani society is measured in knots tied, stories told, and nights counted. Patronage often takes the form of vow-beads, dream-cords, or safe-haven oaths — each carrying the weight of a promise. To emphasize the itinerant mechanics:

- Require players to **negotiate land rent** with local lords, using stories or promises as currency. A failed negotiation may lead to the Hollow.
- Use the **Ninth Night Clock** as a tension mechanic: every night in a Tulkani camp advances the clock. At 8, the Hollow manifests unless the party leaves.
- Let **vow-cords** be physical props — actual knotted strings that players can hold, tie, or cut. A cut cord is a dramatic moment.
- Emphasise that **storytelling is a skill**: reward creative players with mechanical bonuses, and let failed stories have consequences — a bored lord may raise rent, an offended spirit may curse.
- Treat Tulkani society as a **reciprocity economy**, not a debt economy. What you give, you get back — but the circle decides when.

In Tulkani society, the knot remembers everything — and the ninth night forgets nothing.

Part VI

Dhahara — The Kingdom of Brass

Chapter 29

The Mountain Satrapies

Aeler-Dhaharan.

The passes do not care for your lineage or your gods. They care for iron, tea, and the weight of a sworn ledger. Aeler and Dhaharan have bled into the same stone here. I wear a dwarf's breath-counter and a Dhaharan's fire-token. The mountain accepts both.

I am an Elephant Mahout. My grandfather drove elephants for the Sun Kings. My father drove them for the Aeler. I drive them for the Viceroy. The elephants do not care who holds the howdah. They care that the pass is clear and the fodder is fresh.

Iron mines, tea terraces, and the ninth breath—the Mountain Satrapies aren't just Aeler-Dhaharan—they're a leverage market, and oh, how the Aeler viceroy loves a good deal on miner safety. The Aeler have established a viceroyalty here—not conquest, but a long lease. The local rajas pay tribute in iron and receive protection from lowland enemies. It is an uneasy peace, written in bell-codes and toll-ledgers. But here's the secret the Viceroy doesn't want you to know: the lease is not a document. It is the weight of the keystone that holds the roof. If the keystone cracks, the lease cracks with it. And the keystone is cracking.

The architecture blends Aeler stonework with Dhaharan domes; the cuisine mixes dwarf-bread with spiced tea; the law is a creole of Covenant statutes and Aeler breath-bonds. The Aeler engineers speak a creole of their own tongue; the Dhaharan nobles wear Aeler breath-counters as jewellery; and the elephants—the elephants remember who fed them during the famine of the ninth lease. They have not forgotten.

Never count your breaths aloud in a mine. The mountain listens, and if it

hears you reach the ninth, it will take one—a breath, a memory, a shadow.

— *Rani Jaya, who lost an arm to a mine collapse and now wears a prosthetic pickaxe*

The Almanac of Ordinary Days

What do people eat for breakfast? Millet flatbread and spiced tea—the bread is baked on iron griddles, the tea is grown on terraced hillsides. The hillsides are terraced with Aeler engineering. The engineering is paid for in iron. The iron is mined by Dhaharan hands. The hands are calloused. The callouses are a ledger.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To count in two measures. Satrapy children learn the Aeler breath-count (eight to a minute) and the Dhaharan fire-count (eight to a bell). The ninth of either is silence. Silence is the mountain's attention. The mountain is always attentive.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their breath-counter. A stranger whose counter is brass is Aeler-trained. A stranger whose counter is bronze is Dhaharan-trained. A stranger whose counter is iron has never been underground. Iron does not ring. Iron is for weapons. Weapons are for the surface.

What is the most common crime? Ore theft—but ore theft is not a crime, it is a tax evasion. The Viceroy's cut is measured in ingots. An ingot that goes missing is an ingot that was never mined. The mine's ledger is adjusted. The adjustment is creative accounting. The accounting is the art.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The ninth lease was never signed. The Viceroy's seal was forged by a Dhaharan scribe who was paid in tea. The scribe is dead. The forgery is still in use. The lease is void. No one has noticed. No one wants to notice.

Where do people go when they die? To the mines. The dead are not buried. Their bodies are placed in worked-out galleries, sealed with stone. The mountain absorbs them. The mountain's memory grows. The mountain remembers every miner who ever breathed its air.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You offer a keystone—a load-bearing stone from your own house. The stone is installed in the wronged party's wall. If it holds, you are forgiven. If it cracks, you are not. If it crumbles, your house collapses. Apology is architecture. Architecture is law.

What is the most important festival? The Ringing of the Leases (autumn). The Viceroy reads the terms of the lease aloud, in the main square. The lease is nine pages long. The ninth page is sealed with wax. The wax is never broken. The ninth page is a secret. The secret is the Viceroy's profit.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The keystone is not stone. It is a coffin—the tomb of a Dhaharan king who refused to pay the iron tithe. The Aeler sealed him in the foundation of the Viceroy's palace. His ghost haunts the lease negotiations. His ghost votes against the Viceroy. The Viceroy does not believe in ghosts.

29.1 The Mountain Satrapies — “The Iron Passes”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *The mountain weighs every breath, every ingot, every oath. Pay in iron, pay in silence, or pay in blood.*

Viceroy Thrain (Elite): “The passes do not care for your lineage or your gods. They care for iron, tea, and the weight of a sworn ledger. Aeler and Dhaharan have bled into the same stone here. I wear a dwarf’s breath-counter and a Dhaharan’s fire-token. The mountain accepts both.”

Elephant Mahout (Commoner): “My grandfather drove elephants for the Sun Kings. My father drove them for the Aeler. I drive them for the Viceroy. The elephants do not care who holds the howdah. They care that the pass is clear and the fodder is fresh.”

Genre / Mood: High-altitude contract horror, industrial colonialism, elephant-driven logistics.

Starting Location: The Viceroy’s Hall, a longhouse of timber and stone, with a throne of iron ore that no one sits on. Viceroy Thrain stands behind it, a bell around his neck: “The lease is up for renewal. The rajas want lower tithes. The Admiralty wants the passes opened to their trade. And the mines are whispering of a demon waking. You are not here by accident. Tell me whose interests you serve — and whose name I should carve on the next treaty.”

Theme & Atmosphere

The Mountain Satrapies are the northern highlands of Dhahara, where the Aeler viceroys rule on behalf of the distant High King. Here, the air is thin and cold, the rivers run white with snowmelt, and the passes are measured in breath-counts rather than miles. Iron mines scar the hillsides, worked by Dhaharan labourers and overseen by Aeler engineers. Elephant caravans haul ore down to the Brass Coast; mule trains carry silver and tea up to the mountain holds. The Aeler have established a viceroyalty here — not conquest, but a long lease. The local rajas pay tribute in iron and receive protection from lowland enemies. It is an uneasy peace, written in bell-codes and toll-ledgers. The architecture blends Aeler stonework with Dhaharan domes; the cuisine mixes dwarf-bread with spiced tea; the law is a creole of Covenant statutes and Aeler breath-bonds.

What you notice first: The ringing of iron hammers and the lowing of elephants. The way every bridge has a dwarf toll-keeper with a brass scale. The silence after a bell rings — the silence is for the mountain to answer.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never count your breaths aloud in a mine. The mountain listens, and if it hears you reach the ninth, it will take one — a breath, a memory, a shadow.

Regional Mood: The Weight of the Lease

Power here is measured in iron quotas, tea taxes, and the length of a viceroy’s lease. The Satrapies are not a colony — the Aeler High King holds the passes by treaty, renewed every nine years. The Viceroy answers to the High King, but also to the local rajas, the Covenant judges, and the elephant clans. Every decision is a negotiation between mountain custom and lowland law. The Aeler engineers speak a creole of their own tongue; the Dhaharan nobles wear Aeler breath-counters

as jewellery; and the elephants — the elephants remember who fed them during the famine of the ninth lease.

Prominent NPCs of the Mountain Satrapies

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Viceroy Thrain	Aeler governor of the Iron Passes	Maximise ore output for the High King	He wears a bell around his neck; it rings when he lies.
Rani Jaya	Local raja of the eastern hills	Balance tribute to Aeler with loyalty to her clan	She lost an arm to a mine collapse; the prosthetic is a pickaxe.
Mine-Captain Korr	Aeler engineer	Keep the tunnels safe and the quotas met	He counts his breaths in eights; he has never reached nine.
Tarkan	Elephant caravan master	Move iron to the coast before the snows close the passes	He speaks to his elephants in Dhaharan; they answer in Aeler.
Sister Gaura	Covenant judge of the hill circuit	Resolve disputes between Aeler law and local custom	She carries a water-clock that runs on tears — her own.

Names of the Mountain Satrapies

A mix of Aeler gutturals and Dhaharan vowels. Surnames may be Aeler clan names or Dhaharan hill titles.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Clan/House	Epithets
Thrain	Jaya	Ironfoot	<i>the Bell-Breaker</i>
Korr	Gaura	Stonehand	<i>Breath-Counter</i>
Borin	Meera	Vikram	<i>the Elephant's Friend</i>
Halk	Sita	Aezelbron	<i>Bridge-Warden</i>
Rurik	Laxmi	Thrainsdottir	<i>Toll-Eater</i>

(**Mine/Bridge/Hall**) Iron mine with a carved face above the entrance; Aeler toll bridge with a dwarf and a scale; Viceroy’s hall with a throne of iron ore.

Spades — Places

2. **Iron Mine of the Crying Face** — A deep shaft with a carved face above the entrance. *The face weeps rust. The tears are iron oxide. The mountain is mourning its dead.* ‘[BREATH]’
3. **Aeler Toll Bridge** — A stone arch over a gorge; a dwarf with a scale sits at the far end. *The toll is not in coin — it is in weight. Your truth is weighed against a bar of iron.* ‘[TOLL]’
4. **Viceroy’s Hall** — A longhouse of timber and stone; a throne of iron ore. *The throne is cold. The viceroy never sits on it — only stands behind it.* ‘[LEASE]’
5. **Elephant Corral (Mountain)** — A fenced area with heavy chains; elephants are chained by one leg. *The chains have names — each is the elephant’s first kill.* ‘[COMMUNITY]’
6. **Silent Pass** — A high mountain pass where no bird flies. *The air is too thin for sound. Arguments must be written in the snow.* ‘[BREATH]’
7. **Mine of the Ninth Seal** — A sealed tunnel with a Covenant seal on the timbers. *Inside is a demon that the miners woke. The seal is cracking.* ‘[MAGIC]’ ‘[LEASE]’
8. **Tea Terraces (Aeler-Dhaharan)** — Stone-step fields where tea shrubs grow. *Each terrace is a different clan’s share of the harvest. The tea tastes of slate.* ‘[TRADE]’
9. **Dwarf Counting-House** — A low building with brass scales and an iron ledger. *The ledger records breath-bonds. It weighs the air.* ‘[TOLL]’
10. **Raja’s Fort (Hill)** — A stone fortress with painted gates and a single tower. *The tower is also a fire shrine. The flame is lit with dwarf-coal.* ‘[COMMUNITY]’
- J **Bridge of Nine Echoes** — A rope bridge over a chasm; each step echoes nine times. *The ninth echo is always a whisper. It is the name of the next person to fall.* ‘[OMEN]’
- Q **Abandoned Smelter** — A ruined furnace where iron was once refined. *The slag heaps are still warm. Something lives in the warmth.* ‘[MAGIC]’
- K **Viceroy’s Archive** — A subterranean vault of treaties and toll receipts. *The archive is sealed with Aeler keystone wax and Dhaharan clay.* ‘[LEASE]’
- A **The First Lease Stone** — A monolith carved with the original treaty between Aeler and Dhahara. *The stone is warm. It glows when the lease is renewed. It cracks when the lease is broken.* ‘[LEASE]’ ‘[OMEN]’

(**Engineer/Raja/Judge**) Mine-captain with a tuning fork and a level; Rani Jaya with a pickaxe prosthetic; Sister Gaura with a water-clock that runs on tears.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Mine-Captain (Aeler)** — A dwarf with a tuning fork and a level. He can hear a crack in a beam from a hundred paces. *He never walks under a keystone. The mountain has ears.* ‘[BREATH]’
3. **Rani Jaya** — A young woman in armour, riding a caparisoned elephant. She lost an arm to a mine collapse. *The prosthetic is a pickaxe. She can write with it. The letters are iron filings.* ‘[COMMUNITY]’

4. **Covenant Judge (Sister Gaura)** — Robed in grey, a water-clock on her belt. The clock runs on tears. *She refills it from her own eyes when she hands down a death sentence.* '[LEASE]'
5. **Elephant Caravan Master (Tarkan)** — Old, missing two fingers, tattooed with elephant footprints. *He knows the name of every elephant that has crossed the pass in fifty years.* '[COMMUNITY]'
6. **Aeler Toll-Keeper** — A dwarf with a brass scale and a ledger. He weighs your goods and your lies. *The scale tips for both. A lie makes the pan dip lower.* '[TOLL]'
7. **Smelter Worker** — A young man with red-rimmed eyes. He coughs iron dust. *His spittle stains the ground. He will not live past thirty. He knows.* '[LABOR]'
8. **Treasure Hunter** — A foreigner digging in an old landslide. He is looking for the tomb of a prince. *The prince is the one who stole the Kalrantha amulet. The treasure hunter is a fool.* '[MAGIC]'
9. **Raja's Spymaster** — A woman with a limp; she uses a walking stick that is also a blowpipe. *The darts are tipped with tea — caffeine that stops hearts.* '[POLITICS]'
10. **Tea Trader (Fhara)** — A merchant with a caravan of mules. He sells tea to the Aeler; they pay in iron. *He sells iron to the coast; they pay in silver. He is the richest man in the passes.* '[TRADE]'
- J **Blind Pilgrim** — A woman in white, walking the passes alone. She is searching for a shrine where a bell rang without a clapper. *The shrine is a cave. The cave is the mine of the ninth seal.* '[FAITH]'
- Q **Ghost of the Landslide** — A figure in grey, seen only at dusk. It points at the pass. *It is pointing at a safe route — or a trap. No one has survived to find out.* '[OMEN]'
- K **Viceroy's Cipher Clerk** — A dwarf who writes diplomatic letters in code. *The code is a poem. The poem is about a lost mine. The mine is real.* '[LEASE]'
- A **Demon's Whisper (from the Ninth Seal)** — A voice heard in the sealed mine. *It offers a deal: a year of good fortune for a single memory. The memory is the last breath of a dying friend.* '[MAGIC]' '[LEASE]'

(Cave-in/Toll/Echo) A cave-in traps miners; the Aeler toll-keeper demands double payment; the ninth echo on the bridge speaks a name.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Cave-In (Sabotage)** — A tunnel collapses. The collapse was not an accident — a saboteur loosened the timbers. '[DISASTER]' *The saboteur is in the party. Or the party is accused.*
3. **Toll Dispute** — The Aeler keeper demands double; the raja's men refuse. The dispute is a trap. '[TOLL]' '[POLITICS]' *Both sides want the party to choose a side. Neither is honest.*
4. **Ninth Echo** — On the Bridge of Nine Echoes, someone counts the echoes. The ninth echo says a name. '[OMEN]' '[FEAR]' *The name is the speaker's. They faint. The bridge remembers.*
5. **Landslide** — The pass is blocked. The alternative route is three days longer. '[WEATHER]' '[TRAVEL]' *The landslide was deliberate — a rival caravan master wants to delay you.*
6. **Breath Shortage** — At high altitude, the party struggles. Mark Fatigue 1 per scene. '[BREATH]' '[ENDURANCE]' *Acclimatisation requires a rest day. The rest day will cost a*

toll.

7. **Spy in Camp** — A worker is stealing iron samples. The spy is working for an Ashaani agent. ‘[POLITICS]’ ‘[STEALTH]’ *The samples are for a new alloy. The alloy is a weapon.*
8. **Covenant Audit** — Sister Gaura demands to inspect the party’s cargo. ‘[LEASE]’ ‘[JUSTICE]’ *The cargo includes a relic from the Red Desert — a stolen Covenant seal.*
9. **Aeler Bell Code Change** — The toll-keeper rings a different sequence; the party is now “unregistered.” ‘[TOLL]’ ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The change was ordered by the viceroy. The viceroy is testing your loyalty.*
10. **Elephant Sickness (Curse)** — A disease spreads through the caravan. The disease is a curse from a local spirit. ‘[COMMUNITY]’ ‘[MAGIC]’ *The spirit was disturbed by the mine’s expansion. It wants a sacrifice — a memory, not blood.*
- J **Viceroy’s Summons** — Thrain demands the party attend him. He offers a deal: find the saboteur in exchange for a toll waiver. ‘[LEASE]’ ‘[POLITICS]’ *The saboteur is his own clerk. The clerk is his daughter.*
- Q **Silent Pass’s Cold** — The temperature drops; the party loses 1 Supply per hour. ‘[WEATHER]’ ‘[BREATH]’ *The cold is supernatural — a frost spirit has taken residence. It wants a memory.*
- K **Demon Wakes (Ninth Seal)** — The sealed mine cracks open. A shadow escapes; it possesses the nearest Aeler engineer. ‘[MAGIC]’ ‘[LEASE]’ *The engineer begins to sabotage the pass. The demon wants the lease broken.*
- A **Lease Stone Cracks** — The First Lease Stone glows red and splits. The treaty is void. War is coming. ‘[LEASE]’ ‘[APOCALYPSE]’ *The party has one day to flee the passes before the Aeler and Dhaharan armies clash.*

(**Token/Ingot/Seal**) Aeler breath-counter (silver bell, wear to count breaths safely); iron ingot (stamped with the viceroy’s mark); Covenant seal (clay, for witnessing oaths in the passes).

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Aeler Breath-Counter (Silver Bell)** — Wear it to count your breaths in high altitude. The bell rings when you reach eight. ‘[BREATH]’ ‘[TRAVEL]’ *Stop at eight. The ninth breath is the mountain’s.*
3. **Iron Ingot (Viceroy’s Mark)** — A single bar of high-grade iron, stamped with a dragon. Worth 1 Measure. ‘[TRADE]’ ‘[LEVERAGE]’ *The dragon is the viceroy’s mark. Present it to any Aeler forge for a favour.*
4. **Covenant Seal (Clay, Himadri)** — A lump of clay. Heat it to witness any oath in the foothills. ‘[LEASE]’ ‘[JUSTICE]’ *The heat comes from a coal taken from the sealed mine. The coal whispers.*
5. **Toll Waiver (Brass Nail)** — A brass nail. Present it to pass any Aeler bridge for free. ‘[TOLL]’ ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The nail fits into a hole in the toll-keeper’s scale. The hole is for bribes.*
6. **Elephant Whistle (Bone)** — A bone whistle. Blow it to call an elephant from the caravan. ‘[COMMUNITY]’ ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The whistle is made from the tusk of a bull that died in a rockslide. Its ghost runs with the elephant.*
7. **Raja’s Signet Ring (Silver)** — A silver ring with a tiger. Commands loyalty from the raja’s clan. ‘[COMMUNITY]’ ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The ring is a copy. The real one was lost in a landslide. The ghost of the original owner wears it.*

8. **Smelter's Gloves (Asbestos)** — Handle hot metal safely. The gloves are cursed: they itch when you lie. '[CRAFT]' '[TRUTH]' *The itch is mild at first. It becomes unbearable with repeated lies.*
 9. **Map of the Silent Pass (Leather)** — A chart drawn on leather. Shows a safe route through the high pass. '[TRAVEL]' '[SECRET]' *The map is incomplete. The missing section is a fold. The fold is a secret — a cave with a spring.*
 10. **Viceroy's Letter of Introduction** — A sealed scroll. Grants access to any Aeler hold in the mountains. '[LEASE]' '[AUTHORITY]' *The letter is written in blood. The blood is the viceroy's. He changes his blood type each season.*
- J Blind Pilgrim's Staff** — A wooden staff with a bell on top. Ring it to summon a guide. '[FAITH]' '[TRAVEL]' *The guide is a ghost — the pilgrim's predecessor. She will lead you safely, but she will ask for a story.*
- Q Demon's Nail (Sealed Mine Timber)** — A piece of the sealed mine's timber. Touch it to a lock; the lock opens. '[MAGIC]' '[STEALTH]' *The lock also screams. The scream alerts the demon.*
- K Ninth Echo's Whisper (Recording)** — A piece of slate carved with the ninth echo's words. Play it to silence a foe. '[COMBAT]' '[FEAR]' *The foe hears their own name and freezes for one exchange. The slate then crumbles.*
- A Viceroy's Forgiveness (Pardon)** — A written pardon for any crime in the Satrapies. '[LEASE]' '[AUTHORITY]' *The pardon is conditional. The condition is a secret mission. The mission is to assassinate a rival viceroy.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (bells, ingots, nails) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **mountain-omens**—iron that weeps rust, bells that ring without clappers, a pass that closes behind you.

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **The Ninth Breath:** Aeler miners believe that counting to nine in a mine summons the mountain's attention. They count in eights, resetting after each set. Visitors who count to nine aloud may trigger a cave-in — or worse. Mechanically, any character who voluntarily counts to nine in a mine must test Resolve (DV 4) or mark 1 Fatigue as the mountain takes a breath. On a critical failure, the mountain takes a memory instead (lose 1 XP or forget a minor detail).
- **Lease Clock [8]:** Tracks the political pressure around the treaty renewal. The clock ticks when the party assists or hinders a faction (Aeler, rajas, Admiralty, Covenant). At 4 segments: a faction threatens to walk out of negotiations. At 8: the lease is broken or renewed in the party's favour (or against it). The party can reset the clock by brokering a concession.
- **Elephant Community Share:** Instead of individual ownership, elephant caravans operate on a share system. A character who helps the caravan (clearing a pass, feeding a sick elephant, healing the mahout) gains a **Share Token**. Spend it to call on the caravan for a single favour:

passage for a wagon, a day’s fodder, or a warning about a rival. Share Tokens are not debt — they are reciprocity.

- **Breath-Bonds as Leverage:** Aeler engineers use breath-bonds to secure contracts. A character who holds a breath-bond can demand a renegotiation of tolls, quotas, or labour terms. The bond is not a debt — it is a recorded agreement that both parties benefit from keeping. Breaking a breath-bond does not incur a curse; it simply ends the trust, and the other party will never deal with you again.
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
 - **Thrain the Counter** — Mykkiel. *The divine auditor; every deed must balance.*
 - **The Silent Bell** — The Sealed Gate. *The threshold that asks only that you stop at eight.*
 - **The Forge Father** — Adur (Oath of Flame and Light). *The flame that tempers iron and burns lies.*
 - **The Old Breath** — The Traveler. *The wind that carries caravans and counts their steps.*

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Ninth Seal Mine and the Kalrantha Amulet (Dhahara):** The demon sealed in the mine is a fragment of Varash the Unmaker. The Veiled Sisters want to free it to use against the Covenant. The Breath-less want to re-seal it. The demon speaks in the voices of dead miners.
- **Iron Trade and the Ngomebe (Stone Men):** The iron from the Satrapies is used to forge rollers for the walking cities of Ngomebe. A disruption in the iron supply could stop a city mid-migration. The Mason-Kin have a permanent envoy at the Viceroy’s hall.
- **Covenant Judges and the Sidhi (Way of Silk):** Sister Gaura is a Covenant judge; her water-clock is a Sidhi design. She may have contacts in the Brass Coast who can verify a freedman’s seal. She also knows which freedmen are still being hunted.
- **The Blind Pilgrim and the Hollow (Eastern Realms):** The pilgrim is searching for a shrine that marks the Hollow’s boundary in the high passes. Aelaerem hedge-keepers know the location but refuse to speak it. They say the shrine is a missing ninth step in the mountain’s own counting song.

Mountain Satrapies Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Mine:** Crumble a crust into the tunnel mouth. Ignore the first *Cave-In* penalty. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Knot the Bell Rope:** Tie a knot in the rope of a shrine bell. Cancel *Ninth Echo* or take –1 die on your next stealth roll (the bell still rings, but muffled). ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Name to the Iron:** Whisper a dead miner’s name into an ingot. Gain +1 Effect when negotiating with Aeler this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Viceroy. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **Aeler engineers or raja’s spies**.

- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **mine guards or toll-keepers**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **elemental spirits or rival caravans**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favourable toll rates**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** Local **mine-captain or toll-keeper** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **landslide or thin air**.
- **Foe Appears:** A rival **raja's guard or a demon fragment** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **Aeler engineers, raja's soldiers, or mountain spirits** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes—**mine seals/lease stone cracks/ninth echo spoken**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **Viceroy, High Raja, or Demon from the Ninth Seal** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically—**mine collapses/bridge falls/lease stone shatters**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice—**omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Satrapies (Mine Law):** Iron veins glow faintly, the mountain groans, a breath-counter ticks backward.
- **Satrapies (Lease Politics):** The Viceroy's bell rings once for no reason, a raja's elephant kneels unprompted, a treaty scroll spontaneously combusts.
- **Satrapies (Pass Law):** Snow falls upward, the ninth echo repeats a different name each time, a bridge appears where there was only chasm.

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Wits + Survival):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Thin Air*.
- **Cut the Toll (Presence + Sway):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a toll waiver is in your possession, +1 die.

- **Weather the Cave-in (Body + Athletics):** On a hit in *Cave-In*, you pick who escapes first; on a miss, the GM does.

Boss Seeds (Iron & Breath)

- **The Breath-Eater (Nine Silence)** — *Phases:* Mines Collapsing → Orchestrated Cave-In → Pass Coup. *Cracks:* find a lost breath-counter, expose a false lease, survive a count of nine.
- **The Unsealed (Demon of the Ninth Seal)** — *Phases:* Whispers in the Mine → Procession of Cracking Timbers → Iron-Baptism of a Viceroy. *Cracks:* relic Covenant seal, survivor testimony, the mine’s face weeping clear water.

Patronage & Power

Among the Mountain Satrapies, power flows through iron, tea, and the weight of the lease. The Viceroy holds authority from the Aeler High King, but the rajas control the mines, the Covenant judges the courts, and the elephant masters move the ore. No single faction rules — and every faction owes a share of their success to the mountain.

For the GM: Power in the Satrapies is measured in breath-counts, toll receipts, and the loyalty of the elephant caravans. Patronage often takes the form of iron ingots, breath-counters, or toll waivers — each tied to a specific mine, bridge, or clan. To emphasise community and leverage over debt:

- Tie rewards to physical tokens (bells, ingots, nails) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided by a rival.
- Let the lease negotiation be a campaign front: the party’s actions tick clocks for Aeler, rajas, Admiralty, and Covenant.
- Use the mines, bridges, and the Viceroy’s hall as arenas for social contests, where a breath-count is a threat and a sealed mine is a death sentence.
- Encourage players to earn **Share Tokens** from the elephant caravans — these are not debts but markers of mutual trust.

In the Mountain Satrapies, the mountain forgets nothing — and the ninth breath is always waiting. But the mountain also remembers every kindness, every shared fire, every elephant that was fed.

Chapter 30

The Brass Coast

Shore of Silver and Spice.

The tariff is the law. The law is the tariff. I do not care if your goods are stolen, blessed, or weeping. I care that you pay. The Admiralty does not rule this coast. The ledger rules. I am merely its pen.

I am a Sidhi Freedman. My grandmother was born in Galanina. My mother was born in a slave ship. I was born in a lighthouse. The Admiralty calls me a subject. The Covenant calls me a freedman. I call myself a Sidhi of the Brass Coast. We are far from home, but the tide remembers.

The Brass Coast is Dhahara's southern rim: a humid, feverish coastline of palm groves, salt pans, and crowded port cities. The Kahfagian Admiralty administers it as a "client province," but the Sidhi run the real trade, and the local Dhaharan rajas chafe under foreign tariffs. Here, a man can buy anything—a ship, a spice lot, a freedman's seal—and sell anything except his own shadow. But here's the secret the Admiralty doesn't want you to know: the ropeways that carry spice baskets from ship to warehouse are braided with Sidhi hair. The dead still pull their weight. And the dead are not content to be forgotten.

The Admiralty's Maritime Court settles disputes with a judge's gavel and a marine's cutlass. The Sidhi lighthouse courts offer an alternative: justice by green flame, witnessed by the drowned. The Sidhi do not forget—and they do not forgive. A Sidhi merchant's word is her bond, because every bond is witnessed by a lighthouse lamp and recorded in a water-resistant ledger. The Admiralty holds the legal authority, but the Sidhi hold the ropes. A Sidhi strike could halt all trade in a day.

Never board a ship that has a green lantern at the mast. It means the

captain is under a death vow—and you are the payment.

— *Syndic Olena, Port-Master of Tamralipta, whose brass hook is also a stamp*

The Almanac of Ordinary Days

What do people eat for breakfast? Rice and fermented fish paste—the rice is grown in coastal paddies, the fish is caught by the lighthouse keepers' children. The children are paid in copper. The copper is melted into seals. The seals are sold to freedmen.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To read a lighthouse code. Brass Coast children are taught the eight lamp-flashes: Tariff, Inspection, Quarantine, Smuggler, Pirate, Rescue, Home, and the ninth—the flash that means "the collector is coming." The ninth flash is never used. The ninth flash is a warning.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their papers. The Admiralty requires a manifest for every shipment, a seal for every trader, a stamp for every dock. A stranger whose papers are in order is a merchant. A stranger whose papers are missing is a smuggler. A stranger whose papers are too perfect is a spy. The spies are Admiralty. The Admiralty spies on itself.

What is the most common crime? Tariff evasion—but tariff evasion is not a crime, it is a profession. The tariffs are set by the Admiralty. The Admiralty is corrupt. The evaders pay the Admiralty directly. The payment is called a "consulting fee." The fee is tax-deductible.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The lighthouse lamps are not fuelled by oil. They are fuelled by the fat of the drowned—whales, sailors, slaves who did not survive the crossing. The fat burns green. The green is the colour of memory. The memory is the dead's.

Where do people go when they die? To the sea. The dead are weighted with brass and dropped in the deep channel. The channel is called the Freedman's Grave. The grave is unmarked. The grave is the entire coast.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You offer a tariff—a payment of silver, calculated by the wronged party's estimate of their loss. The tariff is paid to the Maritime Court. The court takes a percentage. The percentage is the judge's fee. The judge's fee is negotiable.

What is the most important festival? The Burning of the Ledgers (new year). Every merchant's ledger is brought to the lighthouse. The ledgers are read aloud. The debts are tallied. The ledgers are burned. The ash falls on the water. The water carries the debts to the sea. The sea does not forgive. The sea reschedules.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The lighthouse lamps are not all green. One lamp burns blue—the Admiral's personal beacon. The blue flame is not fat. It is a spirit—a Sidhi oracle who was bound to the lighthouse nine generations ago. She sees everything. She speaks to no one. The Admiral does not know she is still alive.

30.1 The Brass Coast — “The Shore of Silver and Spice”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *Every tariff is a story. Every story has a price. The green flame remembers.*

Admiralty Port-Master (Elite): “The tariff is the law. The law is the tariff. I do not care if your goods are stolen, blessed, or weeping. I care that you pay. The Admiralty does not rule this coast. The ledger rules. I am merely its pen.”

Sidhi Freedman (Commoner): “My grandmother was born in Galanina. My mother was born in a slave ship. I was born in a lighthouse. The Admiralty calls me a subject. The Covenant calls me a freedman. I call myself a Sidhi of the Brass Coast. We are far from home, but the tide remembers.”

Genre / Mood: Mercantile noir, post-colonial tension, ghost-lit coast.

Starting Location: The pepper auction floor, where a hundred merchants clap their bids and a whalebone hammer cracks. A Sidhi port-master pulls you aside: “The Admiralty has doubled the tariff on Sidhi goods. The lighthouse keepers are talking of a strike. And there is a green lantern ship in the harbour — the Drowned Captain’s. The dead are offering passage. I need you to find out why.”

Theme & Atmosphere

The Brass Coast is Dhahara’s southern rim: a humid, feverish coastline of palm groves, salt pans, and crowded port cities. The Kahfagian Admiralty administers it as a “client province,” but the Sidhi run the real trade, and the local Dhaharan rajas chafe under foreign tariffs. The air smells of pepper, cinnamon, and the low tide of a thousand ships. Here, a man can buy anything — a ship, a spice lot, a freedman’s seal — and sell anything except his own shadow. The Admiralty’s Maritime Court settles disputes with a judge’s gavel and a marine’s cutlass. The Sidhi lighthouse courts offer an alternative: justice by green flame, witnessed by the drowned. The ropeways that carry spice baskets from ship to warehouse are braided with Sidhi hair — a reminder that the dead still pull their weight.

What you notice first: The heat pressing down like a damp cloth. The constant noise of haggling in a dozen languages. The way the sea is the same colour as the sky, so the horizon disappears.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never board a ship that has a green lantern at the mast. It means the captain is under a death vow — and you are the payment.

Regional Mood: The Weight of the Tariff

Power here is measured in spice lots, tariff exemptions, and the allegiance of the lighthouse keepers. The Admiralty holds the legal authority, but the Sidhi hold the ropes — literally. The ropeways that move cargo are Sidhi-built and Sidhi-maintained; a Sidhi strike could halt all trade in a day. The native Dhaharan rajas of the inland hills resent the Admiralty’s taxes and the Sidhi’s influence, but they need the ports to sell their iron and tea. The Covenant has a Maritime Court in every major port, but the Admiralty often ignores its rulings. The Brass Coast is not a colony; it is an argument.

Prominent NPCs of the Brass Coast

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Admiral Voss	Kahfagian Governor of the Brass Coast	Maximise tariff revenue for the Admiralty	He keeps a ledger in his own blood; he says ink fades.
Syndic Olena	Port-master of Tamralipta	Enforce the tariff schedule	She has a brass hook where her left hand used to be; the hook is also a stamp.
Captain Idris	Sidhi lighthouse commander	Keep the Brass Coast free of Ashaani slavers	His left eye is a brass lens; he can read the stars even in fog.
Shipwright Elara	Builder of freedmen's boats	Launch one new vessel each year for escaped slaves	She names each boat after a dead family member. The names are never painted — only carved.
Raja Govind	Inland hill ruler (native Dhaharan)	Break the Admiralty's monopoly on spice exports	He has never seen the sea. He is afraid of it.

Names of the Brass Coast

Inspired by the southern coasts: Tamil and Sinhalese influences, with Sidhi and Kahfagian admixtures. Surnames denote a port, a boat, or a trade.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surname/Clan	Epithets
Voss	Olena	Pallava	<i>the Brass-Fingered</i>
Idris	Elara	Chettiar	<i>Coin-Counter</i>
Govind	Mangai	Saliya	<i>the Tide-Reader</i>
Kannan	Ilavarasi	Pattinam	<i>Lighthouse Born</i>
Muthu	Kalyani	Mudaliar	<i>Shark-Tooth</i>

(Harbour/Warehouse/Lighthouse) Tamralipta harbour (a forest of masts); pepper warehouse with slatted walls; Sidhi lighthouse with a brass mirror and green flame.

Spades — Places

2. **Tamralipta Harbour** — A forest of masts; the smell of tar and spices. *The harbour is a maze of floating houses. The residents are all Sidhi. They never touch the shore.* ‘[TRADE]’
3. **Pepper Warehouse** — A long building with slatted walls; the air is sharp. *The workers are freedmen earning passage for their families. Their eyes are red from pepper dust. They never blink.* ‘[LABOR]’
4. **Lighthouse of the Brass Flame** — A stone tower with a copper mirror. *The light is green. It shows the faces of the drowned. The keeper knows their names.* ‘[JUSTICE]’
5. **Salt Pan of the Silent Widows** — A flat expanse of white crust; women in black work the rakes. *The women are all widows; their husbands were lost at sea. The salt is bitter. They sell it to remember.* ‘[COMMUNITY]’
6. **Kahfagian Admiralty House** — A white building with a veranda; a flag with a lantern. *The flag is lowered at sunset. The Admiral is drunk by dawn. The clerks are sober — and watching.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
7. **Sidhi Court of the Lighthouse** — A circular chamber with a brass scale. *The judge is blind; she hears truth in the echo of a coin. The coin is never returned.* ‘[JUSTICE]’
8. **Palm Grove of the Elephants** — A grove where temple elephants are bathed. *The elephants are painted with turmeric. The paint is a prayer for safe passage.* ‘[RITUAL]’
9. **Coral Reef of the Sunken Ship** — A reef just offshore; a mast breaks the surface. *The ship was a slaver; the slaves escaped. They live in the reef now. They trade salvage for silence.* ‘[LEGEND]’
10. **Pepper Auction Floor** — A crowded hall; voices bid in claps. *The auctioneer has a hammer of whalebone. It cracks when he lies. The cracks are getting louder.* ‘[TRADE]’
- J **The Green Lantern Tavern** — A low building with a green lantern. *The lantern is never lit. The owner says it would attract the wrong kind of dead. The right kind drink here for free.* ‘[SOCIAL]’
- Q **The Shipbreaker’s Yard** — A beach where old ships are dismantled. *The workers are convicts; they wear chains that drag in the sand. They earn one link off each season.* ‘[LABOR]’
- K **The Admiral’s Palace (Former Fort)** — A former Sidhi fort, now occupied by Kahfagian officers. *The flag is flown upside down. The Admiral does not know the difference. The Sidhi do. They count the days.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
- A **The Undercliff (Smuggler’s Cove)** — A smuggler’s cove accessible only at low tide. *The entrance is a cave; the cave leads to a hidden harbour. The harbour is a city of thieves — and a union of freedmen.* ‘[LEGEND]’

(Keeper/Factor/Raja) Sidhi lighthouse keeper with a brass telescope; pepper factor with red-stained fingers; Raja Govind, afraid of the sea.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Sidhi Lighthouse Keeper** — Blind in one eye; carries a brass telescope. He can see the future through the lens. *“Only the futures that end at sea,” he says. “The rest are private. I sell them to captains who need to avoid them.”* ‘[JUSTICE]’

3. **Kahfagian Port-Master (Syndic Olena)** — A thin woman with a brass hook for a hand. The hook is a stamp. *She stamps every tariff receipt. The stamp leaves a scar. She says it builds character.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
4. **Pepper Factor** — A thin woman with red-stained fingers and a black tongue. *She can tell the quality of pepper by taste. She has never been wrong. She has also never been paid on time.* ‘[TRADE]’
5. **Shipwright Elara (Sidhi)** — A woman with a hammer and a jar of brass nails. She builds boats for freed slaves. *Each boat is named after a dead family member. The names are never painted — only carved. The wood remembers.* ‘[COMMUNITY]’
6. **Admiral Voss** — A grey-haired man with a glass eye. The glass eye is from a defeated pirate. *The pirate still watches through it. Voss does not sleep well. The eye weeps salt water.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
7. **Raja Govind (Inland)** — A young man in silk, come to the coast to sell iron. He has never seen the sea. *He is afraid of it. He refuses to step on a boat. He negotiates from the shore, shouting through a brass horn.* ‘[POLITICS]’
8. **Smuggler Captain (Brass Coast)** — A woman with a parrot on her shoulder, a curved knife on her belt. *The parrot is her navigator; it knows the reefs by sound. The parrot is blind. It has never been wrong.* ‘[STEALTH]’
9. **Ashaani Refugee (Family)** — A family hiding in a pepper warehouse. They paid the factor to forget them. *The factor forgets nothing. He is waiting for a better offer. The family is saving for a boat.* ‘[COMMUNITY]’
10. **The Drowned Priest (Ghost)** — A ghost in a wet robe who walks the shore at low tide. *He asks for a coin to pay the ferryman. Give it, and he will not follow. Refuse, and he will ask for a story instead.* ‘[DEATH]’
- J **The Black Bishop (Covenant Maritime Judge)** — A judge who rules on maritime disputes. He wears a ring made from a ship’s nail. *The ship was the first slaver he freed. The nail still has rust on it. He calls it his conscience.* ‘[JUSTICE]’
- Q **The Green Lantern’s Owner** — A woman with no shadow. She sold her shadow for the tavern. *The shadow now serves drinks. The customers do not notice. The shadow remembers every secret.* ‘[MYSTERY]’
- K **The Sea King of Kalinga (Pirate Lord)** — A pirate lord with a fleet of painted dhows. *He has nine wives; each is from a different kingdom. The ninth is a spy. He knows. He keeps her for the gossip.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
- A **The First Freedman (Legend)** — A slave who bought his freedom with a story. He now sits at the bottom of the Ninth Well. *If you tell him a true story, he will tell you the location of a hidden lighthouse. The lighthouse is not on any map.* ‘[LEGEND]’

(**Fire/Press/Blockade**) Pepper dust fire — the air is flammable; Admiral’s press gang — marines grab bystanders; Sea King’s tax — pirate fleet blockades the harbour.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Pepper Dust Fire** — A spark ignites a warehouse; the air is flammable. ‘[DISASTER]’ *The workers are trapped. Save them or save the cargo. The fire is spreading. The pepper smoke makes you cough memories.*

3. **Admiral’s Press Gang** — Kahfagian marines grab bystanders for the fleet. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[COMBAT]’ *The marines are drunk. They do not recognise rank. One of the bystanders is a Covenant judge. She is about to be impressed. She asks for your help.*
4. **Green Lantern Lit** — Someone lights the forbidden lantern at the tavern. The dead come. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[FEAR]’ *They are looking for the person who killed them. That person is in your party. The lantern owner will not extinguish it.*
5. **Shipbreaker’s Curse** — A cursed ship in the yard breaks its chains. It wants a new victim — a ship’s captain. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[COMBAT]’ *The captain is you. The ship was a slaver. It remembers your face from a raid you did not commit. Its chains are warm.*
6. **Tariff Hike (Admiralty)** — The port-master doubles duties on all goods. The hike is a bribe. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[DEBT]’ *The bribe is to the Black Bishop. The Bishop has already accepted. Your protest is treason. The merchants are watching.*
7. **Coral Reef Piracy** — Pirates hide behind the reef; they attack at dusk. ‘[COMBAT]’ ‘[STEALTH]’ *The pirates are escaped slaves. They do not take prisoners. They also do not know the reef’s safe channel. Their navigator is a blind parrot.*
8. **Elephant Rampage (Coast)** — A temple elephant breaks free and runs through the market. ‘[DISASTER]’ *It is looking for its mahout, who was arrested. The mahout is innocent. The elephant will not hurt children. Adults are another matter.*
9. **Smuggler’s Betrayal** — A smuggler captain sells the party to the Admiralty. ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[TRAP]’ *The betrayal was a test. The captain wants to see if you can escape. If you do, you are worthy of trust. If not, you were never worth the cargo space.*
10. **Sea King’s Tax (Blockade)** — A Kalingan pirate fleet blockades the harbour. The tax is one ship. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[COMBAT]’ *Choose which ship to give up. The Sea King will remember your choice. The crew will remember longer.*
- J **Drowned Priest’s Demand** — The ghost appears during the day. He asks for a name. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The name must be someone who owes a death. If you cannot give one, he takes yours. He writes it in a ledger that never dries.*
- Q **Black Bishop’s Verdict (False)** — The judge declares the party’s cargo forfeit. The verdict is false. ‘[JUSTICE]’ ‘[TRAP]’ *The bishop is bribed. The briber is the Admiralty. Prove it, or lose everything. The real verdict is written in disappearing ink.*
- K **Sea King’s Ninth Wife (Spy)** — The spy reveals herself. She offers a deal: the Sea King’s treasure for safe passage. ‘[POLITICS]’ ‘[MAGIC]’ *The treasure is a curse. The curse is a fragment of the Kalrantha amulet. The amulet whispers in your sleep.*
- A **Undercliff Collapse** — A rockslide seals the smuggler’s cove. Inside are the party and a monster. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[TRAP]’ *The monster is a salt-crocodile. It is blind. It hunts by sound. Do not scream. The walls are listening.*

(**Charter/Lens/Seal**) Lighthouse charter (right to anchor in any Sidhi port); lighthouse keeper’s lens (reveals the nearest slaver ship); freedman’s seal (proof of emancipation).

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Lighthouse Charter (Brass Key)** — The right to anchor in any Sidhi port without inspection. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The key fits a lock on a sea-chest, not a harbour gate. The chest contains a map of smuggler’s coves. The map is tattooed on a dead sailor’s back.*

3. **Lighthouse Keeper's Lens (Brass Tube)** — Look through it to see the nearest slaver ship. '[JUSTICE]' *The lens also shows the faces of the slaves on board. They look back. They do not blink.*
4. **Freedman's Seal (Brand on Leather)** — Proof of emancipation. Glows when a slaver ship is near. '[SOCIAL]' *It also glows when a Black Hand agent is near. Trust the glow. It has never been wrong.*
5. **Pepper Merchant's Seal (Wax)** — A wax seal from a dead factor. Present it to sell pepper at double price. '[TRADE]' *The factor's ghost haunts the warehouse. He will ask for a story. The story must be about a bad deal.*
6. **Salt Widow's Blessing (Bag)** — A bag of bitter salt. Throw it into the sea to calm a storm. '[WEATHER]' *The salt is from the widows' pans. They have blessed it with their tears. The storm will pause for one hour.*
7. **Admiral's Pardon (Signed)** — A signed document. Cancels one crime on the Brass Coast. '[AUTHORITY]' *The Admiral signs with a glass eye. The signature is a lie. The pardon still works. The eye watches you afterwards.*
8. **Sidhi Court Ruling (Written)** — A written judgment. Win any maritime dispute in a Sidhi court. '[JUSTICE]' *The ruling is valid only if witnessed by a lighthouse keeper. The keeper is Idris. He will witness for a story.*
9. **Elephant's Tooth (Tusk)** — A tusk from a temple elephant. Present it to any temple for shelter. '[SOCIAL]' *The elephant was executed for killing its mahout. The temple will not refuse. They will also not ask questions.*
10. **Shipbreaker's Hook** — The hook of a dead shipbreaker. Use it to command the cursed ship in the yard. '[MAGIC]' *The ship will obey one command — then it will try to drown you. The hook is warm. It remembers its owner's last words.*
- J **Smuggler's Map (Tattooed Skin)** — A chart of hidden coves, tattooed on a dead sailor's back. '[TRAVEL]' *The skin is preserved in salt water. It must be kept wet or the map fades. The sailor's ghost will guide you — for a fee.*
- Q **Sea King's Pardon (Flag)** — A flag of truce. Fly it to pass Kalingan waters unharmed. '[TRAVEL]' *The flag is a shirt. The shirt belonged to a dead pirate. He may want it back. He will ask politely.*
- K **Green Lantern's Flame (Small)** — A small lantern that burns green. Light it to summon the dead. '[DEATH]' *They will answer one question. Then they will ask one. The question is never easy. The answer is never free.*
- A **Black Bishop's Ring (Ship's Nail)** — Wear it to be immune to Admiralty arrest in Sidhi ports. '[JUSTICE]' *The nail is from a freed slaver. The slaves' ghosts protect you. They also watch. They judge. They remember.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (charters, lenses, seals) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **coast-omens**—green flames that burn blue, salt that tastes sweet, a drowned face in a still puddle.

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **The Sidhi Diaspora Network:** Sidhi characters gain +1 die on social rolls with other Sidhi, but –1 die on social rolls with Admiralty officials (who view them with suspicion). Once per session, a Sidhi PC can declare a “lighthouse contact” in any port — a cousin, a freedman, a former shipmate who will offer safe harbour or a warning.
- **The Tariff Clock [6]:** Represents the Admiralty’s pressure on local trade. Each time the party bribes an official, smuggles goods, or is caught without papers, tick the clock. At 3 segments: all goods cost +1 Supply. At 6: a general audit is declared — all ships are searched, and the party gains a “Wanted by Customs” tag (social DV +1 in any Admiralty-controlled port).
- **Green Flame Justice:** Sidhi lighthouse courts operate on the principle of “witnessed truth.” Any party member may request a green flame judgment instead of a conventional trial. Roll Presence + Lore (DV 4). On success, the judge rules in your favour; on a miss, the green flame shows a hidden crime you committed, and the penalty is doubled.
- **Ropeway Leverage:** The ropeways are the arteries of the coast. A character who controls a ropeway (by owning a share, bribing a foreman, or holding a Sidhi charter) may impose a “ropeway toll” on any cargo moving through that district: +1 Supply to the party or –1 Supply to a rival. Using this leverage ticks the Tariff Clock by 1.
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
 - **The Green Keeper** — The Witness. *The flame that shows the truth, even when it burns.*
 - **The Hook** — Maelstraeus. *The price of a second chance; the interest on a freedman’s soul.*
 - **The Tide Father** — Khemesh. *The pressure beneath the keel; the debt that the sea collects.*
 - **The Lantern Bearer** — The Traveler. *The light that guides lost ships — and lost souls.*

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **Sidhi Freedmen and the Breath-less (Ashaan):** The Sidhi of the Brass Coast have family who were taken as slaves to Ashaan. A freedman’s seal can be used to smuggle a Breath-less agent out of Galanina. Captain Idris has done this nine times. The tenth may be his last.
- **Spice Trade and the Fhara (Way of Silk):** Pepper from the Brass Coast is a major commodity on the Fhara caravan routes. A Fhara well-judge may accept a Sidhi lighthouse charter as proof of credit. The charter must be witnessed by a living flame.
- **The Undercliff and the Kalrantha Amulet (Dhahara):** The smuggler’s cove is a known transit point for artifacts stolen from the Himadri temple. The Sea King’s ninth wife claims to have seen the amulet pass through. She also claims the amulet spoke to her. It asked for a drink of water.
- **The Drowned Priest and the Hollow (Eastern Realms):** The ghost who walks the shore at low tide is said to be a Debt-Walker who lost his way. Aelaerem leave offerings of salt to keep him from following them home. The salt must be from the pans of the Silent Widows. Any other salt will attract him.

Brass Coast Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Tide:** Toss a crust into the harbour. Ignore the first *Pepper Dust Fire* penalty. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Knot the Anchor Chain:** Tie a sailor’s knot in a mooring rope. Cancel *Admiral’s Press Gang* or take –1 die on your next escape roll (your choice). ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Name to the Lighthouse:** Whisper a dead captain’s name into the green flame. Gain +1 Effect when smuggling this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Sidhi. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **Admiralty customs or Sidhi port-masters**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **warehouse guards or lighthouse keepers**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **smugglers or the Black Bishop’s spies**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favourable tide**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Local port-master or lighthouse commander** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **green flash or rising tide**.
- **Foe Appears:** An **Admiralty press gang or a Sidhi enforcer** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **Admiralty marines, Sidhi ropemen, or pirate dhows** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes—**tariff hike/green lantern lit/shipbreaker’s curse activates**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **Admiral Voss, Black Bishop, or Drowned Priest** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically—**harbour catches fire/lighthouse collapses/undercliff floods**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice—**omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.

- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Brass Coast (Tariff Law):** Scales tip without weight, ledgers rewrite themselves, a port-master’s hook stamps a nullity.
- **Brass Coast (Lighthouse Law):** Green flame flickers, salt crystals form on skin, a drowned face appears in a puddle.
- **Brass Coast (Smuggler’s Law):** Ropeways hum with whispers, a parrot speaks a secret, a hidden cove appears on no map.

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Wits + Sail):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Green Flash*.
- **Cut the Tariff (Presence + Sway):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a lighthouse charter is in your possession, +1 die.
- **Weather the Raid (Resolve + Spirit):** On a hit in *Admiral’s Press Gang*, you pick who is taken; on a miss, the GM does.

Boss Seeds (Tariff & Flame)

- **The Hook-Master (Nine Stamps)** — *Phases:* Tariff Forgeries → Orchestrated Strike → Port Coup. *Cracks:* recover a true stamp, expose a forged ledger, survive a night in a lighthouse.
- **The Drowned Admiral (Ghost Fleet)** — *Phases:* Lost Ships Called Home → Procession of Empty Lanterns → Tide-Baptism of a Factor. *Cracks:* relic green flame, survivor testimony, the lighthouse keeper’s lens turning clear.

Patronage & Power

On the Brass Coast, power flows through tariffs, lighthouse charters, and the weight of the green flame. The Admiralty holds the legal authority, but the Sidhi control the ropes and the courts. The native rajas of the inland hills resent both, but they need the ports. The Covenant’s Black Bishop is the only neutral arbiter — and he is not as neutral as he seems. **For the GM:** Power on the Brass Coast is measured in spice lots, tariff exemptions, and the loyalty of the lighthouse keepers. Patronage often takes the form of lighthouse charters, freedman’s seals, or a Black Bishop’s ruling — each tied to a specific port, ship, or court. To emphasize the Sidhi minority presence:

- Make Sidhi NPCs scarce but influential. A Sidhi port-master may be the only person who can issue a freedman’s seal.
- Let the Admiralty’s tariffs be a recurring obstacle — players must find Sidhi smugglers or bribe officials to avoid ruinous taxes.
- Use the tension between the Maritime Court and the lighthouse courts as a source of adventures: a disputed verdict, a bribed judge, a ghost that testifies.

On the Brass Coast, the sea forgets nothing — and the green flame remembers every face.

Chapter 31

The Nine Kingdoms

The Peacock Throne and Its Rivals.

The Peacock Throne is not a seat. It is a promise made by the first sun king: that the nine kingdoms would remain nine, never one, never fewer. I do not rule. I balance. A peacock's tail has nine eyes. Each eye watches a different kingdom. When one closes, the throne weeps.

I am a Temple Dancer. My dance is not for the king. It is for the monsoon. If my ankle bells ring true, the rains come. If they falter, the wells dry. They have never faltered. I do not sleep before a performance. I dream the rhythm.

Between the Satrapies plateau and the Brass Coast lies a fertile, contested lowland: the land of the Nine Kingdoms. This is the heart of Dhahara, where ancient dynasties still claim descent from the sun, and where the Peacock Throne of Ahimsa casts its shadow over half a dozen rival courts. Here, rivers are borders, elephants are war machines, and every harvest is a negotiation between kings who have never met but whose grandfathers swore blood oaths. But here's the secret the Maharaja doesn't want you to know: the number "nine" is a lie. There have never been nine kingdoms. The number is a ritual—a prayer that the Hollow will not notice that one of the nine is always missing. The throne weeps because the missing kingdom is always the one that mattered.

The Covenant has a strong presence in the sacred cities; the Aeler have counting houses in the iron towns; the Sidhi sail up the rivers to trade. But the Nine Kingdoms belong to the Dhaharan—to their poets, their temple dancers, their bandit kings, and their queens who rule from behind silk screens. A king's authority rests on his genealogy—how many generations back to the sun, how many treaties sealed, how many marriages made. The Peacock

Throne of Ahimsa is the nominal centre, but the other eight kings vie for influence, and the balance shifts with every monsoon.

Never praise a king's elephant. The elephant is sacred; your praise will be taken as an insult to the king's own mount. Compliment the mahout instead. The mahout will tell the elephant.

— *Temple Dancer Mira, who has stopped three droughts and started none*

The Almanac of Ordinary Days

What do people eat for breakfast? Rice porridge with mango pickle—the rice is from the royal granaries, the mangoes are from the king's orchards. The king's orchards are irrigated by the river. The river is contested. The contest is a negotiation. The negotiation is breakfast.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To recite their genealogy. Nine Kingdoms children are taught the names of their ancestors back to the sun. A child who cannot recite is a child without a kingdom. A child without a kingdom is a servant. Servants are not fed.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their caste mark. The Nine Kingdoms have nine castes—priest, warrior, merchant, farmer, artisan, servant, outcast, foreigner, and the ninth—the caste that has no name. The ninth caste is the king's spies. The spies are everywhere. The spies have no caste mark.

What is the most common crime? Tax evasion—but tax evasion is not a crime, it is a political statement. The king's tax collectors are also the king's spies. A merchant who evades taxes is a merchant who has something to hide. The king wants to know what. The king will find out.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Peacock Throne is empty. The Maharaja died seven years ago. His death was concealed by the courtiers, who rule in his name. The courtiers are the nine ministers. The ninth minister is a eunuch who controls the palace guards. The eunuch has the real power.

Where do people go when they die? To the river. The dead are cremated on the ghats. Their ashes are scattered on the water. The water flows to the sea. The sea is the kingdom's border. The border is a negotiation. The negotiation never ends.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You offer a dance—a performance at the temple of the sun. The dance is judged by the priest. If the priest smiles, you are forgiven. If the priest weeps, you are not. If the priest is silent, you are cursed. The curse is the sun's glare. The sun will not look away.

What is the most important festival? The Coronation of the Monsoon (summer). The king offers a golden elephant to the rain clouds. The clouds accept or refuse. The clouds have refused for nine years. The king's treasury is empty. The king's patience is not.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The golden elephant is hollow. It is filled with the ashes of the ninth king—the one who tried to unite the kingdoms and failed. His ghost rides the monsoon winds. His ghost is still trying. His ghost will never succeed.

31.1 The Nine Kingdoms — “The Peacock Throne and Its Rivals”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *Nine thrones, one shadow. The peacock watches. The well remembers.*

Maharaja of Ahimsa (Elite): “The Peacock Throne is not a seat. It is a promise made by the first sun king: that the nine kingdoms would remain nine, never one, never fewer. I do not rule. I balance. A peacock’s tail has nine eyes. Each eye watches a different kingdom. When one closes, the throne weeps.”

Temple Dancer (Commoner): “My dance is not for the king. It is for the monsoon. If my ankle bells ring true, the rains come. If they falter, the wells dry. They have never faltered. I do not sleep before a performance. I dream the rhythm.”

Genre / Mood: Courtly intrigue, elephant warfare, monsoon ritual, honour as currency.

Starting Location: The Peacock Throne Hall in Ahimsa, where a golden peacock with ruby eyes watches the court. The Maharaja’s chamberlain approaches: “The Maharaja wishes to renew the Nine-Kingdom Pact. But the King of Vajrapur has sent a forged genealogy. The Queen of Mahishmati has refused to attend. And the ninth kingdom — the one that is always missing — has sent a messenger. The messenger is a ghost. Speak carefully.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Between the Sarpies plateau and the Brass Coast lies a fertile, contested lowland: the land of the Nine Kingdoms. This is the heart of Dhahara, where ancient dynasties still claim descent from the sun, and where the Peacock Throne of Ahimsa casts its shadow over half a dozen rival courts. Here, rivers are borders, elephants are war machines, and every harvest is a negotiation between kings who have never met but whose grandfathers swore blood oaths. The Covenant has a strong presence in the sacred cities; the Aeler have counting houses in the iron towns; the Sidhi sail up the rivers to trade. But the Nine Kingdoms belong to the Dhaharan — to their poets, their temple dancers, their bandit kings, and their queens who rule from behind silk screens. The number “nine” is traditional; the actual number of kingdoms fluctuates with wars, marriages, and the mood of the Peacock Throne.

What you notice first: The smell of jasmine and dust. The way every crossroads has a painted stone — a boundary marker, a warning, a prayer. The constant murmur of bazaars where haggling is a form of theatre.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never praise a king’s elephant. The elephant is sacred; your praise will be taken as an insult to the king’s own mount. Compliment the mahout instead. The mahout will tell the elephant.

Regional Mood: The Weight of the Peacock

Power here is measured in river rights, elephant herds, and the thickness of a dynasty’s archive. A king’s authority rests on his genealogy — how many generations back to the sun, how many treaties sealed, how many marriages made. The Peacock Throne of Ahimsa is the nominal centre, but the other eight kings vie for influence, and the balance shifts with every monsoon. The Covenant judges provide legal arbitration; the temple dancers control the ritual calendar; the bandit kings of Kalinga

pay no tribute to anyone. The number nine is sacred, but also a warning: when a ninth kingdom falls, the Hollow comes.

Prominent NPCs of the Nine Kingdoms

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Maharaja Suryavarman	King of Ahimsa (Peacock Throne)	Unite the nine under his dynasty	He has a pet peacock that follows him; the peacock's cry is a warning of assassination attempts.
Rani Chandravati	Queen of Vajrapur (Iron Kingdom)	Protect the iron mines from Aeler encroachment	She wears a bracelet of dwarf teeth — each tooth is from an engineer she outwitted.
King Bhim	Buffalo King of Mahishmati	Expand his pastoral kingdom into Anga	He has never lost a buffalo race; his buffalo is named “Conqueror.”
Covenant High Judge Vasu	Head of the Kosala sacred circuit	Enforce contract law across the nine kingdoms	He carries a scale that never balances; he says justice is never equal, only weighed.
Temple Dancer Mira	Devadasi of the Peacock Throne	Keep the peace through ritual	Her dance is said to bring rain; she has stopped three droughts.

Names of the Nine Kingdoms

Sanskrit and Prakrit roots, with honourifics (Rao, Singh, Deva, Bai). Surnames often denote clan or profession.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Clan/Surname	Epithets
Surya	Chandravati	Somavamsi	<i>the Peacock</i>

Bhim	Mira	Kalachuri	<i>Iron-Fisted</i>
Vasu	Ganga	Yadava	<i>Buffalo-Loyal</i>
Rajendra	Lakshmi	Gupta	<i>the Coin-Eater</i>
Krishna	Durga	Pala	<i>the Learned</i>

(Hall/Gate/Track) Peacock Throne Hall with marble pillars; Iron Gate Market outside Vajrapur; Buffalo Race Track outside Mahishmati.

Spades — Places

2. **Peacock Throne Hall** — A vast chamber with pillars of carved marble; the throne is a peacock of gold and lapis lazuli. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The peacock’s eyes are rubies. They follow anyone who approaches the throne. The throne has never been sat upon by a usurper.*
 3. **Iron Gate Market (Vajrapur)** — A bazaar outside the fortress; the smell of iron dust and spices. ‘[TRADE]’ *The market has a section where slaves are sold. The slaves wear iron collars stamped with the king’s mark. One collar is always empty.*
 4. **Buffalo Race Track (Mahishmati)** — A dusty oval; the betting is fierce. ‘[SPORT]’ *The track has a shrine at the centre — a buffalo that never lost. Its skeleton is on display. The skeleton sometimes snorts.*
 5. **Sacred City of Sravasti (Kosala)** — A walled city with a thousand temples; the Covenant courthouse is here. ‘[JUSTICE]’ *The city has no bells. The Covenant forbids them. The silence is enforced by armed judges. The silence is loudest at noon.*
 6. **Anga Fort** — A hilltop fortress with a dry moat; the walls are painted with tiger stripes. ‘[DEFENSE]’ *The fortress has never been taken. The king’s secret is a network of hidden tunnels. The tunnels have not been mapped in a century.*
 7. **Western Port of Surashtra** — A Sidhi trading post; the harbour is full of dhows. ‘[TRADE]’ *The port has a lighthouse shaped like a woman. The woman is a Sidhi saint. Her lamp is lit with green flame.*
 8. **Rajagriha Ruins** — The former imperial capital, now a graveyard of broken pillars. ‘[RUINS]’ ‘[DEATH]’ *The ruins are haunted by the ghosts of Gupta emperors. They ask for news of their empire. They do not accept bad news.*
 9. **Elephant Stables of Ahimsa** — A complex of stone stalls; each elephant has its own name carved above the door. ‘[COMMUNITY]’ *The names are not the elephants’ birth names. They are the names of enemies they trampled. The elephants remember.*
 10. **Well of the Nine Kings** — A deep stepwell with nine landings; each landing has a statue of a different king. ‘[MYSTERY]’ *The water is black. It shows the face of the next king to die. The face changes when you blink.*
- J **Silent Court of Kosala** — A Covenant courthouse with no speaking allowed; all arguments are written. ‘[JUSTICE]’ *The judges write their verdicts in disappearing ink. Only they know the secret reagent. The reagent is tears.*
- Q **Peacock Gardens** — A walled garden behind the throne hall; only the king may enter. ‘[LEGEND]’ *The garden contains a single peacock that is immortal. It was the first king’s familiar. It has not eaten in three hundred years.*
- K **Whispering Pass (Anga-Mahishmati)** — A narrow defile where the wind carries conver-

sations. '[SPY]' *Spies use it to listen to enemy camps. The pass is named for the dead — they whisper too. Their whispers are always true.*

- A **Nine Kings' Tomb** — A subterranean complex where the founders of each dynasty are buried. '[DEATH]' '[LEGEND]' *The tomb is sealed. The key is a single word that changes each year — the name of the current weakest king. The word is never spoken aloud.*

(**Chamberlain/Overseer/Herders**) Peacock Throne chamberlain with a mirror on a stick; iron mines overseer (dwarf with a breath-counter); buffalo herder with a red turban.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Peacock Throne Chamberlain** — A eunuch in silk; he controls access to the king. '[AUTHORITY]' *He has a mirror on a stick; he uses it to see around corners. He has seen nine assassins before they struck. He has not warned the king about the tenth.*
 3. **Iron Mines Overseer (Dwarf)** — Wears an Aeler breath-counter. He is loyal to the queen, but his cousin is a viceroy's clerk. '[POLITICS]' *He keeps two ledgers. One is for the queen. One is for the Aeler. Both are forgeries. The truth is in his head. He is losing his memory.*
 4. **Buffalo Herder** — A young man with a staff and a red turban. '[COMMUNITY]' *He can find water in a drought by listening to the ground. His buffalo have never gone thirsty. He shares his wells with travellers.*
 5. **Covenant Judge (High Judge Vasu)** — A grey-haired man with a brass scale. He has never smiled. '[JUSTICE]' *His clerks have never seen him eat. He drinks only rainwater. He says food clouds the mind. His judgments are always delivered at noon.*
 6. **Temple Dancer (Mira)** — A woman with anklets of silver and eyes lined with kohl. '[RITUAL]' *Her dance is a prayer. The prayer is for peace. She has never failed — but the peace never lasts. She dances anyway.*
 7. **Bandit of Kalinga** — A man with a parrot on his shoulder, a scar across his face. '[STEALTH]' *The parrot is his conscience. It screams when he lies. He lies often. The parrot has lost its voice.*
 8. **Spice Merchant (Sidhi)** — A Sidhi trader with a leather bag full of cinnamon. He speaks seven languages. '[TRADE]' *He lies in all of them. His weights are true, though. He says the weights are the only honest thing about him.*
 9. **Poet of the Peacock Throne** — A woman with a stringed instrument, her voice cracked from singing. '[SOCIAL]' *She writes verses for the king. The verses are encoded warnings. The king cannot read. He has her sing them instead.*
 10. **Well Keeper of the Nine Kings** — A blind woman who sits by the stepwell. '[MYSTERY]' *She knows the depth of the water by the echo of a dropped stone. She knows the future by the same echo. She does not charge for her visions. She charges for the silence afterwards.*
- J **Ghost of Rajagriha** — A translucent figure in a crown. He asks one question: "Does my empire still stand?" '[DEATH]' *The answer must be a lie, or he will weep and flood the ruins. The lie must be kind. He can tell the difference.*
- Q **Silent Judge's Clerk** — A young woman who writes in disappearing ink. She is the only one who knows the reagent. '[JUSTICE]' *She has been attacked twice. She carries a dagger made of frozen ink. The ink melts after one use.*
- K **Peacock Keeper** — A boy who tends the immortal peacock. The peacock speaks to him.

‘[LEGEND]’ *It tells him which courtiers are plotting. The boy has never been wrong. He does not tell the king. He tells the peacock.*

- A **Ninth King’s Ghost** — A shade that walks the tomb. It points at the killer — but the killer is always a living king. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[FEAR]’ *It points at whoever is closest. That person is accused. The accusation is always false. The crowd does not care.*

(Stampede/Riot/Excommunication) Elephant stampede — trained to kill; buffalo race riot — crowd turns violent; Covenant excommunication — contract voided, goods seized.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Elephant Stampede (Royal)** — The king’s elephants break loose; they are trained to kill. ‘[DISASTER]’ ‘[COMBAT]’ *The stampede was ordered by a rival queen. The target is a visiting diplomat. The diplomat is you. The elephants are not confused.*
 3. **Buffalo Race Riot** — A disputed finish; the crowd turns violent. ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[COMBAT]’ *The dispute is a trap. The losing king wants an excuse to invade. You are the excuse. The buffalo are innocent.*
 4. **Covenant Excommunication** — High Judge Vasu declares your contract void; your goods are seized. ‘[JUSTICE]’ ‘[DEBT]’ *The excommunication is a bribe. The bribe was paid by a merchant you undercut. The merchant is in the crowd, smiling.*
 5. **Temple Dance Cursed** — Mira stumbles; the rain does not come. The priest blames the party. ‘[RITUAL]’ ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The sacrifice is a goat. The goat is a spy. The spy is working for Vajrapur. The goat will not stop talking.*
 6. **Spy in the Peacock Gardens** — Someone overheard the king’s war plans. ‘[POLITICS]’ ‘[STEALTH]’ *The spy is a poet. The poet is you — you were hired to write verses, not to eavesdrop. The king has a long memory for verse.*
 7. **Nine Kings’ Tomb Robbers** — Grave robbers break into the tomb. They seek the key word. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[THEFT]’ *The word is “forgiveness.” The robbers are agents of a rival kingdom. They do not know the word. They are digging anyway.*
 8. **Well of Nine Kings Poisoned** — The black water turns red; people sicken. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[WEATHER]’ *The poison was placed by an Ashaani agent. The agent wants to destabilise the kingdoms. The water tastes of iron and old regrets.*
 9. **Peacock Throne Assassination Attempt** — A courtier tries to kill the king. ‘[POLITICS]’ ‘[COMBAT]’ *The assassin is the chamberlain. The chamberlain is a spy for Vajrapur. He has been waiting nine years. His hands do not shake.*
 10. **Silent Court Leak** — A judge’s verdict is revealed before it is read. ‘[JUSTICE]’ ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The leak is a clerk. The clerk is selling secrets to the Bandit King. The verdict is your death. The clerk is sorry. He is not sorry enough.*
- J **Whispering Pass Ambush** — The party is caught in a crossfire between two kingdoms. ‘[COMBAT]’ ‘[STEALTH]’ *The pass is neutral ground. Both sides will claim you are a spy. Choose a side — or escape. The wind will carry your choice to both.*
- Q **Immortal Peacock’s Cry** — The peacock screams; the court panics. ‘[OMEN]’ ‘[FEAR]’ *The cry is a warning. An assassin is in the hall. The assassin is a guest. The peacock will not say which one. It wants to watch.*
- K **Ghost’s Demand (Ninth King)** — The ghost points at you. It accuses you of murdering

the king's descendant. '[DEATH]' '[SOCIAL]' *The descendant is an infant. You must prove your innocence. The ghost will not be reasoned with. It will accept a trade: one secret for one life.*

- A **Well's Vision** — One PC sees their own face in the black water. The face is old, scarred, and weeping. '[MYSTERY]' '[FEAR]' *The well says: "This is your future if you stay." The vision is true — but only for this moment. The moment is passing.*

(**Feather/Pass/Key**) Peacock feather (enter any court); iron gate pass (bypass customs); nine kings' key word ("forgiveness" — opens the tomb and a secret door in the Peacock Throne Hall).

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Peacock Feather** — A single iridescent feather from the immortal peacock. Present it to enter any court in the nine kingdoms. '[SOCIAL]' *The feather never fades. It glows when the king is lying. It glows brighter when you are lying. The king will notice.*
 3. **Iron Gate Pass (Brass Key)** — A brass key. Bypass customs at Vajrapur's market. '[TRAVEL]' *The key is also a weapon. It can break chains. It was forged from a slave collar. The slave's ghost thanks you every time you use it.*
 4. **Buffalo Horn Trumpet** — A carved horn. Blow it to summon a buffalo cavalry. '[COMBAT]' *The cavalry are mercenaries. They demand payment in land. One acre per horn blast. They will accept a story instead — if the story is about a lost battlefield.*
 5. **Covenant Seal (Kosala)** — A clay seal. Witness any contract in the sacred city. '[JUSTICE]' *The seal is fragile. It breaks if the contract is false. The breaking is loud. The sound carries for a mile. Everyone will know.*
 6. **Temple Dancer's Anklet (Silver)** — A silver anklet with bells. Wear it to gain +1 die to any persuasion roll. '[SOCIAL]' *The bells are silent unless you are honest. Dishonest words make no sound. The silence is more damning than a lie.*
 7. **Rajagriha Coin** — A Gupta-era gold coin. Trade it for a favour from the ghosts. '[DEATH]' *The ghosts will answer one question about the empire's fall. The answer is always a warning. The warning is always about you.*
 8. **Well Water (Vial)** — A vial of black water from the Nine Kings' Well. Drink it to see the future. '[MYSTERY]' *The future is always a death — yours or someone else's. The vision lasts one minute. You will not forget it.*
 9. **Silent Court Disappearing Ink (Bottle)** — A small bottle. Write a message that vanishes. '[STEALTH]' *The reagent is your own tears. The message reappears when you weep. The reappearance is permanent. Choose your tears carefully.*
 10. **Nine Kings' Key Word** — A single word: "forgiveness." Speak it to open the tomb. '[LEGEND]' *The word also opens a lock in the Peacock Throne Hall. The lock is a secret door. The door leads to a room that contains the king's true genealogy.*
- J **Immortal Peacock's Second Feather** — A tail feather from the immortal peacock. It is said to grant a wish. '[LEGEND]' '[MAGIC]' *The wish is that the king will die. Use it wisely. The feather burns after use. The peacock will know. It will not forgive.*
- Q **Whispering Pass's Map (Ear)** — A chart of the defile and its listening posts. Written on a human ear. '[SPY]' '[TRAVEL]' *The ear was from a spy. It still hears whispers. Hold it to your own ear to listen to distant conversations. The ear will whisper back. Do not answer.*

- K Peacock Throne’s Blessing (Decree)** — A royal decree. Demand a favour from any king of the nine. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The favour is limited: they will not start a war for you, but they will end one. They will also end a blood feud, a trade embargo, or a marriage alliance.*
- A Ninth King’s Crown (Gold Circlet)** — Found in the tomb. Wear it to command the ghosts of Rajagriha. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[LEGEND]’ *They will fight for you once. Then they will claim you as their king. You cannot leave the ruins. The ruins will grow around you. The ghosts will keep you company.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (feathers, keys, seals) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **peacock-omens**—ruby eyes that move, a well that reflects a face not yours, a throne that creaks when empty.

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **The Nine Kingdoms Pact Clock [8]:** Tracks the cohesion of the alliance. Advances when a kingdom sends a false genealogy, when a king refuses to attend the renewal, or when a border raid occurs. At 4 segments: tariffs increase between kingdoms. At 8: the pact collapses — war is declared, and the Peacock Throne becomes a target.
- **The Honor Dial (Reputation Track):** Each PC has a personal Honor score from –3 to +3. Gain Honor by keeping oaths, protecting the weak, and donating to temples. Lose Honor by breaking promises, insulting elders, or harming sacred animals. High Honor (+2 or +3) grants +1 Position in social encounters with nobles and priests. Low Honor (–2 or –3) doubles market prices and may trigger assassination attempts (GM’s discretion).
- **Elephant Bonding:** A character who spends a downtime scene with a war elephant may form a bond. The elephant gains a name and a personality. Once bonded, the elephant grants +1 die to the mahout’s Command rolls in battle, but the mahout suffers –1 die to social rolls with elephant-hating factions (e.g., the Aeler counting houses, who fear the beasts).
- **Ritual Calendar:** Temple dancers control the monsoon schedule. A party that earns the favour of a temple dancer (by protecting a shrine, funding a festival, or telling a true story) may ask for a “weather window”: one journey leg where rain, fog, or heat does not apply. Using this favour ticks the Honor Dial by –1 (the dancer’s rivals will spread rumours).
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
 - **The Peacock’s Eye** — The Witness. *The ruby that sees all false genealogies. It does not blink.*
 - **The Iron Queen** — Mykkiel. *The law that binds the nine kingdoms, even when kings forget.*
 - **The Monsoon Lord** — Khemesh. *The pressure that brings the rain — and the flood that follows.*
 - **The Dancing Star** — The Traveler. *The rhythm that guides the dancer’s feet and the monsoon’s arrival.*

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Nine Kings' Tomb and the Kalrantha Amulet (Dhahara):** The tomb is said to contain a map to the Himadri temple where the amulet was sealed. A rival king may offer the party a noble title in exchange for the map. The map is tattooed on the inside of the Ninth King's ghost. You will need to ask politely.
- **Covenant Judges and the Sidhi (Way of Silk):** High Judge Vasu has ruled on several cases involving Sidhi freedmen. He is known to be fair but harsh. A Sidhi port-master may ask the party to deliver a bribe — or a warning. The warning is written in disappearing ink. The ink is your own blood.
- **Elephant Herds and the Kuvani (Way of Silk):** The Kuvani have tried to buy war elephants from the Nine Kingdoms. The price is always refused — but a Kuvani remount master may offer a story worth the trade. The story must be about a horse that outran a king. The elephants will listen. They are not impressed.
- **The Immortal Peacock and the Hollow (Eastern Realms):** The peacock is said to be the Hollow's original form — before it learned to hunger. Aelaerem hedge-keepers leave offerings of peacock feathers at the Hollow's gates to remind it of what it once was. The feathers are always accepted. The Hollow never thanks them.

Nine Kingdoms Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Peacock:** Crumble a crust before the throne. Ignore the first *Elephant Stampede* penalty. '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Knot the Anklet:** Tie a silver bell to a dancer's anklet. Cancel *Temple Dance Cursed* or take -1 die on your next performance roll (your choice). '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Name to the Well:** Whisper a dead king's name into the black water. Gain +1 Effect when negotiating a truce this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Covenant. '[SUPERSTITION]'

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **court chamberlains or temple priests**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **elephant mahouts or bazaar merchants**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **rival spies or Covenant bailiffs**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favourable audience with a king**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Local king's guard or Covenant bailiff** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **elephant stampede or riot**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **rival kingdom's spy or a bandit** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.

- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **elephant cavalry, temple guards, or bandit crews** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes—**pact broken/well poisoned/ghost accuses**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival: Maharaja, High Judge Vasu, or Ninth King’s Ghost** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically—**throne hall collapses/well floods/peacock screams**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice—**omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Nine Kingdoms (Court Law):** Peacock feathers shed without reason, a throne’s ruby eyes follow a different person, a forgotten genealogy appears on a wall.
- **Nine Kingdoms (Elephant Law):** Elephants kneel unprompted, a tusk glows faintly, a mahout speaks a prophecy in his sleep.
- **Nine Kingdoms (Honor Law):** A merchant refuses to meet your eyes, a child throws salt at your feet, a temple door closes as you approach.

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Wits + Stealth):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Dust Cloud*.
- **Cut the Pact (Presence + Sway):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a peacock feather is in your possession, +1 die.
- **Weather the Stampede (Body + Ride):** On a hit in *Elephant Stampede*, you pick who is trampled; on a miss, the GM does.

Boss Seeds (Throne & Well)

- **The Ninth King (Unburied)** — *Phases:* Tomb Robberies → Orchestrated Succession Crisis → Throne Coup. *Cracks:* return a stolen crown, expose a false genealogy, survive the Ninth King’s Ghost.
- **The Drought-Maker (Well Poisoner)** — *Phases:* Wells Drying → Procession of Empty Stepwells → Monsoon Baptism of a Dancer. *Cracks:* vial of pure well water, survivor testimony, the temple dancer’s bells ringing true again.

Patronage & Power

Among the Nine Kingdoms, power flows through genealogy, elephant herds, and the honour of the court. A king's authority rests on his dynasty's archive; a queen's on her marriage alliances; a temple dancer's on the rhythm of the monsoon. The Peacock Throne is the centre, but the other eight kingdoms are not satellites — they are competitors.

For the GM: Power in the Nine Kingdoms is measured in iron, buffalo, and the thickness of a family's scroll collection. Patronage often takes the form of peacock feathers, iron gate passes, or Covenant seals — each tied to a specific kingdom, clan, or court. To emphasize this:

- Use the **Honor Dial** as a visible track. Let players gain or lose Honor based on their actions in native courts. High Honor opens doors; low Honor closes them — and may bring assassins.
- Let the nine kingdoms be a web of shifting alliances. A favour from the Maharaja may be an insult to the Rani. Players must navigate the politics.
- Use the stepwells, elephant stables, and throne halls as arenas for social contests, where a well-recited genealogy is a weapon and a broken promise is a declaration of war.

In the Nine Kingdoms, the peacock remembers every eye — and the well shows every death.

Chapter 32

The Himadri Foothills

The Iron Passes (Aeler Focus).

The mountain does not speak in words. It speaks in the crack of a bearing, the echo of a hammer, the taste of ore on the tongue. We Aeler do not conquer stone. We negotiate with it. The lease is not a document. It is the weight of the keystone that holds the roof.

I am a Mine-Breath. I carry a bell that counts my breaths. Eight is safe. Nine is the mountain's. My grandfather counted to nine once. The mountain took his shadow. He lived another thirty years, but he never cast a shadow again.

The Ninth Seal mine isn't just holding a demon—it's a seal market, and oh, how the Vent-Prior loves a good deal on demon containment. The Aeler do not rule through armies; they rule through the maintenance contracts that keep the mines from collapsing, the bridges from falling, and the passes from freezing. A vent-prior's authority rests on his ability to read the mountain's cracks; a mine-captain's on her skill with a tuning fork. But here's the secret the Vent-Prior doesn't want you to know: the demon in the Ninth Seal is not the only thing the mountain is holding. There are older things deeper down. The Aeler sealed them first. The Ninth Seal is just the newest.

The elephant caravans haul ore down to the Brass Coast; mule trains carry silver and tea up to the mountain holds. The Aeler engineers speak a creole of their own tongue; the Dhaharan nobles wear Aeler breath-counters as jewellery; and deep beneath the oldest mine, a demon sleeps behind a Covenant seal—a fragment of the thing that turned the Red Desert to glass. The seal is cracking. The demon whispers through the cracks. It offers favours. It asks for small betrayals. It is very patient.

Never count your breaths aloud in a mine. The mountain listens, and if it hears you reach the ninth, it will take one—a breath, a memory, a shadow.

— *Mine-Breath*, who carries her grandfather's bell and has never reached nine

The Almanac of Ordinary Days

What do people eat for breakfast? Iron rations and tea—the rations are hardtack and dried meat, the tea is brewed from leaves that grow only above the snow line. The leaves are harvested by the Vent-Prior's apprentices. The apprentices are chosen by lottery. The lottery is a death sentence.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To read a pressure gauge. Himadri children are taught the eight pressures: Safe, Warning, Danger, Collapse, Flood, Fire, Seal, and the ninth—the pressure that means the mountain is breathing. The mountain's breath is the miners' death.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their bell. Every miner carries a breath-counter bell. A stranger whose bell rings too fast has been running. A stranger whose bell is silent is dead. A stranger whose bell rings the ninth note is a demon. The demons are sealed. The seals are cracking.

What is the most common crime? Ore smuggling—but ore smuggling is not a crime, it is a perquisite. The mine-captains take a cut of every shipment. The cut is called "the Vent-Prior's fee." The fee is negotiable. The negotiation is a ritual. The ritual involves tea and threats.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Ninth Seal is not a seal. It is a door—a gate to a prison that holds something that should not be named. The seal's keepers do not know what is inside. The keepers do not want to know. The keepers are paid to not know.

Where do people go when they die? To the mountain. The dead are not buried. Their bodies are left in worked-out galleries. The mountain absorbs them. The mountain's memory grows. The mountain remembers every breath it has taken.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You offer a breath—one of your own, counted and witnessed. The breath is sealed in a brass capsule and placed in the Vent-Prior's ledger. The ledger is the court. The court's judgment is the mountain's. The mountain's judgment is final.

What is the most important festival? The Counting of the Breath (winter solstice). Every miner's breath-counter is read aloud. The miners with the lowest counts are promoted. The miners with the highest counts are retired. Retirement is a sealed gallery. The gallery is a tomb.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The demon in the Ninth Seal is not a demon. It is an Aeler—the first Vent-Prior, who volunteered to be sealed with the mountain's hunger. He is still alive. He has been counting his breaths for nine centuries. He has reached the ninth count. He is still counting.

32.1 The Himadri Foothills — “The Iron Passes”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *The mountain negotiates. The seal remembers. The ninth breath is never yours.*

Vent-Prior of the Iron Road (Elite): “The mountain does not speak in words. It speaks in the crack of a bearing, the echo of a hammer, the taste of ore on the tongue. We Aeler do not conquer stone. We negotiate with it. The lease is not a document. It is the weight of the keystone that holds the roof.”

Mine-Breath (Commoner): “I carry a bell that counts my breaths. Eight is safe. Nine is the mountain’s. My grandfather counted to nine once. The mountain took his shadow. He lived another thirty years, but he never cast a shadow again.”

Genre / Mood: Industrial horror, mountain diplomacy, demonic containment.

Starting Location: The entrance to the Ninth Seal Mine, where a Covenant seal of clay and iron glows faintly in the dark. A vent-prior in a brass breath-counter steps forward: “The seal is failing. The demon whispers through the crack. The rajas want to open it — they think the demon’s iron can win their wars. The Covenant wants to re-seal it. The Aeler want to mine around it. You are here because you do not know enough to choose a side. That makes you useful.”

Theme & Atmosphere

The Himadri foothills are the rugged transition between the Sarpies plateau and the towering peaks of the Aelerian mountains. Here, the air is thin and cold, the rivers run white with snowmelt, and the passes are measured in breath-counts rather than miles. Iron mines scar the hillsides, worked by Dhaharan labourers and overseen by Aeler vent-priors. Elephant caravans haul ore down to the Brass Coast; mule trains carry silver and tea up to the mountain holds. The Aeler have established a viceroyalty here — not conquest, but a long lease backed by breath-bonds and keystone wax. The local rajas pay tribute in iron and receive protection from lowland enemies. It is an uneasy peace, written in bell-codes and toll-ledgers. The Aeler engineers speak a creole of their own tongue; the Dhaharan nobles wear Aeler breath-counters as jewellery; and deep beneath the oldest mine, a demon sleeps behind a Covenant seal — a fragment of the thing that turned the Red Desert to glass.

What you notice first: The ringing of iron hammers and the lowing of elephants. The way every bridge has a dwarf toll-keeper with a brass scale. The silence after a bell rings — the silence is for the mountain to answer.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never count your breaths aloud in a mine. The mountain listens, and if it hears you reach the ninth, it will take one — a breath, a memory, a shadow.

Regional Mood: The Weight of the Keystone

Power here is measured in iron quotas, breath-bonds, and the age of a keystone. The Aeler do not rule through armies; they rule through the maintenance contracts that keep the mines from collapsing, the bridges from falling, and the passes from freezing. A vent-prior’s authority rests on his ability to read the mountain’s cracks; a mine-captain’s on her skill with a tuning fork. The Dhaharan rajas pay tribute in ore, but they also hold the local rituals that appease the mountain

spirits. The Covenant's sealed mine — the Ninth Seal — is a reminder of what happens when the mountain is not respected. The Aeler have kept it closed for three centuries. The seal is cracking.

Prominent NPCs of the Himadri Foothills

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Vent-Prior Thrain	Aeler governor of the Iron Passes	Maximise ore output while keeping the demon sealed	He wears a bell around his neck; it rings when he lies.
Mine-Captain Korra	Aeler engineer	Keep the tunnels safe and the quotas met	She counts her breaths in eights; she has never reached nine.
Rani Jaya	Dhaharan raja of the eastern hills	Balance tribute to Aeler with loyalty to her clan	She lost an arm to a mine collapse; the prosthetic is a pickaxe.
Seal-Keeper Haran	Covenant priest of the Ninth Seal	Ensure the demon never wakes	He has not left the mine entrance in forty years. His eyes are rust-coloured.
Elephant Master Tarkan	Caravan leader	Move iron to the coast before the snows close the passes	He speaks to his elephants in Dhaharan; they answer in Aeler.

Names of the Himadri Foothills

A mix of Aeler gutturals (short, hard consonants) and Dhaharan vowels. Surnames may be Aeler clan names or Dhaharan hill titles.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Clan/House	Epithets
Thrain	Korra	Ironfoot	<i>the Bell-Breaker</i>
Borin	Jaya	Stonehand	<i>Breath-Counter</i>
Harkan	Sita	Aezelbron	<i>Bridge-Warden</i>
Rurik	Laxmi	Thrainsdottir	<i>Toll-Eater</i>
Vikram	Meera	Keystone-bearer	<i>the Unshadowed</i>

(Mine/Bridge/Seal) Iron mine with a carved face above the entrance; Aeler toll bridge with a dwarf and a brass scale; the Ninth Seal Mine entrance with a Covenant seal of clay and iron.

Spades — Places

2. **Iron Mine of the Crying Face** — A deep shaft with a carved face above the entrance. *The face weeps rust. The tears are iron oxide. The mountain is mourning its dead.* ‘[INDUSTRIAL]’
3. **Aeler Toll Bridge** — A stone arch over a gorge; a dwarf with a scale sits at the far end. *The toll is not in coin — it is in weight. Your truth is weighed against a bar of iron.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
4. **Ninth Seal Mine (Sealed)** — A tunnel mouth sealed with Covenant clay and iron bands. *The seal is warm. It glows faintly at night. The demon whispers through the cracks.* ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[MAGIC]’
5. **Keystone Chamber** — A cave where the Aeler store their breath-bond ledgers. *The ledgers are carved on slate. Each slate is a keystone. Break one, void a contract.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
6. **Silent Pass** — A high mountain pass where no bird flies. *The air is too thin for sound. Arguments must be written in the snow. The snow does not lie.* ‘[WEATHER]’
7. **Elephant Corral (Highland)** — A fenced area with chains; elephants chained by one leg. *The chains have names — each is the elephant’s first kill. The names are in Aeler. The elephants remember.* ‘[LABOR]’
8. **Smelter’s Forge (Aeler Mobile)** — A wagon-mounted furnace that follows the ore caravans. *The forge is pulled by a team of oxen. It is always last in the procession. The oxen have no shadows.* ‘[INDUSTRIAL]’
9. **Bridge of Nine Echoes** — A rope bridge over a chasm; each step echoes nine times. *The ninth echo is always a whisper. It is the name of the next person to fall. Do not answer.* ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[FEAR]’
10. **Vent-Prior’s Archive** — A subterranean vault of breath-bonds and toll receipts. *The archive is sealed with Aeler keystone wax. The wax is mixed with miner’s blood. It never melts.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
- J **Abandoned Shaft (Demon’s First Awakening)** — A collapsed tunnel where the demon first spoke. *The air is warm. The walls are coated in green glass — like the Kalrantha amulet. The glass sings at midnight.* ‘[MAGIC]’ ‘[DEATH]’
- Q **Shrine of the Ninth Breath** — A small stone altar where miners leave offerings. *The offerings are not coin — they are memories written on strips of leather. The leather never rots. The memories are still warm.* ‘[RITUAL]’
- K **Raja’s Hill Fort** — A stone fortress overlooking the main mine. *The fort has a fire shrine and an Aeler breath-counter on the gate. Both are watched. The watchers do not blink.* ‘[POLITICS]’
- A **The First Keystone (Myth)** — A stone that never cracks, said to lie at the deepest point of the oldest mine. *It is the mountain’s heart. Touch it, and the mountain will ask a question. Answer poorly, and the passes close forever. Answer well, and it may ask another.* ‘[LEGEND]’

(Captain/Judge/Master) Mine-Captain Korra with a tuning fork; Rani Jaya with a pickaxe prosthetic; Elephant Master Tarkan with a bone whistle.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Mine-Captain (Aeler)** — A dwarf with a tuning fork and a level. She can hear a crack in a beam from a hundred paces. *She never walks under a keystone. The mountain has ears. She has never lost a crew.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
3. **Rani Jaya** — A young woman in armour, riding a caparisoned elephant. She lost an arm to a mine collapse. *The prosthetic is a pickaxe. She can write with it. The letters are iron filings. Her clan trusts her. The Aeler fear her.* ‘[POLITICS]’ ‘[COMMUNITY]’
4. **Seal-Keeper Haran (Covenant)** — An old man in grey robes, sitting by the Ninth Seal. His eyes are rust-coloured. *He has not eaten solid food in forty years. The seal’s glow sustains him. He has forgotten his own name. The seal remembers.* ‘[JUSTICE]’
5. **Elephant Master Tarkan** — Old, missing two fingers, tattooed with elephant footprints. *He knows the name of every elephant that has crossed the pass in fifty years. The elephants know his. They call him “Brother of the Long Road.”* ‘[COMMUNITY]’
6. **Vent-Prior Thrain** — A dwarf with a bell around his neck. He stands behind the iron throne. *The bell rings when he lies. It rings often. He is always lying about the ore quotas. The miners know. They work anyway.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
7. **Aeler Toll-Keeper** — A dwarf with a brass scale and a ledger. He weighs your goods and your lies. *The scale tips for both. A lie makes the pan dip lower. The ledger is written in breath. It fogs when you are honest.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
8. **Smelter Worker (Dhaharan)** — A young man with red-rimmed eyes. He coughs iron dust. *His spittle stains the ground. He will not live past thirty. He knows. He sends half his wage home to a village that has already forgotten him.* ‘[LABOR]’ ‘[COMMUNITY]’
9. **Treasure Hunter (Foreign)** — A foreigner digging in an old landslide. He is looking for the tomb of a prince. *The prince is the one who stole the Kalrantha amulet. The hunter has a map tattooed on his back. The map moves.* ‘[GREED]’
10. **Breath-Bound Miner** — A woman who sold her breath to the mountain for a higher quota. She can only speak in whispers. *Her voice is a rustle. The mountain speaks through her. The other miners leave offerings of silence.* ‘[MAGIC]’ ‘[DEBT]’
- J **Ghost of the Landslide** — A figure in grey, seen only at dusk. It points at the pass. *It is pointing at a safe route — or a trap. No one has survived to find out. The ghost does not speak. It does not need to.* ‘[DEATH]’
- Q **Vent-Prior’s Cipher Clerk** — A dwarf who writes diplomatic letters in code. *The code is a poem. The poem is about a lost mine. The mine is the Ninth Seal. The clerk dreams in couplets.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
- K **Demon’s Whisper (from the Ninth Seal)** — A voice heard in the sealed mine. *It offers a deal: a year of good fortune for a single memory. The memory is the last breath of a dying friend. The voice sounds like someone you loved.* ‘[MAGIC]’ ‘[FEAR]’
- A **The First Miner (Legend)** — A skeleton holding a tuning fork, sitting at the First Keystone. *If you take the tuning fork, you become the mountain’s new voice. You will never leave the depths. The miners will hear you sing. They will not thank you.* ‘[LEGEND]’

(Cave-in/Toll/Echo) A cave-in traps miners — the collapse was sabotage; the Aeler toll-keeper demands double payment; the ninth echo on the Bridge of Nine Echoes speaks a name.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Cave-In (Sabotage)** — A tunnel collapses. The collapse was not an accident — a saboteur loosened the timbers. ‘[DISASTER]’ *The saboteur is in the party. Or the party is accused. The Mine-Captain is watching. Her tuning fork is warm.*
 3. **Toll Dispute** — The Aeler keeper demands double; the raja’s men refuse. The dispute is a trap. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[POLITICS]’ *Both sides want the party to choose a side. Neither is honest. The bridge is the only crossing. The scale is balanced on a lie.*
 4. **Ninth Echo** — On the Bridge of Nine Echoes, someone counts the echoes. The ninth echo says a name. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[FEAR]’ *The name is the speaker’s. They faint. The bridge remembers. The name is now a toll. The bridge will collect.*
 5. **Landslide (Pass Blocked)** — The pass is blocked. The alternative route is three days longer. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The landslide was deliberate — a rival caravan master wants to delay you. His camels are ahead. His guilt is written in the mud.*
 6. **Breath Shortage (High Altitude)** — At high altitude, the party struggles. Mark Fatigue 1 per scene. ‘[WEATHER]’ ‘[SURVIVAL]’ *Acclimatisation requires a rest day. The rest day will cost a toll. The toll is a breath-bond. The mountain is watching.*
 7. **Spy in Camp** — A worker is stealing iron samples. The spy is working for an Ashaani agent. ‘[POLITICS]’ ‘[STEALTH]’ *The samples are for a new alloy. The alloy is a weapon. The weapon is meant to break the Ninth Seal. The spy has a family. They do not know.*
 8. **Covenant Audit** — Seal-Keeper Haran demands to inspect the party’s cargo. ‘[JUSTICE]’ ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The cargo includes a relic from the Red Desert — a piece of green glass. It is humming. Haran’s eyes are weeping rust.*
 9. **Aeler Bell Code Change** — The toll-keeper rings a different sequence; the party is now “unregistered.” ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[TRAP]’ *The change was ordered by the Vent-Prior. The Vent-Prior is testing your loyalty. Fail, and you are banned from the passes. The ban is carved in slate.*
 10. **Elephant Sickness (Curse)** — A disease spreads through the caravan. The disease is a curse from a local spirit. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[MAGIC]’ *The spirit was disturbed by the mine’s expansion. It wants a sacrifice. The sacrifice is a memory. The elephants are coughing up names.*
- J **Vent-Prior’s Summons** — Thrain demands the party attend him. He offers a deal: find the saboteur in exchange for a toll waiver. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[POLITICS]’ *The saboteur is his own clerk. The clerk is his daughter. She is trying to open the Ninth Seal. She wants to free the demon. She thinks it will speak to her.*
- Q **Silent Pass’s Cold (Supernatural)** — The temperature drops; the party loses 1 Supply per hour. ‘[WEATHER]’ ‘[MAGIC]’ *The cold is supernatural — a frost spirit has taken residence. It wants a breath-bond. It will accept a story. The story must be about fire.*
- K **Demon Wakes (Ninth Seal Crack)** — The sealed mine cracks open. A shadow escapes; it possesses the nearest Aeler engineer. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[MAGIC]’ *The engineer begins to sabotage the pass. The demon wants the lease broken. The demon wants the mountain to weep. The engineer’s face is not his own.*
- A **First Keystone Quakes** — The mountain’s heart trembles. The passes close. The mines collapse. The demon is free. ‘[APOCALYPSE]’ *The party has one day to re-seal the demon or flee. The Vent-Prior is weeping. The seal-keeper is dead. The mountain is counting.*

(Bell/Ingot/Seal) Aeler breath-counter (silver bell, wear to count breaths safely); iron ingot (stamped with the Vent-Prior's mark); Covenant seal (clay, for witnessing oaths in the passes).

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Aeler Breath-Counter (Silver Bell)** — Wear it to count your breaths in high altitude. The bell rings when you reach eight. '[TRAVEL]' '[SURVIVAL]' *Stop at eight. The ninth breath is the mountain's. The bell also rings when a demon is near. The tone is flat.*
3. **Iron Ingot (Vent-Prior's Mark)** — A single bar of high-grade iron, stamped with a dragon. Worth 1 Measure. '[TRADE]' *The dragon is the Vent-Prior's mark. Present it to any Aeler forge for a favour. The favour is a breath-bond. The ingot is still warm from the mountain's heart.*
4. **Covenant Seal (Clay, Himadri)** — A lump of clay. Heat it to witness any oath in the foothills. '[JUSTICE]' '[SOCIAL]' *The heat comes from a coal taken from the Ninth Seal mine. The coal whispers. The seal lasts one use. The clay is porous. It drinks lies.*
5. **Toll Waiver (Brass Nail)** — A brass nail. Present it to pass any Aeler bridge for free. '[TRAVEL]' *The nail fits into a hole in the toll-keeper's scale. The hole is for bribes. The nail is also a key. It opens a lock in the Vent-Prior's archive.*
6. **Elephant Whistle (Bone)** — A bone whistle. Blow it to call an elephant from the caravan. '[TRAVEL]' '[COMMUNITY]' *The whistle is made from the tusk of a bull that died in a rockslide. Its ghost runs with the elephant. The elephant will come. It may bring friends.*
7. **Raja's Signet Ring (Silver)** — A silver ring with a tiger. Commands loyalty from the raja's clan. '[SOCIAL]' '[POLITICS]' *The ring is a copy. The real one was lost in a landslide. The ghost of the original owner wears it. He will ask for it back. He will be polite.*
8. **Smelter's Gloves (Asbestos)** — Handle hot metal safely. The gloves are cursed: they itch when you lie. '[CRAFT]' '[SOCIAL]' *The itch is mild at first. It becomes unbearable with repeated lies. The gloves also resist demonic whispers. The demon does not like asbestos.*
9. **Map of the Silent Pass (Leather)** — A chart drawn on leather. Shows a safe route through the high pass. '[TRAVEL]' *The map is incomplete. The missing section is a fold. The fold is a secret — a cave with a spring that never freezes. The spring tastes of iron. It is the mountain's blood.*
10. **Vent-Prior's Letter of Introduction** — A sealed scroll. Grants access to any Aeler hold in the mountains. '[SOCIAL]' '[AUTHORITY]' *The letter is written in blood. The blood is the Vent-Prior's. He changes his blood type each season. The clerks have a chart. They update it daily.*
- J **Seal-Keeper's Prayer (Clay Tablet)** — A tablet inscribed with the original Covenant sealing rite. '[MAGIC]' '[JUSTICE]' *Recite it to strengthen the Ninth Seal for one year. The recitation costs a memory. The memory is forgotten. The seal will remember.*
- Q **Demon's Nail (Timber from Ninth Seal)** — A piece of the sealed mine's timber. Touch it to a lock; the lock opens. '[MAGIC]' '[STEALTH]' *The lock also screams. The scream alerts the demon. The nail crumbles after one use. The demon knows your face now. It will whisper to you in dreams.*
- K **Ninth Echo's Whisper (Slate)** — A piece of slate carved with the ninth echo's words. Play it to silence a foe. '[COMBAT]' '[FEAR]' *The foe hears their own name and freezes for one exchange. The slate then crumbles. The echo is now silent. The bridge has one fewer whisper.*

A **Vent-Prior’s Forgiveness (Pardon)** — A written pardon for any crime in the Himadri foothills. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The pardon is conditional. The condition is a secret mission. The mission is to re-seal the demon — permanently. The Vent-Prior’s bell will not ring for this lie.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (bells, ingots, nails) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **mountain-omens**—iron that weeps rust, bells that ring without clappers, a pass that closes behind you, a whisper that sounds like your own breath.

Additional Features (Aeler Mechanics)

- **Breath-Bonds:** Aeler contracts are sealed with breath — the parties exhale into a brass counter, and the bond is recorded as a weight of air. Breaking a breath-bond causes the breaker to lose the ability to draw a full breath for a year (mark Fatigue 1 at the start of each scene). Breath-bonds are measured in eighths; the ninth part is always held by the mountain. A bond that is kept for nine years is said to become a *mountain-friend* — the signatory can walk any pass without toll.
- **Keystone Law:** Every Aeler mine has a keystone — a single block that bears the weight of the roof. The keystone is also a legal document. Carve a contract into it, and the contract is enforceable by the mountain itself. Defacing a keystone is punishable by burial in the mine. The keystone does not forget. It does not forgive. It may, however, negotiate.
- **The Ninth Seal Clock [8]:** The Covenant seal on the demon mine has a hidden clock that ticks when the demon whispers, when someone takes iron from the sealed tunnel, or when a breath-bond is broken nearby. When the clock fills, the seal cracks. The party can reset the clock by reinforcing the seal with a new Covenant rite (costs a memory) or by feeding the demon a story (costs a truth). The demon prefers stories about betrayal. It pays attention to those.
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
 - **Adur (the Forge-Father)** — Oath of Flame and Light. *The fire in the smelter, the heat that tempers iron and oaths.*
 - **Hemrir the Wanderer** — The Sealed Gate. *The keeper of thresholds; his shrines are bridge-posts and tunnel mouths.*
 - **The Procession** — Clockwork Monad. *The optimisation of the mine; the hunger for efficiency that eats tradition.*
 - **The Breath-Eater** — Khemesh. *The pressure in the deep; the silence that follows a cave-in.*

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Ninth Seal and the Kalrantha Amulet (Dhahara):** The demon in the sealed mine is a fragment of Varash the Unmaker, the same entity trapped in the Kalrantha amulet. The

Veiled Sisters want to free this fragment to use against the Covenant. The Breath-less want to re-seal it permanently. The demon wants to be whole. It offers favours to anyone who brings it a shard of green glass.

- **Iron Trade and the Ngomebe Stone Men:** The iron from the Himadri mines is shipped to Ngomebe to forge rollers for the walking cities. A disruption in the iron supply could stop a city mid-migration. The Ngomebe Mason-Kin have a permanent envoy at the Vent-Prior's hall. The envoy is a woman who speaks only in stone-songs. She has never smiled.
- **Breath-Bonds and the Covenant (Mykkiel):** The Covenant recognises Aeler breath-bonds as legally binding, but only if witnessed by a judge. Sister Gaura (from the Satrapies) often travels to the Himadri foothills to witness the largest contracts. She is afraid of the mines. She goes anyway. She says the light is better underground.
- **The Silent Pass and the Hollow (Eastern Realms):** The Silent Pass is a known threshold where the Hollow's attention is thin. Aelaerem hedge-keepers leave offerings of salt at the pass entrance to keep the Debt-Walkers from following caravans. The salt must be from the pans of the Silent Widows. Any other salt will attract them. The Hedge-Keepers will not explain why. They say the salt knows.

Himadri Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Mine:** Crumble a crust into the tunnel mouth. Ignore the first *Cave-In* penalty. '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Knot the Bell Rope:** Tie a knot in the rope of the shrine bell. Cancel *Ninth Echo* or take -1 die on your next stealth roll (your choice). '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Name to the Iron:** Whisper a dead miner's name into an ingot. Gain +1 Effect when negotiating with Aeler this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Vent-Prior. '[SUPERSTITION]'

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **Aeler mine-captains or Covenant seal-keepers**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **toll-keepers or elephant masters**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **raja's spies or demon-touched miners**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favourable toll rates**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Local mine-captain or seal-keeper** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **landslide or thin air**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **demon-touched miner or a rival raja's guard** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **Aeler engineers, raja’s soldiers, or demon fragments** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes—**mine seals/keystone cracks/ninth echo spoken**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival: Vent-Prior, Seal-Keeper, or Demon from the Ninth Seal** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically—**mine collapses/bridge falls/first keystone quakes**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice—**omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Himadri (Aeler Law):** Breath-counters tick backward, keystones weep water, a tuning fork rings without being struck.
- **Himadri (Seal Law):** The Ninth Seal’s glow intensifies, demon whispers become audible, a crack appears in the clay.
- **Himadri (Pass Law):** Snow falls upward, the ninth echo repeats a different name each time, a bridge appears where there was only chasm.

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Wits + Survival):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Thin Air*.
- **Cut the Toll (Presence + Sway):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a toll waiver is in your possession, +1 die.
- **Weather the Cave-in (Body + Athletics):** On a hit in *Cave-In*, you pick who escapes first; on a miss, the GM does.

Boss Seeds (Breath & Demon)

- **The Breath-Eater (Nine Silences)** — *Phases:* Mines Collapsing → Orchestrated Breath-Bond Break → Pass Coup. *Cracks:* find a lost breath-counter, expose a false keystone, survive a count of nine.
- **The Unsealed (Demon of the Ninth Seal)** — *Phases:* Whispers in the Mine → Procession of Cracking Seals → Iron-Baptism of a Vent-Prior. *Cracks:* relic Covenant seal, survivor testimony, the mine’s face weeping clear water.

Patronage & Power

In the Himadri foothills, power flows through breath-bonds, iron quotas, and the authority of the keystone. The Aeler vent-priors hold the contracts that keep the mines open; the Dhaharan rajas hold the land; the Covenant holds the seal on the demon. No single faction can rule alone, because the mountain itself is a stakeholder — and the mountain has a vote.

For the GM: Power in the Himadri foothills is measured in breath-counts, toll receipts, and the age of a keystone. Patronage often takes the form of breath-counters, iron ingots, or seal fragments — each tied to a specific mine, pass, or contract. To emphasize the Aeler focus:

- Make **breath-bonds** a central mechanic: players can enter into bonds for favours, but breaking them has harsh consequences. A bond kept for nine years becomes a *mountain-friend* — the holder can walk any pass without toll.
- Let the **Ninth Seal Clock** be a visible campaign front. The party's actions tick the clock; when it fills, the demon manifests. The demon does not fight — it negotiates. It offers iron. It offers favours. It asks for small betrayals.
- Use the mines, bridges, and the sealed tunnel as arenas for social contests, where a breath-count is a threat and a keystone is a judge. The mountain is always listening. It may offer advice. The advice is usually good. The price is never stated.

In the Himadri foothills, the mountain forgets nothing — and the ninth breath is always waiting.

Part VII

The Eastern Realms

Chapter 33

Sihai

The Central Kingdom.

The Mandate of Heaven is not a right. It is a loan. The emperor borrows legitimacy from the ancestors, from the land, from the Hollow itself. When the loan is due, the empire falls. I do not serve the emperor. I serve the ledger that tracks the interest.

I am a Provincial Censor. My brush is heavier than any sword. A single stroke can erase a name, a family, a dynasty. The emperor reads my reports and trembles. He knows that I have written nine reports this year. The ninth is about him.

Sihai is the central kingdom, the seat of the Emperor and the Mandate of Heaven. Its canals carry grain from the south; its examination halls produce bureaucrats who govern by the brush. Power here is measured in ink, not iron. The Censorate watches everyone; the Salt Monopoly controls trade; the Lethai-thora keep the secrets that the Mandate prefers to forget. But here's the secret the Emperor doesn't want you to know: the Mandate is not a divine right. It is a loan. The ancestors are the creditors. The Hollow collects the interest. Every dynasty that has ever fallen did so because the interest came due and the emperor could not pay.

Beneath the mortal bureaucracy runs a deeper one: the Celestial Bureaucracy of gods, ghosts, and ancestors, where every official has a heavenly counterpart and every erased name becomes a hungry ghost. The Lethai-thora—the ancient archivists who taught the first emperors to write—still keep the hidden ledgers, the ones that record what the Censorate burns. A well-written couplet can appease a ghost; a forged seal can summon a demon. The Hollow's ninth debt is the unpaid interest on the Mandate itself.

Never speak of succession before naming the Emperor. The Censorate has ears in every tea house. A misplaced word can erase your name from the rolls.

— *Quiet Chancellor Wei, who has never smiled and whose seal is a laughing mouth*

The Almanac of Ordinary Days

What do people eat for breakfast? Congee with preserved vegetables—the congee is rice boiled until it is memory, the vegetables are salted and aged in clay jars. The jars are sealed with the emperor's own wax. The wax is a promise. The promise is that the vegetables will not poison you. The promise is sometimes broken.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To write their name. Sihai children are taught the eight strokes of the character "person"—the ninth stroke is the one that turns a name into a signature. A signature is a contract. A contract is a debt. A debt is a life.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their chop—the seal they carry to sign documents. A stranger whose chop is jade is a noble. A stranger whose chop is brass is a clerk. A stranger whose chop is wood is a merchant. A stranger with no chop is a ghost. Ghosts cannot sign contracts. Ghosts cannot be trusted.

What is the most common crime? Examination fraud—but fraud is not a crime, it is a family business. The examinations determine who governs. The questions are leaked in advance. The answers are memorized. The examiners are bribed. The system is a sieve. The sieve is called "merit."

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Emperor is a figurehead. The real power is the Censorate—nine ministers who have never been seen together. Their names are not recorded. Their faces are not painted. Their orders are whispered. The Emperor signs what they tell him to sign. The Emperor has not refused in forty years.

Where do people go when they die? To the ancestral tablets. The dead are not buried. Their names are written on wooden tablets, placed in the family shrine. The tablets are fed with rice and tea. The dead eat the steam. The dead are never full.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You offer a calligraphy—a scroll written in your own blood. The scroll is presented to the wronged party's ancestral shrine. If the ancestors accept, you are forgiven. If the scroll bursts into flame, you are not. If the scroll writes itself, the ancestors are angry. The ancestors' anger is a famine.

What is the most important festival? The Festival of the Ancestors (autumn). The tablets are cleaned and polished. The dead are invited to feast. The feast is laid out on the family altar. The food is removed after an hour. The dead have eaten the essence. The essence is memory.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Censorate's ninth minister is a woman—the emperor's own mother, who was supposed to have died in childbirth. She faked her death to escape the politics of the court. She has been running the Censorate from a hidden villa in the western hills. The emperor does not know. The emperor's mother signs his death warrants. He signs them too.

33.1 Sihai — “The Central Kingdom”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *The Mandate is a loan. The ancestors are the creditors. The Hollow collects the interest.*

Quiet Chancellor (Elite): “The Mandate of Heaven is not a right. It is a loan. The emperor borrows legitimacy from the ancestors, from the land, from the Hollow itself. When the loan is due, the empire falls. I do not serve the emperor. I serve the ledger that tracks the interest.”

Provincial Censor (Commoner): “My brush is heavier than any sword. A single stroke can erase a name, a family, a dynasty. The emperor reads my reports and trembles. He knows that I have written nine reports this year. The ninth is about him.”

Genre / Mood: Celestial bureaucracy, ghost-ledgers, ink-washed horror, examination hell.

Starting Location: An examination hall where ink-stained desks face a silent proctor. A Provincial Censor holds up a scroll: “This candidate’s family name has been erased. He does not know. You will tell him — or you will take his place in the ledger.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Sihai is the central kingdom, the seat of the Emperor and the Mandate of Heaven. Its canals carry grain from the south; its examination halls produce bureaucrats who govern by the brush. But beneath the mortal bureaucracy runs a deeper one: the Celestial Bureaucracy of gods, ghosts, and ancestors, where every official has a heavenly counterpart and every erased name becomes a hungry ghost. The Lethai-thora — the ancient archivists who taught the first emperors to write — still keep the hidden ledgers, the ones that record what the Censorate burns.

Power here is measured in ink, not iron. The Censorate watches everyone; the Salt Monopoly controls trade; the Kitchen God reports every household’s secrets to the Jade Emperor at New Year. A well-written couplet can appease a ghost; a forged seal can summon a demon. The Hollow’s ninth debt is the unpaid interest on the Mandate itself. Every dynasty borrows legitimacy; every silence is a debt.

What you notice first: The smell of ink and canal water, but also incense and grave-soil. The way officials stamp every document with a brass seal — and the way the seal leaves a faint watermark that looks like a face. The constant ticking of water-clocks, but sometimes the ticking skips a beat, and the shadows pause to listen.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never speak of succession before naming the Emperor. The Censorate has ears in every tea house — and the ghosts have ears in every wall. A misplaced word can erase your name from the rolls, and from the memory of the ancestors.

Regional Mood: The Weight of the Brush

Power here is measured in examination scores, salt licenses, and the thickness of a family’s archive. The Emperor rules, but the Censorate audits, the Salt Monopoly finances, and the Lethai-thora remember what the Censorate burns. A provincial governor’s authority rests on his examination rank; a merchant’s on his salt license. The dead are not gone — they are merely demoted. The

Hungry Ghost Festival is the only time the Celestial Bureaucracy accepts appeals. The Hollow watches from the missing ninth step, the unpoured ninth cup, the unsaid ninth name.

Prominent NPCs of Sihai

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Quiet Chancellor Wei	Imperial censor	Root out corruption before the Mandate fails	He has never smiled. His seal is a laughing mouth. He speaks to the Kitchen God each evening.
Salt Commissioner Li	Head of the Salt Monopoly	Control the price of salt and the flow of silver	She tastes every batch of salt before it is stamped. Her tongue is white. She sees ghosts in the brine.
Provincial Censor Chen	Overseer of the eastern prefectures	Erase a rebel lineage from the rolls	He writes with his left hand. His right hand is for swearing oaths. His left hand has no fingerprints.
Lethai-thora Keeper Lian	Hidden archivist	Protect a scroll that proves the emperor's claim is false	She has not spoken aloud in twenty years. She writes on water. The water never freezes.
The Hollow's Debt-Walker	Spirit of unpaid Mandate	Collect the ninth name, the ninth step, the ninth cup	It appears as a scribe with too many fingers. It never blinks. It smells of old incense.

Names of Sihai

Inspired by the central kingdom: short, tonal, with honorifics. Surnames often denote a clan or a prefecture.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Clan/House	Epithets
Wei	Lian	Chen	<i>the Quiet</i>
Li	Mei	Zhou	<i>Salt-Tongue</i>
Chen	Huan	Zhao	<i>the Unerased</i>
Zhang	Ning	Wu	<i>Ninth Seal</i>
Liu	Ping	Tang	<i>the Brush</i>

(Hall/Canal/Archive) Examination hall with ink-stained desks; Grand Canal lock with barges queueing; Lethai-thora hidden archive behind a waterfall.

Spades — Places

2. **Examination Hall (Hell of Ink)** — A long building with ink-stained desks, silent proctors, and a single bell. *The bell rings when a candidate cheats. It rings once a day on average. The ghosts of failed candidates write answers on the ceiling.* ‘[DEATH]’
3. **Grand Canal Lock (Dragon Gate)** — A stone gate where barges queue for inspection. Officials stamp manifests. *The stamp leaves a watermark that glows under moonlight — a dragon scale. Forgeries are obvious. The dragon knows.* ‘[MAGIC]’
4. **Lethai-thora Hidden Archive** — A pavilion behind a waterfall, filled with forbidden scrolls. *The scrolls are sealed with silk cords. The cords have nine knots. The ninth is a lie. The archivists are all ghosts.* ‘[SECRET]’
5. **Salt Commissioner’s Counting House** — A fortress of ledgers, guarded by armed clerks. *The ledgers are written in disappearing ink. Only the Commissioner knows the reagent — tears of a famine widow.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
6. **Provincial Censorate Office** — A grey building with a brass scale above the door. *The scale weighs truth and lies. It has never balanced. When it tips, someone is erased.* ‘[JUSTICE]’
7. **Emperor’s Forbidden Garden (Kunlun Pavilion)** — A walled garden where no one may enter without permission. *The garden contains a single tree with nine branches. The ninth branch is dead. A phoenix nests in the eighth.* ‘[MYTH]’
8. **Well of Erased Names** — A stone well where the Censorate throws scrolls of erased lineages. *The scrolls burn as they fall. The smoke smells of ink and old blood. The well is bottomless.* ‘[DEATH]’
9. **Tea House of the Ninth Cup (Ghost Festival)** — A popular establishment where the ninth cup is never poured. *The owner has a bell that rings when someone pours the ninth cup. It rings often. The ring attracts hungry ghosts.* ‘[SOCIAL]’
10. **Canal Mother’s Court** — A shaded bench where water rights are assigned. *The bench is carved with the names of every canal mother for nine generations. The ninth name is blank. It waits.* ‘[COMMUNITY]’
- J **The Emperor’s Tomb (Unfinished)** — A subterranean complex where the current emperor’s tomb is being built. *The workers are slaves. They will be buried with him. They know. They carve their names into the walls.* ‘[DEATH]’
- Q **The Hollow’s Gate (Subterranean)** — A crack in the floor of the Forbidden Garden. *The crack is warm. It whispers the names of emperors who died without heirs. The names are getting longer.* ‘[MYSTERY]’

- K The Ninth Ledger's Vault** — A vault beneath the Counting House, accessible only by nine keys. *The ninth key is held by the Hollow. The Hollow will lend it — for a price. The price is a name you have never spoken.* '[DEBT]'
- A The First Examination Hall (Myth)** — Where the first emperor tested his sons. *The hall is invisible. Only those who have passed nine examinations can see it. Inside, the first emperor still grades papers.* '[LEGEND]'

(Censor/Merchant/Keeper) Provincial censor with a list of forbidden words; salt merchant with honest scales except when they aren't; Lethai-thora memory-keeper with a silence-token.

Hearts — People Factions

2. **Provincial Censor** — Grey-robed, a brass seal on a chain. He carries a list of forbidden words. *"Speak the ninth word," he says, "and your name will join the list." The list is written on human skin.* '[AUTHORITY]'
 3. **Salt Merchant** — A thin woman with a brass scale. Her weights are hollow. *"The scale is honest," she says. "My hand is not." She has nine weights. The ninth is empty.* '[TRADE]'
 4. **Lethai-thora Keeper** — Silent, carrying a brass lamp. She writes on water with a reed brush. *"The words vanish," she says. "That is how I know they are true." Her lamp burns without oil.* '[SECRET]'
 5. **Canal Mother** — A matriarch in blue robes, a key to the sluice gate on her belt. *"Water is memory," she says. "The canal remembers every bribe." She has never taken a bribe. She has taken nine stories.* '[COMMUNITY]'
 6. **Examination Candidate** — A young man with ink-stained fingers. He has failed nine times. *"The tenth will be different," he says. He has said this nine times. His shadow is missing two fingers.* '[DESPERATION]'
 7. **Quiet Chancellor's Spy** — A woman disguised as a tea-seller. She listens at every table. *She writes reports on her own skin. The ink is invisible. Her skin is full. She is running out of space.* '[STEALTH]'
 8. **Salt Worker (Slave)** — A man with cracked hands, harvesting salt from pans. *"The salt tastes of tears," he says. "Whose tears, I do not know." He owes nine years of labor. He has served eight.* '[LABOR]'
 9. **Hollow's Debt-Walker** — A tall figure in grey, with too many fingers. It carries a ledger. *It asks: "Where is the ninth name?" It will not leave without an answer. Its ledger is made of human bone.* '[DEATH]'
 10. **Emperor's Dreamer** — A woman locked in a tower. She dreams the emperor's nightmares. *She wakes screaming. The dreams are always about the Hollow. She has not dreamed in nine days. The emperor has not slept.* '[MYSTERY]'
- J The First Censor (Ghost)** — A skeleton in grey robes, sitting in the Well of Erased Names. *He asks: "Did I erase the right name?" The answer is always a lie. He knows. He asks anyway.* '[DEATH]'
- Q Canal Mother's Ghost** — A translucent figure walking the canal at midnight. *She checks the water level. When it drops, a debt is overdue. She carries a dipper that never empties.* '[COMMUNITY]'
- K The Ninth Emperor's Ghost** — A crowned skeleton in the unfinished tomb. *He asks: "Is*

the Mandate renewed?” If you say no, he weeps. His tears turn to ink. The ink writes new laws. ‘[LEGEND]‘

- A **Kuva’s Shadow (Hollow)** — The vast darkness that covers the Forbidden Garden at midnight. *It asks: “Who holds the ninth key?” The answer is a name no one knows. The darkness absorbs the answer. ‘[PATRON]‘*

(Forgery/Monsoon/Ancestor) A scroll is found to be a forgery — the party is blamed; monsoon breaks early — the canal closes; an ancestor demands a public accounting of a forgotten debt.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Forged Scroll** — A tax ledger is discovered to be a fake. The forgery is perfect. *The forger is a Censorate clerk. The scroll is not a forgery — it is the original. The Censorate has been lying for centuries. ‘[DECEPTION]‘*
 3. **Monsoon Breaks Early** — The canal closes for inspection. Delay 2 segments. *The closure is a cover. The Censorate is searching for a specific barge. The barge carries a forbidden ancestor tablet. ‘[WEATHER]‘*
 4. **Ancestor’s Demand** — A ghost appears at the family shrine. It demands a public accounting. *The debt is from nine generations ago. The ancestor will not leave until it is paid. It will accept a story if the story is true. ‘[DEATH]‘*
 5. **Censorate Audit** — Officials arrive with a warrant. They have a list of forbidden words. *The list includes a word you spoke yesterday. The penalty is erasure. The word was your grandmother’s name. ‘[AUTHORITY]‘*
 6. **Salt Monopoly Price Hike** — The Commissioner doubles the salt tax. Riots begin. *The hike is a bribe. The bribe is to the Quiet Chancellor. He accepted. The salt is now grey. It used to be white. ‘[TRADE]‘*
 7. **Canal Lock Sabotage** — Someone drops a barge at the lock. The canal backs up. *The saboteur is a Canal Mother’s son. He wants to flood the Censorate office. The water is rising. The papers are drowning. ‘[DISASTER]‘*
 8. **Examination Cheating Scandal** — A candidate is caught with a cheat sheet. The sheet has your name. *The cheat sheet was planted. The real target is your patron. The cheat sheet is written in disappearing ink. It will be gone by dawn. ‘[TRAP]‘*
 9. **Lethai-thora Archive Fire** — A lamp falls in the hidden pavilion. Scrolls burn. *The fire was set by the Censorate. They want to erase a specific history. The history is about the first emperor’s true lineage. ‘[DESTRUCTION]‘*
 10. **Hollow’s Debt Called** — A Debt-Walker appears at the tea house. It points at a party member. *The member owes a debt. The debt is the ninth cup. Pay in story or memory. The Debt-Walker will know if you lie. ‘[DEBT]‘*
- J **Emperor’s Health Fails** — The Mandate wavers. Succession rumours spike. *The emperor has no heir. The Hollow is watching. It will collect the ninth name. The name is the emperor’s. He does not know it. ‘[POLITICS]‘*
- Q **Forbidden Garden Breached** — Someone enters the garden without permission. The Hollow follows. *The intruder is a child. The Hollow asks: “Why are you here?” The child does not know. The child is a ghost. It has been dead for nine years. ‘[MYSTERY]‘*
- K **Ninth Ledger Stolen** — The vault is cracked. The ninth ledger is missing. *The ledger*

contains the names of everyone the Censorate has erased. The thief is a ghost. The ghost is the first emperor. He wants his name back. ‘[DEATH]’

- A **Mandate Falls** — The emperor dies without an heir. The Hollow claims the throne. *The Hollow sits on the dragon throne. It asks: “Who will rule?” Silence is the only answer. The Hollow begins to write.* ‘[APOCALYPSE]’

(Pass/Seal/Token) Stamped pass from a provincial governor (one use); copy of the Celestial Ledger (reveals one hidden tax); Lethai-thora silence-token (one question the keeper must answer).

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Stamped Pass (Governor’s Seal)** — A wax-sealed document. Grants passage through any provincial checkpoint. *The seal is a tiger. It glows when a Censorate agent is nearby. The tiger’s eyes follow you.* ‘[TRAVEL]’
 3. **Celestial Ledger (Copy)** — A scroll containing one hidden tax. Use it to blackmail an official. *The ledger is written in disappearing ink. Read it aloud before it fades. The ink tastes of copper.* ‘[BLACKMAIL]’
 4. **Lethai-thora Silence-Token** — A brass charm. Present it to demand a keeper answer one question. *The keeper cannot lie. The question must be about a forgotten secret. The secret is never small.* ‘[SOCIAL]’
 5. **Junk Seal (Official)** — A brass seal. Impersonate a provincial official for one scene. *The seal is warm. It glows when someone tests its authenticity. The glow is the colour of a lie.* ‘[DECEPTION]’
 6. **Canal Mother’s Key** — A bronze key. Open any sluice gate in the Grand Canal. *The key is cold. It warms when a water right is being violated. The warmth is the temperature of a drowning.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
 7. **Salt Commissioner’s Waiver** — A stamped document. Exempts you from the salt tax for one year. *The waiver is written on silk. The silk was stolen from the Commissioner’s own robes. The thread is from a noose.* ‘[TRADE]’
 8. **Examination Answer Key (Forged)** — A cheat sheet that actually works. Pass one examination automatically. *The answers are written in invisible ink. The reagent is moonlight. The answers are wrong — but the examiners cannot tell.* ‘[DECEPTION]’
 9. **Quiet Chancellor’s Seal (Jade)** — A jade seal. Commands the Censorate to ignore one crime. *The seal is a forgery. The Chancellor made it himself. It still works. The jade is warm. It was cut from a tomb.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
 10. **Forbidden Garden Key (Iron)** — A heavy iron key. Opens the gate to the Emperor’s garden. *The key is cursed. Each use ages the wielder one month. The key does not care. It has been waiting for centuries.* ‘[MYSTERY]’
- J **Hollow’s Ninth Ledger Page** — A single page from the ninth ledger. Contains nine erased names. *Speak a name, and that person’s deeds become known. The Hollow will remember too. The page is warm. It has a pulse.* ‘[DEATH]’
- Q **First Censor’s Brush** — A brush made from a phoenix feather. Write any name, and it is erased from all records. *The brush works once. Then it crumbles. The Hollow will know. The phoenix will not forgive.* ‘[LEGEND]’
- K **Canal Mother’s Ghostly Dipper** — A clay dipper used by a dead Canal Mother. Use it

to control any sluice gate. *The dipper is cold. It weeps water when a debt is overdue. The water is salt. It tastes of old grief.* ‘[COMMUNITY]’

- A **The Mandate Itself (Scroll)** — A scroll that proves the current emperor has no legitimate claim. *Read it aloud, and the Mandate falls. The Hollow will take the throne. The scroll burns after reading. The smoke is a new name.* ‘[APOCALYPSE]’

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (passes, seals, tokens) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **ink-omens**—scrolls that rustle in still air, a lamp that burns green, a forgotten name whispered from a shelf, a ghost that asks for a pen.

Additional Features (Celestial Bureaucracy)

- **The Mandate Clock [8] (Shared Campaign Clock):** Tracks the stability of the dynasty. The party inherits 2 ticks at the start of any adventure set in Sihai (the old debt). The clock ticks when the emperor’s health fails, when a succession dispute arises, when a major corruption scandal is exposed, or when the party breaks an oath witnessed by an ancestor. When the clock reaches 4: the Censorate becomes more aggressive (all audits start at Desperate Position). When it reaches 8: the Mandate fails — the Hollow claims the throne, civil war erupts, and the party must choose a side or flee. Resetting the clock requires a **Ancestor Rite** at the Imperial Ancestral Temple (downtime, costs 1 Supply and a truthful confession) or a public execution of a corrupt official (costs 1 Boon and may create enemies).
- **The Two Ledgers (Ancestral Names Mechanic):** Every character has two “names”: their **Mortal Name** (what the Censorate knows) and their **Ancestral Name** (recorded in the Celestial Ledger, kept by the Lethai-thora). The Ancestral Name cannot be erased by mortal means. Discovering a character’s Ancestral Name requires a **Research Clock (size 6)** in the Lethai-thora archives. Once known, the player may invoke the Ancestral Name once per session to gain +2 dice on any roll related to that ancestor’s domain (e.g., a farmer’s ancestor aids harvest, a soldier’s ancestor aids battle). However, invoking the Ancestral Name creates an **Ancestral Debt (size 4 clock)**. When it fills, the ancestor demands a service — usually something the ancestor failed to do in life (e.g., “Apologize to my widow” or “Find my stolen seal”). Refusing the demand marks 1 Corruption and adds 2 ticks to the Mandate Clock.
- **Censorate Audit (Social Combat Mechanic):** The Censorate can audit any character at any time. An audit is a social combat with three phases:
 1. **Pleadings** (Presence + Sway vs. Censor’s Lore). Success grants +1 die to the next phase.
 2. **Evidence** (Wits + Investigation vs. DV 4). Success reveals a hidden debt or a forged document; failure gives the Censor a piece of evidence against you.
 3. **Judgment** (Resolve + Lore vs. DV 5). Success: the character is cleared. Failure: the Censorate erases a name — the character loses one Bond (that person no longer remembers them) or one Asset (it is seized), and the Mandate Clock ticks +1.

Players can avoid an audit by: **Bribing the Censor** (costs 1 Honey Jar or 1 Boon),

Presenting a forged document (requires a Forgery Clock, size 4), or **Calling a ghost witness** (requires a Spirit + Lore test, DV 4; the ghost cannot lie, but it will ask for a favor in return – usually a promise that creates a new Ancestral Debt).

- **Examination Hell (Dungeon Mechanic):** The Forbidden Garden contains a subterranean examination hall where the ghosts of failed candidates still write their answers. The party can enter to find a lost Ancestral Name – but the hall is alive.
 - The hall has a **Stress Clock (size 8)**. Each failed roll, each lie spoken, each broken taboo ticks the clock.
 - At 4: The hall begins to change. Doors lead to different corridors. Navigation becomes Desperate.
 - At 8: The **Examiner Ghost** appears – a skeleton in scholar’s robes. It asks one question. The party must answer in verse. If the verse is good, the ghost grants a boon (reveals one Ancestral Name). If poor, the ghost erases one of the party’s names – that character is forgotten by the living for 1d4 days (lose all Bonds temporarily, cannot be recognised). The Stress Clock resets after the encounter.
- **Paper Soldiers and Hungry Ghosts (Minion Types):**
 - **Paper Soldiers (Tier I, Cap 2):** Origami constructs animated by Censorate magic. They have Harm 2, Body 2, Melee 1. They are Vulnerable to fire (double Harm) and to a successful Lore test (reveals their true name, causing them to crumple).
 - **Hungry Ghosts (Tier II, Cap 3):** Spirits of those whose names were erased. They have Harm 3, Spirit 3, and the ability **Memory Drain** (touch, target forgets a minor detail – a face, a password, a skill point for one scene). They cannot cross a line of salt or a properly witnessed oath-circle.
- **Water Rights as Ancestral Currency:** In the canal system, water rights are traded like silver, but they are also offerings to the Dragon Kings of the Four Seas. A Canal Mother’s key is worth more than a chest of coins — it can also summon a rain spirit (once per season, calm a storm or flood a district). Forging a water right angers the Dragon King; the forger’s wells run dry for nine years (all Survival tests to find water suffer –2 dice).
- **Lethai-thora Archivists of the First Seal:** The Lethai-thora are not merely librarians — they are the keepers of the original Mandate, written on tortoise shells and dragon bones. They do not serve the emperor; they serve the ledger that predates the empire. A Lethai-thora keeper can declare any document void by writing “void” in water over it. The water must be from the Well of Erased Names. Doing so costs 1 Obligation to the Lethai-thora and ticks the Mandate Clock +1 (the Censorate will investigate).
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
 - **The Jade Censor** — The Witness. *A magistrate who never blinks, who writes every truth in a ledger of jade.*
 - **The Dragon Salt** — Maelstraeus. *The price of a monopoly; the interest on a nation’s thirst.*
 - **The Ninth Ancestor** — Khemesh. *The ghost of the first emperor, who still reviews petitions.*
 - **The Brush That Walks** — The Traveler. *A calligraphy brush that guides lost officials through the underworld.*
 - **The Kitchen’s Ear** — The Sealed Gate. *The god who reports every secret to the Celestial Bureaucracy.*

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Ninth Ledger and the Kalrantha Amulet (Dhahara):** The ninth ledger is said to contain the name of the prince who stole the amulet. The Veiled Sisters want to erase it. The Breath-less want to find it. The Lethai-thora have hidden it in a scroll that unrolls forever.
- **Silence-Tokens and the Covenant (Mykkiel):** The Covenant recognises Lethai-thora silence-tokens as valid requests for closed hearings. A silence token can pause any court proceeding for the duration of a single breath. The token is a strip of silk from a burial shroud.
- **Canal Mothers and the Fhara (Way of Silk):** Fhara well-judges and Sihai canal mothers use similar water-measuring systems. A canal mother’s key can be used to negotiate a well contract — but the key must be dipped in the well first. The water will remember.
- **The Mandate and the Hollow (Eastern Realms):** The Hollow is the unpaid interest on the Mandate. Aelaerem hedge-keepers say that when a dynasty falls, the Hollow eats the ninth name. The name is always the emperor’s secret childhood name.

Sihai Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Canal:** Crumble a crust into the water. Ignore the first *Forged Scroll* penalty. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Knot the Scroll:** Tie a single knot in a silk cord. Cancel *Censorate Audit* or take –1 die on your next forgery detection roll (your choice). ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Name to the Well:** Whisper a dead censor’s name into the Well of Erased Names. Gain +1 Effect when negotiating with the Censorate this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Hollow. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **Censorate clerks or ancestor ghosts**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **canal patrols or hungry ghosts**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or the Kitchen God**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favourable water level**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Local censor or canal mother** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **fog or a ghost procession**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **paper soldier (origami construct) or a hungry ghost** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **Censorate guards, ancestor spirits, or paper soldiers** arrive.

- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes—**ancestor summoned/ledger stolen/mandate questioned**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival: Quiet Chancellor, Salt Commissioner, or First Censor's Ghost** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically—**canal floods/archive burns/mandate falls**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice—**omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Sihai (Celestial Bureaucracy):** A ghost clerk appears with a writ, a paper seal floats down from nowhere, the Emperor's Dreamer whispers a warning.
- **Sihai (Ancestor Law):** A family shrine glows, an ancestor's portrait weeps ink, a forgotten debt is recalled in a dream.
- **Sihai (Examination Hell):** A failed candidate's ghost asks for a pen, a test paper bleeds, the proctor's bell rings nine times.

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Wits + Navigation):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Paper Trail*.
- **Cut the Seal (Presence + Lore):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a stamped pass is in your possession, +1 die.
- **Weather the Audit (Resolve + Spirit):** On a hit in *Censorate Audit*, you pick who testifies; on a miss, the GM does.

Boss Seeds (Brush Mandate)

- **The Forgotten Emperor (Ghost of the Ninth Seal)** — *Phases:* Names Erased → Ledger Stolen → Mandate Reclaimed. *Cracks:* present a true ancestor tablet, expose a forged lineage, survive a night in the Well of Erased Names.
- **The Brush That Writes Itself (Living Ink)** — *Phases:* Paper Soldiers → Scroll Prison → Ink Flood. *Cracks:* a Lethai-thora silence-token, a confession written in water, the First Censor's Brush.

Patronage & Power

In Sihai, power flows through ink, salt, and the weight of the Mandate. The Emperor rules, but the Censorate audits, the Salt Monopoly finances, the Lethai-thora remember, and the ancestors watch. A well-written couplet can appease a ghost; a forged seal can start a war. The Celestial Bureaucracy is always hiring.

For the GM: Power in Sihai is measured in examination scores, salt licenses, and the thickness of a family’s archive. Patronage often takes the form of stamped passes, ledger copies, or silence-tokens — each tied to a specific office, canal, or debt. To emphasize the mythological flavour:

- Use the **Mandate Clock** as a visible campaign front. The party’s actions can tick or reset it. Ancestor rites are the only safe way to reduce it.
- Enforce **Censorate Audits** as a recurring threat — players must maintain clean papers or face erasure. Ghost witnesses can be summoned by either side.
- Let **water rights** be a form of currency that can be stolen, forged, or contested — but angering the Dragon King has consequences.
- Introduce **paper soldiers** (origami constructs) as low-tier enemies and **hungry ghosts** as mid-tier threats. The Censorate employs both.

In Sihai, the brush forgets nothing — and the Hollow remembers every erased name.

Chapter 34

Nihori

The Isles of the Dawn Spirit.

I ruled the waves before the Hollow learned to walk. My empire sank because I spoke a name I should not have. Do not speak my name. Do not ask what it was. The sea remembers. That is enough.

I am a Wanderer. I carry a broken sword and a grudge. The sword was my father's. The grudge is mine. The man who killed him died nine years ago. I still walk the isles, looking for his ghost. The ghost is looking for me too.

Nihori is a chain of volcanic islands, shrouded in mist and lashed by storms. Here, the old empire sank beneath the waves, and the Lethai-al guard the drowned kingdom's memory. The people are wanderers, duelists, and shrine maidens. They worship the storm spirits and fear the ninth wave. The Hollow breathes in the salt foam; the Debt-Walkers ride the tide. But here's the secret the Shogun doesn't want you to know: the old empire did not sink. It was pulled under. And whatever pulled it is still down there, waiting for the ninth wave to break the right way.

The Shogun sits in a half-ruined castle, his authority challenged by three rival daimyo who sharpen their blades and their treaties. Oni cults whisper in the ash wastes, offering forgotten bargains. The Storm Emperor's ghost does not rule—but his silence haunts every island. The ninth taboo is absolute: never speak the name of the drowned capital. The sea will hear you, and it will ask why you called. And when the sea asks a question, it expects an answer—in blood, in memory, or in a name you did not mean to give.

Never speak the name of the drowned capital. The sea will hear you, and it will ask why you called.

— *The Storm Emperor's Ghost, who appears as a column of steam over the water*

The Almanac of Ordinary Days

What do people eat for breakfast? Grilled fish and pickled vegetables—the fish is caught in the caldera lakes, the vegetables are fermented in clay pots buried in volcanic ash. The ash is warm. The warmth is the mountain's breath. The mountain is sleeping. The mountain dreams of the drowned empire.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To read the tide. Nihori children are taught the eight wave-heights: Calm, Ripple, Swell, Storm, Tsunami, and the ninth—the wave that has no height because it is the sea itself rising. The ninth wave is the drowning. The drowning is the empire's memory.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their sword. Nihori warriors carry their ancestors' blades, passed down for generations. A stranger whose sword is rusted has forgotten their lineage. A stranger whose sword is sharp has remembered. A stranger with no sword is a coward. Cowards are not fed.

What is the most common crime? Dueling—but dueling is not a crime, it is a conversation. The dueling codes are written in verse. The verses are interpreted by the Shogun's court. The interpretations are contradictory. The contradictions are settled by dueling. The circle is beautiful.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The drowned capital is not underwater. It is beneath—beneath the caldera, beneath the bedrock, beneath the world. The sea is a lid. The lid is cracked. Something is leaking through. The leaks are the oni. The oni are the empire's regrets.

Where do people go when they die? To the sea cliffs. The dead are placed in caves overlooking the water. The waves sing to them. The songs are the empire's lullabies. The dead listen. The dead do not sleep.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You offer a duel—a matched contest with the wronged party's choice of weapon. If you lose, you are forgiven. If you win, you are not. If you refuse, you are exiled. Exile is the open sea. The sea is patient. The sea will wait.

What is the most important festival? The Calling of the Tides (spring). The shrine maidens walk into the water, singing the names of the drowned. The waves answer. The waves speak the names of the living who will die in the coming year. The names are never forgotten. The names are never repeated.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Shogun is a ghost. He died in the last oni war, but his body was never found. The daimyo rule in his name because they are afraid of what will happen if they admit he is gone. The oni know. The oni are waiting for the admission. The admission will be the war.

34.1 Nihori — “The Isles of the Dawn Spirit”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *Duel at dawn. Honour the storm. The ninth wave never breaks.*

Storm Emperor’s Ghost (Elite): “I ruled the waves before the Hollow learned to walk. My empire sank because I spoke a name I should not have. Do not speak my name. Do not ask what it was. The sea remembers. That is enough.”

Wanderer (Commoner): “I carry a broken sword and a grudge. The sword was my father’s. The grudge is mine. The man who killed him died nine years ago. I still walk the isles, looking for his ghost. The ghost is looking for me too.”

Genre / Mood: Storm-tossed honour duels, kami politics, oni cults, volcanic doom.

Starting Location: A bamboo grove on a clifftop, where two duelists face each other at dawn. Ash from the volcano dusts their shoulders. A Shrine Maiden rings a copper bell: “The Shogun’s envoy demands the duel stop. The daimyo of the southern isle says it will not. The storm-spirit is watching. Choose a side — or the ninth wave will choose for you.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Nihori is a chain of volcanic islands, shrouded in mist and lashed by storms — a shattered shogunate where the old empire sank beneath the waves and the Lethai-al guard the drowned kingdom’s memory. The people are wanderers, duelists, shrine maidens, and oni-touched outcasts. They worship the storm spirits (kami of wind, wave, and crater) and fear the ninth wave. The Hollow breathes in the salt foam; Debt-Walkers ride the tide. The Shogun sits in a half-ruined castle, his authority challenged by three rival daimyo who sharpen their blades and their treaties. Oni cults whisper in the ash wastes, offering forgotten bargains. The Storm Emperor’s ghost does not rule — but his silence haunts every island. The ninth taboo is absolute: never speak the name of the drowned capital. The sea will hear you, and it will ask why you called.

What you notice first: The smell of salt and volcanic ash. The way every traveller carries a sword, even the tea-sellers. The constant sound of bells on shrine gates — ringing in the wind. And the silence when a daimyo’s retinue passes.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never draw steel in a shrine. The kami will witness. They may not forgive.

Regional Mood: The Weight of the Wave and the Edge of the Blade

Power here is measured in duels won, storms survived, and the number of clans that bow to your banner. The Shogun rules from Castle Kurotani, but his writ fades as the islands stretch into the mist. Three daimyo vie for supremacy: the Northern Crane (old blood, slow to anger, quicker to negotiate), the Southern Serpent (pragmatic, pirates in his pay, a smile like a cracked bell), and the Western Oni (rumoured to have made a pact with a Crater Oni, his eyes glow faintly red in the dark). Between them, the Shrine Maidens keep the peace — not through steel, but through storm-calling and the threat of the ninth wave. A duel is not merely a fight; it is a negotiation sanctified by kami. First blood decides the truth. The loser owes a story. The winner owes a cup of sake — and a prayer at the nearest shrine.

Starting Location: The Shogun’s court in Castle Kurotani, where a fractured stone throne overlooks a bay that steams with volcanic vents. A Shrine Maiden rings a copper bell: “The Storm Emperor’s ghost spoke last night. It said: ‘The serpent will swallow the crane, and the oni will laugh.’ The Shogun wants you to find out which daimyo is making a pact with the oni cult. Do not get caught. The oni eat liars first.”

Prominent NPCs of Nihori

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Shogun Atsumori	Figurehead ruler of the shattered realm	Keep the daimyo from open war	He has not spoken in seven years. His attendants speak for him.
Daimyo Sadako (Southern Serpent)	Ruler of the southern isles, pirate ally	Break the Shogun’s peace and claim the throne	She wears a necklace of brass hooks — one for each ship she has taken.
Daimyo Yoritomo (Northern Crane)	Old-blood traditionalist	Restore the shogunate’s authority by the old laws	He has never lost a duel. He has never drawn first blood.
The Oni-Eyed (Daimyo of the West)	Ruler of the western ash wastes, rumoured oni-touched	Ascend to a new form — neither human nor spirit	His eyes glow red in darkness. His retainers wear masks.
Shrine Maiden Hana	Keeper of the Storm Shrine	Pacify the spirit of the ninth wave	She rings a bell that can only be heard underwater.
Wanderer Ronin	Masterless swordsman	Find the ghost of his father’s killer	He has never lost a duel. He has also never drawn first blood.
Pirate Captain Red-Hook	Kalingan raider	Control the strait between the isles	His left hand is a brass hook. The hook is also a key.

The Drowned Scholar (Ghost)	A Lethai-al who died before completing his research	Ask the living to retrieve a scroll from the sunken capital	He appears at low tide, holding a skeletal oar.
Oni-Brewer (Cult Leader)	A priest of the Crater Oni who brews memory-erasing sake	Turn the daimyo’s court into puppets	His breath smells of ash and plum wine. He never blinks.

Names of Nihori

Inspired by the northern isles: short, with vowel endings and occasional glottal stops. Surnames denote a clan, a wave, or a drowned ancestor.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Clan/Epithet	Wave-Name
Kenji	Hana	Wave-walker	<i>Ninth Breath</i>
Ronan	Yuki	Storm-kin	<i>Salt-Tongue</i>
Kael	Mira	Drowned-line	<i>Unforgotten</i>
Takeshi	Sora	Foam-born	<i>Tide-Charm</i>
Jiro	Nami	Ancestor-salt	<i>the Unshadowed</i>

(Forge/Grove/Shrine) A swordsmith’s forge with a waterfall cooling tank; a bamboo grove where duels are fought at dawn; a storm-shrine on a cliff with ropes for climbing.

Spades — Places

2. **Swordsmith’s Forge (Volcano-Fired)** — A waterfall cooling tank; prayer strips on the bellows. *The swordsmith prays before each strike. The prayer is a verse from the old epic.* ‘[CRAFT]’
3. **Bamboo Grove (Duel Ground)** — A clearing where the stalks are scarred by blade cuts. *The bamboo bleeds sap when a duel is dishonourable. The sap is red.* ‘[HONOUR]’
4. **Storm-Shrine (Cliff)** — A wooden platform on a sea cliff, with ropes for climbing. *The ropes are braided with human hair. The hair is from sailors who survived shipwrecks.* ‘[KAMI]’
5. **Drowned Palace (Ruins)** — Half-submerged columns visible at low tide. *The columns are carved with names. The names are the drowned kingdom’s royalty.* ‘[DEATH]’
6. **Volcano Shrine (Dormant)** — A crater where the forbidden name was spoken. *The crater is warm. Speaking any name aloud here causes the ground to tremble.* ‘[ONI]’
7. **Castle Kurotani (Shogun’s Seat)** — A half-ruined fortress on a clifftop, roofs patched with salvaged ship timber. *The Shogun’s throne is cracked. The crack is shaped like a wave.* ‘[POLITICS]’
8. **Southern Serpent’s Fleet Anchorage** — A hidden harbour where pirate dhows and war junks moor together. *The flags are all different. The loyalty is all to the same purse.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’

9. **Oni's Caldera (Western Ash Wastes)** — A crater lake where the Oni-Eyed daimyo holds court. *The water is warm and red. It tastes of iron and forgotten promises.* '[CORRUPTION]'
10. **Crane Clan's Archive Temple** — A library built into a sea cliff, scrolls sealed in wax. *The clan has not opened the oldest wing in a century. The seal is still warm.* '[TRADITION]'
- J **The Sunken Gate** — An underwater archway that leads to the drowned capital. *It can only be reached by holding your breath for nine heartbeats.* '[THRESHOLD]'
- Q **Storm-Reader's Lookout** — A wooden tower on the highest cliff. *From here, the Storm-Reader can see three storms coming. He has never been wrong.* '[WEATHER]'
- K **The Ninth Wave's Rock** — A black stone that the ninth wave strikes every full moon. *The wave leaves behind a single white shell. The shell contains a memory.* '[OMEN]'
- A **The Drowned Capital (Myth)** — A sunken city said to rise once every century. *Those who enter can speak to the dead. The price is a breath.* '[LEGEND]'

(Wanderer/Maiden/Pirate) Wanderer with a broken sword; Shrine Maiden with a copper bell; Pirate Captain with a brass hook.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Wanderer (Ronin)** — A man with no master, a scarred blade, and a cup of sake. *He offers a cup to every opponent. "Drink," he says. "The duel will be fair."* '[HONOUR]'
3. **Shrine Maiden Hana** — A woman with a copper bell on a rope. She rings it at dawn. *The bell's tone tells the fishing fleet whether to sail. It has never been wrong.* '[KAMI]'
4. **Pirate Captain Red-Hook** — A woman with a brass hook for a hand. She lost the original to a sea monster. *The hook is also a key. It opens a chest of treasure maps — and a dossier on the Southern Serpent's spies.* '[STEALTH]'
5. **Storm-Reader** — Grey-haired, eyes the colour of storm clouds. He can feel the pressure change in his bones. *"The storm will arrive in nine hours," he says. "Bring your offerings — or your prayers."* '[WEATHER]'
6. **Swordsmith** — A woman with calloused hands and a prayer strip on her forehead. *She names each sword after a dead warrior. The sword remembers. The warrior's ghost may visit.* '[CRAFT]'
7. **Shogun's Chamberlain** — A soft-spoken man with a fan painted with a crane. He speaks for the silent Shogun. *He never raises his voice. The daimyo lower theirs when he enters.* '[POLITICS]'
8. **Daimyo Sadako (Southern Serpent)** — A woman with a scarred lip, a fleet of dhows, and a network of informants. *She wears a necklace of brass hooks — one for each ship she has taken. She adds a new one each season.* '[AUTHORITY]'
9. **Daimyo Yoritomo (Northern Crane)** — An old man with perfect posture, a blade that has never drawn blood, and a library of old laws. *He has never lost a duel. He has never drawn first blood. His opponents always apologise.* '[TRADITION]'
10. **The Oni-Eyed** — A figure in a tattered mask, one eye glowing red. He rules the ash wastes from a throne of cooled lava. *His retainers wear masks of their own faces — cast from the moment they swore loyalty.* '[CORRUPTION]'
- J **Oni-Brewer (Cult Leader)** — A bald man with burn scars, a ceramic sake jug, and a sweet,

rotten smile. *His sake erases memories. He sells it to daimyo who want to forget debts — and to assassins who want to forget guilt.* ‘[DEBT]’

Q Storm Emperor’s Ghost — A column of steam over the water, shaped like a crowned man. *He asks: “Has anyone spoken the name?” If you say yes, he weeps. If you say no, he waits.* ‘[DEATH]’

K Crater Oni (Sealed) — A horned shadow visible only in the reflection of volcanic vents. *It offers bargains: a year of luck for a memory, a century of life for a death. The Oni-Eyed accepted. He does not remember the price.* ‘[PATRON]’

A The First Drowned (Legend) — The first Lethai-al who died in the sinking. She sits at the bottom of the sea. *If you bring her a memory, she will teach you to breathe water. If you bring her a lie, she will drown you.* ‘[LEGEND]’

(Ashfall/Duel/Pirate) Ashfall from the volcano — all actions Desperate; a duel challenge is issued — refusal loses face; a pirate flotilla claims the strait — pay toll or fight.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Ashfall (Volcano)** — The dormant crater emits ash. Visibility drops. All actions are Desperate. ‘[WEATHER]’ *The ash is warm. It smells of old names. Speaking a name makes the ash thicken — and the oni listen.*
3. **Duel Challenge (Issued)** — A Lethai-al challenges a party member to a duel. Refusal loses face. ‘[HONOUR]’ ‘[COMBAT]’ *The duel is to first blood. The loser owes a story. The story must be true. The winner owes a prayer.*
4. **Pirate Flotilla (Southern Serpent’s Fleet)** — Kalingan pirates block the strait. They demand a toll of one tide-charm. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[COMBAT]’ *The charm must be from a drowned ancestor. Refuse, and they attack — with cannon.*
5. **Oni Cult Initiation** — A traveller is marked by the Oni-Eyed’s cult. Their shadow has horns. ‘[CORRUPTION]’ ‘[FEAR]’ *The cult demands a service: steal a scroll from the Crane Clan’s archive, or the mark will spread.*
6. **Tide-Charm Stolen** — Someone steals a pouch of charms. The ancestors are angry. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[DEBT]’ *The thief is a foreign merchant in the pay of the Southern Serpent. The charms are in a cargo hold guarded by oni-touched pirates.*
7. **Daimyo Summit (War Threatened)** — The three daimyo agree to meet. The Shogun’s peace holds — barely. ‘[POLITICS]’ *Any false move could ignite a civil war. The party is there as witnesses — or scapegoats.*
8. **Volcano Name Whispered** — Someone speaks the forbidden name near the crater. The ground shakes. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[DISASTER]’ *The speaker is a child of the Oni-Eyed’s household. The child did not know. The volcano remembers. The oni laughs.*
9. **Ninth Wave Warning** — The full moon is tomorrow. The ninth wave will be larger than any in a century. ‘[WEATHER]’ *The fishing fleet cannot be recalled. Someone must warn them — or bargain with the storm-spirit for their lives.*
10. **Sake House Brawl (Oni-Brewer’s Sake)** — A dispute over a duel’s fairness turns violent. The ninth cup is poured. ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[DEBT]’ *The ninth cup is for the dead. Someone has just died. The brawl is now a blood feud — and everyone has forgotten why.*
- J Sunken Gate Opens** — The underwater archway becomes passable. Something swims out.

‘[THRESHOLD]’ ‘[DEATH]’ *It is a drowned spirit. It wants its name back. It will trade a secret for it — or take yours.*

Q Storm-Reader’s Silence — The old man stops reading the storm. The fishermen do not know where to sail. ‘[WEATHER]’ ‘[GRIEF]’ *He is grieving. His son died at sea. He will not speak until the body is found — or until someone tells him a true story of the sea.*

K Duel to the Death (Oni-Eyed’s Assassin) — A duel that was meant to be to first blood becomes a killing. ‘[HONOUR]’ ‘[TRAP]’ *The killer is a spy from the Western Ash Wastes. The duel was an assassination. The party is blamed — unless they can prove the oni-touched intervened.*

A The Ninth Wave Takes — The massive wave crashes over the cliff shrine. The bells are silent. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[CATASTROPHE]’ *The shrine maiden is gone. The storm-spirit is free. The Hollow walks the shore. The only way to appease it is to speak the name of the drowned capital — and accept the consequences.*

(Token/Bell/Charm) Swordsmith’s token (one reroll on a failed melee attack); shrine bell (reveals hidden spirits for one scene); wanderer’s oath-bracelet (one use to compel a service).

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

- 2. Swordsmith’s Token (Iron)** — A small iron disc. Reroll a failed melee attack once. ‘[COMBAT]’ *The token is stamped with a prayer. The prayer is for a clean cut. The swordsmith made it for a warrior who never returned.*
- 3. Shrine Bell (Copper)** — A small copper bell. Ring it to reveal hidden spirits for one scene. ‘[KAMI]’ *The bell’s tone is inaudible to humans. The spirits hear it clearly. They may answer — or they may hide.*
- 4. Wanderer’s Oath-Bracelet (Leather)** — A braided leather bracelet. Demand a service from any wanderer once. ‘[HONOUR]’ *The bracelet is stained with sake. The wanderer cannot refuse. The service is one night’s vigil or one day’s guide.*
- 5. Storm-Charm (Bone)** — A carved bone. Ignore one weather penalty on a journey leg. ‘[WEATHER]’ *The bone is from a sailor who died in a storm. His spirit protects you — but he will ask for a story in return.*
- 6. Tide-Charm (Shell)** — A white shell. Whisper a drowned ancestor’s name to calm a storm for one hour. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[WEATHER]’ *The shell is warm. It glows when the ancestor is listening. Do not lie. They know.*
- 7. Duelist’s Sake Cup** — A ceramic cup used in a fair duel. Demand a duel to first blood. ‘[HONOUR]’ *The cup is chipped. The chip is from a blade that drew first blood. The loser’s story is carved into the rim.*
- 8. Pirate Captain’s Hook (Brass)** — A brass hook prosthetic. Use it as a key to open any chest in the cove. ‘[STEALTH]’ *The hook is also a weapon. It can cut rope and bone. It also fits the lock on the Southern Serpent’s war chest.*
- 9. Volcano Priest’s Whisper** — A single word: the forbidden name. Speak it to cause a tremor. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[MAGIC]’ *The word burns the tongue. Use once. The volcano will remember. The oni will hear.*
- 10. Drowned Scholar’s Scroll (Waterproof)** — A scroll retrieved from the sunken capital. Contains a forgotten secret. ‘[LEGEND]’ *The scroll is wet. It will never dry. The secret is about the Storm Emperor’s true name — and why he spoke it.*

- J Ninth Wave’s Shell** — A white shell from the Ninth Wave’s Rock. Break it to experience a memory. ‘[OMEN]’ *The memory is always a death. The death is always a drowning. The memory may be yours — or an ancestor’s.*
- Q Storm-Reader’s Flute (Bone)** — A bone flute. Play it to predict the weather for the next 24 hours. ‘[WEATHER]’ *The tune is sad. It always predicts a storm. It is always right. The Storm-Reader will not explain why.*
- K Sunken Gate Key (Coral)** — A piece of coral shaped like a key. Opens the Sunken Gate. ‘[THRESHOLD]’ *The key is alive. It grows. It will only fit the gate once. The gate may not open again for a century.*
- A First Drowned’s Breath (Glass Vial)** — Seawater from the bottom of the sunken capital. Drink it to breathe water for one hour. ‘[LEGEND]’ *The water tastes of salt and sorrow. The lungs will ache. The memory of drowning will stay with you.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits. Highest rank sets main Clock.
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (tokens, bells, charms) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **sea-omens**—a wave that breaks twice, a bell that rings underwater, a name that echoes from the foam.

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **Duel Law:** Disputes in Nihori are settled by duel to first blood. The loser owes a story; the winner owes a cup of sake. A duel can be witnessed by anyone; the witness’s word is law. Refusing a duel is an admission of guilt. In the shogunate courts, a duel verdict can overturn a written contract.
- **Storm Season Clock [8]:** Tracks the approach of the monsoon. When it fills, a typhoon strikes — all travel becomes Desperate for 2 legs. The clock ticks each day during storm season. The Shrine Maidens can delay it by one day for a suitable offering (a tide-charm, a memory, or a promise).
- **Kami Favour (Reputation Track):** Instead of debt, track **Kami Favour [6]**. Gain favour by respecting shrines, winning duels honourably, and appeasing storm-spirits. Spend favour to ask a kami for a boon (e.g., calm weather, a warning, a safe passage). At 0 favour, shrines are hostile — all social rolls at shrines are Desperate.
- **Oni Corruption Track [6]:** Represents the influence of the Oni-Eyed’s cult and the Crater Oni. Tick when a character makes a bargain with an oni, drinks oni-brewed sake, or speaks the forbidden name. At 3 segments: the character’s shadow grows horns. At 6: the character becomes oni-touched — they gain +1 die to intimidation but suffer –1 die to all social rolls with shrine maidens and can never enter a shrine without being attacked.
- **Shogunate Faction Clocks:** Track the three daimyo’s schemes:
 - **Southern Serpent’s Ambition [6]** — advances when she bribes officials, builds her fleet, or sponsors pirate raids. When full, she declares open war on the Shogun.
 - **Northern Crane’s Patience [6]** — retreats when he is humiliated or his allies defect. When it reaches 0, he abandons the Shogun’s peace and marches south.

- **Oni-Eyed’s Ascension** [8] — advances each time a character accepts an oni bargain or the party fails to stop a cult ritual. When full, the Crater Oni manifests in the material world.
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
 - **The Storm Emperor’s Ghost** — Khemesh + The Witness. *The pressure of a forbidden name, the memory of a drowned kingdom.*
 - **The Crater Oni** — Malachai. *Cursed gifts, bargains that leave scars, power that transforms you from the inside.*
 - **The Ninth Wave** — Raéyn. *The storm that does not break, the tide that remembers every sailor.*
 - **The Bell of Drowned Shrines** — The Sealed Gate. *The boundary between the living and the dead, guarded by bells and salt.*

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Drowned Capital and the Kalrantha Amulet (Dhahara):** The sunken city is said to contain a temple that holds a fragment of the demon Varash. The Veiled Sisters want it. The Oni-Eyed wants to bargain with it. The Shrine Maidens want it to stay drowned.
- **Tide-Charms and the Tulkani (Way of Silk):** Tulkani story-tellers sometimes carry Lethai-al tide-charms as proof of a witnessed drowning. A charm from Nihori is worth twice as much — and attracts twice as much Hollow attention.
- **Storm-Spirits and the Veiled Sisters (Ashaan):** The Veiled Sisters have tried to bind storm-spirits for use in their fleet. The Lethai-al have foiled nine attempts. The tenth attempt is being funded by the Southern Serpent’s pirate gold.
- **Oni Bargains and the Chain (Bitter Root):** Daughters of the Cord refuse to treat with oni — the interest is always paid in souls, and the Cord cannot collect from a damned spirit. An oni-touched Daughter is a contradiction; one may be hiding in the ash wastes, trying to untie her cord from a Crater Oni’s bargain.
- **The Ninth Wave and the Hollow (Eastern Realms):** Aelaerem hedge-keepers say that the ninth wave is the Hollow’s breath. When it crashes, the Hollow exhales. Those who hear it must speak a true name or lose one of their own.

Nihori Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Foam:** Crumble a crust at the water’s edge. Ignore the first *Pirate Flotilla* penalty. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Knot the Rope:** Tie a single knot in a shrine climbing rope. Cancel *Storm-Spirit Offended* or take –1 die on your next sailing roll (your choice). ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Name to the Wave:** Whisper a drowned ancestor’s name into the ninth wave. Gain +1 Effect when navigating a storm this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Hollow. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Sake to the Oni:** Pour a cup of sake onto volcanic stone. Cancel one tick of the *Oni Corruption* track — but the oni will remember your face. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **clan retainers or shrine maidens**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **duelists or pirate lookouts**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **oni cultists or the Storm-Reader’s spies**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favourable tide**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Local daimyo’s guard or shrine keeper** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **ashfall or rising water**.
- **Foe Appears:** An **oni-touched ronin or a pirate boarding party** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **oni cultists, pirate ships, or clan samurai** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes—**duel becomes a killing / volcano trembles / ninth wave crests early**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **Shogun’s Chamberlain, Oni-Eyed, or Storm Emperor’s Ghost** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically—**volcano erupts / tsunami strikes / shrine collapses**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice—**omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Nihori (Duel Law):** A witness recants, the first blood is disputed, a duelist’s story is revealed as false.
- **Nihori (Storm Kami):** A kami demands a toll, a storm shifts direction, the ninth wave’s timing changes.
- **Nihori (Oni Cult):** A shadow grows horns, a memory curdles, an oni bargain’s fine print appears.

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Wits + Navigation):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Fog Bank*.
- **Cut the Duel (Presence + Honour):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a duelist's sake cup is in your possession, +1 die.
- **Weather the Wave (Resolve + Survival):** On a hit in *Ninth Wave Warning*, you pick who keeps their footing; on a miss, the GM does.

Boss Seeds (Honour Oni)

- **The Oni-Eyed (Ascended Cultist)** — *Phases:* Whispered Bargain → Horned Shadow → Oni Manifest. *Cracks:* speak his original name, destroy the mask, offer a memory the oni cannot refuse.
- **The Storm Emperor's Ghost (Drowned Sovereign)** — *Phases:* Silent Tide → Wave of Names → The Ninth Breaks. *Cracks:* speak the forbidden name at the Sunken Gate, return the drowned scholar's scroll, let the Storm-Reader negotiate.
- **Southern Serpent (Pirate Admiral)** — *Phases:* Fleet Gathers → Tariff Blockade → Throne Claim. *Cracks:* expose her spy network, sink her flagship, convince the Crane to ally with the Shogun.

Patronage & Power

In Nihori, power flows through duels, storms, the favour of kami, and the dangerous bargains of oni. The Shogun is a figurehead; the three daimyo are the real players. A clan chief's authority rests on how many duels he has won and how many shrines he has funded. A shrine maiden's on how many storms she has predicted and how many oni she has banished.

For the GM: Use the **Storm Season Clock** as a visible threat. Let **Duel Law** be a way to resolve conflicts without combat — or a way to escalate them when honour is insulted. Make **Tide-Charms** valuable but dangerous — each use may attract the Hollow or the attention of an oni. Track the three daimyo's **Faction Clocks** as a campaign front; the party's actions can accelerate or delay civil war. Use **Kami Favour** as a reputation currency — players must choose which shrines to support and which kami to appease.

Chapter 35

Ayokha

The Monsoon Throne.

The monsoon does not come because we pray. It comes because the stars align. I read the stars. I align them. Without me, the rains would fail, the rice would burn, and the kingdom would fall. I am not a servant of the God-King. I am his monsoon.

I am a River Merchant. My boat has more secrets than cargo. The lower deck is for silk. The upper deck is for lies. The tiller is for bribes. I have carried nine spies this year. The ninth was the God-King's own daughter.

Ayokha is the land of the Monsoon Throne, where the God-King rules by the rhythm of the rains. Rivers flood, rice terraces glow green, and the wharves are crowded with ships from Dhahara, Sihai, and distant isles. The Lethai-ar witness every contract; the spirit-mediums speak for the nats of the ford. Power here is measured in monsoon schedules, silk vouchers, and the favour of the God-King's astrologer. But here's the secret the astrologer doesn't want you to know: the monsoon does not come because he aligns the stars. The monsoon comes because the river-spirits allow it. And the river-spirits are angry.

The nats—hungry spirits who live in eddies and under bridges—demand offerings of betel leaf, candle wax, and forgotten promises. A merchant who ignores a nat's demand will find his boat sunk and his name struck from the ledgers. A farmer who disrespects the monsoon will find his fields barren and his children dreaming of drowning. In Ayokha, the rain is not weather—it is a creditor. And the God-King is behind on his payments.

Never refuse a gift of betel leaf. It is an oath of hospitality. Refusing it is an insult that can end a bloodline.

— *The God-King's Astrologer, who has not seen the sun in thirty years*

The Almanac of Ordinary Days

What do people eat for breakfast? Rice congee with dried shrimp—the rice is from the terraces, the shrimp is from the delta nets. The delta is where the river meets the sea. The sea is the God-King's mother. The God-King's mother is a nat. The nat is hungry.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To read the river. Ayokha children are taught the eight currents: Flood, Ebb, Eddy, Whirl, Still, and the ninth—the current that flows upstream. The upstream current is the monsoon's breath. The monsoon's breath is the God-King's voice. The God-King is silent.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their offering. Every traveler in Ayokha carries a gift for the nats—betel leaf, candle, a coin. A stranger whose offering is generous has been blessed. A stranger whose offering is small is testing the spirits. A stranger with no offering is a fool. The nats take fools first.

What is the most common crime? Nat-bribery—but bribery is not a crime, it is a negotiation. The nats set the tolls. The merchants pay the tolls. The nats spend the tolls on offerings. The offerings are burned. The ash falls on the fields. The fields are fertile. The circle is the economy.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The God-King is a puppet. The astrologer is the real ruler. The astrologer reads the stars. The stars say what the astrologer tells them to say. The astrologer has not read the stars in twenty years. He reads the nats' moods instead. The nats are fickle.

Where do people go when they die? To the river. The dead are cremated on the ghats. Their ashes are scattered on the water. The water carries them to the delta. The delta is the land of the nats. The nats decide whether the dead become ancestors or hungry ghosts. The nats are not generous.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You offer a nat—a spirit of the river, summoned by a medium. The nat hears your apology. If the nat accepts, the water is calm. If the nat refuses, the water rises. If the nat is silent, the water is still. Still water is the God-King's judgment. The God-King does not forgive.

What is the most important festival? The Welcoming of the Monsoon (summer). The God-King stands in the rain. The rain is the nats' blessing. The blessing is measured in inches. The inches determine the harvest. The harvest determines the taxes. The taxes determine the God-King's wealth. The God-King is not wealthy.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The God-King's daughter is not his daughter. She is the child of the astrologer and a nat—born from a bargain made during a failed monsoon. She can control the rain. She does not know. The astrologer knows. The astrologer is waiting for the right moment to tell her. The right moment is the next drought.

35.1 Ayokha — “The Monsoon Throne”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *The rain writes the law. The river witnesses. The ninth cup is for the drowned.*

God-King’s Astrologer (Elite): “The monsoon does not come because we pray. It comes because the stars align. I read the stars. I align them. Without me, the rains would fail, the rice would burn, and the kingdom would fall. I am not a servant of the God-King. I am his monsoon.”

River Merchant (Commoner): “My boat has more secrets than cargo. The lower deck is for silk. The upper deck is for lies. The tiller is for bribes. I have carried nine spies this year. The ninth was the God-King’s own daughter.”

Genre / Mood: Monsoon noir – waterlogged intrigue, spirit bargains, and the tyranny of the rain.

Starting Location: A river market on stilts, where boats load silk and spices, and the air smells of brine and betrayal. A Lethai-ar Vigil holds a green lamp: “The God-King’s astrologer has predicted a late monsoon. The merchants are panicking. The rice will fail unless someone sacrifices to the river spirit. You are someone. Go.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Ayokha is the land of the Monsoon Throne, where the God-King rules by the rhythm of the rains. Rivers flood, rice terraces glow green like jade stairways, and the wharves are crowded with ships from Dhahara, Sihai, and distant isles. The Lethai-ar witness every contract; the spirit-mediums speak for the nats of the ford – hungry spirits who live in eddies and under bridges. Power here is measured in monsoon schedules, silk vouchers, and the favour of the God-King’s astrologer, a man who has not seen the sun in thirty years. The ninth taboo is absolute: never pour the ninth cup, never count the ninth wave, never speak the ninth name. The Hollow watches from the flooded fields, and the drowned sometimes knock on the hulls of passing boats.

What you notice first: The smell of wet earth and fermenting rice, thick as a fever dream. The way every bridge has a spirit shrine at its foot, offerings of betel leaf and candle wax. The constant sound of water — dripping, flowing, raining, whispering.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never refuse a gift of betel leaf. It is an oath of hospitality. Refusing it is an insult that can end a bloodline.

Regional Mood: The Weight of the Monsoon

Power here is measured in monsoon predictions, silk bales, and the number of spirits placated. The God-King rules from a floating palace, but the astrologer sets the calendar, the Lethai-ar witness the contracts, and the spirit-mediums negotiate with the nats. A merchant who ignores a nat’s demand will find his boat sunk and his name struck from the ledgers. A farmer who disrespects the monsoon will find his fields barren and his children dreaming of drowning. In Ayokha, the rain is not weather – it is a creditor.

Prominent NPCs of Ayokha

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
God-King's Astrologer	Royal astronomer	Predict the monsoon before the people starve	He has not seen the sun in thirty years. He works by candlelight.
Vigil Lady Suyin	Lethai-ar witness-master	Keep the river's ledger free of forgeries	She has cut nine witness cords. The ninth was her own.
River Merchant	Silk trader	Smuggle contraband under the God-King's tariffs	She has a hidden deck that only appears at low tide.
Spirit-Medium	Nat negotiator	Speak for the spirit of the ford	She carries a bowl of water; the spirit speaks through ripples.
The Drowned Nat (Ghost)	A spirit of a broken oath	Demand payment before the monsoon fails	It appears as a wet figure in torn robes. It never blinks.

Names of Ayokha

Inspired by the monsoon kingdoms: soft, flowing consonants, honorifics (Lady, Master). Surnames denote a river, a wharf, or a spirit.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Clan/Epithet	Monsoon-Name
Hiro	Suyin	River-watch	<i>the Uncut</i>
Tama	Mira	Silk-hand	<i>Ninth Knot</i>
Kaito	Yuki	Lamp-bearer	<i>Green Flame</i>
Riku	Hana	Oath-strand	<i>the Witness</i>
Sora	Nami	Mud-dyer	<i>the Unforgotten</i>

(Market/Temple/Bridge) A river market on stilts; a step-pyramid temple with monsoon carvings; a bridge that appears only once a century.

Spades — Places

2. **River Market (Stilts)** — A floating market where goods are passed from boat to boat. ‘[COMMERCE]’ ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The prices are written in water. They change with the tide.*
 3. **Step-Pyramid Temple** — A stone pyramid rising from the riverbank. Carvings of the first monsoon. ‘[RELIGION]’ ‘[WEATHER]’ *The carvings weep water during the rainy season. The water is holy.*
 4. **Bridge of Three Echoes** — A wooden bridge that appears only once a century. ‘[MYSTERY]’ ‘[THRESHOLD]’ *Those who cross it see three versions of themselves: past, present, and future.*
 5. **Silk Village (Mulberry Groves)** — A village where silk is spun and cords are woven. ‘[CRAFT]’ ‘[OATH]’ *The mulberry trees were planted by the first God-King. Their leaves are sacred.*
 6. **Astrologer’s Observatory** — A roofless tower with a bronze armillary sphere. ‘[MAGIC]’ ‘[SECRET]’ *The sphere has nine rings. The ninth ring is broken. The astrologer refuses to fix it.*
 7. **River Court (Floating)** — A barge that serves as a mobile courthouse. ‘[LAW]’ ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The barge is anchored at a different spot each day. The river is the judge.*
 8. **Spirit-Medium’s Hut** — A small shelter on the riverbank, surrounded by offering bowls. ‘[SPIRIT]’ ‘[MYSTIC]’ *The bowls are filled with rice, flowers, and small coins. The spirits take the offerings at night.*
 9. **Well of the Drowned Nat** — A stone well where a spirit was trapped. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[DEBT]’ *The well is covered by a stone slab. The slab has nine holes. The spirit breathes through them.*
 10. **God-King’s Palace (Floating)** — A wooden palace built on pontoons, anchored in the river. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[WEALTH]’ *The palace rises and falls with the flood. The God-King never touches dry land.*
- J **The Ninth Terrace** — A rice terrace that is flooded only once every nine years. ‘[FORBIDDEN]’ ‘[LEGEND]’ *The rice grown there is for the God-King alone. Eating it is treason.*
- Q **Monsoon Bell Tower** — A stone tower with a single brass bell. The bell is rung at the first rain. ‘[WEATHER]’ ‘[RITUAL]’ *The bell’s tone determines the harvest. A high tone means abundance. A low tone means famine.*
- K **The First Bridge (Myth)** — Where the first God-King crossed the river and claimed the throne. ‘[LEGEND]’ ‘[THRESHOLD]’ *The bridge is invisible. Only those who have witnessed nine true oaths can see it.*
- A **The Monsoon’s Eye** — A still pool in the astrologer’s observatory. It reflects the sky. ‘[OMEN]’ ‘[MAGIC]’ *The pool shows the future of the monsoon. The astrologer is the only one who can read it.*

(Merchant/Medium/Vigil) River merchant with a boat of secrets; spirit-medium with a bowl of water; Lethai-ar Vigil with a green lamp.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **River Merchant** — A woman with a brass earring and a hidden deck. She never sails without a bribe. ‘[COMMERCE]’ ‘[DECEPTION]’ *“The tariff is negotiable,” she says. “My*

silence is not."

3. **Spirit-Medium** — A woman with a bowl of water. She watches the ripples. '[SPIRIT]'
'[SOCIAL]' *"The nat says the river is angry," she says. "Someone broke a promise."*
4. **Vigil Lady Suyin** — Grey-robed, a green lamp at her hip. She never blinks when witnessing an oath. '[LAW]' '[OATH]' *"The cord will tighten," she says. "I do not need to watch. The river watches for me."*
5. **God-King's Astrologer** — A pale man in silk robes, surrounded by candles. '[MAGIC]'
'[SECRET]' *"The monsoon will be late," he says. "The rice will fail unless..." He trails off.*
6. **Rice Farmer** — A woman with mud-stained feet and a straw hat. She leaves offerings at the terrace edge. '[SURVIVAL]' '[SPIRIT]' *"The spirits are hungry," she says. "Feed them, or they feed on you."*
7. **Silk Weaver** — A man with thread between his fingers. He weaves witness cords for the Lethai-ar. '[CRAFT]' '[OATH]' *"The cord must be perfect," he says. "A single flaw can break an oath."*
8. **Monsoon Bell Ringer** — A young woman who rings the bell at the first rain. She has never been late. '[RITUAL]' '[WEATHER]' *"The rain waits for me," she says. "I do not wait for the rain."*
9. **Drowned Nat's Ghost** — A wet figure in torn robes, standing by the well. '[DEATH]'
'[DEBT]' *It asks: "Who sealed me here?" The answer is a name. The name is the God-King's.*
10. **God-King (Offstage)** — Never seen, rarely heard. His decrees are delivered by astrologer. '[AUTHORITY]' '[MYSTERY]' *Rumour says he is a spirit. Rumour says he is a child. Rumour says he is the river itself.*
- J **The First God-King's Ghost** — A crowned skeleton in the palace's lower deck. '[DEATH]'
'[LEGEND]' *He asks: "Is the monsoon still on time?" If you say no, he weeps.*
- Q **Monsoon Spirit (Kami)** — A whirlwind with eyes, seen over the river during storms. '[SPIRIT]' '[WEATHER]' *It asks: "Who rang the bell?" The answer must be the ringer's name.*
- K **The Ninth Terrace's Keeper** — An old woman who tends the forbidden rice. '[FORBIDDEN]'
'[WISDOM]' *She has never eaten the rice. She has never been tempted.*
- A **Kuva's Shadow (Hollow)** — A vast darkness that covers the river at midnight. '[DEATH]'
'[HORROR]' *It asks: "Who poured the ninth cup?" The answer is a name. The name is the speaker's.*

(Flood/Rumor/Offense) The river floods — a bridge is swept away; a rival merchant spreads rumours of cursed silk; the nat of the well is offended — no one may draw water.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **River Floods** — The monsoon rises. The bridge is gone. The wharf is isolated. '[WEATHER]'
'[DISASTER]' *The flood is not natural. A river-spirit is angry. An oath was broken upstream.*
3. **Rumour of Cursed Silk** — A merchant claims that a bale of silk is cursed. Trade stops. '[SOCIAL]' '[DECEPTION]' *The curse is a lie. The merchant wants to drive down prices.*
4. **Well-Spirit Offended** — A traveller threw trash into the sacred well. The spirit refuses water. '[SPIRIT]' '[DEBT]' *The spirit demands an apology. The apology must be an oath.*

The oath must be witnessed.

5. **Monsoon Late** — The astrologer’s prediction fails. The rains do not come. ‘[WEATHER]’ ‘[CRISIS]’ *The astrologer is a fraud. Or the spirits are angry. Either way, the rice is dying.*
 6. **Witness Cord Cut (False)** — Someone cuts a witness cord that was tied in good faith. ‘[OATH]’ ‘[BETRAYAL]’ *The cutter is the Vigil’s own apprentice. She thought the oath was false. It was true.*
 7. **Silk Village Poisoned** — Someone poisons the mulberry trees. The silkworms die. ‘[CRIME]’ ‘[ECONOMY]’ *The poisoner is a rival merchant. He wants to monopolise the silk trade.*
 8. **River-Spirit Demands a Story** — The nat appears at the ford. It asks for a broken oath. ‘[SPIRIT]’ ‘[DEBT]’ *It will not leave until someone confesses. The confession must be true.*
 9. **God-King’s False Oath** — The king swears a vow he does not intend to keep. The Vigil knows. ‘[LAW]’ ‘[POLITICS]’ *If she exposes him, the king will exile the Lethai-ar. If she stays silent, the cord tightens.*
 10. **Astrologer’s Betrayal** — The astrologer sells the monsoon schedule to a foreign power. ‘[TREASON]’ ‘[WAR]’ *The foreign power is Ashaan. They want to time an invasion with the floods.*
- J **The Ninth Cup Poured (By Mistake)** — A stranger pours the ninth cup at a river market. The Hollow comes. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[TABOO]’ *The Hollow asks: “Who poured this cup?” The stranger points at the party.*
- Q **First Bridge Appears** — The mythic bridge manifests. Crossing it grants a new name. ‘[THRESHOLD]’ ‘[DEBT]’ *The new name is a debt. The debt is to the first God-King. He will collect.*
- K **Monsoon Bell Cracked** — The bell is struck too hard. It cracks. The tone is wrong. ‘[SABOTAGE]’ ‘[OMEN]’ *The bell-ringer is a spy. She cracked it on purpose. The monsoon will fail.*
- A **The Monsoon Fails** — The rains do not come for nine weeks. The river dries. The Hollow walks. ‘[APOCALYPSE]’ ‘[DEATH]’ *The Hollow asks: “Who failed to ring the bell?” The answer is a name.*

(Schedule/Voucher/Cord) Monsoon schedule (predicts safe sailing days); silk voucher (trade goods at 10% profit); Lethai-ar witness cord (enforce any oath).

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Monsoon Schedule (Astrologer’s Copy)** — A scroll of safe sailing days for the next season. ‘[TRAVEL]’ ‘[WEATHER]’ *The schedule is written on dried palm leaf. The leaf will crumble after use.*
3. **Silk Voucher (Merchant’s Seal)** — A stamped document. Trade goods at 10% profit in any Ayokha port. ‘[COMMERCE]’ ‘[WEALTH]’ *The seal is a fish. The fish glows when the voucher is genuine.*
4. **Lethai-ar Witness Cord** — A silk cord dyed with river mud. Enforce any oath. ‘[OATH]’ ‘[MAGIC]’ *The cord tightens when the oath is broken. It will not stop until blood is drawn.*
5. **God-King’s Blessing (Scroll)** — A royal decree. One national favour in Ayokha. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The scroll is sealed with river clay. The clay is from the palace’s foundation.*

6. **River Merchant's Hidden Deck Key** — A brass key. Access any smuggler's hold on the river. '[STEALTH]' '[CRIME]' *The key is warm. It glows when a customs boat is near.*
7. **Spirit-Medium's Bowl** — A clay bowl. Fill it with water to speak with any river-spirit once. '[SPIRIT]' '[KNOWLEDGE]' *The spirit will answer one question. The answer will be a ripple.*
8. **Vigil's Lamp (Green Flame)** — A small oil lamp. Gain +1 die to social rolls in any Lethai-ar court. '[SOCIAL]' '[TRUTH]' *The flame flickers when someone lies. It also flickers when you lie.*
9. **Silk Weaver's Needle** — A needle carved from a mulberry branch. Tie a witness cord without cutting the silk. '[CRAFT]' '[OATH]' *The needle can also cut a cord without making a sound. Use once.*
10. **Monsoon Bell Tone (Recording)** — A clay cylinder that captured the bell's ring. Play it to summon a monsoon spirit. '[MAGIC]' '[WEATHER]' *The spirit will come. It will demand an offering. The offering must be a promise.*
- J **First Bridge Plank** — A piece of the mythic bridge. Cross any river as if on solid ground once. '[TRAVEL]' '[LEGEND]' *The plank crumbles after use. The first God-King will remember.*
- Q **Ninth Terrace Rice (Grain)** — A single grain from the forbidden terrace. Eat it to gain a vision of the future. '[MAGIC]' '[OMEN]' *The vision is always a flood. The flood is always coming.*
- K **Astrologer's Sphere Ring (Broken)** — The ninth ring from the armillary sphere. Touch it to predict the monsoon's arrival. '[WEATHER]' '[MAGIC]' *The ring is cold. It warms when the rains are nine days away.*
- A **The Monsoon's Eye (Water)** — A vial of water from the astrologer's pool. Drink it to see the future of the harvest. '[VISION]' '[DEBT]' *The water tastes of salt. The vision is always a famine. The famine is not inevitable.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (schedules, vouchers, cords) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **monsoon-omens**—water that flows upstream, a lamp that burns green without oil, a cord that ties itself.

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **Debt to the Rain (Shared Clock, size 8):** Every broken promise to a river-spirit, every unpaid offering, every late monsoon payment ticks the clock. The party inherits the God-King's debt at the start of any adventure set in Ayokha – they begin with 2 ticks already accrued (the old debt). When the clock reaches 4: the astrologer's predictions become unreliable (roll twice for weather, take worse). When the clock reaches 8: a **Debt-Walker** rises from the river and demands payment in memories, names, or a season of servitude. Resetting the clock requires a **Monsoon Rite** (downtime, costs 1 XP or a story worth a season's wages) or a sacrifice to the Drowned Nat (a memory or a magical item).
- **Monsoon Clock [6]:** Tracks the approach of the rainy season. When it fills, the monsoon

arrives — all river travel becomes Desperate for 2 legs. The clock ticks each day during the dry season. The astrologer can predict the exact day; a successful Wits + Lore test (DV 4) reveals the remaining ticks. The party can slow the clock by performing **Rain Offerings** (betel leaves, silk scraps, or stories) — each offering ticks the clock back by 1, but adds 1 tick to **Debt to the Rain**.

- **River Court Justice:** Disputes on the river are settled by a floating court. The judge is a Lethai-ar Vigil. The verdict is written on a clay tablet and thrown into the water. If the tablet floats, the verdict is true. If it sinks, the verdict is false — and the judge is drowned. A character may attempt to influence the verdict by offering a bribe (a Diamond or a story) before the tablet is thrown. If the bribe is a story, the GM gains 1 SB; if a Diamond, the judge’s verdict tilts in your favour automatically (no test).
- **Betel Leaf Hospitality:** Offering a betel leaf is an oath of hospitality. Refusing is a grave insult. Accepting binds both parties to non-violence for the duration of the visit. Breaking this oath marks 1 Corruption and begins a **River’s Grudge** [4] clock. When the clock fills, a nat appears and demands an equal price (1 Harm, a memory, or a public apology).
- **Astrologer’s Ledger (Player Resource):** A character who earns the astrologer’s trust (or steals his notes) may carry a copy of his ledger. The ledger has 3 pages. Each page can be used to:
 - **Predict the Monsoon:** Once per journey, ask the GM if the weather will turn against you in the next leg. The GM answers truthfully (yes/no).
 - **Forge a Schedule:** Once per session, treat a failed navigation roll as a success, but add 1 tick to **Debt to the Rain** (the astrologer will notice the forgery eventually).
 - **Blackmail an Official:** Gain +1 Position on social rolls against any Ayokha official who relies on the monsoon schedule (harbor masters, customs officers, grain factors). Using this burns the page.

Refilling the ledger requires a downtime action and a bribe to the astrologer (1 Boon or a story worth a season’s gossip).

- **The Ninth Terrace (Forbidden Zone, Mechanic):** The terrace is flooded only once every nine years. The rice grown there is for the God-King alone — eating it is treason. But the rice is also the *only* thing that can cure the monsoon blight (a crop disease that ticks the Monsoon Clock by 2 each day). Entering the Ninth Terrace requires a **Water-Key** (a coral token, acquired from the astrologer or a nat). The terrace is guarded by **Hungry Ghosts** — the spirits of farmers who starved when the monsoon failed. They attack anyone whose **Debt to the Rain** clock is 4 or higher. Harvesting the rice takes 3 actions. Each action triggers a ghost attack (Resolve test DV 4 or take 1 Fatigue). Success yields a **Ninth Terrace Rice** grain (see Diamonds).
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
 - **The Rain That Waits** — Ikasha. *She Who Sleeps beneath the flood; her dream is the monsoon’s hesitation.*
 - **The Unbroken Cord** — Inaea. *The river’s memory woven into silk; every oath is a knot.*
 - **The Drowned King** — Khemesh. *Pressure from the deep; the ninth wave is his breath.*
 - **The Green Lamp** — The Witness. *The Vigil’s flame; it flickers when a lie enters the ledger.*

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Kalrantha Fragment (Malachai, the Chained Angel):** A silver coin that never spends was found floating in the Monsoon's Eye. The astrologer keeps it in a jar of brine. It whispers to him at night — promises of perfect predictions, of rains that never fail. The coin's warmth spreads through the palace like a fever.
- **The Drowned Courier (The Grey Wanderer's Grimoire):** A Breath-less agent drowned in the river last monsoon, but her ghost still carries messages. She appears at midnight on the Bridge of Three Echoes, offering to deliver secrets to the dead. The price is a memory of living sunlight.
- **The Root That Drinks (The Bitter Root):** A Daughter of the Cord has taken refuge in the well of the Drowned Nat. She claims the spirit is not a nat but a Hollowed — one of the High Mother's own, lost when a witness cord was cut. She asks the party to help her re-tie the cord before the monsoon fails.
- **The Ninth Terrace's Debt (Ukwe – Sekogo):** The forbidden rice of the Ninth Terrace is said to be grown from seeds stolen from the Ukwe's roots. The Green Council demands its return, but the God-King refuses. A Sekogo druid offers the party a way to steal the rice without angering the spirits — if they also bring back a vial of water from the Monsoon's Eye.

Ayokha Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the River:** Crumble a crust into the current. Ignore the first *River Floods* penalty. '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Knot the Cord:** Tie a single knot in a witness cord before using it. Cancel *Witness Cord Cut* or take -1 die on your next oath. '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Name to the Well:** Whisper a dead Vigil's name into the well. Gain +1 Effect when witnessing an oath, but mark *Obligation* to the Monsoon Spirit. '[SUPERSTITION]'

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **river merchants or spirit-mediums**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **bell-ringer or customs boats**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **river-spirits or the Vigil**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favourable tide**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Local Vigil or spirit-medium** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **flood or fog**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **rival merchant's boat or a river-spirit** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **spirit-mediums, customs boats, or river-spirits** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes — **monsoon fails / well runs dry / cord is cut**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **God-King’s Astrologer, Vigil Lady Suyin, or the Drowned Nat** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically — **flood sweeps the market / bell tower cracks / ninth terrace floods**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice — **omen appears / blessing lost / curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Ayokha (Monsoon Law):** Rain falls upward, the river changes course, a cord ties itself.
- **Ayokha (Spirit Law):** A nat laughs from the well, an offering steams, the Vigil’s lamp burns blue.
- **Ayokha (Rice & Silk):** A terrace floods for no reason, a silk bale weeps water, the bell rings twice.

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Wits + Navigation):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Monsoon Swell*.
- **Cut the Cord (Presence + Lore):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a witness cord is in your possession, +1 die.
- **Weather the Flood (Resolve + Survival):** On a hit in *River Floods*, you pick who keeps their boat; on a miss, the GM does.

Boss Seeds (Monsoon & Debt)

- **The Rain-Eater (Nine Dried Fields)** — *Phases:* Wells Sinking → Orchestrated Drought → Terrace Coup. *Cracks:* find a hidden spring, expose a false monsoon schedule, survive a night on the Ninth Terrace.
- **The Drowned Vigil (Cord of the River)** — *Phases:* Broken Oaths → Procession of Empty Barges → Flood-Baptism of a Merchant. *Cracks:* relic witness cord, survivor testimony, the bell ringer refusing to strike.

Patronage & Power

In Ayokha, power flows through the monsoon, the river, and the weight of a witnessed oath. The God-King rules from his floating palace, but the astrologer sets the calendar, the Lethai-ar hold the ledgers, and the spirit-mediums speak for the nats. No one rules alone — and everyone owes a debt to the rain.

For the GM: Use the **Monsoon Clock** as a visible campaign timer — it ticks down to famine or flood. Let **River Court Justice** be a high-stakes social encounter where a single lie can drown a judge. Enforce **Betel Leaf Hospitality** as a binding ritual — breaking it invites the Hollow and advances the **River's Grudge** clock. Offer Diamonds as monsoon schedules, silk vouchers, and witness cords — each a tool to survive the next storm or the next audit. Track **Debt to the Rain** as the region's central pressure; the party's actions can reduce it (by performing rites or paying sacrifices) or increase it (by breaking oaths or ignoring nats). The God-King's astrologer is a potential ally, but his ledgers are for sale to the highest bidder.

Part VIII

The Spaces Between

Chapter 36

Ubral

The Stone Between Spears.

The stone here remembers every oath sworn upon it and every blood spilled in its shadow. To lead is to understand that the land itself is the true sovereign, and we are merely its stewards.

I am a Hearth-Aunt. Hospitality's a sacred thing in these hills—break bread at my table and you're family till the sun sets twice. But cross that trust and the very stones will remember your name.

Ubral is a land of upland mists, stone cairns, and clan oaths held tighter than iron. Caught between the Aelerian mountains and the lowland courts of Viterra, its hills are scarred by old raids and crowned by watch-fires that speak faster than any rider. Here, law is written not in charters but in cattle, wergild, and songs; a guest's word can buy more than a sword, but one broken vow can spark a feud lasting generations. But here's the secret the Lady of Tor doesn't want you to know: the cairns are not just markers. They are witnesses. Every stone in every cairn has a name. If you touch the right stone, you can hear the dead voting on the disputes of the living. The dead have long memories. They vote with the wind.

Viterra has tried to conquer Ubral a dozen times; each attempt ended with supply lines cut by reivers, passes sealed by Aeler outcast engineers, and lowland knights lost in mist. The Utaran Imperium itself broke its leg on these hills and limped away. Now the clans watch the lowlands with patient eyes, and the exiled Aeler of Khaz-Vurim weigh every traveler's honesty on iron scales. A guest here is kin—until they prove otherwise. And kin here will die for you—or kill you over a stolen cow.

Never refuse a cup from a hearth-aunt. Hospitality is a contract sealed in

salt and bread. Refusal is an insult that blood must answer.

— *Hearth-Aunt Brigid, who has never drawn a blade and has never needed to*

The Almanac of Ordinary Days

What do people eat for breakfast? Oatcakes and skyr—the oats are grown in highland clearings, the skyr is cultured in stone crocks buried in the peat. The peat is ancient. The peat remembers the old kings. The old kings are buried beneath it.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To count cattle. Ubral children are taught the eight breeds of the hills: Black, Red, White, Brindled, Dun, Grey, Spotted, and the ninth—the breed that has no colour because it belongs to the cairn-folk. The cairn-folk are the dead. The dead do not pay taxes.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their guest-token. Every Ubral traveller carries a token—a stone, a bone, a braid of hair—given by their last host. A stranger whose token is warm has been recently welcomed. A stranger whose token is cold has been travelling long. A stranger with no token is a spy. Spies are given a token—a rope. The rope is for their neck.

What is the most common crime? Cattle raiding—but raiding is not a crime, it is a sport. The cattle are the wealth. The wealth is the clan's. A stolen cow is a stolen child. The child must be returned. The return is a negotiation. The negotiation is a feud. The feud is a song.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Lady of Tor is not the ruler. The cairns rule. The cairns vote at each full moon. Their votes are carried by the wind. The wind speaks to the hearth-aunts. The hearth-aunts speak to the clan. The clan obeys. The Lady is the voice. The cairns are the vote.

Where do people go when they die? To the cairns. The dead are not buried. Their bones are added to the cairns. The cairns grow taller each year. The tallest cairn is the oldest. The oldest cairn has no name. The oldest cairn remembers the first clan.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You offer a wergild—a payment in cattle, calculated by the wronged party's estimate of their loss. The cattle are driven to the cairn. The cairn is the court. If the cattle graze peacefully, you are forgiven. If they scatter, you are not. If they refuse to enter the cairn's shadow, your debt is blood.

What is the most important festival? The Gathering of the Clans (autumn). The clans meet at the Great Cairn. The cattle are counted. The songs are sung. The feuds are settled. The dead are named. The wind carries the names to the hills. The hills remember.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Great Cairn is not a cairn. It is a prison—the tomb of a Viterran king who tried to conquer Ubral and failed. He was buried alive, with his crown and his sword. His ghost votes with the cairns. He votes for war. The cairns have not yet agreed.

36.1 Ubral — “The Stone Between Spears”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *The lowlands write their laws in ink. We carve ours in stone. The ink fades.*

Lady of Tor (Elite): “The stone here remembers every oath sworn upon it and every blood spilled in its shadow. To lead is to understand that the land itself is the true sovereign, and we are merely its stewards. The lowland kings write their claims on parchment. We write ours in cairns.”

Hearth-Aunt (Commoner): “Hospitality’s a sacred thing in these hills – break bread at my table and you’re family till the sun sets twice. But cross that trust and the very stones will remember your name. The Viterran tax men learned that. Their bones are under the sheepwalk now.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Ubral is a land of knife-edged ridges, mist-veiled glens, and stone cairns that mark the bones of old kings. Caught between the Aelerian mountains to the north and the lowland courts of Viterra to the south, its hills are scarred by centuries of raiding and reprisal. The clans speak a tongue thick with swallowed consonants and older grudges. They measure wealth in cattle, honour in wergild, and time in the generations since a Viterran banner last burned in the high passes. Exiled Aeler — dwarves who could not abide the Deep Vaults’ suffocating tradition — have found refuge here, sharing their cunning with forge and toll-road, and their outcast bitterness with any clan willing to listen. The lowland lords of Viterra claim suzerainty over Ubral; the clans call those claims “ink on wet stone.” Every pass holds a watch-fire, every ford a memory of a battle, every hearth a knife waiting for a guest who stays too long.

What you notice first: The smell of peat smoke and wet granite. The constant lowing of cattle on distant hills. The way every threshold has a knife hidden nearby—for guests, not against them.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never refuse a cup from a hearth-aunt. Hospitality is a contract sealed in salt and bread. Refusal is an insult that blood must answer.

Regional Mood: Cairn, Tor, and Oath

Here, the past is never past. Every cairn holds a voice, every burn scar on a hillside remembers a raid. Viterra has tried to conquer Ubral a dozen times; each attempt ended with supply lines cut by reivers, passes sealed by Aeler outcast engineers, and lowland knights lost in mist. The Utaran Imperium itself broke its leg on these hills and limped away. Now the clans watch the lowlands with patient eyes, and the exiled Aeler of Khaz-Vurim weigh every traveler’s honesty on iron scales. A guest here is kin—until they prove otherwise. And kin here will die for you—or kill you over a stolen cow. The Lady of Tor rules by consent of the Council of Cairns, and the Council speaks for the dead as much as the living. Every nine years, a moot is called at Grey Tor to settle the great feud — a dispute between the two oldest clans that no one can remember the origin of, but everyone remembers the blood.

Starting Location: A Warden’s Cairn at the fog line. Spears planted like grave markers, their shafts wrapped in faded clan ribbons. Hoofbeats echo in the valley below. The Hearth-Aunt offers a cup of small beer and a piece of oatcake. “The Wolf Road wakes,” she says. “Viterran tax men are

asking which passes you used. The clans are counting your steps. Speak true, or the cairn will add your name to its tally. And mind the Aeler outcast in the smithy — he’s been here forty years and still forgets to duck under doorframes.”

The Clans of Ubral (A Highland Primer)

The Great Houses of the Stone			
Clan	Homeland	Feuds (Ancient)	Relationship with Viterra
Mac Tern	Grey Tor, upper Glen Tern	O’Creagh (blood feud)	Defiant; has never paid a lowland tax
O’Creagh	Black Broom Bog, eastern fells	Mac Tern, Mac Gowan	Wary; accepts bribes but no garrisons
Mac Gowan	Khaz-Vurim Steps, western passes	O’Creagh	Pragmatic; trades iron for lowland silver
O’Ruarc	Bride’s Causey, southern marches	None active	Collaborator; factor in Valora is a cousin
Mac Taggart	Three-Fires Ridge, northern heights	Mac Tern (old)	Neutral; sells beacon service to both sides
O’Cahan	Pass of Ashes, far west	None	Isolationist; speaks to lowlanders only through Aeler outcasts

The Mac Tern – O’Creagh feud has outlasted every lowland king. Each has a cairn for every generation lost. No wergild has ever settled it; no marriage has ever bridged it. The Lady of Tor keeps the peace by reminding both that a Viterran judge would hang them all.

Faction Clocks (Campaign Engines)

- **The Viterran Yoke [6]** – Lowland crown’s creeping control. Advances when a chief accepts a Viterran title, the party enforces lowland law, or a garrison is established. Retreats when a tax collector is sent home empty (or headless) or a claim is exposed as fraud. On full: a Queen’s Justiciar arrives with a circuit court; lowland law becomes default.
- **Tor’s Hold [6]** – Lady Morwen’s personal authority. Advances when she wins a moot, brokers peace, or gains an ally. Retreats when she loses a feud or a client clan defects. On 0: she is deposed; civil war follows.
- **Ancestral Grudge [8]** – The dead’s patience. Advances when oaths are broken, wergild unpaid, or cairns defiled. On full: a cairn-wight (see *Witnessed Prey*) rises and demands blood.
- **The Forge Ledger [6]** – Khaz-Vurim’s economic leverage. Advances when they secure toll contracts, sell iron, or gain a clan’s debt. On full: they can close a pass to enforce terms.
- **The Deep Road [8]** – Aeler outcasts’ secret ambition. Advances as they survey, bribe, or blast. On full: construction begins on a dwarf under-way that would destroy several clan cairns.
- **Mac Tern’s Revenge [6]** – Advances when Mac Tern suffers an insult or loses cattle. On full: they launch a devastating raid.
- **O’Creagh’s Patience [6]** – Retreats when O’Creagh is wronged. When it hits 0, they strike without warning.

Wergild Price Table (Quick Reference)

Blood Prices (in cattle, unless noted)

Insult (spoken)	1 cow
Stolen sheep	3 cows
Broken betrothal	5 cows + a horse
Wounding	7–15 cows (by severity)
Killing a clansman	21 cows + a public apology
Killing a chief	42 cows + a hostage

The Hollow’s Cairn (Legendary Site)

Hidden in the high mist, a ninth stone circle with no clan markings. The dead do not vote here; they *listen*. Once per arc, a character may climb the cairn and ask one question of the Hollow. The answer is always a price.

Mechanics: Spirit + Resolve (DV 6). Success: the GM answers truthfully (one sentence). Failure: the character gains the Condition *Marked by the Hollow* (the GM may spend 2 SB to have a Debt-Walker appear).

Starting Hooks

- **The Wolf Road wakes:** Viterran tax men are asking which passes you used. The clans are counting your steps.
- **The Bride-Price Default:** A Mac Tern groom cannot pay the wergild for an O’Creagh bride. The bride has fled to the Pass of Ashes. Retrieve her – or pay her price yourself.
- **The Toll-Master’s Ledger:** Khaz-Vurim has doubled tolls on the Steps. A clan chief suspects they are skimming to fund the Deep Road. Infiltrate the counting-house and copy the ledger.
- **The Cairn that Weeps:** A shepherd reports that a cairn on Three-Fires Ridge is weeping water that tastes of salt. The dead are agitated. Find out why before the clan blames a rival.

Faction Turn Cheat Sheet

Between sessions, roll 1d6 for each major faction. Write one sentence of fallout and adjust the relevant clock.

Roll	Progress	Clock Change
1–2	Setback	–1 segment (min 0)
3–4	Stalled	No change
5–6	Advance	+1 segment

Example: Mac Tern raided O’Creagh’s cattle (**Mac Tern’s Revenge** +1). The Viterran factor raised tariffs (**The Viterran Yoke** +1). Khaz-Vurim surveyed a new pass (**The Deep Road** +1).

Prominent NPCs of Ubral

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Lady Morwen	Clan-chief of the Grey Tor	Keep the old oaths and resist Viterran encroachment	She lost a hand to a Viterran knight; her iron hook has a built-in bell.
Hearth-Aunt Brigid	Keeper of guest-right (commoner exemplar)	Protect her household and settle feuds before blood is spilled	She has never drawn a blade. She has never needed to.
Councillor Gethin	Elder of the Council of Cairns	Preserve the wergild system and the memory of the dead	He speaks once a year; his sentences take a full season to deliver.
Oath-Singer Liliás	Verse-weaver and feud mediator	Turn vengeance into cattle, not corpses	Her tongue is forked—she can praise and curse in the same breath.
Vent-Prior Orla	Aeler outcast leader of Khaz-Vurim	Build a new under-way through Ubral, linking mountains to lowlands	She carries a bell that rings once for each miner she left behind.
Sister Niamh	Healer of the Cairn-Keeper of the Grey Palm (Temple of Light)	Run a free hospice at Grey Tor without angering the old gods	She asks no payment, but she writes every patient's name on a slate that never fills.

Names of Ubral

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Gethin	Morwen	ap Cairn	<i>the Grey</i>
Bran	Brigid	ferch Tor	<i>Oath-Sworn</i>
Drystan	Liliás	mac Tern	<i>the Stone-Foot</i>
Eilian	Niamh	O'Ruarc	<i>Hollow-Tongue</i>
Padraig	Siorcha	Mac Gowan	<i>the Unbroken</i>

Tegid	Ailbhe	O’Creagh	Ash-Finger
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Spades — Places

2. **Sheepwalk Ledge** — Goat path with room for one honest lie at a time. ‘[THRESHOLD]’
The lie must be small—a false weight, a borrowed name. Tell it twice and the ledge crumbles. A Viterran spy learned that the hard way.
3. **Warden’s Cairn** — Windy tor; signal-fire basket and dry cache; eyes of the hills. ‘[WATCH]’
The cache holds a single arrow. Light it with the fire, and the message is war. The arrow is fletched with eagle feathers — a clan’s highest oath.
4. **Wergild Ford** — Flat stones, deep pools, table rock for counting silver. ‘[LAW]’ ‘[TRADE]’
The table rock is smooth as glass. Blood washes off; lies do not. The water remembers every price ever paid here.
5. **Droppers’ Bridge** — Stone span rigged to fall; pins already loosened. ‘[TRAP]’ *The pins are greased with mutton fat. The bridge knows who paid for the grease. Its fall has ended three feuds and started two.*
6. **Scree-Ladder** — Climbing to a notch; red rags mark safe steps through danger. ‘[TRAVEL]’
The rags are old clan banners. Step where they wave, not where they lie flat. One rag is white — that marks a traitor’s grave.
7. **Moot Hollow** — Ring of standing stones; voices carry and won’t quite stop. ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[OATH]’
The stones have ears. Speak a false oath here, and every cairn will know. The dead vote by how the mist moves.
8. **Reiver’s Gate** — Between boulders; cart-ruts vanish into heather’s memory. ‘[STEALTH]’
The gate has no lintel. Above it, ravens nest in a skull. The ravens are the clan’s spies.
9. **Khaz-Vurim Steps** — Dwarf-cut switchbacks with iron mile studs; toll and toil. ‘[TRAVEL]’ ‘[AUTHORITY]’
The studs are cold iron. Touch them, and the mountain knows your weight. Aeler outcasts maintain the toll — they accept stories as often as coin.
10. **Grey Tor Fort** — Earthen rampart, timber crown, smoky cook pits. ‘[COMMUNITY]’ *The cook pits have been burning for three hundred years. The ash is deep enough to bury a secret — and more than one Viterran scout.*
- J **Black Broom Bog** — Stepping-logs; wrong one drinks you into silence. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[FEAR]’
The logs are painted with warding runes. One is unpainted — that one is the quick way. The bog exhales names of the drowned.
- Q **Bride’s Causey** — Raised road to a valley kirk; ribbons hang like warnings. ‘[SOCIAL]’
The ribbons are from wedding gowns — cut short when the groom fell in a feud. The kirk is neutral ground, but the path is not.
- K **Three-Fires Ridge** — Watchposts that see Viterra and Vhasia both; news travels fast. ‘[WATCH]’
The fires are layered: birch for peace, pine for raid, oak for invasion. A fourth fire — yew — means the Hollow walks.
- A **Pass of Ashes** — When snow closes here, the upland becomes an island. ‘[WEATHER]’ ‘[DEATH]’
The ash is from old sacrifices. The pass remembers every offering. The last sacrifice was a Viterran herald. His voice is still in the wind.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Hearth-Aunt** — Holds guest-cup and house's temper; hospitality as power. *She has never drawn a blade. She has never needed to. Her hospitality has ended more feuds than swords.*
3. **Hill Guide** — Thorn-staff and ten quiet shortcuts; the land as a map. *He taps each stone before stepping. The stones talk to him. He learned the tongue from an Aeler outcast who went deaf and learned to listen with his feet.*
4. **Feud-Broker** — Knows the weight of a life in cattle and coin; peace as trade. *His ledger is a row of tally sticks. Each notch is a death—or a birth. He has notched both sides of the same feud for forty years.*
5. **Reiver Band** — Light on tack, heavy on nerve, laughing in the rain. *They wear no colors. Their horses answer to whistles, not names. They raid Viterran supply trains and leave heather sprigs as signatures.*
6. **Fire Warden** — Braziers speak faster than riders; warning as weapon. *She can light a signal with a single word. The word is a dead man's name. The dead man was a Viterran knight who burned her village.*
7. **Wergild Counter** — Keeps tallies, ends grudges, starts others; law as math. *His abacus beads are sheep knuckles. He clicks them in his sleep. His grandmother taught him; she learned from an Aeler vent-prior.*
8. **Dwarf Warden (Aeler Outcast)** — Khaz-Vurim road; toll first, friendship later. *Her hammer has a chip where she cracked a liar's skull. She never fixed it. She came to the surface for the sky — and stayed for the feuds.*
9. **Oath-Singer** — Verses bind hands and open gates; word as iron. *Her tongue is forked—she can praise and curse in the same breath. Her songs are older than the Viterran crown.*
10. **Lowland Factor** — Buying iron blooms, selling trouble; coin as catalyst. *He carries two ledgers. One is for the clans. One is for the tax man. The third ledger is in his head; it lists every bribe he has ever taken.*
- J **Bride-Carrier** — Peaceweaver walking bloodlines with a knife and a smile. *Her knife has a wooden blade. The threat is real. She has walked between warring clans nine times. The ninth was a Viterran lord who wanted a wife. He got a treaty instead.*
- Q **Lady of Tor** — Clan-chief in cloak and mail; her nod is winter or spring. *She lost a hand to a Viterran knight. Her iron hook has a built-in bell. The bell rings when she lies. It has never rung.*
- K **Council of Cairns** — Greybeards and granite wills; they do not hurry. *They have sentenced men to exile. The sentences take a year to deliver. The exile always knows before they speak.*
- A **Stone-Speaker** — Aeler outcast envoy whose word moves roads and rates. *He carries a tuning fork. Strike it, and the mountain answers. He has not seen his homeland in sixty years. He calls the mist his ceiling now.*

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Upland Mist** — Hear horns but not edges; navigation by sound and instinct. '[WEATHER]' '[STEALTH]' *The horns are calling a muster. Which clan? You will know when they arrive. The mist smells of wet wool and old iron.*
3. **Feud Rekindled** — Cousin spits on guest-law; knives wake from sleep. '[SOCIAL]' '[COMBAT]' *The spit lands at your feet. The insult is now yours to answer. The cousin's father was*

killed in a cattle raid thirty years ago. He has been waiting.

4. **Bridge Dropped** — Pursuers fall... and the route with them; passage becomes peril. ‘[TRAP]’ ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The bridge was cut from the far side. Someone expected you. The cut ropes smell of dwarf-made pitch — a signature of the Aeler outcasts.*
5. **Black-Rent Demand** — “Privateering on land”; pay or be “escorted.” ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[DEBT]’ *The escort has a noose. Choose your words carefully. The man collecting is a Viterran factor with a royal warrant. The warrant is a forgery. No one will admit it.*
6. **Wergild Breach** — Silver short by a head; tempers long by a spear’s length. ‘[LAW]’ ‘[DEBT]’ *The bereaved clan has a new widow. She is sharpening a blade. The missing silver was paid in lowland coin — debased, clipped, and worthless. The insult is not the shortfall; it is the contempt.*
7. **Snow-Squall** — Seals the notch; tents turn to coffins if you dally. ‘[WEATHER]’ ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The snow is tinged grey—ash from the Pass. Someone burned an offering. The offering was a Viterran tax ledger. The gods accepted.*
8. **Dwarf Toll Hike** — At the Steps; papers right, purses wrong; law costs coin. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[DEBT]’ *The warden quotes a rate from a book that wasn’t there yesterday. The book was written by an Aeler outcast who lost his sense of humour but not his arithmetic.*
9. **Cattle Scatter** — Bells ringing downslope; the cover story runs with the herd. ‘[STEALTH]’ ‘[DISASTER]’ *The bells are yours. The herd is not. The real owner is a clan chief with a long memory and three sons with sharp swords.*
10. **False Alarm** — Watch-fire beacons ridge to ridge; levies seize the road. ‘[WATCH]’ ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The fire was lit by a child. Or a spy. The levy doesn’t care. The spy is a Viterran agent. The child is his nephew.*
- J **Bride-Theft** — A wedding becomes a war-party; you are caught between both. ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[COMBAT]’ *The bride’s veil is on the ground. The groom’s own kin drew first blood. The bride was promised to a neighbouring clan. She chose her own groom. Now three clans want her head — and her hand.*
- Q **Royal Incursion** — Neighbor’s “lawful” arrests in the uplands; flags and chains. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[DEBT]’ *The flags are Viterran. The chains are new. The prisoners are children. The crime is not paying a tax that was never law. The clans are calling the muster.*
- K **Clan Muster** — Horns call men from steadings to spears; all traffic stops. ‘[WATCH]’ ‘[COMBAT]’ *The muster stone is black with old blood. The new blood will be red. The last muster was forty years ago, to drive out a Viterran garrison. The garrison’s bones are under the sheepwalk.*
- A **Hill-Fall** — Rain liquefies a slope; trail, proof, and bodies slide together. ‘[WEATHER]’ ‘[DEATH]’ *The mud is warm. Something underneath is still breathing. The slide exposed a mass grave — clan warriors who fell in a forgotten feud. Their ghosts are counting the wergild still owed.*

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Guest-Token** — One hearth owes food, bed, and steel at dawn. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The token is a knucklebone from a feast. The host’s name is carved on it. Break it, and the obligation ends. The host will not thank you.*
3. **Guide’s Braid** — Lawful passage on named sheepwalks (once). ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The braid is woven from horsehair and a promise. Unravel it to return. The promise was made to a hill*

guide who died last winter. His ghost still checks the knots.

4. **Ford Remission** — Cross Wergild Ford free for a season; water as ally. '[TRAVEL]' '[DEBT]' *The remission is a white stone. Skip it across the ford to pay. The stone was taken from a Viterran courthouse. The law has not found it yet.*
 5. **Feud-Charter** — Two clans sheath blades until the next harvest. '[SOCIAL]' '[OATH]' *The charter is a broken spear. Each clan keeps a half. The spear was used to kill a Viterran tax collector. His family still wants it back.*
 6. **Bloom Allotment** — Claim on a week's iron from a hill bloomery. '[TRADE]' *The bloomery is a woman's name. She decides how much you get. She is an Aeler outcast's granddaughter. Her iron is harder than any lowlander's steel.*
 7. **Watch-Code** — Today's beacon order from Three-Fires Ridge. '[WATCH]' '[TRAVEL]' *The code is a sequence of smoke puffs. Read it, and the hills will watch for you. The code changes weekly. The fire wardens burn the old codes — the smoke carries the memory.*
 8. **Pass-Ring** — Dwarf road priority for one train of carts. '[TRAVEL]' '[AUTHORITY]' *The ring is iron. Wear it on your off hand. The Aeler outcasts who made it stamped their names inside. One name is scratched out — the smith was killed in a feud. The ring still works.*
 9. **Bride-Escrow** — Hold the purse; both sides must humor you. '[SOCIAL]' '[DEBT]' *The purse is a leather bag. The coins inside are from a dead man's hoard. The dead man was a Viterran lord who tried to tax the clans. His ghost asks for his money back.*
 10. **Shelter Writ** — Grey Tor opens its gates during storm or pursuit. '[SOCIAL]' *The writ is a raven feather. Burn it to claim shelter. The raven was a clan spy. His memory still watches the gates.*
- J **Oath-Bracelet** — One binding vow ends cleanly, witnessed. '[OATH]' '[MAGIC]' *The bracelet is silver. The clasp is a wolf's head. Bite it to break the oath. The wolf's head was a seal of a Viterran king. The oath was sworn under duress. The bracelet remembers.*
- Q **Council Audience** — The Cairns hear you alone; precedent sticks like stone. '[SOCIAL]' '[LAW]' *The audience is held at midnight. The stones glow when they agree. The last audience exiled a clan chief. He is still walking the passes, looking for a cairn that will forgive him.*
- K **Road Commission** — Collect tolls on a stretch of pass (for now). '[AUTHORITY]' '[TRADE]' *The commission is a wooden staff. Plant it at the toll gate. The staff was carved from a gallows tree. The last toll-keeper was hanged. The staff still creaks.*
- A **Stone-Clause** — Temporary exception to dwarf toll or law, sealed. '[AUTHORITY]' '[OATH]' *The clause is a single rune. Carve it on the toll post, and the mountain will honor it — once. The rune was taught to the clans by an Aeler outcast who wanted to see a Viterran knight pay double.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (oaths/rights/tokens) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **stone and spear** motifs—cairns that watch, voices that echo, and oaths that cut deeper than steel.

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **Guest-Law:** Breaking hospitality stains a name worse than breaking a sword. Guest-right tokens guarantee shelter, but abuse invites a blood feud. A Viterran lord who broke guest-law at Grey Tor had his name struck from the Council’s cairn. His own clan disowned him.
- **Wergild System:** Every injury has a price in cattle or coin. Wergild counters keep tallies that outlive the injured; debts pass to kin. The lowland courts have no equivalent; they imprison the poor and hang the desperate. The clans consider that barbaric.
- **Dwarf Toll Roads:** Khaz-Vurim gates charge for passage, but their roads are sure and swift. Pass-rings grant priority, but dwarf law is strict. The Aeler outcasts who run the tolls are exiles — they fled the Deep Vaults because they could not abide the counting. Now they count for the clans, and they are gentle with the weary.
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
 - **The Bone Keeper** — Varnek Karn. *The accountant of ancestral wergild; the witness to every blood price.*
 - **The Iron Crown** — Mykkiel. *The law of the lowlands, cold and distant; the clans honour it by breaking it.*
 - **The Grey Mare** — The Traveler. *The rider who never tires; the path that leads home through the mist.*
 - **The Forge Father (Aeler outcast cult)** — The Sealed Gate. *The fire that shapes iron; the exile who builds a new hearth.*

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Bitter Root:** Daughters of the Cord run a hospice near the Pass of Ashes, tending to the wounded of both sides of the Great Feud. A renegade Sister has hidden a Hollowed in a cairn, trying to discharge a blood-debt by feeding the Hollow memories of Viterran tax collectors. The clans do not know whether to thank her or burn her.
- **Malachai, the Chained Angel:** A silver coin that never spends appears in the palm of every third corpse pulled from a hill-fall. Take it, and the dead will give you their last breath — but the coin will taste of peat smoke and regret.
- **The Grey Wanderer’s Grimoire:** Ubral psions are called “Stone-Listeners.” They press their foreheads to cairns and hear the names of everyone who has touched that stone. The Lady of Tor employs three; they have not spoken aloud in a decade.
- **The Threshold Compendium:** The Pass of Ashes is a Class II Anchor — the spirits of Viterran knights who froze to death in a blizzard still march there, looking for a way home. Saikou Ira left a silver mirror at the summit. The mirror shows the knights their own corpses. They have not advanced since.
- **The Ninth:** In any Ubral scene, the ninth stone in a cairn is always warm. Touch it, and you will remember an oath you never swore. Those who touch the ninth stone three times are said to become a cairn themselves — silent, still, and waiting for the next hand. The Aeler outcasts say the ninth stone is a door to the Deep Vaults they fled. They do not touch it.

Ubral Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Cairn:** Crumble a crust at the base of a standing stone. Ignore the first *Upland Mist* penalty. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’

- **Knot the Guest-Cup:** Tie a single knot in the handle of a drinking cup. Cancel *Feud Rekindled* or take -1 die on your next hospitality roll (your choice). ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Name to the Ford:** Whisper a dead enemy’s name into the Wergild Ford. Gain +1 Effect when collecting from their kin this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Lady of Tor. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **clan guards or reiver scouts**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **watch-fires or hill guides**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or feud-kin**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favorable weather**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Hill guide or clan chief** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **mist or bridge collapse**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **reiver band or feud-kin** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **clan warriors, reivers, or dwarf wardens** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** **The situation fundamentally changes — feud declared/bridge falls/snow closes pass.**
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant **campaign/front clock** by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **Lady of Tor, Council of Cairns, or Stone-Speaker** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically — **mist thickens/bridge drops/hill falls**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice — **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Ubral (Stone & Oath):** Cairns shift position, voices echo from empty air, oaths bind mid-speech.

- **Ubral (Hill Law):** Paths reroute without warning, tolls increase mid-journey, guest-rights expire.
- **Ubral (Feud Culture):** Insults are overheard, weapons appear in sheaths, kin arrive unsummoned.

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Wits + Navigation):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Bog Mist*.
- **Cut the Bridge (Presence + Command):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a **Pass-Ring** is in your possession, +1 die.
- **Weather the Squall (Resolve + Survival):** On a hit in *Snow-Squall*, you pick who finds shelter; on a miss, the GM does.

Boss Seeds (Stone & Spear)

- **The Wolf-Road Captain (reiver-king on a piebald mare)** — *Phases:* Ride-Through → Torch the Fold → Laugh in Rain. *Cracks:* present a **Watch-Code** or **Guide’s Braid** to reduce his effect; strike a truce with a season’s cattle.
- **The Bride-Thief of Black Broom (mask of bog-rush)** — *Phases:* Switch the Bride → Bog Embrace → Nettle Oath. *Cracks:* play a **Bride-Charter** to freeze blades; a **Well-Blessing** nulls one bog move.
- **Stone Auditor of Khaz-Vurim (Aeler outcast toll-magistrate)** — *Phases:* Double the Toll → Weigh the Lie → Seal the Switchback. *Cracks:* present two of {**Pass-Ring**, **Stamped Load-List**, **Named Sponsor**} to downgrade his authority.
- **The Oath-Eater Wight (cairn-bound revenant)** — *Phases:* Take the Word → Cold of Cairn → Bind Witness. *Cracks:* **Oath-Bracelet** or a skald’s stanza spoken over bread and blood cancels one move; repay an ancestral wergild.
- **Grey-Tor Hedge-Witch (heather crown, ash staff)** — *Phases:* Weather-Turn → Hag-Stone Sight → Bind the Gate. *Cracks:* gift a **Bloom Allotment** or a winter’s salt; a **Council Audience** compels parley.

Legendary Sites & Trials

- **Sheepwalk Ledge Trial** — Speak one honest lie to pass. On success, set Position one step safer for the next border scene; on failure, start *Kin Arrive*.
- **Wergild Ford Weighing** — Cast silver on the table-rock. If paid in full, clear 1 *Feud-Smoke*; if short, *Wergild Breach* enters play.
- **Pass of Ashes Vigil** — Hold a fire through the night storm. Success grants **Shelter Writ**; a miss summons the *Oath-Eater Wight* at weak strength.

Extensions (Plug-in)

- **Oath Dial (Honor ↔ Cunning):** Track how the party navigates Ubral norms.
 - *Honor High:* +1 Position when invoking guest-right, keeping truce, or paying wergild promptly; first ambush/raid action each session starts one step worse.

- *Cunning High*: +1 Effect on raids, evasions, and border tricks; first formal parley or oath-bound request each session starts one step worse.
- Center the dial by restoring stolen cattle, hosting an enemy well, or submitting to a cairn ruling.
- **Feud Math (fast settlement)**: Lay three markers: **Blood, Beasts, Blame**.
 1. Make a single *Parley/Command/Study* roll per side. On a hit, move one marker to your side; great Effect moves two.
 2. Win any two to settle: *Blood* = oath/hostage, *Beasts* = wergild in cattle/coin, *Blame* = public apology/verse.
 3. Miss: mark *Feud-Smoke* [4]. At 4, the losing side names a lawful target (bridge, herd, guide).
- **Guest-Right Procedure**:
 - Present a **Guest-Token** (or bread and salt). Host must choose: *Shelter*, *Escort at Dawn*, or *Neutral Meal*.
 - Breaking it creates *Blood-Oath* [6] against the violator; any Ubral ally may spend 1 *◊totickittwice*.
 - Abiding it clears 1 tick from *Feud-Smoke* and grants +1d to the next social action in that steading.
- **Watchfire Net (ridge signals)**:
 - Two clocks: *Beat the Beacons* vs *Ridge Aflame* (size by highest rank in your seed).
 - Choose a lane each exchange: *Low Fold* (slow, stealth), *Sheepwalk* (tricky, quick), *Road* (fast, obvious).
 - Advantage: Low Fold ▷ Road (conceal), Road ▷ Sheepwalk (speed), Sheepwalk ▷ Low Fold (shortcuts).
 - *False Alarm (1 SB)*: light or douse a misleading brazier; shift one segment between the two clocks.
- **Reiver Ride (mounted chase)**:
 - Track *Remounts* (3): each push for speed trades 1 remount for +1d or +1 Effect. At 0, gain *Blown Mounts* condition.
 - *Hag-Stone Cut*: pass a known gap (Sheepwalk Ledge, Droppers' Bridge) to force pursuers to roll or fall behind.
- **Khaz-Vurim Protocol (Aeler Outcast Rules)**:
 - Present any two: **Pass-Ring, Stamped Load-List, Named Sponsor**. Two = safe passage; one = pay toll + scrutiny; none = delay and search.
 - *Stone-Clause* may override one dwarf law once; afterwards start *Ledger Notice* [3] with the wardens (prices rise, patience falls).
 - *Tally Truth*: you may substitute exact weights/measures for charm or coin to improve Position by one step with dwarves.
 - Aeler outcast smiths accept stories as payment for small repairs — the story must be about a betrayal. They are collecting evidence for a case they will never bring.
- **Bride-Peace Interlude**:
 - Play a **Bride-Charter** to suspend violence at a scene. Everyone sheaths—or earns *Song*

Shame [4]. When it fills, a skald memorializes the insult (ongoing -1d with that clan).

- **Start-of-Scene Omens (1d6):**

1. *Clear Ridge*: first signal test gains +1d.
2. *Lowing Herd*: +1d to tracking or herding; -1d to stealth near cattle.
3. *Wet Stone*: climbs start one step worse; mending gear is easier (free repair tick).
4. *Old Verse Remembered*: first oath/plea gains +1d if spoken in rhyme.
5. *Border Drums*: Viterra patrols near; papers safer, raiding harsher.
6. *Dwarf Toll Day*: prices firm; any $\diamond$ *tied to roads counts double value at the Steps*.

- **Plug-in SB Conversions (Ubral Flavor):**

- 1 SB → *Mud and Heather*: footing worsens; next physical action -1d or mark *Winded*.
- 2 SB → *Kin Arrive*: add a rival cousin/ally who changes the ask or splits the pot.
- 3+ SB → *Cairn Decrees*: a standing stone “speaks” (witnesses recall the law); swap one held $\diamond$ *for a less right until you make amends*.

- **Reputation Echoes:**

- *Guest-Faithful*: once/session downgrade a social backlash inside a steading; next time you refuse hospitality, mark *Feud-Smoke* +1.
- *Reiver-Favored*: +1 Effect to seize cattle/contraband on the move; city gates start one step worse Position.
- *Stone-Friend*: +1d with dwarf wardens on roads; any false measure triggers *Ledger Notice* +1.

Patronage & Power

In Ubral, power flows through clan bonds, guest-right, and the careful balance of honor and iron. Clan chiefs maintain authority through wergild, moots, and the respect of their people, while the Aeler outcasts of Khaz-Vurim wield influence through their control of mountain passes and forges. Law is personal and passed down through generations, with each oath and debt creating a web of obligation that can last centuries. The Viterran crown claims suzerainty; the clans call that claim “the ink of thieves.”

For the GM: Patronage in Ubral revolves around hospitality, protection, and the resolution of feuds. Rewards often take the form of tokens, charters, or safe passage that can be leveraged into greater influence. To emphasize this, use the faction clocks, let rival clans issue conflicting protections, and remember the Aeler outcasts — they are exiles, not tourists. They will help a clan for a story, but they will never forget a slight.

In Ubral, your word is your bond, and your bond determines whether you walk in peace or peril. The lowlands write their laws in ink; Ubral carves them in stone. The ink fades. The stone remembers.

Chapter 37

Silkstrand

City of Bridges & Dyewater.

In this city, every bridge is a contract and every current carries coin. The bargains struck in our shadows never quite fade from memory, and the waters remember every handshake.

I am a Bobbin-Runner. I can cross this city faster than any grown-up, and I know which planks creak and which merchants lie. The bridges remember every step, and the canals carry more secrets than fish.

Silkstrand is a city strung across canals and arches, a place where every bridge is a contract and every current carries rumor. The silk looms never sleep, the Exchange never closes, and the Archivolt's notaries seal fates with a drop of wax. Merchants rise and fall with the tide of the market, bravos carve reputations on the planks of Three-Queens Bridge, and the city's underworld runs on whispers and borrowed keys. But here's the secret the Matron doesn't want you to know: the canals are not just water. They are memory. Every bribe, every broken promise, every cargo that was never declared—the canals remember. And sometimes, at low tide, the water shows you the faces of the merchants who drowned rather than pay their debts.

The Matron rules from her palazzo stairs with velvet and iron, but the city itself belongs to silk, silver, and shadow. The Exchange Volatility Clock ticks with every major cargo seizure, every trade route cut, every merchant default. When it fills, a panic hits—the Exchange closes, and all outstanding contracts are voided unless witnessed by the Matron herself. The Matron has voided nine contracts this year. The ninth was her own.

Never name a rival while crossing a bridge at night. The water remembers, and the curse you send may come back wrapped around your own throat.

— *Bobbin-Runner, who ties a knot in her apron string for every secret she carries*

The Almanac of Ordinary Days

What do people eat for breakfast? Rice porridge with dried fish—the rice is from the Oshiiran barges, the fish is from the Zakov fleets. Both are smuggled. Both are delicious. Both are paid for in favours.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To count bridges. Silkstrand children are taught the eight bridges of the city: Merchant's, Weaver's, Dyer's, Cooper's, Pilot's, Beggar's, Saint's, and the ninth—the bridge that is only there at low tide. The ninth bridge leads to the Sunken Quarter. The Sunken Quarter is where debts go to drown.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their ink. Every Silkstrand merchant has a seal-ink stain on their right thumb. A stranger whose ink is fresh is new to the trade. A stranger whose ink is faded has been retired. A stranger with no ink is not a merchant. Not a merchant is not a person.

What is the most common crime? Contract fraud—but fraud is not a crime, it is a negotiation. The contracts are written in disappearing ink. The ink's formula is a secret. The secret is held by the Archivolt notaries. The notaries sell the antidote. The antidote is the fee.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Matron is not the ruler. The canals rule. The canals set the prices. The canals decide who lives and who drowns. The canals are not water. The canals are the city's memory. The memory is the Matron's. The Matron is the canals' voice.

Where do people go when they die? To the canals. The dead are not buried. Their bodies are wrapped in silk and sunk in the deep channels. The channels are the city's ledger. The ledger is never balanced.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You offer a bridge—a toll paid to the Bridge-Lords. The toll is calculated by the wronged party's estimate of their loss. The toll is paid in silver. The silver is melted and poured into the canal. The canal remembers the weight. The weight is your apology.

What is the most important festival? The Dyeing of the Waters (spring). The dyers empty their vats into the canals. The water turns red, blue, green, gold. The colours are the year's fashions. The fashions are set by the Matron. The Matron's favourite colour is the one that sells best. The best colour is the one she dyed her own hair.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The canals are not natural. They were dug by a Sidhi engineer who was paid in promises. The promises were broken. The engineer cursed the city. The curse is that every ninth drop of water is a tear. The tears belong to the engineer. She is still crying. She has been crying for nine centuries.

37.1 Silkstrand — “City of Bridges & Ledgers”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *Every bridge is a contract. Every current carries coin.*

The Matron (Elite): “In this city, every bridge is a contract and every current carries coin. The bargains struck in our shadows never quite fade from memory, and the waters remember every handshake.”

Bobbin-Runner (Commoner): “I can cross this city faster than any grown-up, and I know which planks creak and which merchants lie. The bridges remember every step, and the canals carry more secrets than fish.”

Genre / Mood: Mercantile noir, Renaissance urban fantasy, late-medieval finance.

Starting Location: Three-Queens Bridge, crowded with market stalls, its stones worn smooth by centuries of footsteps. A Guildmistress with ink-stained fingers offers a customs waiver. “The Exchange boils today,” she says. “And something in the canals remembers your scent. Bring me three bolts of untaxed crimson before the closing bell, or the Archivolt will find your name in a dead notary’s ledger.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Silkstrand is a city strung across canals and arches, a place where every bridge is a contract and every current carries rumor. The silk looms never sleep, the Exchange never closes, and the Archivolt’s notaries seal fates with a drop of wax. Merchants rise and fall with the tide of the market, bravos carve reputations on the planks of Three-Queens Bridge, and the city’s underworld runs on whispers and borrowed keys. The Matron rules from her palazzo stairs with velvet and iron, but the city itself belongs to silk, silver, and shadow.

What you notice first: The clash of water against ancient stone. The constant rumble of cart wheels on bridge planks. The way every handshake lingers a heartbeat too long — as if both parties are checking for hidden clauses.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never name a rival while crossing a bridge at night. The water remembers, and the curse you send may come back wrapped around your own throat.

Regional Mood: Bridges and Ledgers

Here, fortune is written in ink and sealed in wax. Silkstrand is not lawless — it is **layered**. Above the tide lies the world of guild charters, notarial seals, and the Matron’s velvet justice. Below the bridges, in the weeping arches and the midnight boat lanes, a quieter economy runs on whispers, borrowed keys, and the careful omission of names. The city’s bravos duel for reputation on Three-Queens Bridge while factors bribe clerks in the Archivolt. Every alliance is a knot that can be pulled loose. Every fortune is a thread that can be cut.

Prominent NPCs of Silkstrand

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Matrona Lucia	The Matron, ruler of Silkstrand	Keep the guilds balanced and the treasury full	She has never raised her voice. The city learned to fear her silences.
Guildmistress Xara She can tell your guild by the stain on your cuff; she never forgets a color.	Head of the Silk	Dye Guilds	Secure the red dye monopoly
Niccolò	Archivolt notary	“Fix” missing recitals for a fee	His inkwell contains a single drop of his own blood. He renews it each spring.
Ravel	Night-boat smuggler	Move cargo that cannot be named	His boat has no name. The canal would remember it, and memory is a kind of tax.
Sister Chiara	Healer of the Weavers of Mercy (The Silk-Shrouded) (Temple of Light)	Run a hospice near the Salt Gate	She asks no payment, but she records every patient’s name in a ledger that never dries.
Captain Borso	Condottieri watch captain	Keep the peace between guilds	He wears a mask on feast days; no one has seen his face in seven years.

Names of Silkstrand

Inspired by the mercantile republics of the southern coast: liquid vowels, soft endings, and surnames that recall a bridge, a canal, or a trade.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
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Lorenzo	Lucia	da Ponte	<i>the Bridge-Wise</i>
Niccolò	Xara	Canaletti	<i>the Unseen</i>
Borso	Chiara	del Forno	<i>Bobbin-Foot</i>
Marco	Fiammetta	Riva	<i>the Silent</i>
Tommaso	Oria	Selci	<i>Red-Handed</i>
Andrea	Zilia	Molin	<i>Ash-Thread</i>

(Bridge/Canal/Market) Three-Queens Bridge with stacked stalls; Archivolt arcade of notaries; Salt Gate quay with customs.

Spades — Places

2. **Three-Queens Bridge** — Stacked market stalls; cells under arches, reputations made and broken. *The cells are for debtors. The walls are washed with canal water so no one forgets the smell.* ‘[TRADE]’
3. **The Archivolt** — Arcaded street of notaries, seals, and quiet knives. *The notaries write in lemon juice. Heat reveals the truth — or a facsimile.* ‘[LAW]’
4. **Silk Exchange** — Floor with chalk circles and clappers for opening bids. *The clappers are whale ribs. The bids echo, and sometimes the echo answers.* ‘[TRADE]’
5. **Salt Gate Quay** — Rope booms, chalk tallies, tired eyes; customs and coin. *The chalk is mixed with ground bone. A false tally writes itself in a dead hand.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
6. **Palazzo della Matrona** — Ruling seat with private river stairs; velvet and iron. *The Matrona’s barge is rowed by debtors who have repaid in years, not coin.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
7. **Spindle Tower** — Creaking windlass-lifts and posted rates; heights and hazards. *The lift operator has a bell. He rings it once for every passenger who didn’t pay.* ‘[LABOR]’
8. **Ropewalk Sheds** — Arrow-straight; bruisers hired by the yard, muscle for hire. *The rope-walkers never look back. They say a rope remembers who pulled it last.* ‘[LABOR]’
9. **Old Arsenal** — Free Company’s barracks now; arms and ambitions stored. *The arsenal’s bell rings at odd hours. No one admits ringing it.* ‘[MILITARY]’
10. **Exchange Coffee House** — Where merchants insure cargo and spread rumors. *The coffee is thick as mud. The policy rates change with the wind.* ‘[SOCIAL]’
- J **Flood-Stairs** — Bronze flood marks, bell rope ready when the Strand runs wild. *The flood marks go up to nine. The ninth step is underwater — always.* ‘[WEATHER]’
- Q **Basilica of Azerin** — Weaver-saint; confraternity rooms hum with vows. *The saint’s icon has one eye. The other was traded for the secret of indigo.* ‘[FAITH]’
- K **Debtors’ Arcade** — Row of pawn shops and loan banks; interest rates carved on the pillars. *The pillars are scored with tally marks. The oldest ones are from three centuries ago.* ‘[DEBT]’
- A **The Unwritten Canal** — A buried waterway that appears only in the lowest tides. *It leads to a vault where contracts are kept that were never meant to be fulfilled.* ‘[MYSTERY]’

(Guild/Factor/Crown) Bobbin-runner child with feet sure on parapets; foreign factor seeking warehouse and friend at customs.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Bobbin-Runner** — Child with sure feet on parapets, rumors in pocket. *She ties a knot in her apron string for every secret she carries. The apron is nearly solid knots.* ‘[STEALTH]’
3. **Mulberry Steward** — Counting leaves; desperate for pickers, quick with coin. *His left hand is missing two fingers — lost to a cocoon-rot curse. He calls it a bargain.* ‘[LABOR]’
4. **Foreign Factor** — Seeking warehouse and friend at customs; connections for sale. *He carries three ledgers. One for the Matron, one for the Archivolt, one for himself.* ‘[TRADE]’
5. **Guildmistress** — Silk Dye guilds’ hands stained, permits tighter than purse strings. *She can tell your guild by the stain on your cuff. She never forgets a color.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
6. **Bridge Bailiff** — Rents stalls, sells gossip by the breath; power in position. *He rings a small bell before each announcement. The tone tells you if it’s truth or theater.* ‘[LAW]’
7. **Archivolt Notary** — “Fixes” missing recitals — for a donation; law as service. *His inkwell contains a single drop of his own blood. He renews it each spring.* ‘[LAW]’
8. **Watch Captain** — Condotta to three lords; passwords change with the wind. *He wears a mask on feast days. No one has seen his face in seven years.* ‘[MILITARY]’
9. **Exchange Caller** — A clap can still a thousand voices; auction master. *He lost his voice to a curse. Now he claps in a language only the bids understand.* ‘[TRADE]’
10. **Insurance Broker** — Writes policies on cargo, lives, and sometimes conspiracies. *His quill is a stiletto. He has used it as both.* ‘[FINANCE]’
- J **Night-Boat Smuggler** — “Ravel,” silent oar, louder favors; shadows for coin. *His boat has no name. The canal would remember it, and memory is a kind of tax.* ‘[STEALTH]’
- Q **The Matron** — Patient, velvet, iron; the city’s thread pulled through her hands. *She has never raised her voice. The city learned to fear her silences.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
- K **Lame King’s Envoy** — Velvet boots; claims certain alleys “protected.” *His cane is hollow. Inside is a letter of marque that expired a decade ago.* ‘[POLITICS]’
- A **Saint of Warps** — If real: sees curses braided in cloth; holy unraveler. *Her eyes are milk-white. She sees not the cloth, but the threads of obligation within.* ‘[FAITH]’

(**Flood/Interdict/Riot**) Flood siren with gates lowering — move crates or kiss them goodbye; quarantine flag at the dyeworks sealing a district; Loom strike over unpaid wages.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Flood Siren** — Gates lowering; move crates or kiss them goodbye to tide. *The gate-keeper’s palm is marked with a bell. Cross it with silver to hurry.* ‘[WEATHER]’
3. **Quarantine Flag** — A district sealed; your cargo implicated. *The flag is dyed with lamp-black and something else — something that smells of graves.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
4. **Loom Strike** — Weavers idle over wage disputes; streets fill with idle frames. *The striking weavers wear red threads around their wrists. They will not speak first.* ‘[LABOR]’
5. **Seal Counterfeit** — Discovered at Archivolt; all contracts frozen. *The forged seal is warm. The real one is cold. Touch both to know which is which.* ‘[LAW]’
6. **Bridge Riot** — A dropped stall blocks lanes; tempers boil faster than vats. *The riot started over a missed bell-ring. Or a stolen bolt. Or a look.* ‘[SOCIAL]’

7. **Condottieri Flip** — Colors change; watchwords shift, escorts vanish. *The captain’s new banner is stitched with thread from his old captain’s shroud.* ‘[MILITARY]’
8. **Insurance Fraud** — A warehouse burns; the policy is a forgery. *The broker has fled. His ledgers are full of ships that never sailed.* ‘[FINANCE]’
9. **Coin Clipping** — Light silver floods the market; the Exchange closes. *The clippings were melted into a statue of the Matron. She is not amused.* ‘[TRADE]’
10. **Salt-Tax Doubled** — At Salt Gate; boats stack three deep, bribes flow. *The tax collector wears a mask. Beneath it, his face is a salt-caked skull.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
- J **Duel Challenge** — Booked on Three-Queens Bridge; you’re named as seconds. *The challenge is written on silk. Burn it to refuse — and lose face forever.* ‘[SOCIAL]’
- Q **Exchange Corner** — Rivals hoard raw silk; prices go vertical. *The cornering merchant has a ledger bound in human skin. The names inside are his competitors.* ‘[TRADE]’
- K **Saint’s Procession** — Closes half the wards; ignore at peril, faith walks the streets. *The icon weeps dyewater. The faithful collect it in silver cups.* ‘[FAITH]’
- A **Curse Awakened** — In canals: no route reaches the address you seek. *The water is still. Your reflection is gone. You are still here — for now.* ‘[DEATH]’

(Permit/Seat/Escort) Bridge token for peak-hour cart crossing free; Exchange floor pass; Matron’s seal for a single contract.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Bridge Token** — One peak-hour cart crossing free; traffic as currency. *The token is a bronze coin with a hole in the center. The hole is the toll.* ‘[TRAVEL]’
3. **Exchange Pass** — Day pass to trade without sponsor; freedom in paper. *The pass is stamped with a spider. The spider’s legs are the signatures of three guilds.* ‘[TRADE]’
4. **Watergate Priority** — Skip one flood closure when it matters; tide waits for none. *The priority token is a dried eel skin. Show it, and the gate-keeper spits but stands aside.* ‘[TRAVEL]’
5. **Notarial Indulgence** — Retrofit a missing recital; past deals stand. *The indulgence is written in lemon juice. Heat it to see the terms.* ‘[LAW]’
6. **Warehouse Seal** — From Matron’s office; rivals legally shut out. *The seal is a brass bell. Ring it once to claim the space.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
7. **Ropewalk Credit** — Hire crews before you have coin; muscle on credit. *The credit is a knotted rope. Cut a knot for each favor called.* ‘[LABOR]’
8. **Arsenal Key** — One night’s issue for retinue; arms in trusted hands. *The key is a finger bone. The lock is a gauntleted fist.* ‘[MILITARY]’
9. **Insurance Policy (Blank)** — Insure one cargo against any loss; the policy pays in silver. *The policy is a prayer. The prayer is a contract. The contract is a bet.* ‘[FINANCE]’
10. **Condotta Rider** — City watch escorts through any ward, once. *The rider’s horse has iron shoes. The sparks tell him who to watch.* ‘[MILITARY]’
- J **Matron’s Audience** — Private whisper becomes policy; velvet commands. *The Matron’s ear is a bell. Speak into it, and the city listens — once.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
- Q **Tax-Farm Share** — On Three-Queens stalls for a season; profit in peddlers. *The share is a tally stick. Break it in half to claim your portion.* ‘[FINANCE]’

- K Golden Thread** — Temporary charter to set tolls on a named canal. *The thread is real gold. It will not break — but it will stretch.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
- A The Unwritten Contract** — A blank parchment signed by a dead notary. Fill it in. *The notary’s ghost will enforce it. The ghost has a sense of humor.* ‘[MAGIC]’

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (permits, passes, seals) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **silk and water** motifs — threads that bind, currents that remember, bargains that stain the ledger.

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **Duel Etiquette:** Duels fought on bridges draw crowds eager to wager on blood. Refusing stains a name worse than losing. The winner may claim the loser’s bridge token (if any) as a trophy.
- **Canal Omens:** Canals run strange colors at dawn; red foretells riots, blue brings calm, black means a curse has awakened. A successful Wits + Lore test (DV 3) allows a character to interpret the omen and gain +1 die on the next roll to avoid or exploit the coming event.
- **Matron’s Seal:** Any contract bearing her seal is law — but the Matron is known to rescind seals without warning, leaving debts tangled. A seal may be challenged by producing an older Matron’s seal; the older one always holds.
- **Exchange Volatility Clock [6]:** Tracks market instability. Each time a major cargo is seized, a trade route is cut, or a merchant defaults, tick the clock. At 3: prices of all goods increase by 1 Supply. At 6: a panic hits — the Exchange closes for 1d3 days, and all outstanding contracts are voided unless witnessed by the Matron.
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
 - **The Ledger Saint** — The Witness. *Every transaction is a prayer. Every signature is a confession.*
 - **The Unbroken Seal** — Mykkiel. *Contracts are sacred. To break one is to break the city.*
 - **The Tide Father** — Khemesh. *The canal’s hunger; the interest on a loan never repaid.*
 - **The Lantern Bearer** — The Traveler. *The light that guides lost ships — and lost debtors.*

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **Saint Lazarus of the Unfinished Ledger (The Witness):** The Archivolt notaries keep a sealed archive of *unwritten contracts* — promises that were never stamped. The Order of the Witness claims that reading even one of these binds the reader to fulfil it. The Matron has never opened the archive. The Red Clerk has, and his inkwell is now a skull.

- **Saint Fina of the Dyed Veil (Isoka):** The Basilica of Azerin has a side chapel dedicated to the *Shedding Saint*, whose mosaic shows a silkworm breaking its cocoon. Pilgrims who leave a confession there wake the next morning having forgotten one sin — but also one kindness they received. The Guildmistress permits the chapel because the offerings keep the silk guilds wealthy.
- **The Weavers of Mercy (The Silk-Shrouded):** A hospice near the Salt Gate is run by grey-robed healers who ask no payment. They are tolerated because they treat wounded condottieri for free, but the Black Purse faction suspects they also erase debts — ledgers left near their doors have been found blank. The Order’s rule: “You do not pay back. You pay forward. But woe to the one who strikes a healer.”
- **The Ledger of Unbroken Promises (The Syndicate Seal):** A small but influential order of notaries based in the Archivolt. They adjudicate disputes over contracts, cargo claims, and bridge tolls. Their judgments are always delivered in triplicate, and they accept no bribes — only binding oaths. Those who lie before a Covenant judge find that their next three shipments are impounded.
- **The Ninth:** In any Silkstrand scene, the ninth bridge crossed in a day leads somewhere unexpected. The wise stop at eight and take a boat. Those who cross the ninth are said to hear a faint laugh from the water — and their contracts are never quite fulfilled.

Silkstrand Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Canal:** Toss a crust into the water before crossing a new bridge. Ignore the first *Bridge Riot* penalty. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Knot the Thread:** Tie a single knot in a scrap of silk. Cancel *Seal Counterfeit* or take –1 die on your next negotiation (your choice). ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Name to the Water:** Whisper a debtor’s name into the canal at dawn. Gain +1 Effect when collecting from them this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Archivolt. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **city watch** or **rival merchants**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **crowds** or **bridge traffic**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers** or **customs**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time** or **favorable tide**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Bridge bailiff** or **guildmaster** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **crowd movement** or **flood**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **rival merchant** or **hired bravo** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **condottieri**, **smugglers**, or **guild enforcers** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes — **flood hits/contract voided/duel declared**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival: The Matron, Watch Captain, or Guildmistress** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically — **flood rises/bridge collapses/procession blocks streets**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice — **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Silkstrand (Bridges & Trade):** Bridge planks shift underfoot, bargains restructure mid-speech, coins change hands without touch.
- **Silkstrand (Canals):** Water levels rise without warning, gondolas block routes, a sudden fog hides a rival's approach.
- **Silkstrand (Duel Culture):** Challenges are issued mid-conversation, seconds appear from the crowd, honor prices rise with each breath.

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Wits + Stealth):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Fog Bank*.
- **Cut the Bridge (Presence + Sway):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a bridge token is in your possession, +1 die.
- **Weather the Flood (Resolve + Athletics):** On a hit in *Flood Siren*, you pick who keeps their footing; on a miss, the GM does.

Boss Seeds (three-phase foes)

- **The Corseted Ledger (cursed accounting bound in silk)** — *Phases:* Friendly Audit → Retroactive Debts → Names as Collateral. *Cracks:* burn one forged seal in public; settle a rival's debt at cost; wash the book on Flood-Stairs at high bell.
- **Archivolt Ragman (collector of “missing recitals”)** — *Phases:* Quiet Inserts → Paper Hunts → Bridge Vetoes. *Cracks:* win a duel for precedent; expose a double-entry altar; break his pen with the Matron's Seal.
- **The Tide of Unpaid Interest (a walking loan)** — *Phases:* Grace Period → Collection → Foreclosure. *Cracks:* pay in stories; find the original debtor; renegotiate the contract under a neutral bridge.

Patronage & Power

In Silkstrand, power flows through commerce, connections, and the careful weaving of influence. The Matron maintains control through a web of guilds, factors, and condottieri, each bound by contracts and customs that shift like the tides. Merchants rise and fall with the Exchange, while the city’s bravos and smugglers operate in the spaces between law and profit.

For the GM: Patronage in Silkstrand revolves around access — to bridges, to warehouses, to the Exchange floor itself. Rewards often take the form of permits, seals, or safe passage that can be leveraged into greater influence. To emphasize this:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (seals, tokens, contracts) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided.
- Let rival guilds issue conflicting charters, forcing players to choose whose favor matters more.
- Use the bridges, markets, and Exchange as arenas for social contests, where reputation and connections determine success.

In Silkstrand, your word is your bond, and your bond determines whether you rise or drown.

Chapter 38

The Ways Between

Spiritways & Veilways.

You are reading this sentence twice. The first time, you understood it. The second time, it understood you.

I am a Lost Pilgrim. Or I was. Or I will be. The paths here don't care about tenses. They care about which version of you arrives at the end. I've been walking for—no. That's a lie. The walking has been walking me. I forget which of us started first.

The Ways Between do not measure miles. They measure choices. A wrong turn might lead to yesterday. A right turn might lead to a version of yourself who made a different decision and is still alive to regret it. The mist does not hide landmarks. It hides destinations. And sometimes, when you walk long enough, you realise the destination was never the point. The point was the moment you turned left instead of right. The point was the breath you held at the crossroads. The point was the name you did not speak.

Here is the secret the Wayfinder doesn't want you to know: there is no Wayfinder. There is only the road, and the road is a liar. It tells you it wants you to find your way. What it actually wants is to watch you choose. Every reflection in every pool is a version of you that chose differently. They are all still walking. They are all still watching. And they are all still waiting for you to make the choice that finally lets them stop.

I met myself on a bridge once. They were coming from the opposite direction. We stopped. We looked at each other. We said nothing. We both knew that if one of us spoke, the other would have to listen. And listening is a kind of debt.

Never answer a question asked by a reflection. The answer will bind you to the path you did not choose. But here is the second secret: not answering is also a choice. And the road is very, very patient.

— *The Wayfinder, who exists only in the moment a choice is made, and who is not the same person at the end of this sentence as at the beginning*

The Almanac of Ordinary Days

What do people eat for breakfast? Nothing. There is no breakfast in the Ways Between. There is no morning. There is no hunger. There is only the walking. The walking is sustenance.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To forget. Children born in the Ways Between do not learn. They remember. They remember the path they took to be born. The path has eight turns. The ninth turn is the birth. The birth is a choice. The child does not know they chose.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their direction. A stranger walking toward you may be coming from your future. A stranger walking away may be going to your past. A stranger walking beside you may be yourself from a timeline where you did not turn left. Do not ask them which. They will not answer.

What is the most common crime? Stealing—but stealing is not a crime, it is a paradox. A thief in the Ways Between steals a memory from a version of you that no longer exists. The memory never belonged to you. You cannot miss it. You will miss it anyway.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Ways Between are not between anything. They are the only thing that exists. The solid ground you remember—the cities, the roads, the hearths—is the dream. The Ways Between are the waking. The waking is the walking. The walking never ends.

Where do people go when they die? Deeper. The Ways Between have no surface, no bottom, no end. The dead walk deeper. The deeper they walk, the less they remember. When they remember nothing, they become the path. The path is the walking. The walking is the dead.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You cannot. Apologies require memory. Memory requires a self. The Ways Between erase both. The only apology is to stop walking. Stopping is not an option.

What is the most important festival? There are no festivals. There is only the moment between heartbeats when you realise you have been walking for nine years and you do not remember why. That moment is the festival. Celebrate it by taking the next step.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Wayfinder is not a person. It is the road itself, dreaming of a traveller who will finally reach the end. The end does not exist. The road knows this. The road dreams anyway.

38.1 The Ways Between — Obishaal, the Realm of Dreams and Death

Quick Reference

Tagline: *Every dream is a door. Every door is a judgment. The dead dream forever; the living borrow their sleep.*

The Wayfinder (Elite): “I exist only in the moment of choice, the breath between one path and another. Obishaal is not a place—it is a *state*. To guide here is to understand that every dream leads somewhere, but only the virtuous know which somewhere is worth the waking.”

Lost Pilgrim (Commoner): “The dead don’t leave. They just change addresses. Obishaal is their new neighborhood, and the rent is paid in virtue. If you’re lucky, you’ll only visit. If you’re not... you’ll find yourself climbing stairs that never end, and every landing offers a bargain you can’t refuse.”

Genre / Mood: Dream-death metaphysical, virtue-based ascent, temptation and fall, folk-surrealism.

Starting Location: A crossroad shrine of black glass stones, where travelers meet their reflections coming the other way. The shrine is silent except for the soft hum of the stones. A Backwards Pilgrim stands at the crossroads, facing the direction you came from. “The Thirteenth Stone speaks,” they say. “But the path chooses who arrives. What did you bury on the road here? The stones can smell it. And in Obishaal, every buried thing dreams of waking.”

Theme & Atmosphere

The Ways Between is a transit way, the eternal crossroads through Obishaal, the element of Dreams and Death, the eighth element after Fire, Life, Air, Fortune, Earth, Fate, Water, Dreams/Death. It is the realm where the settled dead go not to oblivion but to an *ideal afterlife*—a dream that reflects the life they lived. A farmer dreams of endless harvest; a warrior dreams of eternal battle; a merchant dreams of ledgers that never close. These dreams are real, and they are paradise or prisons.

The living may enter the Ways through thresholds of sleep, near-death, or deliberate ritual. Once inside, they find a landscape that shifts with their own psyche—but also with the weight of their choices. **To ascend** through the layers of Obishaal, a traveler must demonstrate *virtue*: honesty, courage, mercy, self-sacrifice. **To fall** is to yield to *vice*: greed, cowardice, cruelty, despair. Each layer is a test, and each test is a dream that tempts you to fail.

At the very bottom, pressed into the silt of the deepest dream, lies **Ikasha**, She Who Sleeps. Her sisters Inaea and Isoka imprisoned her there eons ago, for Ikasha dreamed of summoning and confronting the Clockwork Monad—a confrontation that, in their judgment, would unmake reality. Now Ikasha dreams fitfully, and her nightmares seep upward, infecting the layers above. Sometimes a traveler who falls far enough can hear her voice, offering escape in exchange for service—a service that would free her.

Between the layers drift the dead who have not yet found their final dream. They are the *Unsettled*, and they will trade memories, secrets, and virtues for a chance to ascend—or to pull you down with them.

What you notice first: The air tastes of copper and old keys. Your footsteps echo half a beat too late. The waystones are warm—and they pulse like hearts.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never answer a question asked by a reflection. The answer will bind you to the path you did not choose.

Regional Mood: The Dream That Remembers

Here, the dream is not a thing—it is a witness. It remembers every promise made at a deathbed, every lie told to a dying ear, every virtue you failed to keep. Obishaal does not forgive, but it does not forget either. It offers passage in exchange for truth. The longer you stay, the more the dream learns about you. By the time you reach your destination, you may find that the destination knows you better than you know yourself. Some travelers never leave. They become dream-echoes, their faces pressed into the glass of a forgotten dream, their names still warm on the lips of the next pilgrim.

(Path/Crossing/Threshold) Mist-shrouded ford where water runs uphill; footsteps echo backwards; bone-lit corridor where shadows walk the walls.

Spades — Places (Dream Layers)

2. **Mist-Ford of First Doubt** — Water runs uphill; footsteps echo backwards through time. '[THRESHOLD]' *The ford shows you wading through your own past. Do not look down at the water.*
3. **Bone Corridor of Unfinished Business** — Shadows walk the walls but never touch the floor; light as memory. '[DEATH]' *The bones are from those who chose vice and fell. They*

shift when you blink.

4. **Threshold Arch of Virtue** — Shows a reflection as someone you might have been; the past as a mirror. '[TRUTH]' *The reflection has a scar you never got. It asks how you avoided it.*
5. **Spiral Path of Recursion** — Ascends but returns to the same stone marker; the journey as meditation. '[MAGIC]' *Each loop, the stone moves closer to the center. Or you do.*
6. **Promise Bridge of the Unsettled** — Cross with a vow and it remembers your debt; an oath as a toll. '[OATH]' *The bridge's planks are old letters. Read one, and you may owe the writer.*
7. **Crossroads of the Ninth Choice** — All four paths lead to the same destination, but different tomorrows. '[THRESHOLD]' *The center stone is warm. A coin placed there will vanish—or be accepted.*
8. **Stone Circle of Forgotten Villages** — Marks where a village used to be; the houses are now constellations. '[DEATH]' *The stars are too close. You can touch them. They crumble like ash.*
9. **Memory Tunnel of the Dying** — Hear the thoughts of those who passed here; the past as an echo. '[MEMORY]' *The thoughts are in a language you almost understand. One word is your name.*
10. **Fossil Stairs of Ascension** — Each step is an eye that watches your ascent; the climb as scrutiny. '[FEAR]' *The eyes belong to those who fell here. They blink in sequence.*
- J **Waystation of the Virtuous** — The keeper trades in unfinished conversations; words as currency. '[SOCIAL]' *The keeper has no face. It wears the faces of those who paused too long.*
- Q **Junction of Vice and Virtue** — Paths physically collide; you must choose which reality to follow. '[THRESHOLD]' *The collision sounds like breaking glass. The glass reforms into a door.*
- K **Long Mile of Temptation** — The road stretches differently for each traveler; distance as perception. '[MAGIC]' *You are the only one walking. The others are already at the end.*
- A **The Thirteenth Stone — Ikasha's Seal** — Where the path reveals its true destination; truth as revelation. '[TRUTH]' *The stone whispers. The whisper is a promise you made to yourself and broke. Beneath it, the stone is warm—and dreaming.*

(Wayfarer/Spirit/Dream-walker) Lost pilgrim who thinks they're going home but forgot where; toll-taker accepting payment in forgotten memories.

Hearts — Travelers & Guides

2. **Lost Pilgrim** — Thinks they're going home but forgot where; destination as a memory. '[TRAVEL]' *Their pack is full of stones. Each stone is a forgotten promise.*
3. **Toll-Taker (Virtue Assessor)** — Accepts payment in virtues you didn't know you had. '[SOCIAL]' *Their scales weigh truth and echo. A balanced scale means you pass—for now.*
4. **Wayward Guide** — Directions technically correct, morally questionable. '[TRAVEL]' *They point with a broken compass. The needle spins, but the path is true.*
5. **Dream-Merchant** — Carries a sack of nightmares and one perfect dream for sale. '[MAGIC]' *The perfect dream is their own. They are selling it because they cannot wake up.*
6. **Child-Ghost of Unfinished Life** — Knows shortcuts but charges in riddles; wisdom as a puzzle. '[DEATH]' *The riddles have no answer—only a choice. Choose wrong, and you*

become a child.

7. **Wounded Walker (Vice-Bound)** — Bleeding metaphor; their pain grows thorns along the path. '[FEAR]' *The thorns have faces. Each face is someone they failed to save.*
8. **Map-Merchant of Impossible Dreams** — Selling maps to places that don't exist yet; the future as a commodity. '[TRUTH]' *The maps change as you watch. The destination is always one page ahead.*
9. **Guide-Dog (Ancestral Spirit)** — Made of shadow and starlight; follows those who walk with purpose. '[SPIRIT]' *It never barks. It whines when you are about to make a mistake.*
10. **Backwards Pilgrim (Dream-Echo)** — Moving through time; their steps erase what just happened. '[MEMORY]' *They are walking toward their birth. Every step, they forget something.*
- J **Soul-Ferryman** — Carries the luggage of the living; a burden as a service. '[DEATH]' *The luggage is full of things you never said. The ferryman knows them all.*
- Q **Road's Child (Dream-Kin)** — Born where paths crossed, raised by waymarks; navigation as instinct. '[TRAVEL]' *They have no navel. They were never born—they simply began.*
- K **Dead-Road Keeper** — Ensures proper passage for those who should not walk. '[DEATH]' *Their lantern burns a cold blue. The flame does not flicker.*
- A **The Wayfinder (Dream Avatar)** — Exists only in the moment a choice is made; a decision as an entity. '[LEGEND]' *They are every guide you ever needed. They are also every road you refused.*

(Veil-Thin/Dream-Bleed/Wayward) Path loops back to show your funeral preparations; reality thins—you see the dreams of sleeping travelers; Ikasha's nightmare bleeds into the upper layers.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Funeral Loop** — The path shows your funeral preparations; death as a destination. '[DEATH]' '[FEAR]' *The mourners are people you have not met yet. They seem to know you well.*
3. **Reality Thins (Ikasha's Dream Bleed)** — You see the dreams of sleeping travelers; the boundary as a veil. '[MAGIC]' *A dreamer mutters your name. They are dreaming of a choice you will make tomorrow.*
4. **Waymark Lies (Vice's Test)** — Points the wrong way; trust leads to places that never were. '[TRUTH]' *The waymark has a crack. Through the crack, you see a path you should have taken.*
5. **Dream-Bleed** — Waking memories become someone else's nightmares. '[MEMORY]' '[FEAR]' *You remember a childhood fear that was not yours. It still terrifies you.*
6. **Toll Demanded (Virtue Payment)** — Currency you did not know you carried; payment as a revelation. '[SOCIAL]' '[DEBT]' *The toll is a secret you told a dead person. They are now standing behind you.*
7. **Path Split (Virtue vs. Vice)** — Each version of you remembers differently; identity as a choice. '[MAGIC]' *One you is smiling. One you is weeping. One you is already walking away.*
8. **Gravity Shifts (Guilt's Weight)** — Emotional weight grows physically heavy; a burden as physics. '[WEATHER]' *Your pack feels heavier. Inside is a regret you forgot you carried.*

9. **Time-Sickness (Dream Chronology)** — You arrive before you left; paradox shadows follow. '[MAGIC]' *Your past self waves at you. Do not wave back.*
10. **Truth Payment (Ikasha's Price)** — The road remembers your lies and demands truth as payment. '[TRUTH]' '[DEBT]' *The lie is carved on a stone. The stone is warm. It knows your temperature.*
- J **Crossroads Judgment (Virtue Audit)** — The path you chose judges the ones you did not; decision as karma. '[TRUTH]' '[SOCIAL]' *A ghost of the road not taken asks why. You have one sentence to answer.*
- Q **Memory-Thief (Unsettled Dead)** — A rest stop keeper pays in counterfeit recollections. '[MEMORY]' '[SOCIAL]' *The memory is almost right. The color of the sky is wrong.*
- K **Forbidden Path (Ikasha's Descent)** — Opens only for those already lost; loss as a key. '[DEATH]' *The path smells of old tears. You taste salt on your lips.*
- A **Convergence (Ikasha's Waking)** — All travelers arrive together, none recall how; arrival as a mystery. '[MAGIC]' '[LEGEND]' *You recognize everyone. You have never seen any of them before. The air tastes of honey and rust. Ikasha is dreaming of you.*

(**True Name/Safe Passage/Waywisdom**) Waymark that always points toward your next important choice; a token of passage that the road recognizes as belonging.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Choice Compass (Virtue's Needle)** — Always points toward your next important choice. '[TRAVEL]' *The needle is a splinter of the Thirteenth Stone. It hums when you are near a decision.*
3. **Passage Token (Dream-Marked)** — The road recognizes you as one who belongs. '[SOCIAL]' *The token is a braid of your own hair. You do not remember cutting it.*
4. **Dream-Catcher** — Filters nightmares from your rest; sleep as a sanctuary. '[MAGIC]' *The catcher is woven from old promises. It smells of lavender and regret.*
5. **Truth-Compass (Ikasha's Fragment)** — Points to what you most need to know, not what you want. '[TRUTH]' *The compass has no needle. The housing spins until you speak a truth.*
6. **Memory-Anchor** — Keeps you from losing yourself on deeper paths. '[MEMORY]' *The anchor is a river stone. Your name is carved on it in a language you have never seen.*
7. **Safe Haven (Virtue's Rest)** — A guaranteed rest stop without complication. '[TRAVEL]' *The haven is a dry arch. The arch is a doorframe with no door.*
8. **Guide-Light (Virtue's Beacon)** — Burns the color of your truest intention; purpose as a beacon. '[SOCIAL]' *The light is blue. Blue means you are honest. Red means you are not.*
9. **Path-Cutter (Dream Shears)** — Cuts distance through metaphor, not space. '[MAGIC]' *The cutter is a pair of shears. Cut a memory, and the road between here and there vanishes.*
10. **Debt-Clearing (Virtue's Mercy)** — The road forgives one obligation you thought you owed. '[DEBT]' *The obligation was to a dead person. They are no longer dead on this path.*
- J **Crossroads Boon** — Choose among three paths, each exactly where you need to be. '[LEGEND]' *The paths are labeled: Regret, Forgive, Forget. Choose carefully.*
- Q **Way-Wisdom (Dream-Logic)** — Understand the language of paths and signs for one journey. '[TRAVEL]' *The waystones whisper. They are complaining about the last traveler. It*

was you.

- K **Grace Passage (Virtue's Shield)** — Walk safely through any dangerous crossing for one night. '[TRAVEL]' *The grace is a bell. Ring it, and the road will pretend not to see you.*
- A **Road's Name (Ikasha's True Name)** — Call the path by its true name and command its nature. '[LEGEND]' *The name is a single syllable. Speaking it will change the road—and you.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (true names/safe passages/waywisdom) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **dream-road** motifs—reflections that lie, paths that judge, destinations that choose the traveler. Also, the presence of an Ace hints that Ikasha's dream is particularly close.

Additional Features

- **Dream-Logic Navigation:** Any Ace introduces a metaphysical requirement (a sacrifice, a taboo, an exchange) that must be satisfied to pass. Name it at the table; the road will enforce it.
- **Reflection Points:** Face cards (J, Q, K) show alternate selves or unlived choices. Treat them as temporary NPCs or scene tags that can help, hinder, or tempt.
- **Memory Currency:** Diamonds may be traded for knowledge or safe passage as if they were memories. Describe the memory paid; the path (or its keeper) pays in kind.
- **Virtue and Vice Clocks:** Each character in Obishaal tracks a small personal **Virtue** [3] and **Vice** [3] clock. Virtue advances when they act with honesty, courage, mercy, or self-sacrifice. Vice advances when they act with greed, cowardice, cruelty, or despair. When one clock fills, the character **ascends** (Virtue) to a higher layer of Obishaal or **falls** (Vice) to a lower one. Ascension offers a boon; falling offers a temptation (a cursed gift from the layer's vice-spirit). The clocks reset after each layer transition. Reaching the bottom (Vice filled in the deepest layer) allows Ikasha to speak directly to the character.
- **Ikasha's Whisper (Patron Intervention):** When a character falls to the lowest layer (or deliberately seeks her out), they may hear Ikasha's voice. She offers a *Fragment of Freedom*: +2 dice to any roll involving escape, secrecy, or breaking bonds, but each use marks 1 **Obligation to Ikasha** and advances a **Waking Dream** [6] clock. When that clock fills, Ikasha uses the character as a vessel to attempt an escape—a campaign-level event.
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
 - **The Unnamed Guide** — The Traveler. *The road that appears only when you are lost.*
 - **The Mirror Listener** — The Witness. *The reflection that tells you what you need to hear, never what you want.*
 - **The Threshold Child** — The Sealed Gate. *The one who was never born, who guards the places where paths end.*
 - **The Echo King** — The Ninth. *The voice that answers when you speak to the empty road.*

- **The Dreamer Below** — Ikasha (imprisoned). *She who sleeps and dreams of waking. Her whispers are bargains; her freedom is a promise.*

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Bitter Root:** Daughters of the Cord know the Ways Between as the Cord’s shadow. A lost Hollowed wanders here, its thread trailing into the mist. Follow it, and you may find a Sister who cut herself free—and who now tends Ikasha’s dream.
- **The Threshold Compendium:** Saikou Ira’s silver mirror shows the Ways Between as a tangled knot of unfulfilled obligations. He has walked three paths here. He will not speak of the fourth, where he glimpsed Ikasha’s face.
- **Malachai, the Chained Angel:** A silver coin that never spends lies at every crossroads. Pick it up, and the road will offer you a shortcut—but the coin will reappear in your pocket at the next junction, heavier. In Obishaal, the coin is warm and pulses like a heartbeat.
- **The Grey Wanderer’s Grimoire:** Psions call the Ways Between “the Stair.” They climb it in their dreams, trading memories for glimpses of paths not yet walked. Some never wake. The Grey Wanderer claims that the Stair is Ikasha’s spine.
- **The Ninth:** On any path in the Ways Between, the ninth step you take in a straight line will land on a threshold you did not see. The wise take eight steps, then pause to look around. In Obishaal, the ninth step is always a dream of falling.

Ways Between Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Stones:** Crumble a crust at the base of a waystone. Ignore the first *Waymark Lies* penalty. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Knot the Path:** Tie a single knot in a piece of string and hang it from a milestone. Cancel *Path Split* or take –1 die on your next navigation roll (your choice). ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Name to the Crossroads:** Whisper a dead traveler’s name into the center stone. Gain +1 Effect when bargaining with a Toll-Taker this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Wayfinder. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **path keepers or wayward spirits**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **travelers or memory echoes**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or reflection points**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favorable path alignment**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** Toll-taker or wayward guide becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **path shift or reality thinning**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **memory-thief or forbidden path entity** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.

- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **wayward spirits, path entities, or alternate selves** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **path loops/time shifts/reality fractures**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **The Wayfinder, Dead-Road Keeper, or Road's Child** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **reality thins/paths converge/time loops**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Obishaal (Dream-Logic):** Paths rearrange without warning, reflections speak unbidden, destinations shift mid-journey. A character may hear Ikasha's whisper as a free omen (the GM may spend 1 SB to make it a false omen).
- **Obishaal (Memory Currency):** Memories become tangible, forgotten knowledge resurfaces, past and present blur. Trading a memory here may also tick the *Virtue* or *Vice* clock depending on the memory's nature.
- **Obishaal (Virtue and Vice):** Decisions echo forward, alternate selves appear, paths judge moral weight. The GM may spend SB to force a character to test a virtue (e.g., "Resist the temptation to lie") or to offer a vice that ticks their Vice clock.

Path-Moves & Procedures (Optional Depth)

Weighing of Steps (Travel Move) When the company enters a liminal path (Mist-Ford, Bone Corridor, etc.), choose one:

- **Pay the Toll:** Each PC names a small truth or a fond memory (GM: 1 SB banked, +1 Position on navigation).
- **Refuse the Toll:** +1d on Speed, but start a **Way-Debt** [4] clock.
- **Bargain the Toll:** Trade a *Diamond* reward as if it were a memory (see Memory Exchange below); cancel one imminent *Club* card in this scene.

When **Way-Debt** fills, trigger *Crossroads Judgment* at the next junction.

Reflection Duel (Social/Moral Test) When confronted by an alternate self or *Reflection Point*, state what that self wants from you and roll your best social action.

- **Success:** Gain a *Guide-Light* tag for the scene and clear 1 tick from **Paths Decide**.

- **Mixed:** Trade places for one exchange or take a **Condition: Disoriented**.
- **Miss:** The reflection walks away with one of your *Diamonds* (GM picks the most narratively apt).

Memory Exchange (Rates & Risks)	Memory Offered	Buys You	Sid
	A childhood smell, a forgotten nickname	+1 Position on one crossing	A f for
	A first failure or small betrayal	Cancel one minor Complication	Yo ogr
	A true fear you have never spoken	<i>Guide-Light</i> or <i>Way-Cord</i> -like effect	A c nig
	The details of a kept promise	<i>Safe Passage</i> for the party	An mis
	The meaning behind a scar	Convert one <i>Club</i> into <i>Trace</i> only	Th unt
	A perfect day (all details)	Treat the next <i>Heart</i> face as an ally	Sta the

Exchange Rule: If you pay the same *kind* of memory twice in a journey, start **Hollowing** [4]. When it fills, you gain the *Backwards Pilgrim* tag until you reclaim what was lost.

Way-Keys & Taboos (d6)

1. **Speak Last:** Only the final word said at a gate is true; others are “practice.” First speakers take –1d on their next test.
2. **Step Odd:** Crossings require an odd number of steps; even counts loop you back one scene.
3. **Name Nothing:** True names wake *Name-Theft*; use titles or lose a *Diamond*.
4. **Wet Iron:** A drop of water on iron cancels one glamour once per scene.
5. **Back Gift:** Leave something behind to go forward; refuse and tick **Way-Debt**.
6. **Answer Bent:** Answer a waystone’s question with a metaphor, not a fact, or trigger *Truth Payment*.

Boss Seeds (three-phase foes)

- **The Archivist of Unmade Roads (cloak stitched from surveyor’s cords)** — *Phases:* Receipts of Refusal → Stay of Journey → Unfiled Options. *Cracks:* a **Choice Compass** reveals the true path; a **Debt-Clearing** voids his claim.
- **The Toll-Matriarch Beneath the Bridge (many hands, one voice like wet stone)** — *Phases:* Truth Payment → Debt-Clearing → Forbidden Path. *Cracks:* a **Passage Token** marks you as belonging; a **Road’s Name** commands her to stand aside.
- **The Wayfinder’s Shadow (your silhouette, two steps ahead)** — *Phases:* Crossroads Judgment → Guide-Light → Haste Mark. *Cracks:* a **Memory-Anchor** keeps you grounded; a **Grace Passage** slips past its gaze.
- **Ikasha’s Nightmare (Dream-Eater)** — Appears only in the deepest layer. *Phases:* Whispers → Temptation → Consumption. *Cracks:* a **Virtue** filled clock can be spent to reject the nightmare; a memory of true self-sacrifice (cost 1 permanent Bond) banishes it entirely.

Encounter Seeds (quick hooks)

- **The Promise Bridge's Receipt:** An old vow you never spoke was logged here. To cross, define when you would have sworn it—and to whom.
- **Thirteenth Stone Auction:** The stone sells three possible endings. Each bidder is you from a different failure.
- **Bone Corridor Choir:** Shadows sing a name wrong by one letter. Correct it and gain *Truth-Compass*; ignore it and start **Name-Theft**.
- **Ikasha's Finger Bone:** A character finds a bone that pulses with dream-light. If they hold it while sleeping, they can speak to Ikasha directly—but each time, the **Waking Dream** clock ticks.

Extensions (Plug-in)

Choice Dial (Resolve ↔ Drift) Track the party's footing between firm intent and wandering.

- *Resolve High:* +1 Position on *Path Split* tests; the first *Dream-Bleed* each session hits harder (start at 2).
- *Drift High:* +1 Effect when bargaining with way-entities; the first *Truth Payment* each session costs a cherished *detail*.
- Center the Dial by naming aloud the next choice *and* why you might refuse it; clear 1 tick from **Way-Debt**.

Counter-Seal (once/scene, if justified) Break a single metaphysical instruction (taboo, key, or omen) by presenting a memory in symbol form (a token, a letter, a sketch). Gain +1d on that crossing; the GM banks 1 SB as a *Marked Consequence* to spend when reflections return.

Start-of-Scene Murmurs (1d6)

1. *Second Sunrise:* light arrives twice; your first missed navigation roll becomes a mixed success.
2. *Name Draft:* the air steals a syllable; your next lie sounds true once.
3. *Echo Debt:* your footprints owe a step—skip a square or tick **Way-Debt** +1.
4. *Pale Bell:* time hiccups; the first *Club* can be delayed until the end of the scene.
5. *Traveler's Chorus:* distant voices agree with you; +1d on appeals to path entities.
6. *Hollow Weather:* rain that does not wet; conditions look dire but impose no penalties this scene.

Plug-in SB Conversions (Obishaal Flavor)

- 1 SB → *Footprint Vote:* your tracks choose a different direction; increase DV by 1 on any roll that relies on following a trail.
- 2 SB → *Echo of Refusal:* a choice you avoided manifests as a minor obstacle (a locked gate, a forgotten toll). If the choice involved a vice, also tick the Vice clock of the character who refused.
- 3+ SB → *Threshold Cracks:* the path fractures; gain a temporary **Path-Cutter** effect but start **Convergence** [4] (all travelers you have met will arrive together at the next junction). Additionally, Ikasha's dream seeps through the cracks; each character hears a single word of her voice.

Cross-Regional Conversions (Using Diamonds Across the Map)

- *Valewood*: **Road's Name** may count as a *Valeheart Clause* once if spoken under leaves; doing so creates **Court Tithe** [2].
- *Mistlands*: **Grace Passage** functions as *Pall Indulgence* over one levee crown at night; ring a bell afterward or start **Witchlight Count**.
- *Vhasia*: **Way-Wisdom** can be presented as “pilgrim right” to bypass one *Interdict* barrier; begin a **Parlement Divided** tick.
- *Viterra*: **Passage Token** can be notarized into a temporary *Ferry Priority*; on use, advance **Border-Lace**.
- *Ubral*: **Memory-Anchor** counts as a *Guest-Token* at one hearth if you recount a family road-tale.
- *Silkstrand*: **Path-Cutter** doubles as a night-boat route once; spend 1 favor with a smuggler or trigger *Seal Counterfeit*.
- *Linn*: **Choice Compass** acts as a *Pilot's Token* in a reed-maze if you pay a name to the water.
- *Theona*: **Crossroads Boon** allows counting “eight-and-one” to cross an *Uncounted Bridge* safely once.

Patronage & Power

In Obishaal, power flows through understanding the metaphysical nature of dreams, the ability to navigate virtue and vice, and the careful management of obligations to the dead and to Ikasha herself. The true authorities are those who know the True Names of dream-layers, can mediate between the living and the Unsettled, and understand the currency of virtue.

For the GM: Patronage in Obishaal revolves around guidance, safe passage, and the ability to navigate moral tests. Rewards often take the form of dream-tokens, fragments of Ikasha's memory, or knowledge of a layer's True Name. To emphasize this:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (compasses, anchors, bells) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided by the dream itself.
- Let rival guides (Virtue vs. Vice) issue conflicting directions, forcing players to choose whose favor matters more.
- Use the crossroads, waystations, and dream-layers as arenas for moral contests, where a single act of mercy can ascend you—and a single act of cruelty can damn you.

In Obishaal, your virtue is your power, and your power determines whether you wake or sleep forever.

Chapter 39

The Wilds

Roads, Ruins, and Weather.

Between towns and treaties lies the patience of the land. Old roads remember armies; cairns remember names no book keeps. In the Wilds, law thins to trail-marks and favors, and the weather keeps its own counsel. The Edgewalker calls it "unclaimed inventory." The land calls it patience. The land has more patience than the Edgewalker.

I am a ranger now. Stonehaven trained me as a scholar—mapping ruins, copying old ledgers, believing that ink could preserve what the world forgot. Tam taught me that the world does not forget. It waits. And while it waits, it watches. The wilds don't need your roads or your rules; they've got their own ways of keeping score. Follow the cairns if you want to live, and always leave something behind—a coin, a story, a breath held just long enough to be noticed. Every hill hides a secret, and every hollow breathes.

The land has a ledger too. It just doesn't use ink. Between the cartographers' claims, the wilds endure—uninterested in borders, indifferent to tariffs. Here, rangers read spoor and weather; hermits keep shrines at forgotten fords; beasts and older things observe travelers with eyes that have seen empires rise and fall. Travel is a negotiation with the land itself, and the land always remembers a slight. The hollows have long memories. They are not cruel. They are not kind. They are patient.

Never sleep in a hollow that has soot on the ceiling without adding your own to the fire. The land knows the difference between a guest and a thief. It also knows the difference between a thief and a corpse. It prefers the corpse. Less arguing.

— *Moirra of Stonehaven, ranger and reluctant debt-keeper*

The Almanac of Ordinary Days

What do people eat for breakfast? Whatever they found—berries, roots, a rabbit snared at dawn. The wilds provide. The wilds also take. The taking is breakfast for something else.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To read the sky. Wilds children are taught the eight winds by taste: North is dry, South is wet, East is cold, West is warm, and the ninth—the wind that has no direction because it is the land’s own breath. The land’s breath is a warning.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their pack. A stranger whose pack is heavy has been travelling long. A stranger whose pack is light has just started. A stranger with no pack is either a fool or a ghost. The wilds eat fools. Ghosts eat the wilds.

What is the most common crime? Forgetting—but forgetting is not a crime, it is a survival strategy. The wilds are full of things that want to be forgotten. A traveller who forgets them may pass safely. A traveller who remembers must pay a toll. The toll is a story. The story is the memory. The memory is the trap.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The wilds are not empty. They are full of watchers—spirits, beasts, old things that do not have names because names are debts. The watchers do not interfere. They watch. They wait. They remember every footprint. When the footprints stop, the watchers move on.

Where do people go when they die? Into the land. The dead are not buried. They are left where they fell. The land absorbs them. The land grows a little richer. The land’s memory grows a little longer. The dead become the land’s memory. The memory is the wilds.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You leave an offering—a coin, a button, a lock of hair—at the place where the wrong was done. The land accepts or refuses. If the offering is gone by morning, you are forgiven. If it remains, you are not. If it has been moved, the land is testing you. The test is the walk. The walk is the apology.

What is the most important festival? The Turning of the Leaves (autumn). The wilds change colour. The colours are the land’s mood. Red is anger. Gold is warning. Brown is patience. Green is forgetfulness. This year, the leaves are red. The land is angry. Do not ask why.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The wilds have a heart. It is a stone, buried beneath the oldest oak. The stone is warm. The stone is beating. The stone is the land’s pulse. If the stone stops, the wilds die. If the wilds die, there is nothing left to remember. Nothing left to wait.

39.1 The Wilds — “Roads, Ruins, and Weather”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *The land walks when you don’t watch it, and the roads remember who bled on them.*

Claimant Chief (Elite): “These lands answer not to charters but to those who can read their signs and respect their moods. Authority here is earned one campfire at a time, by proving you understand the difference between claiming and belonging.”

Forager Child (Commoner): “The wilds don’t need your roads or your rules – they got their own ways of keeping score. Follow the cairns if you want to live, and always leave something behind to thank the land for letting you pass. Every hill hides a secret, and every hollow breathes.”

Genre / Mood: Hexcrawl wanderlust, ruin-haunted silence, weather as character.

Starting Location: A shelter hollow carved into a fallen giant’s ribcage, moss glowing faintly under starlight. A Forager Child offers a route-song: “The Bad Ground shifts, and the weather walks behind it. Sing with me, or walk alone.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Between towns and treaties lies the patience of the land. Old roads remember armies; cairns remember names no book keeps. In the Wilds, law thins to trail-marks and favors, and the weather keeps its own counsel. This is the country of the hexcrawl: a patchwork of hidden valleys, forgotten ruins, beast lairs, and the bones of failed settlements. No single authority rules here—instead, the land itself is the ledger, and every crossing writes a new line. Walk soft, read the wind, bargain with whatever still listens, and keep one eye on the horizon. The next hex may hold water, treasure, or teeth.

What you notice first: The silence after a bird stops singing. The way a cairn seems to have shifted since you passed it last. The smell of rain on dry stone, even when the sky is clear.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never sleep in a hollow that has soot on the ceiling without adding your own to the fire. The land knows the difference between a guest and a thief.

The Unfinished Map

The Wilds are not a route—they are a grid of secrets. Each day’s march opens a new page. Some hexes are empty: water, fuel, a safe place to sleep. Others hold lairs, ruins, shrines, or the remnants of old wars. The GM should key a handful of interesting places in advance, then let the cards populate the space between. Draw a card for each new leg; let the suit and rank whisper what you find. The land does not repeat itself, but it echoes.

(Crossing/Lookout/Old Road) Crossing point with ford/ice-span/stepping logs/dune saddle/reef shelf; lookout knoll with wind-carved marker; old road trace with cairns half-eaten by terrain.

Spades — Places (Hex Terrain)

2. **Crossing Point** — Ford, ice-span, stepping logs, dune saddle, reef shelf. *The crossing has a price: a stone, a story, or a moment of silence. The water hums when it's satisfied.*
3. **Lookout Knoll** — Tor, cliff, dune, ridge with wind-carved marker. *From here, you can see three hexes in clear weather—and one that shouldn't exist, flickering like a heat-shaped lie.*
4. **Old Road** — Trace with cairns and switchbacks half-eaten by terrain. *The cobbles are worn smooth by ghosts. They whisper directions at dusk. The directions are always true, but never complete.*
5. **Shelter Hollow** — Overhang, cave, root cellar; soot says “used lately.” *The soot is layered in thin, greasy rings. Someone has been coming here for a very long time. The hollow smells of wet fur and old secrets.*
6. **Water Source** — Spring, seep, fog net, snow pan, guarded by thorns or stone. *The water tastes of iron and old bargains. Drink deep, but leave a coin—copper for a safe draw, silver for a question answered.*
7. **Windbreak** — Rock ribs, lee of pines, reed-wall berm. *The windbreak smells of woodsmoke and wool. Someone camped here last night. Their fire is still warm.*
8. **Ruined Outpost** — Watchstack, wayside shrine, marker pile. *The ruin's flagstones are warm, as if a great beast sleeps beneath them. The air tastes of rust and thyme.*
9. **Bad Ground** — Sinkhole, bog crust, crevasse, loess slump. *The ground breathes—a slow, deep inhalation that lifts your heels. Step lightly or it will swallow you.*
10. **Gate Gully** — Pinch point between bluffs, dunes, or ice hummocks. *The gully has a name carved in the rock. The name changes every season. Carve yours, and you may never leave.*
- J **Boundary Row** — Totems, standing stones, prayer flags bent by weather. *The flags are faded. The last prayer was for rain—and it still hasn't come. The totems have grown moss in the shape of faces.*
- Q **Worksite** — Abandoned mine, quarry, logging camp, salt pan. *The tools are scattered, but none are rusted. Whoever left did not plan to return—or has not yet finished.*
- K **Signal Height** — Old fire-pit or mirror stand; smoke stains linger. *Light the fire, and someone will answer. Whether they are friend or foe is your risk. The smoke always smells of your childhood.*
- A **Trail Nexus** — Migratory, pack, or contraband paths knot here. *Three trails meet, but only two are on any map. The third belongs to the dead. Their footprints point the wrong way.*

(Guide/Warden/Caravan) Forager child with truer maps than yours; guide with three routes and one price (changes daily).

Hearts — People & Factions (Hex Denizens)

2. **Forager Child** — Goat-herd or berry-picker with truer maps than yours. *Their map is drawn on a scrap of bark. It shows a path that disappears at a standing stone. The stone is not on any other map.*
3. **Guide** — Three routes and one price (changes daily); navigation as negotiation. *Their price is never coin. It is a favor, a secret, or a night's watch. They will not tell you which until you arrive.*

4. **Warden Patrol** — Local badges, local laws, local patience; order as familiarity. *Their badge is a chipped sunburst. They serve a crown that no longer exists. The crown does not pay them. The land does.*
5. **Caravan Crew** — Drovers, porters, yarn-post hands trading speed for coin. *They know every shortcut and every ambush. They will share both—for a price. Their silence is purchased in stories.*
6. **Pilgrims** — Bound for a tucked-away shrine or stone; faith as a destination. *Their shrine has no name. The stone there is warm, and it answers questions poorly. It prefers to ask them.*
7. **Poachers** — Know every snare and shortcut; survival as expertise. *They wear the teeth of game wardens as necklaces. The game wardens are still alive. They are saving for a full set.*
8. **Hermit-Healer** — Dogs, geese, and opinions about weather; wisdom as isolation. *Their poultices smell of grave-moss. They work anyway. The dogs do not bark at strangers—they judge them.*
9. **Prospectors** — Salt, amber, iron, fungus; chasing rumors and glint. *Their claim is marked with a knot of red thread. Cross it, and they will shoot. The thread glows when a stranger’s foot touches it.*
10. **War-Band** — Reavers or “escorts,” depending on your purse; violence as commerce. *Their banner is a painted skull. The paint is from a dead comrade’s blood. They add a finger bone to the standard after every contract.*
- J **Monster-Hunter** — Rite-keeper wearing yesterday’s trophies; death as livelihood. *Their trophy is still warm. The monster’s mate is close behind. They are not running—they are leading.*
- Q **Quartermaster** — Ledgers first, hospitality second; supply as authority. *Their ledger is written in a code only they understand. The code is their life story. The margins are full of regrets.*
- K **Claimant Chief** — Papers and spears to match; legitimacy as force. *Their papers are stained with water and blood. Both are still wet. The water came from a spring they poisoned. The blood from the spring’s keeper.*
- A **The Stranger** — Spirit-touched nomad or emissary; rules bend near them. *They have no shadow. The ground does not remember their footprints. Their voice echoes twice—once for them, once for the land.*

(Weather/Doubleback/Prowlers) Weather turn with heat snap/cold snap/fog/dust; doubleback with tracks that loop; prowlers shadow with wolves/jackals/ghouls.

Clubs — Complications/Threats (Hex Hazards)

2. **Weather Turn** — Heat snap, cold snap, fog, dust; plans sag like wet leather. *The wind changes direction three times in an hour. Someone is watching. The air tastes of a season that hasn’t come yet.*
3. **Doubleback** — Tracks loop; the navigator swears the land moved underfoot. *Your own footprints face you. They were made yesterday—or tomorrow. The toes point toward a future you have not chosen.*
4. **Prowlers Shadow** — Wolves, jackals, ghouls, seals, ravens by night; hunt as a company. *Their eyes reflect no light. Their teeth do. They are patient. They have been following since*

the last hex. You are only now noticing.

5. **Route Blocked** — Deadfall, rockfall, dune shift, ice heave; the path as an obstacle. *The blockage was placed. The toolmarks are fresh. Whoever cleared this path did not want you to follow—or wanted you to take the other way.*
6. **Quarantine Sign** — Camp fever; wardens sniff your packs for death. *The sign is a ribbon tied in a figure-eight. Do not cross it. The ribbon is damp. It was tied recently. The wardens are still nearby.*
7. **Territorial Beast** — Charge, stampede, or swarm; your choice of which is wrong. *The beast's lair is nearby. You can smell it—old blood and older musk. The ground is warm. You are standing on its pantry.*
8. **Elemental Front** — Grassfire, peat-burn, canopy flare, blowing spindrift. *The fire moves against the wind. The wind is lying. The smoke writes a word in a language you almost understand. It is a warning.*
9. **Paper vs Spear** — Jurisdiction fight in the wilds stalls your day; law as argument. *Two officials, one road. Both have seals. Neither will show them. The seals are warm. They have been used recently—on death warrants.*
10. **Supply Pinch** — Water, fuel, or feed low; pick what starves first. *Your canteen is full. The water is from a source that dried up last year. You do not remember filling it. Someone did.*
- J **Pursuit** — Hunters or avengers follow; signs say “close.” *The tracks are one hour old. They are gaining. The hunters do not need to sleep. They have not slept for three days. Neither have you.*
- Q **Bad Omen** — Will-lights, taboo day, saint bells silent; locals refuse to move. *The omen is written in bird droppings on a milestone. It is still accurate. The birds are watching. They are waiting for you to ignore it.*
- K **General Alarm** — Levy, muster, evacuation; all tracks become checkpoints. *The alarm horn is cracked. It sounds like a scream. The scream is a name. The name is yours.*
- A **Catastrophe** — Flood, whiteout, sandstorm, lahar; clocks jump like frightened deer. *The catastrophe has a name. The land remembers it. The land is shouting it now. The sound is the same as a heartbeat. Yours.*

(**Cache/Pass/Favor**) Cache token for hidden food or fuel stash; right-of-way pass recognized by a named trail; warden's favor with an escort letter.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage (Hex Discoveries)

2. **Cache Token** — Key to a hidden food or fuel stash (once); preparation as power. *The token is a knucklebone. The stash is marked with a cairn that has one stone missing. The missing stone is the token.*
3. **Right-of-Pass** — Recognized marker for a named trail or crossing. *The marker is a notch carved in a milestone. The notch is shaped like a bird. The bird is an owl. The owl watches at dusk.*
4. **Warden's Favor** — Escort letter; “they're with us” as a shield. *The letter is stamped with a bell. The bell's clapper is missing. The absence of sound is the signature.*
5. **Weather Window** — Good forecast and a narrow gate to use it. *The window is a single hour at dawn. The birds will tell you when. They will stop singing. That is the signal.*

6. **Water Deed** — Lawful draw at a scarce source; necessity as a right. *The deed is a clay cup. Break it, and the spring will flow—once. The cup’s shards can be traded for another deed. There are nine shards.*
7. **Route Song** — A map scrap that actually works; knowledge as navigation. *The song has eight verses. The ninth is humming. The humming is the sound of the road itself. It changes with the weather.*
8. **Remount Hire** — Fresh legs or hulls waiting at a post; speed as a service. *The remounts have no names. They answer to whistles and bribes. They remember every rider. They do not forgive cruelty.*
9. **Truce Cord** — Taboo exemption at a site (one scene); peace as a thread. *The cord is braided from wool and ash. Burn it to invoke the truce. The ash must be from the same fire that warmed the truce.*
10. **Toll Waiver** — A ferry, bridge, or reef gate honors this chit; passage as paper. *The chit is a dried leaf. The toll-keeper will not touch it. They will nod and wave you through. They will not speak.*
- J **Rescue Debt** — Locals owe you (or you owe them); trade for labor or intel. *The debt is carved on a tally stick. Break it when the favor is done. The stick will not burn. It will only splinter.*
- Q **Private Audience** — A keeper, shrine-warden, or spirit of the place hears you alone. *The audience is held at midnight. The spirit wears your face. It asks only one question. You will answer truthfully.*
- K **Road Commission** — Temporary authority over a stretch of wilds. *The commission is a whistle. Blow it, and the land will listen—once. The whistle is carved from a bone that was never alive.*
- A **Earth’s Exception** — One temporary rule-bend (cross during a storm, pass uncounted, beasts ignore you). *The exception is a secret. The land will forget it as soon as you use it. You will remember it every night for a year.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (cache/pass/favor) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, add a lingering omen of the land (a smell on the wind, a sound that carries too far, tracks that shift) that you can echo in later scenes.

Travel at a Glance (Fast Loose)

A journey through the Wilds is a series of choices, not a checklist. Before each leg (a day, a stretch of road, a single hex), the party picks two priorities from **Speed**, **Stealth**, **Safety**, **Survey**. Those become your edge; the others become vulnerabilities. The GM then frames a single roll based on the terrain and the weather’s mood (see *Weather Whims*, below). Success means you find what you sought; a mixed result trades progress for a cost; a miss throws a complication from the *Clubs* table onto the path.

Weather Whims (d6, one per leg)

1. *Glass-clear* – long sight, easy navigation. +1 to Survey actions.
2. *Low fog* – stealth advantage, speed suffers. +1 to Stealth, –1 to Speed.
3. *Trickle rain* – tracks wash, cold bites. First navigation or tracking roll at –1 die.
4. *Dry cold / heat* – resources drain faster. Mark +1 supply strain at end of leg.
5. *Shifting wind* – smoke and scent lie. Reroll one die on a weather-related check, but the GM may bank 1 SB.
6. *Omen sky* (aurora, sun-dog, three moons) – the land is listening. The GM may ask one player to answer a single question about the party's future.

Making Camp When you stop, choose one *boon* and accept one *risk*:

- **Boon:** heal a piece of gear; clear 1 Fatigue; scout tomorrow's weather; share a story with a road spirit (gain a *Truce Cord*).
- **Risk:** thin shelter (next weather hits harder); smoky fire (attracts prowlers); exposed approach (ambush more likely); hungry neighbors (locals or beasts appear).

A road spirit's favour requires a small offering—a pinch of salt, a dropped coin, a whispered truth. Be polite.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Bitter Root:** Daughters of the Cord use certain shelter hollows as waystations. A renegade Sister has hidden a Hollowed in a ruined outpost; the child has not moved in weeks.
- **The Threshold Compendium:** Old Roads are Class II Anchor sites—ghosts of imperial surveyors still measure the miles. Saikou Ira would leave a silver coin at every milestone.
- **Malachai, the Chained Angel:** A silver coin that never spends lies at the bottom of every spring. Take it, and the water will never run dry—but the spring will remember your face.
- **The Grey Wanderer's Grimoire:** Wilds psions are called "Stone-Listeners." They hear the memory of old trails. Claimant chiefs pay well for their services—and dispose of those who hear too much.
- **The Ninth:** In any Wilds scene, the ninth cairn you pass in a day will be warm. Leave an offering, or the path will forget you.

Wilderness Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Cairn:** Crumble a crust at a boundary stone. Ignore the first *Bad Ground* penalty.
- **Knot the Trail:** Tie a single knot in a piece of grass at a crossing. Cancel *Doubleback* or take –1 die on your next navigation roll (your choice).
- **Name to the Spring:** Whisper a dead traveler's name into a water source. Gain +1 Effect when foraging this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the land.

Patronage & Power

In the Wilds, power flows through knowledge of the land, the ability to navigate without formal authority, and the careful cultivation of local relationships. True authority comes from understanding weather patterns, reading tracks, and maintaining the favor of both human inhabitants and the spirits of place. Those who can provide safe passage, find water in dry times, or mediate between conflicting claims hold the most influence.

For the GM: Patronage in the Wilds revolves around practical knowledge, local customs, and the ability to provide essential services like navigation, shelter, and supply. Rewards often take the form of tokens, passes, and local knowledge that can be leveraged into greater safety and efficiency. To emphasise the hexcrawl feel:

- Key 6–10 interesting hexes before the session, then use the generator to fill the rest.
- Let the party discover new routes, short cuts, and hidden lairs through successful scouting or lucky finds.
- Use the *Roads Move*, *Weather Wakes*, and *Local Resentment* clocks (from the hexcrawl procedures) to create a living, reactive wilderness—or simply let the cards speak.
- Offer Diamonds as “exploration rewards” that unlock new options (a cache token, a safe passage, a local ally).

In the Wilds, your skill is your standing, and your standing determines whether you survive or perish.

Terrain Stock (d20)

Roll or choose a striking detail to dress a hex.

1. Fresh ash on an old fire ring; prints circle *around* it.
2. Boundary totems toppled but re-stack themselves if watched politely.
3. Broken wagon with salt-vein crystals growing through spokes.
4. Singing culvert; echo names the boldest listener wrongly.
5. Weather bell hung in a pine; tolling swaps rain and wind.
6. Cairn with a copper coin balanced on edge; don’t breathe hard.
7. Fence of antlers pointing uphill; follow and skip one *Bad Ground*.
8. Mummified pack-beast wearing a courier’s braid; letter hums.
9. Pebble mosaic of an old levy call; stepping it summons wardens.
10. Fossil rib arch; shelter under it and dream of tomorrow’s route.
11. Abandoned hunter’s cache; choice of food or rumor, not both.
12. Mirror-puddle; shows last night’s sky whatever the hour.
13. Rope bridge made of prayer knots; one is freshly cut.
14. Scare-stakes dressed in saltcloth; something big respects them.
15. Stone with bite-marks; taste iron and remember a shortcut.
16. Old road mile-post defaced into a saint; offerings still fresh.
17. Thistle patch buzzing with coin-flies; feed them copper for safe passage.
18. Fallen giant’s footprint now a pond; frogs chant a route-song.
19. Soot writing on cliff: *Storm at Second Bell*. It’s right.

20. Hollow tree full of carved names; the newest is yours.

Lair Seeds (One-Page Crawls)

d12 quick lair hooks. Each can be a single session's focus.

1. **Fen Clockworks** — Bog-gears turn under peat; each tooth a drowned oath.
2. **Dry River Gallery** — Petroglyphs re-arrange at dusk; wrong reading summons bramble knights.
3. **Ice-Well Vault** — Stairs drilled through permafrost; breath blooms frost-runes that answer questions badly.
4. **Sunken Forum** — Pillars knee-deep in silt; rust moths nest in the rostrum.
5. **Pilgrim Kilns** — Charcoal mounds hike on stilt roots at night; a hermit-healer bargains weather for charcoal.
6. **Hanging Salt Chapel** — White stalactites ring like bells; grave-eels coil in the font.
7. **Thorn Maze Mill** — Waterwheel turns without water; phase panthers pace the sluice.
8. **Brewer's Hollow** — Barrels of wind; decant a gale or drink a calm.
9. **Antler Archive** — Ledger carved on horn; theft awakens the cairn-wights' accountant.
10. **Black Lantern Mines** — Lantern-eyes nest like bats; light buys silence, darkness buys passage.
11. **Stormbone Spire** — Vertebrae tower; earth-sharks circle beneath like sharks in sand.
12. **Amber Orchard** — Trees fossilised mid-sway; trapped thunderflies grant *Weather Window* when freed.

Wilderness Bestiary

A palette of strange creatures, each with *signs* (what you notice before it sees you) and a *hook* (how to engage or avoid).

- **Earth-Sharks** — Burrow beneath loess and tundra; dorsal ridges like plowshares. *Signs:* furrows that breathe; pebbles rattle. *Hook:* lure with drumbeats or goat bells.
- **Phase Panthers** — Shadow-striped cats that step between gusts. *Signs:* pawprints offset from themselves. *Hook:* mirrored water or bell-silver disrupts the blink.
- **Rust Moths** — Swarms that taste iron memory. *Signs:* lacework mail; pitted nails. *Hook:* feed them old keys; they ignore fresh steel.
- **Lichen-Bears** — Moss-matted ursines with rock-teeth. *Signs:* clawed bark with green scabs. *Hook:* smoke of juniper calms; salt enrages.
- **Wind Drakes** — Rib-thin sky-serpents that ride fronts. *Signs:* shed vanes; feathers like glass. *Hook:* whistle back the storm to ground them.
- **Ooze-Remnants** — Alchemical slough from an old field lab. *Signs:* boot-holes rounded smooth. *Hook:* wood ash firms them; vinegar makes them sprint.
- **Fell Harts** — Antlered shades that herd the living toward cliffs. *Signs:* hoofprints that don't compress soil. *Hook:* speak a hunter's apology while walking backward.
- **Cairn-Wights** — Stone-stack custodians; patient as frost. *Signs:* pebbles rearranged around your fire. *Hook:* rebuild the stack correctly; they serve until dawn.
- **Thundertusks** — Boars that store lightning in tusk-veins. *Signs:* fused sand beads; singed roots. *Hook:* ground your spear; throw shadow to draw the strike.

- **Lantern-Eyes** — Floating orbs of watchlight rumor; jealous of secrets. *Signs:* daylight in ravines at midnight. *Hook:* offer a whispered truth; they part like reeds.
- **Grave-Eels** — Burrow through barrow loam; taste names. *Signs:* sinking turf over old wars. *Hook:* sing lineage or throw false names to mislead.
- **Bramble Knights** — Empty helms grown through with thorn; patrol old borders. *Signs:* briar in boot-grease. *Hook:* present a hedge-blessing; they escort instead of impale.

Strange Finds (d10)

When you discover a hidden cache or an ancient hoard, roll or pick:

1. **Route-stones** that warm near true north.
2. **Weather-bell clapper** that tolls only for lightning.
3. **Trail-right knot** dyed in berry law; locals honour it once.
4. **Salt-vein pick** that cuts oozes like cloth.
5. **Glass feather**; break to call a wind drake for one pass.
6. **Ledger leaf** waterproofed with eel-fat; ink never runs, words drift.
7. **Thorn sigil** that bramble knights read as parley.
8. **Coin-fly cocoon**; hatch it for one honest guide to the nearest water.
9. **Bone flute** that calls earth-sharks to circle elsewhere.
10. **Lantern-eye husk**; squeeze for daylight the length of a camp prayer.

Omens & Signs

The land speaks. Use these when the party pauses or when the GM needs a portent.

Sky Signs (d8)

1. sun-dog
2. mare's tails
3. anvil cloud faces the wrong way
4. silent birds
5. far thunder without storm
6. moon with halo
7. ash scent on clear air
8. stars “shiver”

Ground Signs (d8)

1. cairn with new pebble
2. boot prints that end at rock
3. butchered game left neat
4. snapped twig at head height
5. ash under wet moss
6. ward-knot cut
7. trail beads on shrub

- 8. a single coin on a stone

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **wardens or local hunters**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **prowlers or caravan guards**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or claimants**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favorable weather**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Guide or warden patrol** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **weather shift or route blockage**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **war-band or territorial beast** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **wardens, war-bands, or prowlers** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **weather turns/catastrophe strikes/quarantine declared**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **Claimant chief, quartermaster, or The Stranger** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **weather shifts/blockage clears/catastrophe hits**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Wilds (Weather):** Conditions shift without warning, storms arrive early, calm turns to chaos.
- **Wilds (Navigation):** Trails reroute mid-journey, landmarks disappear, guides demand additional payment.
- **Wilds (Local Customs):** Spirits demand tribute, territorial beasts become aggressive, local laws change with the terrain.

Fast reskin palette**Forest**

swap dunes→deadfall, spindrift→canopy flare, prowlers→boar/wolves; water = spring/stream.

Desert

swap bog→salt pan, fog→dust, shelter = overhang/wadi; water = seep/fog net.

Tundra/Ice

swap dune shift→ice heave, fire→spindrift, boats→sleds; prowlers = bears/wolves.

Coast/Isles

crossings = reef shelves, prowlers = seals/raiders, alarms = harbor booms; fuel = driftwood.

Swamp/Fen

crossings = corduroy/log causeways, bad ground = peat crust, prowlers = gators/leeches.

Highlands

crossings = cols and scree traverses, alarms = beacon chains, prowlers = cats/eagles.

Chapter 40

Dungeons

Living Infrastructure.

Beneath the surface, ancient places breathe with mechanical lungs and dream electric dreams. The walls remember every footfall; the air carries whispers of forgotten conversations. The Edgewalker believes dungeons are infrastructure. The prisoners believe they are hungry. Both are correct.

I am a Scholar-Prisoner. The walls here have a memory like old parchment—they remember every scream, every spell, every drop of blood spilled on the stones. And sometimes, when the air’s just right, they whisper it back to you. The dungeon listens. The question is whether it learns. I have been here for nine years. I have heard it learning. It started with single words. Then sentences. Now it speaks in paragraphs. Last week, it finished my thoughts before I did.

Dungeons are not ruins—they are systems. Ventilation shafts that breathe, water channels that pulse, doors that open and close without any hand to move them. The Aeler built many of them; the Covenant sealed others; the Sidhi mined a few; and some were never built at all. They grew. Like fungus in the dark. Like a story told too many times. Like a debt that compounds.

Never ignore a door that opens when you’re not looking. The dungeon is offering you a choice. Refuse, and the next door may not open at all. Accept, and the door may lead to a room that was always there, waiting for someone to finally walk through. The room has been waiting for nine thousand years. It is not tired of waiting.

— *The Dungeon’s Architect, whose plans are written in a language no one speaks and whose signature is a thumbprint that could be anyone’s*

The Almanac of Ordinary Days

What do people eat for breakfast? Fungus bread and cave water—the fungus grows on the walls, the water drips from the ceiling. Both taste of stone. Both are all there is.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To count footsteps. Dungeon children are taught the eight sounds of the deep: Drip, Creak, Groan, Whisper, Scrape, Echo, Silence, and the ninth—the sound of the dungeon's own heartbeat. The heartbeat is a door opening. The door is always behind you.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their shadow. Dungeon shadows are long, even when the light is bright. A stranger whose shadow is too short has been here too long. A stranger whose shadow moves independently has been touched by the deep. A stranger with no shadow is not a stranger. They are the dungeon's guest. The dungeon never lets guests leave.

What is the most common crime? Map-making—but map-making is not a crime, it is a heresy. The dungeon does not want to be mapped. The dungeon changes its corridors when it feels watched. A map that is accurate at dawn is a lie by dusk. The lie is the map-maker's fault. The punishment is to walk the lie until it becomes true.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The dungeon is not a place. It is a creature—a sleeping thing that dreamed itself into stone. The corridors are its veins. The chambers are its organs. The prisoners are its thoughts. The thoughts are not its own.

Where do people go when they die? Into the walls. The dead are not buried. Their bones are ground into mortar and used to patch the cracks. The cracks always reappear. The dead are never finished being used.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You offer a memory—a true one, witnessed by the dungeon itself. The dungeon accepts the memory. The memory is added to the walls. The walls whisper it back to you when you sleep. The whisper is the apology. The apology never ends.

What is the most important festival? The Turning of the Keys (whenever the dungeon decides). The locks are changed. The prisoners are moved. The corridors are rearranged. The festival has no date, no warning, no end. It is happening now. You did not notice. That is the point.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The dungeon's architect is still alive. They are sealed in the lowest chamber, kept alive by the dungeon's own will. The dungeon does not want to be alone. The architect is the dungeon's only friend. The architect has not spoken in nine centuries. The dungeon does not need words.

40.1 Dungeon — “Living Infrastructure”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *The walls remember. The echoes answer. The architecture chooses.*

Dungeon’s Creator (Elite): “I built more than walls and corridors – I crafted a living symphony of stone and shadow, where every passage breathes and every chamber remembers. The structure itself is the true inhabitant.”

Scholar-Prisoner (Commoner): “The walls here got a memory like old parchment – they remember every scream, every spell, every drop of blood spilled on the stones. And sometimes, when the air’s just right, they whisper it back to you. The dungeon listens. The question is whether it learns.”

Genre / Mood: Living architecture, ecological horror, sentient dungeon, community of exiles.

Starting Location: A spiral stairwell deep beneath a forgotten citadel, pulsing with a heartbeat not entirely mechanical. The steps hum underfoot. A Forgotten Custodian keys a door that wasn’t there yesterday. “The Heart Chamber hungers. Will you feed it – or be fed?”

Theme & Atmosphere

Beneath the surface, ancient places breathe with mechanical lungs and dream electric dreams. Dungeons are not merely ruins but living systems – vascular networks of stone and shadow where every corridor hums with purpose and every chamber holds its own hungry logic. The walls remember every footfall, the air carries whispers of forgotten conversations, and the very architecture shifts like a sleeper turning in bed. Here, the boundary between structure and organism blurs, and those who would plunder its secrets must first learn to speak its language of echoes, scents, and subtle pressures.

What you notice first: The wet stone smell of a place that sweats. The distant grinding of gears that should have seized centuries ago. The way your footsteps echo back with an extra beat – like someone is following, or catching up.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never ignore a door that opens when you’re not looking. The dungeon is offering you a choice. Refuse, and the next door may not open at all.

The Living Hierarchy: Factions of the Deep

Dungeons are not empty. They host a fragile ecology of factions, each with its own relationship to the site’s “consciousness.” A site’s dominant faction determines its mood; a dungeon ruled by *Custodians* may be melancholic and negotiable, while one overrun by *Awakened Organs* is actively predatory.

- **Custodians (Forgotten Caretakers)** – The original stewards, now half-mad or ghostly. They maintain the dungeon’s rhythms (polishing thresholds, oiling traps) and may trade safe passage for a **memory** or a **promise**. *Clocks:* CUSTODIAN PATIENCE [4], MAINTENANCE ROUNDS [6].
- **Invaders (Plunderers & Refugees)** – Living interlopers: mercenary remnants, cult initiates, refugee families. They exploit the dungeon’s resources while trying to avoid its attention. Their presence raises *Dungeon Awareness (Heat)*. *Clocks:* INVADER DESPERATION [4], RIVAL CLAIM [6].

- **Awakened Organs (The Dungeon’s Will)** – Manifestations of the site’s internal systems: the *Heart Chamber*, the *Digestive Array*, the *Ledger Lich*. They act as immune responses or as twisted echoes of the original purpose. *Clocks: ORGAN HUNGER [4], SYSTEM REBOOT [6]*.
- **Wild Symbiotes (Echoes & Aberrations)** – Creatures that evolved within the living infrastructure: stone-wights, memory eels, gravity ticks. They are neither friendly nor hostile – they simply follow the dungeon’s new rules. *Clocks: SWARM TIDE [4], SYMBIOTIC ACCORD [6]*.

Most expeditions will feature two or three of these factions in uneasy balance. A dungeon with predatory *Awakened Organs* and desperate *Invaders* is a very different crawl than one haunted by melancholic *Custodians* and curious *Wild Symbiotes*.

Spades — Places

2. **Cracked Gallery** — Hairline faults veined with damp; grit ticks from the ceiling like a slow clock. ‘[OMEN]’ *The ticking is a language. It is counting the number of intruders.*
 3. **Sunken Vestibule** — Waist-deep water glazed with oil rainbows; cold leeches the knees, something brushes past. ‘[HAZARD]’ *The water has a pulse. It is not yours.*
 4. **Vaulted Refectory** — Tables laid for a meal gone to dust; goblets taste faintly of iron when breathed upon. ‘[MEMORY]’ *The iron is blood – old, dried, and patient.*
 5. **Spiral Stairwell** — Steps cupped by centuries; one cough ricochets down into a throat not your own. ‘[THRESHOLD]’ *The throat is the dungeon’s. The cough is an answer.*
 6. **Collapsed Observatory** — Stars stare through ribs of broken dome; wind brings ash that smears like soot. ‘[MYSTERY]’ *The stars are not real. The dungeon remembers the sky and shows it wrong.*
 7. **Armory Alcove** — Weapon shadows longer than the racks; a glass-front case fogs from the inside. ‘[OMEN]’ *The fog has a shape. The shape is a hand.*
 8. **Chained Sanctuary** — Prayer-niches and iron hooks; stone bruised where something strained to leave. ‘[DEATH]’ *The chains are warm. Something wore them recently.*
 9. **Mirror Hall** — Reflections lag by a heartbeat; one pane shows you older, another shows you missing. ‘[TRUTH]’ *The missing reflection is ahead of you. It will wait.*
 10. **Garden of Stone** — Statues mid-breath; a chisel-mark still weeps dust as if freshly struck. ‘[TRAP]’ *The dust is from the statues. They are not statues. They are frozen.*
- J **Throne of Echoes** — A single block worn satin-smooth; sit and your name returns in a stranger’s verdict. ‘[JUSTICE]’ *The verdict is from a trial you never attended. The jury is the dungeon.*
- Q **Vault of Whispers** — Books exhale when opened; vowels crawl up the spine and into the ear. ‘[MEMORY]’ *The books are not books. They are memory. They eat yours to grow.*
- K **Chamber of Seasons** — Air flips from pollen-sweet to knife-cold; breath ghosts, sweat beads, leaves skitter. ‘[WEATHER]’ *The seasons are the dungeon’s moods. Today it is spring. Tomorrow, winter without end.*
- A **The Heart Chamber** — Mortar smells like blood, light like fever; floor hums to your pulse then sets its own. ‘[BOSS]’ *The pulse is not your own after the third beat.*

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Forgotten Custodian** — Keys like teeth on a ring; polishes thresholds no one crosses. ‘[COMMUNITY]’ *He has forgotten why he polishes. The threshold remembers.*
3. **Scholar-Prisoner** — Ink-stained nails, hollow cheeks; knows which lies the walls prefer. ‘[KNOWLEDGE]’ *The walls prefer lies that are almost true. She tells them often.*
4. **Symbiotic Colony** — Many mouths, one hunger; bargains in warmth, hoards salt. ‘[CURIOSITY]’ *The mouths whisper in chorus. Their voices are the dungeon’s breath.*
5. **Cursed Noble** — Velvet rotted to lace; voice drags like chain, eyes beg for ending. ‘[TRAGEDY]’ *The curse is the dungeon’s favor. He has worn it too long.*
6. **Mercenary Remnant** — Dried mud, wet fear; map carved into forearm with a dinner knife. ‘[SURVIVAL]’ *The map is accurate – for now. The dungeon moves while he sleeps.*
7. **Bound Guardian** — Filigree of wards across stone skin; obeys the letter, hears the spirit. ‘[JUSTICE]’ *The spirit is the dungeon’s. The letter is a suggestion.*
8. **Cult Initiate** — Pupil-widened zeal; speaks passwords like prayers, prayers like debts. ‘[MYSTERY]’ *The debt is to a god that does not answer. The dungeon answers instead.*
9. **Refugee Family** — Boot-scrapes under cots; clutch charms that grow warm when danger nears. ‘[COMMUNITY]’ *The charms are stones from the garden. The statues are their ancestors.*
10. **Merchant of Curiosities** — Breath like cloves and rust; sells certainty bottled and slightly used. ‘[TRADE]’ *The certainty is a lie. The bottle is genuine.*
- J **Ascended Vermin** — Crown of wire, court of nests; taxes crumbs, enforces with a thousand eyes. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The eyes are not all vermin. Some are the dungeon’s.*
- Q **Fallen Hero’s Shade** — Armor of frost, sword of grievance; wants one last right choice. ‘[TRAGEDY]’ *The right choice is the one that frees her. The dungeon disagrees.*
- K **Dungeon’s Creator** — Architect’s hands cracked with mortar; still moving rooms the way others move chess. ‘[LEGEND]’ *He does not remember the Heart Chamber. The Heart Chamber remembers him.*
- A **The Collective Consciousness** — Voices braided into one intention; your thoughts return carrying fingerprints. ‘[BOSS]’ *The fingerprints are yours. The thoughts are the dungeon’s.*

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Shifting Walls** — Mortar pops like knuckles; corridors narrow behind you with polite insistence. ‘[TRAP]’ *The insistence is the dungeon’s. It wants you to stay.*
3. **Hungering Dark** — Wicks gutter blue; shadows lip the flame and swallow the heat first. ‘[FEAR]’ *The dark has weight. It leans.*
4. **Memory Fog** — Cool on the gums, sweet on the tongue; you “recall” a door that never was. ‘[MEMORY]’ *The door is real. The memory is the dungeon’s.*
5. **Gravity Wells** — Knees turn to iron; dropped coins smack floor like thrown knives. ‘[HAZARD]’ *The coins are the dungeon’s now. It will spend them later.*
6. **Temporal Echoes** — Footfalls not yours keep pace; a conversation repeats with one word wrong. ‘[OMEN]’ *The wrong word is a clue. The clue is a trap.*

7. **Corrosive Atmosphere** — Leather slimes, metal freckles; breathe shallow or taste copper. ‘[HAZARD]’ *The copper is blood. The blood is the dungeon’s offering.*
8. **Phantom Locks** — Doors exist when watched sidelong; they prefer particular hands and hours. ‘[TRAP]’ *The hands are yours. The hours are the dungeon’s.*
9. **Borrowed Time** — Hair whitens at the tips; hunger leaps ahead of the clock. ‘[PRESSURE]’ *The time will be returned. The interest is your memory.*
10. **Infectious Transformation** — Fingertips grain to stone, pupils catch light like a cat’s; urges shift. ‘[TRANSFORMATION]’ *The urge is to stay. The garden needs new statues.*
- J **Reality Anchor Points** — Candles burn sideways, water beads uphill; spells itch in the teeth. ‘[MAGIC]’ *The itch is the dungeon laughing.*
- Q **The Dungeon’s Will** — Maps argue with themselves; paths rephrase your intentions. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The path is the dungeon’s intention. Your intention is a suggestion.*
- K **Cascading Failure** — A cracked lintel sighs and the far cistern answers; systems talk in groans. ‘[DISASTER]’ *The groans are a warning. The warning is too late.*
- A **The Price of Passage** — Each shortcut salts your tongue with loss; the house keeps its ledger. ‘[PRICE]’ *The ledger is the dungeon’s. The loss is yours.*

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Wayfinder Compass** — Needle twitches toward safety like a frightened animal; steadies if you hum. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The humming must be in tune with the dungeon’s breath. The breath changes.*
3. **Key of Echoes** — Warms in the palm when a door remembers being opened. ‘[ACCESS]’ *The door’s memory is not yours. It remembers a different key.*
4. **Lantern of Clarity** — Light outlines hollows in the world; truths show up as clean edges. ‘[TRUTH]’ *The truths are sharp. They cut if you look too long.*
5. **Cloak of Passage** — Hem sips through stone or mist; leaves damp prints on the far side. ‘[STEALTH]’ *The prints are the dungeon’s. It will follow.*
6. **Tome of Convenient Knowledge** — Pages grow new margins; ink creeps to answer the question you’re afraid to ask. ‘[KNOWLEDGE]’ *The answer is a lie. The lie is useful.*
7. **Ration of Sustenance** — Bread that tastes like last winter; settles the stomach, quiets the shakes. ‘[SURVIVAL]’ *Last winter was in the dungeon. The bread was grown in the garden.*
8. **Focus Crystal** — Thrum matches your breath; thoughts align the way teeth fit. ‘[MAGIC]’ *The breath is the dungeon’s after the third inhale.*
9. **Token of Safe Return** — Thread around a wrist; tugs once when it’s time to flee. ‘[PROTECTION]’ *The tug is the dungeon’s mercy. It does not offer twice.*
10. **Map that Grows** — Charcoal blooms corridors as you walk; tiny figures drift where things currently are. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The figures are the dungeon’s. They are not always accurate.*
- J **Shield of Temporary Immunity** — Hazards strike sparks and spend themselves like rain on slate. ‘[PROTECTION]’ *The immunity is borrowed. The dungeon will ask for it back.*
- Q **Crown of Momentary Authority** — Creatures blink, recognize a crest they cannot name, and obey. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The crest is the dungeon’s. The obedience is a misunderstanding.*
- K **Forge of Quick Repair** — Heat like a heartbeat; fractured gear exhales and remembers its shape. ‘[CRAFT]’ *The memory is the dungeon’s. The gear will remember you, too.*

A **The Dungeon’s Blessing** — A knack that lingers in the bones; doors like you now, as do certain hungers. ‘[BOON]’ *The hungers are the dungeon’s appetites. They like you very much.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (safeties/knowledge/immunities) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **living infrastructure** – walls shift, voices repeat your plans, light returns redder.

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **Living Infrastructure:** Fluids, heat, dust, and sound move like blood – follow the drafts, the drips, the echoes to find *organs*: cisterns, chimneys, nerve-halls.
- **Scent Ledger:** Track smells (ozone, wet lime, tallow, old wine); they foretell hazards and factions before you see them. A successful Wits + Survival (DV 3) reveals one hidden feature of the next chamber.
- **Echo Etiquette:** Some rooms reward whispers and punish shouts; others demand a spoken price to cross. Listen first. A character who spends a full exchange listening may ask one yes/no question about the room’s “mood” (GM answers truthfully).
- **Community of Exiles:** The dungeon’s refugee factions (Invaders, Custodians) can be bartered with using **memories** or **secrets** instead of coin. A memory of warmth buys a night’s shelter; a secret about the surface buys a guide through a dangerous junction.
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
 - **The Foundation Stone** – The Sealed Gate. *The keystone that remembers every weight placed upon it.*
 - **The Echo-Singer** – The Witness. *The voice that repeats every promise whispered in the dark.*
 - **The Pressure Below** – Khemesh. *The slow hunger of stone, the patience of the deep.*
 - **The Circuit** – Clockwork Monad. *The dungeon’s dreaming nervous system, always optimizing, always watching.*

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Bitter Root:** Daughters of the Cord sometimes serve as custodians, using the dungeon’s memory to collect debts from the living. A renegade Sister hides in the Sunken Vestibule, trying to cut her cord from a bound guardian’s oath.
- **Malachai, the Chained Angel:** A silver coin that never spends appears in the Vault of Whispers. Take it, and the books will answer any question – but the coin will reappear in your pocket each dawn, heavier.
- **The Grey Wanderer’s Grimoire:** Dungeon psions are called “Echo-Readers.” They hear the whispers of past explorers and can reroute a corridor once per expedition by humming the right frequency.

- **The Threshold Compendium:** The Throne of Echoes is a Class III Anchor – the ghost of a judge who died mid-trial. Saikou Ira would leave a coin on the seat and ask for a verdict. The verdict is always a riddle.
- **The Ninth:** In any dungeon scene, the ninth door you open in a row will lead to a place that was not on your map. The wise open eight, then retrace their steps. Those who open the ninth find a shortcut – and a debt.

Dungeon Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Threshold:** Crumble a crust at the base of a door. Ignore the first *Shifting Walls* penalty. '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Knot the Echo:** Tie a single knot in a piece of string and hang it from a lintel. Cancel *Temporal Echoes* or take –1 die on your next navigation roll (your choice). '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Name to the Dark:** Whisper a dead explorer's name into a shadow. Gain +1 Effect when searching for hidden passages this scene, but mark *Attention* from the dungeon. '[SUPERSTITION]'

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **dungeon dwellers or factions**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **creatures or echoes**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or spirits**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or resources**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **The dungeon's will** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **shifting architecture**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **minor entity or faction member** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **dungeon entities or guardians** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes – **trap springs/route blocked/ally turns**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **The Dungeon's Creator or Collective Consciousness** intervenes.

- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically – **walls shift/floor collapses/air thickens**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice – **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Living Infrastructure (1–2 SB):** Corridors whisper your name, reflections blink slower, scent trails loop back.
- **Echo Etiquette (1–3 SB):** Shouts echo thrice, silence answers back, doors ask riddles.
- **Cascading Failure (1–2 SB):** One crack becomes many, water flows uphill, lights dim in sequence.

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Wits + Survival):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Dust Cloud*.
- **Cut the Echo (Presence + Lore):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a Wayfinder Compass is in your possession, +1 die.
- **Weather the Collapse (Body + Athletics):** On a hit in *Cascading Failure*, you pick who escapes first; on a miss, the GM does.

Boss Seeds (Living Infrastructure)

- **The Miscount-King (Nine Errors)** – *Phases:* Bell-Lines Severed → Orchestrated Miscount → Shrine Coup. *Cracks:* re-tie a bell-line, expose a false count, survive a night at the forgotten bell.
- **The Drowned Counter (Spirit of the Ninth Tide)** – *Phases:* Waves Miscounted → Procession of Empty Shrines → Bell-Baptism of a Warden. *Cracks:* relic tide-bead, survivor testimony, the ninth bell refusing to ring.

Plug-in Expedition Layer

- **Universal Clocks (drop into any site):**
 - *Dungeon Awareness (Heat)* [10]: rises on loud actions, light spillage, blood, or haste. At 4/7/10, the Keeper may promote Clubs results one step.
 - *Structure Stress* [6/8]: ticks on blasts, overloading mechanisms, or ignored warnings; when full, trigger *Cascading Failure*.
 - *Expedition Supply:* three pooled tracks – *Light* [4], *Air* [4] (if sealed), *Load* [4] (fatigue/overburden). Each empty track worsens Position for relevant actions until refreshed.
- **Safe Route Tokens:** On a strong success mapping/scouting, issue a *Safe Route* token. Spend to bypass one known hazard in that segment or to negate a single “Position Lost” SB.
- **Retreat & Seal:** When withdrawing, a PC may *seal the way* (chalk, wedges, wards). Clear 1 Heat, but tick *Structure Stress* or spawn a *Phantom Lock* in that lane.

Interfaces & Entanglements (use what fits your campaign)

- **Surface Stakeholders:** *Scavenger Union, Shrinekeepers, Civic Factors*. Register finds to bank a *Finder's Favor* – spend to reduce one sell-off DV; skipping registration adds a “Disputed Claim” tag to the haul.
- **Internal Politics:** *Custodians, Bound Guardians, Refugee Enclaves*. Parley with proper tokens (salt, names, warmth) to downgrade the next Clubs result in their turf.
- **Patron Hooks (optional):**
 - **The Sealed Gate:** Chalk lines cancel one intrusion for a scene; breaking them adds 1 Heat.
 - **Lunara:** Moon-silver reveals one hidden organ (cistern, nerve-hall); mark Exposure +1.
 - **The Traveler:** Waymarks let you finish one travel tick after a room clear.
 - **Varnek Karn:** Naming the dead here clears 1 *Awareness* but starts a *Ledger Attention* [4].
 - **Maelstraëus:** Trade salvage tags at “fair rate” once/expedition; skewed trades create a *Karmic Debt* [6].

Keys, Locks, & Doors (drop-in schema)

- **Door Attitudes:** *Literal* (wants the right key), *Courteous* (opens to the right words), *Hungry* (takes a toll), *Shy* (hates crowds), *Proud* (demands ceremony).
- **Key Types:** *Mechanical* (wards/picks), *Mnemonic* (password, name), *Somatic* (gesture, breath), *Affective* (emotion offered), *Sacrificial* (blood, time, memory).
- **Rule of Two:** Each important barrier recognizes two different key types; learning either grants +1 Effect to breach or parley with it.

Salvage, Haul, & Conversion

- **Salvage Tags:** *Stable* (safe to carry), *Volatile* (ticks Stress on jostle), *Bound* (linked to site), *Loud* (adds Heat when moved), *Forbidden* (attracts factions).
- **Convert on Exit (choose one):** trade haul for a *Map that Grows* upgrade, a *Pass-Key Writ* (one automatic door compliance), or *Market Credit* (reduce next sell-off complication).

Table Prompts (d6 each, fast prep)

Echo Questions

1. What does the room want?
2. Who set this alarm?
3. What was repaired last?
4. Where does the draft go?
5. What memory sticks here?
6. What price opens the way?

Find the Organ

1. Cistern (fluid)
2. Bell-shaft (signal)
3. Heat lung (thermal)
4. Nerve-hall (control)
5. Waste sluice (decay)
6. Relay shrine (intent)

Procedures at the Door (one-minute read-aloud checklist)

1. **Sense:** Name two smells; ask which grew stronger.
2. **Listen:** Offer one echo; ask what word returns wrong.

3. **Light:** Describe color/behavior; ask who steadies it (hum, prayer, silence).
4. **Count:** Beats, drips, or breaths – players may claim *Counting Etiquette* to shift Position safer once.
5. **Declare Price or Key:** Players state attitude + key type; on a hit, grant +1 Effect or a *Safe Route* token.

Plug-in SB Conversions (use with any dungeon)

- First 1 SB in a scene may become *Heat +1* instead of a narrative wrinkle (signal without immediate harm).
- Any 2 SB can instead tick *Structure Stress* and foreshadow *Cascading Failure* rather than spawn foes.
- On 3+ SB, offer a bargain: pay with *memory/gear/time* to halve the consequence and add *Price of Passage* [3].

Bosses & Lairs (Classic Crawl Feel, Fate’s Edge Framework)

Using Bosses Each boss runs on a **Phase Clock** and 2–3 **Lair Actions**. Tie them to the site’s *Dungeon Awareness (Heat)* and *Structure Stress*; as either rises, promote boss position/effect. Boss defeats should yield a Diamond-tier boon keyed to the lair.

Oculus Warden (many-eyed sentry)

A floating nerve-knot studded with glass eyes; lenses irise like gills.

- **Phase Clock:** [8] *Calibration* → *Overwatch* → *Lethal Focus* → *Blind Panic*
- **Moves:** *Disintegrate Signage* (erase waymarks), *Anti-magic Glare* (downgrade 1 magical effect this exchange), *Scry Ping* (advance Awareness +1).
- **Lair Actions (Mirror Hall / Vault of Whispers):**
 1. *Prismatic Sweep:* Split the party’s positions (each PC steps one tier toward Controlled).
 2. *Echo False Order:* One PC hears an ally’s command that was never given; test or waste an action.
 3. *Lens Flare:* Next ranged attack against the Warden loses 1 Effect unless the light source is doused.
- **Counters:** Smoke, darkness, reflective shields, calling shots on specific lenses (name a lens: cancel one Move this round).
- **Drop (Diamond):** *Crown of Momentary Authority* or *Lantern of Clarity*.

Digestive Array (cube-that-crawls)

A transparent, room-sized solvent held in grid tension; carries tools it cannot digest.

- **Phase Clock:** [6] *Probe* → *Enmesh* → *Dissolve*
- **Moves:** *Corrode* (apply COMPROMISED to metal/wood), *Engulf* (split group; trapped PC marks Fatigue or gear loss), *Clean Bones* (remove tags from fallen).
- **Lair Actions (Sunken Vestibule / Chained Sanctuary):**
 1. *Flood Gate Twitch:* Water level rises a step; footing worsens.
 2. *Sluice Pulse:* Pushes all creatures one range band.

3. *Reagent Bloom*: Vapors add –1 die to breathy actions this round.

- **Counters:** Grates, cold cinders, base powders; lures with iron filings or salted meat (draw off for a scene).
- **Drop (Diamond):** *Forge of Quick Repair* salvage or *Ration of Sustenance* (3).

Ledger Lich (archivist revenant)

A curator bound by indices; hands of ink, breath of dust.

- **Phase Clock:** [8] *Citation* → *Injunction* → *Foreclosure* → *Redaction*
- **Moves:** *Name Forfeiture* (steal a declared tag until bell), *Writ of Seizure* (lock a Diamond or gear under spectral seal), *Errata* (retroactively worsen one PC's prior roll Outcome).
- **Lair Actions (Vault of Whispers / Deep Archive):**
 1. *Quiet Hours*: Casting/rites generate +1 SB or fail softly.
 2. *Reference Only*: Movement through stacks costs an action unless proper tokens are presented.
 3. *Cross-reference Collapse*: Bookshelves reconfigure; split the party.
- **Counters:** True names carved in quartz, burning a citation (sacrifice an *index* – a map, a ledger, a vow) to cancel one Move.
- **Drop (Diamond):** *Key of Echoes*, *Tome of Convenient Knowledge*.

Protocol Titan (stone sentinel)

A walking paragraph of law in granite; joints clock with tiny bells.

- **Phase Clock:** [6] *Challenge* → *Adjudicate* → *Execute*
- **Moves:** *Ward Stomp* (shockwave; prone or position –), *Clause Capture* (binds a PC to a declared rule), *Countermeasure* (reflect mundane force).
- **Lair Actions (Measure Vault / Throne of Echoes):**
 1. *Bell of Standing*: Only those who declare an intent may act this round.
 2. *Weigh Deceit*: The largest lie in the scene takes Harm 1 (Stress).
 3. *Seal Turned*: A door the party used closes and locks under new terms.
- **Counters:** Present certified measures, exploit contradictions, or swear a binding minor oath (shift boss Position –).
- **Drop (Diamond):** *The Under-Seal Clause* (local), *Key-Writ*.

Mimetic Colony (door-that-eats)

An ecosystem of impostor hinges, handles, chests, and carpets.

- **Phase Clock:** [6] *Invitation* → *Adhesion* → *Ingestion*
- **Moves:** *Stickfast* (immobilize limb/gear), *Swallow Noise* (negate assists), *Split & Flank*.
- **Lair Actions (Armory / Garden of Stone):**
 1. *Everything's a Mouth*: First interacted object bites.
 2. *False Safe*: Creates a "short rest" that actually advances Heat +2.
 3. *Chew Through*: Destroys one rung/bridge segment.

- **Counters:** Iron spikes, chalk lines, bait boxes; fire/acid cause the colony to fragment (treat as minions).
- **Drop (Diamond):** *Cloak of Passage*, *Token of Safe Return*.

Sluice Dragon (steam & acid wyrm)

A heat lung grown proud; scales are boiler plates, breath a flash-boil scream.

- **Phase Clock:** [10] *Banked Heat* → *Pressure Rise* → *Vent Fury* → *Rupture*
- **Moves:** *Scalding Cone*, *Vacuum Lurch* (pull PCs), *Steam Blind* (Position –).
- **Lair Actions (Heat Lungs / Cistern):**
 1. *Valve Spin:* Change terrain tags (Dry/Wet/Boiling).
 2. *Gauge Pop:* Structure Stress +1; cracks form.
 3. *Pressure Shadow:* The dragon gains +1 Effect for one exchange.
- **Counters:** Chill the room (dump cistern), bleed valves (two actions), or bait with metal ingots.
- **Drop (Diamond):** *Forge of Quick Repair*, *Shield of Temporary Immunity*.

Crawl Procedures (Quick, Crunchy Options)

- **Short Rest (10 minutes):** Clear Fatigue 1 *or* refresh one spent tool; advance *Dungeon Awareness* +1 and roll once on *Ambient Signs* (below).
- **Secure Camp (1 hour, defensible):** Clear Fatigue 2 and one *Condition* (not Harm); *Structure Stress* +1d2 from barricading/heat, *Awareness* +2 unless *Sealed*.
- **Search a Room (5 minutes):** On success, gain 1 *Safe Route* token *or* a *Map that Grows* tick; on miss, trigger a *Door Attitude* complication.
- **Light, Air, Load:** Track three pooled clocks [4] (see Plug-in Expedition Layer). Empty tracks worsen Position until restored.

Wandering Signs & Encounters (d12)

1. Whisper returns one word wrong; nearest door adopts a *Hungry* attitude.
2. Drip changes rhythm; nearby *Gravity Well* awakens.
3. Custodian chalk erased and redrawn *behind* you.
4. A stack exhales: *Memory Fog* for one exchange.
5. Pilfer-vermin court demands toll (crumbs, salt, *or* gossip).
6. Bound Guardian patrol, willing to debate terms (papers help).
7. Refugee child with a *Key of Echoes* that hates you.
8. Floor warms; *Heat Lung* cycling – steam hazard next room.
9. Echo sermon on "proper doors"; ignoring it adds Heat +1.
10. Sloshing in walls; *Digestive Array* scouts with a filament.
11. A mirror shows your gear two items lighter – choose which or mark Fatigue 1.
12. Stone hymn – sing along to cancel first SB this scene, or suffer *Hungering Dark* pulse.

Classic Traps, Living-Site Style (pick 1–2 tags)

- **Pressure Mosaic** (Artful, Loud): Floor pattern asks for a dance step; wrong beat drops spears from *ceiling*, not floor.
- **Breath Tax** (Subtle, Lingering): Room meters exhalations; excess vents sleeping gas; counting etiquette downgrades risk.
- **Magi-Siphon Grate** (Hungry, Magnetic): Drains charges from tools/wards; feeding it a *Focus Crystal* buys safe passage.
- **Echo Latch** (Riddle, Social): Door opens to a truth spoken softly; lies trigger *Phantom Locks*.

Treasure & Upgrade Hooks (d8 hoard seeds)

1. Cage of *tame echoes* – store a sentence for later; release as perfect mimicry.
2. *Map that Grows* (upgraded): shows *organs* (cistern/nerve-hall) when rubbed with tallow.
3. *Wayfinder Compass* attuned: hum a note to swap "nearest exit" with "nearest objective."
4. *Key-ring of Attitudes*: once each – *Courteous*, *Hungry*, *Proud*.
5. Bottle of *stolen seasons*: pour to set room to *pollen-sweet* or *knife-cold* for one scene.
6. *Token of Safe Return* (party-wide) that tugs twice when the *Heart Pressure* hits threshold.
7. A ledger page signed by the *Dungeon's Creator* – treat one barrier as if you are expected.
8. *Lantern of Clarity* mantle: once/session, reveals the *Price of Passage* without paying it.

Boss Build Template (one-minute prep)

1. **Name & Nature:** What organ of the dungeon is this boss the face of?
2. **Phase Clock:** 6/8/10 with 2–4 titled phases.
3. **Three Moves:** One space-control, one resource-tax, one identity/knowledge twist.
4. **Two Lair Actions:** Environmental toggles keyed to this lair.
5. **Counters:** A courtesy, a tool, a sacrifice. (Players should be able to *learn* these.)
6. **Drop:** A Diamond (from §40.1) or bespoke boon tied to the organ.

Dungeon Boss: The Heart Itself (set-piece)

A chamber of ribs and lintels; mortar smells like blood, light like fever.

- **Phase Clock:** [10] *Palpate* → *Synchronize* → *Pacemaker* → *Arrest*
- **Moves:** *Syncopate* (force actions to resolve off-beat; assist dice misfire), *Tachycardia* (Heat +2, Structure Stress +1), *Backflow* (reverse one clock tick on *Floorplan Loops*, but split the party).
- **Lair Actions:**
 1. *Valve Close:* Seal exits; require a "Somatic" or "Affective" key to reopen.
 2. *Adrenal Surge:* The Heart acts twice next round unless fed a secret *all PCs share*.
- **Counters:** Speak the dungeon's *true purpose* (as inferred via organs), vent a heat lung, or sacrifice mapped ground (tear up a *Safe Route*).
- **Victory States:** *Stabilize* (site becomes safer; Awareness clears to 0), *Pacify* (gain *Dungeon's Blessing*), or *Slay* (collapse risk; Structure Stress +2 across the level).

Patronage & Power

The true dungeon is not a place but a process – a slow alchemy that transforms intruders into something the structure can understand or consume. Every chamber is a test, every corridor a negotiation, and every inhabitant a symptom of the site’s deeper hungers. The wise explorer learns to read the dungeon’s moods in the way light falls, the way echoes return, and the way the very air seems to lean toward certain passages. Here, knowledge is not power but currency, and the smart adventurer knows when to pay with memory, when to pay with blood, and when to simply walk away.

For the GM: Dungeon authority is not hierarchical – it is ecological. The Custodians maintain, the Invaders exploit, the Organs react, and the Symbiotes adapt. Players gain leverage by understanding these relationships and offering what each faction lacks: memories for Custodians, safe passage for Invaders, sacrifice for Organs, curiosity for Symbiotes. Emphasise that the dungeon learns. Repeated tactics become less effective; kindness to one faction may anger another. The dungeon is not a monster – it is a neighbourhood.

Epilogue: The Ledger Closes

I closed the book. The ink was dry.

I had written the final entry months ago, in a damp counting-house on the Dhaharan coast, by candlelight. My hands did not shake—they were too good for that—but I set down my abacus very carefully. I had found something in the margins. A footnote I did not remember writing. A clause I did not remember adding. The ink was the same colour as my own blood. The handwriting was my own. The date was tomorrow.

I have learned to trust the things I do not remember. They are usually the truest things I know.

The hat—the one the Trow had given me, the one that was still warm—sat on the corner of the desk. I picked it up, turned it over in my hands, and for the first time in years, I could not think of a single angle. That should have frightened me. Instead, it felt like a door opening. Not the kind of door you walk through. The kind of door that walks through you.

The road was south. I did not know who would be waiting. I went anyway.

— *The Edgewalker*

Postscript

The road is always south. Or north. Or whichever direction you are not facing when you read this sentence. The road does not care about cardinal points. The road cares about movement. And I am still moving.

I sympathise with this "Edgewalker." When I dream, I dream of other faces. When I wander, I feel the weights I do not owe. And, from time to time, I find myself writing in a ledger with a hand I do not recognize as my own. The hat has never cooled.

The ninth entry is always the hardest to write. Not because it is the last. Because it is the one you have to mean.

— *The Grey Wanderer (unsigned, undated, and probably still walking)*

Part IX

World Travel & Gateways

Chapter 41

Global Travel Procedures

41.1 Core Travel Procedure

For each leg of a journey, draw 3–4 cards using the decks for your destination and controlling authority.

- ♠ from the destination deck: sets the scene (place).
- ♥ from the destination deck: introduces the local actor or faction.
- ♣ from the Wilds (general hazards) or destination (if strongly policed): brings pressure.
- ♦ from the authority that gates the route: papers, escorts, rights, or exceptions.

Set a travel clock by the highest rank:

- 2–5 $\Rightarrow$ 4 segments
- 6–10 $\Rightarrow$ 6 segments
- J/Q/K $\Rightarrow$ 8 segments
- A $\Rightarrow$ 10 segments

On success, advance to the next leg; on failure, mark delay, debt, or diversion and resolve a consequence in the fiction.

41.2 Mode Rules

41.2.1 Sea Legs

(Amaranthine, Dolmis, Aberderrin, Gulf of Oshiira, Inland Sea). When crossing international waters, the controlling authority is either the origin port's navy or a neutral convoy league.

41.2.2 Mountain Passes & Underways

(Aeler, Himadri, Taharkan highlands). Any A may convert a surface route to an under-route. ♦ from Aeler always codifies outcomes — no roll — for sealed doors, breath time, and escorted segments.

41.2.3 Desert Legs

(Sahel, Red Desert, Fhara drylands). Water is the primary resource. A dry well hazard can end a journey.

41.2.4 River Legs

(Belworth, Ayokhan rivers, Oshiiran canals). Bridges, booms, and law in Vhasia/Viterra; reed-mazes and bell-lines in Mistlands; canal mothers and weigh-houses in Oshiira.

41.2.5 Steppe Legs

(Violet Steppe, Kuvani grazing lands). Remount stations and grazing compacts. The Ykrul and Kuvani both use story tolls.

41.2.6 Shadow Corridors

(Valewood, Ways Between, Thin Shore). Add a regional taboo: never count to nine, never speak the ninth name. A 9 in the seed triggers the Hollow's attention.

41.3 Gateways & Control Points

Gateway	Region	Diamond Source	Typical Leverage
Kassamira Port	Kahfagia	Kahfagia	Convoy letter, lantern-law wa
Ecktoria Capital Port	Ecktoria	Ecktoria	Berth priority, coin-house cre
Silkstrand	Acasia	Acasia	Exchange floor pass, condott
Marcott	Vhasia	Vhasia	Letters patent, safe-conduct,
Fairport	Viterra	Viterra	Customs seal, ferry priority, l
Tarlington Falls	Viterra	Viterra	Lift priority, bridge/portage
Thepyrgos (boom)	Thepyrgos	Thepyrgos	Harbour pass, crane allotmen
High-Mist Pass	Aeler	Aeler	Underway pass, Key-Writ, br
Payden's Port	Mistlands	Mistlands	Lantern writ, ward-salt, wrai
Thin Shore (Valewood)	Valewood	Valewood/Mistlands	Way-cord, dew-mirror, lantern
Green Gate	Aelinnel	Aelinnel	Tide-path key, host-right bou
Ubral Passes	Ubral	Aeler/Ubral	Vurim pass-ring, hill-fort she
Thing-holm	Linn	Linn	Thing ruling, harbour-green c
Foedus Stone	Vilikari	Vilikari/Ykrul	Foedus renewal, remount allo
Zakov Roadstead	Zakov	Zakov	Harbour-green chit, corsair c
Black Banner Camps	Black Banner	Black Banner/Ykrul/Vilikari	Safe-conduct, remount chit, c
Brass Gate	Ashaan	Ashaan	Spirit-lamp, brass seal, veil-c
Port Shed	Dhahara (Brass Coast)	Sidhi/Kahfagia	Lighthouse charter, port-weig
Sarvistan	Dhahara (Mountain Satrapy)	Aeler	Keystone charter, sledge-wax
Bridge of Nine Echoes	Ayokha	Lethai-ar	Silk voucher, monsoon schedu
Sihai Examination Hall	Sihai	Lethai-thora	Stamped pass, Celestial Ledge
Nihori Storm-Shrine	Nihori	Shrine Maiden	Shrine bell, storm-charmer's
Mbaro Weigh-House	Oshiira	Vermilion Corps	Grain ledger page, tariff stan
The Ukwe (Speaking Tree)	Sekogo	Green Council	Ungwe leaf, nkisi shard, leopa
Himadri Pass	Dhahara (Himadri)	Aeler	Iron ingot, toll waiver, elepha

Table 41.1: World Gateways & Control Points

41.4 Edgewalker's Notes on Leverage

Every Diamond you earn in these generators isn't a reward—it's a weapon. Some open doors. Some silence witnesses. Some are debts I've already bought from your victims.

- **Passage Tokens:** Pass-stones, harbour charters, toll waivers. Use them early—they tend to “expire” when the issuer has an unfortunate accident.
- **Seals & Stamps:** Official marks that prove you belong. A forged seal works once. A real one works until someone audits it.
- **Story Debts:** Tulkani vow-cords, Lethai-ar witness cords, Ukwe leaves. Break them, and the Hollow visits.
- **Spirit Objects:** Storm-charms, tide-beads, nkisi shards. They attract attention. Attention means bids.

Never use a Diamond if you can trade it for three smaller ones. Always keep a ninth—a secret, a story, a knot tied in a victim's hair—for when the toll exceeds your conscience. (It always does.)

Chapter 42

Story Beat (SB) Menus

42.0.1 Universal SB Spend Menu

- **1 SB** — Shave time/position: add +1 segment to the current clock *or* drop Position one step *or* impose a small fee/toll.
- **2 SB** — Escalate pressure: upgrade the active ♣ *or* force a *choice of Diamonds* *or* tick a Front by 1.
- **3 SB** — Lock a gate/taboo: close a route until a named ♦ is spent *or* invoke a regional taboo.
- **4+ SB** — Reshape the leg: rewrite the route, start a new complication clock, demand immediate payment on a Debt.

42.0.2 Regional SB Options

- **Aeler (under-vaults):** Breath-time checks, engineer requisitions, cave-in detours.
- **Oshiira (canals):** Audit traps, locust swarms, Widow's health failures.
- **Ashaan (Veil):** Spirit-dust storms, bound spirits breaking free, Black Hand sweeps.
- **Tulkani (wagon circles):** Debt collectors, Hollow walks on the ninth night, vow-cords tangling.
- **Lethai-ar (bridges):** Snapped strands, web-law challenges, the ninth echo.
- **Aelinnel (bells):** Miscounts, offended tide-spirits, bell-lines breaking.

Colophon

This worldbook was assembled from the journals, ledgers, and bar tabs of one Aeler Edgewalker, paid for by the High King's Office of External Opportunities (budget line: "Unconventional Revenue Generation"). The generator tables were tested in the field—meaning I ran them at gunpoint in a Tulkani wagon circle while a Debt-Walker counted my breaths. They work.

If you find yourself in a tavern and the Edgewalker buys you a drink, don't ask where they are now. The road is long, the ledgers are never balanced, and the ninth measure is always waiting.

— *Faleki of Ironhold, at a weigh-house in Mbaro, under a lamp that flickers nine times before it steadies*